

Translated *by* Bibek Debroy



THE BRAHMA PURANA

Volume 2

From the
master translator
of the Critical Editions
of the MAHABHARATA
and the RAMAYANA





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Bibek Debroy

THE BRAHMA PURANA
Volume 2



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THE BRAHMA PURANA VOLUME 2

Bibek Debroy is a renowned economist, scholar and translator. He has worked in universities, research institutes, the industry and for the government. He has widely published books, papers and articles on economics. As a translator, he is best known for his magnificent rendition of the Mahabharata in ten volumes, the three-volume translation of the Valmiki Ramayana and additionally the *Harivamsha*, published to wide acclaim by Penguin Classics. He is also the author of *Sarama and Her Children*, which splices his interest in Hinduism with his love for dogs.

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For Shaifalika Panda and Subhrakant Panda

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Introduction

The word Purana means old, ancient. The Puranas are old texts, usually referred to in conjunction with *Itihasa* (the Ramayana and the Mahabharata). ¹ Whether *Itihasa* originally meant only the Mahabharata, with the Ramayana being added to that expression later, is a proposition on which there has been some discussion. But that's not relevant for our purposes. In the Chandogya Upanishad, there is an instance of the sage Narada approaching the sage Sanatkumara for instruction. Asked about what he already knows, Narada says he knows *Itihasa* and Purana, the Fifth Veda. ² In other words, *Itihasa*–Purana possessed an elevated status. This by no means implies that the word Purana, as used in these two Upanishads and other texts too, is to be understood in the sense of the word being applied to a set of texts known as the Puranas today. The Valmiki Ramayana is believed to have been composed by Valmiki and the Mahabharata by Krishna Dvaipayana Vedavyasa. After composing the Mahabharata, Krishna Dvaipayana Vedavyasa is believed to have composed the Puranas. The use of the word composed immediately indicates that *Itihasa*–Purana are 'smriti' texts, with a human origin. They are not 'shruti' texts, with a divine origin. Composition does not mean these texts were rendered into writing. Instead, there was a process of oral transmission, with inevitable noise in the transmission and distribution process. Writing came much later.

Pargiter's book on the Puranas is still one of the best introductions to this corpus. ³ To explain the composition and transmission process, one can do no better than to quote him. 'The Vayu and Padma Puranas tell us how ancient genealogies, tales and ballads were preserved, namely, by the *sutas*, ⁴ and they describe the *suta*'s duty . . . The Vayu, Brahmanda and Visnu give an account on how the original Purana came into existence. Those three Puranas say: Krishna Dvaipayana divided the single Veda into four and

arranged them, and so was called Vyasa. He entrusted them to his four disciples, one to each, namely Paila, Vaisampayana, Jaimini and Sumantu. Then with tales, anecdotes, songs and lore that had come down from the ages, he compiled a Purana, and taught it and the *Itihasa* to his fifth disciple, the suta Romaharsana or Lomaharsana . . . After that he composed the Mahabharata. The epic itself implies that the Purana preceded it . . . As explained above, the *sutas* had from remote times preserved the genealogies of gods, rishis and kings, and traditions and ballads about celebrated men, that is, exactly the material—tales, songs and ancient lore—out of which the Purana was constructed. Whether or not Vyasa composed the original Purana or superintended its compilation, is immaterial for the present purpose. After the original Purana was composed, by Vyasa as is said, his disciple Romaharsana taught it to his son Ugrasravas and Ugrasravas the *sauti* appears as the reciter in some of the present Puranas; and the *sutas* still retained the right to recite it for their livelihood. But, as stated above, Romaharsana taught it to his six disciples, at least five of whom were brahmans. It thus passed into the hands of the brahmans, and their appropriation and development of it increased in the course of time, as the Purana grew into many Puranas, as Sanskrit learning became peculiarly the province of the brahmans, and as new and frankly sectarian Puranas were composed.’ Pargiter cited reasons for his belief that the Mahabharata was composed before the original Purana, though that runs contrary to the popular perception about the Mahabharata having been composed before the Puranas. That popular and linear perception is too simplistic, since texts evolved in parallel, not necessarily sequentially.

In popular perception, Krishna Dvaipayana Vedavyasa composed the Mahabharata. He then composed the Puranas. Alternatively, he composed an original core Purana text, which has been lost, and others embellished it through additions. The adjective ‘Purana’, meaning old account or old text, became a proper noun, signifying a specific text. To be classified as a Purana, it has to possess five attributes—*pancha lakshmana*. That is, five topics must be discussed—*sarga*, *pratisarga*, *vamsha*, *manvantara* and *vamshanucharita*. The clearest statement of this is in the Matsya Purana.

Unlike the Ramayana and the Mahabharata, there is no Critical Edition of the Puranas.⁵ Therefore, citing chapter and verse from a Purana text is somewhat more difficult, since verse, if not chapter, may vary from text to text. With that caveat, the relevant *shloka* (verse) should be in the fifty-third chapter of the Matsya Purana. *Sarga* means the original or primary creation. The converse of *sarga* is universal destruction, or *pralaya*. That period of *sarga* lasts for one of Brahma's days, known as *kalpa*. When Brahma sleeps, during his night, there is universal destruction.

In measuring time, there is the notion of a *yuga* (era) and there are four *yuga*—*satya yuga* (also known as *krita yuga*), *treta yuga*, *dvapara yuga* and *kali yuga*. *Satya yuga* lasts for 4,000 years, *treta yuga* for 3,000 years, *dvapara yuga* for 2,000 years and *kali yuga* for 1,000 years. However, all these are not human years. The gods have a different timescale and these are the years of the gods. As one progressively moves from *satya yuga* to *kali yuga*, virtue (*dharma*) declines. But at the end of *kali yuga*, the cycle begins afresh, with *satya yuga*. An entire cycle, from *satya yuga* to *kali yuga*, is known as a *mahayuga* (great era). However, a *mahayuga* is not just 10,000 years. There is further complication. At the beginning and the end of every *yuga*, there are some additional years. These additional years are 400 for *satya yuga*, 300 for *treta yuga*, 200 for *dvapara yuga* and 100 for *kali yuga*. A *mahayuga* thus, has 12,000 years, adding years both at the beginning and at the end. 1,000 *mahayuga* make up one *kalpa* (eon), a single day for Brahma. A *kalpa* is also divided into fourteen *manvantaras*, a *manvantara* being a period during which a Manu presides and rules over creation. Therefore, there are 71.4 *mahayuga* in a *manvantara*. Our present *kalpa* is known as the Shveta Varaha Kalpa. Within that, six Manus have come and gone. Their names are (1) Svyambhuva Manu, (2) Svarochisha Manu, (3) Uttama Manu, (4) Tapasa Manu, (5) Raivata Manu and (6) Chakshusha Manu. The present Manu is known as Vaivasvata Manu. Vivasvat, also written as Vivasvan, is the name of Surya, the sun-god. Vaivasvata Manu has that name because he is Surya's son. Not only do Manus change from one *manvantara* to another. So do the gods, the ruler of the gods and the seven great sages, known as the *saptarshis* (seven rishis).

Indra is a title of the ruler of the gods. It is not a proper name. The present Indra is Purandara. However, in a different *manvantara*, someone else will hold the title. In the present seventh *manvantara*, known as Vaivasvata *manvantara*, there will also be 71.4 *mahayuga*. We are in the twenty-eighth of these. Since a different Vedavyasa performs that task of classifying and collating the Vedas in every *mahayuga*, Krishna Dvaipayana Vedavyasa is the twenty-eighth in that series. Just so that it is clear, Vedavyasa isn't a proper name. It is a title conferred on someone who collates and classifies the Vedas. There have been twenty-seven who have held the title of Vedavyasa before him and he is the twenty-eighth. His proper name is Krishna Dvaipayana, Krishna because he was dark and Dvaipayana because he was born on an island (*dvipa*). This gives us an idea of what the topic of *manvantara* is about. This still leaves *pratisarga*, *vamsha* and *vamshanucharita*. The two famous dynasties/lineages were the solar dynasty (*survya vamsha*) and lunar dynasty (*chandra vamsha*) and all the famous kings belonged to one or the other of these two dynasties. *Vamshanucharita* is about these lineages and the conduct of these kings. There were the gods and sages (*rishis*) too, not always born through a process of physical procreation. Their lineages are described under the heading of *vamsha*. Finally, within that cycle of primary creation and destruction, there are smaller and secondary cycles of creation and destruction. That's the domain of *pratisarga*. In greater or lesser degree, all the Puranas cover these five topics, some more than the others. The Purana which strictly adheres to this five-topic classification is the Vishnu Purana.

There are Puranas and Puranas. Some are known as Sthala Puranas, describing the greatness and sanctity of a specific geographical place. Some are known as Upa-Puranas, minor Puranas. The listing of Upa-Puranas has regional variations and there is no country-wide consensus about the list of Upa-Puranas, though it is often accepted there are eighteen. The Puranas we have in mind are known as Maha-Puranas, major Puranas. Henceforth, when we use the word Puranas, we mean Maha-Puranas. There is consensus that there are eighteen Maha-Puranas, though it is not obvious that this number of eighteen existed right from the beginning. The names are

mentioned in several of these texts, including a *shloka* that follows the *shloka* cited from the Matsya Purana. Thus, the eighteen Puranas are (1) Agni (15,400); (2) Bhagavata (18,000); (3) Brahma (10,000); (4) Brahmanda (12,000); (5) Brahmavaivarta (18,000); (6) Garuda (19,000); (7) Kurma (17,000); (8) Linga (11,000); (9) Markandeya (9,000); (10) Matsya (14,000); (11) Narada (25,000); (12) Padma (55,000); (13) Shiva (24,000); (14) Skanda (81,100); (15) Vamana (10,000); (16) Varaha (24,000); (17) Vayu (24,000); and (18) Vishnu (23,000). A few additional points about this list. First, the Harivamsha is sometimes loosely described as a Purana, but strictly speaking, it is not a Purana. It is more like an addendum to the Mahabharata. Second, Bhavishya (14,500) is sometimes mentioned, with Vayu excised from the list. However, the Vayu Purana exhibits many more Purana characteristics than the Bhavishya Purana does. There are references to a Bhavishya Purana that existed, but that may not necessarily be the Bhavishya Purana as we know it today. That's true of some other Puranas too. Texts have been completely restructured hundreds of years later. Third, it is not just a question of Bhavishya Purana and Vayu Purana. In the lists given in some Puranas, Vayu is part of the eighteen, but Agni is knocked out. In some others, Narasimha and Vayu are included, but Brahmanda and Garuda are knocked out. Fourth, when a list is given, the order also indicates some notion of priority or importance. Since that varies from text to text, our listing is simply alphabetical, according to the English alphabet. The text of the Brahma Purana has no such listing of Puranas. But in the last chapter of Part I, Chapter 1(138), which praises the Purana, it describes itself as the first Purana, Adi Purana. Indeed, the Brahma Purana is described as Adi Purana in several other Purana texts too, underlining its importance.

The numbers within brackets indicate the number of *shlokas* each of these Puranas has, or is believed to have. The range is from 10,000 in Brahma to a mammoth 81,100 in Skanda. The aggregate is a colossal 409,500 *shlokas*. To convey a rough idea of the orders of magnitude, the Mahabharata has, or is believed to have, 100,000 *shlokas*. It's a bit difficult to convert a *shloka* into word counts in English, especially because Sanskrit

words have a slightly different structure. However, as a very crude approximation, one *shloka* is roughly twenty words. Thus, 100,000 *shlokas* become 2 million words and 400,000 *shlokas*, four times the size of the Mahabharata, amounts to 8 million words. There is a reason for using the expression ‘is believed to have’, as opposed to ‘has’. Rendering into writing is of later vintage, the initial process was one of oral transmission. In the process, many texts have been lost, or are retained in imperfect condition. This is true of texts in general and is also specifically true of *Itihasa* and Puranas. The Critical Edition of the Mahabharata, mentioned earlier, no longer possesses 100,000 *shlokas*. Including the Harivamsha, there are around 80,000 *shlokas*. The Critical Edition of the Mahabharata has of course deliberately excised some *shlokas*. For the Puranas, there is no counterpart of Critical Editions. However, whichever edition of the Puranas one chooses, the number of *shlokas* in that specific Purana will be smaller than the numbers given above. Either those many *shlokas* did not originally exist, or they have been lost. This is the right place to mention that a reading of the Puranas assumes a basic degree of familiarity with the Valmiki Ramayana and the Mahabharata, more the latter than the former. Without that familiarity, one will often fail to appreciate the context completely. More than passing familiarity with the Bhagavad Gita, strictly speaking a part of the Mahabharata, helps. ⁶

Other than the five attributes, the Puranas have a considerable amount of information on geography and even geological changes (changes in courses of river) and astronomy. Therefore, those five attributes shouldn’t suggest the Puranas have nothing more. They do, and they have therefore been described as encyclopedias. Bharatavarsha is vast and heterogeneous and each Purana may very well have originated in one particular part of the country. Accordingly, within that broad compass of an overall geographical description, the extent of geographical information varies from Purana to Purana. Some are more familiar with one part of the country than with another. For example, for the Brahma Purana, Part I has extensive descriptions of the Utkala region, while Part II has the same for the region of Dandkaranya, through which the Godavari flows. Though not explicitly

mentioned in the five attributes, the Puranas are also about pursuing *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*, the four objectives of human existence, and about the four *varnas* and the four *ashramas*. The general understanding and practice of *dharma* is based much more on the Puranas than on the *Vedas*. Culture, notions of law, rituals, architecture and iconography are based on the Puranas. There is beautiful poetry too.

Perhaps one should mention that there are two ways these eighteen Puranas are classified. The trinity has Brahma as the creator, Vishnu as the preserver and Shiva as the destroyer. Therefore, Puranas where creation themes feature prominently are identified with Brahma (Brahma, Brahmanda, Brahmavaivarta, Markandeya). Puranas where Vishnu features prominently are identified as Vaishnava Puranas (Bhagavata, Garuda, Kurma, Matsya, Narada, Padma, Vamana, Varaha, Vishnu). Puranas where Shiva features prominently are identified as Shaiva Puranas (Agni, Linga, Shiva, Skanda, Vayu). While there is a grain of truth in this, Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva are all important and all three feature in every Purana. Therefore, beyond the relative superiority of Vishnu vis-à-vis Shiva, the taxonomy probably doesn't serve much purpose. The Brahma Purana is so named because it was originally recounted by Brahma, with subsequent transmissions by Vedavyasa and Lomaharshana, Vedavyasa's disciple. The second classification is even more tenuous and is based on the three *gunas* of *sattva* (purity), *rajas* (passion) and *tamas* (ignorance). For example, the Uttara Khanda of the Padma Purana has a few *shlokas* along these lines, recited by Shiva to Parvati. With a caveat similar to the one mentioned earlier, this should be in the 236th chapter of Uttara Khanda. According to this, the Puranas characterized by *sattva* are Bhagavata, Garuda, Narada, Padma, Varaha and Vishnu. Those characterized by *rajas* are Bhavishya, Brahma, Brahmanda, Brahmavaivarta, Markandeya and Vamana, Those characterized by *tamas* are Agni, Kurma, Linga, Matsya, Skanda and Shiva.

Within a specific Purana text, there are earlier sections, as well as later ones. That makes it difficult to date a Purana, except as a range. Across Purana texts, there are older Puranas, as well as later ones. Extremely speculatively, the dating will be something like the following. (1) Agni

(800–1100 CE); (2) Bhagavata (500–1000 CE); (3) Brahma (700–1500 CE); (4) Brahmanda (400–600 CE); (5) Brahmavaivarta (700–1500 CE); (6) Garuda (800–1100 CE); (7) Kurma (600–900 CE); (8) Linga (500–1000 CE); (9) Markandeya (250–700 CE); (10) Matsya (200–500 CE); (11) Narada (900–1600 CE); (12) Padma (400–1600 CE); (13) Shiva (1000–1400 CE); (14) Skanda (600–1200 CE); (15) Vamana (450–900 CE); (16) Varaha (1000–1200 CE); (17) Vayu (350–550 CE); (18) Vishnu (300 BCE to 450 CE); and (19) Bhavishya (500–1900 CE). Reiterating once again that there is no great precision in these ranges, by this reckoning, the Vishnu Purana is the oldest and some parts of the Bhavishya Purana are as recent as the nineteenth century.

As mentioned earlier, there is no Critical Edition for the Puranas. Therefore, one has to choose a Sanskrit text one is going to translate from. If one is going to translate all the Puranas, it is preferable, though not essential, that one opts for a common source for all the Purana texts. The common source for the Brahma Purana, and all the Purana translations, is the one brought out by Nag Publishers, with funding from the Ministry of Human Resource Development.⁷ To the best of my knowledge, other than this translation, there is only one unabridged translation of the Brahma Purana in English.⁸ Though this translation was undertaken by a board of scholars, a discerning reader, who compares the two translations, will find that we have differed from this earlier translation in interpreting some verses and words.

For some Puranas, the range of possible dates of composition, as indicated above, is narrow. Agni, Brahmanda, Garuda, Kurma, Matsya, Varaha, Vayu and Vishnu are examples. The range is however extremely wide for Brahma Purana, from 700 to 1500 CE. There clearly was an original Brahma Purana, large chunks of which have been lost. In other words, the present Brahma Purana might not be the same as the original Brahma Purana, which has been lost.

R.C. Hazra's dissertation is still one of the best introductions to the Purana corpus, for all the Puranas, not just the Brahma Purana.⁹ 'It is a

general belief that the present Brahma Purana is the original one, the peculiarity being that it has suffered through additions and losses. This belief is at the base of almost all statements that have been made so long by scholars about its date and authoritativeness. From an examination of the Puranas and the Smriti-Nibandhas, however, it has been found that the present Brahma Purana is not the original one but is merely an Upa Purana of the same title and that it was known as such even as late as in the sixteenth century A.D, if not later. Almost all the Nibandha-writers have profusely drawn upon the 'Brahma Purana' or 'Brahma' which was therefore, one of the most authoritative works in the whole range of Puranic literature. But, curiously enough, not a single of the numerous quotations made is traceable in the present Brahma Purana. The apocryphal Brahma Purana, with its borrowed and non-borrowed chapters, does not seem to have been composed, or rather compiled, earlier than the beginning of the tenth century AD. Had it been composed earlier, it should have been drawn upon, or at least referred to, by the Nibandha-writers earlier than the middle of the thirteenth century. The determination of the date of composition of the chapters of Purusottamaksetra-mahatmya is rather difficult. They could not possibly have been written earlier than the end of the ninth century AD because there is mention of the Siva-temple at the side of the Markandeya Lake. This temple was built in 820 AD by Kundala-kesarin, king of Orissa. Again, the expensive stone temple, which mythical king Indradyumna is said to have built at Purusottama-ksetra, may be identical with that built by Ananta-varman Codaganga (Saka 998–1069), one of the eastern Ganga kings of Orissa. We cannot, however, put much stress on this supposition because it is not known definitely that there was no Vishnu-temple at Puri before the time of Ananta-varman Codaganga . . . It is extremely difficult to prove that the Sun-temple mentioned by the Brahma Purana is the same as that built between 1240 and 1251 AD by Narasimhadeva I of the Ganga dynasty of Orissa. It is therefore highly probable that there was already an ancient Sun-temple at Konarka before 1240 AD, and Narasimhadeva I either built another which has superseded the ancient temple in its fame and glory

or rebuilt the ancient one which can be expected to have been in a dilapidated condition.’

Stated simply, there are sections on Purushottama *kshetra* and Jagannatha, underlining the lower end of the range of 1500 CE. There are references to Indradyumna and Konarka, the present temple having been built around 1250 CE, though an earlier temple might have existed at the same site. However, there are also sections that are of earlier vintage. There is the question of the relative superiority of Shiva and Surya, vis-à-vis Vishnu. For example, the Brahma Purana has 108 of Surya’s names. There are chapters that are verbatim reproductions of sections from the Mahabharata, Hari Vamsha and other Puranas, but there are also sections on Surya that are new. One should not deduce that the Brahma Purana copied from these texts, since these various texts might have had a common origin. The sections on Utkala read like a Sthala Purana, not deserving of the status of a Maha-Purana. To compound matters, there is the Goutami Mahatmya section, about the greatness of the river Goutami or Godavari. This too, has the attribute of a Sthala Purana and is different in nature from the rest of the Brahma Purana. Should it at all have been included in a translation of the Brahma Purana? We have decided to include it, because it is part of the Brahma Purana text published by Nag Publishers. It was also included in the Brahma Purana translation undertaken earlier by the board of scholars. Accordingly, we have labelled the main Brahma Purana text as Part I of the text and the Goutami Mahatmya section as Part II of the text. As mentioned earlier, the Brahma Purana text is believed to possess 10,000 *shlokas*. Part I, the main portion of the text, has 9,137 *shlokas*, fairly close to the cited number of 10,000. Part II has 4,681 *shlokas*, with an aggregate of 13,818 *shlokas* for the entire text. There are 138 chapters in Part I and 105 in Part II, a total of 243 chapters for the entire text. In numbering the chapters, the first number refers to the part and the second number (within brackets) refers to the number of the chapter within that part. Thus, Chapter 2(35) means the thirty-fifth chapter from Part II. While parts of the Brahma Purana were composed by those familiar with the region of Utkala and

Dandakaranya, Chapter 1(23) reveals some familiarity with other parts of the country too.

In the translations of the Bhagavad Gita, the Mahabharata, the Hari Vamsha, the Valmiki Ramayana, the Bhagavata Purana and the Markandeya Purana, ¹⁰ we followed the principle of not using diacritical marks. The use of diacritical marks (effectively the international alphabet of Sanskrit transliteration) makes the pronunciation and rendering more accurate, but also tends to put off readers who are less academically inclined. Since diacritical marks are not being used, there is a challenge of rendering Sanskrit names in English. Sanskrit is a phonetic language and we have used that principle as a basis. Applied consistently, this means that words are rendered in ways that may seem unfamiliar. Hence, Gautama will appear as Goutama here. This is true of proper names, and, in a few rare cases, of geographical names. The absence of diacritical marks causes some minor problems. How does one distinguish Vasudeva Krishna from Krishna's father, Vasudeva? Often, the context will make the difference clear. If not, we have written the son as Vaasudeva and the father as Vasudeva. In translating, the attempt has been to provide a word for word translation, so that if one were to hold up the Sanskrit text, there would be a perfect match. In the process, the English is not as smooth as it might have been, deliberately so.

The intention is also to offer a translation, not an interpretation. That sounds like a simple principle to adopt and, for the most part, is easy to follow. However, there is a thin dividing line between translation and interpretation. In some instances, it is impossible to translate without bringing in a little bit of interpretation. Inevitably, interpretation is subjective. We have tried to minimize the problem by (a) reducing interpretation; (b) relegating interpretation to footnotes; and (c) when there are alternative interpretations, pointing this out to the reader through those footnotes.

But all said and done, there is no substitute to reading these texts in the original Sanskrit. To the average person, the name of the Brahma Purana may not be as familiar as that of the Bhagavata Purana or the Markandeya

Purana, but it is an important Purana. Therefore, it is worth reading and translating.

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Part I of Brahma Purana

Chapter 1(113): 170 shlokas
Chapter 1(114): 56 shlokas
Chapter 1(115): 65 shlokas
Chapter 1(116): 57 shlokas
Chapter 1(117): 63 shlokas
Chapter 1(118): 67 shlokas
Chapter 1(119): 50 shlokas
Chapter 1(120): 152 shlokas
Chapter 1(121): 88 shlokas
Chapter 1(122): 82 shlokas
Chapter 1(123): 93 shlokas
Chapter 1(124): 40 shlokas
Chapter 1(125): 49 shlokas
Chapter 1(126): 75 shlokas
Chapter 1(127): 31 shlokas
Chapter 1(128): 69 shlokas
Chapter 1(129): 89 shlokas
Chapter 1(130): 57 shlokas
Chapter 1(131): 61 shlokas
Chapter 1(132): 112 shlokas
Chapter 1(133): 48 shlokas
Chapter 1(134): 58 shlokas
Chapter 1(135): 90 shlokas
Chapter 1(136): 48 shlokas
Chapter 1(137): 53 shlokas
Chapter 1(138): 40 shlokas

Total in Part I 9,137

Chapter 1(113) (Virtuous practices)

Vyasa said, ‘In this way, a householder must properly worship the gods and the ancestors with *havya* and *kavya*.¹ Guests, relatives, servants, all other beings like animals, birds, ants, mendicants who seek alms and travelers who come to the house must be offered food. O *brahmanas*! This is good conduct for virtuous householders. If one transgresses *nitya* and *naimittika* rites,² one commits a sin.’

The sages asked, ‘O *brahmanas*! You have spoken about *nitya* and *naimittika* rites. The tasks undertaken by a man are of three types—*nitya*, *naimittika* and *kamya*. O sage! We wish to hear about *sadachara*.³ Please tell us. What are these, enabling a man to obtain happiness in this world and in the next one?’

Vyasa replied, ‘A householder must always examine his conduct. A man devoid of good conduct does not obtain benefit in this world or in the next one. Sacrifices, donations and austerities do not bring benefit to a man who transgresses the norms of *sadachara*. A person with good conduct obtains a long lifespan like that of Brahma. Tasks that have *dharma* and *sadachara* should be the signs of conduct.

O *brahmanas*! I will tell you about the nature of good conduct. One must follow these with single-minded attention. A person who is a householder must seek to attain the three objectives.⁴ Thereby, a householder obtains success in this world and also obtains success in the world hereafter. A person who knows himself should use one-fourth of what he possesses for the world hereafter.⁵ He should use half to sustain himself and for *nitya* and *naimittika* rites. The remaining quarter should be used to increase the original wealth. O *brahmanas*! If he acts in this way, the *artha* becomes successful. To counter sins, a learned person must indulge in acts of

dharma. Such tasks undertaken for the next world also bring success in this world. Depending on what one desires, conduct to accomplish the three objectives are of two contrary types—those that are desirable and those that are perverse. Since they are linked to each other, one must think about each of these. O supreme among *brahmanas*! Understand the ones that are perverse in nature. *Artha* that is pursued for *dharma* is good, but *artha* that is not used for *dharma* causes suffering to one's own self. ⁶ Similarly, *dharma* is of two types and *kama* is also of two types. One must get up at the time of brahma *muhurta* ⁷ and think about *dharma* and *artha*. After getting up, one must perform one's ablutions. One must control oneself and bathe and purify oneself. This is the time of the morning *sandhya*, when the *nakshatras* are still in the western horizon. ⁸ As is proper, he should worship them, along with the sun. He should drink water or take food only after this. He must avoid lies, excessive talk and false and harsh words. O *brahmanas*! He must avoid wicked texts and the service of those who are wicked. He must always control himself and offer oblations in the morning and in the evening. At the time of sunrise and sunset, he must not look at the sun. Some tasks must be performed in the forenoon—cleaning the hair while looking at a mirror, brushing the teeth and washing the mouth and offering oblations to the gods. Urine and excrement must not be released in habitations within villages, *tirthas*, ⁹ fields, along roads and in pastures and pens of cows. One should not look at another person's wife when she is naked or at one's own excrement. One should not see, touch or converse with a woman who is going through her period. One should not release urine or excrement in water or indulge in sexual intercourse inside water. One should not stand on urine, excrement, hair, ashes, or the sharp edges of swords. A wise person will not stand on husk, burning coal, bits of ropes and garments that are strewn along the path or are lying on the ground. A householder should eat only after he has worshipped the gods, the ancestors, humans and other creatures according to his wealth. Purifying himself after rinsing his mouth and maintaining silence, a man must eat his food while seated facing the east or the north. He must always place his hands on his knees. Except when the food is tainted, a learned person will

not point out defects in the food. He should avoid the direct use of salt and should not eat leftover food. ¹⁰ A self-controlled man will not pass urine or excrement while he is standing or walking. He will never eat anything that has been touched by *ucchishta*. If he has eaten anything that is *ucchishta*, he will avoid studying then. He will not willfully look at the sun, the moon or the *nakshatras*. If a seat, a bed or a vessel is broken, he must not use it. A person must stand up and offer his *guru* his own seat. An intelligent person will always converse kindly with them. ¹¹ He must always follow them and not act against them. Clad in a single garment, one should not eat or worship the gods. O *brahmanas*! Without a fire, an intelligent person will not offer oblations. A man must never bathe or sleep naked. When he scratches his head, he must not use both of his hands together. Without examining it and without any reason, a learned person does not wash his head. After the head has been washed, he must not allow oil to touch any of his limbs. One must avoid studying on any of the days when studying is prohibited. One must never show disrespect to *brahmanas*, the fire, cows or the sun. During the day, urine and excrement must be released while facing the north. During the night, it should be the south. However, at a time when there is some impediment, they can be released as one wishes. One should not speak about any wicked deed a *guru* may have done. When he is angry, one should placate him. One should not listen to those who slander him. The right of path should be given to *brahmanas*, the king, those who are miserable and afflicted, to those who are superior in learning, pregnant women, to those who are suffering from disease, those who are greater, the deaf, mute and blind and to those who are intoxicated or mad. A learned person must perform *pradakshina* ¹² of a temple, a tree in a chaitya, ¹³ a crossroads where four roads meet and a *guru* who is superior in learning. One should not wear footwear, garments or garlands worn by another.

‘On the eighth, fourteenth or fifteenth lunar day or on auspicious days, one should not smear the limbs with oil. On these days, one must also avoid intercourse with a woman. A wise person will never sit with his legs or feet extended. One should not fling one’s legs around nor should one rub one leg against another leg. He should avoid the use of harsh words to revile

and pierce the inner organs of a *pumshchali*,¹⁴ a child or a fallen person who has performed a misdeed. A discriminating person should never be insolent, proud or harsh. He should not laugh at or revile those who are stupid, mad, distressed, malformed, suffering from delusion, lacking a limb, or a poor person. He should not impose punishment on anyone else. Nor, for the sake of instruction, should he punish a son or a disciple. When he is about to sit, a wise person will not drag the seat towards him with a foot. He should not prepare *samyava*,¹⁵ *krisara*¹⁶ or flesh for himself. In the morning and in the evening, he should eat only after the guests have been honoured. Without speaking, he must clean his teeth with his face towards the east or the north.

O *brahmanas*! Forbidden wood must never be used for cleaning the teeth. A man must not sleep with his head facing the north or the west. One should sleep with the head facing the south or the east.¹⁷ One should not bathe in water that smells nor should one bathe at night. Bathing at night is permissible only on days when there is an eclipse. After bathing, one should not use one's hands or a piece of cloth to wipe the water from the body. After bathing, one should not get rid of the water by shaking one's head or shaking one's garment. Unless he has bathed, a learned person will never apply unguents on his body. He should not wear a red garment, a black garment, or a garment that is multicoloured. Garments or ornaments must not be contrary to the rules. A damaged or torn garment must never be used. One should not eat food that has hair or lice in it, food that has been trodden upon or food that a dog has looked at. One should avoid meat licked by a dog, meat where the essence has been tainted, the flesh from the back and flesh cooked in vain.¹⁸ A man should not use salt directly. O *brahmanas*! Food that has been left for a long time, food that is dry or is tainted in any other way must be avoided. O supreme *brahmanas*! However, derived products of cakes, vegetables, sugarcane and milk and derived products of meat need not be avoided even if they have been left for a very long time. One should not sleep between sunrise and sunset. A man must not sleep after a bath. He should not sleep when his mind is distracted. He should not sleep when seated. When he sits down, or when he lies down, he must not

make a sound. A man must not eat without giving a share to those who are looking. According to the injunctions, he must eat after he has bathed in the morning and in the evening. A learned man will not have intercourse with another person's wife. If a man has intercourse with another man's wife, his good merits from sacrifices and civic works are destroyed. In this world, there is nothing that is as destructive of a man's lifespan as having intercourse with another person's wife. After properly and reverentially performing *achamana*,¹⁹ one should perform the rites for the gods, the fire and the ancestors and greet the *guru*. The act of taking food must be done only after this. The water used for *achamana* must be without foam, without a smell and without dirt. The rinsing must be done with the head facing the north or the east. For cleaning oneself,²⁰ five kinds of earth must be avoided—earth from inside a water body, from the habitation, from a termite-hill, from a rat-hole and leftover earth from an earlier act of cleaning. After cleaning oneself, the hands and the feet must be cleaned attentively. Seated, with his knees next to each other, a man must sip water three or four times. He must touch his limbs and his head with the water twice. With these rites, he purifies himself properly with water. After sneezing, spitting or wearing a garment, a learned person must rinse his mouth. After sneezing, spitting, passing wind or passing excrement, he must do this. When he touches something that should not be touched, he must perform *achamana*, look at the sun and touch his right ear to the extent he can. He must follow this in the due order. If one act in the order is missing, he should proceed with the next one. It is said that if a preceding act is missing, one should proceed with the subsequent one. One should not gnash one's teeth, nor should one strike one's own body. At the time of the two *sandhyas*, one should not sleep, study or eat. One should not indulge in sexual intercourse or depart at the time of *sandhya*. In the afternoon, one should faithfully offer oblations to the ancestors. This is also true of washing the head or performing rites for the gods and the ancestors. Shaving must be done while facing the north or the east. Even when she has been born in a good lineage, a woman who is diseased, without a limb or malformed in a limb must be avoided. The girl one marries should not be

related on the father's side for seven generations and on the mother's side for five generations. It is necessary to avoid all jealousy and protect the wife. Sleep and sexual intercourse during the day must be avoided. Acts that cause torment to others and affliction to creatures must always be shunned. During the four days when a woman goes through her period, all the *varnas* must avoid association with her. If the birth of a daughter is to be avoided, one must avoid intercourse on the fifth night and indulge in it on the sixth night. Even nights are the best. Boys are born through intercourse on even nights and girls through intercourse on odd nights. Intercourse on festive days ²¹ gives birth to a son who is against *dharma*. Intercourse in the evening gives birth to a eunuch. When shaving, a discriminating person will avoid a desolate spot. One should never listen to what insolent people say. An excellent seat should never be affectionately offered to a person who is not excellent. O *brahmanas*! A wise person has a bath after shaving, after intercourse with a woman, after vomiting and after visiting a cremation ground. O *brahmanas*! The gods, the Vedas, *brahmanas*, virtuous and great-souled ones, preceptors, women who are faithful to their husbands, those who perform sacrifices and ascetics must not be criticized. Nor should one laugh at them. One should wear white garments and adorn oneself with white flowers. One must always be clad in what is auspicious, never in something that is inauspicious. A learned person must never associate with, or contract a friendship with, a person who is insolent, mad, foolish, proud, wicked in conduct, those who are defiled because of age and class, those who spend excessively, men who are enemies, those who are unskilled in their work, those who are censured, those who associate with rogues, those who are without money, men who are addicted to arguing and those who are debased in any other way. One should stand up and greet well-wishers, those who have been initiated, the king, *snatakas* ²² and the father-in-law when they visit the house, using words of welcome. O *brahmanas*! One should offer them proper hospitality according to one's means. When they have stayed for more than a year and they return to their own residences, they must be honoured in the proper way.'

‘After having honoured them in the due order, he must worship the fire, progressively rendering oblations into it. The first offering must be given to Brahma, the second to Prajapati, the third to the divinities in the house, the fourth to Kashyapa and the last to Anumati.²³ This is the way offerings must be made in the house. I have already described to you the recommended *nitya* rituals. O *brahmanas*! Hear about how offerings must be made to the Vishvadevas. In separate regions, there must be separate offerings for the divinities. Three offerings must be made to Parjanya, the earth and the water-pot.²⁴ After this, an offering will be given to Vayu and beginning with the east, each cardinal direction must progressively be given offerings. Progressive offerings are rendered to Brahma, the sky, the sun, the Vishvadevas and all the creatures in the universe. Purifying oneself, offerings are given to Usha²⁵ and the lord of creatures²⁶ in the northern direction. Uttering ‘*svadha cha namah*’, offerings to the ancestors are given in the southern direction.²⁷ Using his right hand, he will then follow the rituals, take the remaining bit of food and water and offer it in the north-western direction to Vayu, uttering, ‘To Yakshma.’²⁸ Thereafter, he will prostrate himself before the gods and the *brahmanas*. For *achamana*, *brahma-tirtha* is the line at the base of the right thumb.²⁹ The region between the right thumb and the right index finger is said to be *pitri-tirtha*. With the exception of the *nandimukha* ritual, this is used to offer water to the ancestors.³⁰ The tips of the fingers are known as *deva-tirtha* and are used for rites connected with the gods. The base of the little finger is known as *kaya-tirtha* and is used for rites connected with Prajapati. The rites for the gods and the ancestors must always be performed with these *tirthas* and an inappropriate *tirtha* must never be used. *Brahma-tirtha* is best for *achamana* and *pitri-tirtha* must always be used for the ancestors. *Deva-tirtha* must be used for the gods and *kaya-tirtha* must be used for rites connected with Prajapati. During the *nandimukha* ritual, a wise person will use *kaya-tirtha* to perform the *pinda* and water rites. Everything connected with Prajapati must be through *kaya-tirtha*.

‘A discriminating person must not hold water and fire at the same time. In front of *gurus*, gods, ancestors and *brahmanas*, he will not stretch out his legs. He glances towards ³¹ a cow that is suckling her calf. He should not drink water from the cup of his palms. The rites of purification, whether the transgression is major or minor, must be undertaken at the right time. An intelligent person will not delay the rite of purification. One should not use one’s mouth to blow into a fire. O *brahmanas*! One should not reside in a region that does not have four things—a person who lends money, a physician, a learned brahmana and a river full of water. A wise person will always reside in a place where there is a powerful king who is devoted to *dharma* and has control over his servants. How can there be happiness when the king is wicked? There is happiness from residing in a place where self-controlled citizens always follow law and the people are devoid of jealousy and are tranquil. A discriminating person should live in a kingdom where the farmers are generally strong and not excessively proud, where there is no dearth of crops and medicinal herbs. O *brahmanas*! One should never live in a place where three kinds of people exist—those who are always eager to conquer, those who are always addicted to festivities and those who are former enemies. A learned person will always reside with companions who are good in conduct. O *brahmanas*! For the sake of your welfare, I have described all this to you.’

‘I will next tell you about food and about how it is to be taken. Stale rice, even if it has been kept for a long time, can be eaten as long as it is soaked in oil. Products of wheat, barley and milk, when kept for a long time can be eaten without being soaked in oil. The meat of hares, tortoises, lizards, porcupines and fish with scales can be eaten. However, the meat of domesticated pigs and domesticated hens should not be eaten. There is no taint from eating meat that is leftover after the offerings to the gods and ancestors or at *shraddha* ceremonies in accordance with the wishes of *brahmanas*, once it has been purified, ³² or meat that is for medication. Conch shells, stones, gold, silver, ropes, garments, vegetables, roots, fruits, wickerwork baskets, leather objects, jewel-encrusted garments, coral, pearls and vessels and spoons are also best cleaned with water. Iron is cleaned

with water, stone through rubbing and oily vessels with warm water. Winnowing baskets, deer skin, mortars, pestles and heaps of garments are cleaned by sprinkling water over the collection. All kinds of bark are properly cleaned with water and earth. Objects made of wool or hair are cleaned with *kalka* paste³³ and then with the oil of sesamum seeds. There must always be purification and cleansing. Thus, a cotton garment is always purified with water and ashes. Objects made of ivory, bones or horn are purified through paring. An earthen vessel is purified when it is baked again. Something obtained as alms, an object fashioned through the hand of an artisan, an article traded and a woman's mouth are pure. Something brought along a road, an object that is unknown, something that has been cleaned by a retinue of servants, something that has been praised earlier, something that is long past, an object that has passed through many hands, a light object, something that has many children inside it, something for which aged people have made efforts, a store of coal when the required task is over and the two breasts of a woman are pure. Odourless water that has a flow is said to be pure. The ground is purified over time and when cattle roam over it. A dwelling-house is purified by smearing,³⁴ scraping, sprinkling and sweeping. Something tainted with hair, worms or flies, or smelt by cattle, is purified with earth, water and ashes. Objects made of *udumbara*³⁵ wood are cleaned with acid, those made of tin through a caustic solution, those of copper with water and ashes and through repeated washing. Something with a bad smell is purified by using earth and water to remove the bad smell. Other objects are thus purified when their bad complexion and bad odour has been removed. Meat dropped by a *chandala*³⁶ or a predatory creature is pure. Oil that has spilt on the road is pure. Water that satisfies a cow is pure. Dust particles, a fire, a horse, a cow, a shadow, rays,³⁷ the wind, the earth and a drop of water do not get polluted even if they come into contact with something vile like a fly. The mouth of a goat or the mouth of a horse is pure, but this is not true of the mouth of a calf when its mother is still suckling it. A fruit brought down by a bird is pure. Like an object that is traded, a seat, a bed, a vehicle, the bank of a river and grass are pure because the rays of the sun and the moon fall on them and the

air passes over them. After travelling on the road, bathing, eating, drinking and other tasks, one must change one's garment and perform *achamana*. If one comes into contact with a bad road, mud and water or an object made of brick or clay, nothing need be done. They are purified by the wind. If a large quantity of rice has been tainted, a bit from the top should be thrown away. The remainder is purified by sprinkling some earth and water on it. If one eats something that should not be eaten, whether voluntarily or involuntarily, to atone for this sin, one should fast for three nights. If a person touches a woman who is going through her period, a woman who has touched her, a woman who has just delivered, an outcaste or one who has borne a dead body, he must purify himself by having a bath. If a brahmana touches a human bone that has fat in it, he is purified by bathing. However, if he touches a human bone without fat, he should perform *achamana*, touch a cow and look at the sun. A wise person will never walk over blood or spit or leap over an obstacle. Leftovers, urine, excrement and water used to wash the feet must be cast away outside the house. One should not bathe in another person's water without taking up five *pindas* of clay from there. One should bathe in natural ponds, ³⁸ the Ganga and rivers and lakes. A wise person will not remain in gardens and similar places at the wrong time. One should not converse with those who are hated by people or with women who do not have brave sons. One should not touch or have a conversation with those who criticize the gods, the ancestors, the sacred texts, sacrifices and *sanyasis*. If one happens to touch or converse with them, one should purify oneself by looking at the sun. A wise person who looks at a woman going through her period, an abandoned dead body that has been cast away, a person who is against *dharma*, a woman who has just delivered, a eunuch, a naked person, an outcast, a person who carries dead bodies or an adulterer, should purify himself in the same way. When a person who knows about *dharma* touches a mendicant who should not be fed, a heretic, a cat, an ass, a cock, a person who has fallen down, a *chandala* or a person who carries a dead body, a woman during her period or a village pig, he is purified by taking a bath. This must also be done if a person touches a woman who has just delivered, a man who is tainted and

polluted in this way, a person who does not perform the daily *nitya* tasks in his home, a person who has been abandoned by *brahmanas*, or a worst among men who lives on sin. The *nitya* rites must never suffer. I will tell you about the only occasions when they need not be performed. In the case of birth and death, a brahmana can refrain from donations and offering oblations for ten days. A *kshatriya* can refrain from *nitya* rites for twelve days, a *vaishya* for fifteen days and a shudra for a month. Thereafter, as instructed, one should engage in one's own tasks. The dead body must be cremated outside the house by people who belong to the same *gotra*. After this, water is offered to the departed spirit on the first, third, seventh or ninth day.³⁹ On the fourth day, the ashes and bones⁴⁰ are collected by people who belong to the same *gotra*. After they have undertaken the task of collection, it is recommended that their upper bodies be touched. After the collection, all the rites should be performed by those who are from the same *gotra*. On the day of death, only *sapindas* are allowed to touch each other.⁴¹ When death is caused by a weapon, hanging by a rope, fire or poison, the same method must be followed. When death occurs because of an act of *praya*,⁴² when the person dies when he is in some other country or when the dead person is a child, the period of impurity lasts for one day, though some say impurity lasts for three days. If a *sapinda* dies after another *sapinda*'s death, the period of impurity is reckoned from the day on which the first *sapinda* died. The daily purification rites mentioned earlier, must be performed. These are also the recommended norms for a birth, to be followed after delivery by *sapindas* and *sahodakas*. When a son is born, a father must have a bath wearing the clothes he was wearing at the time of birth. If after the birth of the first son, another son is born, the period of impurity is reckoned from the day of the first birth. After ten, twelve, fifteen days and a month,⁴³ all the *varnas* should perform their respective recommended rites. Thereafter, for the departed spirit, an *ekoddishtha*⁴⁴ ceremony must be performed. As gifts to *brahmanas*, learned people give whatever is cherished in the world and whatever is loved in the house. Desiring one's undecaying prosperity, in the name of the departed spirits, one should give all that possesses qualities. When those days are over, one

touches water, a mount or a weapon. Each *varna* undertakes the proper completion of the rites. If one observes all the rites recommended and purifies oneself, one obtains prosperity in this world and in the next world. If one studies the three Vedas every day, one becomes learned. Having accumulated riches according to *dharma*, one must make efforts to undertake sacrifices. O *brahmanas*! One must act so that one is not condemned. One must unhesitatingly do whatever need not be kept a secret from great people. O *brahmanas*! If a householder acts in this way, he obtains *dharma*, *artha* and *kama* in this world and all that is auspicious in the world hereafter. This is the secret to increasing the lifespan, prosperity and intelligence. This is sacred and destroys all sins. This is auspicious and ensures prosperity, nourishment and freedom from disease. It ensures fame and deeds and increases the strength and energy of men. O supreme among sages! It ensures the excellent objective of heaven and men must always observe it, whether they are *brahmanas*, *kshatriyas*, *vaishyas* or *shudras*. Those who desire their benefit must carefully get to know everything about this. Having learnt it, a person must undertake it at the right time. He will then be freed from all sins and attain greatness in heaven. O excellent *brahmanas*! You have been told about the essence of all essences. This is the *dharma* mentioned in the *shruti* and *smriti* texts. O *brahmanas*! This must never be revealed to non-believers, those who are evil in intelligence, those who are insolent or foolish and those who indulge excessively in false debates.'

Chapter 1(114) (The tasks of *varnas* and *ashramas*)

The sages said, ‘O *brahmanas*! We wish to hear about the specific dharma for different *varnas*. O noble brahmana! Please tell us about the dharma for the four *ashramas*.’ ⁴⁵

Vyasa replied, ‘Listen attentively. In due order, I will tell you about the *dharma* for *brahmanas*, *kshatriyas*, *vaishyas* and *shudras* and the *dharma* for the *varnas*. A brahmana must always practice compassion, donations, austerities, sacrifices to the gods and self-studying. He must always observe the water-rites and maintain the sacrificial fire. O *brahmanas*! For the sake of subsistence, he will perform sacrifices for others. He will teach *brahmanas*. In the case of sacrifices, he will consciously accept donations. O *brahmanas*! He must always do what ensures benefit for everyone and never cause harm to anyone. Friendliness towards all creatures is the greatest wealth for a brahmana. O *brahmanas*! His intelligence must be such that he regards a cow and someone else’s jewel as equal. O *brahmanas*! When he has intercourse with his wife just after her period is over, that is praised. A *kshatriya* will give *brahmanas* whatever they wish for. O *brahmanas*! He must study and perform different kinds of sacrifices. He must earn his living through weapons. Protecting the earth is the best means of subsistence for him. Protection of the earth has been thought of first. Lords of the earth have become successful in their objectives by protecting the earth. When there is a king, sacrifices and other rites are protected. The task of a king is to punish the wicked and protect the virtuous. That is the way he establishes the *varnas* and attains the desired worlds. O supreme sages! Brahma, the grandfather of the worlds, gave *vaishyas* animal husbandry, trade and agriculture as a means of subsistence.

Studying, sacrifices and donations are also praised as *dharma* for them, as is the performance of *nitya*, *naimittika* and other rites. A shudra's tasks derive from the sustenance of *dvijas*.⁴⁶ Therefore, he must give them whatever riches he earns through sale and purchase or artisanship, in the form of donations. A shudra must also perform all the rites for the ancestors and *paka-yajna*.⁴⁷ O supreme *brahmanas*! The following are said to be general qualities of all the *varnas*—receiving gifts for the sustainment of servants and others, approaching one's own wife at the time of her period, compassion towards all creatures, forbearance, lack of pride, truthfulness, the easy observance of purity and everything auspicious, amiable speech, friendliness, lack of desire, lack of miserliness and lack of jealousy. These are the general characteristics of all the *ashramas*. O *brahmanas*! Secondary *dharma* and qualities also exist for *brahmanas* and others. When there is a calamity, a brahmana can follow the tasks indicated for a *kshatriya* or a *vaishya*. In times of a calamity, a *kshatriya*⁴⁸ can follow the tasks indicated for a *vaishya* or a shudra and a *vaishya* can follow the tasks indicated for a shudra. O *brahmanas*! If he is incapable, he can give up either. However, even in the case of a calamity, one must not mix up the two kinds of tasks.⁴⁹ O *brahmanas*! I have, thus described to you the *dharma* of the *varnas*.

'I will now properly tell you about the *dharma* of the *ashramas*. Listen, after the sacred thread ceremony⁵⁰ has been performed, a boy must study the Vedas. O *brahmanas*! He will reside in his *guru*'s house, controlling himself and practicing *brahmacharya*. His task there is to practice purity in conduct and serve his preceptor. He must observe the vows and turn his mind towards receiving the Vedas. O *brahmanas*! He must control himself and worship the sun and the fire at the time of both the *sandhyas*. He must stand up and greet the preceptor. When the preceptor stands, he will stand. When the preceptor walks, he will walk. When the preceptor is seated, he will be seated below him. O best among *brahmanas*! A disciple must avoid anything that is against the preceptor. He will stand in front of him and with a single-minded attention study the Vedas recited by him.⁵¹ When he is permitted by his preceptor, he will eat the food received as alms. He will

bathe in the water in which his teacher ⁵² has bathed. He must be ready to collect kindling and water at dawn. After having received the Vedas he is entitled to receive, a wise person will take leave from his *guru* and having taken his leave, will enter the stage of *garhasthya*. Following the norms, he will obtain a wife and earn riches through his own tasks. O *brahmanas*! According to his own capacity, he must perform all the tasks indicated for a householder. He must worship the ancestors, perform sacrifices to the gods, offer food to the guests, honour the sages by studying and have offspring to honour Prajapati. Through his offerings he will honour creatures and through his true words, the entire world. In this way, through his own clean deeds, a man obtains the worlds. There are those who follow *brahmacharya* and travel around while sustaining themselves on what is obtained as alms. They depend on the householder. Therefore, the stage of *garhasthya* is the best. O *brahmanas*! There are *brahmanas* who roam around the earth, disseminating the Vedas, bathing in *tirthas* and visiting different places on earth. They have no fixed abode. When they are hungry in the evening, it is the householder who always offers them food and shelter. Therefore, it is said that they depend on the householder. A householder must welcome them with gifts and pleasant words. When they come to his house, he must offer them a bed, a seat and food. When a guest who has arrived at a house goes away dissatisfied, he leaves his bad deeds with the householder and takes away the householder's good deeds. For a householder, the following are never praised—disrespect to others, egotism, insolence, slander, causing harm and harsh words. If a householder properly follows the supreme norms that have been indicated, he is freed from every kind of bondage and attains excellent worlds. O *brahmanas*! When a householder is ripe and has completed all the tasks meant for a householder, he leaves for the forest. He can entrust the care of his wife with his sons, or take her with him. He survives on leaves, roots and fruits. He does not cut his hair or shave his beard and his hair is matted. O *brahmanas*! Like a sage, he lies down on the ground and can be a guest at anyone's house. His upper garment must be made of hide, *kasha* grass or *kusha* grass. O supreme among *brahmanas*! It is recommended that he should bathe thrice a day. For him, the following

are praised—worshipping the gods, offering oblations honouring all those who visit him, begging for alms and performing sacrifices. It is recommended that he smear his limbs with oil obtained from the forest. O Indras among *brahmanas*! A sage who is in *vanaprastha* must always tolerate extreme heat and cold. Those are his austerities. Like a fire, it burns down his taints and he attains the eternal worlds. The learned have spoken of the fourth *ashrama* as that of the *bhikshu*.⁵³ O excellent ones! I will speak about it. Understand its nature. O supreme among *brahmanas*! He must give up all attachment towards his sons, wives and objects. He will proceed to the fourth *ashrama* only when he has given up all envy. O supreme *brahmanas*! He will not undertake any task indicated for the three *varnas*. He will be friendly towards all creatures and treat all of them as his friends. In his thoughts, words and deeds, he will never cause injury to creatures born from the womb, from the egg and so on. He will give up all sense of attachment. He will stay in a village for one night and in a city for five nights.⁵⁴ He will not exhibit affection or hatred for inferior species. For the sake of sustaining his life, he should visit houses and ask for alms, but only when the coal is not burning and when the incumbents have not eaten.⁵⁵ He will not be distressed when nothing is obtained. Nor will he be delighted when something is obtained. He will always abhor gains that are extremely sought after. Such extremely sought-after gains bind down a sage. Casting aside, *kama*, *krodha*, *darpa*, *lobha*, *moha* and the other taints, he will free himself from the sense of ‘mine’.⁵⁶ As he roams around the earth, he will grant all creatures freedom from fear. When he is freed from everything connected with the body, he will never suffer from fear. He will perform the *agnihotra* sacrifice from within his own body, using his own mouth to offer oblations to the fire that is within his body. A brahmana will use what he has obtained through begging to offer oblations to the fire that is in his consciousness. When he is in the *ashrama* of *moksha*, his resolution and intelligence must be to purify himself in this way. Like a fire without kindling, such *dvijas*⁵⁷ are serene and go to Brahma’s world.’

Chapter 1(115) (Transition between *varnas*)

The sages said, ‘O immensely fortunate one! You know everything and are engaged in the welfare of all creatures. O sage! There is nothing that you do not know, of the past, the present and the future. Through what *karma* does one obtain a destination as an inferior *varna* and how does one attain the status of a superior *varna*? O immensely intelligent one! Please tell us this.’ Through what *karma* does a shudra obtain the status of a brahmana? We wish to hear how a brahmana becomes a shudra.’

Vyasa replied, ‘The beautiful summit of the Himalayas is decorated with many kinds of minerals. There are many kinds of trees and creepers and varied wonders. The three-eyed Mahadeva, the destroyer of Tripura,⁵⁸ resides there. The goddess, the daughter of the king of the mountains,⁵⁹ bowed down before the lord of the gods. O *brahmanas*! In ancient times, the one with the beautiful eyes asked him this question. O supreme among sages! I will tell you about this. Listen.’

Uma said, ‘O illustrious one! O destroyer of Bhaga’s eyes and Pusha’s teeth!⁶⁰ O one who destroyed Daksha’s sacrifice! O three-eyed one! I have a great doubt. In ancient times, the illustrious Svayambhu⁶¹ created the four *varnas*. How and through what *karma* does a *vaishya* become a shudra? Through the practice of what *dharma* does the reverse progression happen?⁶² Through what *karma* is a brahmana born as a shudra? O lord! Through what *karma* does a *kshatriya* become a shudra? O god! O Bhutapati!⁶³ I have a doubt about this. Please tell me. Through what kind of nature can the three *varnas* become *brahmanas*?’

Maheshvara replied, ‘O goddess! The status of becoming a brahmana is difficult to obtain. It is my view that *brahmanas* are naturally auspicious, while *kshatriyas*, *vaishyas* and shudras are naturally not auspicious.

Through wicked deeds of *karma*, *brahmanas* are dislodged from their position. Though they have obtained the status of the best *varna*, they are flung down from there. If a *kshatriya* or a *vaishya* follows the *dharma* of a *brahmana* and earns his living through what is specified for a *brahmana*, he obtains the status of a *brahmana*. If a *brahmana* gives up what is meant for him and follows the *dharma* of a *kshatriya*, he is dislodged from the status of being a *brahmana* and is born as a *kshatriya*. The status of being a *brahmana* is extremely difficult to obtain. However, having attained it, out of avarice or confusion, if a *brahmana* undertakes the tasks of a *vaishya*, the *brahmana* becomes a *vaishya*. That is also how a *vaishya* becomes a *shudra*. A *brahmana* who is dislodged from his own *dharma* becomes a *shudra*. A person who has been ousted from his own *varna* goes to hell. A person who has been dislodged from Brahma's world is born as a *shudra*. O immensely fortunate one! A *kshatriya* or a *vaishya* who deviates from his own *dharma* and *karma* and follows the *karma* of a *shudra* is dislodged from his own *varna* and is born as one whose *varna* is mixed. Such a *brahmana*, *kshatriya* or *vaishya* can also become a *shudra*. A *shudra* engaged in his own *dharma*, one who is pure and conversant with *jnana* and *vijnana* ⁶⁴ and knowledgeable about *dharma*, one who is devoted to *dharma*, obtains the fruits of that *dharma*. O goddess! In this connection, the *brahman* has also been spoken about. Those who desire success in the pursuit of *dharma* must be devoted to *adhyatma*. ⁶⁵ O goddess! The food cooked by an *ugra* ⁶⁶ is condemned. Food cooked collectively or at the time of birth or death, is also condemned. When the cooking of food is announced publicly or when that food has been cooked by a *shudra*, that too must never be taken. O goddess! Gods and great-souled ones always condemn food cooked by a *shudra*. It is my view that what has emanated from the grandfather's mouth is sufficient proof. If a *brahmana* dies with the remnants of food cooked by a *shudra* in his stomach or offers oblations to the fire or performs sacrifices with such food, ⁶⁷ he obtains the status of being a *shudra*. Because of the leftovers of food cooked by a *shudra*, such a *brahmana* is expelled from the status of being a *brahmana* and becomes a *shudra*. There is no need to reflect on this. If a *brahmana* dies with the remnants of food cooked by any *varna* in his

stomach, that brahmana attains the status of the *varna* by whose food he has sustained himself. The status of being a brahmana brings happiness and is extremely different to obtain. Having obtained it, if a person shows it disrespect by eating food that should not be eaten, he falls down from the status of being a brahmana. A drunkard, one who kills a brahmana, a thief, a robber, one who breaks his vows, an impure person, one who does not study, a wicked person, a greedy person, one who performs wicked deeds, a deceiver, one who does not observe vows, one who is the husband of a *vrishala* lady,⁶⁸ a pimp, a person who sells *soma* and a person who serves those who should not be served—such a brahmana falls down from the status of being a brahmana. One who has intercourse with his preceptor's wife, one who hates his preceptor, one who loves reviling his preceptor and one who hates *brahmanas*—such a brahmana falls down from the status of being a brahmana. O goddess! By performing the following auspicious deeds, a shudra becomes a brahmana and a *vaishya* becomes a *kshatriya*. A shudra becomes a *vaishya* by properly undertaking all the tasks recommended for a shudra, offering hospitality to everyone and eating the left over food, carefully attending to and serving the superior *varnas*, showing respect to those who are superior, always remaining established on the virtuous path, always worshiping gods and *dvijas*, observing the vow of offering hospitality to everyone, attentively having intercourse with his wife at the time of her period, being restrained in diet, being skilled, by searching for virtuous people and not eating meat in vain.⁶⁹ A *vaishya* becomes a brahmana by being truthful in speech, by being free from *ahamkara*, by being bereft of the opposite pair of sentiments, by being accomplished in conciliation, by always performing sacrifices, by studying, by being extremely pure, by being controlled, by doing good deeds towards *brahmanas*, by not being envious of any of the *varnas*, by following the vows of a householder, by eating twice a day, by eating leftovers, by following a restrained diet, by being without desire, by not speaking about himself, by performing *agnihotra* sacrifices, by following the rites and offering oblations into the fire, by being hospitable to all guests and eating leftover food and by maintaining the three fires.⁷⁰ A pure *vaishya* who

deserves to be born in a *kshatriya* lineage is a true *vaishya*. If a *vaishya* remains clean since birth, he is born as a *kshatriya*. If he is consecrated, clean and devotes himself to the vows, he becomes a brahmana. He performs sacrifices with copious quantities of *dakshina*. If he studies and always resorts to the three fires, he goes to heaven. A *kshatriya* must follow *dharma* and protect the subjects. His hand must always be wet. ⁷¹ Pure in his discrimination, he must always distinguish the true from the false. To obtain success in the pursuit of *dharma*, *artha* and *kama*, he must use his staff of *dharma* to burn down. ⁷² He must be controlled in his tasks and take a share of one-sixth. ⁷³ He must not be addicted to carnal intercourse and must be readily accomplished in *artha*. He must have *dharma* in his soul and must always approach his wife at the time of her period. He must be controlled and must always fast. He must be pure and engaged in self-studying. He must always sleep inside his house and not outside its boundaries. With a happy mind, he must always be hospitable and pursue the three objectives. ⁷⁴ He must always tell shudras who desire food, 'It has been cooked.' He should not glance at anything with selfish eyes of desire. He must gather everything required for gods and ancestors. In his house, he must worship them, even if that has to be done through begging. Following the norms, he must offer oblations and perform *agnihotra* twice a day. For the welfare of cattle and *brahmanas*, he must advance into battle and even be killed. If he purifies himself through *mantras* to the three fires, he becomes a brahmana. He becomes full of *jnana* and *vijnana*. He cleanses himself and becomes accomplished in the Vedas. Through his own deeds, a *vaishya* who has *dharma* in his soul becomes a *kshatriya*. O goddess! These are the fruits of deeds for those who are born in different classes. By cleansing himself, even a shudra can become a brahmana. In that way, if a brahmana deviates from cleaning himself and from clean food, he loses his state of being a brahmana and becomes a shudra. O goddess! If a shudra is pure in soul and conquers his senses and if he is pure in his deeds, he becomes a brahmana. Brahma has himself said this. If a shudra is engaged in his own tasks and purifies himself, he becomes a brahmana. Know that this is my view. Birth, sacraments, learning and offspring cannot be the

reason for someone being a brahmana. Good conduct alone is the reason. In this world, those who are *brahmanas* are characterized by good conduct. If he is established by good conduct, even a shudra becomes a brahmana. O one with the beautiful hips! It is my view that a brahmana is one in whom the essence of the *brahman* exists. If the *nirguna* ⁷⁵ and sparkling *brahman* exists, that person is a brahmana. O goddess! Such unblemished people indicate what should be done in different states. Brahma, the creator of subjects and the one who bestows boons, has himself said this. The brahmana is like a giant field that is roaming around on its feet. O beautiful one! If anyone sows seeds in this field, that act of agriculture yields fruits after death. If a person wants to be content, he must always think of adhering to the virtuous path. His conduct should be characterized by adhering to the brahmana's path. A person who is a householder should study the *samhita* texts ⁷⁶ at home. He must always be engaged in studying but should never resort to teaching for earning his living. Such a brahmana is always established in the virtuous path. He offers oblations into the fire and studies and is fit to be merged into the *brahman*. O goddess! Having obtained the status of being a brahmana, one must always seek to protect it. O one with the beautiful smiles! He must engage in his tasks and receive gifts from worthy donors. I have thus told you the secret about how a shudra can become a brahmana and about how a brahmana can be dislodged from *dharma* and become a shudra.'

Chapter 1(116) (Virtuous Conduct)

Uma asked, ‘O illustrious one! O lord of all beings! O one who is worshipped by the gods and the *asuras*! O god! O lord! I have a doubt about *dharma* and *adharma* for men. Please tell me. An embodied being is always bound by three bonds of thoughts, words and deeds. How is he freed from this? O god! Through what good conduct, deeds and good qualities, do men go to heaven?’

Maheshvara replied, ‘O goddess! O one who knows the true purport of *dharma*! O Uma! O one who is always devoted to *dharma*! This question is beneficial to all beings and increases their intelligence. Listen. Those who are engaged in true *dharma* are serene and show no external signs. Their doubts have been dispelled and they are not bound by notions of *dharma* or impediments to *dharma*. They know the truth about creation and destruction. They know everything and their vision is impartial. They are devoid of attachment. Such men are freed from the bondage of *karma*. In thoughts, words and deeds, they do not cause harm to anyone. They are not immersed in anything and *karma* does not bind them down. They refrain from causing injury to life. They are good in conduct and full of compassion. They are impartial towards those who hate them and love them. They are controlled and are freed from the bondage of *karma*. They are compassionate towards all creatures. They are trusted by all creatures. The conduct of such men is free from violence and they go to heaven. They are always free from any sense about what belongs to them and what belongs to others. They never associate with the wives of others. Such men enjoy wealth that has been obtained through *dharma* and go to heaven. They are devoted to their own wives and approach them at the time of their period. They refrain from the pleasure that comes from vulgar carnal

pursuits. Such men go to heaven. They refrain from theft and are always satisfied with their own riches. They earn a living through their own fortune. Such men go to heaven. Men with good conduct cover their eyes when they look at the wives of others. They are virtuous in their conduct and they conquer their senses. Such men go to heaven. In this way, men must always follow the path determined by the gods. Learned men must always follow a path that is untarnished. A learned man must always follow a path that does not unnecessarily harm others. This is a path marked by donations, rites and austerities, with good conduct, purity and compassion. This path, and no other, must be followed by those who desire to go to heaven.'

Uma said, 'O god! O Bhutapati! O unblemished one! Tell me about speech that binds people and that which frees them.'

Maheshvara replied, 'Men who do not resort to the *adharma* of uttering a lie, for their own sake or for others, go to heaven. Men who do utter a falsehood for the sake of subsistence, *dharma* or addiction to *kama*, go to heaven. Men who do not say what is not true, go to heaven. Men who go to heaven speak soft, sweet and welcoming words, clearly articulated and devoid of sin. Virtuous men who do not speak harsh, acerbic, cruel words and those who do not slander go to heaven. Those who do not slander their friends or speak so as to hurt others are men who go to heaven. Men who avoid harsh words that are full of malice towards others, those who are tranquil and impartial towards all creatures, go to heaven. Men who do not deceive or speak excessively, those who are not adversarial and are always amiable in speech, go to heaven. Their words are not spoken out of rage and do not pierce the heart. Men who are peaceful and not angry go to heaven. O goddess! Through such speech, men always serve the cause of *dharma*. These are auspicious qualities of the truth. Learned men must always avoid lies.'

Uma said, 'O immensely fortunate one! O god of the gods! O wielder of the Pinaka! ⁷⁷ What kind of thoughts always bind down a man? Please tell me.'

Maheshvara replied, ‘O fortunate one! Men whose thoughts are always full of *dharma* go to heaven. I will describe this. Listen. O one with the auspicious face! When a man’s thoughts lead him astray and when his inner being leads him astray, he is bound. Listen. When he sees another person’s possession kept in a desolate spot in the forest, but a man’s thoughts do not turn towards seizing them, he goes to heaven. There are men who are never delighted when another person’s possessions are left in a desolate spot in the village or in the house. They go to heaven. In that way, there are men whose thoughts are not overwhelmed by desire. They do not wish to seize the unprotected wives of others. Such men go to heaven. There are men whose thoughts regard friends and enemies equally. They are friendly towards whom they meet. Such men go to heaven. Men who go to heaven are learned, compassionate, pure, devoted to the truth and satisfied with their own riches. They are without any sense of enmity and their minds are naturally prone towards friendliness. They are compassionate towards all creatures. Such men go to heaven. There are learned men who perform rites. They are forgiving and love their well-wishers. They always know about *dharma* and *adharma*. Such men go to heaven. O goddess! There are men who do not wish to accumulate the fruits of auspicious or inauspicious deeds. They go to heaven. When their fortunes are on the ascendance, there are men who are always devoted to gods and *brahmanas*, avoiding those who are wicked. They go to heaven. O goddess! I have described the fruits of auspicious deeds and the path followed by those who go to heaven. What else do you want to hear?’

Uma said, ‘O Maheshvara! I have a great doubt about mortals. You are accomplished. Therefore, you should explain it to me now. O lord! Through what deeds does a man obtain a long lifespan? O lord of the gods! Through what austerities does he obtain a great lifespan? Through what deeds does a man obtain a short lifespan on earth? O god! O unblemished one! You should tell me about perverse deeds. Some have good fortune, others suffer from ill fortune. Some are born in noble lineages, others are born in inferior lineages. Some men are ugly to behold, as if they are made of wood. There are other men who are handsome to behold. Some are limited in wisdom,

others become learned. Some are extremely wise, others lack in *jnana* and *vijnana*. Some speak little, others are very eloquent. O god! This is the way men appear. You should explain this to me.'

Maheshvara replied, 'O goddess! I will tell you about the fruits of *karma*. All men on earth reap the fruits of their own deeds. There may be a man who is an Indra among *yogis*. Nevertheless, he always raises his staff to destroy life. There may be a man who always raises his weapons to kill various categories of beings. He is cruel towards all creatures and always causes anxiety. He is even merciless towards worms and insects that seek refuge. O goddess! Such a man always goes to hell. On the other hand, there may be one who has *dharma* in his soul. He is born in his own form. ⁷⁸ Those who are violent go to hell. Those who are non-violent go to heaven. In that terrible hell, a man suffers from pain and hardships. If he manages to pass through that hell in some fashion, he is born as human, but has a brief lifespan. O goddess! If a person performs wicked and violent deeds that injures all beings, he is born with a brief lifespan. O goddess! There are men who perform auspicious deeds that avoid injury to life. They do not hurl their weapons or use their staffs. They do not cause violence. They do not strike or kill, or approve of killing. They are affectionate towards all creatures and look upon others as their own self. O goddess! Such men always deserve divinity. They are happy and always enjoy bliss and objects of pleasure. They are good in conduct and follow the path of good *karma*. When they are born in the world of humans, they have a long lifespan. This is because they are free of causing violence to life. This is what Brahma has said.'

Chapter 1(117) (Attaining Heaven)

Uma asked, ‘Through what kind of conduct does a man attain heaven? What should be his behaviour and *karma*? What is the nature of his donations?’

Maheshvara replied, ‘O goddess! The following kind of man goes to the world of the gods. He is generous and shows honour to *brahmanas*. The immensely intelligent one donates food, cooked food and drinks to those who are miserable, afflicted and distressed. He constructs places to rest like assembly halls, wells and lakes. He is pure and controls himself, performing *nitya* and other rites. He is a man who with an extremely serene mind and always donates seats, couches, vehicles, homes, jewels, riches, different kinds of grains, excellent fields and women. O goddess! Such a man is born in the world of the gods. There, he enjoys excellent objects of pleasure for an extremely long period of time. Along with the *apsaras*, he amuses himself in Nandana and other places. O wife of Mahesha! O goddess! When he is dislodged from heaven, he is born in an extremely fortunate lineage and is worshipped by men. He enjoys wealth and grain. With all the qualities that characterize desire, he is happy. He enjoys a lot and performs great deeds. The man is wealthy. O goddess! Among beings, such men are extremely fortunate. They are generous. Earlier, Brahma has said that everyone finds them handsome to behold. O goddess! On the other hand, there are *brahmanas* who are miserly and do not give to others. They are limited in intelligence and do not give food, even when they possess it. Their tongues are full of greed. Therefore, those who seek, the distressed, the blind, the miserable, mendicants and guests, return dissatisfied. They never give wealth, garments and objects of pleasure, gold, cattle or cooked food. They should not be greedy, but are greedy. There are non-believers

who do not give. O goddess! Since their intelligence is perverse, such men go to hell. After the passage of time, they are born as humans. However, because they are limited in intelligence, they are born in a family that does not possess a great deal of wealth. They suffer from hunger and thirst and people treat them as outcasts. Their hopes to obtain objects of pleasure are not met and they spend their lives in *adharma*. These men are born in families with limited fortune and are addicted to trifling objects of pleasure. O goddess! Through this kind of *karma*, men are born as those who are limited in wealth. There are others who are always insolent, proud in their behaviour towards others. They are limited in intelligence and do not offer a seat or stool to those who deserve one. Since they suffer in intelligence, they do not yield passage to those who deserve to be given right of way. They do not offer *arghya* ⁷⁹ and food to those who should be worshipped and honoured according to the rites. Suffering in intelligence, they do not offer *padya* and *achamaniya*. ⁸⁰ They do not greet their revered *gurus* with loving and welcoming words. Because their arrogance increases, they are full of avarice. They disrespect those who are elders and who should be honoured. O goddess! All men who are of this type go to hell. After several years, when such men pass through hell, they take birth in condemned lineages like *shvapakas* and *pulkasas*. ⁸¹ These condemned lineages lack in intelligence. Having been born in such lineages, they do not show respect to seniors and elders. O goddess! But there are men who go to heaven—those who are not insolent and proud, those who worship gods and guests, those who are worshipped and revered by the worlds, those who speak sweet words, those who are pleasant in all their deeds, those who are engaged in what is agreeable with all creatures, those who are pleasant of face and do not hate, those who always speak soft and gentle words, those who welcome everyone, those who do not cause injury to creatures, those who perform all the rites properly, those who do not sit down without performing worship, those who always grant the right of way to those to whom the path should be yielded, those who always worship their *gurus* and those who welcome revered guests and others who arrive. When they are born as humans, this is in special lineages. Having been born, they

enjoy extensive objects of pleasure and possess all the jewels. They worship those who should be worshipped and follow *dharma*. They are revered by all creatures and worshipped by all the worlds. A man always reaps the fruits of the deeds he has himself performed. I have described the *dharma* Vidhatri ⁸² has himself spoken about. O beautiful one! There are those whose conduct and behaviour is such that they go to hell—those whose conduct is terrible, those who cause fear to all creatures, those who use hands, feet, ropes, rods and stones to stupefy and oppress beings, those who are limited in wisdom and violently cause agitation and those who attack creatures and always cause anxiety amongst people. After the due progress of time, they become humans. They are born among worst families, in lineages that suffer from many impediments. Through his own deeds, such a man reaps the fruits of an inferior lineage that is hated by people. O goddess! Among men and relatives and kin, this should be known. There are also men who look towards all beings with compassion. Their vision is friendly and they behave like fathers towards them. They conquer their senses and are without any sense of enmity. They do not agitate or kill beings and are full of compassion. They control their hands and feet and earn trust among all creatures. They do not use ropes, rods, stones and weapons to agitate creatures. Such a man always performs auspicious deeds. With such conduct and behaviour, he is born in heaven. Such a man easily enjoys happiness and is always without anxiety. O goddess! This is the path of the virtuous and there are no impediments along it.’

Uma said, ‘One can see men who are full of great enthusiasm and skill. They possess *jnana* and *vijnana*. They are wise and know about *artha*. O god! There are others who suffer in wisdom and are devoid of *jnana* and *vijnana*. Through what kind of *karma* does a man become wise? O Virupaksha! ⁸³ Why does a man suffer in wisdom? O supreme among those who uphold every kind of *dharma*! Please dispel my doubt about this. O god! Some are born blind. Others suffer from ailments. Some men are seen to be eunuchs. Please tell me the reason for this.’

Maheshvara replied, ‘*Brahmanas* who are learned in the Vedas, those who know about success in *dharma*, those who always ask about what is

good and what is bad and those who avoid inauspicious deeds and practice auspicious ones—such people always obtain happiness in this world and go to heaven. When they are born as humans, they are intelligent. They are born as those who are fortunate. They are learned and devoted to sacrifices. They do not look at the wives of others with wicked eyes. If a person's nature is evil like that, he is born blind. If a man looks at a naked woman with a vile mind, because of his wicked deed, he is born as the one who suffers from ailments. If a man is so foolish that he performs the wicked act of having intercourse with someone he shouldn't, he is limited in his wisdom and is born as a eunuch. Men who tie up animals, violate their preceptor's bed and indulge in indiscriminate intercourse are born as eunuchs.'

Uma asked, 'O supreme among gods! What kind of a deed is honoured and what is condemned? How does a man obtain what is beneficial?'

Maheshvara replied, 'If a man constantly searches for the beneficial path and asks *brahmanas*, if he searches for *dharma* and the qualities, he obtains heaven. O goddess! If he is born as a human, he becomes a person who controls himself. He is born intelligent and wise, with a strong memory. O goddess! This is the *dharma* of the virtuous which brings prosperity. It is the path one should traverse along. For the welfare of men, I have always spoken about it.'

Uma said, 'There are men who are limited in intelligence. They revile *dharma*. They do not wish to approach *brahmanas* who are learned in the Vedas. Some men observe vows. They are devoted and exercise self-control. There are others who are without vows. They deviate from rituals. There are others who are like *rakshasas*. But there are those who perform sacrifices. There are others who are free of delusion. What is the *karma* that leads to this? Please tell me.'

Maheshvara replied, 'For this world, the *agama* texts ⁸⁴ have already laid down the parameters of *dharma*. Having followed the authority laid down in these, there are men who are seen to be firm in their vows. However, there are those who are confounded by confusion. They speak of what is *adharma* as *dharma*. They are without vows and destroy the ordinances.

They are said to be *brahma-rakshasas*.⁸⁵ After the passage of time, because they make efforts, they become humans. But they become the worst among men, who do not offer oblations or exclaim *vashatkara*.⁸⁶ O goddess! For the sake of dispelling all your doubts, I have thus described the ocean of *dharma* to you and what is good and bad for men.'

Chapter 1(118) (Maheshvara tells the sages about Vishnu)

Vyasa said, ‘O *brahmanas*! Having heard the words that her husband had spoken, the mother of the universe was astounded and extremely happy. The best among sages were also near Tripurari.⁸⁷ In connection with visiting the *tirthas*, those *brahmanas* had gone to that mountain. They worshipped the divinity with the trident in his hand and prostrated themselves before him. For the welfare of the worlds, they asked him about their doubt.’

The sages said, ‘O Trilochana!⁸⁸ O destroyer of Daksha’s sacrifice! We bow down before you. O Jagannatha!⁸⁹ We are asking you about a doubt that exists in our hearts. This *samsara*⁹⁰ is extremely terrible. It is fearful and makes the hair of the body stand up. Men who are limited in intelligence wander around for a very long time. Through what means can they be freed from the bondage of birth and *samsara*? We have great curiosity about this. Please tell us.’

Maheshvara replied, ‘Men are bound in the noose of their *karma* and they suffer miseries. O *brahmanas*! I do not see any means other than the supreme Vasudeva. Those who properly worship the one who holds the conch shell, the *chakra* and the mace in their thoughts, words and deeds reach the supreme destination. Trying like an animal, what is the point of remaining alive in this world if the consciousness is not inclined towards Vasudeva, who pervades the universe?’

The sages said, ‘O wielder of Pinaka! O one who destroyed Bhaga’s eyes! O one who is revered by all the worlds! O Shankara! We wish to hear about Vasudeva’s greatness.’

Maheshvara replied, ‘Hari, the eternal being, is superior to the grandfather. Krishna’s golden radiance is like that of the sun rising in a sky without clouds. He possesses ten arms and is greatly energetic. He is the destroyer of the enemies of the gods. Hrishikesha has the *shrivatsa* mark on his chest and is the leader of all the gods. Brahma originated from his stomach and I originated from his head. The stellar bodies were born from the hair on his head. The gods and *asuras* were born from his body hair. The *rishis* and the eternal worlds emerged from his body. He himself resides in Brahma. He resides in all the gods. The lord of the three worlds is the one who created the entire earth. He is the one who destroys all beings, mobile and immobile. He is supreme among gods. The scorcher of enemies is himself the protector of the gods. He knows everything. He has created everything. He goes everywhere. His face is in every direction. There is no being in the three worlds who is superior to him. He is eternal. He is immensely fortunate. He is known as Govinda. He is the one who kills all the kings in a battle. He is the one who bestows honours. To accomplish the tasks of the gods, he assumes a human form. Without Trivikrama’s ⁹¹ power, the large number of gods have no strength. Without their leader, they cannot undertake the tasks of the gods in this world. He is the leader of all creatures. He is revered by all creatures. Every task, superior and inferior, is done by the protector of the gods. He is identical with the *brahman*. He is the constant refuge of *brahmarshis*. Brahma resides in his navel and I reside in his body. All the gods happily reside in his body. The god, Pundarikaksha ⁹² has Shri ⁹³ in his stomach. He resides with Shri. He has the Sharnga bow, ⁹⁴ the *chakra* and a sword as weapons. The enemy of all the *nagas* ⁹⁵ is on his standard. He possesses excellence, good conduct, purity, self-control, valour, bravery, a handsome body, capacity to ascend, energy, uprightness, prosperity, lack of violence, beauty and strength. He possesses all kinds of divine weapons that are extraordinary to behold. He possesses the *maya* of *yoga*. ⁹⁶ He possesses one thousand eyes. He possesses malformed eyes. He is extremely generous. He uses his words to praise those who are friendly. He loves his relatives and kin. He is forgiving and does not speak about himself. He is the divinity who bestows the *brahman*. He destroys the fear

of those who are afflicted by fear. He enhances the delight of his friends. He is the refuge of all creatures. He is engaged in protecting those who are distressed. He possesses learning and wealth. All creatures bow down to him. He performs good deeds for those who seek refuge with him. He generates fear among enemies. He knows about good policy. He follows good policy. He knows about the *brahman*. He has conquered his senses.

‘For the existence of the gods, the one with supreme intelligence, the great-souled Govinda, will be born in Manu’s lineage. This is the auspicious line purified by *dharma*, descended from Prajapati Manu. Manu will have a son named Amsha and Amsha’s son will be Antardhama. Antardhama’s son will be the unblemished Prajapati,⁹⁷ Havirdhama. O *brahmanas*! Havirdhama’s son will be Prachinabarhi. Prachinabarhi will have ten sons, Prachetas as the foremost. Daksha Prajapati will be born as the son of Prachetas. Aditya will be born through Dakshayani.⁹⁸ Aditya’s son will be Manu.⁹⁹ Ila and Sudyumna will be born in Manu’s lineage. Pururava will be born from Budha.¹⁰⁰ Ayus will be Pururava’s son. Nahusha will be the son of Ayus and Yayati will be the son of Nahusha. The immensely strong Yadu will be Yayati’s son and Yadu’s son will be Kroshta. Kroshta will have a great son named Vrijinivan. Vrijinivan’s son will be the unvanquished Ushangu.¹⁰¹ Ushangu will have a brave son, Chitraratha. Ushangu will also have a younger son, known by the name of Shura. O supreme among *brahmanas*! This lineage will be famous for its valour, conduct, character, qualities, performance of sacrifices and purity. Shura, supreme among *kshatriyas*, will be immensely valiant and immensely famous. He will extend his lineage and bestow honours. His son will be Vasudeva, famous by the name of Anakadundubhi. His son will be four-armed Vasudeva.¹⁰² He will donate. He will show respect to *brahmanas*. He will have the *brahman* in him. He will love *brahmanas*. Having defeated King Jarasandha, Yadava¹⁰³ will free all the kings who will be imprisoned inside a cave in a mountain. The valiant one will become an excellent jewel among all the kings. Throughout earth, his valour will be unimpeded. Through his valour, the prosperous one will be the king over all the kings. The brave lord will subdue all of them and reside in Dvaraka. Having

conquered the ones with evil desires, he will protect the goddess earth. Along with excellent *brahmanas* who deserve to be worshipped, you should approach him. He is like the eternal *brahman* and should be duly worshipped. Anyone who desires to see me or Brahma the grandfather should see the powerful and illustrious Vasudeva. When he is seen, I am also seen. There is no need to reflect on this. O stores of austerities! Know that Vasudeva is the grandfather. If Pundarikaksha is pleased with a person, the large number of gods with Brahma leading are also pleased with him. If a man in this world seeks refuge with Keshava, he obtains deeds, fame and heaven. He becomes one who himself follows *dharma* and indicates the contours of *dharma* for others. A person who knows about *dharma* should always worship Achyuta, the lord of the gods. When the lord is worshipped, *dharma* is always present. The immensely energetic divinity desires to do what is good for subjects. It is for the sake of *dharma* that the tiger among men has created crores of rishis. Having been created by Brahma, Sanatkumara and the others ¹⁰⁴ who dwell in Mount Gandhamadana, performing austerities. O bulls among *brahmanas*! Therefore, the eloquent one, who knows about *dharma*, must be bowed down to. When he is worshipped, he returns the worship. When he is honoured, he returns the honour. When he is constantly seen, he shows himself. When one seeks refuge with him, he offers refuge. O supreme among *brahmanas*! When the divinity is constantly venerated, he shows veneration. Therefore, supreme austerities are in worshipping Vishnu. He is the great and original god and worshipping him always characterizes the virtuous. In the world, the eternal one is always worshipped by the gods. If one follows him and seeks refuge with him, one accordingly obtains freedom from fear. In thought, words and deeds, *brahmanas* must always bow down to him. If one takes care, Devaki's son will certainly be seen. O excellent sages! I have thus described the path to you. When the lord of all the gods is seen, all the supreme gods will be seen. The grandfather of the worlds and I always bow down to the lord of the universe, the divinity who is the great Varaha. There is no doubt that all three ¹⁰⁵ will be seen in him. We, all the gods, reside in his body. His elder brother has the complexion of a collection of white mountains. The

one who holds up the earth ¹⁰⁶ will be famous as Bala, the wielder of the plough. The lord is Ananta and his three hoods will be seen. Despite his strength and valour, Suparna, ¹⁰⁷ Kashyapa's son, was unable to see the ends of the supreme-souled divinity. Filled with great joy, he wanders around as Shesha. Encircling the earth, he resides inside that serpent. He is Ananta Vishnu, the one who holds the earth. The one who is Rama is Achyuta Hrishikesha, the one who holds the entire earth. Those two tigers among men are divine in their valour. The wielder of the *chakra* and the plough deserve to be seen and deserve to be honoured. O stores of austerities! It is through his favour that I have spoken about this sacred account to you. You must make efforts to worship the best among the Yadus.'

Chapter 1(119) (Vishnu's devotees)

The sages asked, 'How wonderful is Krishna's account. We have heard this extraordinary account. It is sacred and destroys all sins. It is blessed and destroys *samsara*. O great sage! There are men who are devoted to worshipping Vasudeva. After devotedly worshipping Vasudeva in the proper way, where do they go? O great sage! Do they go to heaven or obtain *moksha*? O best among sages! Or is it the case that they obtain both the fruits? O one who knows everything! Our hearts have a doubt on this account and you should dispel it. O supreme among sages! Other than you, there is no one in this world who is capable of dispelling this doubt.'

Vyasa replied, 'This is praiseworthy. O best among sages! What you have spoken about is noble and praiseworthy. Listen progressively to what brings happiness to Vishnu's devotees. O *brahmanas*! As soon as men are consecrated into worshipping Krishna, they obtain *moksha*. What needs to be said about those who constantly worship Achyuta? O supreme sages! Heaven or *moksha* are not difficult for them to obtain. Vishnu's devotees can obtain other objects of desire that are extremely difficult to obtain, but they do not hanker for them. O tigers among sages! After ascending a mountain of jewels, a man can take away whichever jewel he wants. In that way, whatever one wishes for can be obtained from Krishna. He is like a *kalpavriksha*, ¹⁰⁸ instantly yielding any fruit one desires. O *brahmanas*! A man can take whatever he cherishes from Krishna. If one faithfully worships Vasudeva, the preceptor of the worlds, in the proper way, a man obtains the fruits of *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*. With a pure heart, if a man worships Jagannatha, he obtains objects of desire that are extremely difficult for the gods to obtain. If one constantly worships the undecaying Vasudeva with devotion, there is nothing in the three worlds that is difficult

to obtain. In this world, men who constantly worship Hari are blessed. He is the divinity who destroys all sins and bestows all the fruits that one desires. *Brahmanas*, *kshatriyas*, *vaishyas*, women, shudras and *antyajas* ¹⁰⁹ who worship the best among gods obtain the supreme destination. O sages! O unblemished ones! Therefore, hear what you have asked me about. I will briefly tell you about the destinations obtained by those great-souled ones. They give up this human body which is temporary and is the abode of ailments. It is characterized by old age and death and is like a bubble in the water. It has flesh and blood and is associated with the stench of urine and excrement. It consists of pillars made out of bones, fat, sinews, skin and arteries. On *vimanas* which can travel as they will, have the complexion of the rising sun and are decorated with nets of bells, to the sound of divine *gandharvas* singing and praised by *gandharvas* and ornamented *apsaras*, they go to separate abodes of the guardians of the worlds. They enjoy those separate worlds which are decorated with different objects of pleasure for the duration of a *manvantara*. After this, they go to a world in the firmament that bestows every kind of happiness. O *brahmanas*! For ten *manvantaras*, they enjoy excellent objects of pleasure there. O *brahmanas*! Thereafter, Vishnu's devotees go to the world of the *gandharvas*. They enjoy those agreeable objects of pleasure for a period that is equal to twenty *manvantaras*. After this, they are worshipped and they go to Aditya's world. For thirty *manvantaras*, they enjoy objects of pleasure that are superior to those enjoyed by the gods. O *brahmanas*! Thereafter, they go to Chandra's world which brings bliss. Devoid of old age and death, they enjoy the auspicious qualities of objects of pleasure for a duration that is equal to forty *manvantaras*. O best among sages! On ornamented *vimanas*, they next go to the world of the *nakshatras*, ornamented with all the qualities. They enjoy the desired objects of pleasure for fifty *manvantaras*. O *brahmanas*! After this, they go to the world of the gods, which is extremely difficult to obtain. O *brahmanas*! For the duration of sixty *manvantaras*, they enjoy many kinds of objects of pleasure that are extremely difficult to obtain. They also obtain the eight *siddhis*. ¹¹⁰ Next, they are worshipped by the gods and they go to Shakra's world. ¹¹¹ They enjoy themselves with superior and

inferior divine objects of pleasure for a period that is equal to seventy *manvantaras* and this enhances their mental delight. From there, they go to Prajapati's supreme world where they enjoy all the desired objects of pleasure with all the wished for qualities. With every kind of happiness, they spend a duration of eighty *manvantaras* there. O *brahmanas*! After this, devotees of Vishnu go to the grandfather's world. They happily sport there for ninety *manvantaras*. When they again return to this world, they are born in the families of supreme *brahmanas*. O *brahmanas*! They are born as *yogis* who know the purport of the Vedas and the sacred texts. In this way, they enjoy all the desired objects of pleasure in all the worlds. Having returned here, they again progressively ascend upwards. O supreme *brahmanas*! They enjoy the desired objects of pleasure for one hundred years and then go to a different world. When they have progressively completed ten births, they proceed from Brahma's world to Hari Vishnu's divine world. Having gone there, they enjoy all the undecaying objects of pleasure with all the qualities for one hundred *manvantaras*. They do not experience birth or death. O supreme *Brahmanas*! After this, they go to Varaha's world. They became gigantic in size and immensely strong. They possess divine bodies and wear earrings. O Indras among *Brahmanas*! Assuming four-armed forms, they sport there for ten thousand crore years. O excellent *Brahmanas*! They possess that eternal state where they are worshipped by all the gods. O *Brahmanas*! From there, those persevering ones go to Narasimha's abode. They happily sport there for ten thousand crore years. When this is over, they go to Vishnu's city, frequented by the *siddhas*. They happily sport there for ten thousand years. O *Brahmanas*! Then, those excellent *sadhakas* ¹¹² go to Brahma's world again. They remain there for a very long time, for many hundreds of crores of years. Thereafter, those lords among *sadhakas* go to Narayana's city. They enjoy diverse objects of pleasure for one hundred million crores of years. Thereafter, those supreme *sadhakas* go to Aniruddha's city. They have divine forms and are immensely strong, praised by the gods and the *asuras*. Vishnu's devotees remain there for fourteen thousand crore years. They do not suffer from old age or death. Without any anxiety, they next go to Pradyumna's

city. O *Brahmanas*! They remain there for three hundred thousand crores of years. They can travel wherever they want. They are happy, full of strength and power. Thereafter, the *yogis* go to the place where Samkarshana is the lord. They reside there for a very long time, enjoying thousands of objects of pleasure. They then enter Vasudeva, who is unblemished and has no form and no name. Freed from old age and death, they enter the supreme truth. Having gone there, there is no doubt that they attain emancipation. In this way, those learned ones progressively obtain emancipation. O tigers among sages! Engaged in worshipping Vasudeva, they are freed.'

Chapter 1(120) (The *chandala* and the *brahma-rakshasa*)

Vyasa said, ‘There is no doubt that a man who controls himself and fasts on *ekadashi* ¹¹³ in either *paksha* goes to Vishnu’s supreme abode. He must follow the norms and bathe properly. He must conquer his senses and wear washed garments. He must control himself well and following the norms, worship Vishnu properly. He must use flowers, fragrances, lamps, incense, *naivedya* ¹¹⁴ and different kinds of gifts. He must perform *japa*, ¹¹⁵ offer oblations and donate *dakshina*. He must chant many kinds of stotrams and use pleasant singing and musical instruments. He must prostrate himself like a rod and exclaim excellent sounds of ‘Victory’. Worshipping in this way, he must remain awake during the night. Devoted to Vishnu, he must chant Vishnu’s songs and accounts.’

The sages asked, ‘O great sage! What are the fruits obtained from remaining awake during the night and singing Vishnu’s songs? We have great curiosity and wish to hear about this. Please tell us.’

Vyasa replied, ‘O tigers among sages! Listen. I will duly tell you about the fruits that are mentioned from remaining awake during the night and singing Vishnu’s songs. The city named Avanti is famous on earth. Holding a conch shell, a *chakra* and a mace, the illustrious Vishnu is there. On the outskirts of that city, there was a *chandala* who was accomplished in singing. Earning riches through legitimate means, he was engaged in nurturing his servants. The *chandala* was devoted to Vishnu and was firm in observing the monthly vows. When *ekadashi* arrived, he fasted and sang. The songs were praises of Vishnu and to express the sentiments, used notes like *gandhara*, *shadaja*, *naishada*, *panchama* and *dhaivata*. ¹¹⁶ He stayed awake during the night and sang these chants to Vishnu. On the morning of

dvadashi, ¹¹⁷ he prostrated himself before the lord and returned home. O supreme among *brahmanas*! He ate after feeding his nephews, daughters, sons-in-law and family members. In this way, he resided there for many years, pleasing Vishnu through many kinds of wonderful songs. On one occasion in the month of Chaitra, ¹¹⁸ when *ekadashi* of *krishna paksha* approached, he went to an excellent forest to serve Vishnu. Full of great devotion, he started to collect wild flowers. On the banks of the Kshipra, in that great forest, he reached the foot of a *vibhitaka* ¹¹⁹ tree. On seeing that he was without a protector, a *rakshasa* seized him so as to devour him. The *chandala* told him, “You should not devour me today. O fortunate one! You can eat me tomorrow in the morning. I give you my word that I will return. O *rakshasa*! I have a great task to be performed today. Therefore, please release me. I pledge truthfully that I will return tomorrow and you can eat me then. To serve Vishnu, I have to remain awake during the night. O *rakshasa*! You should not create an impediment in my observance of the vow.” The *rakshasa* replied, “O Matanga! ¹²⁰ I have not eaten for ten days and I have obtained you today. I will not free you. I am suffering from great hunger and I will eat you.” Hearing the words of the one who roamed in the night, ¹²¹ Matanga spoke to him in soft words, assuring him that he was firm and truthful in his words.’

Matanga said, ‘O brahma-*rakshasa*! Listen to me. Everything in the universe has a foundation in truth. I truthfully pledge to you that I will return. The sun, the moon, the fire, the wind, the earth, the firmament, the water, the mind, night and day and the two *sandhyas* know everything that a man does. The sins of having intercourse with someone else’s wife, stealing objects that belong to another person, killing a brahmana, drinking, violating a preceptor’s bed, being the husband of a woman who is barren, being the husband of a *vrishala* lady, subsisting on offerings made to an image, eating fish and flesh, eating the meat of a pig, eating the meat of a tortoise, eating flesh in vain, ¹²² eating flesh from the back, killing a friend, being ungrateful, being the husband of a widow, the pollution due to child-birth, being cruel in deeds, being a miser, leaving guests unsatisfied, having intercourse on *amavasya*, *shashthi*, *ashtami* or *chaturdashi* ¹²³ during

krishna paksha or *shukla paksha*, being a brahmana who has intercourse with his wife during her period, having intercourse with a woman just after performing *shraddha*,¹²⁴ eating without having had a bath, eating filth, having intercourse with a friend's wife, indulging in back-biting, being addicted to confusion and insolence, destroying honey, going back on a word given to a brahmana, lying about a daughter, lying about cows and mules, killing a woman or a child, uttering a falsehood, being harsh towards gods, Vedas, *brahmanas*, kings, sons, friends and virtuous women, lying or being wicked in conduct towards a *guru*, committing arson, setting fire to a forest, being a sinful householder, killing a cow, being the worst among *brahmanas*, not marrying before the younger brother has got married, getting married before the elder brother has got married, receiving from, or giving to such people¹²⁵ and killing a fetus—if I do not fulfil my pledge, let all these sins descend on me. O *rakshasa*! What is the need to speak a lot? I give you my pledge. Listen to a pledge that is so terrible that it is difficult to utter it. There are sins from earning a living through one's daughter, lying under oath, bearing false witness, performing a sacrifice for a person who does not deserve to sacrifice, being an eunuch, being the worst listener, resorting to *sannyasa* and then becoming a householder and being a *brahmachari* who succumbs to desire. If I do not return to your presence, let me be tainted with all these sins.'

Vyasa continued, 'Hearing Matanga's words, the brahma-*rakshasa* was astounded. He said, "Go and be truthful to your pledge." Thus, addressed by the *kunapasha*, the *shvapacha* gathered flowers.¹²⁶ Having gathered them, he went to Vishnu's temple. He gave them to a brahmana, who washed them with water and using these to worship Vishnu, went to his own house. O stores of austerities! Matanga fasted throughout the night, remaining awake. He sat down on the ground outside¹²⁷ and sang. When night turned into dawn, he praised the god and prostrated himself before him. True to his pledge, he left for the place where the *rakshasa* was. As he was proceeding along the road, a man asked him, "O fortunate one! Where are you going?" When he told him everything, he said, "The body is the means for achieving *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*. An intelligent person should make great

efforts to protect the body. If a man remains alive, he obtains *dharma*, *artha*, happiness and *moksha* as the ultimate destination. By remaining alive, one obtains fame. In this world, who remembers a dead person?" Hearing these words, Matanga replied in words that were full of meaning. Matanga said, "O fortunate one! I am going because I regard truth as most important. I have made a pledge." He said again, "You are foolish in your intelligence. O virtuous one! Have you not heard the words spoken by Manu? ¹²⁸ There are five kinds of lies that are not sins—for the sake of protecting cows, women and *brahmanas*; lies in connection with marriages; for the sake of well-wishers; when life is in danger; and when all the riches are liable to be destroyed. The words of *dharma* about not indulging in falsehood do not apply in the case of women, at the time of marriage, when there are enemies, when one is liable to be deceived, when wealth can be destroyed or when the person is himself liable to be destroyed." Hearing his words, Matanga replied, "O fortunate one! Do not say this. Truth is revered in the worlds. Every happiness that exists in the universe is obtained through truth. It is because of truth that the sun heats. It is because of truth that water has juices. It is because of truth that fire burns. It is because of truth that the wind blows. *Dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha* are extremely difficult to obtain. However, they are generated through truth. Therefore, the truth must not be discarded. Truth is the supreme *brahman*. Truth is the best among sacrifices. Heaven is gained through truth. Therefore, truth must not be abandoned." Saying this, Matanga ignored that excellent man. He went to the place where the *brahma-rakshasa*, the destroyer of beings was. The *brahma-rakshasa* saw that the *chandala* was approaching and his eyes dilated in wonder. He shook his head and spoke. The *brahma-rakshasa* said, "This is praiseworthy. O immensely fortunate one! This is to be lauded. You are truthful to your words. Since you have the attributes of truth, I do not think that you are a *matanga*. Because of your deeds, I think that you are a pure *brahmana* who cannot decay. O foremost among fortunate ones! O refuge of *dharma*! Tell me something. During the night, what did you do in Vishnu's temple? Please tell me." Matanga replied, "Listen to what I did during the night in Vishnu's temple. I will tell

you the truth. I lowered my head and remained below Vishnu's temple. I remained awake during the night, chanting Vishnu's songs." The *brahma-rakshasa* asked him, "How long have you observed this vow of faithfully remaining awake in Vishnu's temple? Please tell me." He smiled and said, "O *rakshasa*! I have done this for twenty years. I remain awake every month, during *ekadashi*." Hearing Matanga's words, the *brahma-rakshasa* spoke. The *brahma-rakshasa* said, "You should do exactly what I am asking you to do. O virtuous one! Give me the benefits of remaining awake for a single night. If you do that, I will free you. I will not free you otherwise. O immensely fortunate one! I pledge three times." Saying this, he stopped. Matanga replied, "O roamer in the night! I have surrendered myself to you. What is the need to speak? As you will eat me up." The *rakshasa* again said, "Give me the benefit of remaining awake for two *yamas* ¹²⁹ and the benefit of singing. You should show me this much of compassion." Matanga told the *rakshasa*, "Why are you speaking in this incoherent way? As you will eat me up. I will not give you the benefit of remaining awake during the night." Hearing Matanga's words, the *brahma-rakshasa* spoke to him again. The *brahma-rakshasa* said, "Which extremely evil-minded person will look at you with a view to harm you or make you suffer? You are protected by your deeds of *dharma*. A virtuous person should exhibit compassion towards a foolish person who is distressed and confounded by material objects, suffering from terrible sins and hell's afflictions. O immensely fortunate one! That is the reason you should show me compassion and give me the benefit of remaining awake during the night. Give me the benefit of one *yama* and go to your own residence." At this, the *chandala* again said, "I will not go to my own residence. How can I possibly give you the benefit of remaining awake even for a single *yama*?" At this, the *brahma-rakshasa* smiled and spoke to the *chandala*. The *brahma-rakshasa* said, "When night is over, you find delight in activities like singing songs. Give me those and save me from this sin." Addressed in this way, Matanga spoke to him.

Matanga asked, 'What is the perverse deed that you committed earlier? Because of that taint, you have been born as a *brahma-rakshasa*.' Hearing

Matanga's words, the brahma-*rakshasa* remembered what he had himself done and tormented with grief, replied. The brahma-*rakshasa* said, 'Hear who I used to be earlier and what I had done. Because of that I have been born in the wicked womb of a *rakshasa* lady. Earlier I was a brahmana, known by the name of Somasharma. I was the son of Devasharma. He was devoted to studying and performed sacrifices. There was a certain *yajamana* ¹³⁰ who had been prohibited from using the sacred thread or *mantras*.

Engaged in that king's tasks, I performed the rites near the sacrificial post. Confused and overcome by greed, I was the priest who kindled the fire for the sacrifice. When that was over, in my folly and insolence, I started a large sacrifice that would last for twelve days. While that was going on, I suffered from a pain in my stomach. Though ten days had passed, the sacrifice had not yet been completed. When oblations were being given to Virupaksha, ¹³¹ it was the moment that is associated with *rakshasas*. I died at that time and because of the taint, was born as a brahma-*rakshasa*. There was a person for whom the sacred thread and the sound of *mantras* had been prohibited. In my folly and ignorance about sacrifices, I had performed a sacrifice for one who was not entitled to perform a sacrifice. Because of that perverse deed, I became a brahma-*rakshasa*. I have thus been submerged in this great ocean of sin. Save me. At least give me the benefit of the last song you sing while you remain awake during the night.' The *chandala* told him, 'If you refrain from taking life, I will give you the benefit of the last song. When he agreed to this, Matanga invoked the fruits of remaining awake and singing a song for half a *muhurta* ¹³² and gave those to him. Having obtained the fruits of that song, the brahma-*rakshasa* bowed down to Matanga. He cheerfully went to the supreme *tirtha* of Prithudaka.

¹³³ O *brahmanas*! He made up his mind to fast there and give up his life. As a result of the powers of Prithudaka, enhanced by the fruits of the song, he was released from his state as a *rakshasa* and obtained Brahma's world, which is extremely difficult to obtain. He resided there for ten thousand years without any fear. When this was over, he was born as a controlled brahmana who retained his memory. O *brahmanas*! I will tell you about his conduct later.'

‘Listen to my words. I will tell you the rest of Matanga’s story. When the *rakshasa* left, the intelligent one who was in control of himself went to his residence. Since he remembered what he had been told, he became pure and non-attached. He left his wife in the care of his sons and started to roam around the earth. He started with Kokamukha and went to see Skanda.¹³⁴ Having seen Skanda, he went to Dharachakra and performed *pradakshina* there. He then went to the supreme mountain of Vindhya, with a large number of lofty peaks. O *Brahmanas*! He went to the *tirtha* of Papapramochana. The one born in a *chandala* family bathed in the place that cleanses sins. Freed from his sins, he remembered many of his former births. In an earlier birth, he had been a mendicant, controlled in his mind, speech and body. He was intelligent and accomplished in the Vedas and the *Vedangas*.¹³⁵ Once, thieves were taking cows away from a city. Since the alms were polluted by the dust, the mendicant discarded them. Because of the taint of that *adharma*, he was born in the womb of a *chandala* lady. Having bathed in Papapramochana, he died on the banks of the Narmada. O *brahmanas*! He was born as a supreme brahmana in Varanasi but was stupid. He dwelt there for thirty years. There was a *siddha* man¹³⁶ who possessed the powers of *yoga* and *maya* but was disfigured. Roaming around, he arrived there. On seeing him, he laughed and spoke to him. “O *siddha*! Are you well? Where have you come from?” Thus addressed, the *siddha* thought that he had been recognized. The revered one replied, “I have come from the world of heaven.” The foolish person asked the *siddha*, “In heaven, do you know the supreme *apsara* Urvashi? She was born from Narayana’s thighs.” The *siddha* replied, “I know Urvashi, the supreme ornament in heaven. She was born from a virtuous person and holds the whisk for Shakra.” The brahmana had no sense of what was right and told the *siddha*, “O friend! Lovingly, will you carry my message to Urvashi? Please tell her what I have said and tell me what she says in reply.” When the *siddha* agreed to this, the brahmana was filled with joy. The *siddha* went to the abode of the gods, on the slopes of Meru. He met Urvashi and told her what the brahmana had said. She told the supreme *siddha*, “Please tell the brahmana, I do not know who the lord of Kashi is. I know that you have

been told the truth but my memory hasn't retained it." Saying this, she left. After a long period of time, the *siddha* again went to Varanasi and met that foolish person again. On seeing him, he asked, "What did the lady who was born from the thighs tell you?" The *siddha* replied, "Urvashi herself told me that she does not know." Hearing the *siddha*'s words, a smile played on his lips and he again said, "Please tell Urvashi, 'How can you possibly know?'" Agreeing to do this, the *siddha* went to heaven. He saw Urvashi emerging from Shakra's residence. When the supreme *siddha* told her, she told the *siddha*, "Let the supreme brahmana undertake some rituals. O *siddha*! Through those rituals I will know who he is, not otherwise." He went to the foolish brahmana and told him what Urvashi had said. He told the *siddha*, "I will observe a supreme rite. O *siddha*! In front of you, I am taking this pledge about the ritual. I tell you truthfully that from today, I will not eat *saktu*." ¹³⁷ Thus addressed, the *siddha* went to heaven and met Urvashi. He told her, "He has said that from today, he will never eat *saktu*." Urvashi told the *siddha*, "Now I know what he is like. From the ritual he has chosen, it is evident that he is foolish and should be laughed at." Saying this, Narayana's daughter ¹³⁸ quickly went to her own residence. As he willed, the *siddha* wandered around on earth. Urvashi, supreme among beautiful ones, went to the city of Varanasi. The one with the divine body had a bath in the waters of Matsyodari. ¹³⁹ O sages! The foolish one also went to bathe in River Matsyodari. When he went there, he saw Urvashi having a bath. When he saw her, Manmatha ¹⁴⁰ caused great agitation in him. From his gestures and attempts, Urvashi realized that this was the foolish person himself. Knowing that he was the foolish person the *siddha* had spoken about, she smiled and spoke to him. Urvashi said, "O immensely fortunate one! Quickly tell me what you desire from me. Trust me. I will do whatever you ask me to do." The foolish brahmana replied, "O one with the beautiful smiles! Save me by giving yourself to me." Urvashi told the brahmana, "I am observing some rituals now. Remain here for a while and wait for my return." When the brahmana said he would remain there, she went off to heaven. When she returned after only a month, the divine lady saw that the brahmana had become emaciated. Without any food, he had remained on

the banks of the river. Seeing that he was firm in his resolution, she assumed the form of an old lady. On the banks of the river, she made a mixture of *saktu*, sugar, honey and *ghee*. She went to River Matsyodari and bathed there. The one with the beautiful eyes sat down on the ground and summoned the brahmana with these meaningful words. Urvashi said, “O brahmana! For the sake of good fortune, I have observed a great vow. O brahmana! I am giving you this for the completion of the vow. Please accept it.” He said, “Coated in sugar, what are you giving me? O virtuous one! O fortunate one! My throat is suffering from hunger. Please tell me.” She told him, “O brahmana! This is *saktu*, mixed with ground sugar. Without any delay, accept this and save your life.” Hearing this, he remembered. Though he was suffering from hunger, he replied, “O fortunate one! I have taken a vow and cannot accept this. In front of the noble *siddha*, I said that I would not take *saktu*. Urvashi will get to know. Please give it to someone else.” She said, “O fortunate one! You made that vow about *saktu* mixed in wood. This has not been mixed in wood. Eat it. You are suffering from hunger.” The brahmana replied, “I did not qualify it in any way. O fortunate one! I took a general vow.” She told him, “O brahmana! Do not eat it. Accept it and go home. Your family members will eat it.” He replied, “O one with the excellent teeth! I will not go home now. The beautiful one surpasses everyone in the three worlds in qualities. ¹⁴¹ Madana afflicted me and I sought her. When she left, she assured me and told me to remain here for a while. I agreed to do that. O fortunate one! It has only been a month since she left and I have stayed here. O one who is firm in vows! I am devoted to the truth and wish to unite with her.” Hearing his words, she assumed her own excellent form. Her smile was full of deep sentiments. Urvashi spoke to the brahmana. Urvashi said, “O brahmana! This is wonderful. Your resolution has been firm and you have been truthful to your vow. Wishing to see me, you have followed it without any deceit. O brahmana! I am Urvashi and I have come here to test you. Tested, your resolution has been seen to be firm. You are a *rishi*, truthful in your austerities. Go to the region of the boar, famous by the name of Rupatirtha.

O Indra among *brahmanas*! You will achieve success there and obtain me.”
O *brahmanas*! Saying this, Urvashi leapt up into the sky and departed.’

The brahmana, devoted to the truth and austerities, went to Rupaṭīrtha. Filled with serenity, he observed pure vows and rituals there. When he gave up his body, he went to the excellent world of the *gandharvas*. There, he enjoyed the appropriate objects of pleasure for one hundred *manvantaras*. After this, he was born in an excellent lineage as a king, devoted to delighting his subjects. He performed many kinds of sacrifices at which excellent *dakshina* was distributed. Handing over the kingdom to his sons, he again went to the region of the boar. He died in Rupaṭīrtha and went to Śakra’s world. There, he enjoyed objects of pleasure for one hundred *manvantaras*. Dislodged from there, he was born in the excellent city of Pratiśṭhāna as Pururava, Budha’s son. O stores of austerities! He then united with Urvashi. In this way, in earlier times, there was a brahmana who followed truth and austerities in the place known as Rupaṭīrtha. If one worships and pleases Viṣṇu, one can obtain objects of pleasure and emancipation even in this life.

Chapter 1(121) (On *maya*)

The sages said, ‘We have heard the benefits of singing to Krishna while one remains awake during the night. That is how the *chandala* obtained the supreme destination. O immensely intelligent one! Please tell us about developing devotion towards Vishnu. We now wish to hear about austerities and deeds that ensure this.’

Vyasa replied, ‘O tigers among sages! Listen. I will tell you about it in the proper order, about how a man derives great fruits through devotion towards Krishna. This *samsara* is extremely terrible and brings great fear to all beings. It is full of hundreds of miseries and causes great grief to men. They have to be born thousands of times as inferior species. O *brahmanas*! It is only sometimes that one obtains birth in a human body. Having become human, it is rare to be a brahmana. Having become a brahmana, it is rare to have discrimination. From a sense of discrimination, one develops intelligence about *dharma*. Intelligence brings supreme benefit. However, across successive births, until a man has not destroyed his accumulated sins, devotion towards Vasudeva, who pervades the universe, is not generated. O *brahmanas*! I will tell you how devotion towards Krishna comes about. In thoughts, words and deeds, there may be devotion towards other gods. O supreme among *brahmanas*! When there is single-minded devotion in the inner core, he performs sacrifices to them. O *brahmanas*! He controls himself and is devoted to Agni. ¹⁴² When the fire-god is satisfied, devotion towards Bhaskara ¹⁴³ results. O *brahmanas*! Then, he constantly worships Aditya. When Bhaskara is pleased, devotion towards Shankara results. He then makes efforts and follows the norms to worship Shambhu. ¹⁴⁴ When Trilochana is satisfied, devotion towards Keshava results. He worships the

undecaying Jagannatha, known as Vasudeva. O supreme among *brahmanas*! It is then that he obtains objects of pleasure and emancipation.'

The sages said, 'O great sage! Men who are not devoted to Vishnu are seen. O brahmana! What is the reason for them not worshipping Vishnu?'

Vyasa replied, 'O supreme among sages! Two kinds of creation are known in this world. Earlier, Svayambhu ¹⁴⁵ created *asuras* and gods. When one obtains a divine nature, Achyuta is worshipped. When a man obtains an *asura* nature, he reviles Hari. The *vijnana* of those worst among men is destroyed by Vishnu's *maya*. O *brahmanas*! Unable to obtain Hari, they head towards an inferior destination. His deep *maya* is incomprehensible to gods and *asuras*. This causes great delusion among men and those who have not cleaned their souls find it impossible to cross.'

The sages said, 'We wish to understand Vishnu's *maya* which is so very difficult to cross. O one who knows about *dharma*! We have great curiosity. You should tell us about it.'

Vyasa replied, 'That *maya* drags the worlds. It is like a dream, like magic. With the exception of Keshava himself, who is capable of understanding Hari's *maya*? Because of that *maya*, great mortification affected the conduct of a brahmana and Narada. O *brahmanas*! Listen to my words. Earlier, in a city, there used to be a prosperous king known as Agnidhra. His son, Kamadamana, was pure and found delight in *dharma*. His conduct was forgiving and he was engaged in serving his father. He was accomplished in delighting the subjects and he made efforts to learn the *shruti* texts and the sacred texts. ¹⁴⁶ His father made attempts to get him married, but he did not desire it. His father asked him, "Why don't you want to have a wife? Men desire wives for every kind of happiness. A wife is the source of happiness. Therefore, act in that way." He heard his father's words and out of respect for him, remained silent. O *brahmanas*! However, every once in a while, his father continued to urge him. At this, he told his father, "O father! This does not suit my name. ¹⁴⁷ It is evident that I should follow the vow of being devoted to Vishnu, seeking refuge in him." His father told him, "O son! You should not act in this way. This is not *dharma*. No learned man will act in this way. O son! Act in accordance with my words. I am your father and

master. Do not immediately immerse my lineage in the destruction of hell.”

¹⁴⁸ Hearing his father’s words, the self-controlled son remembered an ancient account about the wonder that was *samsara*. He cheerfully replied to his father.’

The son said, ‘O father! Listen to my words. They are full of truth and reason. O king! One should act in accordance with one’s name. That is the way of the truth. I have been through thousands of births with hundreds of occasions of old age and death. I have been united with many wives and have been separated from all of them. I have obtained hundreds of states—grass, shrubs, creepers, plants, reptiles, wild animals, birds, domesticated animals, women, men and so on. I have repeatedly become a *gana*, *kinnara*, *gandharva*, *vidyadhara*, giant *uraga*, *yaksha*, *guhyaka*, *rakshasa*, *danava*, *apsara* and god. ¹⁴⁹ O father! Thousands of times, I have become creatures that live in rivers. I have been through many creations and many destructions. O father! I have been through many births as a man, a god, a *gandharva*, a giant *uraga*, a *vidyadhara*, a bird and a *kinnara*. In a lineage, I was born as a *maharshi*, given to great austerities. My devotion to Janardana, the protector of the world who killed Madhu, ¹⁵⁰ was unwavering. I devotedly followed many kinds of vows and fasting and satisfied the one who wields the *chakra* and mace as weapons. Satisfied, the great-souled Vishnu arrived before me, astride the king of the birds. He wished to bestow a boon on me. In a loud voice, he told me, ‘O brahmana! Ask for the boon you wish. I will give it to you.’ I told the lord Hari, ‘O Keshava! If you are satisfied with me, I will ask for a boon. O Janardana! I wish to know about your supreme *maya*.’ At this, Madhu and Kaitabha’s enemy replied, ‘O brahmana! What will you do with my *maya*? I will bestow *dharma*, *artha* and *kama* on you. I will give you the best of sons and freedom from disease. Thereupon, I again spoke to Murari. ¹⁵¹ ‘I wish to conquer *dharma* and *artha*. I wish to know about your *maya*. O lotus-eyed one! Show that to me now.’ The excellent Nrisimha, ¹⁵² Shri’s lord, the lord Vishnu, addressed me in these words. ‘No one knows my *maya* and no one will ever know it. O brahmana! Earlier, there was a *devarshi* known as Narada. He was Brahma’s son and was full of devotion towards me. Earlier,

full of faith, he satisfied me with his devotion. I went to him to confer a boon on him and he asked for the boon that you have asked for. Though I tried to restrain him because of his excessive folly, he asked for the boon that you have asked for. At this, I told him, ‘O Narada! Immerse yourself in water. Once you are so submerged, you will know my *maya*.’ Accordingly, Narada submerged himself in the water and turned into Sushila, the daughter of the king of Kashi. When she attained youth, he ¹⁵³ bestowed her on Charudharma, the excellent son of the king of Vidarbha. United with Sudharma, ¹⁵⁴ the *maharshi* enjoyed unmatched desire. When his father went to heaven, the kingdom passed onto him and the powerful one happily protected the kingdom of Vidarbha, surrounded by many sons and grandsons. Thereafter, there was a great battle between King Sudharma and the king of Kashi. In that battle, the king of Vidarbha and the king of Kashi were both destroyed along with their sons and grandsons. Sushila got to know that her father had been killed along with his sons and that her husband had also been killed, along with his sons and grandsons. Sushila emerged from the city and went to the field of battle. She saw the great carnage in her father’s army and her husband’s army there. Miserable, she lamented for a very long time. Afflicted by grief, she went to her mother. She collected the remains of her brothers, sons, brothers’ sons, grandsons, husband and father and went to the great cremation ground where she lit a large funeral pyre. She kindled the fire herself and when the fire was blazing, Sushila rushed forth and entered the fire, exclaiming, ‘Alas, son! Alas, son!’ She once again turned into the sage Narada and the fire turned into sparkling crystal. He emerged from the full lake and saw Keshava, supreme among gods, in front of him. He was four-armed and held a conch shell, mace and sword in his hands. He laughed and spoke to *devarshi* Narada. ‘O *maharshi*! Who is your son? Tell me. O one whose intelligence has been destroyed! Who are you grieving over?’ Narada stood there, ashamed, and I spoke to him again. ‘O Narada! My *maya* is like this, full of misery. The one who is seated on the lotus, ¹⁵⁵ the great Indra and Rudra are incapable of understanding it. It will be extremely difficult for you to understand it.’ Hearing my words, the great *maharshi* replied, ‘O Vishnu!

Grant me devotion. O lord! At whatever time I remember you, may I always be able to see you. O Achyuta! This is a place where afflicted by grief, I climbed into the funeral pyre. Let it be a *tirtha* that destroys all sins. O Keshava! Along with the one who is seated on the lotus, may you always be present here.’ O brahmana! I told Narada, ‘Your funeral pyre will be the *tirtha* of Sitoda. As Vishnu, I will always be present here and Maheshvara will remain towards the north. When Virinchi’s mouth utters harsh words, the three-eyed one will sever it. ¹⁵⁶ To free the skull, he will come to this *tirtha* of yours. When the destroyer of Tripura bathes in this *tirtha*, the skull will fall down on the ground. Therefore, this *tirtha* will be famous on earth by the name of Kapalamochana. ¹⁵⁷ From that time, the one who rides on the clouds ¹⁵⁸ has not left that supreme and extremely sacred *tirtha*, to free himself from the sin of killing a brahmana. ¹⁵⁹ O brahmana! As long as the slayer of the enemy of the immortals does not leave that *kshetra*, the foremost *kshetra* will continue to bestow great merits. The gods refer to the *tirtha* as Vimukta and praise it as a place that bestows undecaying merits. Even if a man commits great sins, if he enters it, he becomes pure and clean. If he thinks of me, the illustrious one, through my favours, he becomes pure and obtains emancipation. In another birth, he may become what is known as a *rudra-pishacha* ¹⁶⁰ and experience miseries. After many years, he will be freed from his sins and take birth in the house of a brahmana. When he becomes pure and is in control of himself, at the time of his death, for his welfare, Rudra will recite the *taraka mantra* to him. ¹⁶¹ After telling Narada, the noble brahmana all this, I went to my own abode in the ocean of milk. The brahmana *rishi* went to heaven and was worshipped by the king of the *gandharvas*. All this has been said to make you understand. My *maya* is incapable of being understood. If you wish to understand it, trust me and enter this water. You will understand.’ Thus, Hari made the brahmana understand. To understand the meaning of *yoga*, he immersed himself in the water. O father! The brahmana immersed himself in the water in Kokamukha and became a maiden in a *chandala*’s house. She was beautiful and possessed good conduct and qualities. When she attained youth, she was married to the son of a *chandala*. He was

named Subahu and he was devoid of beauty. She did not like her husband, although he was attached to her. She gave birth to two sons who were blind. After this, she gave birth to a daughter who was deaf. Her husband was poor. Therefore, every day, she used to go to the river and cry miserably. On one occasion, she took her pot with her and entered the water to have a bath. She instantly regained her form as a brahmana, good in conduct and devoted to the rites of *yoga*. When she did not return for a long time, to search for her, her husband went to the extremely sacred river. He saw the water-pot on the bank, but could not see her. Extremely miserable, he started to cry loudly. The two blind sons and the deaf daughter also came there. On seeing that their father was crying miserably, they too started to weep, suffering from grief. He asked some *brahmanas* who were on the banks of the river. ‘Did you see a woman come here for water?’ They replied, ‘We saw her come here for water and enter, but we did not see her emerge again from the water. We know only this much.’ Hearing these extremely terrible words, tears started to flow from his eyes and he wept in grief. Seeing him, his sons and daughter weep, I also became afflicted by grief. O lord of the earth! ¹⁶² My sorrow made me remember that I was the *chandala* lady. O king! I spoke to the *matanga*. ‘Why are you crying? O foolish one! You are not going to get her back through your weeping. This lamentation is useless.’ He told me, ‘These sons are blind and the daughter is deaf. O brahmana! They are grieving. How can I comfort them and rear them now?’ Saying this, along with his sons and daughter, he started to shriek and cry. The more the *shvapaka* cried, the more I felt compassion for him. I restrained the afflicted person and told him about the account of my birth. Miserable and suffering, along with his sons and daughter, he entered Kokamukha. As soon as the *matanga* entered the water, because of the power of the *tirtha*, he was cleansed on his sins. O father! While I looked on, he ascended a *vimana* that was like the moon and went to heaven. When he entered the water and died, that misery caused great delusion in me. O noble king! I entered the extremely sacred waters of Kokamukha and went to heaven. I was born in a *vaishya* lineage and suffered from pain. However, because of the favours of that supreme *tirtha*, I remembered my previous

birth. My mind was greatly detached. Controlling my speech and mind, I went to Kokamukha. Resorting to a vow, I dried up my body and went to heaven. O father! When I was dislodged from there, I was born in your house. But because of Hari's favours, I remembered my former births. Having worshipped the divinity Murari in Kokamukha, I have given up all desire for the auspicious and the inauspicious.' Saying this, he prostrated himself before his father and went to the foremost *tirtha* of Kokamukha. The bull among men worshipped Vishnu in the form of Varaha and obtained success. Thus, Kamadamana gave up his body which was full of taints in the greatly sacred and supreme *tirtha* of Kokamukha. Along with his sons and grandsons, ¹⁶³ he went to heaven in a *vimana* that resembled the sun. I have thus spoken about the supreme lord's *maya*. Even the gods find it impossible to think about it. O *brahmanas*! It resembles a dream, or magic. Using this, Murari confounds the universe.

Chapter 1(122) (*kali yuga*)

The sages said, ‘O Vyasa! We have heard what you have told us about the manifestation of Vishnu’s sacred *maya*, which is so very difficult to understand. O great sage! We wish to hear from you about the withdrawal of everything at the end of the *kalpa*, known as the great *pralaya*.’ ¹⁶⁴

Vyasa replied, ‘O best among sages! Hear about the annihilation at the end of a *kalpa*, when *prakrita pralaya* occurs. ¹⁶⁵ A human month is a day for the ancestors and a human year is a day for the residents of heaven. O supreme *brahmanas*! One thousand *mahayuga* amount to one of Brahma’s days. The four *yuga* are *krita*, *treta*, *dvapara* and *kali*. Twelve thousand years of the gods are said to amount to this. ¹⁶⁶ The four *yuga* are similar to each other in form. O sages! *Krita yuga* is said to be the first and *kali* is the last. In the first *krita yuga*, Brahma carried out his creation. In that way, annihilation occurs at the end of the last *kali yuga*.’

The sages said, ‘O illustrious one! You should explain to us the nature of *kali yuga* in detail. O illustrious one! That is when the four feet of *dharma* decline.’ ¹⁶⁷

Vyasa replied, ‘O *brahmanas*! O unblemished ones! You have asked me about the nature of *kali yuga*. This has great detail. I will tell you briefly. Understand. In *kali yuga*, the conduct of men is not based on *varnas* and *ashramas*. The rituals of *Sama*, *Rig* and *Yajur Veda* are not carried out. Marriages in *kali yuga* do not follow *dharma*, disciples do not seek out preceptors. The sons do not follow *dharma*, the progressive rituals about the sacrificial fire do not exist. In *kali yuga*, the strongest person becomes the lord of everyone regardless of the lineage in which he has been born. A man subsists by accepting a maiden from all *varnas*. ¹⁶⁸ In *kali yuga*, a *brahmana* is initiated through any possible method. O Indras among *brahmanas*! In

kali yuga, anything is regarded as a means of atonement. O *brahmanas*! In *kali yuga*, anything is said and everything is accepted as a sacred text. In *kali yuga*, everyone is a god and everything is an *ashrama*. In *kali yuga*, one fasts, makes efforts and donates wealth as one pleases and that is regarded as dharma. In *kali yuga*, men become intoxicated with even a little bit of wealth. The beauty of women is decided on the basis of their hair. Since gold, jewels, gems and garments deteriorate in *kali yuga*, women can only dress their hair. If they lack in riches, women abandon their husbands. In *kali yuga*, only the rich become the husbands of women. Anyone who donates a lot becomes the lord of men and nobility of lineage is decided on the basis of such lordship. Accumulated riches are exhausted in building a house. When riches are exhausted, the mind turns towards earning money. Without money, there are no objects of pleasure in *kali yuga*. In *kali yuga*, women love intercourse and become *svairinis*.¹⁶⁹ They desire men who have earned wealth through illegitimate means. O *brahmanas*! Even if he is asked by a well-wisher, no man will tolerate something that harms his own selfish end, even if it is to the extent of one-quarter of a *pana*.¹⁷⁰ In *kali yuga*, the mind of a brahmana will always be full of virility. Cows will be honoured only as long as they yield milk. There will often be a drought and subjects will suffer on account of hunger. Therefore, all of them will constantly look up towards the sky.¹⁷¹ Like ascetics, men will subsist on roots, leaves and fruits for food. Extremely miserable because it does not rain, they will kill themselves. They will always suffer from famine and hardships and will be unable to master these. In *kali yuga*, the happiness of men will suffer and they will be distracted. They will eat without having a bath. They will not worship the fire, gods or guests. When *kali yuga* arrives, *pinda* will not be given and water-rites will not be performed. In *kali yuga*, women will be greedy and short in stature. They will want to eat a lot. They will be unfortunate but will have many children. Women will use both their hands to scratch their heads. They will ignore the instructions of their seniors and husbands and will go out uncovered. They will be angry and devoted to nourishing themselves. They will not clean their bodies. In *kali yuga*, women will speak harsh and false words. They will be wicked in

conduct and will always desire those who are wicked in conduct. The women of the family will be attracted towards men who are evil in conduct. Those who are prohibited and those who are without vows will study the Vedas. Householders will not offer oblations into the fire and will not offer appropriate donations. Those who reside in forests will eat what villagers should eat. Mendicants will be driven by bonds of affection towards their sons. Kings will no longer protect. Instead, they will use interest and taxes to take away. When *kali yuga* arrives, they will take away the wealth of people. Anyone who possesses superior horses, chariots and elephants will become a king. In *kali yuga*, anyone who is weak will be a servant to everyone. *Vaishyas* will abandon their own means of subsistence, agriculture and trade and take to the means of livelihood for shudras. They will earn a living through artisanship. Shudras will observe the vow of begging for alms. The worst among men will exhibit signs of renunciation. Those who have not gone through *samskaras* will indulge in heretical activities. People will greatly suffer from famine and taxes. Miserable, they will migrate to regions where wheat and barley exist. The path indicated in the Vedas will decay and people will become heretics. As *adharma* increases, the lifespan of people will decline. People will torment themselves with austerities that are not sanctioned by the sacred texts. Because of the sins of men and kings, infants will die young. In *kali yuga*, when they are five, six or seven years old, girls will give birth to children and the fathers will be eight, nine or ten years old. The hair will turn grey at the age of twelve years. In *kali yuga*, no one will live till the age of twenty years. In *kali yuga*, men will be limited in wisdom. They will bear false signs and will be wicked inside. They will, therefore, be destroyed within a brief span of time. Whenever there are signs of heretics increasing in importance, the learned recognize that *kali yuga* is increasing. Whenever the path of the Vedas followed by the virtuous tends to suffer, the learned infer that *kali yuga* is increasing in importance. O *brahmanas*! Whenever men who follow *dharma* tend to suffer, the learned infer that *kali yuga* is increasing its influence. Whenever sacrifices to the lord Purushottama, the lord of sacrifices, are not undertaken, that should be taken as a sign of *kali*

yuga's strength increasing. Whenever there is no pleasure in discussing the Vedas and there is attraction towards heretical doctrines, the wise and the learned infer that *kali yuga* is increasing in importance. O *brahmanas*! In *kali yuga*, Vishnu, the lord of the universe, the lord who has created everything, is not worshipped. Men are overwhelmed by heretics and are verbose in exclaiming, "What use are gods? What use are *brahmanas* and the Vedas? What is the point of purifying one's birth with water?" Parjanya¹⁷² rains little and therefore the yield of crops is limited. O *brahmanas*! When *kali yuga* arrives, fruits have limited substance. Garments extend only up to the knees. All trees are generally like the *shami* tree.¹⁷³ In *kali yuga*, all the *varnas* are generally like shudras. Grain is generally as small as an atom.¹⁷⁴ Milk is obtained from goats. When *kali yuga* arrives, unguents are only made out of *oushira* grass.¹⁷⁵ In *kali yuga*, men generally regard fathers-in-law and mothers-in-law as the seniors. O supreme among sages! Brothers-in-law and the wife's relatives are regarded as well-wishers. Men who follow their father-in-law say, "Whose mother? Whose father? A man is the result of his own *karma*." In thoughts, words and deeds, they are repeatedly overwhelmed by taints. Therefore, limited in intelligence, men commit sins every day. O *brahmanas*! They are without truth, without purification and without modesty. Therefore, in *kali yuga*, everything is a source of misery. There is no studying and no *vashatkara*. There are no exclamations of *svadha* and *svaha*. A brahmana becomes rare in this world. Supreme and excellent good merits, which required austerities in *krita yuga*, can be achieved in a short span of time.'¹⁷⁶

The sages asked, 'At what time does a limited amount of *dharma* yield great fruits? You should tell us in detail. We wish to hear.'

Vyasa replied, 'O *brahmanas*! *Kali yuga* is blessed, since only a little bit of effort yields great fruits. Women and shudras become blessed. Listen. O *brahmanas*! The fruits of *brahmacharya* and *japa* take ten years in *krita yuga*, but are achieved through six months in *treta* and one month in *dvapara*. It is said that a virtuous man achieves this through one day and night in *kali yuga*. Fruits were obtained through *dhyana* in *krita*, performing sacrifices in *treta* and worshipping in *dvapara*. Those are obtained by

chanting Keshava's name in *kali yuga*. With a little bit of effort, a man achieves the best of *dharma* in *kali yuga* and becomes knowledgeable about *dharma*. That is the reason I am satisfied with *kali yuga*. Earlier, *dvijas* followed supreme vows and grasped the Vedas. They followed the norms and performed sacrifices with wealth obtained through *dharma*. However, fruitless talk, pointless food and taking themselves to be *dvijas* led to their downfall, along with those of the mendicants. The tasks were imperfectly completed and this led to every object being tainted. O *brahmanas*! They ate and drank what they wished and this led to them not gaining anything. This was true of every attempt they made for the world hereafter. In this world, they suffered great hardships even though they humbly undertook sacrifices. However, shudras served *dvijas* and were engaged in *paka-yajna*, thereby conquering their own worlds. Hence, shudras are more blessed. O tigers among sages! They did not suffer from any sins regarding what should be eaten and what should not be eaten. There were no virtuous rules for them. Thus, such men were engaged in their own *dharma* and always earned riches without any conflict. O supreme among *brahmanas*! There are great hardships in following the rules on who one should donate to, how one should follow the norms and perform sacrifices and how wealth should be earned. It is very difficult to comprehend the mystery of what is a virtuous rule for men. O supreme among *brahmanas*! Hence, through their own efforts, these other men progressively conquered their own worlds, those of Prajapati and others. O *brahmanas*! By serving her husband in thoughts, words and deeds, a woman also obtains these regions and worlds. Unlike a man, she obtains them without a great deal of effort. For the third time, I am stating that women are virtuous. O *brahmanas*! I have thus told you what you came here for. Clearly ask whatever you want and I will tell you. With a little bit of effort, a great deal of *dharma* is achieved in *kali yuga*. Using their own qualities like water, men can wash off every kind of sin. O supreme sages! Shudras achieve this by being devoted to serving *dvijas* and women easily obtain this by serving their husbands. That is the reason it is my view that these three are the most blessed. ¹⁷⁷ In *krita* and others, *dvijas* had to make a great deal of effort to achieve *dharma*. But,

through a few austerities, men can obtain success. ¹⁷⁸ O supreme among sages! Those who follow *dharma* at the end of a *yuga* ¹⁷⁹ are blessed. I have told you what you desired and also what was not asked. O ones who know about *dharma*! O *brahmanas*! What else should be done?

Chapter 1(123) (*Kali yuga* continued)

The sages said, ‘O brahmana! We do not know whether the age that causes hardship ¹⁸⁰ is imminent. The decay and end of *dvapara yuga* has arrived. We have come to you with a thirst for knowing about the *dharma* that is appropriate for this time. We will happily undertake whatever few deeds ensure supreme *dharma*. However, we are also scared and anxious that the end of the *mahayuga* will arrive. O one who knows about *dharma*! You should tell us about the signs of *dharma* being destroyed.’

Vyasa replied, ‘Kings will take away their shares of taxes, but will not protect. The influence of the end of the *mahayuga* will be such that they will only be engaged in protecting themselves. Those who are not *kshatriyas* will become kings. *Brahmanas* will resort to means of subsistence meant for shudras. At the end of the *mahayuga*, shudras will practice the conduct of *brahmanas*. At the end of a *mahayuga*, learned *brahmanas*, *kandaprishthas* and those who do not perform rites or offer oblations will eat while seated in the same row. ¹⁸¹ Men will not be polished in conduct. They will be addicted to *artha* and will love liquor and flesh. At the end of the *mahayuga*, the worst among men will approach the wives of their friends. Thieves will conduct themselves as kings. Kings will practice theft. When the *mahayuga* comes to an end, servants will take away food without being asked to do so. Wealth will be something to boast about. The conduct of the virtuous will no longer be honoured. At the end of the *mahayuga*, those who have fallen down will not be condemned. Men will have noses missing. They will be disfigured and their hair will be disheveled. Women who have not attained the age of sixteen years will give birth. At the end of the *mahayuga*, habitations will have shops for selling food. Crossroads will have shops for selling cattle. There will be shops for

women to dress their hair. Everyone will speak about the *brahman* and *brahmanas* will follow the Vajasaneya texts. ¹⁸² *Brahmanas* who speak will be *antyavasina* and will be like shudras. ¹⁸³ Their teeth will be white. They will be victorious in debates. Their heads will be shaved and they be dressed in ochre garments. Earning a living through deceitful intelligence, shudras will speak about *dharma*. When the *mahayuga* is about to come to an end, there will be plenty of predatory creatures and cows will diminish in number. With the suffering of the virtuous, knowledge will come to an end. Those who should dwell in the extremities will live in the middle. Those who should dwell in the middle will live in the extremities. At the time of the end of the *mahayuga*, the subjects will be without shame and everything will be destroyed. The best of *brahmanas* will sell the fruits of austerities and sacrifices. At the end of the *mahayuga*, the seasons will turn adverse. In *kali yuga*, bulls that are not one year old will be yoked to the plough. When the *mahayuga* decays, Parjanya's showers will become erratic. Anyone who is born in a noble lineage will be capable of becoming a protector. In that way, at the end of the *mahayuga*, all the subjects will become inferior. When the *mahayuga* comes to an end, men will not follow dharma and sons will not give what is due to their fathers. The land will mostly turn barren and the roads will be infested with thieves. At the end of the *mahayuga*, everyone will engage in trade. The sons will divide what they have received as inheritance from their father. Overcome by avarice, they will act against each other and make efforts to take away from the others. At the end of the *mahayuga*, beauty of form and jewels will diminish. Therefore, women will only dress their hair. For a householder, sexual intercourse will lack potency. When the end of the *mahayuga* arrives, no one will be loved as much as one's own wife. There will be many women who are wicked in conduct. Their beauty will be futile because there will be few men and many women. That is a sign of the end of the *mahayuga*. There will be many people who are beggars and they will not give to each other. They will decay and face destruction because of kings, thieves, fire and punishment. The crops will not yield fruit. Young men will behave like those who are aged. At the end of the *mahayuga*, people will be happy

when they are wicked in conduct. During the monsoon, harsh winds will blow close to the ground and will shower down stones. At the end of the *mahayuga*, doubts will be raised about the world hereafter. Like *vaishyas*, king will earn subsistence through wealth and grain. As the *yuga* progressively move on, there will be no relatives. Contracts and pledges will no longer be seen to have any validity. As the *mahayuga* starts to decay, debts will no longer be humbly honoured. Happiness will bear no fruits. But anger among men will be fruitful. At the end of the *mahayuga*, goats will be reared for the sake of milk. Sacrifices will be performed without following the sacred texts. Men who pride themselves on being learned will not be able to cite any proof. There is no doubt that there will be no one to speak about the sacred texts. Everyone will know everyone and no one will serve the elders. When the end of the *mahayuga* arrives, there will be no one who is wise. The *dvijas* will not undertake tasks on the basis of the conjunctions of the *nakshatras*. When the end of the *yuga* arrives, kings will generally be thieves. Bastards, deceivers and drunkards will speak about the *brahman*. When the end of the *mahayuga* arrives, the best among *brahmanas* will officiate at horse sacrifices performed by those who should not perform sacrifices and eat food that should not be eaten. When the end of the *mahayuga* arrives, *brahmanas* will thirst after wealth. Since they will not study, they will only know how to utter “*Bhoh*”. ¹⁸⁴ Fastened with grass, women will wear a single conch shell around their necks. The *nakshatras* will be faded and the ten directions will turn perverse. When the end of the *mahayuga* arrives, the tinge of *sandhya* will turn ashen. Sons will dispatch fathers to perform their own tasks and daughters-in-law will send their mothers-in-law. In that last *yuga*, men and women will live like this. They will eat without offering oblations into the fire. *Brahmanas* will not offer oblations into the fire. Without giving alms and offering sacrifices, men will themselves eat. Deceiving husbands who are asleep, women will go to others. This is despite the husbands not being diseased, not being jealous and not lacking in beauty and enterprise. When the end of the *mahayuga* arrives, no one will be grateful for a good turn that is done.’

The sages asked, ‘When *dharma* is suspended and men suffer from taxes, which regions will they reside in? What will they eat? How will they amuse themselves? What will be their tasks? What will be their wishes? What will be their stature? What will be their span of life? After what duration of time will *krita yuga* arrive again?’

Vyasa replied, ‘When *dharma* loses its qualities, the subjects fall down from above. When good conduct suffers, so do their lifespans. When the lifespan suffers, strength declines. The decline in strength leads to pallor. Pallor leads to their suffering from ailments and this suffering from ailments leads to non-attachment and this non-attachment contributes to self-understanding. Self-understanding brings about an inclination towards *dharma*. When this supreme objective is reached, they attain *krita yuga*. Some are goaded into the good conduct of *dharma*, others remain in a medium state. Some will only be curious and ponder, ‘What is the *dharma* of good conduct?’ Some will decide that the true proof is only through direct perception and inference. There are other people who will say that nothing can ever be proved. Some will thus be non-believers and contribute to the impairment of *dharma*. There will be foolish men and *Brahmanas* will pride themselves on their learning. Since they will only have faith in what is instantaneous, they will be deprived of the *jnana* of the sacred texts. With their *jnana* disappearing, men will become insolent. In this way, *dharma* will be destroyed. However, there will still be superior ones who will be respected. They will act in accordance with what is auspicious and be devoted to donating. When people eat everything, when they think they can protect themselves, when they are without compassion and without shame, that is a sign of *kali yuga*.¹⁸⁵ During the time of *kali yuga*, when devotion towards *jnana* has been destroyed, even people who have not been through *samskara* can obtain success with a little bit of effort. O *brahmanas*! When people from inferior *varnas* resort to the eternal conduct of *brahmanas*, that is a sign of *kali yuga*. When the *mahayuga* declines, there will be great battles, heavy rains, strong winds and scorching heat. That is a sign of *kali yuga*. When the end of the *mahayuga* presents itself, disfigured *rakshasas* who learn through their ears¹⁸⁶ will become kings and

enjoy the earth. There will be no studying and no exclamations of *vashatkara*. There will be evil and insolent leaders. In the form of *brahmanas*, predatory creatures will eat everything. Vows will be fruitless. People will be foolish and attached to *artha*. They will be inferior and their garments will be inferior. The conduct of business will be perverse. They will be dislodged from eternal *dharma*. They will steal the jewels of others and force themselves on the wives of others. They will be full of desire and evil-souled. They will indulge in frauds and be reckless. However, because of such powers everywhere among people, there will be many unthinking sages in many different kinds of forms. When *kali yuga* arrives, the foremost people will be those who are good with words. They will be worshipped by all men. There will be thieves who steal crops, others who steal garments. There will be those who steal food, others who steal baskets. There will be thieves who steal from thieves. There will be killers who kill killers. When thieves destroy thieves, peace will descend. The period will be without substance and full of agitation. There will be no rites and rituals. Suffering from the burden of taxes, men will resort to the forest. The rites of sacrifices will cease. *Rakshasas*, predatory creatures, insects, rats and snakes will make men suffer. But even when the *mahayuga* decays, there will be superior men in some spots. They will enjoy peace, food, freedom from disease and support from relatives. They will protect themselves from being robbed by thieves and will be like laden boats. In different spots, they will exist in groups. In general, people will be dislodged from their own countries, along with their relatives and will lack in substance. When time decays, this is what will happen to all men. Out of fear, all of them will come together. Suffering from hunger, such men will take their sons and will cross River Koushiki. ¹⁸⁷ Men will seek refuge in Anga, Vanga, Kalinga, Kashmira and Koshala and the valleys of Mount Rishikanta. They will reside everywhere on the slopes of the Himalayas and the shores of the salty ocean. They will attire themselves in many kinds of decaying leaves, bark and hides that they make themselves. When the *mahayuga* decays, they will reside there. Along with *mlecchas*, ¹⁸⁸ men will inhabit the forests. The earth will not be empty, but nor will it have new forests. Kings will be

protectors and also those who do not protect. Men will subsist on deer, fish, birds, carnivorous beasts, snakes, insects, honey, vegetables, fruits and roots. They will live like sages and attire themselves in decayed leaves, bark and hides that they make themselves and subsist on fruits. They will not be able to extract oil from oilseeds, but will injure themselves with the wooden stakes. ¹⁸⁹ They will always rear goats, sheep, donkeys and camels. They will resort to the banks of rivers and use dams to stop the flow of the waters. They will trade with each other and buy and sell cooked food. ¹⁹⁰ They will be covered with hair everywhere on the body. They will have many wives but no sons. They will be devoid of lineage and good conduct. Men will be like this, without any sense of *dharma*. The inferior subjects will follow a *dharma* that is inferior. The lifespan of mortals will at most be thirty years. They will be weak and attached to material objects. They will be overwhelmed by old age and misery. At that time, there will be disease and the senses will suffer. The lifespan will be reduced further because of the violence that they cause to each other. Though they will love the sight of virtuous people, they will themselves need to be tended to. However, because of uncertainty about the nature of conduct, they will praise the truth. When nothing is gained through desire, they will follow *dharma*. Afflicted by the decay of their own side, they will cleanse themselves. They will practice serving, donations, truth and protecting life. In this way, benefit will be obtained and one-fourth of *dharma* will be regained. When the qualities change and this has been gained, they will see that this is *dharma* and ask, ‘What is this tasty thing?’ Just as there was progressive decay, there will be progressive expansion. When *dharma* is duly accepted, there will be *krita yuga* again. The good conduct of *krita yuga* is said to subsequently decay during *kali yuga*. This is just like the moon becoming pale in complexion, as a result of the progression of time. In *kali yuga*, it is as if the moon is shrouded in darkness. However, in *krita yuga*, the moon emerges from darkness. But the learned know that the supreme meaning of the *brahman* is in the purport of the Vedas. Something that is indeterminate and unknown is regarded as something to be given away. ¹⁹¹ Rites are said to be austerities and it is austerities that ensure steadfastness. Qualities are

obtained by refraining from deeds, but qualities are also obtained by resorting to pure deeds. From one *yuga* to another *yuga*, on seeing men who follow the dictates of the time and the place, *rishis* have pronounced benedictions over them. From one *yuga* to another *yuga*, sacred and auspicious benedictions are obtained by those who follow *dharma*, *artha* and *kama* and rites to the gods. The *yuga* circle around for a long time, depending on their nature and conduct, as determined by the creator. In this world of the living, rise and fall also circle around, neither remaining for more than an instant.'

Chapter 1(124) (*naimittika* destruction)

Vyasa said, ‘It has been held that there are three kinds of withdrawals of all living creatures—*naimittika*, *prakritika*¹⁹² and *atyantika*. When everything is withdrawn into the *brahman* at the end of a *kalpa*, that is *naimittika*. *Atyantika* is the one that leads to *moksha* and *prakrita* amounts to two *parardhas*.’

The sages said, ‘O illustrious one! Tell us what has been said about the duration of a *parardha*, since doubling it one obtains a *prakrita* withdrawal.’

Vyasa replied, ‘O *brahmanas*! Each number is counted as ten times the number that succeeds it.¹⁹³ Thus, *parardha* is at the eighteenth place.¹⁹⁴ O *brahmanas*! When a *parardha* is double, *prakrita laya* takes place.¹⁹⁵ In that destruction, everything manifest is withdrawn into the unmanifest, the original cause. The basic measurement of time for humans is *nimesha*.¹⁹⁶ Fifteen *nimeshas* make up one *kashtha* and thirty *kashthas* make up one *kala*. Fifteen *kalas* make up one *nadika*. In a vessel that is six and a half *palas*¹⁹⁷ in weight, with sides measuring four *angulas*, a hole that is four *angulas* in length is made and a golden wire four *angulas* long and one *masha* in weight is inserted into it. The time taken for this to be submerged in water is one *nadika*. O supreme *brahmanas*! In Magadha, the measurement is for water to pass through a *prastha*.¹⁹⁸ Two *nadikas* make up one *muhurta*. Thirty *muhurtas* make up a day and night.¹⁹⁹ There are thirty days in a month. Twelve months make up a year and this is equivalent to a day and night in heaven. Three hundred and sixty human years amount to one year for the gods. Twelve thousand divine years amount to a set of the four *yuga*.²⁰⁰ One thousand *mahayuga* amount to one of Brahma’s days. O supreme *brahmanas*! This is a *kalpa* and within this, there are fourteen

Manus. O *brahmanas*! At the end of this, Brahma's *naimittika laya* occurs. O Indras among *brahmanas*! Its nature is terrible. Listen to my words. I will tell you about *prakrita laya* later. At the end of one thousand *mahayuga*, the earth is almost destroyed. For one hundred years, a terrible drought occurs. O best among sages! Almost every being on earth that has limited energy and substance suffers a great deal and is destroyed. The illustrious and undecaying Krishna assumes the form of Rudra. He makes all the subjects headed for destruction a part of his own self. O supreme sages! The illustrious Vishnu is stationed in the form of the sun, with seven rays and drinks up all the water. O *brahmanas*! After having drunk up all the water of the creatures and beings, he dries up the entire surface of the earth. The oceans, the rivers, the mountains, the springs in the mountains and all the water in the nether regions is conveyed to destruction. There is a lack of water. Having drunk up the water, seven suns each with one thousand rays are generated. Those seven suns heat from above and below. O *brahmanas*! They scorch the three worlds and the seven nether regions.²⁰¹ The blazing and resplendent suns scorch the three worlds. No liquid is left in the mountains, trees and oceans. O *brahmanas*! Everywhere in the three worlds, the trees and water are scorched. The earth assumes the form of the back of a tortoise. Hara Rudra, the destroyer of the creation of beings, assumes the form of the fire of destruction. Using the breath of the serpent Shesha, he burns the nether regions from below. The great blaze scorches all the nether regions and reaching the earth, burns down everything on the surface of the earth. There are terrible garlands of fire in *bhuvarka* and *svarka*.²⁰² Giant storms swirl around. All the three worlds come to resemble a frying pan. Surrounded by whirling flames, all the residents of these two worlds lose their strength. O *brahmanas*! Suffering from the heat, they seek refuge in Maharloka. But there too, the subjects are scorched by the great heat. Surrounded by this grief, seeking to save themselves, they go to Janaloka. O supreme among sages! Having scorched the entire universe in his form of Rudra, from the breath that is expelled from his mouth, Janardana creates clouds. They resemble elephants born in excellent lineages and there is thunder tinged with lightning. These dense and terrible

samvartaka clouds ²⁰³ cover the sky. Some are like masses of collyrium, others are like Kumuda. ²⁰⁴ Some clouds have the complexion of smoke, other clouds are yellow. Some have the complexion of turmeric, others have the complexion of the juice of lac. Some are like lapis lazuli, others are like blue sapphire. Some are like the conch shell or the moon. Others are like *jati* and *kunda* flowers. ²⁰⁵ Some are like the *indragopa* insect, ²⁰⁶ others have the complexion of red arsenic. Some have the complexion of lotus petals, other clouds rise up atop other clouds. Some have the forms of excellent cities, others are like mountains. Some clouds have the complexion of the turrets of mansions, others have the complexion of barren ground. They are gigantic in form and with their loud roars, they fill up the firmament. O *brahmanas*! Extremely dense, they shower down and pacify that extremely terrible fire that has spread everywhere in the three worlds. When the fire has been extinguished, the clouds shower down for more than one hundred years. O supreme sages! They shower and flood the entire universe. O *brahmanas*! The torrential downpour floods and deluges *bhuloka* and *bhuvarloka*, and above this, *svarloka*. The worlds are enveloped in darkness and everything mobile and immobile is destroyed. The giant clouds shower down for more than one hundred years.

Chapter 1(125) (*Prakritika* destruction)

Vyasa said, ‘O supreme among sages! The water approaches the place of the *saptarshis* ²⁰⁷ and everything in the three worlds becomes a single ocean of water. O *brahmanas*! After more than one hundred years have passed, the wind generated from Vishnu’s breathing dispels those clouds. The unthinkable and illustrious creator of all beings has all the beings in him. He is the origin, but is without a beginning. He drinks up all the wind in the firmament. The lord lies down on that single ocean of water, resting on Shesha. Hari is the creator of everything. Assuming the form of the *brahman*, the illustrious one lies down. Sanaka and the other *siddhas* who have gone to Janaloka praise him. Those who desire *moksha* and have gone to Brahmaloka think about him. In his own divine *maya*, he lies down in *yoganidra*. ²⁰⁸ The supreme lord, known as Vasudeva, thinks about himself. O Indras among *brahmanas*! This withdrawal is known as *naimittika*. This is because Hari, in his form of the *brahman*, lies down as *nimitta*. ²⁰⁹ When the one who is the *atman* of everything is awake, the universe moves. When Achyuta lies down in his bed of *maya*, everything shuts down. One thousand *mahayuga* are one day for the one who originated from the lotus. ²¹⁰ When the entire universe is reduced to a single ocean of water, it is said to be night for him. When he wakes up at the end of the night, Aja ²¹¹ creates again. As has been told to you earlier, it is Vishnu who assumes the form of Brahma to do all this. O *brahmanas*! This *pralaya*, the withdrawal at the end of a *kalpa*, is known as *naimittika*. ²¹² I have told you about this. Hear about *prakrita pralaya* next. O *Brahmanas*! Through lack of rain and fire, everything in the nether regions and in all the worlds is completely destroyed. Mahat and the other specific transformations are destroyed. This withdrawal is brought about when Krishna so desires it. First, water devours

smell and the other attributes of the earth. When smell is taken away, the earth is ready for destruction. When the subtle attribute of smell vanishes, the earth merges into water. The forceful water is everywhere and emits a loud roar. It fills everything, exists everywhere and roams around. Everywhere, Lokaloka ²¹³ is enveloped in waves of water. The attribute of water is drunk up by fire. When taste, the attribute of water, is destroyed, the water is severely scorched and is also destroyed. With taste, the attribute of water, destroyed, water merges into fire. The energy of fire surrounds water from every direction. That fire pervades every direction and water is withdrawn. Fire gradually fills up everything in the universe. The rays are everywhere, above, below and diagonal. Form is the subtle attribute of fire, giving it luster, but fire is drunk up by wind. When that is destroyed, everything is filled up by wind. The subtle attribute of fire is form and fire loses its form. When fire has been pacified, the great wind starts to blow. The entire world is without light, since all that energy is inside the wind. It is withdrawn inside the wind, which was its origin. The wind blows in the ten directions, above, below and diagonal. Space devours touch, the subtle attribute of wind. Wind is pacified and space remains, without any cover. It has no form, taste, touch or smell and is without any embodied form. It is not manifest, but fills everything. Everything is enveloped by space with its subtle attribute of sound. The attribute of sound is next devoured by *ahamkara*. ²¹⁴ The senses exist simultaneously with *ahamkara*. However, since *ahamkara* is based on pride, ²¹⁵ it is said that *ahamkara* has a *tamas* characteristic. *Mahabuddhi*, ²¹⁶ with its sense of discrimination, devours *ahamkara*. This great space exists inside and outside the universe. In this way, *Mahabuddhi* and the seven *prakritis* are progressively drawn into each other. ²¹⁷ Everything is enveloped in darkness and merges into the cosmic egg, which is in the water. The seven *dvipas*, ending in the oceans and the seven worlds, along with the mountains, are surrounded by water, which is drunk up by fire. Fire merges into wind and wind, finds its destruction in space. Space is devoured by *ahamkara* and *ahamkara* is devoured by Mahat. ²¹⁸ O *brahmanas*! Prakriti devours Mahat and everything else. O supreme among *brahmanas*! Prakriti is that in which all the *gunas* ²¹⁹ are in

balance. Nothing is excessive or deficient. Prakriti is said to be the cause. Pradhana ²²⁰ is the supreme cause beyond this. Prakriti is sometimes manifest and sometimes unmanifest. O *brahmanas*! The manifest part of Prakriti merges into the unmanifest part. After this, there is a single pure *akshara* ²²¹ that pervades everything. O Indra among *brahmanas*! A portion of the *paramatman* exists within all beings. When everything is destroyed, all conceptions of names and categories are also destroyed. What exists is known as the *paramatman*. This knowledge about the *paramatman* is *jnana*. This is the *brahman*, the supreme abode. This is the *paramatman*, the supreme lord. This is Vishnu, who exists everywhere. On obtaining him, no one returns. I have told you that Prakriti has both a manifest part and an unmanifest part. Both Purusha and Prakriti merge into the *paramatman*. The *paramatman* is the supreme lord, the foundation of everything. In the Vedas and Vedanta, he is chanted about, using the name of Vishnu. There are two kinds of rites in the Vedas—with *nivritti* and *pravritti*. ²²² In both of these, Purusha is worshipped. He is the embodied form of the sacrifice. Using the paths of the *Rig Veda*, the *Yajur Veda* and the *Sama Veda*, he is worshipped through *pravritti*. He is the lord of the sacrifice. He is Purusha. He is the being in the sacrifice. He is Purushottama. He is also worshipped through the path of *jnana*. His *atman* is *jnana*. He is the embodiment of *jnana*. When this path of *yoga* and *nivritti* is used, Vishnu confers the fruits of emancipation. There are things that are spoken about through *hrasva*, *dirgha* and *pluta* vowels and there are things that are beyond speech. ²²³ The undecaying Vishnu is all of these. He is manifest and he is unmanifest. He is the undecaying Purusha. He is the *paramatman*. He is the *atman* of the universe. Hari assumes the form of the universe. It is into him that the manifest and unmanifest forms of Prakriti merge. O *brahmanas*! Purusha also merges into the undifferentiated *atman*. O *brahmanas*! I have spoken to you about a period of time that lasts for two *parardhas*. O Indras among *brahmanas*! When Prakriti is manifest, this is spoken about as the Lord Vishnu's day. O stores of austerities! When Prakriti merges into Purusha, that duration of time is his night. However, for the *paramatman*, there is no real night or day. For the lord, such expressions are only used to articulate

matters. O tigers among sages! I have, thus, spoken to you about *prakrita* *laya*.'

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Chapter 1(126) (*Atyantika* destruction)

Vyasa said, ‘O *brahmanas*! After learning about the three kinds of suffering, *adhyatmika* and the others, ²²⁴ a learned man obtains *jnana*, develops non-attachment and proceeds to *atyantika* destruction. There are two kinds of *adhyatmika* suffering, physical and mental. The physical suffering can be of many types. Listen. Pain in the head, cold, fever, rheumatism, fistula, enlargement of the spleen, piles, swelling, asthma, nausea, disease of the eyes, diarrhea, leprosy, those that are described as diseases of the limbs and many others—these result from the body. You should now hear about mental torment. O best among *brahmanas*! There are many kinds of torments of the mind—desire, anger, fear, hatred, greed, confusion, grief, sorrow, jealousy, dishonour, envy and malice. O supreme among sages! These are the different kinds of ailments. Men suffer from *adhibhoutika* suffering on account of animals, birds, other men, *pishachas*, *uragas*, *rakshasas* and reptiles. O foremost among supreme *brahmanas*! *Adhidaivika* sufferings are said to be because of cold, heat, wind, rain, water and lightning. O supreme among sages! Due to conception, birth, old age, ignorance, death and hell, there are thousands of different kinds of hardships. In the womb, the delicate being is surrounded by a lot of excrement. Engulfed in this, its back, neck and joints in the bones are broken. The mother eats food that is excessively pungent, bitter, sharp, hot and salty and makes it suffer. Confined in this way, it suffers a lot of pain. It is not the lord of its own self and cannot stretch or contract its limbs. Lying down in the great mire of urine and excrement, it suffers in every possible way. It is breathless, but is conscious and remembers hundreds of births. Because of the bondage of its own karma, it suffers from this great misery in the womb. When the infant is born, its face is smeared with urine, blood,

excrement and semen. The joints in its body suffer from the wind known as *prajapatya*. When it is born, those strong winds make it face downwards. Suffering, it emerges from the mother's womb with a great deal of difficulty. When it is touched by the wind outside, it suffers from a great loss of consciousness. O supreme among sages! When it is born, all its *vijnana* is destroyed. Its limbs seem to be pierced by thorns. It seems to be sliced with saws. It falls down on the ground, like an insect from a wound full of pus. It isn't capable of scratching itself or turning around. Someone else is its master. It is only through the desires of others that it can drink milk and obtain food. When it lies down on a dirty bed, it is bitten by insects and gnats. Though it is bitten by them, it is incapable of repulsing them. There are many kinds of hardship at the time of birth and there are other kinds of miseries after birth. When he becomes a child, he faces *adhibhoutika* suffering. Enveloped by the darkness of ignorance, a man is foolish inside. He does not know, "Where have I come from? Who am I? Where will I go? What is my *atman*? Why am I fettered in these bonds? What is the reason? Or is there no reason? What should be done? What should not be done? What should be spoken? What should not be spoken? What is *dharma*? What is *adharma*? What constitutes it and how? What is duty? What is not duty? What is good? What is bad?" In this way, he is foolish like an animal because of the great power of ignorance. Addicted to the penis and the stomach, men suffer from pain. Ignorance is due to the sentiment of *tamas*. O *brahmanas*! Though there is an inclination to undertake tasks because of ignorance about what should be done, *karma* suffers. *Maharshis* have said that when *karma* suffers, one goes to hell. Therefore, those who are ignorant suffer pain in this world and in the world hereafter. A man's body is devastated by old age and the body turns flaccid. The teeth decay and are dislodged. The sinews and nerves are covered by wrinkles. The pupils are fixed towards the sky. Hair sticks out of the nostrils. The body trembles. All the creature's bones stick out. The joints of the bones in the back are bent. Since the digestive fire no longer functions, he eats little. He can only move a little. He can move, rise, lie down, sit or exert himself with a great deal of effort. Sight and hearing weakens. He

exudes saliva that smears his face. Unable to control anything, he looks forward to dying. He is incapable of feeling anything that happens at that moment. He cannot remember anything. He has to make tremendous efforts to speak even a little. Because of problems with breathing, he remains awake at night. When he is aged, others have to make him get up or lie down. He is dishonoured by his own servants, sons and wives. All purity becomes lax, but he still retains his desire for sporting and eating. His family members laugh at him and his relatives no longer feel any attachment towards him. He feels and remembers everything that he has done in his youth as if they have been done in some other birth. Tormented, he heaves deep sighs. These are the miseries he suffers in old age. Now hear about the miseries he faces at the time of death. His neck, hands and legs become loose. The man keeps trembling. Because of these miseries, he sighs repeatedly. He repeatedly tries to find strength in his knowledge. Extremely anxious because of a sense of ownership, he wonders, “What will happen to my gold, grain, sons, wives, servants and home?” Major ailments strike at his inner organs like terrible saws. Like the terrible destroyer, the joints in his bones clutch at his inner organs. The pupils of his eyes roll and he repeatedly flings his hand and feet around. His throat and palate turn dry and he cries out in distress. The *udana* breath makes him suffer and chokes his throat. He is enveloped in great heat and he is afflicted by hunger and thirst. He leaves the body with great difficulty and is oppressed by Yama’s servants. With great difficulty, he assumes another body in which he undergoes pain. Men face many other terrible sufferings at the time of death. When men die, they go to *naraka*. Hear about this. Yama’s servants seize him with nooses and strike him with sticks. The sight of Yama is terrible. The path that takes one to Yama is also terrible. O supreme *brahmanas*! It is strewn with terrible mire, sand, fires, machines and weapons. All of these cause ²²⁵ great pain. Saws and black crucibles are used to make men suffer. They are struck with battle-axes. They are buried in pits in the ground. They are impaled on spikes and forced to enter the mouths of tigers. Vultures devour them and they are fed to wolves. They are boiled in oil and smeared with corrosive mud. They are hurled down from

above and catapults are used to fling them away. Because of the sins, there are many kinds of hardships in hell. O *brahmanas*! The number of miseries in *naraka* cannot be counted. O best among *brahmanas*! It is not that miseries are faced only in hell. Because of the fear of falling down, there is no respite in heaven either. He is conceived in a womb again and takes birth as a man again. He finds himself in a womb again. Having been born, he dies again. Sometimes, he dies as soon as he is born. Sometimes, he dies during childhood or youth. O *brahmanas*! Anything that men find pleasing has the seed of misery. It is this seed that gives rise to the tree of unhappiness. Men endeavour to find a lot of happiness in wives, sons, friends, homes, fields, wealth and other things. However, these bring unhappiness. Tormented by the grief of *samsara*, the senses are scorched. Without the tree that yields emancipation, how can men possibly obtain happiness?

‘The learned say that the three kinds of misery make one suffer in the womb at the time of birth and old age. Though they may be seen to exhibit the signs of delight, they actually cause misery. It is held that the only medication is *atyantika* destruction into the illustrious one. Therefore, a learned man must make efforts to achieve this. O supreme *brahmanas*! The means of obtaining him are said to be *jnana* and *karma*. *Jnana* is said to be of two types—from the *agama* texts and from discrimination.²²⁶ The *agama* texts are full of *shabda*-brahma. *Para*-brahma is achieved through discrimination.²²⁷ Ignorance is like blinding darkness, the *jnana* that results from the sense of discrimination is like a lamp. O *brahmanas*! *Jnana* that results from a sense of discrimination is like the sun. O supreme sages! Manu has spoken about the meaning of the Vedas. That should be remembered. In this connection, I will state it. Listen to my words. There are two brahmans that should be known, *shabda*-brahma and *para*-brahma. If one is conversant with *shabda*-brahma, one achieves *para*-brahma. The *Atharva Veda* has said that both kinds of learning must be understood. The achievement of *para*-brahma is without decay. *Rig Veda* and the others lead to the other one. Those who desire emancipation should comprehend the supreme refuge of the *brahman*. He is not manifest. He is without old age.

He cannot be thought of. He is without birth. He is without decay. He cannot be indicated. He has no form. He has no hands or feet. He is not associated with anything else. He is the worthy one. He goes everywhere. He is eternal. He is the cause behind the origin of beings. Everything that deserves to be pervaded is pervaded by him. The learned ones look on him that way. He is the one who is spoken about in the words of the sacred texts. He is subtle. He is Vishnu's supreme destination. He is creation and destruction. He is the one who knows about the creation and destruction of beings. He is their refuge. He is knowledge. He is ignorance. He is spoken of as the illustrious one. He is the one who possesses unlimited learning, power, strength, lordship, vigor and energy. He is devoid of any inferior qualities. He is spoken of as Bhagavan. The *paramatman* resides in all beings. As the *atman* who resides in all beings, he is Vasudeva. When asked by the *maharshis* earlier, this is what Prajapati ²²⁸ said. In truth, the number of names by which Vasudeva is known is infinite. When he resides inside all beings and is the creator and arranger of the universe, he is the Lord Vasudeva. Though he assumes the natures, *gunas* and taints of all beings, he is beyond all *gunas*. ²²⁹ Since he is beyond all coverings, but envelopes the entire world, he is Akhilatman. ²³⁰ He possesses all the auspicious qualities. With a little bit of his powers, he creates all the categories of beings. To bring about the success of everything in the universe, depending on his wishes, he assumes different forms. There are no limits to his great energy, strength and prosperity. Through his own energy and powers, he is a reservoir of every kind of quality. He is greater than the greatest. He is the lord of all those who are supreme. When one reaches him, there is no hardship. In his individual and collective forms, he is Ishvara. ²³¹ He is not manifest. He manifests himself in his own forms. He is the lord of everything. His eyes are everywhere. He knows everything. He possesses all the powers. He is known as Parameshvara. ²³² He is without any taints. He is pure and supreme. He sparkles in his single form. He can be comprehended, one can see him and one can go to him through *jnana*. Everything else that is spoken about is ignorance.'

Chapter 1(127) (The practice of *yoga*)

The sages said, ‘Please tell us about *yoga* now. When one comes into contact with miseries, it is the medication. When we understand it, we will be united with the undecaying Purushottama.’

Suta said, ‘Hearing their words, Krishna Dvaipayana Vyasa, the *yogi*, supreme among all those who know about *yoga*, was greatly delighted. He spoke.’

Vyasa said, ‘O *brahmanas*! I will tell you about *yoga*. It destroys worldly existence. Listen. By practising it, a *yogi* obtains *moksha*, which is so very difficult to obtain. He must devotedly worship his *guru* and hear about the texts on *yoga*. He must become accomplished in *itihasa*, Puranas and the *Vedas*. An intelligent person must understand about the diet that causes harm to *yoga*, about the time and the place. Having understood everything, he must practise *yoga*. He must be without the opposite pairs of sentiments²³³ and without possessions. He must subsist on *saktu*, *yavagu*, *takra*, roots, fruits, milk, barley and bits of oilcake.²³⁴ Such a diet helps obtain success in *yoga*. One must never practise *yoga* when the mind is unhappy, when one is excited, when one is exhausted, when one is hungry, when the opposite pairs of sentiments exist, when it is cold, when it is hot, where there is too much of wind, where there is sound, near water, inside a cattle-pen that is dilapidated, at crossroads, in a place frequented by reptiles, in a cremation ground, on the banks of a river, near a fire, in a *chaitya*,²³⁵ in a place where there is a termite-hill, where there is reason for fear, near a well, or where there is a heap of dry leaves. These places must be avoided. If, because of folly, one practises *yoga* in spots that are described to be impediments, I will tell you about the taints that result—deafness, stupidity, loss of memory, dumbness, blindness and fever. These result immediately and give

rise to ignorance. Therefore, a person who knows about *yoga* must make every effort to protect himself against these, since it is the body which ensures success in achieving *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*. It must be practised in an *ashrama*, in a desolate spot, in a secret place, where there is no sound, where there is no fear, near a tree, in an empty house, in a pure and beautiful place, where one is alone and in a temple. One must control oneself and practise it in the first or last *yama* of the night.²³⁶ It can also be practised in the forenoon or at midday. He must be restrained in diet and must conquer his senses. Immobile, he must seat himself on a beautiful and comfortable seat facing the east. It should not be too high or too low. He must be without desire, must be truthful and pure. He must not sleep too much. He must conquer his anger and be engaged in the welfare of all beings. He must withstand the opposite pair of sentiments. He must persevere. He must hold his body, head and legs steady. He must place both of his hands on his navel. He must be calm and be seated in *padmasana*.²³⁷ He must fix his eyes on the tip of his nose. He must control his speech and practise *pranayama*.²³⁸ The sage must withdraw his senses and his mind and fix them in the heart. Immobile and covering his mouth, he must continuously chant *pranava*.²³⁹ He must use *rajas* to control *tamas* and use *sattva* to control *rajas*. He must close his eyes and remain steady, withdrawn, peaceful and serene. Purshottama, the one who bestows emancipation, is omnipresent. The unblemished one resides inside the cavity of his heart, which is like a lotus. In this way, the *yogi* will always be united with the unsullied one. He must first fix the senses of perception, the organs of action and the elements in the *kshetrajna*.²⁴⁰ After this, a person who knows about *yoga* will unite the *kshetrajna* with the *paramatman*. That supreme destination has the characteristic of being like one hundredth the size of the tip of a strand of hair.²⁴¹ Immersed in *dhyana*, a *yogi* will use the lamp of his mind to see this. Like a tortoise draws in its limbs, a person who knows about *yoga* will withdraw his senses. When the objects of the senses are discarded and the mind is unwaveringly fixed in the *paramatman*, it is evident that success in *yoga* will be achieved. Detached from material objects, the consciousness merges into the supreme *brahman*. The supreme

destination of *yoga*, one of *samadhi*, is then achieved. ²⁴² At that time, the *yogi*'s consciousness is detached from every kind of *karma*. Immersed in bliss, he achieves *nirvana*. ²⁴³ Beyond the three states, this is known as *turiya*. ²⁴⁴ This is Purushottama. When a *yogi* uses the strength of *yoga* to achieve this, there is no doubt that he is liberated. He does not desire any of the objects of desire. He is always beautiful to behold. His intelligence always transcends everything. The *yogi* cannot but be freed. A person who knows about *yoga* does not serve the senses. He is not attached to anything. Through the constant practise of *yoga*, there is no doubt that he will be freed. *Yoga* is not achieved through *padmasana* or by glancing at the tip of the nose. The union of the mind and the senses ²⁴⁵ is spoken of as *yoga*. O best among sages! I have, thus, spoken to you about *yoga*. It bestows emancipation. It leads to emancipation from *samsara*. What else do you wish to hear?'

Lomaharshana continued, 'Listening to Vyasa's words, they worshipped him and praised and applauded his words. They got ready to ask him again.'

Chapter 1(128) (*Samkhya* and *Yoga*)

The sages said, ‘O sage! The words have emerged like *amrita* from the ocean of your mouth. O best among *brahmanas*! We do not see any end to the satisfaction that is generated from drinking it. O sage! Therefore, tell us in detail about *yoga*. It bestows emancipation. O best among bipeds! We also desire to hear about *samkhya*. O brahmana! There may be a learned brahmana who is wise. He performs sacrifices and is known as being wise. He does not suffer from jealousy and is devoted to the *dharma* of the truth. How does he attain the *brahman*? Is this achieved through austerities, *brahmacharya*, renouncing everything, intelligence, *samkhya* or *yoga*? This is what we are asking you. Please tell us. Through what method does a man achieve the fixation of the mind and the senses? You should explain the truth about this to us.’

Vyasa replied, ‘This is never achieved without *jnana* and austerities. This is never achieved without controlling the senses. Success is never achieved without renouncing everything. Earlier, all the great elements were created by Svayambhu. These are also embedded in the bodies of all living beings. The body results from the element that is the earth. Everything viscous results from the element that is the water. The eyes are said to result from the element that is the fire. *Prana* and *apana* find their foundation in the element of the wind.²⁴⁶ The cavities in the body result from the element of space. Vishnu exists in the stride, Shakra in strength, Agni in the stomach in the form of the desire to eat, the divinities of the directions in the ears and Sarasvati in the tongue, in the form of speech. The two ears, the two eyes, the tongue and the nose as the fifth—these are said to be the gates used to accomplish success in reception. Sound, touch, form, taste and smell as the fifth—these are always known as the objects of the senses, distinct from the

senses. Like a helpless snake that has no poison, the senses are always connected with the mind. Connected with the mind, the *atman* is always present inside the heart of the being. The mind is the lord of all the senses. The *atman* of a being controls or releases the mind. The following are always present in the body of a living and embodied being—the senses, the objects of the senses, innate nature, consciousness, the mind, *prana* and *apana*. There is no refuge for *sattva* in this. Anything for which the word *guna* is used, has no consciousness. Energy creates the living being, but never the *gunas*. The body consists of seventeen and is surrounded by sixteen attributes. ²⁴⁷ O *brahmanas*! The learned use the mind to see the *paramatman* in the *jivatman*. ²⁴⁸ It cannot be perceived through the eyes or through any of the senses. Illuminated by the mind, the great *atman* manifests itself. It is devoid of sound, touch, form, taste or smell. It doesn't possess a body and is bereft of the senses. However, it can be perceived inside the body. It is greatly revered, but is not manifested in the bodies of all mortals. If a person sees it, after death, he is fit to merge into the *brahman*. The wise looks equally upto a *brahmana* who is learned and humble, a cow, an elephant, a dog and a *shvapaka*. ²⁴⁹ It exists in all beings, mobile and fixed. The great *atman* resides in everything. When a person sees his *atman* in all beings and all beings in his *atman*, he is one for whom the *atman* in the being merges with the *brahman*. ²⁵⁰ A person understands his *atman* to the extent that he sees his *atman* in the *paramatman*. If a person always knows this, he is thought to be fit for immortality. A person who sees his *atman* in all creatures is engaged in the welfare of all beings. Seeking the destination along this path, even the gods are confused and stumble. The movement of birds in the sky or that of birds in the water cannot be discerned. Like that, the progress of those who possess *jnana* can also not be discerned. Using the *paramatman* in the *jivatman*, time cooks all beings. But no one knows when time is itself cooked. It ²⁵¹ is not above or below. Nor is it located diagonally. Nor can anyone ever grasp it in the middle. All the worlds are located in it and nothing is outside it. Even if an arrow is properly released from the string of a bow and if one possesses the speed of thought, one will never be able to reach the end of that ultimate

cause. There is nothing more subtle than that. There is nothing grosser than that. It has hands and feet everywhere, its eyes, heads and mouths are in every direction. Its eyes are everywhere. It exists, enveloping everything in the world. ²⁵² It is smaller than the smallest. It is greater than the greatest. It certainly exists inside all beings, but it cannot be perceived. The *atman* has two kinds of expressions—the perishable and the imperishable. The perishable is in all beings and the divine and imperishable part is immortal. Hamsa creates a city with nine gates and always controls it. ²⁵³ In this way, it exists in all beings, mobile and immobile. Those who know about the supreme say that it possesses the attribute of the swan because it can separate the undecaying essence from the accumulation that is the bodies of men. However, what is known as Hamsa is also perishable. The deeper one is imperishable. ²⁵⁴ A person who knows this gives up his *prana* and birth and obtains what is imperishable.

‘O *brahmanas*! I have accurately told you the truth about what you asked me. I have described to you the *jnana* behind *samkhya*. O *brahmanas*! I will next tell you how *yoga* is undertaken. This amounts to bringing the mind, the intelligence and the senses together, for the pervasive *jnana* about the *atman*. This is supreme knowledge. This can be understood by those who are tranquil and self-controlled, devoted to knowledge about the *adhyatma*. ²⁵⁵ The intelligence of these people is such that they take delight in the *atman* and in performing pure deeds. The wise know that there are five taints in the path of *yoga*—desire, anger, avarice, fear and slumber as the fifth. Anger is defeated through mental self-control, desire by discarding such thoughts. A persevering person must destroy slumber by focusing on *sattva*. Fortitude protects against the penis and the stomach. The eyes guard against the action of the hands and the feet. The mind guards against the eyes and the ears, deeds guard against the mind and speech. One conquers fear by not being distracted, insolence is conquered by associating with those who are wise. In this way, with constant attention, one conquers the taints in the path of *yoga*. A person must always bow down to *brahmanas*, the fire and gods. One must avoid insolent and violent speech and practice what is pleasant to the mind. The seed of the *brahman*’s energy is

everywhere in the universe and he sees this in mobile and immobile objects, that which is manifest and that which is not manifest. Meditation, studying, donations, truth, modesty, uprightness, forgiveness, purity, purification of the *atman* and conquest of the senses—through these, energy increases and wicked inclinations are curbed. He must be impartial towards all beings and towards what has been obtained and what has not been obtained. He must cleanse his *atman*, control his diet, conquer his senses and become energetic. Having subjugated desire and anger, he will serve the supreme *brahman*. He will single-mindedly control his mind and senses. At the beginning of the night and at the end of the night, he will fix the *jivatman* in the *paramatman*. A being has five senses. Even if one of them is moistened like water flowing from the foot of a mountain, the wisdom is drained away. A killer of fish takes away turtles. Like that, the mind must first be restrained. A person who knows about *yoga* next restrains the ears, the eyes, the tongue and the nose. He restrains them and fixes them in his mind. After that, he restrains all the resolutions in his mind and fixes them in his *atman*. The five senses and the mind are fixed in heart. In this way, with the mind as the sixth, they are fixed in the *atman*. He is pleased with these having been fixed and the *brahman* manifests itself. Like a flame without smoke, it is as radiant as the sun. He sees the *paramatman* in his *atman*, dazzling like lightning or the fire. Everything is seen in it and it is seen to pervade everything. Learned *brahmanas* see the great *atman* in this way. They are the ones who possess fortitude and are immensely wise, engaged in the welfare of all beings. Firm in one's vows, one must thus practice for a limited period. He must be seated in a desolate spot, seeking similarity with the imperishable one. He must use *yoga* to control confusion, the whirlwind of errors, extraordinary sensations about hearing, seeing and touch, the wind that seems to be too hot or too cold and understanding about evil portents.²⁵⁶ Through equanimity, he can ignore them and withdraw from them. The *yogi* will control himself like a sage and not reveal himself to the three worlds. He must practise *yoga* on the summit of a mountain, in a *chaitya* or under a tree. Like vessels stored in a room, he must control all his senses. He must single-mindedly think of what is permanent and use

yoga to control the mind. The mind is fickle, but these are the means whereby one is capable of restraining it. He must practice in this way and not waver. Single-minded, he must seek to make a residence in an empty house. In his words, thoughts and deeds, he must avoid the excessive crossing of norms. Impartial, he must be restrained in diet, impartial towards what has been obtained and what has not been obtained. He will be indifferent towards being congratulated or honoured. He must be indifferent towards both the auspicious and the inauspicious. He will not be delighted when something has been obtained, nor think about something that has not been obtained. He will follow the *dharma* of the wind and be impartial towards all creatures. Secure in this way, a virtuous person will be impartial towards everything, everywhere. Within six months, he will approach *shabda*-brahma. He will see what is beyond all pain and grief and be impartial towards a lump of earth or iron and gold. On seeing that others are suffering or confused, he will not desist from the path. Even a person from an inferior *varna*, or a woman who desires dharma, obtains the supreme destination along this path. O *brahmanas*! He is ancient and without birth. He is without decay. He is eternal. He is beyond the perception of the senses. He is the imperceptible Parameshthi. On being united with him, the learned obtain a destination from which there is no return.'

Chapter 1(129) (*Samkhya* and *Yoga* continued)

The sages said, ‘The words of the Vedas say—undertake tasks and renounce them.²⁵⁷ What destination is obtained by those who follow knowledge? What destination is obtained by those who undertake tasks? O illustrious one! We wish to hear about these, two. Please tell us. There seems to be a contradiction between these since they are inconsistent with each other.’

Vyasa replied, ‘O tigers among sages! Listen. I will briefly tell you what you have asked me about. I will tell you about both tasks and knowledge and about what is perishable and what is imperishable. I will tell you about the destination obtained by those who follow knowledge and the destination obtained by those who undertake tasks. O *brahmanas*! Listen now. The answer is deep and complex. *Dharma* exists. There are those who say it does not exist. This is similar to equating *dharma* with a *yaksha*, if something like a *yaksha* at all exists. The Vedas are established on two paths—the characteristic of one kind of *dharma* is *pravritti*, while that of the other is said to be *nivritti*. Tasks bind a being, knowledge frees him. Therefore, mendicants who know about the supreme do not engage in tasks. As a result of *karma*, after death, one is born again, in an embodied form with the sixteen attributes.²⁵⁸ Knowledge leads to the eternal and unmanifest, the imperishable *atman*. Therefore, men who are limited in their understanding praise *karma*. As a result, they serve the pleasure obtained through a net of bodies. There are those who possess supreme intelligence about *dharma*. They are accomplished in their vision and do not praise *karma*. A person who drinks from a river does not praise a well. Through *karma*, one obtains the fruits of happiness and unhappiness, of birth and death. Through knowledge, one obtains such a destination once

one reaches it, one does not grieve. When one has gone there, one is not born. When one has gone there, one does not die. When one has gone there, one does not decay. When one has gone there, one does not increase. The supreme *brahman* is there. It is unmanifest, fixed and certain. It does not have transformations. It has no extensions. It is immortal and a person who knows about *yoga* goes there. In thoughts and deeds, one is not obstructed by the opposite pairs of sentiments there. One is impartial and friendly towards everyone. One is engaged in the welfare of all living beings. O *brahmanas*! There is a being that is full of knowledge and there is another being that is full of *karma*. O *brahmanas*! This is like the subtle touch of the moon, as opposed to the *kalas* it is based on.²⁵⁹ The *rishis* have spoken and sung about this in detail. This is like a strand in a wheel in the sky. One is incapable of seeing it, or speaking about it. O *brahmanas*! In the embodied form, there are eleven transformations or digits within it.²⁶⁰ Know that these are the results of *karma* and *gunas*. Like the moon in the sky, there is an intelligent divinity that resides within this. Know this to be the eternal *kshetrajna*. One can always comprehend this through *yoga*. Know that the *gunas* of a *jivatman* are *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*. But know that the *gunas* of the *jivatman* are those of the *paramatman*. It is said that the attribute of a living being is consciousness and that this attribute of a living being makes it exert itself. Those who know about what is superior to the *kshetra*²⁶¹ have thought of the seven worlds.²⁶² The transformation of Prakriti is known as *kshetrajna*. No one knows it and it does not know anyone. It performs tasks through the senses, with the mind as the sixth. This is like a well-trained charioteer, using excellent horses to firmly control the chariot. The objects of the senses are superior to the senses. The mind is superior to the objects of the senses. Intelligence is superior to the mind and the great *atman* is superior to intelligence.²⁶³ The unmanifest is superior to the great *atman*. The immortal is superior to the unmanifest. What is superior to the immortal? That is the supreme and ultimate destination. In all beings, the *atman* is hidden and is not seen. It can only be discerned by those who are focused in their intelligence, those who can see what is more subtle than the subtle. Using his intelligence, he will make his senses and mind merge into

the inner *atman*. He will not think a lot and will not use his senses to think about the objects of the senses. Using his knowledge, he will force the mind to be engaged in supreme *dhyana*. He will be serene in his *atman* and no one will control him. He will then proceed to the supreme destination. If the *atman* comes under the control of any of the senses and if memory is fickle, a mortal person submits his *atman* to death. Discarding all resolution, the consciousness must be submerged in *sattva*. If the consciousness is merged in *sattva*, one does not suffer from decay and death. With a cheerful consciousness, a mendicant casts aside all that is auspicious and all that is inauspicious. With his joyful *atman* immersed in the *paramatman*, he enjoys infinite bliss. The sign of this joy is like a happy dream. It is like a blazing lamp that does not flicker from the wind. Thus, in the first part of the night or towards the end of the night, one should unite the *jivatman* with the *paramatman*. He must restrain his diet and cleanse his soul. He will then see the *paramatman* in his own *atman*. This is the secret of all the Vedas. This is the unmatched freedom from all ailments. This visualization of the *atman*, from the sacred texts must be passed on to one's son. This is what has been spoken about in the texts about *dharma* and the texts about truth. After churning those for ten thousand years, this *amrita* has been extracted. This is like producing butter from curds, or fire from kindling. In that way, for the sake of emancipation, the learned have extracted this *jnana*. This sacred knowledge must be spoken about to *snatakas*²⁶⁴ and sons. It must not be imparted to ascetics who are not tranquil and controlled. Nor must it be imparted to those who are learned in the Vedas or those who are not followers. It must not be given to those who are not jealous and not upright, or those who have no sense of direction. It must not be given to those who are prone to arguing or to those who indulge in slander. It must be imparted to a serene ascetic who praises it, one who is praiseworthy. This secret *dharma* must be spoken about to beloved sons, disciples and followers, never to anyone else. Even if the earth, with its full complement of jewels is donated, a man who knows what is good for him takes this truth to be superior. This superhuman knowledge of *adhyatma* has a deep meaning. This has been seen by *maharshis* and has been chanted about in Vedanta. O

excellent ones! I have told you whatever you have asked me about, about what is in my mind and about the doubts in your hearts. All of you have heard this. What shall I tell you about next?’

The sages said, ‘Please tell us about *adhyatma* again, in detail. O illustrious one! O excellent *rishi*! Let us understand *adhyatma*.’

Vyasa replied, ‘O *brahmanas*! I will tell you what a man reads about *adhyatma* and about the explanations. Understand. The great elements are earth, water, fire, wind and space. The one who created these elements is inside all beings.’

The sages said, ‘Space and the others have no embodied form and no one can see them. How does one describe their existence in bodies? What are the qualities of the senses? How does one observe them?’

Vyasa replied, ‘I will describe this as it has been described. Listen attentively to the truth, exactly as it is. The three attributes of space are sound, the ears and the void. The three attributes of wind are *prana*, movement and touch. The three attributes of fire are said to be form, the eye and the digestive process. The three attributes of water are taste, the tongue and sweat. The three attributes of earth are smell, the nose and the body. This is described as the category of senses that evolved from the five elements. Touch is the attribute of wind, taste is the attribute of water, form is the attribute of fire, sound is the attribute of space and smell is said to be the attribute of earth. The mind, intelligence and innate nature are attributes that have their own origins. They do not follow the other attributes. It is held that they are superior to the other attributes. A turtle extends and withdraws its limbs. Like that, a person with superior intelligence restrains the aggregate of the senses. If a person acts in a way that he sees above, diagonally and below his feet, this indicates that he possesses supreme intelligence. The *gunas* lead intelligence. However, intelligence leads the senses. The mind is the sixth. If intelligence does not exist, how can all the *gunas* exist? A man has five senses and the mind is said to be the sixth. Intelligence is said to be the seventh. Know that *kshetrajna* is the eighth. The eye sees, the mind doubts. Intelligence studies this, while the *kshetrajna* is said to be only a witness. *Sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas* have their

own origins. These *gunas* are noticed to equally exist in all beings. When one discerns the *atman* and is happy and serene, this means one is united with *sattva*. When it is noticed that a person is tormented in his body or mind, this displays the functioning of *rajas*. When one is filled with a terrible confusion that cannot be discussed or understood, it is caused by *tamas*. Joy, delight, bliss, self-dependence and mental stability—these are said to be the qualities of *sattva*. Arrogance, false speech, greed, confusion and lack of forgiveness—when these signs exist, that has been caused by *rajas*. Confusion, being distracted, languor, slumber, lack of understanding and a tendency to somehow remain alive—these are known to be the qualities of *tamas*. There are three kinds of urges behind action. The mind leads to sentiments, intelligence determines and the heart considers what is pleasant. The objects of the senses are superior to the senses. The mind is superior to the objects of the senses. Intelligence is superior to the mind. The *atman* is said to be superior to intelligence.²⁶⁵ Since intelligence leads the *atman*, the comprehension of the *atman* depends on intelligence. When it leads to perverse sentiments, it adversely affects the mind. The senses are separate. It is intelligence that causes perversion. At the time of hearing, it acts like the ear. At the time of touching, it acts like the skin. At the time of seeing, it acts like the eye. At the time of tasting, it acts like the tongue. At the time of smelling, it acts like the nose. It is intelligence that causes the perversion. In those that are referred to as senses, it is intelligence that is established in them. Intelligence exists in a man and it is intelligence that causes sentiments. Sometimes, one obtains happiness. Sometimes, one grieves. It is never actually happy, unhappy or confused. It itself causes those sentiments and acts like a leader in engineering those three sentiments.²⁶⁶ This is like the ocean, the lord of rivers, rushing towards the great shore-line and causing waves. Whatever intelligence wishes for is followed by the mind. However, it is cited as existing independently. All the senses are collectively gathered in intelligence. All of them have evolved in the due order. When the intelligence is undivided, the mind follows this. When *rajas* starts to function, it can overcome *sattva*. Know that these three inclinations²⁶⁷ pursue their objectives like the spokes in the wheel of a

chariot follow the rim. One must use the senses with supreme intelligence and ignite the mind. One can choose to be indifferent or one can direct them towards appropriate ends. If one understands this as innate nature, one is not confused. One does not grieve, nor is one delighted. One is always devoid of envy. The senses follow desire and cannot perceive the *atman*. Since they function in many ways, a person whose soul isn't cleansed cannot control them. The mind is like reins, used to restrain them properly. The resplendent *atman* then manifests itself like a form illuminated by a lamp. When darkness is dispelled, all creatures are brought to light. This is the way one should think about it. An aquatic bird is not touched by the water it roams around in. Like that, a *yogi*'s free *atman* is not smeared by the taints of the *gunas*. If one accomplishes wisdom in this way, there is no taint from association with material objects. Even one is not attached to anything, how can one be contaminated? Such a person casts aside his former *karma* and finds delight in the great *atman*. He sees his *atman* in all beings. Sometimes, because of contact with the *gunas*, he is born again and comes into contact with the *gunas*. The *gunas* do not know the *atman*, but the *atman* knows the *gunas*. Understanding the functioning of the *gunas*, he should see how they act. A man must perceive the difference between *satva* and *kshetrajna*. One of them creates the *gunas*, the other does not create the *gunas*.²⁶⁸ They are separate in nature, even though they are naturally connected to each other. This is like rock and gold existing together,²⁶⁹ a gnat and *udumbura*²⁷⁰ being together, or a blade of *munja* grass and the grass. They exist separately, though they exist together and seem to be dependent on each other.'

Chapter 1(130) (*Samkhya* and *Yoga* continued)

Vyasa said, ‘Sattva creates the *gunas* and *kshetrajna* presides over them. When all the *gunas* act, *kshetrajna* is like an indifferent master. They have their individual natures and it creates all these *gunas*, just as a weaver creates the strands in its web. *Pravritti* cannot be discerned. Therefore, one cannot withdraw from *pravritti*. Some hold this view. Others hold the view that one can follow *nivritti*. One must use one’s intelligence to study these views and come to a conclusion. There may be a great doubt on this matter. The *atman* has no birth or death. After comprehending this, a man must amuse himself accordingly. He must never be angry or delighted. He must always be without envy. Using his intelligence, he must always steadily ponder about this in his heart. All happiness and reason to grieve are temporary. Therefore, he must sever all doubts. Having been dislodged on earth, a man will then cross it the way he crosses a full river, even if he is immersed in the water. O *brahmanas*! A learned person is not tormented. A person who knows the truth behaves as if he is walking on solid ground. He only thinks about the *atman* and *jnana* about the *atman*. A man understands the creation of beings, how they emerge and where they go. Having examined it properly, he obtains what is auspicious and excellent. This is the objective behind the birth of *dvijas*, especially *brahmanas*, *jnana* and affection towards the *atman*, which is the ultimate refuge. Having understood this, one becomes a *buddha*? ²⁷¹ What other sign can there be of becoming a *buddha*? After learning this, learned men become emancipated and accomplish their objective. Those who are not learned face a great fear in the world hereafter, but a learned person faces no such fear. A learned person attains the eternal destination and there is nothing superior to that. Unable to see the gods, or the mother of the worlds, a man grieves. But an

accomplished person who has understood both what has been done and what has not been done, does not sorrow. If a person undertakes tasks without being attached, all his former *karma* is burnt away. When he undertakes tasks in this world, that is caused by both the auspicious and the inauspicious that he has formerly done.’

The sages said, ‘Please tell us about the special *dharma* that is superior to all other kinds of *dharma* and better than everything that exists.’

Vyasa replied, ‘I will tell you about the ancient *dharma*, praised by the *rishis*. This is superior to every other kind of *dharma*. O supreme sages! Listen. The senses cause agitation and spread in every direction. Like a father controlling his sons during childhood, one must use one’s intelligence to control them. The greatest austerity is concentrating the mind and the senses. This is superior to every other kind of *dharma*. This is spoken of as supreme *dharma*. Using knowledge, one must control them, with the mind as the sixth. A person must be content in his own *atman* and must not think many kinds of thought. When the cows return from grazing, they are kept in their own abodes. Like that, one should see the eternal *paramatman* in one’s own *atman*. The great *atman* is in all *atmans* and is like a smoke without fire. Learned *brahmanas* see this great *atman*. This is like a great tree with many branches and flowers and fruit. If one does not know the *atman*,²⁷² where is the question of the flowers or the fruit? If one does not know the *atman*, how can one ask—where will I go and where have I come from? There is the other one²⁷³ that exists in one’s inner core and witnesses everything. When the mind is illuminated with the lamp of knowledge, one sees the *paramatman* in one’s *jivatman*. O *brahmanas*! When you see the *atman* in this way, you will develop non-attachment. Like snakes shedding their skin, you will be freed of all sins. With this supreme intelligence, you will be devoid of anxiety and will be free from unpleasant thoughts. This world is like a terrible river with currents everywhere. The five senses are crocodiles. The resolutions in the mind are like the banks. Avarice and confusion are the grass that covers the banks. Desire and anger are reptiles. Truth is like *tirthas* and falsehood is like eddies. In this excellent river, anger forms the mud. It originates in the unmanifest and flows swiftly, full

of desire and anger. Using intelligence, one can cross the river. However, those who have not cleansed their souls find it impossible to cross. It flows into the ocean that is *samsara*, with the womb as a nether region that is impossible to traverse. This starts with a person's birth and becomes difficult to cross because there are many tongues. ²⁷⁴ A persevering and learned person, accomplished in wisdom, can cross it. When one crosses it, one is freed from everything. A person becomes pure and his soul is cleansed. Using that excellent intelligence, he is fit to merge into the *brahman*. He overcomes every kind of hardship. He is serene and his soul is cleansed. When he looks at all manner of beings again, he is not angered, nor is he pleased. His mind does not turn towards violence. He sees the origin and destruction of all beings. The learned think that this is the best kind of *dharma*. Sages, truthful in speech and upholders of *dharma*, have held this to be the best kind of *dharma*. O *brahmanas*! The *atman* pervades everything. This is what should be instructed to one's sons. For their welfare, it should be revealed to those who are controlled and those who are followers. This great *jnana* about the *atman* is secret and is most mysterious. I have told you about it. One's sparkling *jivatman* is a witness to all this. The *brahman* is not masculine, feminine or neuter. It does not experience joy or misery. It has the past, present and future inside it. On knowing this, a man or a woman does not have to return to earth again. There are many kinds of views which state different things. O *brahmanas*! I have told you what is true, not what is not true. If the son possesses the qualities, out of compassion and affection towards that virtuous son and to ensure his benefit, one should tell the son what I have told you.'

The sages said, 'The grandfather has spoken about the methods through which one can attain emancipation and the methods through which one cannot. O sage! We wish to hear about the proper methods.'

Vyasa replied, 'O immensely wise ones! We must subject this to skilled scrutiny. O unblemished ones! One must always examine all the different methods. Intelligence is used to fashion a pot, but intelligence is not the cause of the pot. In that way, there are different methods to achieve *dharma*. But these other methods have not caused *dharma*. The path that leads to the

eastern ocean does not lead to the western ocean. There is only one path to liberation. O unblemished ones! Hear about it from me. Forgiveness must be used to overcome anger. By discarding all resolution, one overcomes desire. By resorting to *sattva*, a persevering person must destroy slumber. A learned person must protect the body against fear and being distracted. Through fortitude, one must control wishes, hatred and desire. Through the practice of *jnana*, a person who knows the truth will conquer slumber and audacity. The *yogi* will conquer ailments by only eating after the food eaten earlier has been digested. A person who has seen the truth will use contentment to conquer greed towards material objects and confusion. Compassion and indifference must be used to conquer what is *adharma*. He must use what he has got to conquer desire and must conquer his capacity by avoiding attachment. A learned person will conquer attachment by recognizing that these are temporary. He will conquer hunger through *yoga*. He will use compassion and see his *atman* in all *atmans*. He will use satisfaction to conquer thirst. To conquer lassitude, he will wake up early. He will use determination to conquer debates. He will conquer excessive speech through silence and use bravery to conquer fear. Using the insight of *jnana*, he will use his intelligence to conquer his speech and mind. Knowledge about the great *atman* will be used to sever everything. What exists in his inner core can be used to sever everything. A tranquil person who is pure in his deeds will understand this. Those who are wise know that there are five taints in the pursuit of *yoga* and these must be destroyed—desire, anger, avarice, fear and dreaming as the fifth. Through serving the practice of *yoga*, one casts all these aside. Meditation, studying, donations, truth, modest, uprightness, forgiveness, purity in conduct and purification and control of the senses—these increase energy and destroy sins. All resolutions are accomplished and *vijnana* starts to function. A person who is restrained in diet and has conquered his senses, cleanses his sins and becomes energetic. Having subjugated desire and anger, he achieves the destination of the *brahman*. This is beyond foolishness and attachment, devoid of desire and anger. This is a state where there is no distress, no boasting and no anxiety. This is the sparkling, pure and contented path

towards *moksha*. Speech and the mind are controlled and as one wishes, a state without decay can be achieved.'

Chapter 1(131) (Practice of *yoga*)

The sages said, ‘O brahmana! You should tell us the specific characteristics of *samkhya* and *yoga*. O one who knows about *dharma*! O supreme among sages! You know everything.’

Vyasa replied, ‘Those who know about *samkhya* praise *samkhya*, those who know about *yoga* praise *yoga*. They will give reasons to establish why their own view is superior. O supreme among sages! How can something that does not believe in the lord confer emancipation? Citing this reason, there are learned ones who rightly say that *yoga* is superior. There are also *brahmanas* who cite proper reasons about *samkhya*’s superiority. If one knows about the destination of everything and is not attached to material objects, only then can he be liberated, once he casts aside his body, not otherwise. Citing this, immensely wise ones say that *samkhya* shows the path to *moksha*. These are beneficial words, rationale in favour of the respective sides, and worthy of being accepted. You are revered by virtuous people and should accept the view that is superior. The reasons in favour of *yoga* are directly perceived, the determination of *samkhya* is based on the sacred texts. O supreme *brahmanas*! Both of these views are based on the truth. Sages who are revered by virtuous people know about both views. If something is practised in accordance with the sacred texts, it conveys the person to the supreme destination. O unblemished ones! They are identical in what they say about purity and compassion towards beings. They are equal in what they say about vows. But they are not identical in their *darshana*.’ ²⁷⁵

The sages said, ‘O great sage! For this world, they are identical in vows, purity and compassion. O supreme among *brahmanas*! How are they not identical in their *darshana*? Please tell us.’

Vyasa replied, ‘Those who practise yoga can only suffer from five defects—attachment, confusion, affection, desire and anger. Just as fish cut through a large net and reach the water again, those who practice yoga can destroy their sins and obtain the desired destination. This is like a powerful deer escaping the snare and reaching an unrestricted path, free of all bondage. O *brahmanas*! The bonds that result from avarice and the other things are powerful. Severing them, a person who practises *yoga* proceeds along a sparkling and unrestricted path. O *brahmanas*! They are firm and do not waver, destroying all snares. Without the strength of *yoga*, how can one not have doubts? O Indras among *brahmanas*! O *brahmanas*! This is like a weak person getting caught in a snare. O unblemished ones! It is extremely rare for a person without *yoga* to escape from the bonds. O scorcher of enemies! This is like weak birds getting ensnared in a trap. They cannot escape from the calamity. It is only the strong who can free themselves. O *brahmanas*! Those who practice *yoga* are bound in the bondage that results from *karma*. The weak are destroyed, but the strong free themselves. O *brahmanas*! A small fire is weak and can be pacified. It is said that the strength of *yoga* pacifies it even when it is fed with a large quantity of kindling. O *brahmanas*! Fanned by the wind, the fire may also become stronger and swiftly burn down everything on earth. A *yogi* who possesses *jnana* about the truth is extremely strong and blazes in his energy. He is like the sun which dries up everything in the universe at the time of universal destruction. O *brahmanas*! A weak man is borne away by the force of the current. Like that, a weak *yogi* is borne away by material objects. An elephant can withstand that same current. Having obtained the strength of *yoga*, material objects cannot make one deviate. Those who possess the strength of *yoga* subjugate everything through *yoga*. They become like Prajapati Manu, the lord of all the great elements. O *brahmanas*! Because of the great energy of *yoga*, they are not subjugated by anything—Yama, the angry Destroyer, or powerful and valiant Death. O supreme *brahmanas*! There are many thousands of *jivatmans*. Through the strength of *yoga*, one can enter all of them and wander around the earth. Having obtained material objects, one can again practice fierce austerities. O *brahmanas*! Like the

sun casts aside all qualities of energy, one can again fling them aside. O supreme sages! To obtain the best strength from *yoga*, one should unhesitatingly seek refuge with Vishnu. All strength is in him and he has the power to bestow emancipation. O supreme *brahmanas*! I have spoken about the strength of *yoga*. O *brahmanas*! As an example, let me again tell you about what is subtle. O *brahmanas*! One must fix one's *atman* in the act of *dharana*. O supreme among sages! Hear about the subtle examples. An archer who is not distracted controls himself and strikes the target. Like that, there is no doubt that a person who practices *yoga* properly attains *moksha*. A man whose mind is unwaveringly full of concentration can control his mind and ascend a flight of stairs with a vessel full of oil. In that way, if a person does not waver at all from *yoga*, his *atman* will be freed. If he frees himself from blemishes, he will see his *atman*, like the sun in a mirror. O Indras among *brahmanas*! The helmsman of a ship concentrates and swiftly conveys the ship across the great ocean. In that way, a person who knows about *yoga* uses *yoga* to control his *atman*. O *brahmanas*! When he gives up his body, he obtains a destination that is extremely difficult to attain. O *brahmanas*! A charioteer controls himself and uses well-trained horses to quickly convey a bull among archers to the desired destination. O *brahmanas*! In that way, a *yogi* immerses himself in *dharana*. Like a released arrow that strikes the target, he swiftly obtains the supreme objective. He unwaveringly uses his *jivatman* to enter the *paramatman* and remain there. This is like fish destroying a net and obtaining a destination that does not suffer from decay. An infinitely valiant *yogi* engaged in the great vow must concentrate in the following spots—the navel, the head, the stomach, the heart, the chest, the sides, the eyes, the ears and the nose. O supreme among *brahmanas*! In this way, he properly unites his *jivatman* with the subtle *paramatman*. Using this excellent *yoga* unwaveringly, he swiftly destroys what is known as *karma*, both auspicious and inauspicious. If he so desires, he is liberated.'

The sages asked, 'O excellent one! Through what kind of food does a *yogi* conquer and obtain strength? You should tell us about this.'

Vyasa replied, ‘O excellent *brahmanas*! If he eats barley for a long period of time and eats once a day, a *yogi* purifies his soul and obtains strength.²⁷⁶ For fortnights, months and many diverse seasons, he should roam around and dwell in caves. He should drink milk mixed with water. Thereby, a *yogi* obtains strength. O supreme among sages! Without a break, he should constantly fast for a month. In this way, a *yogi* purifies his soul properly and obtains strength. He must conquer desire, anger, cold, heat, rains, fear, sorrow, slumber, harshness, material objects and hatred.

O *brahmanas*! These are seen to be terrible and extremely difficult to conquer. O excellent sages! Touch, sleep and lethargy are also difficult to conquer. But when this is done, the great and subtle *paramatman* blazes in one’s *jivatman*. One is devoid of attachment and becomes immensely wise. Meditation and studying become the wealth. Even for learned *brahmanas*, this path is held to be difficult. O excellent sages! Just as only a few can pass through a terrible forest filled with snakes and reptiles, only a few can comfortably and quickly travel along this path. Without water and covered with thorns, the traveler finds it difficult to traverse. In general, it is dense with trees. In some places, the trees have been burnt down by forest fires. The path is infested with thieves and it is difficult to travel comfortably. In that way, only a few *brahmanas* can travel along the path of *yoga*. It is held that a person with many taints cannot travel along this path comfortably. O supreme *brahmanas*! It is as sharp as a razor’s edge. This *dharana* of *yoga* cannot be traversed by a person who has not cleansed his soul. O

brahmanas! A boat without a helmsman does not convey men to an auspicious destination. O *brahmanas*! Like that, *dharana* is difficult to follow. If one follows the principles and remains established in the *dharana* of *yoga*, one triumphs over death, birth and misery and is characterized by happiness. This has been described in many sacred texts and many sages have followed it. This path of *yoga* has been recommended for those who are *dvijas*. O Indras among sages! This is immersed in the *brahman* and has been approved by Brahma, Isha, Vishnu, the one who bestows boons, Bhava, the great-souled Dharma and Brahma’s great-souled sons.²⁷⁷

Progressively, the *yogi* passes through the hardship of *tamas*, the extremely

great *rajas*, the pure *sattva* and supreme Prakriti. He obtains *siddhis*, the goddess who is Varuna's wife, ²⁷⁸ all kinds of energy and extremely great fortitude. He obtains the status of the lord of the stars, ²⁷⁹ the sky that is sparkling in nature, the Vishvadevas, the gods, the *uragas*, the ancestors, all the mountains, the terrible oceans, all the rivers, trees, serpents, Sadhyas, large numbers of *yakshas*, the directions, the *gandharvas*, the *siddhas*, men and women. The *yogi* soon enters the great *atman* and is emancipated. O best of *brahmanas*! This account is auspicious and even the extremely energetic gods find it to be attractive. Through *yoga*, all mortals can swiftly experience Narayana.'

Chapter 1(132) (Principles of *samkhya*)

The sages said, ‘O Indra among *brahmanas*! You have properly described the practices along the path of *yoga*. This is revered by the virtuous and you have rightly described it to your disciples with a view by ensuring their welfare. Please tell us now about the practice of *dharma* along the path of *samkhya*. All the knowledge in the three worlds is known to you.’

Vyasa replied, ‘O sages! Listen. These principles of *samkhya* have been laid down by ancient mendicants who knew about the *atman*, Lord Kapila and others. O excellent sages! Some confusion can be seen along this path. But it has many qualities and no defects. O *brahmanas*! Through *jnana* about *samkhya*, men can conquer taints associated with material objects, which are so very difficult to conquer. O *brahmanas*! One can obtain and know about all the material objects possessed by *pishachas*, *uragas*, *gandharvas*, ancestors, those who roam around as inferior species, Suparna,²⁸⁰ the Maruts, the *maharshis*, the *rajarshis*, the *asuras*, the Vishvadevas, the *devarshis* and also the supreme objectives of *yoga*. One is enveloped by these objects and also those in Brahma’s dominion. People understand the truth about lifespans and the supreme nature of time. O excellent sages! They understand the duration of supreme bliss and the duration of the misery those addicted to material objects descend into. O *brahmanas*! They understand about downfall into inferior species and hell. O *brahmanas*! They also understand the qualities and taints associated with heaven. They understand about the qualities and taints associated with the Vedas, as practised by those who follow the Vedas. They understand the qualities and taints associated with the path of *jnana yoga*. O *brahmanas*! They also understand the qualities and taints associated with knowledge of *samkhya*. One understands the ten qualities of *sattva*, the nine qualities of *rajas*, the

eight qualities of *tamas*, the seven qualities of *buddhi* and the six qualities of the sky. ²⁸¹ One also understands the three qualities of the great *tamas*, the two qualities of *rajas* and the single quality of *sattva*. Following the path, one understands the truth about non-appearance and destruction. Possessing *jnana* and *vijnana*, one can use these as instruments to cleanse one's soul. One obtains the auspicious end of *moksha* and after that, the subtlety of the sky. Form is associated with the eye and the attribute of smell is associated with the nose. Sound is received through the ears and the attribute of taste through the tongue. Touch is associated with the skin and the wind is experienced through this. Confusion is associated with *tamas* and avarice is dependent on confusion. Vishnu is in the stride, Shakra in strength and Anala ²⁸² is associated with the stomach. The goddess ²⁸³ is associated with water and water depends on energy. Energy is associated with wind and wind depends on space. Space is associated with the earth and *tamas* is dependent on Mahat. *Rajas* is associated with *sattva* and *sattva* is associated with the *atman*. The *atman* is associated with the lord, the divinity Narayana. The divinity is associated with *moksha* and *moksha* is not associated with anything. One understands that *sattva guna* is surrounded by the sixteen physical qualities. ²⁸⁴ One understands that innate nature and cognition depend on the body. The *atman* is in the middle and no sin is associated with it. O Indras among *brahmanas*! For those desiring material pleasures, there is a second aspect to be known. All the senses and the objects of the senses are based on the *atman*. Through the former sacred texts, one should know that *moksha* is extremely difficult to obtain. One must also first understand about the power of the wind and the truth about *prana*, *apana*, *samana*, *vyana* and *udana*. Each of these is divided into seven flows and each of the seven is again divided into seven. O *brahmanas*! One should know about Prajapati, *rishis*, the many excellent creations, *saptarshis*, many *rajarshis* who were scorchers of enemies, *surarshis*, ²⁸⁵ Maruts, other *brahmarshis* who resembled the sun and those who witnessed prosperity over a long period of time. O *brahmanas*! One will hear about a great number of beings who came about their destruction. One will know the destination of auspicious words and those who should be

worshipped by evil-doers.

One will understand the hardships of those who descend into Vaitarani and Yama's world. One will understand about the inauspicious movements of diverse kinds of species. O *brahmanas*! One will understand about the inauspicious residence in the womb, feeding on blood and water, in a place that is full of phlegm, urine and excrement and has a foul stench; about the mixing of semen and blood and the origin of marrow and sinews; about the hundreds of veins in the city with the nine gates; ²⁸⁶ and for one's own welfare, one will understand about the various kinds of *yoga*. O excellent sages! One will understand the despicable *tamas* conduct of creatures and about beautiful ones with *sattva*, who nevertheless have falsehood in their *atmans*. There are great ones who know about the *atman* and *samkhya*, but nevertheless perform condemned acts. One understands evil portents and the moon's energy. One witnesses the progressive downfall of stars and *nakshatras*. O *brahmanas*! One understands the miserable separation of couples and witnesses the inauspicious act of beings feeding on one another. One understands the confusion of childhood and the inauspicious aspect of the body. Even among those who possess *sattva*, there are some who confront anger and confusion. Among thousands of men, only one turns his mind towards *moksha*. The former sacred texts of *vijnana* have said that *moksha* is extremely difficult to obtain. O *brahmanas*! One also understands the oppression due to material objects, how one attaches a lot of respect towards what has not been obtained, but is indifferent towards what has been obtained. One understands the auspicious end of beings who had shattered their bodies and given up their lives. O *brahmanas*! One understands the misery faced by those who possess *sattva*, since they have to reside in the families of beings. They tolerate this and wait for death. One understands the destinations obtained by those who kill *brahmanas* and the extremely terrible end faced by those who fall down. One understands the inauspicious ends of those who are addicted to drinking liquor, of evil-souled *brahmanas* and of those who are attached to the wives of their preceptors. O excellent *brahmanas*! One properly understands how men behave well towards their mothers and how they treat all beings like

divinities. Using this *jnana*, one understands the destinations obtained by those who perform inauspicious deeds. One understands the separate destinations obtained by those who become inferior species. One understands the wonderful arguments in the Vedas and the progression of the seasons. One witnesses the passing of years, months, seasons and days. One directly perceives the waxing and waning of the moon. One also witnesses the ebb and flow of tides in the oceans. One also witnesses the decline and increase in wealth. In particular, one witnesses the periods that join the *yuga*. One properly understands the truth about the incapacity brought on by the ego. One understands all of one's own taints, all of which are established within one's own self. One understands the inauspicious taints that arise out of one's own body.'

The sages asked, 'O one who knows about the *brahman*! What taints do you see in connection with portents? We have a doubt about this. You should completely explain this mystery to us.'

Vyasa replied, 'O excellent sages! Listen. Those who know about Kapila's path of *samkhya* speak about five taints that are seen in the bodies of all embodied creatures—desire, anger, fear, slumber and breathing as the fifth. Anger is severed through forgiveness, desire by abandoning all resolution, slumber by resorting to *sattva* and fear by not becoming distracted. O *brahmanas*! Defects in breathing are destroyed by being restrained in diet. One uses hundreds of good qualities to understand about good qualities and hundreds of taints to understand about taints. One uses hundreds of reasons to understand about reasons and hundreds of wonderful things to understand the truth about wonderful things. The world is like foam in water. It has been created through hundreds of kinds of Vishnu's *maya*. It resembles a painting and is as futile as substance inside a hollow reed. One sees that it is being whirled around in *tamas*. It resembles bubbles during the monsoon. Though it seems to be pleasant, it generally brings destruction. Transcending the destruction, there is great fear. Like an elephant that is incapacitated in mud, one is submerged in *rajas* and *tamas*. O *brahmanas*! Therefore, those who are immensely wise in *samkhya* cast aside all affection on account of offspring. O *brahmanas*! Using *samkhya*,

one comprehends the great *jnana* that pervades everything. O excellent ones! Using the weapon of *jnana* about the *atman* and the staff of austerities, one severs the inauspicious odours associated with *rajas* and *tamas*, the auspicious odours associated with *sattva* and touch and other things that are dependent on the body. Using wisdom, one crosses over the terrible water of miseries with great pools of thoughts and grief, extremely terrible ailments and death, giant serpents in the form of great fear, the turtles of *tamas* and the fish of *rajas*. O excellent *brahmanas*! Affection is like mud, old age is like rough ground, touch is like an island, *karma* is the depths and truth represents the banks on which learned ones who observe vows stand. Violence is the swift and forceful current, filled with many kinds of tastes, and the many kinds of pleasure are great jewels. However, there is the wind of grief and fever. There are giant eddies of grief and thirst. Fierce ailments are like a giant storm of dust. O excellent *brahmanas*! The joints in the bones are stairs that lead down to unite with phlegm. Donations resemble a store of pearls. The terrible flow of blood is like coral. Loud roars are heard in the form of laughter and screams. Many kinds of ignorance make this very difficult to cross. The dirt accumulating from drops of tears are the brine, resulting from union and attachment. When one takes birth in this world, one obtains sons and relatives as habitations. Non-violence and truth set the boundaries. Union with the breath of life constitutes the waves. For all beings, this is like an ocean of milk and excellent followers are the milk. This ocean of misery has a subterranean fire ²⁸⁷ and *moksha* is a destination that is extremely difficult to obtain. Using *jnana yoga*, accomplished and unblemished mendicants cross this. After crossing many difficult births, they enter the sparkling sky. On seeing them arrive there, the sun bears them along on its rays. O *brahmanas*! As they spread through that region, the rays enter them like the fibres in a lotus. Those unblemished ones are borne along and received by the wind. Those stores of austerities have overcome attachment and are successful, endowed with energy. O *brahmanas*! The wind is subtle, cool, fragrant and pleasant to the touch. O Indras among *brahmanas*! They proceed to the auspicious and supreme worlds of the seven Maruts. ²⁸⁸ They

are then borne along to a supreme destination in the sky. The sky bears them to a supreme destination in the world of *rajas*. O Indras among *brahmanas*! *Rajas* bears them to a supreme destination in the world of *sattva*. *Sattva*, pure in soul, bears them to the supreme and auspicious Narayana. The lord, pure in soul himself bears them to the *paramatman*. Having attained the *paramatman*, they lose their taints and are always unblemished. O *brahmanas*! They are fit to become immortal and do not return. O *brahmanas*! Shedding the opposite pairs of sentiments, those great-souled ones obtain the supreme destination. They are full of truth and uprightness and possess compassion towards all beings.'

The sages asked, 'They obtain the excellent spot of the illustrious one and are firm in their vows. Till their death and rebirth, do they amuse themselves there? What is the truth about that region? You should tell us accurately. O excellent one! With your exception, there is no other man who is worthy of being asked this question. It would be a great taint of *moksha* if others, *rishis* who are successful and supreme mendicants who possess *vijnana*, also go there. ²⁸⁹ O brahmana! We can see the supreme *dharma* that is characterized by *pravritti*. However, if a person is immersed in supreme *jnana*, does he have to undergo misery after that?'

Vyasa replied, 'O best among sages! You have stated your question properly and have asked about your doubt. O excellent sages! The learned are also confused about this question. Listen to my words about the supreme truth concerning this. This reflects the supreme intelligence of great-souled ones like Kapila. O *brahmanas*! The senses of an embodied being understand what is in its own body. There are organs of action and senses of perception. Through these, the *jivatman* understands what is subtle. ²⁹⁰ Without the *jivatman*, there is no doubt that wicked deeds bring about destruction, like waves being destroyed in the ocean. When the embodied being is asleep or eager, along with the senses, the subtle *jivatman* wanders around, like the wind that goes everywhere. O unblemished ones! It duly sees everything. It touches everything and remembers. O *brahmanas*! It understands everything that had happened earlier. The senses are no longer masters. Like snakes that have lost their

poison, they are properly restricted to their own respective spots. All the senses are in their respective spots. The subtle *jivatman* acknowledges their movements. However, when it moves around there is no doubt. O excellent ones! It comprehends all the *gunas*—*sattva guna*, *rajas guna* and *tamas guna*. O ones who know everything! It understands the attributes of the mind, the attributes of space, the attributes of the wind, the attributes that result from affection, the attributes of water and the attributes of the earth. O *brahmanas* O supreme *brahmanas*! It understands all the attributes in the *kshetra*. The *kshetrajna*, the *jivatman*, roams around amidst good and bad *karma*. O *brahmanas*! For the great-souled one, the senses are like disciples. They transcend Prakriti and reach the pure and subtle refuge, the great-souled Narayana, who has no transformation and is greater than the greatest. Freed of all sins, they enter him and no longer suffer from any decay. O excellent ones! The *paramatman* does not possess any *gunas*. O *brahmanas*! The senses and the mind approach the supreme one, like disciples approaching the *guru* at the right time for instructions. Within a short period of time, it is possible to obtain the traits of serenity. O Indras among *brahmanas*! In this way, using *samkhya* and *yoga*, those who desire *moksha* can obtain emancipation. O *brahmanas*! Using *samkhya*, immensely wise ones obtain the ultimate destination. O Indras among *brahmanas*! There is no knowledge which is equal to this *jnana*. You should have no doubt on this account. It is held that *samkhya* represents supreme *jnana*. Earlier, it has been stated that the eternal *brahman* is everlasting and without decay. It has no beginning, no middle and no end. It does not suffer from the opposite pairs of sentiments. It is the eternal doer. Those who are serene in their souls speak of it as the eternal and pre-eminent one. All acts of creation and destruction flow from there. In the sacred texts, the *maharshis* have praised it in this way. All *brahmanas*, Vedas and people who are conversant with the *Sama Veda* speak of him as the supreme one, the divinity Ananta, the supreme Achyuta, the one who is devoted to *brahmanas*. O *brahmanas*! Those who know about the *gunas* speak of him in this way and worship him. Those who follow *yoga* are supremely united with him and so are those who follow *samkhya*, infinite in their vision. O

Indras among *brahmanas*! He has no embodied form. The sacred texts say that *samkhya* is his embodied form. O excellent sages! He should be known through many signs. O excellent *brahmanas*! There are two kinds of beings on earth. They are known as mobile and immobile and the mobile ones are superior. O *brahmanas*! *Jnana* is greater than the greatest. O Indras among sages! Everything that has been instructed in the Vedas, *samkhya* and *yoga* and in the different Puranas has originated in *samkhya*. O great Indras among sages! Everything great that has been instructed in *itihasa*, the meanings of the sacred texts, all special instruction and all the *jnana* in the worlds has been spoken about in *samkhya*. O *brahmanas*! All that has been instructed about supreme strength and *jnana*, everything that has been said about *moksha* and subtle austerities, has been laid down in *samkhya*. Those who follow *samkhya* always overcome their hardships and always happily obtain what is beneficial. Bearing those principles in mind, they become successful in their objectives. When they fall down again, this is in the homes of *brahmanas*. When they cast aside their bodies, the followers of *samkhya* and *yoga* obtain *moksha* or become residents of heaven. O *brhmanas*!

Between the two, people are more interested in *samkhya*. It is extremely valuable and virtuous people on earth follow it. For them, no birth is seen as inferior species. Nor is there a downward movement and residence in regions meant for evil-doers. *Brahmanas* and sages who are not devoted to it never become the best. *Samkhya* is extensive, supreme, ancient and sparkling. It is like a large ocean that has no end. Great-souled sages who follow *samkhya* render everything to the immeasurable Narayana, the one who holds up everything. I have thus spoken about the supreme truth, about the ancient Narayana who is everywhere in the universe. At the time of creation, he is the one who creates. At the time of annihilation, he is again the one who destroys.'

Chapter 1(133) (Conversation between Vasishtha and Karala-Janaka)

The sages asked, ‘What is said to be *akshara*,²⁹¹ so that one does not return from it again? O great sage! We wish to ask you about the distinction between *akshara* and *kshara*. O best among sages! O bull among sages! We wish to understand the truth. You are spoken about as the best among those who possess knowledge. You are accomplished in the Vedas. You are best among immensely fortunate *rishis* and great-souled mendicants. O immensely wise one! We desire to hear the truth about everything. We are not satisfied at hearing about this supreme *amrita*.’

Vyasa replied, ‘In this connection, I will describe to you an ancient account, about a conversation between Vasishtha and Karala-Janaka.²⁹² Vasishtha, best among *rishis*, possessed a form like that of the sun. When he was seated, King Janaka asked him about the *jnana* that would bring supreme benefit. He asked him about the *paramatman*, about what would ensure benefit and about the destination and determination of *adhyatma*. When Maitra-Varuni²⁹³ was seated, he joined his hands in salutation and honoured him. In ancient times, King Karala-Janaka asked the supreme *rishi* in words that were well articulated, humble, sweet and devoid of arguments. Janaka said, “O illustrious one! I wish to hear about the supreme and eternal *brahman*, on obtaining whom learned ones do not return. What is that which is spoken of as *kshara*, into which the universe is itself destroyed? What it said to be *akshara*, auspicious, beneficial and without any taint?”’

Vasishtha said, ‘O lord of the earth! Listen to how this universe is destroyed, where it is destroyed initially and how long it takes. Know that twelve thousand years constitute a *mahayuga* and four such taken one

thousand times are said to make up a *kalpa*, one of Brahma's days.²⁹⁴ O king! Understand that Brahma's night is of the same duration. When he wakes up, he undertakes his infinite tasks of creation. Though he is without form, the universe is his embodied form. O excellent king! Svayambhu Shambhu is the foundation and origin and I will tell you about him. He is Ishana and he is resplendent and without decay. *Anima*, *laghima* and *prapti* are in him.²⁹⁵ The extremities of his hands and feet extend in all the directions. His eyes, head and mouths are everywhere. His ears are everywhere in the world and he is stationed enveloping everything. This illustrious Hiranyagarbha²⁹⁶ is said to be *buddhi*. In the texts of *yoga*, he is known as Mahat and Virinchi. He is addressed by many different names in the sacred texts of *samkhya*. He has many different forms and he is the *atman* of the universe. He is known as Ekakshara.²⁹⁷ All the three worlds are held up by him and he pervades them with his *atman*. He is also known as Bahurupa and Vishvarupa.²⁹⁸ Through transformations, he creates himself from his own *atman*. Pradhana is an extremely great city created from the union.²⁹⁹ The great energy of *ahamkara* is revered by Prajapati. The manifest³⁰⁰ is created from the unmanifest and this is said to be *vidya-sarga*.³⁰¹ Mahat and *ahamkara* represent *avidya-sarga*.³⁰² Mobile and immobile were also created from the single one. Those who have thought about and know the purport of the *shruti* and *smriti* texts, have said that *vidya* and *avidya* are known in this way.³⁰³ O king! Know that the elements are created from *ahamkara* as the third.³⁰⁴ O king! Know that the fourth creation resulting from *ahamkara*, is *vaikrita*. This consists of wind, light, space, water and earth and their attributes of sound, touch, form, taste and scent. There is no doubt that these ten categories were created simultaneously. O Indra among kings! Know that there is a fifth kind of creation, known as *bhoutika-sarga*. These are the ears, the skin, the eyes, the tongue, the nose as the fifth, speech, the two hands, the two feet, the anus and the genitals. These are the senses of knowledge and the organs of action. O king! They were created at the same time as the mind. It is the truth that these twenty four exist in all forms.³⁰⁵ A brahmana who knows and has seen the truth about this does not sorrow. The excellent three worlds

are produced in this way. O best among men! In this ocean which is like hell, this must always be known. O son! ³⁰⁶ In everything that is *kshara*, *yakshas*, demons, *gandharvas*, *kinnaras*, giant *uragas*, *charanas*, *pishachas*, *devarshis*, travelers in the night, ³⁰⁷ gnats, insects, mosquitoes, filthy worms, rats, dogs, *shvapakas*, *aineyas*, ³⁰⁸ *chandalas*, *pulkasas*, elephants, horses, mules, tigers, wolves, cattle and in everything that has form in the water, on earth and in the sky, it ³⁰⁹ exists. We have heard that everything that possesses a body dies on one or another day. However, the *atman* that is in beings is *akshara*. It is said that it is *akshara*, though the universe is *kshara*. The universe is full of confusion. It is manifest, but has originated from the unmanifest. The *akshara* is great and eternal and is always delinked from the *kshara*. O great king! I have told you what leads to no return. However, there is also a twenty fifth. This is eternal and goes by the name of *tattva*. The learned ones who know the truth call it *tattva* because it depends on *sattva*. ³¹⁰ Everything that is manifest and has form is based on the unmanifest which has no form. Those twenty four are manifest. However, the twenty fifth has no form. It exists in the heart of all beings and its form is established in one's own *atman*. Consciousness and lack of consciousness always exists in all bodies that have form. But it has no form. Following the *dharma* of creation and destruction, it creates and it destroys. It is *nirguna*. However, because it has the signs of the *gunas*, it can always be perceived. In this way, the great-souled and intelligent one ensures crores of creations and destructions, but does not think that it identifies with any of these. In the womb, it is united with *tamas*, *sattva* and *rajas*. Though it possesses an understanding, it resides with those who do not have intelligence. Therefore, it thinks, "I am not someone else." "I am this one." It follows the *gunas*. Having been enveloped by *tamas*, it has many kinds of sentiments that are *tamas* in nature. In that way, *rajas* and *sattva* lead to the sentiments of *rajas* and *sattva*. There are the three complexions of white, red and black. ³¹¹ Know that Prakriti gets associated with all these forms. *Tamas* conveys to hell and *rajas* to the status of humanity. With *sattva*, one enjoys happiness and goes to the world of the gods. If one indulges in wicked deeds beyond this world, one obtains birth as inferior species. With both

good and bad deeds, one becomes human. With only good deeds, one becomes a god. The learned ones say this about *moksha* and the unmanifest. This is the twenty-fifth and it functions on the basis of *jnana*.'

Chapter 1(134) (Conversation between Vasishtha and Karala-Janaka continued)

‘Vasishtha said, ‘Because it moves from a state of understanding to a state of lack of intelligence, it rushes from one physical body to thousands of bodies. This includes birth as inferior species. Sometimes, it obtains the status of a god because of the qualities of austerities and *yoga*. From the status of humanity, it goes to heaven. From heaven, it obtains the status of humanity. From humanity it sinks into a residence in hell. This is like an insect weaving a sheath around itself ³¹² using thread as strands. In that way, the qualities are always like threads woven around the *atman*. Though it should be beyond opposite sentiments, it is thus that creatures succumb to opposite sentiments. Because of this, headaches, eye-diseases, toothaches, throat problems, dropsy, hemorrhoids, diseases like enlargement of glands, cholera, white leprosy, leprosy, *agnidaha*, ³¹³ *sidhma*, ³¹⁴ epilepsy and many other kinds of opposites are naturally seen in bodies. It sees itself to be afflicted by these and other ailments and identifies with the bodies. Because of arrogance, a man performs many kinds of good deeds. He attires himself in a single garment or undertakes *chaturvas*. ³¹⁵ He always lies down on the ground. He lies down like a frog or seats himself in *virasana*. ³¹⁶ After *virasana*, he lies down under the sky. Or he lies down on bricks and stones or on round boulders and stones. He lies down on ashes or bare stones. Or he smears himself and lies down on the ground. He sleeps in places meant for heroes, in mud and on stakes. Searching for many kinds of fruits, he futilely uses these different kinds of beds. He lies down in gardens or threshing floors. Or he wears silk and the skin of black antelopes. He attires himself in hemp or hair, or is dressed in tiger-skin, lion-skin, woven silk, garments made out of leaves and garments made out of bark. He wears

those woven by insects and torn rags. Dressed in many other kinds of attire, he thinks himself to be intelligent. There are many kinds of food and many kinds of jewels. He sometimes eats once a day or on alternate nights. Alternatively, he eats at every fourth hour, sixth hour or eighth hour. Sometimes, he eats once every six days or eight days. He fasts for a month or eats only roots and fruits. He subsists on air or water, or only eats oilcakes, curds and cow dung. He drinks only cow's urine and eats flowers of the *kasha* tree. ³¹⁷ He eats moss or only subsists on other things. He subsists on leaves that have fallen down or a fruit that has fallen down. In a desire for obtaining success, he undergoes many other kinds of hardship. There are many types and many kinds of chandrayana. ³¹⁸ There are different kinds of *dharma* and *adharma* indicated for the *ashramas*. A person may follow this or something else. He may follow diverse heretical doctrines. He may reside in the desolate shadows of mountains, or near springs. He may resort to many kinds of forests or desolate banks of rivers. There are desolate groves and large caves in mountains. There are many kinds of rituals and diverse types of austerities. There are different kinds of sacrifices and diverse forms of knowledge. There are the paths of merchants and those of *brahmanas*, *kshatriyas*, *vaishyas* and *shudras*. There are many kinds of donations, indicated for the miserable, the blind and the helpless. Instigated by the different *gunas*, *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*, he thinks he is pursuing *dharma*, *artha* and *kama*. With these influencing his *atman*, he engages in all these virtuous tasks. He performs rites to the sounds of *svadha*, *vashat* and *svaha*. He officiates at sacrifices, teaches, gives donations, receives, performs sacrifices, studies and does many other things. For birth, death, disputes, causing death and everything connected with the good and the bad, it has been said that this is the eternal path. But it is the Goddess Prakriti who actually does everything. At the time of the fear of the great destruction, at the end of the day, ³¹⁹ all those qualities are withdrawn, like the sun withdrawing its net of rays at the time of setting. In this way, she ³²⁰ can be thought of as repeatedly sporting with everything. Depending on the *atman*, there are many kinds of qualities that bring pleasure to the heart. But this is the way the *dharma* of creation and

destruction works. There are rituals along the path of rituals. Those who are attached to the three qualities follow those three qualities. Driven by those, a person follows rituals along a path of rituals. He ³²¹ has a sense of ownership and it is that which binds him down. O lord! It is because of ignorance that he thinks that all these can be transcended through the path of rituals and refraining from them. Everything is blinded by Prakriti. In many ways, everything is pervaded by *rajas* and *tamas*. “I always suffer from the opposite pair of sentiments, but I will transcend them. They originate in me. At the time of destruction, they merge into me. Therefore, all of these must be transcended.” O lord of men! Since the intelligence is partial, the *atman* thinks in this way. “These objects of pleasure will be enjoyed by me. I will enjoy the fruits of good and bad deeds in the world and then go to the world of the gods. It is my task to ensure happiness and through these good deeds, happiness will be mine. I will obtain happiness till the end of this life and also ensure it when I am born and born again. But because of what I do, till the end of my life, I may also confront misery. There is great misery for humans and the prospect of submerging in hell. From hell, it will take a long period of time before I become human again. From humanity, I may obtain divinity. From divinity, I may again obtain humanity. From humanity, I may also progressively have to descend into hell.” Those who always think in this way are those whose *atmans* are covered by a sense of “mine” and they always circle around there. At the end of death, they have to go through millions of births. If a person acts in this way with a desire for good and bad fruits in mind, he obtains the fruit of having to assume a body in the three worlds. But it is actually Prakriti who performs the tasks, with good and bad fruits. Prakriti can go anywhere in the three worlds and enjoy the fruits. Inferior species, humanity and the world of the gods—all those three regions should be known as belonging to Prakriti. Prakriti has no signs. But she is said to possess signs in this world. In that way, Purusha is also thought of as possessing signs. Prakriti is without signs or taints, but she enters inside something ³²² that possesses signs. Therefore, instated in a body that has life, one thinks this is the work of the *atman*. The ear and the other senses and the five organs of action

become associated with the *gunas* and this brings attachment to the *gunas*. Because of the senses, the *atman* thinks, “I am the one who is acting.” Though it has no wounds, it takes itself to be wounded. It is without signs, but thinks it possesses signs. It is beyond time, but thinks itself to be subject to time. It is beyond truth, but thinks itself to be truth. It is immortal, but thinks itself to be mortal. It is without death, but thinks that it dies. It is motionless, but thinks itself to possess motion. It is without a field, ³²³ but thinks itself to possess a field. It is without attachment, but thinks that it possesses attachment. It is devoid of principles, but thinks that it is the principle. It is beyond creation, but thinks itself to be created. It is without decay, but the intelligence is such that it takes itself to be perishable. Though understanding exists, because of association with those who do not possess understanding, it goes through thousands of crores of births that lead to downfall. It goes through thousands of births, ending in death, as inferior species, as human, and in the world of the gods. Like the encasement of the moon, it waxes and wanes thousands of times. Though understanding exists, because of perverse intelligence, it destroys itself. It is read that the moon always has *kalas* ³²⁴. Fifteen of these seem to increase and decrease, but sixteen are always there. Only the ignorant think in this way, not the intelligent. O king! Like the moon, the sixteenth is always subtle and sustained. ³²⁵ It is not united with anything, not even the gods. Nor is it used up. O supreme among kings! If the sense of ‘mine’ is destroyed, it is born again. Since Prakriti possesses three *gunas*, it also has three *gunas*.’

Chapter 1(135) (Conversation between Vasishtha and Karala-Janaka continued)

Janaka said, ‘The relationship between *kshara* and *akshara* is desired. It is said that it is like the relationship between a woman and a man. Without a man, a woman can never conceive. Without a woman, a man can also not create a form. ³²⁶ They have a relationship with each other and depend on the qualities of each other. That is the way forms are created among all kinds of beings. For the sake of desire, they have intercourse with each other at the right season and resort to each other’s qualities. That is the way forms result. Let me tell you about these signs. There are qualities for a man and there are qualities for a mother. O brahmana! We know that bones, sinews and marrow come from the father. We have heard that skin, flesh and blood comes from the mother. O best among *brahmanas*! This is what has been read in the sacred texts of the Vedas. Since it has been laid down in the Vedas and one reads about it in the sacred texts, it can be taken as proof. The proofs of the Vedas and the sacred texts represent eternal proof. This is the eternal relationship between Prakriti and Purusha. O illustrious one! But nothing has been said about the *dharma* of *moksha*. Or are these signs to be determined thereafter? Please tell me the truth about this. You are always present in front of me. I desire emancipation. I desire that which grants freedom from ailments. It ³²⁷ cannot be vanquished. It is without decay. It is eternal and is beyond the senses. It is the ultimate lord.’

Vasishtha replied, ‘What you have said about the proofs of the Vedas and the sacred texts is indeed true and you have accepted the truth. O lord of men! O one who knows the truth! But though you have accepted both those types of books, the Vedas and the sacred texts, you must grasp the truth that is there in those books. If a person is eager to accept books like the Vedas

and the sacred texts, but does not know the truth about the purport of those books, then his acceptance is fruitless. A person who does not understand the purport of those books only bears a burden. If a person does not understand the truth about the purport of a book, then his study of that book is fruitless. If a person like me is asked about the purport of a book, he should explain what he has grasped by studying the truth carefully. If a person is gross in his intelligence and cannot explain the meaning of a book, then it is evident that his knowledge is limited and he cannot speak about its meaning. A man who does not know the truth in the texts should not explain them. If he does this out of greed or pride, he is a sinner and will descend into hell. There are gaps in his understanding of the texts and he does not expound the truth. A person who has not cleansed his soul does not know the purport or the truth. O Indra among kings! Therefore, listen to what has been instructed by the great-souled ones who know about *samkhya* and *yoga*. What is seen by those who practice *yoga* is exactly that which is followed by those who practice *samkhya*. A person who sees that *samkhya* and *yoga* are identical is intelligent. O son! ³²⁸ Skin, flesh, fat, bile, marrow and sinews—these belong to the senses and you have spoken to me about them. Objects result from objects and senses from the senses. Like seeds from seeds, bodies originate from bodies. The *atman* is beyond senses, without seed and without objects. How can that great-souled one, who possesses no *gunas*, give rise to *gunas*? Qualities result from qualities and are destroyed into them. These *gunas* are born from Prakriti and merge into it. Skin, flesh, blood, fat, bile, marrow, bones and sinews—know that these eight are created from the semen and Prakriti. Male and non-male—these three ³²⁹ genders are said to result from Prakriti. This is spoken of as Vayu, Puman and Rasa. ³³⁰ Prakriti has no gender. But her offspring obtain gender and form. For example, flowers and fruits have form, though they result from what is formless. It is inferred that gender is obtained in this way. O son! It is the twenty-fifth one who determines the gender of the *atman*. ³³¹ He is without beginning and without end. He is infinite. He is alone and witnesses everything. It is because of the pride of the *gunas* that he is said to possess *gunas*. How can there be *gunas* in something that is without

gunas? However, *gunas* must result from *gunas*. People who have insight about the *gunas* know this. When one identifies with Prakriti's *gunas*, one thinks that one possesses *gunas* and perceives differences in the *gunas*. A person who knows about all the schools of *samkhya* and *yoga* has the intelligence to speak about the supreme. Such immensely wise ones are intelligent and have abandoned ignorance. Those who are ignorant speak of a manifest Ishvara who possesses his own *gunas*. Ishvara is always established as someone who is devoid of *gunas*. Those who are accomplished in *samkhya* and *yoga* understand about the supreme. They know about a twenty fifth who is beyond Prakriti's qualities. Those who know about the unmanifest can overcome the fear of birth. Those who know go there, just as the intelligent ones do. ³³² O scorcher of enemies! These are the indications that have been properly instructed, though the paths of those who are intelligent and those who know are separate. They respectively speak about the signs of what is *kshara* and what is *akshara*. There is a single one who is *akshara* and everything else is said to be *kshara*. When a person has studied the twenty five attributes properly, he realizes that all kinds of *darshana* lead to the single one and many kinds of *darshana* are irrelevant. There is a truth that is over and above individual indications. In the twenty-five categories, the learned speak of this as the truth. The supreme truth is said to be what is beyond the twenty-five. There are categories and there is conduct according to the categories. While this is true, the eternal truth is above this and the categories and conduct should be discarded.'

Janaka said, 'O supreme among *brahmanas*! You have spoken about the characteristics of the many and the one. ³³³ But I still detect some doubt about the signs of the two. O unblemished one! This is comprehended by both those are knowledgeable and those who are ignorant. ³³⁴ However, because my intelligence is gross, I still have some doubt about the truth of this. You have spoken about the causes behind that which is *kshara* and that which is *akshara*. O unblemished one! However, because my intelligence is fickle, I have forgotten about all of that. That is the reason I wish to know how one can be seen in many. How does a knowledgeable or ignorant

person comprehend the truth about this? O illustrious one! Tell me, completely and separately, what *samkhya* and *yoga* say on knowledge and ignorance and on the *akshara* and the *kshara*.’

Vasishtha replied, ‘I will tell you what you have asked me about. O great king! Hear separately from me about the practice of *yoga*. For *yogis* who practice *yoga*, meditation is the supreme strength. Those who possess knowledge say that there are two kinds of meditation—concentration of the mind and *pranayama*. *Pranayama* possesses qualities, while concentration of the mind is without qualities.³³⁵ O lord of men! With the exception of two times, passing urine and releasing excrement, or eating, at all other times, the mind should be devoted to this. A sage uses his mind to withdraw from the senses and the objects of the senses and should engage in the twenty-two and the supreme twenty-four.³³⁶ The intelligent person uses these to direct the *jivatman* to the *paramatman*. Learned ones have said that this should not be practiced when one is standing or walking. It has been heard that the *paramatman* must always be known. It has been determined that this is for someone whose mind has been delinked from objects and not for others. He must be free from all attachments. He must be restrained in diet and conquer the senses. During the early and later part of the night, the mind must be fixed in the heart. O lord of Mithila! All the senses must be stilled by the mind. The mind must be stilled with intelligence. Having done this, one should be as motionless as stone. He must be as motionless as a pillar. Like a piece of wood, he must not move. When learned ones who know about the techniques are like this, they are said to be united in *yoga*. He does not hear. He does not inhale. He does not taste. He does not see anything. He does not know any touch and there is no resolution in his mind. He does not pay attention to anything or understand anything. He is like a piece of wood. The learned say that such a person is then united with *Prakriti*. One is seen to blaze like a lamp in a place where there is no wind. There are no other signs. Such a person ascends upwards and doesn’t descend into inferior species. Then he sees what is to be seen. Having seen, he does not speak. O son! People like us say that the heart of the knower and what is to be known, the *atman*, have become one. He is like a

smokeless fire with the seven flames.³³⁷ He is like the sun with its rays. He is like the fiery lightning in the sky. He sees the *paramatman* in his own self. Great-souled and persevering and learned *brahmanas* see it in this way. This is the *brahman*, who has no origin. This is immortality that exists in the *atman*. It is said that this is more subtle than what is most subtle and greater than what is greatest. Though it is inside all beings, it is certain that it cannot be seen. The creator of the world can be seen through the wealth of intelligence and the lamp of the mind. O son! It is the greatness that is beyond darkness. It is located beyond darkness. Those who know about the truth of the Vedas say that it is the dispeller of darkness. It is sparkling. It is the revered one. It is without attributes. It has the characteristic of being without traits. *Yogis* say that this is *yoga*. What other signs of *yoga* can there be? This is the way they see the supreme and undecaying one in their own *atmans*. I have thus told you the truth about the *darshana* of *yoga*.’

‘I will now tell you about the knowledge of *samkhya* and about its enumeration. Those who know about Prakriti say that the unmanifest Prakriti is the supreme. O supreme among kings! From this, the second entity, known as Mahat, is generated. We have heard that the third entity, *ahamkara*, results from Mahat. Those who have the insight of *samkhya* say that the five elements are created from *ahamkara*. These eight are Prakriti.³³⁸ There are sixteen transformations of these. In particular, there are the five senses and the five organs of action. Learned ones who know about *samkhya* say that this is the truth. They know about the ordinances of *samkhya* and are always established along the path of *samkhya*. Whatever is generated from the cause, is also destroyed within it. As they have been created from inside it, they are destroyed in reverse order. They are created in the proper order, but are destroyed in the reverse order.³³⁹ O supreme among kings! The qualities are always like waves in an ocean and are dissolved in the qualities. This is the way the creation and destruction of Prakriti also takes place. When there is destruction, the single one³⁴⁰ alone remains and many are subsequently created from it. O Indra among kings! This is what has been determined by those who have reflected on it and this is what should be known. It is evident that the presider³⁴¹ is not manifest. It

is both one and many and so is the case with Prakriti. There is a single one at the time of destruction and many at the time of creation. Prakriti generates from its womb and the *atman* makes it many. ³⁴² The great-souled one is established over the twenty-five that constitute the *kshetra*. ³⁴³ O Indra among kings! That is the reason the best among ascetics say that it ³⁴⁴ is the presider. We have heard that it is the presider and it presides over the field. ³⁴⁵ Because it knows the *kshetra*, the unmanifest one is known as *kshetrajna*. Since the unmanifest one lay down in earlier times, it is spoken of as Purusha. ³⁴⁶ Those that are known as *kshetra* and *kshetrajna* are distinct. While *kshetra* is also not manifest, it becomes discernible because of the twenty-fifth. Knowledge and the object of knowledge are said to be distinct. Knowledge is not manifest, but becomes known because of the twenty-fifth. The *kshetra* is not manifest and neither are the truth and Ishvara. The lack of Ishvara isn't the truth. Truth is known because of the twenty-fifth. These are the principles of *samkhya* philosophy and there is no enumeration beyond this. *Samkhya* only describes the action of Prakriti. The enumeration can be twenty-four or forty. One can enumerate one thousand such categories. However, the twenty-fifth is beyond all these. It is said that if a person has got to know the twenty-fifth, he is the one who knows. A person who knows this, realizes that it is the *atman* alone that exists. I have properly spoken to you about the true nature of *samkhya darshana*. A person who knows this, obtains tranquility. Prakriti is manifest to such a person as something that is directly seen. It is the one with qualities and there is also the entity without qualities. When they no longer exist separately for a person, he does not have to return again. A person who understands the relationship between these two unmanifest entities is no longer *kshara*. It is held that such a person's vision is perfect. But there are also those who do not see properly and do not see everything as one. O scorcher of enemies! They do not reach the unmanifest and have to return again and again. Such *brahmanas* have not understood everything about the infinite. They are born in manifest forms and are under the subjugation of the manifest. Everything that is manifest results from the unmanifest and the twenty-fifth. A person who knows this does not suffer from any fear.'

Chapter 1(136) (Conversation between Vasishtha and Karala-Janaka continued)

Vasishtha continued, ‘O supreme among kings! I have spoken to you about the *darshana* of *samkhya*. Now listen to me as I describe knowledge and ignorance to you progressively. The manifest, which is subject to the *dharma* of creation and destruction, is said to be ignorance. Twenty principles, subject to creation and destruction, are said to represent both *vidya* and *avidya*.³⁴⁷ Listen in due course to the relationship between them. This has been described as knowledge. O son! *Rishis* who have the insight of *samkhya* have laid this down. Among the senses and the organs of action, the senses are said to represent knowledge. Among the senses, it is said that intelligence represents knowledge. The learned ones have said that the mind is superior to the senses and represents knowledge. Compared to the mind, the five elements are said to represent knowledge. There is no doubt that *ahamkara* is superior to the five elements. O lord of men! Compared to *ahamkara*, intelligence represents knowledge. Compared to intelligence, the unmanifest Prakriti, expressive of the truth about the supreme lord, is knowledge. O best among men! Among the different kinds of knowledge that are to be known, the ordinances are said to be the supreme. The unmanifest and twenty-fifth is said to be the supreme form of knowledge. Among everything that can be known, this is said to be the supreme kind of knowledge. The twenty-fifth is the object of knowledge and knowledge about this is said to be unmanifest. A person who knows about the twenty-fifth knows about what is unmanifest. I have told you the difference between knowledge and ignorance. I will now tell you what has been said about the destructible and the indestructible. Listen. Both³⁴⁸ have been said to be perishable and imperishable. I will tell you the reasons that have been

cited in support of this on the basis of what is known. There is the view that both are imperishable and both are without a beginning and without an end. Therefore, both are supreme. Those who have thought about knowledge have said that both are truly nothing but principles. Though it leads to the principles of creation and destruction, the unmanifest ³⁴⁹ is said to be imperishable. It is through its qualities that it repeatedly creates. Mahat and the other qualities are respectively generated. It is said that the twenty-fifth presides over the *kshetra*. The unmanifest that is the twenty-fifth withdraws from the net of qualities and the qualities merge into it. The qualities merge into its quality and the single one that remains is Prakriti. *Kshetrajna* then merges into *kshetra*. ³⁵⁰ Prakriti, characterized by its qualities, then goes towards destruction. With the qualities withdrawn, we have heard that Prakriti becomes *nirguna*. In this way, *kshetrajna*'s knowledge of *kshetra* is also destroyed. Prakriti is then devoid of qualities like the *paramatman*. He ³⁵¹ realizes that just like himself, Prakriti is devoid of qualities. Discarding Prakriti, he then becomes pure. The intelligent one realizes himself to be distinct. ³⁵² O Indra among kings! When he gives up that combination, he exists separately and Prakriti is also seen to be distinct from that combination. When he no longer desires Prakriti and that net of *gunas*, he can behold the supreme. Having seen the supreme, he is free from all anxiety. "What have I done? I have been like a person overtaken by destiny. Because of my ignorance, I have been like a fish entangled in a net. Because of my delusion, I have moved from one body to another body. My conduct has been like that of an ignorant fish, moving from one body of water to another body of water and thinking in its ignorance that the water is everything. In that fashion, because of my ignorance, I have not known my own *atman*. Shame on my intelligence that I have been repeatedly submerged. Because of my confusion, I have followed the course from one body to another body. This ³⁵³ is alone my friend when I face destruction. I am capable of being united with it. I am just as it is. I see myself as equal to it. I am like it. It is without blemish. I can see that I am just like it. I have been ignorant and deluded. Because of ignorance and delusion, I have been properly entangled. Though without attachments, I have spent a long period

of time being attached. For a long period of time, I have been controlled by others, but did not realize it. There are different kinds of states, high, medium and low. ³⁵⁴ How can I be like that? How can I dwell with *maya* ³⁵⁵ as an equal? Because of my ignorance, I went to her earlier. I will steady myself now. I will not dwell with her and be deceived for a long period of time. I am without transformations. However, I have been deceived by the one who possesses transformations. ³⁵⁶ That is not her crime. It is my crime. It is because of my sentiments that I became attached and withdrew from what had presented itself. ³⁵⁷ That is the reason I assumed many forms and moved from one body to another body. Despite being one without a body, I have assumed the form of a body and have been assailed because of that sense of ownership. Prakriti has accordingly conveyed me into those wombs. I am without a form. Thanks to the sense of ownership, what acts have I performed in those forms? She is in those wombs and destroys sense and consciousness. I do not possess any sense of ownership. But goaded by *ahamkara*, I have been equated with her and have performed acts. She divided my *atman* into many parts and repeatedly engaged me. However, now my intelligence is such that I have no sense of ownership and no *ahamkara*. I have acted so as to discard the sense of ownership and have always removed a sense of *ahamkara* from myself. Having escaped from all that, I have resorted to what is beneficial. I will go to that tranquility and not be united with what is without consciousness. That kind of union is beneficial. I have no similarity with her.” He, thus, realizes the supreme relationship with the twenty-fifth. He abandons what is *kshara* and not beneficial and is conveyed to the *akshara*. This is unmanifest. But because of the nature of becoming manifest, one without *gunas* is vested with *gunas*. O one from Mithila! Having seen the original one who is *nirguna*, he becomes like it. I have spoken to you about the indications of what is *akshara* and *kshara*, according to the knowledge that I have obtained and according to what the sacred texts have instructed. I will now again tell you about what I have heard. Listen. This is knowledge that is sparkling, without any doubt, extremely pure and subtle. I have told you what the sacred texts of both *samkhya* and *yoga* instruct. This has been stated in the

sacred texts of *samkhya* and *darshana* of *yoga*. O lord of the forests! This knowledge of *samkhya* can awaken people and for the welfare of disciples, this has been clearly enunciated. Learned people say that those sacred texts are extensive. In texts of *yoga*, rebirth is placed at the forefront. O lord of men! Those who follow *samkhya* do not see the truth about a supreme twenty-fifth. What they regard as supreme has already been accurately described. ³⁵⁸ Those who cite indications from *yoga* speak about the truth of awakening, knowledge, that which is to be known and the one who knows.

Chapter 1(137) (Conversation between Vasishtha and Karala-Janaka concluded)

Vasishtha continued, ‘Hear about awakening and the unmanifest one, from whom the store of *gunas* is created. He sustains these *gunas* and creates and withdraws them. O lord of men! For the sake of sport, Aja³⁶⁰ divides his own self into many parts and collects them again. The one who can understand this action³⁶¹ does not understand. Because he is capable of understanding the one who is not manifest, he is spoken of as *budhyamana*.³⁶² Nevertheless, he cannot understand the one who is not manifest, whether it is with *gunas* or without *gunas*. Therefore, rare is the case when he is awakened. The learned texts have said that whenever *budhyamana* gets to know the unmanifest and twenty-fifth one, he becomes united with it. That is the reason the one who is not manifest is spoken of as ignorant.³⁶³ *Budhyamana* is spoken of as being both unmanifest and ignorant. Nothing with life can comprehend the great-souled and twenty-fifth. The twenty-sixth is sparkling, immeasurable and eternal and it can understand.³⁶⁴ It can always understand the twenty-fourth and the twenty-fifth. The immensely radiant one³⁶⁵ follows her nature, vis-à-vis both what is seen and is not seen. O son! Those who truly understand can not only see the twenty-fourth and the twenty-fifth, but also the unmanifest *brahman*. When a person knows the *atman*, he thinks himself to be it.³⁶⁶ He uses that insight to look at Prakriti and the unmanifest. With that pure and unsullied knowledge, he comprehends the supreme. O tiger among kings! He is then established in knowledge about the twenty-sixth. He then casts aside the unmanifest³⁶⁷, which is subject to the *dharma* of creation and destruction. Though because of consciousness, Prakriti is invested with *gunas*, he knows the one without *gunas*. Having seen the unmanifest, he is only full of *dharma*. Having

approached the whole, he is freed and obtains the *atman*. This is spoken of as the truth. It is beyond the truth. It is immortal and without decay. O king! By hearing about it, one gets to comprehend the truth. The learned ones talk about twenty-five principles. O son! A person who knows about the truth is not immersed in *samsara*. The swift freeing from principles is a sign of intelligence. A wise person knows himself to be the twenty-sixth. However, though awakened by the intelligent twenty-sixth, there is still ignorance. The sacred texts of *samkhya* have spoken about the signs of this. When one is united with consciousness and the twenty-fifth, ³⁶⁸ because of that consciousness, one does not comprehend the sense of unity. O lord of Mithila! O lord of men! Because of the rules of attachment, one is not awakened. However, when one is awakened and loses attachment, one realizes unity. Without any sense of attachment, a learned person approaches the twenty-sixth. Abandoning the unmanifest, ³⁶⁹ the lord obtains the understanding. With knowledge about the twenty-sixth awakened, he realizes that the twenty-four are valueless. O unblemished one! It is in this way that *budhyamana* gains understanding. As indicated in the sacred texts, I have spoken to you about the true nature of understanding. One must understand the difference between the gnat and the fig, ³⁷⁰ the fish and the water and this and that. ³⁷¹ That is the way a person must approach the one and the many. When one is full *jnana* and *vijnana*, this is said to be *moksha*. This twenty-fifth resides in bodies and when one has understanding about the unmanifest, this is said to be *moksha*. It has been determined that this is the only method for emancipation and there is no other. Because it ³⁷² dwells in the body, it conveys the impression of being different. By uniting with purity, one becomes pure. An intelligent person does not unite with what is impure. O bull among men! If a person's intelligence turns towards this *dharma*, he becomes free. By following the *dharma* of detachment, the *atman* becomes free. By uniting with the *dharma* of emancipation, one becomes emancipated. By striving for emancipation, one unites with emancipation. By performing pure deeds, one becomes pure and extremely intelligent. By uniting with the unblemished *atman*, one's own *atman* becomes unblemished. ³⁷³ By uniting

with the absolute, one obtains the absolute in one's *atman*. By uniting with the one who is free, one uses that freedom to obtain freedom. O great king! I have told you the truth. I have accurately described the exact truth to you. This is about the immortal, pure and original *brahman*. Accept the purport of this. O king! You can pass on this supreme knowledge to a person who does not follow the Vedas, as long as that person is free of malice. But he must seek this knowledge, which leads to an awakening. As long as he bows down and follows instructions, you can pass this on, for the sake of his awakening. However, it should not be passed on to a person who has falsehood in his soul, or is deceitful, impotent, or fraudulent in his intelligence. Nor must the knowledge be given to learned men who are jealous. It must be imparted to disciples. Listen to the ones to whom it can be given. A person who is faithful, possesses qualities, one who always abstains from censuring others, one who performs pure *yoga* for the sake of knowledge, a forgiving person who is full of compassion, one who can discriminate about good conduct, a person who loves the rituals, one who is extremely learned and does not engage in quarrels, a person who is humble in attire and one has no selfish motives—these are the people to whom it can be given. It is said that this pure and supreme knowledge of the *brahman* should not be given to those who are devoid of these qualities. Those who know about *dharma* have said that no benefits accrue from giving it to undeserving people. If a person does not observe the vows, it should not be given to him, even if one obtains the earth, full of riches, in exchange. O Indra among men! But there is no doubt that this supreme knowledge can be communicated to a person who has conquered his senses. O Karala! Having heard about the supreme *brahman* now, you should not have the slightest reason for fear. I have spoken about the pure and the supreme, the dispeller of sorrow, the one who is without a beginning, a middle and an end. This is fathomless and without birth and death. It is auspicious and frees from disease and fear. Having understood it, abandon all your delusion now. Know that this is the true nature of knowledge. O lord of men! In ancient times, I gratified the eternal Hiranyagarbha and obtained it from him. I made efforts to please the one who is fierce in his

energy. Having obtained knowledge about the supreme *brahman*, I have now passed it on to you. O Indra among men! Asked by you, I have now told you exactly what I learned. O Indra among men! This is what I obtained from Brahma. This is great knowledge, the ancient wisdom about *moksha*.’

Vyasa said, ‘O best among sages! I have told you what Vasishtha, the best among sages, said in ancient times. I have spoken to you about the twenty-fifth, the supreme *brahman* from whom, one does not return. If one does not comprehend this supreme and undecaying knowledge, one has to return again. But if one comprehends the truth, there is no decay and no death. O *brahmanas*! I heard about this supreme and beneficial knowledge from the *devarshi* ³⁷⁴ and have recounted it to you. O *dvijas*! The great-souled Vasishtha obtained it from Hiranyagarbha. Narada obtained it from Vasishtha, tiger among *rishis*. I got to know about the great and eternal from Narada. O best among sages! Do not grieve. You have heard about this supreme objective. A person who knows about the *kshara* and the *akshara* has no reason to fear. A person who does not know about it has reason to fear. Because of ignorance and foolishness in the soul, a person has to repeatedly return and assume bodies. After death, he is born thousands of times and dies again. He is sometimes in the world of the gods, but is also born as inferior species. If he is freed from that, he is immersed in an ocean of ignorance. That ocean of ignorance is terrible. It is said to be unmanifest and fathomless. O *brahmanas*! Day after day, beings are submerged in it. But you have crossed that eternal, unmanifest and fathomless ocean of ignorance. O *brahmanas*! Therefore, you have been freed from *rajas* and from *tamas*. O best among sages! I have, thus, described the supreme essence of all essences. I have spoken about supreme *moksha*. Knowing this, one does not return. This must never be given to those who are non-believers or those who are without faith. O *brahmanas*! It must not be given to those who are evil in intelligence or those who turn away from devotion.’

Chapter 1(138) (Praise of the Purana)

Lomasharshana said, ‘O *brahmanas*! In ancient times, the sage Vyasa recited the Purana in a melodious tone. His words were full of substance and were free of the eighteen defects. ³⁷⁵ The Purana had no blemishes and was pure and complete, containing the gist of many sacred texts. It was pure in character and adorned with *samkhya* and *yoga*. It stated *purvapaksha* ³⁷⁶ and arrived at a firm conclusion. As is proper, the immensely intelligent one made them hear it and stopped. The best among sages heard the first Purana, known as Brahma Purana. It was in conformity with the Vedas and yields all the fruits one wishes for. They became happy and extremely delighted. They were repeatedly astounded. They praised the sage, Krishna Dvaipayana Vyasa.’

The sages said, ‘O best among sages! This is wonderful. This Purana is in conformity with the *shruti* texts. It is supreme and bestows all the desired fruits. It destroys every kind of sin. It has colourful lines and syllables. You have recited it and we have heard. O lord! There is nothing in the three worlds not known to you. O immensely fortunate one! Like Brihaspati among the gods, you know everything. O immensely wise one! O one immersed in the *brahman*! O great sage! We bow down before you. You have expressed the meaning of the Vedas in Bharata. ³⁷⁷ O great sage! Who is capable of describing all your qualities? You have studied the four Vedas, the *Vedangas* and *vyakarana*. ³⁷⁸ Thereafter, you composed the sacred text of Bharata. You are full of knowledge. We bow down before you. O Vyasa! We bow down before you. O one who is extensive in intelligence! O one with eyes like the large petals of a blossoming lotus! Bharata is like a lamp full of oil, kindled by you for the sake of knowledge. There are those who

are blinded by ignorance, whirled around because of their perverse vision. Using the torch of knowledge, you have opened their eyes.’

Lomaharshana continued, ‘Having said this, they worshipped Vyasa and he honoured them back. Successful in their objective, they returned to where they had come from, their own hermitages. O best among sages! In that way, I have described the eternal Purana to you. It is extremely sacred and destroys every kind of sin. O supreme *brahmanas*! You asked me questions. Through Vyasa’s favours, I have answered all of them. This should be heard by householders, mendicants and *brahmacharis*. It bestows wealth and happiness on men and destroys every kind of sin. *Brahmanas* who are devoted to the *brahman* and other self-controlled *brahmanas* must hear it. All those who desire their own benefit must make great efforts to hear it properly. A brahmana will obtain learning, a *kshatriya* will be victorious in battle, a *vaishya* will get inexhaustible riches and a shudra will obtain happiness. If a man purifies himself and thinking about something he desires, listens to it, there is no doubt that the man will obtain whatever he wishes for. This is Vaishnava Purana and destroys every kind of sin. It is special among all sacred texts and accomplishes the objectives of human existence. I have recited the Purana which is in conformity with the Vedas. If one listens to it, heaps of sins and taints are destroyed. If a man listens to it, he obtains the fruits that are obtained by fasting in Prayaga, Pushkara, Kurukshetra and Arbuda. O *brahmanas*! If a person listens to this extremely sacred account even once, he obtains the fruits obtained by performing *agnihotra*, with excellent oblations for a year. A man obtains fruits by bathing in the waters of the Yamuna on *dvadashi* in the month of Proshthapada,³⁷⁹ or by seeing Hari in Mathura. O *brahmanas*! If a person focuses his mind on Keshava, concentrates and recites this Purana properly, those same fruits are obtained. If a man reads it or hears it, he obtains fruits that are the same as the fruits a man obtains by seeing Shri. This Purana is in conformity with the Vedas. If a person constantly reads it or hears it, after death, he goes to Hari’s abode. A brahmana who controls himself and always makes others hear it on *ekadashi* and *dvadashi* and on auspicious days, goes to Vishnu’s world. O *brahmanas*! This is blessed. It confers

fame, a long lifespan and happiness and extends deeds. It bestows strength and nourishment. It dispels nightmares. This is the best of accounts. If a person controls himself well and faithfully recites it at the time of the three *sandhyas*, he obtains everything that he desires. A diseased person is freed of disease. A person who has been bound is freed of his bonds. A person who is afraid loses his fear. A person suffering from a hardship is freed of the hardship. A person remembers his past lives and obtains learning. He obtains sons, intelligence, animals and fortitude. A man obtains *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*. If a man controls his mind and reads it, there is no doubt that he obtains everything that he wishes for. This bestows heaven and emancipation. If a man purifies himself and constantly listens to it with devotion in his mind, prostrating himself before Vishnu, the preceptor of the worlds and the bestower of boons, he obtains happiness. Cleansed of sins, he enjoys divine bliss in heaven. After that, he is freed from Prakriti's *gunas* and obtains an extremely sparkling destination with Hari. Therefore, excellent *brahmanas* who are devoted to their own *dharma* and desire to proceed along the path of liberation, controlled bulls among *kshatriyas* who always desire what is good for themselves, *vaishyas* who have been born in pure lineages and *shudras* who are devoted to *dharma* must always listen to this excellent account. It bestows many fruits—*dharma*, *artha* and *moksha*. O best among men! May your minds always turn towards *dharma*. In the world hereafter, that alone is the friend. Even if a person is accomplished, the power of *artha* and women have no stability. A man obtains a kingdom through *dharma*. It is through *dharma* that a man goes to heaven. A man obtains a long lifespan, deeds, austerities, *dharma* and *moksha* through the practice of *dharma*. *Dharma* is a mother and a father. In the world hereafter, *dharma* is a friend. *Dharma* is the saviour and bestows *moksha*. There is nothing other than *dharma*. This Purana is in conformity with the Vedas and is the greatest secret. It should not be revealed to those who are evil in intelligence, especially not to non-believers. I have recounted this supreme Purana. It destroys sin and extends *dharma*. O sages! You have heard this supreme secret. Now grant me permission to leave.'

This ends Part I of Brahma Purana.

Part II (Goutami Mahatmya)

Chapter 2(1): 33 shlokas
Chapter 2(2): 44 shlokas
Chapter 2(3): 36 shlokas
Chapter 2(4): 68 shlokas
Chapter 2(5): 88 shlokas
Chapter 2(6): 50 shlokas
Chapter 2(7): 40 shlokas
Chapter 2(8): 77 shlokas
Chapter 2(9): 22 shlokas
Chapter 2(10): 94 shlokas
Chapter 2(11): 22 shlokas
Chapter 2(12): 16 shlokas
Chapter 2(13): 30 shlokas
Chapter 2(14): 20 shlokas
Chapter 2(15): 24 shlokas
Chapter 2(16): 71 shlokas
Chapter 2(17): 26 shlokas
Chapter 2(18): 49 shlokas
Chapter 2(19): 47 shlokas
Chapter 2(20): 36 shlokas
Chapter 2(21): 13 shlokas
Chapter 2(22): 49 shlokas
Chapter 2(23): 28 shlokas
Chapter 2(24): 50 shlokas
Chapter 2(25): 32 shlokas
Chapter 2(26): 27 shlokas
Chapter 2(27): 33 shlokas
Chapter 2(28): 22 shlokas
Chapter 2(29): 12 shlokas
Chapter 2(30): 33 shlokas
Chapter 2(31): 20 shlokas

Chapter 2(32): 11 shlokas
Chapter 2(33): 12 shlokas
Chapter 2(34): 92 shlokas
Chapter 2(35): 31 shlokas
Chapter 2(36): 58 shlokas
Chapter 2(37): 88 shlokas
Chapter 2(38): 131 shlokas
Chapter 2(39): 58 shlokas
Chapter 2(40): 230 shlokas
Chapter 2(41): 86 shlokas
Chapter 2(42): 28 shlokas
Chapter 2(43): 23 shlokas
Chapter 2(44): 25 shlokas
Chapter 2(45): 20 shlokas
Chapter 2(46): 25 shlokas
Chapter 2(47): 20 shlokas
Chapter 2(48): 33 shlokas
Chapter 2(49): 20 shlokas
Chapter 2(50): 18 shlokas
Chapter 2(51): 26 shlokas
Chapter 2(52): 105 shlokas
Chapter 2(53): 217 shlokas
Chapter 2(54): 141 shlokas
Chapter 2(55): 56 shlokas
Chapter 2(56): 40 shlokas
Chapter 2(57): 64 shlokas
Chapter 2(58): 84 shlokas
Chapter 2(59): 127 shlokas
Chapter 2(60): 34 shlokas
Chapter 2(61): 58 shlokas
Chapter 2(62): 9 shlokas
Chapter 2(63): 27 shlokas
Chapter 2(64): 16 shlokas
Chapter 2(65): 27 shlokas
Chapter 2(66): 43 shlokas
Chapter 2(67): 41 shlokas
Chapter 2(68): 41 shlokas

Chapter 2(69): 20 shlokas
Chapter 2(70): 39 shlokas
Chapter 2(71): 30 shlokas
Chapter 2(72): 14 shlokas
Chapter 2(73): 17 shlokas
Chapter 2(74): 27 shlokas
Chapter 2(75): 14 shlokas
Chapter 2(76): 45 shlokas
Chapter 2(77): 23 shlokas
Chapter 2(78): 27 shlokas
Chapter 2(79): 19 shlokas
Chapter 2(80): 23 shlokas
Chapter 2(81): 29 shlokas
Chapter 2(82): 42 shlokas
Chapter 2(83): 16 shlokas
Chapter 2(84): 34 shlokas
Chapter 2(85): 14 shlokas
Chapter 2(86): 11 shlokas
Chapter 2(87): 31 shlokas
Chapter 2(88): 40 shlokas
Chapter 2(89): 49 shlokas
Chapter 2(90): 22 shlokas
Chapter 2(91): 78 shlokas
Chapter 2(92): 33 shlokas
Chapter 2(93): 53 shlokas
Chapter 2(94): 54 shlokas
Chapter 2(95): 48 shlokas
Chapter 2(96): 13 shlokas
Chapter 2(97): 33 shlokas
Chapter 2(98): 38 shlokas
Chapter 2(99): 49 shlokas
Chapter 2(100): 89 shlokas
Chapter 2(101): 48 shlokas
Chapter 2(102): 20 shlokas
Chapter 2(103): 39 shlokas
Chapter 2(104): 33 shlokas
Chapter 2(105): 90 shlokas

Total in Part II: 4,681 shlokas

Total in Brahma Purana: 13,818 shlokas

Chapter 2(1) (Description of *tirthas*)

The sages said, ‘Having heard in detail about the *tirthas*, we are not satisfied. Please tell us about the secret once again, in detail, about the greatness of the *tirthas* and about the *tirtha* that is best among them all.’

Brahma replied, ‘O best among *brahmanas*! Earlier, Narada asked me exactly the same question and I made great efforts to tell him.’

Narada said, ‘O origin of the universe! O lord of the universe! I have heard from you that visiting the *tirthas* is superior to austerities, sacrifices and donations. O lord of the gods! Which are the different *tirthas* and what fruits are obtained from visiting them? Which is always the best among all the *tirthas*?’

Brahma replied, ³⁸⁰ ‘O tigers among sages! There are four kinds of *tirthas*—those of gods, *asuras*, *rishis* and men. These are famous in the three worlds of heaven, earth and the nether regions and are visited by the gods. In every way, the *tirthas* of *rishis* are better than the *tirthas* of men. The *tirthas* of *asuras* bring greater benefits than the *tirthas* of *rishis*. O son! ³⁸¹ In every way, the *tirthas* of gods are better than the *tirthas* of *asuras*. Those created by Brahma, Vishnu and Mahesha are spoken of as the *tirthas* of the gods. No one knows of anything superior than those created by these three. In the three worlds, there are *tirthas* that are spoken of as belonging to mortals. ³⁸² Among these, those in Jambu-dvipa are said to be the best in qualities. Among the *tirthas* in Jambu-dvipa, the sacred texts state that the ones in Bharatavarsha are famous. Within Bharata, Dandakaranya ³⁸³ is the best among all *tirthas*. O son! It is spoken of as a *tirtha* that is a *karma bhumi*. ³⁸⁴ All the *tirthas* that I spoke to you about are there. I will briefly describe their names to you. Listen. Depending on whether they are for gods, *asuras* or humans, there are differences between them. There are six

rivers between the Himalayas and the Vindhya and they are divine in origin. O brahmana! There are also six rivers, divine in origin, between the Vindhya and the southern ocean. These twelve rivers are described as the most important. Since Bharata confers a great deal of merit, it is worshipped. The gods also speak of this *varsha* ³⁸⁵ as *karma bhumi*. The *tirthas* of *rishis* and the others ³⁸⁶ were created by the gods. Worshipping there, one obtains benefit, emancipation and prosperity. One obtains fruits for one's own self, or fame. O Narada! The *tirthas* created by men are known as human *tirthas*. O excellent sage! In this way, there are four different kinds of *tirthas*. No one knows about these differences. O Narada! Therefore, you should hear about this. There are many who are heard to speak of themselves as learned. However, which person, meritorious in deeds, will hear or speak about his own qualities?'

Narada said, 'I wish to hear the truth about their nature and differences. Hearing about this, one is eternally freed from all sins. O Brahma! In the first *krita yuga*, there is no method other than that of frequenting the *tirthas*. Through a little bit of effort, one obtains the desired objectives. O Dhatri! ³⁸⁷ As a speaker, there is no one who is your equal. As one who knows, there is no one who is your equal. You originated from the lotus in Vishnu's navel. You were the first to be born.'

Brahma replied, 'The six rivers to the south of the Vindhya are said to be Godavari, Bhimarathi, ³⁸⁸ Tungabhadra, Venika, ³⁸⁹ Tapi ³⁹⁰ and Payoshni. ³⁹¹ Bhagirathi, Narmada, Yamuna, Sarasvati, Vishoka and Vitasta have a refuge on the slopes of the Himalayas. These rivers are most sacred and are spoken of as the *tirthas* of the gods. The *tirthas* where Gaya, Kolasura, Vritra, Tripura, Andhaka, Hayamurdha, Lavana, Namuchi, Shringaka, Yama, Patalaketu, Madhu and Pushkara performed rites are known as auspicious *asura tirthas*. O Narada! *Tirthas* frequented by sages like Prabhasa, Bhargava, Agasti, Nara, Narayana, Vasishtha, Bharadvaja, Goutama, Kashyapa, Manu and others are *tirthas* of the *rishis*. The auspicious *tirthas* created by Ambarisha, Harishchandra, Nahusha, Rama, Kuru, Kanakhala, Bharata, Sagara, Ashvayupa, Nachiketa and Vrishakapi, scorcher of enemies are human *tirthas*. O Narada! They created them for

the fruits of fame and prosperity. Anywhere in the three worlds, wherever *tirthas* have originated of their own accord, those sacred *tirthas* are known as the *tirthas* of the gods. I have, thus, spoken about the differences between *tirthas*. Anything not dug up by anyone else is spoken of as something that has been dug up by the gods. O sage! I have briefly spoken to you about the differences between *tirthas*. Even if a man merely knows about them, he is freed from all sins.'

Chapter 2(2) (Preparations for Shambhu's marriage)

Narada asked, 'Among all the *tirthas* where the three gods ³⁹² exist, which one is the best? Please tell me in detail about the differences in its nature.'

Brahma replied, 'Sacrifices and other rites in the other *tirthas* give rise to good merits only as long as the three gods do not show themselves. ³⁹³ If one resorts to the Ganga, great fruits are obtained from vows, fasting and by undergoing various kinds of hardship. It is seen that those with bodies undertake hardships in all the *tirthas*. O sage! Those with bodies thus purify themselves, their objects, fathers, mothers and others. However, in the absence of the three gods, how can sins be destroyed? Ganga is the best among rivers and grants everything that one desires. Remembering, seeing or touching Ganga bestows everything that one asks for. O best among sages! The three gods exist there. Hear about her origin. Ten thousand years ago, a task of the gods presented itself. Because of the boons bestowed by me, Taraka became extremely insolent and strong. Using his strength, he took away the great prosperity of the gods. With Indra at the forefront, the gods went and sought refuge with the divinity Vishnu, the great grandfather ³⁹⁴ of the universe. He was lying down on the ocean of milk and the gods had no other refuges. Joining their hands in salutation, the gods spoke to him. The gods said, "O protector! You are the saviour of the universe. You extend the deeds of the gods. You are the lord of everything. You are the origin of the universe. The three ³⁹⁵ are your forms. We bow down to you. You are the creator of the worlds. You are the destroyer of *asuras*. You are the lord of the universe. You are the reason behind creation, preservation and destruction. You pervade the universe. For those with bodies other than you, there is no saviour in the three worlds. When they face calamities, who

else can they go to? O one with eyes like the petals of a lotus! Other than you, who can pacify the three kinds of calamity? ³⁹⁶ You are the mother and father of the entire universe. O divinity! Through serving you, you can easily be obtained. O lord! Be pleased and save us. We are suffering from great fear. Other than you, who can dispel our affliction? Please tell us. You are the original creator. You are the boar, the fish and the tortoise. ³⁹⁷ When fear arrives, you save us through such diverse forms. Large numbers of *asuras* have taken away our possessions. They have taken away our wives. They have taken away our abodes. O divinity! O Hari! Other than you, who will save us? Where will we seek refuge?” Lying down on Shesha, the illustrious one, Shri’s consort, spoke to them. “Forget your anxiety. Where has this fear surfaced from? Please tell me.” Therefore, they spoke to Shri’s consort about Taraka’s death. The gods said, “This terrible fear has arisen on account of Taraka and it makes the body hair stand up. We are incapable of destroying him through fighting, austerities or curses. He cannot come about his death except through a child who is not yet ten days old. ³⁹⁸ O divinity! Therefore, other than you, who can devise an appropriate method?” Narayana spoke to them again. “O gods! I am not someone who is excessively strong. His death cannot come about through me, my offspring, or the offspring of the gods. Ishvara will have an extremely strong son. Taraka, the one who scorches the worlds, will come by his death through him. O gods! Therefore, along with the mendicants and the *rishis*, let us go to him. The first task for Vishnu and the other lords is that one should make efforts so that he accepts a wife.” Thus addressed, the large number of gods went to the supreme mountain, Himalayas, full of jewels and to Mena, ³⁹⁹ loved by the Himalayas. All of them spoke to the snow-covered mountain and his wife. The gods said, “Dakshayani ⁴⁰⁰ is the mother of the worlds. She is Shakti, Shiva, Buddhi, Prajna, Dhriti, Medha, Lajja, Pushti and Sarasvati. ⁴⁰¹ Purifying the worlds, she is present in the world in many forms. To accomplish the task of the gods, she will enter your union. The mother of the universe will be born as your daughter and will become Shambhu’s wife. She will protect us and you.” Himalayas welcomed the words of the gods. Mena was also extremely enthusiastic and

approved of these words. Thus, Gouri, the mother of the universe, was born in the home of the Himalayas. She was always devoted to meditating on Shiva. She was his beloved and was devoted to him. The large number of gods told her, “For the sake of Isha, ⁴⁰² perform austerities.” At this, Gouri performed great austerities on the slopes of the Himalayas. The gods consulted among themselves again. “How can Isha meditate on her? We do not know what Bhava ⁴⁰³ meditates on. Does he meditate on the *atman* or on something else? How can the mind of the lord of the gods be focused on Menaka’s daughter? We should think about the best means of achieving this. That will be beneficial for us” At this, the immensely intelligent one, extensive in his wisdom, spoke. Brihaspati said, ‘The intelligent Madana Kandarpa ⁴⁰⁴ is the one who wields a bow made out of flowers. Let him pierce the serene Shiva with auspicious arrows that are made out of flowers. Pierced by him, the three-eyed Isha’s mind will turn towards her. There is no doubt that Hara will marry Girija ⁴⁰⁵ then. He will be vanquished by the one with the five arrows. ⁴⁰⁶ No one has been able to repulse his arrows. When the mother of the universe is married, Shambhu’s son will be born. When a son is born to the three-eyed one, the son will kill Taraka. Let Vasanta, ⁴⁰⁷ the one with the beautiful lips who has a storehouse of flowers, go as Kama’s aide. He delights everyone’s mind.’ The large number of gods, scorcher of enemies, were eager to defeat the *asuras*. They agreed and sent Madana and the storehouse of flowers to Shiva’s presence. Along with Madhava, Kama swiftly departed, wielding his bow. Kama went with Rati ⁴⁰⁸ to perform this extremely difficult task. He held his bow and arrows and stood in front of Ishvara. “The lord Shambhu is the preceptor of the worlds. He cannot be pierced. Will I pierce him? My arrows can vanquish the three worlds. But will they be firm in front of Shambhu?” The fire from his eyes reduced him completely to ashes. ⁴⁰⁹ The excellent gods had also gone to witness the firm act. When they arrived, hear about the astounding event that occurred. The large number of gods looked at Shambhu and Manmatha and seeing that Kama had been reduced to ashes, they were filled with fear. The gods joined their hands in salutation and praised Ishana, the lord of the gods. The gods said, “On account of Taraka, we are suffering from fear.

Please accept the daughter of the mountain as your wife.” With his mind pierced, Hari immediately agreed to the words the gods had spoken. For the sake of others, great-souled ones do not think about what is good or bad for them. For the sake of the alliance between the Himalayas and the protector of the worlds, the immortals sent Arundhati,⁴¹⁰ Vasishtha, me and the wielder of the *chakra*⁴¹¹ to make arrangements for the marriage.’

Chapter 2(3) (Brahma receives a water-pot)

Brahma said, ‘Himalayas, best among mountains, is decorated with many wonderful jewels. It is full of diverse trees and creepers and is frequented by many kinds of birds. It is covered with female rivers, male rivers, lakes, wells, ponds and other water bodies and is frequented by gods, *gandharvas*, *yakshas*, *siddhas* and *charanas*. An auspicious breeze blows there and is sufficient reason for a great deal of joy. It is surrounded by mountains like Meru, Mandara, Kailasa and Mainaka. Vasishtha, Agastya, Poulastya, Lomasha and other sages frequent it. The marriage was organized amidst great festivities. A lofty platform, adorned with gold and embellished with jewels was erected. Vishvakarma⁴¹² created a divine and agreeable pavilion. The pillars were encrusted with diamonds, rubies and lapis lazuli. The divinities Jaya, Lakshmi, Shubha, Kshanti, Kirti, Pushti and others surrounded it.⁴¹³ The mountains Meru, Mandara, Kailasa and Raivata adorned it. The powerful Vishnu, protector of the worlds, showed it his respect. The golden Mainaka, best among mountains, was resplendent. The *rishis*, the guardians of the worlds, the Adityas and the large number of Maruts fashioned the altar for the wedding of the wielder of the trident, the lord of the gods. Tvashta Vishvakarma himself constructed the platform, along with the gates. There were divine cows like Surabhi, Nandini, Nanda and Sunanda, who yielded every object of desire. As the wedding was about to take place, they too made the place beautiful and pleasant. The oceans, the rivers, the *nagas*, the *rishis*, the mothers of the worlds, the trees and all the seeds also arrived. Ila⁴¹⁴ performed the earth’s work. The herbs undertook the task of praising. Varuna took care of tasks connected with drinking and Kubera took care of tasks connected with donating. Agni did whatever the Himalayas and the protector of the worlds desired. The eternal

Vishnu undertook separate tasks of worship. The Vedas and their mysteries sang and spoke. All the *apsaras* danced and all the *gandharvas* and *kinnaras* sang. O supreme among sages! Mainaka held the parched grain. O Narada! The sacred words were spoken inside that house. The couple, supreme among the gods, sat on the platform. O son! Following the norms, the fire was ignited on the stone altar. Following the norms, the couple offered the parched grain and performed *pradakshina*. Having touched the stone on Vishnu's instructions, Shambhu touched the toe on the right foot of the goddess with his hand.'

'At that time, I was offering oblations near Hara. On seeing her toe, my mind turned perverse and my semen was ejaculated. In the three worlds, who is not distracted by Kama? I was ashamed because of this sin and the semen gathered in drops. The minute *valakhilyas* ⁴¹⁵ were born from the drops of my semen. The gods raised loud sounds of lamentation. Overcome by shame, I stood up from my seat and started to leave. O Narada! In silence, the large number of gods looked on. Seeing that I was leaving, Mahadeva spoke to Nandi. Shiva said, "Bring Brahma here. I will free him from his sin. Even if a person commits a sin, the mind of a virtuous person is compassionate towards him. Attracted to the material senses, even the learned are confounded." Saying this, out of compassion towards me and for the welfare of the worlds, along with Uma, the illustrious Hara started. O Narada! Hear attentively what the lord of the worlds did. "The earth and water will cleanse sinners of their sins. I will take out the purifying essence from all the waters." Having said this, the illustrious one extracted the essence from the water. Having placed a *kamandalu* ⁴¹⁶ on the ground, he placed the water inside it. He carefully recited the *pavamana sukta* and other *mantras*. ⁴¹⁷ He remembered Shakti, who purifies the three worlds and destroys sins. The lord of the worlds told me, "Accept this *kamandalu*. The goddesses who are mothers are in the water. The earth is another mother. For the sake of creation, preservation and destruction, both of them are located here. The eternal *dharma* of sacrifices is established here. Objects of pleasure and emancipation are here and so are all mobile and immobile objects. As soon as one remembers this, all sins of thought and speech are

destroyed. By using water to bathe, drink and consecrate, all physical sins are destroyed. In the worlds, there is nothing else that offers greater purification. O Brahma! I have sanctified this *kamandalu* with *mantras*. Accept it. If a person remembers the water that is inside it, or drinks it, he obtains all the objects of desire. Accept this *kamandalu*. Among the five elements, water is the greatest element. There is nothing that is superior to it. Accept this *kamandalu*. The water inside it is auspicious, sacred and purifying. O Brahma! If one touches it, remembers it or sees it, one is freed from sins.” Saying this, Mahadeva gave me the *kamandalu*. When the lord of the gods said this, all the large number of gods was delighted. There were loud roars of joy and shouts of “Victory”. At the time of the divine festivities, I saw the tip of the mother’s foot and a sin caused my downfall. However, out of compassion towards me, the father gave me the water of the Ganga in that sacred *kamandalu*. Even if one remembers the water, one is purified.’

Chapter 2(4) (Ganga enters Shiva's hair)

Narada said, 'The goddess in the *kamandalu* enhances what is sacred. O lord! Tell me in detail how she reached the earth.'

Brahma replied, 'There was a great *daitya* named Bali and this enemy of the gods could not be vanquished. There was no one in the three worlds who was his equal in *dharma*, fame, protecting the subjects, devotion to the *guru*, truth, valour, strength, renunciation and forgiveness. Witnessing his rise, the gods were filled with thoughts. The immortals spoke to each other. "How will we triumph over Bali?" As long as he ruled over the kingdom, the three worlds were bereft of thorns. There were no enemies. There were no physical or mental ailments. There was no drought or *adharma*. There were no non-believers or wicked people. As long as Bali ruled over the kingdom, such things were not seen, not even in dreams. The gods could find no peace. The arrows of his prosperity mangled them. The sword of his fame sliced them into two. The javelin of his commands pierced their limbs. Since envy was most important for them, they consulted among themselves. They were extremely anxious because his fame ignited a fire in their limbs. They went to Vishnu. The gods said, "O lord of the universe! O one who holds the conch shell, the *chakra* and the mace! We are afflicted. For our sake, you have always wielded weapons. O lord of the universe! When you are our lord, we have been reduced to such a state of misery. Our heads have bowed down before you. How can they bow down before a *daitya*? In our thoughts, deeds and words, we seek refuge with you. We seek refuge at your feet. How can we bow down before a *daitya*? We perform sacrifices to you. O Achyuta! In great sacrifices, our words are meant for you. You are the only one we seek refuge with. How can we bow down before a *daitya*? With Indra at the forefront, the gods have always sought refuge in your

valour. We have obtained our status because of you. How can we bow down before a *daitya*? Assuming the form of Brahma, you are the one who creates. Assuming the form of Vishnu, you are the one who preserves. In your power as Rudra, you are the one who destroys. How can we bow down before a *daitya*? In the world, everything is due to prosperity. Without prosperity, everything is futile. O lord of the gods! With our prosperity taken away, how can we bow down before a *daitya*? You are without a beginning. You are the creator of the universe. You are infinite. You are the preceptor of the universe. Facing destruction at the hands of an enemy, how can we bow down before a *daitya*? With your prosperity nourishing our limbs, we will use our energy to conquer the three worlds. O lord of the gods! We will then attain stability. How can we bow down before a *daitya*?” The destroyer of *daityas* heard the words spoken by the gods. To accomplish the task of the gods, he spoke to all the immortals. Vasudeva replied, “The *daitya* Bali is devoted to me. He cannot be vanquished by gods or *asuras*. Just as you are sustained by me, Bali is also nourished by me. The kingdom of heaven has been taken away from the gods. Without a conflict, I will take it back and return it to you. Using *mantras*, I will bind Bali down.” Thus addressed, the large number of gods went to heaven.

‘The illustrious lord of the gods entered Aditi’s womb. ⁴¹⁸ When he was born, there were festivities. O brahmana! The lord of sacrifices, the being who is the sacrifice, was born as a *vamana*. ⁴¹⁹ O brahmana! At this time, Bali, the best among those who were strong, summoned the best among *rishis* and consecrated himself for a horse sacrifice. His priest was Shukra, ⁴²⁰ knowledgeable about the Vedas and the *Vedangas*. Bali was the one who undertook this sacrifice. The best among *rishis* officiated at this sacrifice and Shukra was the chief priest. Gods, *gandharvas* and *pannagas* seated themselves to receive their shares of the oblations. There were separate sounds of—“Let it be given”, “Let it be enjoyed”, “Let the worship be undertaken”, “It has been filled” and “It has been completed”. While this was going on, he slowly approached the spot, chanting hymns from the *Sama Veda*. Wearing earrings and holding an umbrella, Vamana reached the sacrificial altar. Vamana praised the sacrifice. The divinity was in the form

of a brahmana. The destroyer of *daityas* was in the form of a dwarf. He is the one who bestows sacrifices and austerities. He is the one who slays *rakshasas*. Bhargava ⁴²¹ saw him and recognized who he actually was. He quickly spoke to the king, extensive in his energy. Bali, the best among those who were strong, was a victor, following the *dharma* of *kshatriyas*. He was generous, faithfully donating riches. Along with his wife, he had consecrated himself for the sacrifice. Meditating on the being who is the personified form of sacrifices, he was separately offering oblations. The extremely intelligent Shukra, tiger of the Bhrigu lineage, spoke to him. Shukra said, “In the form a brahmana, this dwarf has come to your sacrifice. O Bali! He is not really a brahmana. He is actually the lord of sacrifices, the creator of sacrifices. He is the being who is greater than the greatest. Having come here, he will ask you for something. O lord! Give it to him only after consulting with me.” Bali, scorcher of enemies, replied to Bhargava, the chief priest. Bali said, “I did not even imagine that the lord of sacrifices would come to my house. Since he has come here, if he asks me for something, what should I think of now?” Saying this to Shukra, the chief priest along with his wife went to the place where Vamana, Indra among *brahmanas* and Aditi’s son, was. He joined his hands in salutation and asked, “Why have you come? Please tell me.” Vamana replied, “Give me as much of land that can be covered in three of my steps. I wish to place my feet. I do not desire anything else.” There was a water-pot that was decorated with many kinds of jewels. While the best among *rishis* and Shukra, the chief priest looked on, he poured water from this and gave Vamana the required ground. While the best among the gods looked on, he gave Vamana the required ground. As the large number of *daityas* looked on, there were sounds of “Victory”. Vamana spoke gently. “O king! May you be fortunate. May you be happy. As you have promised, grant me the land that can be measured out in three of my strides.” As soon as he heard these words and as Vamana looked on, the lord of the *daityas* agreed and replied, “Please take it.” The lord of sacrifices used his valour to extend his form. As his size increased, the sun and the moon were between his breasts. The gods were near his head. This is what the divinity Ananta Achyuta, the

creator of the worlds who pervades the universe, did. The king of the *daityas* was full of humility. Along with his wife, he saw this and spoke. Bali said, “O Vishnu! O lord of the worlds! O one who pervades the universe! O lord of the gods! O one who has created the universe! Take your steps and vanquish me in every possible way.” At the same time, Shukra spoke these harsh words. ⁴²² “O Indra among kings! Thanks to my intelligence, I had warned you earlier. You have now been extinguished.” At the same time, Vishnu, who is the great sacrifice, spoke to him. Vishnu said, “O lord of the *daityas*! O mighty-armed one! O king of the *daityas*! Behold my strides.” Thus addressed, he repeatedly replied, “O Vishnu! Take your strides. Placing his feet on the back of the tortoise, ⁴²³ he placed one foot on Bali’s sacrifice. Hari said, “O lord of the *asuras*! Give me all the worlds for my second step. There is no place left for my third step. O Bali! Give me the ground for my third step.” With his wife, Bali joined his hands in salutation and smiled. Bali replied, “O lord of the gods! You have created the entire universe. I am not the creator. O one who pervades the universe! It is because of your fault that the area is limited. What can I possibly do? O Keshava! Nevertheless, I have never uttered a falsehood in the past and never will. Make my words come true. Place your foot on my back.” The illustrious one, who assumes the three forms ⁴²⁴ and is worshipped by the gods was pleased. “O fortunate one!

O king of the *daityas*! I am pleased at your devotion. Ask for a boon.” He replied, “O protector of the universe! O Trivikrama! ⁴²⁵ There is nothing I desire from you.” Pleased, Vishnu himself gave him what his mind wished for—the lordship of Rasatala, the future status of Indra, ⁴²⁶ lordship over his *atman* and a lot of fame that would transcend that of Hari’s. ⁴²⁷ Having granted all these boons to Bali, Hari placed Bali, the enemy of the immortals, in Rasatala along with his wife and sons. As was the case earlier, Shatakratu was given the kingdom of the gods. After this, worshipped by the gods, he returned to his own abode, where he had come from.

‘O immensely wise one! The region where my father, Vishnu, had placed his second foot became my home and abode. Seeing that, I thought, “I have received this position from Vishnu. What auspicious act shall I perform? I

looked at everything and saw that the *kamandalu* was the best. It had been given to me by Tripura's enemy ⁴²⁸ and its water was the best. It confers boons and serenity and is worshipped. It bestows supreme peace. It is auspicious and bestows what is auspicious. It always confers objects of pleasure and emancipation. It is like a mother of the worlds. It is pure medication and is *amrita*. It is sacred and purifies. It should be worshipped. It is the greatest and best and brings everything that is auspicious. When it is remembered, it purifies the worlds, not to speak of when it is seen. Using that pure water, I will offer an *arghya* to my father." I thought in this way. Taking that water, I offered *arghya*. Invoked with *mantras*, the water from the *arghya* fell on Vishnu's foot. That pure water descended on Meru and flowed on earth in four different streams—east, south, west and north. O sage! The water that descended towards the south was caught in Shankara's matted hair. The water that flowed towards the west was again received by the *kamandalu*. The water that descended towards the north was again received by Vishnu. The water that flowed towards the east bestows everything auspicious and is spoken of as the best. It was received by the *rishis*, the gods, the ancestors and the guardians of the worlds. The waters that flowed towards the south are the mothers of the worlds. For the sake of *brahmanas*, these mothers of the world flowed from Vishnu's foot. They remained in Maheshvara's matted hair and give rise to everything that is auspicious. By remembering their powers, one obtains everything that one desires.'

Chapter 2(5) Interaction between Vinayaka and Goutama

Narada said, ‘O god! I have heard how the goddess from the *kamandalu* entered Maheshvara’s matted hair. Please tell me how she came to earth.’

Brahma replied, ‘O immensely intelligent one! Because there were two people who brought them down, there were two divisions of the divine water in Maheshvara’s matted hair. One portion was brought by a brahmana who was devoted to vows, donations and meditation. Goutama, revered in the worlds, worshipped Shiva and brought it down. O immensely wise one! The other one was a powerful *kshatriya*. He worshipped the divinity Shankara through austerities and rituals. This was King Bhagiratha, who brought down the second portion. O supreme among sages! In this way, Ganga assumed two different flows.’

Narada asked, ‘Why did Goutama bring down the water that was in Maheshvara’s matted hair? Which *kshatriya* brought it down? Please tell me.’

Brahma replied, ‘O son! For the sake of your pleasures, I will tell you all the details about how one part was brought down by a brahmana and how the second was brought down by another person. O immensely radiant one! At the time when Uma became the beloved wife of the lord of the gods, Ganga also became Shambhu’s beloved. At that time, Shiva was thinking about a method for dispelling my taint. Though he was with Uma, the prosperous one glanced towards the goddess.⁴²⁹ Immersed in creating an excellent juice for me, he was focused on her juice too. He loved her beloved juice, feminine and purifying in nature. O supreme among *brahmanas*! In particular, he loved Ganga the most. He placed Ganga on his head. Since Uma knew about it, Maheshvara was always full of thoughts.

Despite being hidden in his matted hair, there some other reason for Ganga coming out. However, Shambhu hid Ganga in his matted hair. Knowing that she was hidden in his head, Uma was unable to tolerate this. She could not tolerate the idea of Ganga repeatedly emerging from the matted hair. Full of intolerance, Gouri spoke to her lord, Bhava. ⁴³⁰ “O Shambhu! O one who loves juices! She has excellent juices, but she should not reside here. Please send her away.” Miserable, Uma addressed her lord in these words.

However, she also thought about the goddess being hidden in matted hair. Therefore, in private, she addressed Vinayaka, Jaya and Skanda in these words. ⁴³¹ “Ishana, the lord of the gods, desires her and will never let Ganga go. She is loved by Shiva. How will he cast away his beloved?” Thinking about this in many ways, Gouri spoke to Vinayaka. Parvati said, “Even if gods, *asuras*, *yakshas*, *siddhas*, kings, you, and others try, the lord will not give up Ganga. I will go to the Himalayas, supreme among mountains, and perform austerities. Or, I will leave it to sacred *brahmanas* who can cleanse sins through their austerities. Perhaps they can pray and bring down Ganga from the matted hair.” Thus addressed by his mother, Vighnaraja ⁴³² replied to his mother. “We should consult my brother, Skanda and Jaya. We will act so that my father casts Ganga away from his head.’ O brahmana!

At this time, there was a drought that lasted for twelve years. It caused great fear to beings in the mortal world. Everything mobile and immobile in the world was destroyed. The only exception was Goutama’s sacred hermitage, which yielded every object of desire. O son! Earlier, I desired to create mobile and immobile objects. Therefore earlier, I had performed a sacrifice on Mount Devayajana. Since then, because of my name, that mountain has always been famous as Brahmagiri. ⁴³³ Goutama has always resorted to that excellent mountain. His extremely sacred hermitage was on the auspicious and excellent Brahmagiri. There were no physical or mental ailments there. There was no famine or drought. Fear, sorrow and poverty have never been heard of there. Other than his hermitage, there was no *havya* or *kavya*. O son! There was no one to donate, offer oblations or perform sacrifices. The gods in heaven were honoured only when the brahmana Goutama gave and offered oblations, not otherwise. In the world of the mortals and in the

world of the gods, the sage Goutama was heard of. Learned people knew that he alone was the giver and enjoyer. There were sages who resided in many hermitages. Hearing about Goutama's hermitage, they asked where it was. Those stores of austerities went there. When all these sages arrived, Goutama faithfully nurtured them like a father, as if they were his disciples or sons. The sage served them in accordance with what was appropriate for each in due order of worth, and gave them everything that they wished for. On Goutama's command, the herbs became the mothers of the world and Brahma, Vishnu and Maheshvara were worshipped again. When the herbs were generated, they were used to enjoy. Through the strength of Goutama's austerities, it could be resolved that they should be sown. Everyone became prosperous and every mental desire was accomplished. Every day, Goutama humbly addressed the sages who had arrived like sons or disciples and asked, "What can I do for you?" For many years, he nurtured them like a father. O son! In this way, Goutama attained great fame.

'After this, Vinayaka spoke to his mother, brother and Jaya. Vinayaka said, "O mother! In the abode of the gods, the brahmana Goutama is chanted about. 'Goutama has made efforts to ensure that the tasks of the large number of gods is accomplished.' O goddess! I have heard this about the strength of the brahmana's austerities. O mother! This brahmana may be able to dislodge Ganga from the matted hair. Through austerities or other means, he can worship the three-eyed one. He can then ask for my father's beloved, who is in the matted hair. We should determine a proper method so that the brahmana asks for her. Through his powers, the best among rivers will descend from the hair." Having told his mother this, Vighnaraja, along with his brother and Jaya, went to the spot where Goutama was. The brahmana was lean and wore a sacred thread. They resided for a few days in the circle that was around Goutama's hermitage. Then Vighnaraja spoke to all the *brahmanas*. "We should not remain here. We should return to our own abodes and our own pure hermitages. We have been nourished by Goutama's food. Let us go and ask the sage Goutama." Those excellent sages consulted amongst themselves and went and took their leave from the

sage. With his mind full of affection, he separately tried to restrain the sages. Goutama said, “I am humbly joining my hands in salutation and asking you to remain here. O bulls among sages! I will serve at your feet. I will always serve you, as one does towards a son. You should stay here. You are like gods on earth and it is not proper that you should go and stay in some other hermitage. It is my view that this hermitage is sacred in every possible way. O sages! Enough of this. Please do not go to any other hermitage.” Hearing the words of the sage, Ganadhipa ⁴³⁴ remembered his duty of creating impediments. He joined his hands in salutation and spoke to the *brahmanas*. Ganadhipa said, “Simply because he has bought us over with food, how can Goutama restrain us? Using words of conciliation, we have not been allowed to go to our own respective abodes. The supreme among *brahmanas* has done us a good turn and does not deserve to be punished. ⁴³⁵ Therefore, I will use my intelligence to devise a means and all of you should approve of this.” At this, all the best among *brahmanas* replied, “So as to do him a good turn and for the welfare of the worlds, act. Do what is best for all the *brahmanas*.” Hearing the words of the *brahmanas*, Ganadhipa approved and addressed them in the following words. Vinayaka said, “I will do that which ensures special benefit to Goutama.” Pervasive in his intelligence, he repeatedly entreated the *brahmanas*. Assuming the form of a brahmana, he repeatedly prostrated himself before the *brahmanas*.’

‘Knowing what was in his mother’s mind, Ganeshvara ⁴³⁶ spoke to Jaya. Vinayaka said, “O auspicious one! O one with the beautiful face! Act so that no one else gets to know. Assume the form of a cow and go to the place where Goutama is. O beautiful one! Eat the *shali* rice ⁴³⁷ and act perversely, as if you are destroying it. If you are beaten, or if anyone pronounces *humkara* ⁴³⁸ and glances towards you, scream loudly. Remain as if you are struggling between life and death.” Following what was in Vighneshvara’s ⁴³⁹ mind, Vijaya did exactly this. Jaya assumed the form of a cow and went to the spot where Goutama was. She went and started to eat the *shali* paddy. Goutama saw her. On seeing that the cow was destroying the paddy, the brahmana tried to restrain her with a blade of grass. As soon as he tried to

restrain her, she screamed loudly and fell down on the ground. When she fell down, there were loud sounds of lamentation. Hearing the scream, the distressed *brahmanas* saw what Goutama had done. With Vighnaraja at the forefront, they spoke to him. The *brahmanas* said, “All of us will leave this place. We will not remain in your hermitage. O bull among sages! You have nurtured all of us like sons, but we will take your leave now.” Hearing the words of the *brahmanas* that they were about to leave, it was as if the sage had been struck by the *vajra*. He prostrated himself before the *brahmanas*. All the *brahmanas* spoke to him, “Look at her, fallen down on the ground. She is the mother of the Rudras. She is the beloved goddess who purifies the world. All the *tirthas* and all the gods are in her nature. Through the force of destiny, this cow has fallen down. O best among sages! We should not remain here, but should go elsewhere. If we reside in this hermitage, the fruits of our vows will be diminished and destroyed. O brahmana! We do not possess any other riches. We are rich only because of our austerities.” Standing in front of the *brahmanas*, Goutama replied humbly. Goutama said, “You are my refuge. You should remain here and purify me.” Surrounded by the *brahmanas*, the illustrious Vighnaraja answered. Vighnaraja said, “This is neither dead, nor alive. Therefore, we are unsure about what we should state as a proper rite of atonement.” Goutama replied, “The cow is not just senseless, there is no doubt that she will die. You should tell me about how she can be made to rise up again and about my atonement. There is no doubt that I will act accordingly.” The *brahmanas* responded, “This intelligent one will express our collective view. O Goutama! His words are indicative of all our views.” Urged by the *brahmanas* and also strongly urged by Goutama, the creator of impediments, in the guise of a brahmana, addressed them in the following words. Vighnaraja said, “I will accurately state everyone’s views. Let the sages and Goutama follow my words. We have heard that the water from the *kamandalu* of Brahma, whose birth is not manifest, is located in Maheshvara’s matted hair. Following austerities and rituals, quickly bring it. O illustrious one! Sprinkle the cow that is lying down on the ground with it. After that, all of us will reside in your house, as used to be the case

earlier.” In the assembly of *brahmanas*, the Indra among *brahmanas* addressed him in this way. Sounds of “victory” were uttered and flowers were showered down. Joining his hands in salutation and bowing down, Goutama spoke these words. Goutama said, “Through austerities, through Agni’s favours, through the favours of the divinity Brahma and through your favours, may my resolution meet with success.” Agreeing with this, the *brahmanas* took their leave of the bull among sages and returned to their own respective regions, nourished with food and water.’

‘When the *brahmanas* departed, along with his brother and Jaya, Ganeshvara returned, extremely happy that he had accomplished his objective. When the group of *brahmanas* and Ganesha had left, Goutama, the best among sages performed austerities to cleanse himself of his sin. The sage meditated about the meaning of this. “Why have I been reduced to this state?” Thinking about it in many ways, the brahmana used his *jnana* to understand. He made up his mind that he had been tainted by this sin to accomplish some purpose of the gods. “This will bring welfare to the worlds and please Shambhu. Through bringing Ganga, Uma will be pleased. I think it will be best for everyone. Therefore, I have not been tainted by sin.” Thinking this in his mind, the best among *brahmanas* was extremely delighted. The excellent brahmana consulted his wife and said, “I will worship the three-eyed Vrishadhvaja, the lord of the universe. I will bring the best among rivers and please the daughter of the mountain. The co-wife of the mother of the universe is in Maheshvara’s matted hair.” Having made up his mind, Goutama, the excellent sage, went to Brahmagiri. He wished to please Shambhu, who is fierce in his energy, who resides in Kailasa and is worshipped by the gods.’

Chapter 2(6) (Bringing of Goutami)

Narada said, ‘Having gone to the summit of Kailasa, what did the illustrious *rishi* Goutama do? What austerities did he perform? What excellent praise did he use?’

Brahma replied, ‘O child! Having gone to the mountain, Goutama controlled his speech. The wise one spread *kusha* grass on the excellent mountain of Kailasa. Purifying himself, he sat down on it and chanted hymns. As he praised Maheshvara, flowers were showered down. Goutama said, “To bestow objects of pleasure on those who desire objects of pleasure, along with Uma, he assumes eight great forms. ⁴⁴⁰ People always praise the god Mahadeva’s qualities. He is the lord of all mobile and immobile objects and himself brings bliss in his dominions. For the sake of prosperity and its increase, Ishvara assumes the form of the earth. For the sake of creating, preserving and destroying the earth and upholding it, he assumes his own form of water. For the happiness of people and for the sake of establishing dharma in the universe, he assumes the tranquil body of Shiva. For the sake of creating, preserving and destroying beings, he is established as Kala and exudes *amrita*. He brings joy, happiness and upliftment to subjects and assumes a body that has fire, the sun and the moon. For enhancement, progress, undecaying strength, the conduct of subsistence and the manifold joy of beings, Isha assumes the form of Vayu. O illustrious one! You are indeed this. *Dharma* will not exist without differences. Nor will the directions and the firmament exist. Heaven, earth and the space between them will not exist. There will be no objects of pleasure or emancipation. O Isha! Therefore, you assume the form of space. For the sake of establishing *dharma*, you divide the branches of *Rig Veda*, *Sama Veda*, *Yajur Veda* and the sacred texts. In this world, there also exist

the tales, *smriti* texts, Puranas and others that are articulated through words. There are *yajnas*, *kratus* ⁴⁴¹ and other means. Depending on the fruits, the time and the place, the officiating priest is your own form. You are Shambhu, the supreme objective. You are spoken of as the one whose body has all the limbs of the sacrifice. You are the doer. You are the giver. You are the representation. You are the donation. You are the omniscient witness. You are the Supreme Being. You are the realization of the *atman*. Your form is the supreme objective. You are everything. What purpose do these words serve? The Vedas, the sacred texts and *gurus* have not instructed about you. You cannot be perceived through intelligence and other means. You are without origin. You are beyond measurement. O illustrious one! You are the truth, articulated in the words “Shiva”. I bow down before you. O Shiva! Your nature is one and can sometimes be visualized as “My *atman*.” ⁴⁴² Sometimes, you are perceived as different. You are many and your power is unthinkable. The universe is your form. Because of her sentiments, she ⁴⁴³ is pervasive in Bhava. She is the cause. But because of her own reasons, she is established in Bhava. Shivaa is eternal. She possesses all the signs. She is without signs. She is the Shakti that creates the universe. Generation, preservation and the increase and destruction of food—these are always necessary for offspring. She is the entire earth. What is impossible for Hara’s beloved? For the sake of food and wealth, beings offer sacrifices to her and perform austerities of *dharma*. She is the mother of the universe. His beloved is the one who gives birth. Soma’s great deeds are her manifestation. Vasava desires her glances and through those, we obtain everything that is auspicious. She pervades the universe and makes it pure. She is Somaa, her form is always like that of Soma. It is through her favours that intelligence, sight, consciousness and mental pleasures of Brahma and others, mobile and immobile, always yield fruits. She is the Ishvari of speech. She is the extremely beautiful preceptor of the worlds. “The mind of the one with the four faces ⁴⁴⁴ has been defiled. What can be said of other beings?” Thinking this, she should devise many means for Ganga’s descent and purify the entire world. Considering the *shruti* texts and all their proofs, people in the universe accepted Hara’s

lordship. They performed acts of *dharma* and enjoyed objects of pleasure. This is always due to Shiva's powers. He is the original agent behind tasks, rites, instruments and agents mentioned in the Vedas and popular practice. He is the best means and is spoken of as the beloved. He is the one who ensures success. For meditations, he is the supreme one. He is the supreme *brahman*. He is the foremost being. He is the unmanifest one whose essence is worshipped. Having obtained him, *yogis* are instantly emancipated and do not have to return again. Uma's consort is emancipation. O mother! For the welfare of the universe, whenever Shambhu assumes an immeasurable form full of *maya*, devoted to your husband, you also assume a corresponding form.' 'As he praised in this way, along with Uma, Vrishadhvaja appeared in front of him. The prosperous one was surrounded by Ganesha and the other *ganas*.'

'Shambhu himself appeared before him, pleased, and addressed him in these words. Shiva said, "O Goutama! I am pleased with your auspicious devotion, hymns and vows. What will I give you? Ask for something that is difficult for even the gods to obtain." Hearing the words of the one whose manifestation was the universe, Goutama, accomplished in speech, was filled with tears of delight that flowed over his limbs. He thought, "This is the divinity. How wonderful is *dharma*. How wonderful is the worship of a brahmana. How wonderful is the progress of the worlds. How wonderful is the creator. I bow down to you." Goutama said, "O lord of the gods! O one who is the refuge of the three! ⁴⁴⁵ O one who is worshipped by the gods! If you are pleased with me, grant me auspicious Ganga, who is in your matted hair." Ishvara replied, "For the welfare of the three worlds, you have asked for her. Speak without any fear. Ask for something for yourself." Goutama said, "I praised you and the goddess with a *stotram*. If people praise you devotedly using this, let them prosper with everything that they desire. This is the boon I ask for." Pleased, the lord of the gods agreed and spoke these words. "Without any anxiety, ask for some other boon from me." Thus addressed, Goutama happily spoke to Shankara. Goutama said, "This goddess in your matted hair is the mother of the worlds. She is the one who purifies. O lord of the universe! She is loved by you. On the words of this

brahmana, please release her. As she flows towards the ocean, let all the *tirthas* be along her side. O Shankara! As soon as one bathes in her, let all sins of thoughts, speech and deeds, the killing of a brahmana and others be destroyed. O divinity! O Hara! There are fruits that are obtained from bathing at other sacred *tirthas* at the time of a solar or lunar eclipse, the change of one *ayana* into another, *vishuva sankranti* and conjunctions like *vaidhriti*.⁴⁴⁶ If one only remembers this auspicious one, let all those fruits be obtained. During *krita yuga*, austerities are praised. In *treta yuga*, this becomes rites of sacrifices. In *dvapara yuga*, it becomes sacrifices and donations. Donations are praised in *kali yuga*. There is *dharma* of the *yuga* and different regions have their own *dharmas*. Depending on the time and the region, different kinds of *dharma* are praised. There are other good merits obtained through bathing, donating and self-control. O divinity! O Hara! If one only remembers this auspicious one, let all those fruits be obtained. Wherever she goes as she flows towards the ocean, let yourself also be present there. This is the excellent boon that I ask for. O Shiva! Even if great sinners come within a distance of ten *yojanas* of her banks and bathe in her, let them and their ancestors be freed. Let all mortals who bathe in her be emancipated. Let all the *tirthas* in heaven, earth and the nether regions be on one side and let her be on the other side, with her being superior. O Shambhu! That will be enough. I bow down to you.” Hearing Goutama’s words, Shiva replied that it would be this way. “There has been no *tirtha* which is superior to her, nor will there ever be. This is the truth. This is the truth. This is the truth.”⁴⁴⁷ This is in the Vedas. Goutami will be the most sacred of all.” Saying this, he vanished. When the illustrious one who is worshipped by the worlds departed because of his command, Goutama became full of strength. He received the best of rivers from the matted hair. Surrounded by the gods, he entered Brahmagiri. O Narada! As soon as Goutama received her from the matted hair, flowers were showered down. The lords among the gods, *rishis*, immensely fortunate *brahmanas* and *kshatriyas* assembled there. Full of delight, they worshipped the brahmana with words of “Victory”.’

Chapter 2(7) (Greatness of this tirtha)

Narada asked, ‘After receiving the Ganga from Maheshvara’s matted hair and going to Brahma’s sacred mountain, what did Goutama do?’

Brahma replied, ‘Accepting Ganga, Goutama purified and controlled his mind. He was worshipped by gods, *gandharvas* and the residents of the mountain. Placing the one from the matted hair on the summit of the mountain, he remembered the three-eyed divinity. The best among *brahmanas* joined his hands in salutation and spoke to Ganga. Goutama said, “You have originated from the three-eyed one’s matted hair. You bestow everything that one wishes for. O mother! O serene one! Flow happily and do everything that is beneficial.” The goddess Ganga was in a divine form. She was adorned with divine garlands and unguents. Thus addressed by Goutama, she replied to Goutama. Ganga asked, “Where will I go? Will I go to the abode of the gods, the *kamandalu* or to the nether regions? You have been born as someone who is truthful in speech.” Goutama said, “I have asked for you for the welfare of the three worlds. O goddess! That is the reason you have been given by Shambhu. Let there be no violation of that.” Hearing Goutama’s words, Ganga listened to the words spoken by the brahmana. She divided herself into three flows—for heaven, the world of the mortals and the nether regions. She flowed in heaven in four streams. She flowed in the mortal world in seven streams. She flowed in the nether regions in seven streams. There are, thus, fifteen different streams. Everywhere, she destroys all sins committed by all living beings. She always grants every object of desire. She is chanted about in the Vedas. The mortals only perceive that part of her that flows through the mortal world, not that which flows in the nether regions. Ignorant in their intelligence, mortals do not see that part of her which flows in heaven. As

long as the goddess flows towards the sea, it is said that all the gods are in her. Released by Goutama, she flowed from the west towards the eastern ocean. The auspicious mother of the universe is frequented by gods and *rishis*. Goutama, tiger among sages, performed *pradakshina* around her. Goutama first worshipped the three-eyed one, the lord of the gods. He made up his mind, “I will bathe along both her banks.” As soon as he remembered him, the three-eyed, who is an ocean of compassion, appeared before him. Devotedly, he joined his hands in salutation and asked the divinity Sharva how a bath would become successful.’

Goutama said, ‘O lord of the gods! O Mahesha! For the welfare of the worlds, please tell me about the proper methods for bathing in the *tirthas*.’ Shiva replied, ‘O *maharshi*! Hear all the norms about Godavari. Having purified the body, it is recommended that *nandimukha* should be performed first. *Brahmanas* must be fed and their permission must be obtained. As one proceeds towards the river, one must observe *brahmacharya*, avoiding conversing with those have fallen down. ⁴⁴⁸ If the hands, feet and mind are controlled properly and if one possesses learning, austerities and deeds, fruits are obtained from a *tirtha*. One must cast aside all wicked sentiments and be devoted to one’s own *dharma*. One should massage the limbs of those who are exhausted and give them the appropriate food. Garments and blankets must be given to virtuous people who possess nothing. One must hear divine accounts about Hari and about Ganga’s origin. If one follows these norms properly as one proceeds, one obtains the fruits from visiting a *tirtha*.’ The three-eyed one again spoke to Goutama as he was surrounded by the sages. ‘O Goutama! The *tirthas* are at a distance of two hands from each other. I am present everywhere and bestow everything that one wishes for. Bhagirathi ⁴⁴⁹ bestows everything auspicious and emancipation to men—in Gangadvara, ⁴⁵⁰ Prayaga and the confluence with the ocean. Narmada, best among rivers is in the mountain of Amarkantaka. Yamuna and Sarasvati join the Ganga in Prabhasa. ⁴⁵¹ O Narada! There are Krishna, Bhimarathi and Tungabhadra. The *tirtha* that is the confluence of the three bestows emancipation on men. ⁴⁵² The river’s confluence with Payoshni also bestows emancipation. ⁴⁵³ O son! Such is the Goutami. ⁴⁵⁴ On my

instructions, she always confers emancipation on all the men who bathe in her. On some occasions, because the gods assemble there at those times, some *tirthas* are extremely sacred. However, there is no doubt that Goutami is always the best among all these *tirthas*. Bathing in Bhagirathi for sixty thousand years is equivalent to bathing once in Godavari when Brihaspati ⁴⁵⁵ is in Simha. ⁴⁵⁶ This *tirtha* is special because Rama's feet were placed there when he visited it. It is extremely rare for men to bathe in Goutami when Brihaspati is in Simha. When the sun is in Simha, the rivers Bhagirathi, Narmada, Yamuna, Sarasvati, Bhimarathi and others arrive to bathe in Goutami. When the two preceptors ⁴⁵⁷ are in Simha, if a foolish person avoids Goutami Ganga and frequents any other *tirtha*, he goes to hell. O tiger among sages! O Goutama! Within a distance of two hundred *yojanas*, there will be three and a half crores of *tirthas*. This Ganga from Maheshvara is known as Goutami, Vaishnavi, Brahmi, Godavari, Nanda and Sunanda. She bestows everything desired. She has been brought through a *brahmanas*'s energy and destroys all sins. As soon as she is remembered, she destroys sins. She is always loved by me. Among the five elements, it is water which is the best. Among all kinds of water, water in the *tirthas* is said to be the best. Among these, Bhagirathi is the best. But among the flows of Bhagirathi, Goutami is the best. You brought this Ganga from the matted hair and there is nothing more auspicious than her among all the *tirthas* in heaven, earth and the nether regions. O sage! This bestows everything.' O son! He said this to the great-souled Goutama. Pleased, he himself granted him a boon and I have told you about it. Thus, it is held that Goutami Ganga is the best. I have spoken about her nature. What else do you wish to hear?

Chapter 2(8) (Descent of Bhagirathi)

Narada said, ‘O best among gods! But you spoke about two of her forms. You have only spoken about the form that was brought by the brahmana. A *kshatriya* brought down the other part from the matted hair of Bhava, the lord of the gods. Please tell me about this.’

Brahma replied, ‘O sage! There was a king who descended from Vaivasvata Manu. ⁴⁵⁸ He was born in the Ikshvaku lineage and his name was Sagara. The ocean takes his name from him. ⁴⁵⁹ He performed sacrifices and was devoted to donations. He always thought about the conduct of *dharma*. He had two wives who were extremely attached to their husband. However, since he had no sons, he was overcome by thoughts. When Vasishtha arrived in his house, as is appropriate, he worshipped him. The king spoke to him, asking how he might obtain offspring. Hearing his words, he thought about it and spoke to the king. Vasishtha said, “O king! Along with your wives, always worship *rishis*.” O brahmana! Uttering these words, the sage returned to wherever he had come from. On one occasion, a store of austerities came to the *rajarshi*’s ⁴⁶⁰ house. When the *rishi* was worshipped, he was satisfied and addressed him in these words. “O extremely fortunate one! Ask for a boon.” Thus addressed, he asked for the boon that he might have sons. The sage told the king, “One of your wives will have a son who will sustain the lineage. The other wife will have sixty thousand sons.” Having granted the boon, the sage left and thousands of sons were born. He performed many horse sacrifices and gave away a lot of *dakshina*. On one such occasion following the norms, the king consecrated himself for a horse sacrifice. Along with the soldiers, the king entrusted his sons with the task of guarding the horse. Detecting an opportunity, Shatakratu stole the horse. The sons searched for the horse’s trail, but could not find it. There were

sixty thousands of them and they were skilled in many kinds of fighting. Sagara's sons had been engaged to guard the horse. But even as they looked on, the horse was abducted and taken to the nether regions. Because the *maya* of *rakshasas* had been used,⁴⁶¹ Sagara's sons could not see the horse. Sagara's strong sons could not see the horse. Meanwhile, the officiating priests pronounced benedictions and performed the auspicious rites for the king to be consecrated. However, unable to see the beautiful animal, the king was filled with thoughts. Searching for the horse's trail, all of Sagara's sons searched and even went to the world of the gods. But they did not see it there. Therefore, the sons of the king returned to earth and searched the mountains and forests. But they could not see the horse. At that time, a divine voice was heard. "O sons of Sagara! The horse is tethered in Rasatala, not anywhere else." Hearing these words, they wished to go to Rasatala. In every direction, Sagara's sons dug up the ground. Afflicted by hunger, day and night, they ate the dry earth. Having dug up the earth, they swiftly went to Rasatala. The powerful sons of King Sagara reached the place. Hearing this, the *rakshasas* were terrified and approached Kapila. The immensely wise Kapila was lying down in Rasatala. Earlier, he had accomplished an excellent task for the gods. Exhausted because of the task he had accomplished for the gods, he was asleep. The prosperous Kapila had told them, "Give me a place to sleep in." When they gave him Rasatala, the sage told the gods, "If a wicked person wakes me up, he will instantly be reduced to ashes. I will sleep in the nether regions only on this condition. Otherwise, I will not sleep." Thus addressed, the large number of gods agreed and gave him Rasatala to sleep in. The *rakshasas*, full of *maya*, knew about his powers. All of them thought of a means to kill Sagara's sons. Even though there had been no fighting, the *rakshasas* were scared. Hence, they quickly went to the place where Kapila, great in his rage, was. They tied the horse near his head and swiftly withdrew some distance away, from where, they silently wished to observe what would happen. All the sons of Sagara entered Rasatala. They saw the horse tethered near a man who was asleep. They thought that this was the thief who had ruined the sacrifice. "We will kill

this extremely wicked person and take the horse back to the king.” Others said, “Let us take the bound animal. What do we have to do with this person?” Still others said, “We are brave kings and we are rulers. We must wake up this extremely wicked person and using the splendor of being *kshatriyas*, kill him.” Uttering these words, they cruelly kicked the sage with their feet. Kapila, the excellent sage, was filled with great rage. He glanced at the sons of Sagara and this rage was used to reduce them to ashes. All the sons of Sagara were consumed in that blaze. Not knowing all this, King Sagara consecrated himself. However, Narada told the great-souled Sagara this. ⁴⁶² He also told him where Kapila was, where the horse was, the perverse deed perpetrated by the *rakshasas* and about the destruction of Sagara’s sons. The king was filled with thoughts and did not know what he should do.

‘The king had another son known by the name of Asamanja. In his folly, he used to hurl children and citizens into the water. Sagara got to know this in an assembly of the citizens. When he got to know that he was a bad son, the king was angry and spoke to his own advisers. The king said, “This Asamanja has given up on the *dharma* of *kshatriyas* and has killed children. We must act so as to exile him from the kingdom.” Hearing Sagara’s words, the advisers swiftly abandoned the king’s son and Asamanja went to the forest. “All the sons of Sagara have been destroyed in Rasatala because of a *brahmanas*’s curse. The single one has gone to the forest. What shall happen to me now?” ⁴⁶³ Asamanja had a son known by the name of Amshuman. The king summoned the child and told him about the task that needed to be undertaken. The child, Amshuman, went to Kapila. He gave the horse to Sagara and the sacrifice was thus completed. Amshuman had an energetic son named Dilipa who was devoted to *dharma*. Dilipa had an intelligent son known by the name of Bhagiratha. He heard about the destination obtained by his grandfathers and was extremely miserable. With humility, he asked Sagara, tiger among kings. “How can all the sons of Sagara be saved?” The king told Bhagiratha, “O son! ⁴⁶⁴ Kapila knows.” Hearing his words, the child went to Rasatala. He bowed down to Kapila and told him everything. The sage thought for a long time and said, “Use

austerities to worship Shankara. O excellent king! Flood your ancestors with the water that is in the matted hair. In this way, you and your ancestors will become successful.” He prostrated himself before the sage and spoke to him again. “I will act accordingly. O best among sages! But where should I go? You should tell me this.” Kapila replied, “Go to Kailasa, best among mountains, and praise Maheshvara. According to your capacity, perform austerities and you will obtain what you desire.” Hearing the sage’s words, he bowed down before the sage and went to Mount Kailasa. The child, prone to activities of children, purified himself. Bhagiratha resolved to perform austerities and spoke these words. Bhagiratha said, “O lord! I am a child and my intelligence is that of a child. You are the one who holds up the young moon. O lord! I do not know anything. Nevertheless, be pleased with me. O lord of the immortals! O Soma! ⁴⁶⁵ O one who is worshipped by gods and others! O one who holds the crescent moon on his head! O Shiva! Act for the benefit of those who are devoted to my welfare, those who have done me good turns in words, thoughts and deeds, for those who have given me birth, for those who have reared me, for those who possess my own *gotra* and for those who follow own *dharma*. I always prostrate myself before you. Please act so as to ensure what they desire.” Praised in this way, Shiva appeared before him. He asked Bhagiratha to unhesitatingly ask for the boon he wished. Shiva said, “O Bhagiratha! O immensely wise one! Without any fear, tell me what you desire. I will certainly give it to you, even if it cannot be given to *sadhyas* and the large number of gods.” Cheerfully, Bhagiratha prostrated himself before Isha and spoke to Shankara. Bhagiratha said, “My ancestors can be purified by the best among rivers, who is in the matted hair. O lord of the gods! Please grant her to me and everything will be accomplished.” Mahesha laughed and spoke to Bhagiratha. Shiva replied, “O son! O one who is excellent in vows! I am giving her to you. Please praise her once again.” Hearing his words, he performed great austerities for that purpose. Controlling his mind, he devotedly praised Ganga. Though he was still a child, acting as if he wasn’t a child, he obtained her favours too. Obtaining Ganga from Maheshvara, he took her down to the nether regions and told the great-souled sage, Kapila,

everything. In the proper way, he carefully placed Ganga and performed her *pradakshina*. He joined his hands in salutation and spoke to her. Bhagiratha said, “O goddess! Because of the curse of the great sage, Kapila, my ancestors have come to a perverse end. O mother! You should save them from their downfall.” The divine river, who performs good deeds for everyone, agreed. For the sake of the welfare of the worlds, for the sake of purifying his ancestors, especially for the sake of filling up the ocean which had been drunk up by Agastya,⁴⁶⁶ for the sake of destroying sins as soon as she is remembered and for the sake of acting in accordance with Bhagiratha’s words, the divine river remained in Rasatala. Because of the brahmana’s curse, the sons of King Sagara had been reduced to ashes. She flooded the ashes of those who had been consumed and filled up the holes they had dug. She flooded Meru and remained there. The young king told her, “You must remain in this *karma bhumi*.” Agreeing to this, she went to the Himalayas. From the sacred mountain of Himalayas, she came to Bharatavarsha. Through its midst, the sacred river flowed towards the eastern ocean. O great sage! Ganga is Maheshvari, Vaishnavi, the purifying Brahmi and the divine river. I have spoken about how she was brought down by a *kshatriya* and became Bhagirathi on the summit of the Himalayas. From Maheshvara’s matted hair, the water divided into two parts. To the south of the Vindhya, Ganga is known as Goutami. To the north of the Vindhya, she is known as Bhagirathi.’

Chapter 2(9) (Varaha *tirtha*)

Narada said, ‘Hearing the account spoken by you, my mind is not content. My mind wishes to hear separately about the fruits of the *tirthas* and please tell me about them in the due order, starting first with how the brahmana brought Ganga. Then separately, please tell me about the history and the fruits of the *tirthas*.’

Brahma replied, ‘I am not capable of separately telling you about the fruits and the greatness of all the *tirthas*, nor are you capable of hearing them. O Narada! Nevertheless, I will tell you something. Listen attentively. After bowing down to the three-eyed one, I will briefly tell you about what has been said about the *tirthas* in the words of the sacred texts. O sage! The *tirtha* where the illustrious three-eyed one directly manifested himself is known as Tryambaka and it bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation. ⁴⁶⁷ There is another *tirtha* known as Varaha, famous in the three worlds. ⁴⁶⁸ I will tell you about its nature and also how it came to be named after Vishnu. It has been heard that in ancient times, a *rakshasa* named Sindhusena defeated the gods and seizing the sacrifice, went to Rasatala. When the sacrifice was taken to the nether regions, there were no sacrifices on earth. When there are no sacrifices, nothing exists in this world or in the world hereafter. That was the state then. Following their enemy, the gods also entered Rasatala. However, with Indra at the forefront, the gods were incapable of defeating him. They went to Vishnu, the ancient being, and told him about the *rakshasa*’s deeds, especially about the destruction of the sacrifice. The illustrious one said, “I will assume the form of a boar, holding a conch shell, a *chakra* and a mace in my hands. I will go to Rasatala, slay the bull among *rakshasas* and bring back the sacred sacrifice. O gods! Dispel all your mental anxiety and return to heaven.” O son! There was a

path Ganga had followed when proceeding to the nether regions. Using that, the wielder of the *chakra* swiftly penetrated the earth and went to Rasatala. Assuming the form of a boar, the prosperous one killed the *rakshasas* and *danavas* who were residents of Rasatala. He held the giant sacrifice in his mouth. In his form of a boar, the illustrious enjoyer of sacrifices seized the sacrifice. Using the path that Vishnu, the vanquisher of enemies, had used to go to the nether regions, with the great sacrifice in his mouth, he emerged from Rasatala. The gods were waiting for Hari in Brahmagiri. O Narada! Along the path that Ganga had used to flow down, he washed off the blood from his own limbs. The water from the Ganga formed Varahakunda. Holding the great sacrifice in his mouth, Hari presented himself before the gods. The best of the gods gave it to them and the great sacrifice thus originated from his mouth. Since the divinity assumed the form of a boar, the ladle has been the first limb of the sacrifice.⁴⁶⁹ Therefore, Varaha *tirtha* is most sacred and confers everything that is desired. Bathing, donating and all the sacrifices performed there yield fruits. If a person stands there and remembers his ancestors, he performs an auspicious act. Freed from all sins, his ancestors go to heaven.'

Chapter 2(10) (Kapota *tirtha*)

Brahma continued, ‘I am not capable of telling you about the greatness of Kushavarta. ⁴⁷⁰ Even if a man remembers it, he accomplishes every objective. The place famous as Kushavarta yields all objects of desire to men. There, the great-souled Goutama stemmed the flow with *kusha* grass. When the sage brought her, he stemmed the flow with *kusha* grass. Bathing and donations there bring satisfaction to the ancestors. Nilaganga, best among rivers, emerges from Mount Nila. ⁴⁷¹ If a man controls himself and performs a little bit of bathing and other rites there, his learning and everything else become inexhaustible and provide satisfaction to his ancestors. The excellent Kapota *tirtha* is famous in the three worlds. O sage! I will tell you about its nature. Hear about its great fruits. There was an extremely fierce hunter in Brahmagiri. ⁴⁷² He made *brahmanas*, virtuous people, mendicants, cattle, birds and animals suffer. The evil-souled one was like that, prone to anger and someone who uttered falsehoods. His form was fierce. His eyes were blue. His arms were short. His teeth were decayed. He had lost his nose and eyes. ⁴⁷³ His feet were short, but his waist was large. His hands were small. His stomach was small. He was malformed and his voice was like that of a donkey. He had a noose in his hand and his mind was evil. He was wicked and always wielded a bow. O Narada! His wife and children were also like him. Goaded by her, he entered the dense forest. The wicked one killed many kinds of birds. He flung some others which were still alive inside a cage. Suffering from hunger, distracted by thirst and hot all over his limbs, he wandered in many regions before he headed home. It was afternoon and the spring months were over. Clouds arrived in an instant and there was thunder and lightning. A wind blew and hail-stones showered down. There was an extremely

terrible shower of rain. As he proceeded, the exhausted hunter could not discern the path. He could not distinguish water from land, the pits and the path or the directions. The sinner was exhausted and looked for a refuge. He thought, “Where will I go? Where will I stay? What will I do? Like the Destroyer, I have taken away the lives of all living beings. My destroyer, in terms of this shower of hail-stones, has arrived. I do not see anyone who can save me. There is no boulder or tree nearby.” In this way, the hunter thought in many ways. He then saw a tree in the forest, like a king of trees. It resembled the moon ⁴⁷⁴ among the *nakshatras*, the lion among animals, a householder among the *ashramas* and the mind among the senses. It was like a saviour of creatures. This sparkling tree was the best, ornamented with branches and sprouts. With his clothes wet, the hunter sought refuge there and sat down under it. He remembered his wife and children and wondered whether they were still alive. At that time, the sun set.

‘Along with his wife, a *kapota* ⁴⁷⁵ lived on that tree. Surrounded by his sons and grandsons, he lived on that excellent tree. He was happy and without any fear. He was extremely content and delighted. The bird had resided there for many years. His wife was devoted to her husband and was exceedingly happy with him. They dwelt in a hollow inside that excellent tree, where there was no water, wind or fire. The pigeon was always surrounded by his wife and sons. On that particular day, because of destiny, the male pigeon and the female pigeon had both gone out in search of food and the male pigeon had returned. O son! But such was destiny that the female pigeon was captured by the hunter. Though she was alive, she was inside the cage. The male pigeon looked at his children, separated from their mother. The terrible rain was showering down and the sun had set. He looked at his own empty hollow and started to lament. The king of pigeons did not know that she was bound inside the cage. The male pigeon started to sing about the qualities of his beloved. “The fortunate one, who extends my delight has not returned. She is the mother of my *dharma*. She is the mistress of my body. She is always my aide in the pursuit of *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*. When I am content, she laughs. When I am angry, she wipes away my misery. She is my friend and constantly counsels me. She

always abides by my words. Though the sun has set, the fortunate one has not yet returned. She is devoted to her husband and does not know of any other vow, *mantra*, divinity, *dharma* or *artha*. Her husband is her life. Her husband is her *mantra*. She loves her husband. The fortunate one has not yet returned. What will I do? Who will I go to? Without you, is it not evident that my house is a desolate forest? With her, everything is full of prosperity. With her, even something terrible seems to be agreeable. My beloved has not returned to the place that is known as home. I will not remain alive without her. I will even give up my beloved body. However, what will my children do? My *dharma* will also be destroyed.” From inside the cage, she heard her husband’s words of lamentation and addressed her husband in these words. The female pigeon said, “O excellent bird! I am helpless and am bound here. O immensely wise one! Binding me in a noose, the hunter has brought me here. I am blessed. I am favoured that my husband has spoken about my qualities. Whether this is true or whether this is false, there is no doubt that I am content. When a woman’s husband is satisfied, all the gods are satisfied. When it is the converse, a woman is certainly destroyed. You are my divinity. You are my lord. You are my well-wisher. You are my refuge. You are my vow. You are the supreme *brahman*. You are heaven. You are emancipation. O fortunate one! Do not worry. Steady your intelligence. Through your favours, I have enjoyed many kinds of objects of pleasure. Enough of this sorrow. Immerse yourself in *dharma* and steady your intelligence.” Hearing the words of his beloved, the male pigeon swiftly descended from that excellent tree and approached the place where the female pigeon was inside the cage. Having approached, he saw his beloved and also saw the hunter. He said, “The hunter is motionless now. I will free you.” She replied, “O immensely fortunate one! Do not release me. Know that all relationships are fickle. Birds provide food for hunters. A living being feeds on another living being. He has not committed a crime. Remember *dharma* and steady your intelligence. For *brahmanas*, Agni is the preceptor. For *varnas*, a brahmana is the preceptor. For women, their husbands are the preceptors. But for everyone, a guest is the preceptor. When a guest arrives, if he is satisfied with words of welcome, the goddess

of speech is certainly satisfied. When he is satisfied with the offering of food, Shakra is satisfied. When his feet are washed, the ancestors are satisfied. When he is given food, Prajapati is satisfied. When he is served in other ways, Lakshmi and Vishnu are pleased. When he is given a bed, all the gods are satisfied. Therefore, a guest ⁴⁷⁶ must always be worshipped. If a guest is exhausted and scorched by the hot sun when he arrives home, one should know that he has arrived in the form of all the gods. He represents the fruits of all sacrifices. When a guest leaves exhausted, all the gods, the ancestors and Agni follow him. When he is satisfied, they are happy. When his hopes are dashed, their hopes are also dashed. O beloved! Therefore, in every possible way cast aside your grief. Be calm. Be steady and use your auspicious intelligence. Follow *dharma* in your conduct. Doing a good turn to a person who has caused injury is revered as excellent. Everyone does a good turn towards someone who has done a good turn. Someone who exhibits virtuous conduct towards a person who has caused injury is spoken of as an auspicious person.” The male pigeon said, “O one with the beautiful face! What you have said about us is appropriate. What you have thought is virtuous. But I have something to say. Listen. There are some who fill their stomachs with thousands, others with hundreds and consider themselves to be happy. We fill our stomachs with a great deal of difficulty. Some have pits filled with grain and riches, others obtain wealth through hardships. Some fling their wealth into pits, our wealth is in our beaks. O auspicious one! How will we worship this exhausted guest?” The female pigeon replied, “Fire, water, auspicious words, grass, wood and the like can be offered. In addition, the hunter is suffering from the cold.” Hearing the words of his beloved, the king of birds climbed back onto the tree and saw a fire burning, some distance away. He went to the spot where the fire was burning and using his beak, brought back a burning splinter. The male pigeon lit a fire in front of the hunter. In the night, the king of pigeons repeatedly flung dry wood, leaves and grass into the fire. The hunter was suffering on account of the cold. Seeing the blazing fire, the hunter heated his incapacitated limbs and was happy. The female pigeon saw that the hunter was scorched by the flames of hunger. She told her husband, “O

immensely fortunate one! Release me. I will use my own body to please the hunter who is suffering from grief. O one who is excellent in vows! A person who satisfies a guest obtains the desired worlds.” The male pigeon replied, “As long as I am here, this is not your recommended dharma. O auspicious one! Grant me leave. I will give the guest what he wishes for.” Having said this, he circumambulated the fire thrice and remembered Mahavishnu, the four-armed divinity who is the *atman* of the universe, the refuge who is affectionate towards his devotees. “Happily, eat me.” Saying this, he entered the fire. On seeing that he had flung his life into the fire, the hunter spoke these words. The hunter exclaimed, “How wonderful! Shame on this life in a human body. For my sake, the king of birds has acted so bravely.” When the hunter said this, the female pigeon spoke to him in these words. The female pigeon said, “O immensely fortunate one! Please release me. My husband is going a long distance away.” Hearing the words of the female pigeon from inside the cage, as if he was frightened, the hunter quickly released her. She performed *pradakshina* of the fire and sung these words towards her husband. The female pigeon said, “Serving the husband is supreme *dharma* for women. This is the path indicated in the Vedas, revered by all the worlds. A snake-catcher forcibly takes a snake far away from its hole. Like that, if a woman follows her husband, she goes to heaven with him. There are three and a half crores of body hair in a human body. A woman who follows her husband resides in heaven for that many years.” Bowing down to the earth, the gods, Ganga and the large tree, she comforted her children and addressed the hunter in these words. “O immensely fortunate one! Through your favours, this opportunity has presented itself before someone like me. You should pardon my children. I am going to heaven with my husband.” Saying this, the virtuous female bird entered the fire. As soon as she entered the fire, there were sounds of “Victory”. An extremely beautiful *vimana* that was as resplendent as the sun appeared in the sky. The couple was seen astride this, resembling the gods. The hunter was astounded and full of joy, they spoke to him. The couple said, “O immensely intelligent one! Taking your permission, we are going to the abode of the gods. These stairs will take us to heaven. O *atithi*! We

bow down before you.” The hunter saw the two of them, astride that excellent *vimana*. He threw away his bow and cage. Joining his hands in salutation, the hunter said, “O immensely fortunate ones! You should not abandon me. I am ignorant. Something should be given to me. I am your revered *atithi* here. You should tell me the means for my salvation.” The couple said, “O fortunate one! Go to Goutami and tell her about your crime. If you bathe there for a fortnight, you will be cleansed of all your sins. After being freed from your sins, if you bathe in the Ganga again, you will obtain the sacred fruits of a horse sacrifice and be purified. Goutami is best among rivers and is praised by Brahma and Vishnu on earth. If you bathe there again, you will cast aside this defiled body. There is no doubt that you will go to heaven then, astride a *vimana*.” Hearing their words, this is what the hunter did. Astride an excellent *vimana*, he assumed a divine form. He was attired in celestial garlands and garments and was worshipped by large numbers of *apsaras*. Through the powers of Ganga, the male pigeon, the female pigeon and the hunter as the third, went to heaven. Since then, the place has been famous as *kapota tirtha*. Bathing, donating, worshipping the ancestors, *japa*, sacrifices and other rites performed there bring infinite fruits.’

Chapter 2(11) (Kumara *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There is another supreme *tirtha* known by the name of Kumara or Kartikeya. Merely hearing about it purifies one’s lineage. When Taraka *daitya* was slain, there was relief in heaven.⁴⁷⁷ Parvati was pleased with her eldest son, Kartikeya, and spoke to him. ‘Enjoy yourself happily with all the objects of pleasure in the three worlds that delight your mind. Through my command and your father’s favours, you will be happy.’ Vishakha,⁴⁷⁸ loved by the gods, was addressed by his mother in this way. As he pleased, the powerful one amused himself with the wives of the gods. O Narada! The wives of the gods also amused himself with them and the residents of heaven were unable to restrain Kartikeya. They went and told Parvati about her son’s deeds. His mother, or the gods, were unable to restrain the wielder of the spear. The one with the six faces⁴⁷⁹ was so attached to women that their words were unable to restrain him. Scared of a possible curse, Parvati thought about this. She was constrained by love for her son, but also wanted to accomplish the task of the gods. Deciding to protect the wives of the gods, she repeatedly thought for a long time. Whichever lady Skanda wished to sport with, Parvati made her assume a form that was just like Parvati’s own. Whenever the one with the six faces summoned the wives of Indra or Varuna and when he looked at her, he saw a form that was just like that of his mother’s. Seeing this, he bowed down and summoned someone else instead. However, seeing his mother’s form in her too, he was ashamed. He saw everything outside pervaded by his mother’s form. Thinking about this, Gangeya⁴⁸⁰ developed non-attachment. Realizing that this was his mother’s doing, he refrained from *pravritti*. ‘If I was supposed to withdraw from physical pleasures, why was I asked to indulge in it in the first place? Because of what my mother has done, I have

become a laughing stock before everybody.’ Filled with great shame, he went to Goutami. ‘This also has my mother’s form. Therefore, listen to my words. From now on, it will be my view that everything feminine will be like my mother.’ Realizing this, Shankara, the lord of the worlds, and Parvati tried to restrain their son.’ However, he replied that he had already decided this. His father, the lord of the gods, thought, ‘What can I possibly give him?’ Joining his hands in salutation, Skanda replied to his father. Skanda said, ‘I am the commander of the gods and I am your son too. O lord of the gods! O one who is worshipped by the gods! What other boon can there be? Or perhaps, if you wish to give, give me something for the welfare of the worlds. O divinity! With your permission, I do not desire anything for myself. There are great sinners, such as those who have intercourse with the wives of their preceptors. As soon as they bathe here, let them be purged of all sins. O lord of the gods! Let inferior species also have excellent births. As soon as they bathe here, let those who are deformed become beautiful.’ Shambhu agreed to the words spoken by his beloved son. Since then, that place has been famous as Kartikeya *tirtha*. Bathing and donations there yield the fruits of all sacrifices.’

Chapter 2(12) (Krittika *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The next, after Kartikeya *tirtha* is known as Krittika *tirtha*. Even if one hears about it, one obtains the fruits obtained from drinking *soma*. O sage! Earlier, for the destruction of Taraka, Kavi had drunk the semen.⁴⁸¹ On seeing that Kavi had the semen inside him, the wives of the *rishis* desired him. With the exception of Arundhati,⁴⁸² the wives of the other *saptarshis* had bathed after their periods. Through Agni, these six wives conceived. O sage! Having just bathed after their periods, these beautiful women were scorched. “What will we do? Where can we go? How will we perform a good deed?” Having spoken to each other in this way, they anxiously went to Ganga and massaged themselves. As a result of this, the fetuses emerged and floated in the water in the form of foam. Fanned by the wind, all these bits united in the water. Therefore, the baby who was born had one body, but six faces. When the fetuses were discharged, the wives of the *rishis* returned home. However, seeing that their forms were distorted, the *rishis* told them, “Leave. Quickly do. One should not follow the conduct of a *svairini*. O son! The women were, thus, refused by their husbands. Being abandoned by their own husbands, those six were miserable. Seeing them, Narada said,⁴⁸³ “Kartikeya is the son of Hara. But the slayer of Taraka will also be famous as the son of Ganga and Agni. Go to him.⁴⁸⁴ Within a short while, he will grant you objects of pleasure.’ Following the words of the *devarshi*, they approached the one with six faces. The Krittikas⁴⁸⁵ themselves told him exactly what had happened. Kartikeya accepted the words of the Krittikas and told them, ‘All of you go to Goutami. Bathe there and worship Maheshvara. Come. I will take you there to the god’s temple.’ Agreeing to this, the Krittikas bathed in Goutami Ganga. Following Kartikeya’s instructions, they worshipped the

lord of the gods. Through the favours of the lord of the gods, they went to the god's temple. Since that time, that *tirtha* has been spoken of as Krittika *tirtha*. In the month of Kartika, ⁴⁸⁶ if one bathes there when the *nakshtra* Krittika is in the ascendant, one obtains the fruits of all the sacrifices. One becomes a king who is devoted to *dharmā*. Even if a person remembers the *tirtha* or hears about it, he is freed from all sins and obtains a long lifespan.”

Chapter 2(13) (Dashashvamedha *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘O sage! Hear about Dashashvamedha *tirtha*. Even if a person hears about it, he obtains the fruits of a horse sacrifice. Vishvakarma’s son was the handsome and immensely strong Vishvarupa. His son was Pramati and Pramati’s son was the lord Bhouvana. His priest was Kashyapa, accomplished in all forms of knowledge. The mighty-armed Bhouvana, the emperor of all the worlds, asked him the following question. “O sage! I simultaneously wish to perform ten horse sacrifices. O preceptor! O brahmana! Therefore, I am asking you. Who among the gods has performed such a sacrifice?” He told him, “O best among kings! These are the various places where the gods have performed sacrifices. These are the places where excellent *brahmanas* have performed great sacrifices. These are the places where large numbers of *rishis* have performed circles of sacrifices. These are the places where the priest simultaneously started ten horse sacrifices, but they weren’t successfully completed. Avoiding the places where the gods performed their sacrifices, the sacrifices can be undertaken at other spots. The other sacrifices that were started were tainted and faced impediments.” Seeing this, the king became full of thoughts. Seeing that the sacrifices had not been completed, the king spoke to his preceptor. The king asked, “Was the place tainted? Was the time tainted? Is there some taint in me or in you? Why were those ten horse sacrifices not completed?” With his priest, Kashyapa, the miserable king went to Samvarta, Gishpati’s ⁴⁸⁷ elder brother, and spoke to him. Kashyapa and Bhouvana said, “O illustrious one! O one who bestows honours! We wish to simultaneously perform ten horse sacrifices. Which is the place where we can complete them? O preceptor! Please tell us.” The best among *rishis* meditated for some time and told Bhouvana, “Go to Brahma. He will tell

you about the preceptor and the spot.” The immensely wise Bhouvana and the great-souled Kashyapa came to me and asked me about the appropriate preceptor, the spot and other things. O son! I spoke to Bhouvana and Kashyapa. “O Indra among kings! Go to Goutami. That is an extremely sacred spot for performing a sacrifice. Kashyapa is the best preceptor for you. He is accomplished in the Vedas. O king! Through the favours of your preceptor and through Goutami’s favours, if you bathe there and perform a single horse sacrifice, you will obtain the fruits of ten horse sacrifices.” Hearing this, King Bhouvana went to the banks of Goutami. With Kashyapa as an aide, he consecrated himself for a horse sacrifice. The great horse sacrifice, the lord of all sacrifices, commenced there. When it was completed, the king was ready to donate the entire earth. The excellent king was standing there, having worshipped the *brahmanas*, the officiating priests and the assistant priests. A loud voice was heard from the firmament. The voice from the firmament said, “O king! With Kashyapa as your priest, you have evinced a desire to donate the entire earth, along with its mountains and forests. That is as good as giving it away. Give up this desire to donate land. Donate food. That brings great fruits. In the three worlds, nothing yields as much of good merits as the donation of food. O sage! ⁴⁸⁸ This is especially because you have devotedly performed a horse sacrifice on the banks of the Ganga and have given away a lot of *dakshina*. O fortunate one! You have already accomplished your objective. There is no need to think about this.” Nevertheless, since he wanted to give, the earth spoke to Bhouvana. The earth said, “O Vishvakarma’s descendant! Do not repeatedly want to give me away. If a person resorts to the banks of Goutami and gives a mouthful of food, it is as if everything has been given. O Bhouvana! Why will you give me away? I will then sink into this water. Therefore, you should not give me away.” Bhouvana was scared and asked, “What should be given away then?” The earth again spoke to Bhouvana, who was surrounded by *brahmanas*. The earth said, “On the banks of Goutami, if a person gives away a little bit of sesamum, cattle, riches and grain, that donation is as good as inexhaustible. O Bhouvana! Why will you give me away? If a person resorts to the banks of Goutami and gives a

mouthful of food, it is as if everything has been given. O Bhouvana! Why will you give me away?”⁴⁸⁹ Hearing the earth’s words, Bhouvana, the universal emperor, agreed that this was indeed the case. He gave the *brahmanas* a great deal of food. Ever since then, that spot has been known as Dashashvamedha⁴⁹⁰ *tirtha*. Bathing there yields the fruits of ten horse sacrifices.’

Chapter 2(14) (Paishacha *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There is another one named Paishacha *tirtha*. It is worshipped by those who know about the *brahman*. I will describe its nature. It is on the southern bank of Goutami. O Narada! Along the side of Brahmagiri, there is a mountain named Anjana. ⁴⁹¹ O excellent sage! On that mountain, there was a supreme *apsara* who had been dislodged because of a curse. Her name was Anjana and her face was like that of a she-monkey. Her husband’s name was Kesari and he had another wife named Adrika. This wife of Kesari’s was also a supreme *apsara* who had been dislodged because of a curse. Her face was like that of a she-cat and she too resided on Mount Anjana. Kesari, famous in the worlds, once went to the southern ocean. Meanwhile, Agastya went to Mount Anjana. Following the norms, both Anjana and Adrika happily worshipped Agastya, supreme among *rishis*. The illustrious one was pleased and requested both of them to ask for boons. Both of them told Agastya, “O lord of sages! Please give us sons. They should be stronger and superior to everyone else. They should do good deeds to everyone.” Having agreed, the best among sages left for the southern direction. There was an occasion when Anjana and Adrika were singing, dancing and laughing on the summit of that mountain. The gods Vayu and Nirriti saw them and smiled. Overcome with desire, both of them rushed forward. “We are gods. We are the ones who bestow boons. Please be our wives.” When they agreed, they amused themselves on the summit of that mountain. Through Vayu, Anjana gave birth to Hanuman. Through Nirriti, Adrika gave birth to the king of the *pishachas*. They said, “Thanks to the best among sages, these sons have been born to us. However, our forms are disfigured and our faces are tainted. We have been cursed by Shachi’s consort. ⁴⁹² You should know about this.” The illustrious Vayu and

Nirriti replied, “If you bathe in Goutami, you will be released from your curse.” Saying this, those two delighted gods disappeared. To please them, Adri,⁴⁹³ who had the form of a *pishacha* took Anjana, his mother and his brother Hanuman and made them have their baths there. In similar fashion, Hanuman also swiftly took Adri, whose form was like that of a cat, to the banks of Goutami Ganga. Since then, this *tirtha* has been named after Paishacha and Anjana. It is auspicious and is near Brahmagiri. It yields all the objects of desire. The region known as Marjara extends fifty-three *yojanas* to the east. Since then, it has been named after Marjara and Hanuman Vrishakapi.⁴⁹⁴ The auspicious confluence of Phena⁴⁹⁵ yields all the objects of desire. Its form, nature and location are spoken about in that place.’

Chapter 2(15) (Kshudha *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘O Narada! Listen attentively about the place known as Kshudha *tirtha*. I will describe this extremely sacred place. For men, it yields all the objects of desire. In ancient times, there was a *rishi* named Kanva. He was an ascetic and knew about the Vedas. Once, he was exhausted from wandering around and was suffering from hunger. Goutama’s sacred hermitage was prosperous and was full of food and water. Kanva saw that he was hungry, while Goutama was prosperous. Because of this inequity, he developed non-attachment. “Goutama is the best among *brahmanas*, but I am also devoted to austerities. One should not seek from someone who is an equal. Therefore, though I am hungry and my body is suffering, I should not eat in Goutama’s home. I will go to Goutami Ganga and earn riches.” Having decided this, the intelligent one went to the purifying Ganga. He bathed and with a pure mind, sat down on a mat of *kusha* grass. He praised Goutami Ganga and the great calamity of Kshudha.

⁴⁹⁶ Kanva said, “I bow down to Ganga, the remover of great afflictions. I bow down to Kshudha, who causes suffering among all beings. I bow down to the auspicious one, who emerged from the great Ishana’s matted hair. I bow down to the great one who emerged from the mouth of Death. ⁴⁹⁷ O one who is serene in form to those who have pure minds! O one who is angry in form to evil-souled ones! O one who assumes the form of a river to dispel the torments and sins of everyone! O one who assumes the form of Kshudha to cause torment to everyone! I bow down before you. I bow down before the one who confers everything that is beneficial, the one who crushes sin. I bow down before the goddess who delivers peace. I bow down before the one who destroys poverty.” Praised in this way, two forms appeared before him. One beautiful form was that of Ganga and the other

form was terrible. The best among *brahmanas* joined his hands in salutation and prostrated himself again. Kanva said, “O auspicious one! O one who is the cause behind everything auspicious! O Brahmi! O Maheshvari! O sacred Vaishnavi! O three-eyed one! O goddess Godavari! I bow down before you. O one who emerged from the three-eyed one’s matted hair! O one who destroyed Goutama’s sins! O one who proceeds to the ocean in seven flows! O Godavari! I bow down before you. O one who destroys all sins! O one who destroys sins committed in the pursuit of *dharma*, *artha* and *kama*! O goddess Kshudha! O one who destroys both misery and avarice! I bow down before you.” Hearing Kanva’s words, they were extremely pleased and spoke to the brahmana. Ganga and Kshudha said, “O fortunate one! O one who is excellent in vows! Speak. Ask for your desired boon.” In due order, Kanva prostrated himself before Ganga and Kshudha and spoke. Kanva said, “O goddess! Please grant me agreeable and desired prosperity, a long lifespan, wealth, enjoyment of objects of pleasure and emancipation. O Ganga! Please give me this.” After addressing Goutami Ganga in this way, the best among *brahmanas* spoke to Kshudha. Kanva said, “O Kshudha! O thirst! O cause of penury! O wicked and harsh one! Let my lineage never suffer from these afflictions. If anyone is afflicted by hunger and praises you with this hymn, let them not suffer from either poverty or miseries. This *tirtha* is extremely sacred. If a man undertakes bathing, donations and *japa* here, let Lakshmi always serve him. If a person reads this hymn in this *tirtha* or at home, let him not suffer from poverty, misery or fear.” Having told Kanva that they agreed to this, they returned to their respective abodes. Since then, this *tirtha* has been named after Kanva, Ganga and Kshudha. O son! It destroys all sins and extends the delight of the ancestors.’

Chapter 2(16) (Ahalya and Indra *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There is a *tirtha* named Ahalya-Sangama that purifies the three worlds. O best among sages! Listen properly to the account that transpired there. O lord of sages! Driven by curiosity, I had created many kinds of maidens earlier. They were beautiful and possessed all the qualities. Among them, I created one who was the best. She possessed the auspicious signs. That maiden was beautiful in all her limbs. On seeing her beauty and qualities, I started to wonder. ‘Who has the capacity to nurture her? There is no one among the *daityas*, gods or sages who possesses the capacity to nurture her.’ This is what I thought. There was an intelligent and senior brahmana who possessed the qualities. He was devoted to austerities and possessed all the signs. He was learned in the Vedas and the *Vedangas*. This was the immensely wise Goutama and to nurture her, I bestowed her on him. “O best among the sages! Protect her, until she attains youth. When she attains youth, bring the virtuous one back to me.” Saying this, I gave Goutama the slender-waisted maiden. The best among sages, whose sins had been cleansed through austerities, obtained her. He nurtured her in the proper way. Then, ornamenting her, he brought her back to me. Indifferent towards Ahalya, the best among sages brought her. On seeing her, all the gods, Shakra, Agni, Varuna and the others separately said, “O lord of the gods! She should be given to me.” In a similar way, on seeing her, all the sages, *sadhyas*, *danavas*, *yakshas* and *rakshasas* approached me for the sake of the maiden. In particular, Indra had a great desire to obtain her. I remembered Goutama’s greatness, depth and fortitude and was extremely surprised. Therefore, I had this good thought. “It is appropriate that the one with the beautiful face should be given to Goutama and to no one else. Therefore, I will bestow her on him.” I also thought, “This maiden has

agitated the minds and patience of everyone.” The gods and the *rishis* said, “Ahalya is mine.” I looked at the gods and the *rishis* and loudly proclaimed the following. I repeatedly said, “This one with the excellent eyebrows will be given to the person who circumambulates the earth and presents himself before me first. She will not be given to anyone else.” The large number of gods heard the words I had spoken. For Ahalya’s sake, the gods started to circumambulate the earth. When the large number of gods had departed, Goutama, lord of sages, also made some efforts for Ahalya’s sake. O brahmana! Meanwhile, Surabhi, ⁴⁹⁸ who yields all the objects of desire, had partly delivered her calf. Seeing her, Goutama remembered that she represented the earth and circumambulated her. He also performed *pradakshina* of the *lingamm* of the lord of the gods. After circumambulating both of them, Goutama, supreme among sages, said, “All the gods have not yet completed a single circumambulation. They have left and have not returned. I have completed two circumambulations.” Having decided this, the sage approached me. The immensely intelligent Goutama bowed down and addressed me in these words. “O one who is seated on the lotus! O one who is the *atman* of the universe! I repeatedly prostrate myself before you. O Brahma! I have circumambulated the entire earth. O lord of the gods! Under the circumstances, you yourself know what is appropriate.” Through the *yoga* of meditation, I understood what Goutama had spoken. “You have performed *pradakshina*. The one with the excellent eyebrows will be given to you. O brahmana *rishi*! Know that even the *nigama* texts ⁴⁹⁹ find it difficult to comprehend *dharma*. Surabhi has partially delivered and she is identical with the earth and its seven *dvipas*. Since you have circumambulated her, you have also circumambulated the earth. The circumambulation of the *lingamm* yields the same fruits. O sage! O Goutama! O one who is excellent in vows! I am pleased with all your efforts, fortitude, learning and austerities. O tiger among *rishis*! I will bestow this maiden, supreme in the worlds, on you.” O sage! After saying this, I bestowed Ahalya on Goutama. After the marriage was over, the gods slowly returned, having completed the circumambulation. They saw the couple, Goutama and Ahalya, and this increased their delight. After

returning, the gods saw them and were amazed. When the marriage was over, all the gods went to heaven. Shachi's consort was full of envy. He glanced towards her and went to heaven. Pleased in my mind, I gave the great-souled Goutama the auspicious Brahmagiri, which yields all the sacred objects of desire.'

'Ahalya found pleasure with Goutama, best among sages. In heaven, Shakra heard about Goutama's sacred account. Shatakratu ⁵⁰⁰ assumed the form of a brahmana and came to the hermitage to see the sage and his unblemished wife. He saw his house, his wife and his prosperity. His mind was full of wickedness and he glanced towards Ahalya. He did not think of himself, or of others. He did not think of the time and the place. He was not scared of the *rishi*'s curse. O son! Overwhelmed by desire, Shatakratu did not comprehend any of this. He was insolent because he was the king of the gods and constantly thought about her. His limbs were heated and he thought, "What will I do? How will I enter?" He resided there in the guise of a brahmana, but did not find an opportunity to enter. On one occasion, the immensely wise Goutama went out of the hermitage along with his disciples to perform the rituals of the forenoon. He went to the hermitage on the banks of the Goutami, full of *brahmanas* and many kinds of grain. Indra, who was looking, saw that the excellent sage had left. He said, "This is my opportunity." Accordingly, he did what would bring pleasure to his mind. Desiring his beloved, Shatakratu assumed Goutama's form. He saw Ahalya, beautiful in all her limbs, and addressed her in these words. Indra said, "I am attracted towards you. Remembering your qualities and your beauty, my steps falter." Saying this, he held her by the hand and entered. Ahalya did not realize this was a paramour. She thought he was Goutama. Before Goutama returned with his disciples, they happily indulged in pleasure. When he returned, Ahalya, pleasant in speech, always went ahead to greet him. She welcomed him with pleasant words and satisfied him with her qualities. That day, the immensely wise one did not see her and thought this was exceedingly strange. O Narada! Everyone saw the best among sages standing at the door. There were those in the *agnihotra* altar. There were guards and those engaged in household duties. Scared and astounded,

they spoke to Goutama, supreme among sages. The guards said, “O illustrious one! What is this amazing incident! You are seen inside and outside. With your beloved, you entered inside. But you are outside too. How wonderful is the power of your austerities! You can assume many different kinds of forms.” Hearing this, he was surprised and entered inside. “Who has entered inside? Who is there? O beloved Ahalya! Why don’t you reply?” Hearing the *rishi*’s words, Ahalya spoke to the paramour. Ahalya asked, “Who are you in the form of the sage? You have committed a sin.” Saying this, she quickly arose from the bed, terrified. Scared of the sage, the wicked Shakra assumed the form of a cat. The sage saw that his beloved Ahalya had been forcibly outraged and defiled. He angrily exclaimed, “Who has committed this rash act?” When her husband said this, she was ashamed and did not say anything. The sage saw the cat wandering around, anxious and scared. He asked, “Who are you? If you utter a falsehood, you will be reduced to ashes.” Joining his hands in salutation, Shachi’s consort replied. Indra said, “O store of austerities! I am Shachi’s consort. Earlier, I was the one who has been praised as the destroyer of cities. ⁵⁰¹ This sin has been committed by me. O unblemished one! I am telling you the truth. O sage! I have committed an extremely reprehensible act. When a person’s heart is pierced by the arrows of the god of love, what does he not do? O brahmana! O ocean of compassion! You should pardon my great sin. The virtuous are never harsh, not even towards those who have committed crimes.” Hearing his words, full of rage, the brahmana spoke to Hari. ⁵⁰² Goutama said, “Because of your love for vaginas, you have committed a sin. Let there be one thousand vaginas in your body.” Full of rage, the sage told her, “Become a river that is dry.” She spoke to him about her transgression and sought to placate him. Ahalya said, “Even if women desire other men in their minds, they are wicked. They will be sent to hell for an eternity. All other men are like their brothers. O illustrious one! Be pacified and understand my words. He assumed your form and came to me. These people are witnesses.” The guards confirmed this and said that Ahalya was speaking the truth.’

Through his meditation, the sage also realized this. He became calm and spoke to the one who was devoted to her husband. Goutama said, ‘O fortunate one! When you come into contact with Goutami, foremost among rivers, you will become a river and again attain a form that is loved by me.’ Hearing the *rishi*’s words, this is what the one who was devoted to her husband did. Ahalya, loved by Goutama, met with that goddess. She again attained the form that had been created by me earlier. ⁵⁰³ Joining his hands in salutation, the king of the gods addressed Goutama. Indra said, ‘O tiger among sages! I am a sinner who has come to your house. Please save me.’ Seeing that he was prostrate at his feet, Goutama was filled with compassion and spoke to him. He was also placated by the large number of gods. Goutama, the excellent sage, said, ‘I will act so that Indra, Shachi’s husband, is freed from his curse. O Shachi’s consort! Bathe in the sacred *tirtha* that is the confluence of Ahalya. In an instant, you will be cleansed of your sins and have one thousand eyes.’ O Narada! I witnessed both these astounding events—Ahalya regaining her old form and Shachi’s husband obtaining one thousand eyes. Since then, the *tirtha* that is the confluence of Ahalya has been pure. It is also famous as Indra *tirtha* and grants men every object of desire.

Chapter 2(17) (Janasthana *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There is another *tirtha*, known as Janasthana. It extends for four *yojanas*. As soon as it is remembered, it bestows emancipation on men. In ancient times, in the solar dynasty, King Janaka was born. He married Gunarnava, the daughter of the lord of the waters.⁵⁰⁴ The king was the father of many Janakas who strove for *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*. His wife was similar to him in beauty and qualities. She was an ocean of qualities. Yajnavalkya, Indra among *brahmanas*, was the king’s priest. The best among kings asked the priest Yajnavalkya. Janaka said, “The best among sages have determined that the enjoyment of pleasures and emancipation are both excellent. Female servants, male servants, elephants, horses and the others are the best means of enjoying objects of pleasure. But these come to an end and are without substance. Compared to enjoyment, emancipation alone is permanent. Thus, emancipation is superior to enjoyment. While enjoying, how can one proceed towards emancipation? The pursuit of emancipation by giving up all attachment is extremely difficult. O tiger among *brahmanas*! Therefore, please tell me. How can emancipation be obtained easily?” Yajnavalkya replied, “The lord of the waters is your senior and father-in-law. He will do what brings you pleasure. O lord of men! Go to him and ask. He will instruct you about what is best for you.” Hearing Yajnavalkya’s words, King Janaka went to Varuna and asked him how one could duly proceed along the path of emancipation. Varuna said, “There are two established paths for emancipation—undertaking *karma* and refraining from *karma*. The path determined in the Vedas is that *karma* is superior to refraining from *karma*.⁵⁰⁵ The four objectives of human existence⁵⁰⁶ are all bound to *karma*. Those who say that refraining from *karma* is a path towards emancipation utter a falsehood.

O best among kings! All the crops mature through *karma*. Therefore, men who follow the Vedas must make every effort to undertake *karma*. In this way, men obtain both objects of pleasure and emancipation. *Karma* is more sacred than lack of *karma*. *Karma* depends on the *ashrama*. O Indra among kings! O one who knows about *dharma*! It also depends on one's birth. Listen. O one who bestows honours! For the four *ashramas*, there are different kinds of *karma*. Of the four *ashramas*, that of the householder is said to be the most sacred. Hence, it is my view that enjoyment and emancipation are simultaneously possible." Hearing this, Janaka and the intelligent Yajnavalkya worshipped Varuna and again addressed him in these words. "Which region and what *tirtha* bestows enjoyment and emancipation? O best among gods! You know everything. We bow down before you. Please tell us." Varuna replied, "O son! Within earth, Bharatavarsha is the most sacred and within it, Dandaka is the best. ⁵⁰⁷ Any *karma* undertaken in that *kshetra* bestows enjoyment and emancipation on men. ⁵⁰⁸ Among *tirthas*, Goutami Ganga is the best. It bestows emancipation on men. Through sacrifices and donations there, a person obtains objects of pleasure and emancipation." Hearing the words of the lord of the waters, Yajnavalkya and Janaka took their leave of Varuna and returned to their own city. King Janaka performed a horse sacrifice and other rites. Yajnavalkya, Indra among *brahmanas*, was the officiating priest for the king. Resorting to the banks of Ganga, the king undertook a sacrifice and obtained emancipation. Many other kings known as Janaka also undertook *karma* there. Through Goutami's favours, those immensely fortunate ones obtained emancipation. Since then, that *tirtha* has been famous as Janasthana. ⁵⁰⁹ Since this was the seat of sacrifices performed by Janakas, it is spoken of as Janasthana. It extends for four *yojanas*. As soon as one remembers it, all sins are cleansed. Bathing there, donating there, offering oblations to the ancestors there, remembering that *tirtha*, faithfully going there and frequenting it—through these, a person obtains all the objects of desire and emancipation.'

Chapter 2(18) (Chakra *tirtha* and the courtesan)

Brahma said, ‘O brahmana! There is a great *tirtha*, known by the name of Chakra *tirtha*. If a man bathes there faithfully, he goes to Hari’s world. O lord of the earth! ⁵¹⁰ If a person fasts on *ekadashi* in *shukla paksha* and bathes in the place known as *ganika sangama*, one obtains the eternal destination. In ancient times, an event occurred there. Listen to me attentively. There was a *vaishya* named Vishvavara and he possessed a great deal of riches. O rishi! When he was advanced in age, an excellent son was born to him. He possessed qualities and beauty. He indulged in pleasures and was handsome to behold. After some time his beloved son, whom he loved more than his own life, died. Seeing that the son was dead, the couple was full of grief. They made up their minds that they would die along with him. “Alas, son! Wicked destiny is extremely evil-souled. O ocean of qualities! Though you were in the prime of youth, he has taken you away. We love you more than our own lives, which are so difficult to obtain.” Hearing the couple lament in this way, Yama felt compassion towards them. With his mind overwhelmed by compassion, he swiftly abandoned his own city. He stood on the auspicious banks of Godavari and meditated on Janardana. Within a short time, everywhere, the subjects turned old. No one died and the earth was over-burdened with creatures. The earth filled with sounds of “This bit of ground is mine.” O excellent sage! The goddess earth quickly went to the place where Shakra, the destroyer of enemy cities was, along with the gods. Seeing the earth, Indra prostrated himself and spoke these words. Indra said, “O earth! What is the reason for your coming here? Please tell me.” The earth replied, “O Shakra! Since no one is dying, I am suffering from a heavy burden. I have come to ask the reason for this. Please tell me.” Hearing what the earth said, Indra spoke these words. Indra

said, “Had there been a reason, I would have known it by now. I am the unwavering lord of all the gods.” Hearing these words, the earth replied to Shachi’s consort. “Please command Yama that he should destroy subjects.” O great sage! Hearing the earth’s words, the great Indra instructed the *siddhas* and the *kinnaras* that Yama should quickly be brought before him. All of them swiftly went to Vaivasvata’s ⁵¹¹ city. The *siddhas* and the *kinnaras* did not see Yama there. They quickly returned and reported this account to Shakra. The *siddhas* and *kinnaras* said, “O lord! We could not see Yama in Yama’s city. With great care, we looked in every direction.” Hearing their words, Shakra asked Savitar, ⁵¹² Yama’s father, “Where is he?” Surya replied, “O Shakra! Kritanta ⁵¹³ is now on the banks of Godavari. He is performing extremely fierce austerities there. I don’t know the reason.” Hearing Bhanu’s words, Shakra was worried. Shakra said, “Alas, this is a hardship. This is a great calamity. My lordship over the gods will be destroyed. Yama is making wicked efforts, performing austerities near Godavari. O gods! It is my view that he certainly desires to seize my position.” Stating this, Indra instantly summoned the large number of *apsaras*.’

‘Indra asked, “Who amongst you is capable of standing before the austerities of Yama, ⁵¹⁴ my enemy? Who possesses the capacity to destroy his austerities? Tell me quickly.” O great sage! Hearing Shakra’s words, no one spoke. In great rage, Shakra spoke to the large number of *apsaras* again. Indra said, “Not a single one has said anything. Therefore, we will ourselves go. O gods! Get ready. Without any delay, let the soldiers be brought. We will slay the enemy who desires to obtain heaven through his austerities.” When this was said, the soldiers of the gods presented themselves. Hari, who holds up the worlds, got to know what was in Indra’s mind. For Yama’s protection, the wielder of the *chakra* sent his *chakra*. The supreme Chakra *tirtha* is the place where the *chakra* manifested itself. Menaka, who was scared, addressed Indra in these words. Menaka said, “O lord of the gods! Not a single one among us is capable of looking at Kala. O god! It is better to die at your hands rather than at the hands of Yama. O lord! You should ask this courtesan who thinks she possesses youth and

beauty. She accepts your lordship and you should send her.” Hearing her words, Shakra, the supreme lord of the gods, honoured the courtesan Kshama and commanded the woman. Shakra said, “O courtesan! O beautiful one! Go and perform my task without any delay. Accomplish your objective and return. I will love you, just as I love Shachi.” Hearing Shakra’s words, the courtesan leapt up, over the directions. In a short while, beautiful in form, she reached Yama’s presence. Illuminating the ten directions, she approached Yama. The maiden sang in beautiful tones and danced and swung gracefully. Kala’s fickle mind wavered. The mobile and immobile objects seemed to be agitated. Full of the fire of desire, Yama opened his eyes. O great sage! Her conduct was inimical towards what was good for him. Before his gaze, she instantly melted and attained the state of becoming a river. The extremely fortunate one merged with Goutami. As the large number of courtesans and servants sung her praise, because of the powers of the *tirtha*, she went to heaven. On seeing the courtesan astride a *vimana* proceeding towards heaven, Kala’s darting eyes were filled with great wonder. The sun-god approached Yama and spoke to him. Surya said, “O son! Perform your own task of destroying subjects. Behold the wind that blows, the creator creating subjects, me traversing the three worlds and the earth carrying subjects.”⁵¹⁵ Hearing his father’s words, Yama addressed him in these words. Yama replied, “I will certainly not carry out this reprehensible task. It is an extremely cruel task. You should not command me to undertake it.” Hearing these words, Bhanu spoke the following words. “O Yama! How is your task tainted and condemned? Did you not see the courtesan, wet with water from Goutami, who just left for heaven with large numbers of courtesans and servants singing her praise? O son! You have undertaken extremely difficult and fierce austerities here. I do not see an end to this. Therefore, go to your own city.” Saying this, the illustrious Bhanu bathed there and went to heaven. Bathing at the confluence, Yama also left for his own city. O great sage! The slayer of beings thus discarded his great doubt. Seeing that Yama had departed, the *chakra* also returned to the place where Govinda was, adorned with a garland of wild flowers. If a

mortal person controls himself and reads or hears this, all his calamities are destroyed and he obtains a long lifespan.'

Chapter 2(19) (Ashvabhanu *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘O supreme sage! The two rivers Aruna and Varuna are extremely sacred and auspicious. Their confluence with Ganga is also extremely sacred. This place is more sacred than Manasa, Prayaga and Mandakini and destroys every kind of sin. Hear about its origin. Kashyapa’s eldest son, Aditya, ⁵¹⁶ is famous in the worlds. He is the eye of the three worlds. His rays are sharp. He has seven horses and is worshipped by the worlds. His wife, Usha, is Tvashta’s daughter and is the most beautiful woman in the three worlds. The extremely slender-waisted one was incapable of withstanding her husband’s sharp heat. The beautiful one thought, “What will I do?” Her sons were the extremely wise Manu and Vaivasvata Yama. ⁵¹⁷ Her daughter was the sacred river, Yamuna. Hear about the wonderful way this came about. She took great care to create her shadow, with a form that was exactly like her own. Usha told her, “Be like me. Instructed by me, nurture my husband and children. Until I return, be loved by him and my children. You should not reveal this to anyone, my beloved or the children.” When Chhaya ⁵¹⁸ agreed, Usha left the house. Having said this, she swiftly departed, desiring a serene form. She went to the house of her father, Tvashta, and told him everything. Tvashta was surprised. Since he loved his children, he spoke to his daughter. Tvashta said, “When a husband exists, a wife should not freely act in this way. How will your children manage? What will happen to your husband, Savitar? O fortunate one! I am virtuous and I am scared. Return to your husband’s house again.” Thus addressed by her father, she repeatedly refused. She went to the region of Uttara Kuru and performed austerities there. Assuming the form of a mare, she tormented herself through fierce

austerities there. Usha unwaveringly meditated on her beloved, whose form was impossible to behold.’

‘O son! Meanwhile, in Usha’s form, Chhaya lived with her husband and children were born. They were Savarni ⁵¹⁹ and Shani. There was also a wicked daughter, named Vishti. Chhaya always differentiated in her dealings with her own children and those of Usha. Yama became angry at this. Since Chhaya’s conduct was partial, Yama, the lord of the southern direction, struck his mother with his foot. Agitated at her son’s wickedness, Usha cursed Vaivasvata Yama. “At my command, your foot will fall down.” With his foot destroyed, he wept miserably and went to his father. He told Savitar everything that had happened. Yama said, “O best among the gods! Since she has cursed me in this way, she cannot possibly be my mother. Even if a child acts in a contrary way, a mother is never enraged. I may have said something in my childishness. I may even have committed a wicked act. But a mother never becomes angry. Therefore, she is not my mother. Irrespective of whether a child does something good or bad, a mother tolerates everything. That is the reason she is known as a mother. O father! She constantly looks at me with eyes that seem to burn me down. When she speaks to me, her words are like the fire of destruction. She is not my mother.” Hearing his son’s words, Savitar became thoughtful. ⁵²⁰ “This is Chhaya, not his mother. Usha, his mother, is elsewhere. Desiring that I become serene, she is in some other region, performing austerities. Tvashta’s daughter is in the Uttara Kuru region, in the form of a mare.” Knowing that she was there, Divakara ⁵²¹ went to the spot where his beloved was.’

‘He himself assumed the form of a horse. On seeing her in the form of a mare, in the form of a horse, he rushed towards her. Usha saw a horse, in the throes of desire. She heard the sound of the neighing. Usha was devoted to her husband. She was devoted to meditating on her husband. She did not know who it was and was scared of being ravished by the horse. When her husband approached her, she swiftly fled in a southern direction. “Who will save me now, the *rishis* or the gods?” As his beloved fled in the form of a mare, he himself pursued her in the form of a horse. Wherever Usha went,

Bhanu followed. When a person is seized and comes under the control of desire, what wicked act is he not capable of performing? Heading in the southern direction, the two of them crossed Bhagirathi and other rivers, forests, groves, Narmada and the Vindhyas. Anxious and terrified, Tvastha's daughter went to Goutami. It has been heard that there are sages in Janasthana who protect. Arriving in the region of Goutami, the mare entered a hermitage of *rishis*. Bhanu also followed her, in the form of a horse. The residents of Janasthana tried to restrain the horse. Full of rage, the lord who was Usha's husband cursed them. Bhanu said, "Since you have restrained me, you will become *vata* trees." ⁵²² Through their insight of *jnana*, the sages knew that the horse was Usha's husband. The sages happily praised Bhanu, the lord of the gods. Praised by the large number of sages, Bhanu approached the mare. In the form of the horse, his face touched the face of the mare. Realizing that it was her husband, Tvastha's daughter released the semen through her mouth. Through this semen, the two Ashvins ⁵²³ were born in Ganga. The large number of gods, the *siddhas*, the sages, the male rivers, the female rivers, the herbs, the large number of stellar bodies, Aruna, Bhanu's charioteer, with the sacred chariot drawn by seven horses, Yama, Manu, Varuna, Vaivasvata Shani, the sacred river Yamuna, Tapi and Mahanadi arrived there. O sage! The rivers were amazed at his form.'

'Full of wonder, his father-in-law also arrived, to see what has happening. Understanding his father-in-law's intention, Bhanu spoke. Bhanu said, "O Tvastha! Usha has performed excellent austerities. For her sake, mount me on your machine and pare off a lot of energy. O Prajapati! Pare off parts until she is pleased." Near Somanatha, ⁵²⁴ in the place known as Prabhasa, he started to slice off the energy. There is a place near Goutami, where she met with her husband, in the form of a horse. That is the place where the Ashvins originated and it is known as Ashva *tirtha*. The hermitage where five *vata* trees exist is known as Bhanu *tirtha*. Tapi ⁵²⁵ and Yamuna arrived to see their father. There is an auspicious confluence of the rivers Aruna and Varuna with Ganga. Associated with the gods who arrived, there are separate *tirthas* there. There are twenty-seven thousand such *tirthas*, all possessing qualities. Bathing and donating there, yield all the

inexhaustible good merits. O Narada! If a person remembers, reads or hears it, he is freed from all sins. He becomes devoted to *dharma* and is happy.'

Chapter 2(20) (Garuda *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The *tirtha* named Garuda pacifies all kinds of impediments. I will tell you about its powers. O Narada! Listen attentively. There was a great serpent named Maninaga. He was Shesha’s son. Scared of Garuda, he devotedly propitiated Shankara. The illustrious Parameshthi Maheshvara was pleased at this. He told the great *naga*, “O *pannaga*! Ask for a boon.” The *naga* replied, “O lord! Grant me freedom from fear of Garuda.” Shambhu agreed and said, “You will no longer suffer any fear on account of Garuda.” The *naga* emerged, no longer scared of Garuda, Aruna’s younger brother. He went near the ocean of milk, where the one who lies down on the ocean of milk ⁵²⁶ was. The *naga* wandered around here and there, in a place that was pleasant and cool. Garuda also went to that region. He saw the *pannaga* roaming around fearlessly. He seized the great *naga* and brought him to his own residence. Garuda bound that excellent *naga* in Garuda’s nooses.

‘Meanwhile, Nandi spoke to Isha, the lord of the universe. Nandikeshvara said, “O lord of the gods! The *naga* must certainly have been devoured or bound by Garuda. He may not be alive. He is not wandering around.” Hearing Nandi’s words and understanding what had happened, Shambhu said the following. Shambhu said, “The *naga* has been bound and is in Garuda’s home. Quickly go and tell Vishnu Janardana, the lord of the universe. Though I have myself given him the word, the *naga* has been bound by Kashyapa’s son.” ⁵²⁷ Hearing the lord’s words, Nandi went to Shri’s lord and reported these words to Vishnu, the refuge of the worlds. Pleased, Narayana addressed Garuda in these words. Vishnu said, “O Vinata’s son! Follow my words and hand over the *pannaga* to Nandi.”

Though the bird who was Vinata's son understood, he refused. In Nandi's presence, Suparna⁵²⁸ addressed Vishnu in words that were full of rage.

'Garuda said, "O Vishnu! Other masters give their servants what they like. Not only do you not do that, you take away what they have obtained. Behold! The three-eyed divinity will free the *naga* through Nandi. But you wish to give Nandi the *naga* I have captured. I always carry you along your path. Therefore, you must always give me something. I have captured the *naga* and you should not ask me to give him away. This should not be the conduct of virtuous masters who wish to ensure good conduct. The virtuous give to their servants. But you are taking away what I have obtained. O Keshava! It is through my strength that you defeat the *daityas* in battle. In vain do you boast that you possess great strength." While the guardians of the worlds watched, in Nandi's presence, the wielder of the *chakra* and the mace heard Garuda's words and laughed. The immensely intelligent one said, "O supreme bird! Indeed, I do defeat all the *asuras* through your strength. By bearing me, you have become extremely lean." O brahmana! After saying this, the rage of Shri's lord was pacified. He continued, "In Nandi's presence, bear the little finger of my hand." He placed the finger on Garuda's head and said, "O bird! You have spoken the truth. Look towards your *dharma*." When the finger was laid on his head, it entered his stomach. From the stomach, it went to the extremities of his feet. It entered and seemed to crush him. He was distressed and suffered. Full of shame, he joined his hands in salutation and spoke. Garuda cried, "Save me! O lord of the universe! Save me! Your servant has committed a crime. You are the master of all the worlds. You are the support and you are also the one who is supported. O Vishnu! The powerful pardon thousands of offences. Even for those who are sinners, your compassion is great. All the sages say that you are a store of compassion. O mother of the universe! O one who resides in the lotus! I am suffering. Please save me. O Kamala!⁵²⁹ I am miserable and suffering. I am a child and you are devoted to your children." Taking pity, the goddess Shri spoke to Janardana. Kamala said, "O lord! Save your own servant, Garuda. He is facing a calamity." At this, Janardana spoke to Nandi, Shambhu's servant. Vishnu said, "Take the *naga* and Garuda to

Shambhu's presence. When Maheshvara looks at Garuda, through his favours, Garuda will get back his own form again." Thus addressed, the bull, ⁵³⁰ the *naga* and Garuda slowly went to Shankara and told him everything. Shankara, with the moon on his forehead, spoke to Garuda. Shiva said, "O mighty-armed one! Go to Goutami Ganga, the purifier of the worlds. She is serene and grants all the objects of desire. Once you have bathed in her, you will get your form back. You will accomplish hundreds and thousands of your wishes. There are those who are tormented by all kinds of sins. There are those whose efforts are ruined by adverse destiny. Such beings obtain their desires through Goutami. O bird! Seek refuge with her." Hearing his words, Garuda prostrated himself and went there. Bathing in Ganga, Garuda bowed down to Shiva and Vishnu. The bird's body turned golden and became as firm as the *vajra*. He became immensely strong. O best among sages! The intelligent one speedily rushed to Vishnu. Since then, that place has been known as Garuda *tirtha* and yields all the objects of desire. O son! It is a place loved by Shiva and Vishnu. Anything that a man does there, bathing and other rites, bring inexhaustible benefits.'

Chapter 2(21) (Govardhana *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There is Govardhana *tirtha*. It destroys every kind of sin. For the ancestors, it generates everything that is auspicious. Even if it is remembered, it destroys sins. O Narada! I have witnessed its powers. There was a brahmana known as Jabali. He was a farmer. Even when the sun touched midday, he did not release his two bulls. He struck them on the back and on the sides with his whip. On seeing those two bulls with their eyes full of tears, Surabhi,⁵³¹ the mother of the universe, who yields all the objects of desire, told Nandi everything. He was also distressed and told Shambhu everything. Shambhu told the bull,⁵³² “Everything that you say will come true.” With Shiva’s permission, Nandi took away all the cattle species. All the cattle, in heaven and in the mortal world were swiftly destroyed. The large number of gods came to me and said, “Without cows, it is impossible to live.” I told all the gods, “Go to Shankara and ask him.” All of them praised Isha and told him what needed to be done. Isha told the gods, “My bull knows everything.” The immortals spoke to the bull. “Give us the cows and the bulls. They give us benefits.” The bull told the gods, “Perform the sacrifice known as *gosava*. Through this, you will get back all the cattle, divine as well as human.” Thus, the sacrifice of *gosava*, devised by the gods, was started on the auspicious banks of Goutami and cattle flourished. This *tirtha* of Govardhana⁵³³ enhanced the pleasure of the gods. O best among sages! If one bathes there, this yields the fruits of donating thousands of cows. We do not know the fruits of performing even a little bit of donations there.⁵³⁴ If one sees Goutameshvara Shankara,⁵³⁵ the lord of the gods, one obtains the world of heaven for as long as Meru lasts.’

Chapter 2(22) (Papapranashana *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There is a *tirtha* named Papapranashana. ⁵³⁶ It dispels fear of sins. I will tell you how it came by that name. O Narada! Listen attentively. There was a brahmana who was known in the worlds as Dhritavrata. His wife was named Mahi. She was young and was the most beautiful woman in the world. Their son was known as Sannajata and he was like the sun in complexion. O sage! Death, urged by Kala took Dhritavrata away. She became a young widow who was extremely beautiful and she had a young son. Unable to see a protector, she went to Galava’s hermitage. After entrusting his son to him, the *svairini*, confounded by sin, wandered around in many countries. She followed her desires and sought out men. In Galava’s house, the son became accomplished in the Vedas and the *Vedangas*. However, because of the sins of his mother, ever since he was born, his mind turned towards courtesans. There is a place known as Janasthana and it was full of people from different classes. ⁵³⁷ Mahi lived there, surviving as a woman who sold herself. Her lecherous son also wandered around in many countries. Under the subjugation of destiny, he came to reside in Janasthana. Desiring women, the brahmana who was Dhritavrata’s son looked for a harlot. Mahi also waited for men who would give her some wealth. She did not know her son and the son did not know his mother. As a result of destiny, there was intercourse between the mother and the son. In this way, many days passed and the son used to have intercourse with the mother. They possessed no knowledge about their mutual relationship of being a mother and a son. Though this was his conduct, he possessed sufficient knowledge to follow his father’s *dharma*. O Narada! Listen to the wonderful event that occurred. Though he acted as he willed, the brahmana did not give up the rituals practiced at the time of

sandhya. When this was done, he sought to earn wealth. Because of the strength of his learning, he earned a lot of riches and gave it to her. In the morning, he would get up and go to Ganga to perform the rituals. He purified himself, bathed and observed all the *sandhya* rites in the due order. Having done this, he would bow down before *brahmanas* and be cleansed of his sins. When he went to Goutami in the morning, he was ugly. His limbs were lax because of leprosy and pus and blood would flow. Having bathed in Goutami Ganga, he would become exceedingly handsome. He was peaceful and resembled the sun or the fire. He seemed to be the embodied form of the sun. The brahmana was himself not aware that he possessed two different forms.

‘The illustrious Galava was devoted to austerities and *jnana*. At that time, surrounded by sages, he sought refuge in Goddess Goutami. The brahmana always came to that *tirtha*. Bowing down before Galava, he always went to his own residence. Galava always noticed both of the brahmana’s forms—the form that Sannajata possessed before bathing in Ganga and the brahmana’s form after bathing and the *sandhya* rites. On seeing this, he was astounded and wondered, “What is the reason for this?” Full of amazement, Galava spoke to the brahmana, just as Sannajata was leaving for his house, after bowing down before his *guru*.⁵³⁸ Because of wonder and compassion, the intelligent one carefully summoned him. Galava asked, “Who are you? Where will you go? What do you do? What do you eat? What is your name? Where do you sleep? Who is your wife? Please tell me.” Hearing Galava’s words, the brahmana replied to the sage. The brahmana said, “I will tell you everything tomorrow. Knowing this, one should determine what needs to be done.” Telling Galava this, Sannajata went home. Having eaten properly, he lay down at night with the courtesan. Suddenly remembering Galava’s words, he addressed her in these words. The brahmana said, “You possess all the qualities. Though you are a courtesan, you behave like a woman who is devoted to her husband.”⁵³⁹ Our love is mutual and similar. We should live like this for the rest of our lives. Nevertheless, there is something I must ask you. What is your name? What is your family? Where do you come from? Who are your relatives? Tell me everything.” The courtesan replied, “There

was a brahmana known as Dhritavrata. He was initiated and pure. I am his wife, Mahi. My son is in Galava's hermitage. I left him there. The child is intelligent and is known as Sannajata. Because of my former sins, I abandoned my *dharma* and my family and came here. O brahmana! Though I am residing here as a *svairini*, know that I am a brahmana lady." When he heard her words, it was as if his inner organs were pierced. He suddenly fell down on the ground. The courtesan addressed him in these words. The courtesan asked, "O best among *brahmanas*! What has happened to you? Where has your love gone? Have the words I spoke led to a change in your feelings?" Comforting and reassuring himself, the brahmana addressed her in the following words. The brahmana replied, "The brahmana, Dhritavrata was my father. I am his son, Sannajata. Goaded by destiny, my mother, Mahi, has come here." Hearing his words, she became extremely miserable. Both of them grieved throughout the night.'

'When the sparkling sun dawned, the brahmana went to Galava, the tiger among sages and told him everything. The brahmana said, "O brahmana! I am the son of Dhritavrata. You had reared me earlier. O lord! My mother, Mahi and I have come before you. What shall I do? How will I be cleansed?" Hearing the brahmana's words, Galava became full of compassion and spoke these words. "I had earlier noticed the two forms in you every day. That is the reason I had asked you about your account. I have heard and understood everything. Everything that you did was cleansed as soon as you went to Ganga. Through the greatness of this *tirtha* and through the favours of the goddess, you were cleansed every day. O son! There is nothing to think about. Every day and every morning, your form used to be full of sin. Thereafter, I have seen your form, possessing all the qualities. When you came, you were full of sin. When you departed, you were without blemish. I have witnessed this every day. You have now been purified by the goddess. Therefore, there is nothing else that remains to be done. O brahmana! This mother of yours is known as a courtesan. However, she has repented and has refrained from sinning again. O son! For all creatures, affection is a natural attribute. But if one associates with virtuous people, great merits are reaped and through destiny, one can achieve *nivritti*.

Because of her earlier good conduct, she has repented a lot. Bathing in this *tirtha*, she will become purified.” O Narada! The mother and the son acted accordingly. When they bathed, there is no doubt that they were cleansed of their sins. Since that time, this *tirtha* has been known as Dhoutapapa. ⁵⁴⁰ It is also famous as Papapranashana and Galava. Whether one commits a grave sin or a trifling sin, all sins are destroyed at Dhoutapapa. It bestows extremely great merits.’

Chapter 2(23) (Vishvamitra *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘O brahmana! To its south, ⁵⁴¹ there is an extremely rare *tirtha*. It is known as Pitri *tirtha*. It is sacred and destroys all sins. O brahmana! Along with Sita, Dasharatha’s son, Rama, offered oblations and satisfied the ancestors ⁵⁴² there. That is the reason it is known as Pitri *tirtha*. Bathing, donating and offering oblations to the ancestors there, brings everlasting benefits. There is no need to think about this. This is the place where Dasharatha’s son Rama, Indra among kings, worshipped the great sage Vishvamitra and the other sages who know about the truth. This is the extremely sacred Vishvamitra *tirtha* and it bestows great benefits. I will tell you about its nature, as it has been read by those who know about the Vedas. Earlier, there was a drought that was extremely terrible for subjects. Along with his disciples, the immensely wise Vishvamitra arrived at Goutami. He saw that his disciples, sons and wife were suffering from hunger and were emaciated. Miserable, the resplendent Koushika ⁵⁴³ spoke to his disciples. Vishvamitra said, “Get whatever can be obtained, wherever. Without any delay, get something that can be eaten. Go and bring it back quickly.” Hearing the *rishi*’s words, the hungry disciples quickly left. Wandering around here and there, they saw a dead dog. Picking this up, they quickly returned and offered it to their preceptor. Saying, “This is good,” he accepted it with his hand. “Slice up the dog’s meat. Wash it with water. Utter the *mantras* and cook it. Follow the norms and offer oblations into the fire. When the gods, *rishis*, ancestors, *atithis*, *gurus* and others have been satisfied, we will eat what is left.” This is what Koushika said. Hearing Vishvamitra’s words, the disciples acted accordingly.

‘When the flesh of the dog had been cooked, Agni, the messenger of the gods, went to the abode of the gods and told the gods everything. Agni said,

“Since the *rishi* has thought of this, the gods must now eat a dog’s flesh.” At Agni’s words, Indra assumed the form of a hawk. He flew through the sky and stole the vessel that was full of the flesh.’ Witnessing his deed, the disciples went and told the *rishi* about the hawk. ‘O best among sages! The hawk has no sense and has stolen the vessel.’ The illustrious one was enraged and desired to curse Hari. ⁵⁴⁴ Learning this, the lord of the gods filled the vessel with honey. With the speed of a meteor, Hari, in the form of a bird, placed the vessel back. On seeing that it was filled with honey, Vishvamitra became angry. Glancing at the vessel, Koushika spoke in rage. Vishvamitra said, “Please take away this excellent *amrita* and give us the dog’s flesh. Otherwise, I will reduce you to ashes.” Terrified, Indra replied. Indra said, “Follow the norms and offer oblations of honey. Drink it with your sons. O great sage! Why this flesh of a dog? It is not suitable for an offering.” Vishvamitra said, “No. What is gained if I am the only one who gets to eat? All the subjects are suffering. O Hari! What purpose will your honey serve? If everyone gets to eat the *amrita*, then I will also eat the pure *amrita*. Otherwise, let the gods and the ancestors also eat the flesh of a dog. Thereafter, I will also eat that flesh. I do not utter a falsehood.” Scared, the one with the one thousand eyes instantly summoned the clouds. They showered down *amrita* and this *amrita* satisfied the subjects. When this had been done, the brahmana, Vishvamitra, followed the rituals and used the sacred *amrita* given by Hari to first satisfy the gods and the three worlds. Along with his disciples and wife, he then ate it. Since then, that *tirtha* has been described as one that confers great merits. It is a place where the lord of the gods came and *amrita*, without meat, was offered. Because of this, that *tirtha* brings great benefit to men. Bathing and donating there bestows the fruits of all sacrifices. Since then, it has been known as Vishvamitra *tirtha*. The *tirtha* is also named after Madhu, Indra, Shyena and Parjanya.’

Chapter 2(24) (Shveta and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The auspicious place known as Shveta tirtha is famous in the three worlds. Even if a person remembers it, he is freed from all sins. Earlier, there was a brahmana named Shveta and he was Goutama’s beloved friend. He resided on the banks of Goutami and was always devoted to worshipping *atithis*. In his thoughts, words and deeds, he was devoted to Shiva. The best among *brahmanas* always meditated on Shiva and worshipped him. Till the end of his life, that excellent brahmana was devoted to Shiva. The messengers of the lord of the southern direction came to take him away.⁵⁴⁶ O Narada! However, they were incapable of entering his house. When the time passed, Chitraka spoke to Mrityu.⁵⁴⁷ Chitraka said, “O Mrityu! Why has Shveta not arrived yet? His lifespan is over. Mrityu’s servants have also not returned. This is not appropriate.” Mrityu became angry and himself went to Shveta’s house. He saw Mrityu’s messengers standing outside the house, scared. Mrityu asked the messengers, “O messengers! What is the matter?” The messengers replied, “Please pardon us. Shveta is protected by Shiva and we are incapable of looking at him. If Girisha⁵⁴⁸ is pleased with a person, he has no reason to be afraid.” With a noose in his hand, Mrityu entered the place where the brahmana was. The brahmana did not realize that Mrityu and Yama’s messengers had come. He was devotedly worshipping Shiva. Nandi saw Mrityu, noose in his hand, approach Shveta and was amazed. Nandi said, “O Mrityu! What are you looking at here?” Mrityu replied to Nandi. Mrityu said, “I have come here to take Shveta away. Therefore, I am looking at the excellent brahmana.” Nandi replied, “Go away.” O tiger among sages! However, Mrityu hurled his noose towards Shveta and Nandi became angry. Nandi struck Mrityu with the staff given by Shiva. With the noose in his

hand, Mrityu fell down on the ground. The messengers saw that Mrityu had been struck down. They swiftly went to Yama and reported that Nandi had struck Mrityu down. At this, Dharma Yama was enraged. Astride his buffalo, he summoned Chitragupta, Kala, the protector in the form of Yama's staff, the buffalo, *bhutas*, *vetalas*,⁵⁴⁹ physical ailments, mental ailments, diseases of the eyes, diseases of the stomach, diseases of the ears, the three kinds of fever,⁵⁵⁰ and the different kinds of sins and hells. Yama asked them to hurry. Surrounded by all these, Yama went to the place where Shveta, supreme among *brahmanas*, was. Seeing Yama advance, Nandi raised his weapon and spoke to Vinayaka, Skanda and the leader of the *bhutas*, who held a staff. A clash ensued and it was fearful to all beings. Kartikeya used his spear to pierce Yama's servants. He powerfully struck the lord of the southern directions himself. Those of Yama's followers who were left went and reported this to Aditya. Along with the gods, Aditya heard of this extraordinary event. Surrounded by the guardians of the worlds, they approached me. I, the illustrious Vishnu, Indra, Agni, Varuna, Chandra, Aditya, the two Ashvins, the guardians of the world, the large number of Maruts and many others went to Yama. The powerful lord of the southern directions was lying down on the banks of Ganga, dead. The oceans, the rivers, the *nagas* and many kinds of beings gathered there to see the lord of the gods, Vaivasvata Yama. Seeing that Yama and his soldiers had been killed, the gods were afflicted by fear. All of them joined their hands in salutation and repeatedly praised Shambhu. The gods said, "You are always favourable towards your devotees and slay those who are wicked. You are the original creator. We bow down before you. O Nilakantha!⁵⁵¹ We bow down before you. O one who loves Brahma! We bow down before you. O one who loves the gods! We bow down before you. The brahmana Shveta is devoted to you. His lifespan came to an end, but Yama and all the others were incapable of taking him away. Glance at us with great contentment. You love your devotees. You are truly the protector. You are the refuge of those who seek refuge with you. You are compassionate. Even Kritanta⁵⁵² is incapable of looking at you. O Shiva! Having learnt this, all of them are worshipping you with great devotion.

You are the protector of the universe. You are the lord of the universe. O lord! With your exception, who is capable of ordaining anything?" Praised in this way, Shiva appeared in front of them. Cheerfully, he asked the gods, "What can I give you?" The gods replied, 'Vaivasvata controls *dharma* in all those with bodies. He is a guardian of the world and establishes the practice of *dharma* and *adharma*. He does not deserve to be killed. He has not committed a crime. He is no sinner. Without him, the task of holding up the world cannot be undertaken. O lord of the gods! Therefore, along with his soldiers and mounts, please revive him. O protector! A request made to a great person is never futile.' The illustrious one replied, 'If the gods agree to what I say, there is no doubt that Yama will come back to life.' All the gods said, 'We will certainly act in accordance with your words. Along with Hari and Brahma, the entire universe is under your control.' At this, the illustrious one told the assembled immortals, 'Let my devotee not die.' The immortals replied, 'That is not possible. Everything in the worlds, mobile and immobile, will then become immortal. O lord who pervades the universe! There will be no difference between the mortal and the immortal.' Shambhu spoke again. 'Listen to my words. Vishnu and I are the lords of those who are devoted to me and those who are devoted to Vishnu. If such devotees come to Goutami, Mrityu will have no control over them. Let Yama never act against this agreement. They should never suffer from physical ailments or mental ailments. Anyone who seeks refuge with Shiva will be instantly emancipated. Yama and all his followers should bow down before them.' All the gods told Shiva, the lord of the gods, that they agreed to this. The illustrious lord then spoke to his mount, Nandi. Shiva said, 'Sprinkle the dead Yama with water from Goutami.' Nandi sprinkled Yama and all the others. All of them were revived and arose. They left for the southern direction.'

'Vishnu and all the other gods remained on the northern bank of Goutami. Remaining there, they worshipped Maheshvara, the lord of the gods. There are eight thousand, fourteen thousand, six thousand and six thousand *tirthas* there. ⁵⁵³ There are six thousand and three thousand *tirthas* on the southern bank. ⁵⁵⁴ O Narada! I have described to you the sacred

account of Shveta *tirtha*. The place where Mrityu fell down is known as Mrityu *tirtha*. Even if one hears about it, one lives for one thousand years. Bathing and donating there, destroy all sins. If one hears or reads about it, or remembers it, all impurities are destroyed. For everyone, it bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation.'

Chapter 2(25) (Shukra *tirtha*, Mritasanjivani *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Shukra *tirtha* brings every kind of success to men. It destroys every kind of sin. It destroys every kind of ailment. The two *rishis*, Angiras and Bhrigu, were extremely devoted to *dharma*. Both of them had sons who were extremely wise. They possessed beauty and intelligence. They were known as Jiva and Kavi and they were devoted to their parents. ⁵⁵⁵ On seeing that the sons had been initiated, fathers spoke to each other. The *rishis* said, “Our sons are always controlled. Therefore, only one of us needs to be the instructor. The other one can do as he wills.” Hearing this, Angiras quickly spoke to Bhrigu. ⁵⁵⁶ “I will teach them equally. O Bhrigu! Do what you will.’ Hearing the words of Angiras, Bhrigu agreed with Angiras and entrusted Shukra to Angiras. However, since he was partial in his attitude, he taught the two sons separately. After some time, Shuka spoke. Shukra said, “O *guru*! You always discriminate in the way you teach me. It is not appropriate for a *guru* to differentiate between sons and disciples. Only foolish and ordinary teachers differentiate between disciples. If a person’s intelligence causes discrimination, his sins become innumerable. O *acharya*! ⁵⁵⁷ I have understood you correctly. I bow down before you repeatedly. I will go to another *guru*. Please grant me permission. O brahmana! I will go to my father. If his behaviour is also discriminatory, I will go somewhere else. O lord! Please grant me permission to leave.’ He, thus, took leave of his *guru* and also took Brihaspati’s leave. He thought he would go to his father after having obtained learning. Therefore, he thought, “Who will be my *guru*? Who will be the best?” Thinking in this way, he asked the immensely wise and aged Goutama. Shukra asked, “O best among sages! Please tell me.

Who is a *guru*? Who, in the three worlds, can be my *guru*? I will go to that *guru*.” He told him, “The divinity Shambhu, the lord of the universe, is the *guru* of the universe.” Shukra asked, “How can I see the lord of the gods? How can I worship Girisha?” Thus addressed, Goutama replied to him. Goutama said, “Go to Goutami and purify yourself. Praise Shankara with hymns. When he is pleased, the lord of the universe will bestow learning on you.” Hearing Goutama’s words, Bhargava ⁵⁵⁸ first went to Ganga. The child bathed and purified himself and praised in the proper way. Shukra said, “O lord of the distressed! You are the only refuge. O Shambhu! I seek refuge with you. I am a child. My intelligence is that of a child. O lord who wears the young moon! I do not know anything about how one should praise you. I bow down before you. I have been abandoned by my *guru*. I do not have well-wishers or friends. You are my lord in every possible way. O lord of the universe! I bow down before you. O god! You are heavier than the heaviest. ⁵⁵⁹ You are greater than the greatest. I am only a slight child. O one who pervades the universe! I bow down before you. O lord of the gods! I have come to you for the sake of learning. I do not know anything about your ways. Look on me with compassion. O witness to the worlds! I bow down before you.” Praised in this way, the lord of the gods was pleased. Shiva said, “O fortunate one! Ask for your desired boon, even if it is extremely difficult for the gods to obtain.” Joining his hands in salutation, Kavi, extensive in his intelligence, spoke to the lord of the gods. Shukra said, “There is learning that Brahma and the others, the noble *rishis*, do not have access to. O lord! I seek that learning from you. You are my *guru*. You are my divinity.” The knowledge of Mritasanjivani ⁵⁶⁰ is unknown even to the gods. When Shukra asked, the best among the gods bestowed that on him. That apart, he gave him general knowledge from the Vedas, unknown to others. When Shankara is pleased, where is the need to think about what remains? Having obtained this great knowledge, he went to his father. Kavi was worshipped because of his learning and became the *guru* of the *daityas*. On another occasion, because of a different reason, Brihaspati’s son, Kacha, obtained this knowledge from Kavi. Brihaspati obtained this from Kacha and the different gods also separately obtained it. This great knowledge is

known of as Mritasanjivani. This is the knowledge Kavi obtained after worshipping Maheshvara. Shukra *tirtha* is said to be on the northern bank of Goutami. This is Mritasanjivani *tirtha*. It grants a long lifespan and freedom from disease. Anything undertaken there, bathing and donating, confers inexhaustible good merits.'

Chapter 2(26) (Seven thousand *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The famous Indra *tirtha* destroys the sin of killing a brahmana. Even if a person remembers it, a large number of sins and hardships are destroyed. O Narada! Earlier when Vritra was killed, the sin of killing a brahmana pursued and terrified Hari, Shachi’s consort. Indra, Vritra’s slayer, rushed around here and there, but it also followed him. Wherever he went, that sin of killing followed Indra. He entered a great lake and hid inside the stalk of a lotus. Hiding inside the fibres, Shachi’s consort resided there. The sin of killing waited on the shores of the lake for one thousand divine years. O sage! During all this time, the gods were without an Indra. They anxiously consulted among themselves, “How can we possibly get an Indra?” Thinking about the place where the slaying had taken place, I told the gods, “For the sake of purifying Indra, sprinkle him with water from Goutami. When he is sprinkled in this way, Indra will again turn pure.” Making up their minds to do this, they quickly went to Goutami. The gods and the *rishis* wished to bathe the lord of the gods there. All of them desired to sprinkle Shachi’s beloved there. However, as Indra was about to be sprinkled, Goutama angrily spoke to them. Goutama said, “You wish to sprinkle the great Indra. He is wicked and has violated his *guru*’s bed. ⁵⁶¹ O noble gods! Leave swiftly. Otherwise, I will reduce all of you to ashes.” Hearing the *rishi*’s words, they left Goutami. Taking Indra with them, they quickly went to Narmada. They stood on the northern bank of Narmada, ready to sprinkle him. As Indra was about to be sprinkled, the illustrious *rishi* Mandavya spoke to them. He said, “If you sprinkle him, I will reduce all of you to ashes.” The immortals worshipped Mandavya and praising him, reasoned with him. The gods said, “This Indra possesses one thousand eyes. O sage! In whichever place he is sprinkled, terrible

impediments present themselves. O one who bestows boons! Therefore, be pleased with us and perform a rite of pacification. Let us perform this rite of cleansing and we will give you many boons. All of us will give you a place. Therefore, you should grant us permission. The spot where the great Indra is sprinkled will give men every object of pleasure. It will be full of grains and trees laden with fruit. There will never be any drought or famine there.” Mandavya, best among sages and worshipped by the worlds, agreed to this. For the sake of cleansing impurities, the sprinkling took place there. The gods and the sages spoke of that region as Malava.⁵⁶² When he was sprinkled, the lord of the gods became sparkling again. They brought Goutami Ganga and performed the rite of purification. The gods, the *rishis*, I, Vishnu, Vasishtha, Goutama, Agastya, Atri, Kashyapa, other *rishis*, gods, *yakshas* and *pannagas* bathed him with the pure water and sprinkled him. I also sprinkled Shachi’s husband with water from my *kamamdalu*. From this, two rivers resulted—Punya and Sikta. There is a confluence of Ganga with Sikta. Since then, those two confluences are famous and are always frequented by sages. Since then, that confluence has been spoken of as *Punya tirtha*.⁵⁶³ The sacred confluence of Sikta is known as *Aindra tirtha*.⁵⁶⁴ There are seven thousand auspicious *tirthas* there. Bathing and donating there, especially at the confluences, should be known to bestow inexhaustible benefits. There is no need to think about this. If a person reads or hears this sacred account, he is freed from all sins committed through thoughts, words and deeds.’

Chapter 2(27) (Poulastya *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Poulastya *tirtha* yields every kind of success for men. I will tell you about its powers. It bestows kingdoms that have been destroyed. Earlier, the lord of the northern directions ⁵⁶⁵ possessed every kind of prosperity and success. Earlier, he was the lord of Lanka and was Vishrava’s eldest son. His brothers were strong and extremely resplendent. They were Ravana, Kumbhakarna and Vibhishana, and they were his step-brothers. They too were Vishrava’s sons. However, since their mother was a *rakshasa* lady, they were *rakshasas*. ⁵⁶⁶ On Pushpaka *vimana*, Dhanada, along with his brothers, always used to faithfully come to me and go back. Ravana’s mother became angry and spoke to her sons. Ravana’s mother said, “I won’t live. Because of this disparity, I would much rather die. It is said that the gods and the *danavas* are step-brothers. ⁵⁶⁷ To win over prosperity and bring it under their control, they seek to kill each other. Therefore, you are not men. You are not capable. You do not desire victory. If a person seeks permission from a rival, his life is futile.” O sage! Hearing their mother’s words, the three brothers went to the forest to perform austerities. They performed great austerities. The three *rakshasas* obtained boons from me. Because of the instigation of their maternal uncle, Maricha and their maternal grandfather and because of their mother’s words, he ⁵⁶⁸ asked for Lanka. Because of their *rakshasa* sentiments and because of their mother’s words, there was great enmity between the brothers. There was a battle between them, like that between the gods and the *danavas*. In the clash, he defeated his elder brother, the serene Dhanada. He took away everything, Pushpaka and the city of Lanka. In the three worlds and among all mobile and immobile objects, Ravana made an announcement. “Anyone who offers refuge to my

brother deserves to be killed by me.” The banished brother, Vaishravana,⁵⁶⁹ did not find shelter anywhere. He went to his grandfather Pulastya. Bowing down, he addressed him in the following words. Dhanada said, “I have been expelled by my wicked brother. Please tell me what I should do. Where will I find refuge and shelter, or a divine *tirtha*?” Hearing his grandson’s words, Pulastya replied in the following words. Pulastya said, “O son! Go to Goutami and praise the divinity Maheshvara. He will not be able to enter there in the midst of Ganga’s waters. You will obtain fortune and success. Act in accordance with my words.” Dhaneshvara⁵⁷⁰ agreed and went there along with his wife, his father, his mother and the aged Pulastya.

‘Having gone to Goutami Ganga, he bathed and purified himself. He controlled himself and followed the vows. He praised the lord of the gods, Shiva, who bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation. Dhanada said, “You are the lord of everything mobile and immobile in the universe. O Shambhu! There is nothing superior to you. Because of delusion, if a person brags about ignoring you, one should grieve about him. You are radiant in all your eight forms. Everything happens because of your command. Nevertheless, there are those who are ignorant about you. They do not know about your ancient glory. Something was born from your dirt and Amba⁵⁷¹ laughingly said, ‘O divinity! This is your brave son.’ You glanced at it and Vighnaraja was born. This is what happens through Isha’s glance. On seeing that the couple was separated, Girija’s eyes filled with tears and she spoke to Isha.⁵⁷² Bhava’s mind led to Madana being born again. Because of you and Uma, he and Rati obtained complete good fortune.” Praised in this way, the one with the three-eyes manifested himself before him. He asked him to choose a boon. However, because of his delight, he did not say anything. Dhanada and Pulastya were both silent. Maheshvara repeatedly asked him to choose a boon. Shiva was delighted. Meanwhile, an invisible voice was heard to speak to Maheshvara. “He should become the protector of riches. It was only after ascertaining the minds of Pulastya and Vaishravana’s father that the invisible voice uttered these auspicious words. The future should be like the past. What is received should be what was received earlier. What is given should be what was given earlier.⁵⁷³ He has many enemies. He has

suffered a great deal of grief. He has worshipped Someshvara *lingam*.⁵⁷⁴ He deserves to be a lord of the directions and a lord of riches. He should become generous with many wives and sons.” These were the auspicious words of the divine voice. Hearing these words, Dhanada told the lord of the gods, the one who wields a trident, “Let it be this way.” Telling Dhanada that it would be that way, the lord of the gods approved of the divine words. Shiva, the lord of the gods, honoured Pulastya, the sage Vishrava and the protector of riches with these boons and departed. Since then, the spot has been known as Poulastya⁵⁷⁵ *tirtha*, Dhanada *tirtha* and Vaishravasa *tirtha*. It is sacred and auspicious and yields every object of desire. Bathing and all the other rites undertaken there yield many good merits.’

Chapter 2(28) (Agni *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as *Agni tirtha* yields the fruits of all sacrifices. It destroys every kind of impediment. Hear about the fruits of this *tirtha*. Agni’s brother is known as Jataveda. He is Havyavat.⁵⁷⁶ In a sacrifice that took place in the abode of the *rishis*, along the banks of Goutami, Agni’s excellent brother was bearing *havya* for the gods. He was accomplished and was loved by his brother. While the foremost *rishis* and the gods looked on, Madhu, Diti’s powerful son, slew him. With Jataveda dead, no one carried *havya* to the gods. Agni’s beloved brother, Jataveda, was killed. Filled with great rage, he entered Ganga’s waters. When Agni entered Ganga’s waters, gods and men gave up their lives because it is held that they owe their lives to Agni. All the gods, *rishis* and ancestors went to the place where Agni had entered the waters. They especially praised Agni. “We cannot live without Agni.” Seeing their beloved Agni inside the water, the residents of heaven spoke. The gods said, “The gods survive through *havya* and the ancestors survive through *kavya*. Men survive through cooking food and seeds survive when they are moistened.” Agni told the gods, “Since my younger brother has gone, I am incapacitated. Your task will not be accomplished. However, since Jataveda has gone, I will also follow him. O gods! I am not interested in carrying out your task. Your task was always carried out by Jataveda. Since he has been reduced to this state, I do not know what will become of me. I will no longer possess the strength to pervade this world and the next world. Even if I try to carry out the task, I will not possess the speed.” Full of emotions, all the gods and the *rishis* spoke. “You will be given a lifespan, love for work and pervasive strength. O Havyavahana! We will give you the oblations offered before the sacrifice and the oblations offered after the sacrifice.⁵⁷⁷ You are the excellent mouth

of the gods. The first oblations will be for you. O supreme god! We will enjoy the objects that are offered to you.” At the words of the gods, Vahni⁵⁷⁸ was pleased and in due order, pervaded this world and the next world and bore *havya* and *kavya*. Because of the command of the gods, Vahni became fearless and capable everywhere. He is spoken of as Jataveda, Brihadbhanu, Saptarchi, Nilalohita, Jalagarbha, Shamigarbha and Yajnagarbha.⁵⁷⁹ The gods took Vibhavasū out of the water and consecrated him. Agni goes everywhere and obtained two places to reside in.⁵⁸⁰ The gods returned to wherever they had come from. That place is known as Agni *tirtha*. There are seven hundred *tirthas* in the spot, possessing all the qualities. If one goes there, controls oneself and bathes and donates, one obtains the auspicious fruits of a successful horse sacrifice, performed with the use of fire. It is known as Deva *tirtha*, Agni *tirtha* or Jataveda *tirtha*. There is a *lingam* of many complexions there, established by Agni. If a person beholds the divinity there, he obtains the fruits of all sacrifices.’

Chapter 2(29) (Rinamochana *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘Those who know the Vedas know the name of Rinapramochana *tirtha*.⁵⁸¹ I will tell you about its nature. O Narada! Listen attentively. Kakshivan had a favourite son named Prithushrava. Because of his non-attachment, he did not marry. Nor did he worship the fire. O sage! Though his younger brother was capable, he was scared of becoming a *parivetta*.⁵⁸² He did not perform the rites for ascending to heaven. Nor did he worship the fire. The large number of ancestors spoke these auspicious words separately to the elder brother, Kakshivan and to the younger brother. The ancestors said, “For the sake of repaying the three types of debts, let the marriages be performed.”⁵⁸³ The elder responded, “That will not happen. Who has incurred a debt?” The younger told the ancestors, “It is not appropriate that I should marry. O immensely wise ones! While I have an elder brother, I am scared of becoming a *parivetta*.” The grandfathers spoke to both of them again. The ancestors said, “O sons of Kakshivan! Both of you go to the sacred Goutami. Bathing in Goutami yields everything one wishes for. Go to Goutami Ganga. She purifies everything in the three worlds. Full of devotion, bathe and perform the water-rites. When one sees her, bathes in her and meditates on her, Goutami bestows everything that is desired. The rules of place, time and *jati* do not apply for bathing there. The elder brother will be freed from the debt and the younger brother will not become a *parivetta*.” At this, the elder brother, Prithushrava bathed and performed the water-rites. Kakshivan’s son was freed from the three types of debt he owed to the worlds. Since then, that place has been spoken of as Rinamochana *tirtha*.⁵⁸⁴ O Narada! By bathing and donating there, a person becomes happy and is freed from debts mentioned in the *shruti* and *smriti* texts and also from all other debts.’

Chapter 2(30) (Kadru and Suparna *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There are two confluences named after Kadru and Suparna.⁵⁸⁵ On the banks of Ganga, the divinity Maheshvara resides there. There are sacrificial altars for fire there, named after Rudra, Vishnu, Surya, Soma, Brahma, Kumara and Varuna. There is the confluence of the river Apsara with Ganga. Even if a man remembers that *tirtha*, he becomes successful in every venture. It destroys every kind of sin. O Narada! Hear about it attentively. Earlier, the *valakhilya maharshis* were harmed by Indra. Having given up half of their stores of austerities, they spoke to the sage Kashyapa. The *valakhilyas* said, “Use this to have an auspicious son who will rob Indra of his insolence. We are giving you half of our stores of austerities.” The sage agreed to this. The Prajapati impregnated Suparna’s womb. The brahmana also slowly impregnated Kadru, the mother of snakes, with snakes. When both of them conceived, Prajapati wished to leave and spoke to them. “You must not commit an offence and you must not go anywhere. If you go elsewhere, there is no doubt that you will be cursed.” Having spoken to his two wives in this way, he left. When their husband departed, both of them went to a sacrifice performed by *rishis* who had cleansed their souls. The place was populated by large numbers of *brahmanas* and was on the banks of Ganga. Since both of them were proud of their youth and prosperity, they behaved in this mad way. They were repeatedly restrained by sages who possessed the insight of truth. Nevertheless, they spoilt the hymns and oblations of the sacrifice.⁵⁸⁶ Who is master enough to control the dark and fickle minds of women? On seeing that both of them had traversed along this perverse path, the *brahmanas* were agitated. “Since you have followed this perverse path, both of you will become rivers with contrary flows.” Thus, Suparna and Kadru became rivers.’

‘After some time, Kashyapa Prajapati returned home. From the *rishis*, he heard in detail about what they had done and how they had been cursed. Hearing this, he was amazed and became immersed in thoughts. “What will I do?” He spoke to the *rishis* known as *valakhilyas*. They told the brahmana Kashyapa, “Go to Goutami Ganga and worship Mahesha. They will then again become your wives. Scared of the sin of having killed a brahmana,⁵⁸⁷ the divinity Maheshvara always resides in the middle of Ganga and is known as Madhyameshvara.”⁵⁸⁸ Addressed in this way, Kashyapa, who was observant in his vows, bathed in Ganga. He praised Maheshvara, the lord of the gods, through sacred hymns. Kashyapa said, “He alone is the lord of the three worlds. He does not possess the slightest bit of pride about where he resides. He is Siddhanatha,⁵⁸⁹ the creator of the entire universe. He is Shiva’s⁵⁹⁰ consort. Let him be pleased. Embodied creatures and mobile and immobile objects are extremely scorched from the heat of the three kinds of hardships⁵⁹¹ and are running around here and there. You are the one who is competent to dispel their miseries. You possess the three kinds of yoga related to *sattva* and the others,⁵⁹² and Shakra and the others are incapable of describing this. You are the one who should be worshipped. Thinking about Soma’s wonderful behaviour,⁵⁹³ a man is always happy and becomes devoted to donating.” Shiva, loved by Gouri was praised in these and other ways. Shambhu was pleased and gave Kashyapa many kinds of boons. He was looking for his wives and he told him, “Your two wives will have the forms of rivers. In that form, your two wives will reach Ganga, best among rivers. As soon as they unite with her, they will regain their own forms once again. Through Ganga’s favours, they will become pregnant once again.” In this way, the great-minded Prajapati got his two wives back and was delighted. He invited the *brahmanas* who had sought refuge on Goutami’s banks. Pleased, Prajapati performed their *simantonmayana* rite.⁵⁹⁴ In accordance with the prescribed norms, he fed the *brahmanas*. The *brahmanas* had their food in Kashyapa’s house. Standing near her husband, Kadru looked at the *brahmanas*. Kadru glanced at the *rishis* with slanted eyes and laughed at them. They were disturbed and said, “O wicked one! You have laughed at us with evil eyes. Your eyes have committed a sin. Let

them be slanted.” At this, Kadru became blind in one eye and is known as the mother of snakes. Kashyapa pacified the illustrious *rishis*. Pleased, they continued, “Goutami is supreme among rivers. If one frequents her, she protects against one thousand sins.” Along with his wives, Kashyapa, supreme among sages, did this. Since then, their confluences have been known as *tirthas*. Kadru is in all directions and River Souparnika⁵⁹⁵ is to the east. The *tirtha* of Jatadhara⁵⁹⁶ is more sacred than Varanasi. It destroys every kind of sin and yields the fruits of every kind of sacrifice.’

Chapter 2(31) (Confluence of Sarasvati)

Brahma said, ‘Those who know about the Vedas speak about the *tirtha* of Pururava. Even if one remembers it, all sins are destroyed, not to speak of when one sees it. Pururava went to Brahma’s assembly. He saw the divine river, Sarasvati. In Brahma’s presence, she was laughing as she willed. Seeing her store of beauty, the lord of the earth spoke to Urvashi. The king asked, “Who is this virtuous and beautiful lady who is standing next to Brahma? She is best among all the women and is illuminating this place.” Urvashi replied, “She is the auspicious river of the gods, Sarasvati. She is Brahma’s daughter. She always comes to this place and returns.” Hearing this, the amazed king said, “Bring her to my presence.” Urvashi again replied to the king, who was copious in his donations. Urvashi replied, “O great king! I will tell her everything and bring her.” Delighted, the king sent Urvashi to her. Having gone there, Urvashi reported the king’s words. Sarasvati agreed to what Urvashi had said. She pledged to do that and went to the place where Pururava was. He found pleasure on the banks of Sarasvati for many years. She had a son named Sarasvan and Sarasvan’s son was Brihadratha. I saw that Sarasvati was going to the king’s house every day. I got to know about Sarasvan and about everything else that she had done. Therefore, I cursed her, “Become a great river.” Scared of my curse, Vagisha ⁵⁹⁷ went to the goddess Goutami, the sacred mother who originated from the *kamandalu* and purifies the worlds. She is the one who dispels the three kinds of hardships and bestows what is desired in this world and in the next world. Having gone to the goddess Goutami, she reported everything about the curse, starting at the beginning. Ganga told me, “You should free her from this curse. It is not appropriate that you should impose a curse on Sarasvati. Her nature is feminine and women

desire men. O Brahma! All women are naturally fickle. O one who is seated on a lotus! O one who created the universe! How is it that you don't know this? Whose nature does Kama not cause a disturbance in?" I freed her from the curse and said, "Sarasvati will also be visible." Because of the curse in the world of the mortals, Sarasvati is both visible and invisible. Distracted by her curse, there is a spot where she united with the divine Ganga. Pururva, supreme among kings and devoted to *dharma*, went there. He tormented himself through austerities and worshipped the divinity, Hara Siddheshvara.⁵⁹⁸ Through Ganga's favours, he obtained everything that he desired. Since then, that has been spoken of as Pururava *tirtha*. It is also known as Sarasvati's confluence and Brahma *tirtha*. The divinity Siddheshvara is there and he grants everything that one desires.'

Chapter 2(32) (Five *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The sages know that there are five sacred *tirthas*—Savitri, Gayatri, Shraddha, Medha and Sarasvati. If one bathes there and drinks the water, one is freed from all sins. Savitri, Gayatri, Shraddha, Medha and Sarasvati were my daughters, created for the sake of establishing *dharma*. Among them, the eldest⁵⁹⁹ was the most beautiful. I had created her as the most beautiful woman in the world. O supreme sage! On seeing her, my intelligence turned perverse. Full of desire, I tried to seize her. On seeing me, the maiden fled. The maiden assumed the form of a doe and I assumed the form of a stag. For the sake of preserving *dharma*, Shambhu assumed the form of a hunter who killed deer.⁶⁰⁰ Scared of me, the five daughters went to Ganga, the great river. Maheshvara also went there and for the sake of preserving *dharma*, picked up his bow and arrow. Isha spoke to me, as I was in the form of a stag. Hara, as a hunter of deer, told me, “I will kill you.” Therefore, I refrained from the act and bestowed the maiden on Vivasvat. The five daughters, Savitri and the others, assumed the form of rivers. They returned to the world of heaven again and approached me. O Narada! There are five *tirthas* where the goddesses united.⁶⁰¹ The confluences of the five rivers, Sarasvati and the others, are sacred. If a man bathes, donates, or does anything else there, all the objects of desire are obtained. It is said to confer emancipation and freedom from *karma*. The *tirtha* of Mrigavyadha⁶⁰² is also there and it bestows everything that men want. It is said to bestow the fruits of heaven and emancipation. It is also said to bestow the fruits of Brahma *tirtha*.’

Chapter 2(33) (Shami *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Shami *tirtha* pacifies every kind of sin. I will tell you about its account. O Narada! Listen attentively. There was a *kshatriya* named Priyavrata and he was supreme among victorious ones. On the southern banks of Goutami, his priest initiated him for a horse sacrifice and he was surrounded by officiating priests and *rishis*. Vasishtha was the mighty-armed king’s chief priest. A *danava* named Hiranyaka arrived at the sacrificial arena. On seeing the *danava*, the gods, with Indra at the forefront, were terrified. Some went to heaven and Havyavat entered a *shami* tree. Vishnu entered an *ashvattha* tree, Bhanu entered an *arka* tree and Shiva entered a *vata* tree. Soma went to a *palasha* tree.⁶⁰³ Havyavahana entered the waters of Ganga. The two Ashvins seized the horse and Yama became a crow. Meanwhile, the illustrious *rishi*, Vasishtha, grasped a staff and commanded the *daitya* to stop. Though the *daitya* possessed his own strength, he went away and the sacrifice commenced again. These spots became auspicious *tirthas* and bestowed the fruits of ten horse sacrifices. The first *tirtha* is known as Shami, the second is named after Vishnu. The other *tirthas* are named after Arka, Shiva, Soma and Vasishtha. They yield every object of desire. When the extensive sacrifice was completed, all the gods and *rishis* were satisfied. Delighted, they repeatedly spoke to Vasishtha, Priyavrata, who had performed the sacrifice and the trees and Ganga. “People have gone here and there to undertake horse sacrifices. But these *tirthas* will yield the fruits of horse sacrifices.” This is what the gods said. Thereafter, bathing and donations at those *tirthas* have yielded the fruits of a sacred horse sacrifice. Those words were not false.’

Chapter 2(34) (Twenty-two thousand *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘There are sacred *tirthas* named after Vishvamitra, Harishchandra, Shunahshepa, Rohita, Varuna, Brahma, Agni, Indra, Indava, Ishvara, Mitra, Vishnu, Yama, the Ashvins and Ushanas. Hear from me about them. In the Ikshvaku lineage, there was a king named Harishchandra. Narada and Parvata came to his house. Having offered them hospitality in the proper way, Harishchandra spoke to the two *rishis*. Harishchandra said, “For the sake of a son, people undertake hardships. What is obtained through a son? A son may be learned or ignorant, excellent or middling. O *rishis*! I have always had a doubt about this. Please tell me.” Parvata and Narada replied to Harishchandra. Narada and Parvata said, “O king! There can be one, ten, one hundred, or one thousand different answers. However, the proper answer is said to be the following. O supreme among kings! For a person without a son, the world hereafter does not exist. For such an evil-doer, this world does not exist either. O lord of men! A father who bathes after a son has been born, obtains the fruits of consecrating himself for ten horse sacrifices. When a son is born, a person is established and becomes like a best among immortals. The gods become immortals through *amrita*, *brahmanas* and others through sons. A son releases his father and grandfather from the three kinds of debts. Without a son, what does one get from roots? What does one get from water? ⁶⁰⁴ What does one get from growing a beard? What does one get through austerities? O Indra among kings! A son is said to lead to heaven and emancipation. The son is the world hereafter, the son is success in the pursuit of *dharma*, *artha* and *kama*. The son is emancipation. The son is the supreme light. The son enables all embodied beings to cross over. ⁶⁰⁵ O Indra among kings! Anything given without a son, any oblations offered without a son, indeed

without a son, birth itself is futile. That is the way it appears to me.⁶⁰⁶ A son frees from the debt. Sons make a person free from blemish. If a father lives to see the birth and behold the face of a son who remains alive, he enjoys all the objects of pleasure obtained in the world of mortals or in the firmament. When a father sees a son, he obtains everything. Therefore, there is nothing in the three worlds that is desired as much as a son.” Hearing this, the king’s mind was amazed and he asked again. Harishchandra asked, “How can I obtain a son? Please tell me accurately. I will endeavor to make every kind of effort and practice every kind of manliness. So that I can get a son, I will use *mantras*, sacrifices and donations.” They heard what Harishchandra, the best among kings said, desiring a son. They meditated properly for a while and said, “O one who bestows honours! Go to Goutami. There, the lord of the waters bestows any excellent object that is in one’s mind. The sages have said that Varuna bestows everything. If he is pleased, over a period of time, you will have a son.” Hearing the words of the sages, the best among kings acted accordingly.’

‘He resorted to the banks of Goutami and satisfied Varuna. Varuna was content and spoke to Harishchandra. Varuna said, “O king! You do not possess sons and have tried to follow vows. I will give you a son, provided that you certainly offer that son in a sacrifice.” Harishchandra promised Varuna that he would offer him in a sacrifice. Leaving the place, Harishchandra prepared a *charu*⁶⁰⁷ that was offered to Varuna. The king offered this to his wife and a son was born to the king. When the son was born, the lord of the waters, supreme among those who bestow boons, spoke. Varuna said, “Remember the words you spoke earlier. Offer the son today.” When Varuna appeared in front of him, Harishchandra replied, “An animal is fit for a sacrifice only after ten days have passed. I will perform the sacrifice thereafter.” Hearing the king’s words, Varuna returned to his own abode. When ten days had passed, he appeared again and asked the king to undertake the sacrifice. The king told Varuna, “Unless an animal has teeth, the sacrifice is futile. O lord of the waters! Go now and return when the animal has teeth.” Hearing the king’s words, the lord of the waters went away again. O Narada! When the son was seven years old, the teeth

appeared. He again asked the king to undertake the sacrifice. The king replied, “O lord of the waters! These teeth will fall off. I will perform the sacrifice when other teeth grow. Please go away now.” O Narada! When the permanent teeth appeared, Varuna appeared again and said, “O king! Perform the sacrifice.” But the king replied to the lord of the waters. The king said, “O lord of the waters! If it is a *kshatriya*, he becomes an excellent animal for a sacrifice only when he has learnt *dhanurveda*.”⁶⁰⁸ Hearing the king’s words, Varuna went away to his own abode. Rohita,⁶⁰⁹ scorcher of enemies, became accomplished in the use of *astras* and *shastras*, all the Vedas and all the sacred texts. Having attained the age of sixteen years, Rohita became the heir apparent. The delighted Varuna went to the place where the king and Rohita were and said, “Sacrifice your son now.” The best among kings agreed. While Varuna heard, the lord of the earth spoke to the officiating priest and to Rohita, his eldest son. Harishchandra said, “O extremely brave son! Come. I will offer you in a sacrifice to Varuna.” Rohita asked his father, “What is this?” Thereupon, his father told him in detail what had transpired. While Varuna heard, Rohita spoke to his father. Rohita said, “O great king! I will first purify himself and along with the officiating priests and the chief priest, quickly offer a sacrifice to Vishnu, the lord of the worlds. Varuna will be the sacrificial animal. O lord! Please grant me permission.” Hearing Rohita’s words, the lord of the waters was overwhelmed with great rage. Astride his chariot, wielding a divine bow and arrow, he departed.’

‘Rohita, King Harishchandra’s son, went to the forest where Harishchandra, lord of men, had worshipped Varuna. Rohita went to the place along the Ganga where he⁶¹⁰ had obtained a son. Five years had passed and the sixth year had started. The king’s son remained there. He heard the king was suffering from the ailment of dropsy.⁶¹¹ “Through the birth of a son like me, my father is being made to suffer from this hardship. What fruit has he obtained? What will I do now?” This is what he thought. On those sacred banks, the king’s son saw some *rishis*. He saw an excellent *rishi* wandering around along the banks of Ganga. The aged rishi was named Ajigarta and he was followed by his three sons and his wife. Lacking

a means of subsistence, they were emaciated. On seeing him, the king's son bowed down and addressed him in these words. Rohita asked, "You seem to be distressed in your mind and are emaciated, lacking a means of subsistence. Why is this?" Ajigarta replied to Rohita, the king's son. Ajigarta said, "I have no means of sustaining my body. I have many who need to be fed. Without food, we will die. Tell me. What can we possibly do?" Hearing this, the king's son spoke to the *rishi* again. Rohita said, "O supreme among eloquent ones! Please tell me what is on your mind." Ajigarta replied, "I do not possess gold, silver, cattle, grain or garments. O tiger among kings! It is evident that I do not possess a means of subsistence. I have three sons and a wife and I am the fifth. O supreme among kings! There is no one who will purchase one of us for food." Rohita asked, "O immensely intelligent one! O Ajigarta! Who will you offer for purchase? Tell me truthfully. There is nothing else that you need to say. *Brahmanas* are truthful in speech." Ajigarta said, "Take one of the three sons or me or their mother, my wife. If you purchase one of us, we will remain alive." Rohita replied, "O immensely intelligent one! What will I do with your wife? Since you are aged in form, what will I do with you? Give me one of your young sons, whichever son you wish to give." Ajigarta said, "O Rohita! I will not sell my eldest son, Shunahpuccha. The mother will not sell the youngest one. I will sell the son in the middle, Shunahshepa. Tell me about the riches you will give." Rohita replied, "A man must be thought of as a sacrificial animal to Varuna. He must possess the qualities. O great sage! If you are willing to sell him, tell me the price truthfully." Thus addressed, Ajigarta told him about the price he expected for his son. "O prince! One thousand cows, grains, gold coins and garments—give me this excellent price and I will give you my son." Agreeing to this, Rohita gave him garments and riches. Having given this to him, Rohita went to his father with the *rishi*'s son. He told his father about the purchase of the *rishi*'s son. Rohita said, "With this as an animal, perform the sacrifice to Varuna and be freed of your ailment." When his son had spoken, Harishchandra replied. Harishchandra said, "It has been said that a king must protect *brahmanas*, *kshatriyas* and *vaishyas*. In particular, supreme

brahmanas are best among the *varnas*. They are worshipped by Vishnu, not to speak of people like me. If kings show them disrespect, they destroy their own lineages. All the *tirthas* exist in *brahmanas* and all the gods are also in them. They are the ones who save men who descend into hell. If I make such a person suffer by making him a sacrificial animal, how can I say I protect them? It is not proper that I should make a brahmana a sacrificial animal. It is better that I die as a result of this ailment. How can I make a brahmana a sacrificial animal? O son! That is the way I will act. Along with the brahmana, leave happily.” At this time, an invisible voice was heard.’

‘The voice spoke from the sky, “O Indra among kings! Along with the officiating priests and the chief priest, go to Goutami. Take the brahmana’s son as a sacrificial animal and take Rohita, your son. Your task is to perform the sacrifice without Shunahshepa getting killed. O immensely intelligent one! The sacrifice will be completed there.” Hearing these words, the excellent king swiftly went to Ganga along with *rishi* Vishvamitra, the chief priest Vasishtha, the *rishi* Vamadeva and other sages. Having reached Goutami Ganga, he consecrated himself for a *naramedha* sacrifice.⁶¹² He arranged for the altar, pavilion, sacred pit, sacrificial stake and other things. When everything had been arranged in the proper way, the sacrifice commenced. With *mantras* being chanted, Shunahshepa was tied to the sacrificial stake as a sacrificial animal. Seeing that water was being sprinkled over him, Vishvamitra spoke the following words, especially to the gods, the *rishis*, Harishchandra and Rohita. Vishvamitra said, “I seek leave from all of you about Shunahshepa, the excellent brahmana. Oblations are going to be separately offered to the gods. In particular, I seek leave from all of you about Shunahshepa. With *mantras*, oblations of fat, body hair, skin and flesh will be offered into the fire, along with Shunahshepa, the excellent brahmana. I entreat you. Let all the Indras among *brahmanas* be sprinkled with water. Let the Indras among *brahmanas* go to Goutami and bathe separately. Let them praise the gods with *mantras* and hymns. Let everything be auspicious and let them leave happily. O sages and gods! Please save him and enjoy the oblations.” The sages agreed to this and so did the excellent king. Shunahshepa also went to

Ganga, the purifier of the three worlds. He bathed and praised the gods, the ones who partake of oblations. O sage! The large number of gods were satisfied. While Vishvamitra heard, all the gods spoke to Shunahshepa. The gods said, “Let the sacrifice be completed without Shunahshepa being killed.” In particular, Varuna also spoke to the excellent king. The king’s *naramedha* sacrifice, famous in the worlds, was completed. Through the favours of the gods, through the favours of the sages and through the favours of that *tirtha*, the king’s sacrifice was completed. In that assembly, Vishvamitra honoured Shunahshepa. In the presence of the gods, he honoured him and adopted him as his son. Koushika ⁶¹³ made him the eldest of his sons. The other sons of the intelligent Vishvamitra did not accept Shunahshepa as the eldest son and Koushika cursed them. He honoured only those of his sons who accepted him as the eldest son. The tiger among sages bestowed boons on them. I have thus told you everything that happened on the southern bank of Goutami. There are sacred *tirthas* there, famous even among the gods. O immensely intelligent one! There are many names. Hear about them from me. They are named after Harishchandra, Shunahshepa, Vishvamitra, Rohita and others. There are twenty-two thousand such *tirthas*. Bathing and donating there yield the fruits of a *naramedha* sacrifice. O supreme sage! I have described the greatness of the *tirtha* to you. If a person hears, reads or makes heard this account faithfully, he obtains everything that pleases his mind. A man without sons gets a son.’

Chapter 2(35) (Confluences of twenty-five rivers)

Brahma said, ‘There is a place known as Soma *tirtha*. It enhances the delight of the ancestors. An extremely sacred event transpired there. O Narada! Listen attentively. Earlier, King Soma, full of *amrita*, was the king of the *gandharvas* and not of the gods. The gods came and spoke to me. The gods said, “Earlier, Soma used to bestow life on the gods. But he has been taken away by the *gandharvas*. Unable to meditate on him, the large number of gods and *rishis* are extremely miserable. You should think of a policy so that Soma belongs to us again.” At this, Sarasvati ⁶¹⁴ spoke to the gods. “The *gandharvas* are extremely attached to women. O gods! Give me to them and take back Soma.” The immortals replied to Sarasvati, “Please pardon us. We are incapable of giving you away. We are incapable of existing without him, or without you.” Sarasvati spoke to the gods again. “I will come to you again. We must use our intelligence to think of a means to undertake an excellent sacrifice. Let it be performed on the southern bank of Goutami. If the gods are prepared to come, let a place be found for the sacrifice. Let the best among gods come. The *gandharvas* are always attached to women. Using me as a price, get him ⁶¹⁵ back.” The gods agreed to the words Sarasvati had spoken. Messengers of the gods were separately sent to gods, *yakshas*, *gandharvas* and *pannagas*. They were invited to that sacred and divine mountain. O sage! Since then, that mountain has been known as Devagiri. Large number of gods, *gandharvas*, *yakshas*, *rakshasas*, *siddhas*, *rishis* and the eight species ⁶¹⁶ of inferior gods arrived there. On the banks of Goutami, the *rishis* performed a great sacrifice. Surrounded by the gods, the one with one thousand eyes spoke. In Sarasvati’s presence, Indra honoured the *gandharvas* and said, “Take

Sarasvati as a price and give us *amrita*.” The *gandharvas* were attached to women. Hearing Shakra’s words, they accepted Sarasvati and gave the gods Soma. The immortals got Soma and the *gandharvas* got Sarasvati. While residing there, the goddess of speech always came to see the gods secretly and spoke to them in a low voice. O Narada! That is the reason why one must always speak in a low voice when purchasing *soma*.⁶¹⁷ The purchase of Soma took place in that way. Thus, the gods possessed both Soma and Sarasvati. The *gandharvas* had neither Soma, nor Sarasvati.’

‘For the sake of Soma, all of them came to the banks of Goutami—cows, gods, mountains, *yakshas*, *rakshasas*, *siddhas*, *sadhya*s, sages, *guhyakas*, *gandharvas*, Maruts, *pannagas*, all the herbs, the mothers of the worlds, the guardians of the worlds, Rudras, Adityas, Vasus, the two Ashvins and all the other gods who were entitled to shares of the sacrifice. O sage! Twenty-five rivers merged into Ganga. The place where complete oblations were offered is spoken of as Purna.⁶¹⁸ I have spoken about the confluences all of them had with Ganga. *Tirthas* were named after them. O Narada! I will tell you about them briefly. There were Soma *tirtha*, Gandharva *tirtha*, Deva *tirtha*, Purna *tirtha*, Shala, the confluence of Shriparna, the confluence of Ila, the sacred confluence of Kusuma, the place known as the confluence of Pushti, the auspicious confluence of Karnika, the confluence of Vainavi, the confluence of Krisharasa, the confluence of Vasavi, Shiva, Sharya, Shikhi, Kusumbhika, Uparathya, Shantija, Devaja, Aja, Vriddha, Sura and Bhadra.⁶¹⁹ All of them merged into Goutami. There were many other male and female rivers from earth that went along as companions to that *tirtha* of Devaparvata.⁶²⁰ For the sake of Soma, there were others who went to the sacrificial pavilion. In due order, their confluences with Ganga became *tirthas*. There were some in the form of female rivers, there were others in the form of male rivers. There were some in the form of lakes, there were others that were in the form of streams. All of these separate *tirthas* are famous. Bathing, *japa*, oblations and water-rites performed for the ancestors there yield all the objects of desire. A man obtains objects of pleasure and emancipation. If a person remembers it or reads about it, he is freed from all sins and goes to Vishnu’s city. There are twenty rivers between Purna and

Pravara. They are the daughters of divine rivers. Taken together, twenty-five have been spoken about.'

Chapter 2(36) (Amrita and other confluences)

Brahma said, ‘At the confluence of Pravara, the great river is the best. ⁶²¹ The divinity Siddheshvara, who brings welfare to all beings is there. There was an extremely terrible clash between gods and *danavas*. O great sage! However, they became affectionate towards each other. The gods and the *danavas* consulted each other. Desiring to do what would be good for each other, they went to Mount Meru. The gods and *daityas* said, “*Amrita* ensures immortality. Therefore, let us generate the excellent *amrita*. When we drink it, all of us will become immortal. Uniting ourselves, we will happily rule over the worlds. Giving up all conflict, we will get it. Conflict is the cause of miseries. We will obtain riches through affection and abandoning jealousy, enjoy it. Affectionate conduct has always brought happiness to us. We must never remember our perverse conduct. The happiness one obtains through lack of enmity alone is not obtained through lordship over the three worlds or through an elevated status.” In this way, the gods and *danavas* became affectionate towards each other. Having united and become extremely happy, they churned Varuna’s abode. ⁶²² They made Mandara the churning rod and made Vasuki the rope used for churning. All the gods and *danavas* churned Varuna’s abode. As a result, the sacred *amrita*, loved by the gods, was generated. When the sacred *amrita* had been produced, they spoke to each other. “Having accomplished the intended task, we are exhausted. Let us go to our respective abodes. As is appropriate, let this be distributed equally. O excellent gods! At an auspicious moment, when all of us have assembled, let this sacred *amrita* be divided among us.” Saying this, all the *daityas*, *danavas* and *rakshasas* departed. When the large number of *daityas* left, all the gods consulted amongst themselves. The gods said, “Our enemies, the scorchers of

enemies, have left, trusting us. This *amrita* must never be given to the enemies.” Brihaspati agreed with this and spoke to the gods. Brihaspati said, “Drink the *amrita* in such a way that the wicked ones do not get to know. So that the enemies are defeated, this is the apt advice. Those who are conversant with good policy know that those who cause hate must be hated in every possible way. One must not trust or be friendly with enemies. They should not be consulted. They should not be given *amrita*. Otherwise, they will become immortal. When those who are naturally our enemies, the *daityas*, become immortal, we will be unable to defeat them. Therefore, they must not be given *amrita*.” The gods consulted among themselves and spoke to Vachaspati.’ ⁶²³

‘The gods asked, “Where will we go? Where will we consult with each other? Where will we drink? Where will we base ourselves? O lord! O Vachaspati! We must first do that. Please tell us.” Brihaspati replied, “O immortals! Go to Brahma and ask him about this supreme objective. The grandfather is the one who knows, speaks and gives.” Hearing Brihaspati’s words, they came before me. All the gods bowed down before me and told me what had happened. O son! Hearing their words, along with the gods, I went to Hari. Vishnu was told everything and so was Shambhu, the one who destroys poison. I, Vishnu, Shambhu, the gods, the *gandharvas* and the *kinnaras* went to a cave in Meru. The *asuras* did not know. Having decided to drink *soma* there, ⁶²⁴ Hari was appointed as the guard. Aditya was to keep track of who had partaken of the *soma*. Soma ⁶²⁵ was given the task of apportioning out the *amrita*. The wielder of the *chakra* was the guard. The *daityas*, *danavas* and *rakshasas* did not know of this. The only exception was the immensely wise Rahu, Simhika’s son. He drank *soma*. He could assume any form at will. Assuming the form of a Marut, Rahu sat down amidst them. In the form of a Marut, he held up the drinking-vessel. Soma gave the *daitya amrita*. However, Divakara ⁶²⁶ got to know that this was a *daitya* in the form of a god. He went and told Vishnu that Soma had given him *soma*. While the *daitya* was drinking *amrita*, Vishnu severed his head with his *chakra*. O son! Though the head was quickly severed, it became immortal. Without the head, the body fell down on the ground. O tiger

among sages! When the body which had touched *amrita*, fell down on the southern bank of Goutami, the earth trembled. O son! This was extraordinary, but the body also became immortal. The body needed the head and the head needed the body. Both became immortal and therefore, the *daitya* became extremely strong.’

‘All the gods were scared. “If the body gets united with the head, he will devour all the gods. Therefore, we must first destroy the body, which has fallen down on the ground.” The gods spoke to Shankara. The gods said, “O excellent god! Please destroy the body that has fallen down on the ground. O divinity! You are an ocean of compassion. You protect those who seek refuge with you. Please act so that the *daitya*’s head does not unite with his body.” Isha sent the excellent Shakti, part of his own being. She is the mother who protects the worlds. The goddess went, along with the other mother goddesses. The goddess wielded Isha’s weapon. She possessed Isha’s powers. She went to the place where the body had fallen down on the ground, wishing to devour it. All the gods pacified the head by placing it on Meru. The goddess and the body fought for many years. Rahu told the gods, “Pierce my body first. There are excellent juices inside. Take them out from the body. The excellent juices inside the body are the excellent *amrita*. When they are taken out, the body will be reduced to ashes in an instant. Therefore, take them out first.” Hearing Rahu’s words, all the enemies of the *asuras* were delighted. They happily consecrated him as a planet and said, “You will become a planet.” Hearing the words of the gods and strength of the gods, Shakti, also spoken of as Ishvari, pierced the body of the lord of the *daityas*. She swiftly extracted the excellent *amrita* outside. Thereafter, having placed the body there, Ambika devoured it. Extremely strong, she is spoken of as Kalaratri and Bhadrakali. The juice that had been extracted was an excellent juice. It oozed out from the place where it had been kept and became the river Pravara.⁶²⁷ Once the *amrita* had been extracted, the body was placed there and devoured. After this, the excellent river Pravara originated. She is auspicious and is full of *amrita*. She emerged from Rudra’s body and possesses Rudra’s powers. She is beautiful and is the best among rivers. She originated from *amrita*. There are five

thousand *tirthas* there and they possess all the qualities. Shambhu, worshipped by the gods, is himself always present there. Satisfied, all the gods happily bestowed separate boons on the divine river. “As long as Shambhu, the lord of the gods is worshipped, you will also be worshipped by the worlds. O goddess! For the welfare of the worlds, reside here. May Isha’s juices always remain with you. May you bring every kind of success to everyone. When you are praised, eulogized and meditated upon, you will bestow every kind of desire. Those who desire anything will always devotedly bow down before you. Through the command of the gods, all their tasks will be accomplished. Both Shiva and Shakti will always reside here.” Therefore, the sages speak of this place as Nivasapura. ⁶²⁸ In ancient times, extremely happily, the gods bestowed these boons on Pravara. Her confluence with Ganga is famous and is loved by the gods. Those who bathe there obtain objects of pleasure and emancipation. They satisfy the wishes that are in their minds, even those that are extremely difficult for the gods to obtain. Having granted her everything, the gods departed. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as the confluence of Pravara. She originated from Shakti, who in turn was sent by the lord of the gods. The great river of Pravara is known by the name of Amrita. Bathing, donations and other rites undertaken at the confluence of Pravara bring eternal benefits and learning. They bring delight to the ancestors.’

Chapter 2(37) (Vriddha Sangama)

Brahma said, ‘There is a place known as Vriddha Sangama.

Vriddheshvara Shiva is present there. ⁶²⁹ I will tell you about the account, which destroys sins. Listen. There was a sage in Goutama’s lineage. He was a great ascetic and was known as Vriddha. In earlier times, the brahmana, descended from Goutama’s lineage, did not have a nose. Therefore, he was originally disfigured in form. Full of non-attachment, he wandered around in various regions and *tirthas*. Since he was ashamed, he did not approach any preceptor. Since he was ashamed, he could not study with fellow disciples either. He somehow managed to go to his father, Goutama. After teaching him, Goutama went out on his travels. For a long period of time, the brahmana was nurtured by his brahmana mother. Though he had descended from Goutama, he did not study. Nor did Goutama’s son study the sacred texts. However, he was always firm in his vows and performed the fire rites. He also practiced the chanting of *gayatri mantra*. He was a brahmana only in name, though he performed the fire rites and chanted the *gayatri mantra*. O sage! This was all there in terms of Goutama’s son being a brahmana. The great-souled one worshipped the fire and chanted *gayatri mantra*. Goutama’s son possessed a long lifespan and his age increased. He could not obtain a wife because no one would bestow his daughter on him. Therefore, he roamed around in many regions and *tirthas* and many kinds of forests. Goutama’s son wandered around in sacred hermitages. While wandering around, Goutama’s son arrived in the cold mountains. He found a beautiful cave there, covered with creepers and trees.’

‘Making up his mind to reside there, the Indra among *brahmanas* entered it. When he entered, he saw an excellent woman there. Her limbs were flaccid and she was emaciated. She was aged, engaged in austerities.

Practising *brahmacharya*, she was still a maiden and lived in isolation. Seeing her, the best among sages stood there, ready to bow down. However, as Goutama's son, the best among sages, was about to bow down, she restrained him. The aged woman said, "You will become my *guru*. You should not worship me. If a *guru* bows down, the disciple's lifespan, learning, riches, fame, *dharma*, heaven and everything else are destroyed." Goutama's son was amazed. He joined his hands in salutation and spoke. Goutama's son replied, "You are an ascetic lady. You are aged. You are superior to me in qualities and are beautiful. Relatively, I possess little learning. I am also younger in age. How can I possibly be your *guru*?" The aged woman said, "O one who is excellent in vows! In this connection, there is an ancient account. I will tell you about it. Arshtishena had a son who was known as Ritadhvaja. He possessed the qualities and was intelligent. He was brave and followed the *dharma* of *kshatriyas*. On one occasion, his mind was attracted to the idea of hunting and he came to his forest. To rest, Ritadhvaja entered this cave. He was young and intelligent. He was accomplished and was surrounded by a large army. While the best among kings was resting, he saw an *apsara*. She was the daughter of the king of *gandharvas* and was known as Sushyama. The king saw and desired her and she saw and desired the king. O immensely intelligent one! There was an act of sexual intercourse between her and the king. When the desire was satisfied, the Indra among kings sought her permission to leave for his own home. O immensely wise one! I was born as Sushyama's daughter. O store of austerities! As she was leaving, my mother spoke to me. Sushyama said, 'O fortunate one! Whoever enters this cave will become your husband.' O immensely wise one! Saying this, my mother departed. Since then, no man other than you has entered. After ruling over the kingdom for eighty thousand years, my father tormented himself through austerities and has now gone to heaven. O tiger among sages! After my father went to heaven, my brother ruled over the kingdom for ten thousand years. However, he has also gone to heaven and I alone am left. O brahmana I have not had relationships with anyone. I possess neither a mother, nor a father. O brahmana! I alone decide what I will do. I am the daughter of a

kshatriya and I am attracted to you. O brahmana! Therefore, accept me. I have been observing the vows and have been in search of a man.”

Goutama’s son replied, “O fortunate one! I am one thousand years old and you are senior to me in age. In relative terms, I am but a child and you are aged. Hence, our union is not possible.” The aged woman said, “You have formerly been ordained as my husband. In my view, there is no one else who can be my husband. You have been given to me by the ordainer himself. Therefore, you should not refuse me. I have not been defiled and am ready to follow you. Nevertheless, if you do not desire me, while you look on, I will now give up my life. For all embodied creatures, death is superior to not getting what one has been waiting for. If one gives up one’s life for someone one is attached to, no sin results from that.” Hearing the aged lady’s words, Goutama’s son replied in the following words.

Goutama’s son said, “I do not possess austerities. I do not possess learning. I possess nothing. I am not an appropriate groom for you. I am disfigured and do not have any objects of pleasure. I do not possess a nose. I do not possess either austerities, or learning. What will I do? O auspicious one! Therefore, I must first become handsome and possess learning. After that, I will act in accordance with your words.” The aged lady spoke to the brahmana. The aged lady said, “O brahmana! Through my austerities, I have satisfied the goddess Sarasvati. In that way, I have also satisfied the beautiful water and Agni, who grants form. Therefore, the goddess of speech will bestow learning on you. Agni, the god of beauty will bestow a handsome form on you.” Having told Goutama’s son this, the aged lady spoke to Vibhvasu.⁶³⁰ She desired excellent learning and supreme beauty for the sage. He became extremely learned and extremely fortunate. He became exceedingly handsome and happily made the aged lady his wife. Together, they found pleasure for many agreeable years. They were delighted and lived happily in the cave.’

‘O tiger among sages! While the couple resided happily in the cave in the mountain, there was an occasion when the unblemished sages arrived there. There were Vasishtha, Vamadeva and other *maharshis*. While roaming around the sacred *tirthas*, they arrived at that cave. Learning that the *rishis*

had come, Goutama's son, along with his wife, offered them hospitality. However, there were some who laughed at them. Some of them were young and were proud of their youth. Some were middle-aged. Some saw Goutama's son and the aged lady and laughed at them. She was huge and emaciated. Her lips hung down. She possessed body hair and her ears were like winnowing baskets. Her teeth jutted out and her nose was long. The tips of her hair were long and she was aged. In contrast, Goutama's son possessed beauty, charm, good fortune and learning. Some young sons of *rishis* saw them and laughed. There were also disciples who possessed limited intelligence. They saw them, smiled and spoke. The *rishis* said, "O aged lady! Who is Goutama's son? Is he your son or your grandson? O fortunate one! Tell us truthfully." In this way, the *brahmanas* laughed. "O ascetic lady! It has truly been said that the fruits of austerities are extremely powerful. One obtains serenity through austerities. However, if one doesn't possess the requisite strength, one is exhausted. O extremely beautiful one! Behold. The equanimity and poise that has been cultivated through many births must be protected. That indeed, has been spoken of as the truth. What is the need to speak a lot in this connection? That will now prove to be futile speech. You alone are blessed in this world. Please tell us about the good fortune you possess. Your sins have been burnt down by your austerities. Your exertions in pursuit of austerities are spoken about a lot. In this world, you have become emaciated through your austerities and self-control. You have worshipped guests and have nurtured your son. In this world, let this body which is a store of sins, not be nurtured. Compassion, donations, austerities, truth, control of the senses, honouring guests, serenity, protecting sons and others—you have followed all of these and practiced your own *dharma*. If a person only acts so as to fill his own stomach, it is evident that he is destined for hell. He is only interested in his body. That is the view. O beautiful one! In this world, where is there such a woman who has undergone every kind of misery? Please tell us. O one who possesses excellent eyebrows! Though you have always honoured guests, you are like a dog. Without a husband or a son, you should be known as impure. However, you have indeed fed *brahmanas*. O beautiful one!

Therefore, there is no doubt that you do possess *dharma*, though you are extremely aged and do not have a husband. Hence, though you are disfigured, you must be regarded as beautiful. Though lacking riches, you must be regarded as possessing riches. You have tormented yourself through fierce austerities, like standing on one toe. These are extremely difficult to undertake. You must have faithfully worshipped Lakshmi's consort in your earlier births. You must have given away copious donations. You must have undertaken sacrifices, with large amounts of *dakshina*. You must have properly visited the *tirthas* and offered a lot of oblations. That is the reason you have obtained a son like Goutama's son, who knows the Vedas. He is accomplished in the Vedas and the *Vedangas* and knows the truth. He is learned in all the sacred texts. For those in the three worlds who perform good deeds, someone like Goutama's son is extremely difficult to obtain. Is he your son, your son's son, your daughter's son or your great grandson? A son's son is like grain that gives satisfaction, but a daughter's son is like sesamum kept in a leather bag.⁶³¹ However, because of him, your lineage will obtain a sparkling and pure destination with Vishnu. O one who is aged in austerities! There is no need to think about this." Extremely surprised, some disciples of the *rishis* said, "A young woman is like poison to an old man, but a young man is like *amrita* to an old woman. After a long time, we have seen the desirable and the undesirable together." While the couple heard, some of them spoke in this way. Saying this, when the hospitality was over, all the *maharshis* left.'

'Hearing the words of the *rishis*, both of them were extremely sad. Goutama's immensely wise son was ashamed along with his wife. O tiger among sages! They asked Agastya, supreme among *rishis*. Goutama's son asked, "In what region and in which *tirtha* can one obtain the greatest benefit? O immensely wise one! What bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation quickly?" Agastya replied, "O brahmana! I have heard these words when the sages spoke about it. There is no doubt that all the wishes are met in Goutami. O immensely intelligent one! Therefore, go to Goutami. She destroys all sins. I will follow you. Do what you want." Hearing Agastya's words, the aged lady and Goutama's son went there.

Along with his wife, the illustrious *rishi* tormented himself there with fierce austerities. They praised the divinity Shambhu and Vishnu. For the sake of his wife, the illustrious *rishi* satisfied Ganga. Goutama's son said, "O Bhava! Our minds are distressed. O Shiva! You are the refuge. You are like a tree to travelers in the desert. You are the one who dispels every kind of sin committed by superior and inferior beings. O Krishna! When the planets dry everything up, you are like a cloud for crops. O river that is full of nectar! You are like a flight of stairs leading to Vaikuntha ⁶³², which is so very difficult to reach. O Goutami! You are the refuge for the seven generations that will follow." Goutami was pleased at the words spoken by Goutama's son and the aged lady. She is the refuge for those who are afflicted and they had sought refuge with her. Goutami said, "After pronouncing *mantras* over my water, sprinkle your wife with that. Like that, pour water from the pots over your beloved wife. She will become beautiful and lovely in all her limbs. She will become extremely fortunate, with beautiful eyes. She will possess all the auspicious signs and obtain a handsome appearance. When she is sprinkled in this way, your wife will become beautiful once more. She will then sprinkle water over you and you will possess all the auspicious signs and become beautiful in form." They agreed with the words spoken by Ganga and acted accordingly. Through Goutami's favours, both of them became extremely handsome. O supreme among sages! Because the sprinkling was performed with water from that river, the river became famous by the name of Vriddha. ⁶³³ This river became known as Vriddha and Goutama's son also came to be known after her. The *rishis* who dwelt with them addressed him by the name of Vriddha-Goutama. The aged lady spoke to Goutami Ganga when she manifested herself before her. The aged lady said, "O goddess! After my name, let this river be known as Vriddha. Let the confluence of the river with you become an excellent *tirtha*. Let bathing, donating, oblations and the performance of water-rites to ancestors become extremely pure there, bestowing youth, good fortune and prosperity and enhancing the number of sons and grandsons. Let these lead to a long lifespan, freedom from disease and fortune and enhance victory and joy." Ganga agreed to what the extremely

aged lady, beloved by Goutama's son had said. Goutama's son established a *lingam* there and it is spoken of by the name of Vriddha. Along with the aged lady, the supreme among sages enjoyed himself there. Bathing and donations there yield everything that is wished for. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Vriddha Sangama.' ⁶³⁴

Chapter 2(38) (Sixteen thousand *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Ila *tirtha* bestows every kind of success on men. It cleanses sins like that of killing a brahmana and yields everything that is desired. A lord of men, named Ila was born in Vivasvat’s lineage. ⁶³⁵ With a large army, he went to the forest to hunt. He wandered around in a dense forest, frequented by many predatory creatures. The trees were adorned with many types of birds. Making up his mind to hunt, the best of kings wandered around in that forest. Ila made up his mind to reside there and spoke to his advisers. Ila said, “All of you return to the city which is protected by my son. Protect him, the country, the treasury, the army and the kingdom. Taking our lord, Agni, let Vasishtha also go. ⁶³⁶ Let the intelligent one leave, along with my wives. I will reside here in the forest. I will subsist on forest fare along with some horses, elephants and men who are skilled in hunting. Let everyone else leave this place and go to the city.” They agreed and left. King Ila himself went to the Himalaya mountains, which were full of jewels, and started to live there.’

‘He saw a cave there, decorated with many kinds of wonderful gems. A lord of the *yakshas*, known by the name of Samanyu, resided on that beautiful and excellent mountain. The *yaksha* was accompanied by his wife, named Sama, who was devoted to serving her husband. Along with his wife, the immensely wise one roamed around in the form of a deer. In his own forest, the *yaksha* sported as he willed, singing and dancing. Though he was in the form of a deer, the *yaksha* knew everything about the place. However, Ila did not know that the cave was protected by the *yaksha*. The *yaksha*’s home was huge, decorated with many kinds of wonderful jewels. Surrounded by many soldiers, the king sat down there. He started to live in the home of the intelligent *yaksha*. In the form of a deer, the *yaksha* was

with his wife and he was enraged at this act of *adharma*. “I am incapable of defeating Ila. He has taken away my home. Even if I ask for it, he will not give it back to me. What will I do?” He thought in this way. The king of *yakshas* made up his mind. “I will fight with him. But how can I kill him?” He sent his own relatives, brave *yakshas* who wielded bows. The *yaksha* said, “In a battle, defeat King Ila. He is insolent because he possesses tuskers. You should act so that he leaves my home and goes somewhere else.” The *yakshas* were indomitable in battle and heard the words spoken by the lord of the *yakshas*. All of them went to Ila and said, “Leave this home, inside the cave. Otherwise, you will be routed in a battle and be forced to run away.” Hearing the words of the *yakshas*, the king of kings became angry and started to fight. After defeating many types of *yakshas*, he dwelt there for ten nights.’

‘In the form of a deer, the lord of *yakshas* resided in the forest with his wife. With his home taken away and his servants killed, he lived there with the *yakshini*.⁶³⁷ He was overcome by thoughts and spoke to his beloved who was in the form of a doe. The *yaksha* said, “He is powerful and impossible to assail. He possesses prosperity and is proud of his valour. He is addicted to hunting those like me. O beloved! How will I defeat the king?” The *yakshini* replied, “O beloved! Please tell me. Is there any way to destroy his insolence? Tell me if my words will help. I will do whatever you ask me to do.” The *yaksha* said, “O beautiful one! A method to destroy the king’s insolence exists. Through this excellent means, the king’s pride can be destroyed. O immensely fortunate one! Do what is auspicious and extremely agreeable according to me. O fortunate one! Go to the place where that foolish king lives. O auspicious one! There, show yourself in front of Ila. Attract King Ila to the place known as Umavana.⁶³⁸ O immensely fortunate one! Assume the form of a doe in front of the one who is living in my home. The evil-minded one’s mind is addicted to the flesh of deer and he will become a woman.⁶³⁹ O beloved! This king is evil-minded and his mind is addicted to pleasure. I have thought of this means, whereby he can be made to face a calamity. Because of wicked intelligence, entire kingdoms of kings come to an end. O one with the excellent eyebrows!

Assume the form of a beautiful doe and entice him to Umavana. There is no doubt that once the king enters that place, he will become a woman. O fortunate one! You should do what I am urging you to do. I am male. But you are female and a *yakshini*.” The *yakshini* asked, “Why can’t you go to the excellent Umavana? What will be the sin if you go there? Please tell me the truth.” The *yaksha* replied, “Surrounded by the gods, Shiva is happily roaming around with Uma on the slopes of the Himalayas. On an earlier occasion, in secret, Parvati spoke to Shankara. Parvati said, ‘The nature of women is such that they want to indulge themselves in secret. Therefore, give me a controlled place that is protected in accordance with your words. O Ishana! O lord of the gods! Give me a place known as Umavana. Barring you, Ganesha, Kartikeya and Nandi, any male who enters there will become a woman.’ Thus addressed, the one who wears the moon on his crest was pleased and gave her Umavana. When a beloved lovingly asks for something, what will a man not do? Therefore, I should not go to the excellent Umavana.” The *yakshini* could assume any form at will. Hearing her husband’s words, the large-eyed one assumed the form of a doe and appeared in front of Ila. The *yaksha* remained where he was. Ila saw the doe. His mind was addicted to hunting and moreover, this was a doe. Alone, he jumped onto a horse and followed the doe. She slowly enticed the king who was addicted to hunting, away. Slowly, she went to the spot that was spoken of as Umavana. Sometimes, the doe showed herself. Sometimes, she disappeared. Sometimes, she stood there. Sometimes, she walked. Sometimes, she seemed to be frightened and ran away. The doe, with darting eyes, enticed him to Umavana. Astride the horse, he reached Umavana. As soon as she realized that he entered Umavana, the *yakshini* gave up her form as a doe. The *yakshini* could assume any form at will. She assumed a divine form and stood near an *ashoka* tree with branches that bent down. She was smeared with divine unguents. She was slender and celestial in appearance. Sama had accomplished her objective. She looked at the exhausted king, astride the horse, and laughed. Ila had been searching for the doe with darting eyes. Remembering everything that her husband had said, she spoke to the lord of men. Sama said, “O slender-limbed

woman! Where are you going alone, astride a horse? O Ilaa! ⁶⁴⁰ Attired in the form of a man, who are you following?” Hearing himself addressed as “Ilaa”, the king became senseless with rage and censured the *yakshini*, who had earlier been in the form of a doe. However, the *yakshini* continued, “O Ilaa! What are you looking at?” Hearing the word “Ilaa”, astride the horse, he seized his bow. He angrily showed her the bow that had vanquished the three worlds. However, she again spoke to the great-souled king. “O Ilaa! Look at yourself. After that, tell me whether I am speaking the truth or am lying.” At this, the king looked and saw a pair of peaked breasts between his arms. He was bewildered at what had happened to him. Ilaa said, “What has happened to me? You evidently know the answer. Please tell me everything accurately. O one who is excellent in vows! Who are you? Please tell me.” The *yakshini* replied, “My husband, Samanyu, used to reside in an excellent cave in the Himalayas. He is a prosperous lord of the *yakshas*. I am his wife, a *yakshini*. O king! That is the extremely cool cave you sat down in. It is his *yakshas* you killed in your delusion, though there never was a proper battle. Therefore, to make you emerge, I assumed the form of a doe and came to Umavana. I entered and so did you. Earlier, Maheshvara had said, “Any evil-minded male who enters this place will become a female.” Therefore, you have become a woman and you should not grieve about this. Even an aged person does not know the wonderful course that destiny will take.” Hearing the *yakshini*’s words, he fell down from the horse. The *yakshini* comforted him and again addressed him in the following words. The *yakshini* said, “You have become a woman. You should not behave like a man. Accept the skills that are appropriate for a woman—dancing, singing, decorating, feminine grace, feminine charm and everything else that a woman does.” When Ilaa had learnt everything, ⁶⁴¹ she addressed the *yakshini* in the following words.’

‘Ilaa asked, “Who will be my husband? What should I do now? How will I become a man again? O fortunate one! Tell me this, especially since I am suffering from a great deal of grief. There is nothing that brings greater benefit than the act of pacifying the grief of those who are miserable.” The *yakshini* replied, “Soma’s son is named Budha. O extremely fortunate one!

He possesses beauty and youth and his hermitage is to the east of this forest. The planet Budha follows this path every day to go and see his father, Soma, and pay him his respects. When the serene Budha goes, show yourself to him. O extremely fortunate one! When you see him, you will get everything that you wish for.” Having reassured him, the *yakshini*, with the excellent eyebrows, vanished. The *yakshini* went and told the *yaksha*, who was delighted. Ila’s soldiers, who had been there went away, as they willed. Ilaa remained in Umavana and danced and sang. She followed feminine activities and thought about the path of *karma*. On one occasion, Ilaa was dancing. While the intelligent Budha was going to visit his father, he saw her. Seeing Ilaa, he moved away from his path. Budha approached and spoke to her. Budha said, “Be my wife. Be my beloved and be comfortable in every possible way.” Ilaa faithfully accepted the words Budha had spoken and acted accordingly. O sage! Remembering the *yakshini*’s words, she was satisfied at this. Having taken her to his excellent place, Budha happily found pleasure with her. In every possible way, she also satisfied her husband. After a long period of time had passed, the satisfied Budha spoke to his beloved. Budha asked, ‘O fortunate one! What shall I give you? What is the agreeable wish that exists in your mind?’ Budha, Soma’s son, loved her and was delighted with her. As soon as he spoke these words, Ilaa replied, “Give me a son.” Budha said, “My semen is infallible and will bring delight. There will be a *kshatriya* son who will be famous in the worlds. He will be handsome and will be like the sun in his energy. He will establish the Soma lineage. ⁶⁴² He will be like Brihaspati in intelligence and like the earth in forgiveness. He will be like Hari in valour and energy and like the fire-god in rage.” When Budha’s great-souled son was born, there were sounds of “victory” everywhere in the abode of the gods. As soon as Budha’s son was born, all the lords among the gods arrived there. O immensely wise one! Full of joy, I also went there. As soon as the son was born, he cried in a loud voice. Therefore, all the assembled *rishis* and gods said, “Since he cried loudly, he will be Pururava.” ⁶⁴³ Delighted in their minds, all of them gave him this name. Budha taught his son all the auspicious knowledge meant for a *kshatriya*. Budha taught his son about the

application of *dhanurveda*. He grew up fast, like the moon during *shukla paksha*.’

‘The immensely intelligent one noticed that his mother, Ilaa, grieved. Aila ⁶⁴⁴ humbly bowed down before Ilaa and addressed her in these words. Aila said, “O mother! My father is Budha. He is your husband and you love him. I am your son and am capable of undertaking tasks. Why do you have this mental anxiety?” Ilaa replied, “O son! It is true that Budha is my husband. It is also true that you, my son, are a reservoir of qualities. I never have any worries on account of my husband or son. However, I remember what had happened earlier and am repeatedly miserable. O immensely intelligent one! I think about that.” He replied to his mother. Aila said, “O mother! First tell me what it is.” Ilaa answered, “It is a secret. How can I speak about it? However, since you are my son, I will tell you. A son is the ultimate refuge of the parents. When one is submerged in an ocean of grief, a son is the best ship.” Hearing his mother’s words, he humbly placed her feet on his head. With his eyes overflowing with tears, he spoke to her in a faltering voice. “If a son does not remove the hardships of the parents in every possible way, then his birth and life are useless. Even if he is alive, he is as good as dead. Frequenting *tirthas*, donations, sacrifices, austerities and other sacred tasks are undertaken so that the parents are satisfied. O mother! Therefore, tell me truthfully everything that there is in your mind.” She spoke to her son with quivering lips. With hot breaths, she was distracted and submerged in an ocean of grief, as she told him everything—the birth in the Ikshvaku lineage of the solar dynasty; her birth and name; her obtaining the kingdom and her beloved sons; the chief priest Vasishtha; his beloved wife and his own status; his departure for the forest; the sending back of the advisers and the chief priest to the city; the addiction to hunting; the entry into the home of the lord of the *yakshas* in the cave in the Himalayas; the entry into Umavana and the complete transformation into a woman; Maheshvara’s command about a man who entered the place; the words of the *yakshini* and the obtaining of a boon; getting Budha; and the delight at having given birth to a son. She told him all this. Hearing all this, Pururava asked, “What will I do? In the form of a good deed, what shall I do? O

mother! What will bring you sufficient pleasure? Tell me everything else that is in your mind. Command me.” Aila answered, “I wish to become a man again and get back my excellent kingdom. I wish to crown my sons, especially you. I wish to donate and sacrifice and look towards the path of emancipation. Through your favours, I desire to accomplish all this.” The son said, “I am asking you about the method whereby you can become a man again. Will that be through austerities or through some other means? Please tell me the truth.” Ilaa answered, “O son! Go and ask your father, Budha, about the truth. He knows everything and he will instruct you about what is the best.” Following his mother’s words, Aila went to his upright father. He prostrated himself and asked what he and his mother should do.’

‘Budha said, “O immensely wise one! I know how Ila turned into Ilaa. I know about his entry into Umavana and Shambhu’s command. O son! Hence, it is only through the favours of Shambhu and the favours of Uma that the curse can be countered. There is no means other than that of worshipping him.” Purarava asked, “How can I see the divinity? How can I see the mother, Shivaa? Will that be through *tirthas* or through austerities? O father! Please tell me that first.” Budha replied, “O son! Go to Goutami. Shiva is always present there, along with Uma. The prosperous one dispels curses and grants boons.” Hearing his father’s words, Pururava became happy. To perform austerities, he went to Goutami Ganga, the purifier of the three worlds. Desiring to ensure that his mother would become a man, he quickly performed austerities. He bowed down before the Himalaya mountains, his mother, his father and his *guru*. As he proceeded, Ilaa and Soma’s son followed him. From the excellent Himalaya mountains, all of them reached Goutami. They bathed there and performed some austerities. They then used supreme hymns to progressively praise Bhava, the lord of the gods. Budha praised him first, followed by Ilaa. Then the son, Pururava, praised the goddess Gouri and Shankara. Budha said, “Those two take pleasure from the sound of the girdle. Their complexion is like that of natural gold. They are extremely beautiful. They are worshipped by Skanda and Ganeshvara. They are the ones in whom one should seek refuge. Let them be my refuge.” Ilaa said, “Embodied creatures are scorched by the

forest conflagration of *samsara* and are overcome by worries. However, one instantly obtains *nivritti* through Shankara and Shankari. ⁶⁴⁵ Let them be my refuge. I am afflicted and my mind is suffering. Against hardships, there is no protector who is superior. O divinity! Your feet are extremely auspicious. They are the ones in whom one should seek refuge. Let them be my refuge.” Pururava said, “Let Gouri and Hara be my refuge. They are the ones from which everything visible originates and prospers and they are the ones into which everything is merged. They are the refuges of the entire universe. They are the *atmans* of the universe. In a great festival of the gods, it was said, ‘O Isha! Clasp the feet of the daughter of the lord of the mountains.’ As soon as this was said, Shiva lovingly did this. They are the ones with whom one should seek refuge.” The illustrious goddess asked, “What is it that you desire? What will I give you? Please tell me. O fortunate ones! You have accomplished that which is extremely difficult for even the gods to accomplish.” Pururava replied, “O Ambika! In his ignorance, King Ila entered your forest. O goddess of the gods! Please forgive him and give him his manliness back.” She always abided by Bhava’s views and agreed to all this. The illustrious one, who always abided by the words of the goddess, spoke. Shiva said, “As soon as he is sprinkled with water from here, the king will get his manliness back.” When Budha’s wife bathed, water flowed out from her body. She had obtained knowledge of singing and dancing and feminine grace from the *yakshini*. Along with this water, all of this entered Ganga’s waters. The rivers Nritya, Gita and Soubhagya ⁶⁴⁶ emerged from this flow. They merged into Ganga and these three confluences are sacred. Bathing and donations there yield the fruits of obtaining the kingdom of the gods. Through the favours of Gouri and Shambhu, Ilaa became a man.’

‘To accomplish the objective of great upliftment, he undertook a *vajapeya* sacrifice. The supreme among kings brought the chief priest, Vasishtha, his wife and sons, his advisers, arm and treasury. With an army consisting of the four divisions, ⁶⁴⁷ he established a kingdom in Dandaka. The city there became famous under the name of Ila. This is located in the valley of the Sahya mountains and is superior to the great Indra’s city. In

that excellent and supreme city, he became detached from the enjoyment of earthly pleasures. In due order, he instated his former sons as heirs to the *surya vamsha*. After this, he lovingly instated Aila in the kingdom. This handsome king was the one who established *chandra vamsha*. O sage! He was the most intelligent and respected among all the sons and was the eldest. O Narada! Sixteen thousand auspicious *tirthas* resulted in the auspicious places where King Ila performed sacrifices, where he got back his manliness, where he met his sons, where the auspicious rivers originated from the dancing, singing and good fortune bestowed by the *yakshini* and at their confluences with Ganga. O son! They were on both sides of the river and Shambhurileshvara ⁶⁴⁸ is there. Bathing and donations there, yield the fruits of all sacrifices.'

Chapter 2(39) (Chakra *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Chakra *tirtha* destroys the sin of killing a brahmana and other sins. This is the place where Hari obtained his divine *chakra* from Chakreshvara. ⁶⁴⁹ For the sake of obtaining the *chakra* from Lord Shankara, Vishnu himself remained there and worshipped him. That *tirtha* is known as Chakra *tirtha*. Even if a person hears about it, he is freed from all sins. Daksha’s sacrifice was being conducted. At an assembly of the gods, Daksha abused the divinity, Shiva Sharva Maheshvara. Daksha’s mind was so polluted that he did not invite the lord of the gods. When Ahalya spoke about it, from her words, Dakshayani got to know the reason about the invitation not being used. Sureshvari was enraged. ⁶⁵⁰ On hearing the abusive words her father had spoken about her husband, she said, “I will not forgive my father, the sinner. I will destroy him. There is no limit to the sins of women who hear their husbands being censured. Whatever be the nature of the husband, he is the ultimate refuge for a woman. What need be said about Mahadeva, who is a lord for everyone and the preceptor of the universe? Since I have heard him being censured, I will not bear this body any longer. Therefore, I will give up this body.” This is what the great Sati said. Overwhelmed by great rage, Sureshvari blazed up. With her mind fixed only on Shiva, she used the power of *yoga* to give up her body. From Narada, Maheshvara heard everything that had transpired. He angrily looked towards Jaya and Vijaya and asked them. ⁶⁵¹ Both of them told the divinity what they had heard from Dakshayani about Daksha’s sacrifice being destroyed. Hearing this, Maheshvara left for the sacrifice. He was surrounded by terrible *ganas* and the lords of the *bhutas* went with him. They surrounded the sacrifice, which had been organized by the gods, with Brahma at the forefront. With pure sentiments, it had been guarded by

Daksha, who was performing the sacrifice. It was surrounded by Vasishtha and other fierce sages. It was protected in every possible direction by Indra, the Adityas, the Vasus and others. It was embellished by the sounds of chants from *Rig Veda*, *Yajur Veda* and *Sama Veda* and there were sounds of *svaha*. It was ornamented from every direction by Shraddha, Pushti, Tushti, Shanti, Lajja, Sarasvati, Bhumi, Dyou, Sharvari, Kshanti, Usha, Asha, Jaya, Mati and others. ⁶⁵² The great-souled Tvashta and Vishvakarma had constructed it. ⁶⁵³ There were the cows Surabhi, Nandini, Kamadhuk and Kamadohini. There were many others that showered down every kind of desire. It was prosperous, with every kind of wish being met. There were *kalpavrikshas* like Parijata. There were creepers that yielded everything one desired. Everything that was wished for was present in that sacrifice. It was protected by Maghavan, Pusha and Hari himself. There were cheerful sounds of “Give”, “Eat”, “Do” and “Stay”. In this way, Daksha’s sacrifice was revered through many words. At first, Virabhadra and Bhadrakali went on ahead. Overwhelmed by sorrow and anger, the wielder of Pinaka followed, holding a trident. As Mahadeva advanced, many great *bhutas* ornamented him. Those *bhutas* surrounded Maheshvara and the sacrifice. They destroyed the sacrifice and there was great agitation. Some fled, others sought refuge with Shiva. Some praised the lord of the gods, others were angry with Shankara. Seeing that the sacrifice was being destroyed in this way, Pusha advanced. O brahmana! In an instant, Virabhadra knocked out Pusha’s teeth, routed Indra and plucked out Bhaga’s eyes. Using both his arms, he whirled Divakara around and flung him away.’

‘At this, all the large number of gods sought refuge with Vishnu. The gods said, “Please save us. O one with the mace in your hand! Save us from the fear on account of Bhutanatha. There is a leader of the *pramathas* ⁶⁵⁴ amidst Maheshvara’s *ganas*. While Hara looked on, he has burnt down the entire sacrifice that was undertaken in Vishnu’s honour.” To slay Bhutanatha, Hari hurled his *chakra*. However, as the *chakra* descended, Bhutanatha devoured it. When Vishnu’s *chakra* was devoured, all the guardians of the worlds fled in fear. Standing there, Daksha looked at the sacrifice and at the gods. Full of devotion, Prajapati Daksha praised the

divinity Shankara. Daksha said, “Victory to Shankara Somesha. ⁶⁵⁵ Victory to Shambhu, who knows everything. Victory to the fortunate Shambhu. Victory to the one who is the *atman* of destiny. I bow down before you. I bow down before the one who is the original creator. O Nilakantha! I bow down before you. O one who is fond of Brahma! I bow down before you. O one who assumes the form of Brahma! I bow down before you. O one who assumes the three forms! ⁶⁵⁶ O divinity! O refuge of the three worlds! O Parameshvara! I bow down before you. O one who has every kind of form! I bow down before you. O one who is the support of the three worlds! O one who grants desires! I bow down before you. O one who can be known through *Vedanta*! O *paramatman*! I bow down before you. O one who has the sacrifice as your form! I bow down before you. O refuge of the sacrifice! I bow down before you. O one who is the donations of the sacrifice! I bow down before you. O one who bears the oblations of a sacrifice! I bow down before you. O one who is the destroyer of a sacrifice! I bow down before you. O one who bestows the fruits! I bow down before you. Save me. O lord of the universe! Please save me. O one who is affectionate towards those who seek refuge! O lord! You are the refuge of everyone, whether they are devotees or non-devotees.’ Praised in this way, Maheshvara was pleased. He asked, ‘What will I give you?’ The reply was, “O lord! Please allow my sacrifice to be completed.” The illustrious Mahadeva, the lord of all the gods, agreed. He is Shankara, who is in the *atmans* of all living beings. He is an ocean of compassion. O sage! In this way, Daksha’s sacrifice was successfully completed. Having said that it would be, the illustrious one vanished along with the *bhutas*. All the gods returned to their own respective abodes.’

‘Once, there was a great battle between the gods and the *daityas*. The terrified gods praised Shri’s consort in every possible way and spoke to Janardana. The gods said, “Shakra and the other gods perform austerities so that Lakshmi may cast favourable sidelong glances at them. However, she seeks refuge at your feet and the *brahman* is in you. In the three worlds, there is no one who is superior to Nrisimha, whose mount is Tarkshya. ⁶⁵⁷ Let the lord of the gods protect us from every kind of great fear. Let him

show compassion towards those who have sought refuge.” The illustrious one, who holds the conch shell, *chakra* and mace, was pleased. He asked, “Why have all of you come? I will do that for you.” The gods continued, “O Madhusudana! On account of the *daityas*, we are suffering from a terrible fear. O Janardana! Please turn your mind towards saving us from them.” Hari told the ones who had come, “My *chakra* has been devoured by Hara. You are suffering and have come to me. But what I will I do without the *chakra*? O large number of gods! Leave. I will do what is necessary to protect you.” When the gods had left, Vishnu prepared to get the *chakra* back. He went to Godavari and started to worship Shambhu. Using one thousand divine and fragrant golden lotuses, every day, Vishnu worshipped Uma’s lord. “I bow down to the one who destroys the great fear from this forest of *samsara*. O wielder of Pinaka! O Mahesha! O one bestows everything that is desired.” Using this *mantra* and with his mind filled with devotion, he worshipped Shiva, loved by Bhavani, ⁶⁵⁸ in the proper way. As the worship continued, listen to what happened between them. The number of lotuses was less than one thousand by one. When the enemy of *asuras* ⁶⁵⁹ noticed this, he plucked out one of his eyes and offered that as *arghya*. He took those one thousand lotuses and held the vessel full of *arghya* in his hand. Hari, who had no other refuge, meditated on Shambhu and offered this *arghya*. Vishnu said, “O divinity! You know all the innermost desires of men. You alone are the refuge and the lord. There is no doubt about this.” He said this with tears in his eyes and merged himself completely into Ishvara. Along with Bhavani, Shambhu appeared before him. He embraced Hari firmly and bestowed many kinds of boons on him. He got back his *chakra* and regained his eye, as was the case earlier. At this, all the large number of gods praised Hari and Shankara. They praised Ganga, best among rivers, and Vrishadhvaja. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Chakra *tirtha*. Even if one hears about it, one is freed from all sins. If a person bathes or donates there and performs the water-rites for the ancestors, he is freed from all sins. Along with his ancestors, he goes to heaven. Even now, that *tirtha* can be seen to be marked with the sign of a *chakra*.’

Chapter 2(40) (Various *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘After Chakra *tirtha*, there is the place named Pippala *tirtha*. It is known as Chakra *tirtha* because the divinity Chakreshvara is present there and because Hari got back his *chakra* there. For the sake of obtaining the *chakra* from Lord Shankara, Vishnu himself remained there and worshipped him. That is the reason that *tirtha* is known as Chakra *tirtha*. The place where Shambhu was pleased with Vishnu is known as Pippala. ⁶⁶⁰ Even the great lord of serpents ⁶⁶¹ is incapable of describing the greatness of this spot. That is the reason Chakreshvara is also known as Pippalesha. O Narada! Listen devotedly to what I say. This has also been mentioned in the Vedas.’

‘There was a sage, famous by the name of Dadhichi. He possessed all the qualities. His immensely wise wife was born in a noble lineage and was devoted to her husband. She was Lopamudra’s ⁶⁶² sister and was known as Gabhastini. She was known by this name but was also spoken of as Vadava. Dadhichi loved her. Along with her, he always tormented himself through great austerities. Dadhichi was devoted to the *dharma* of being a householder and always had a fire burning in his house. He lived along the banks of Bhagirathi and worshipped gods and guests. He loved his own wife and was as serene as Kumbhayoni. ⁶⁶³ Because of his powers, there were no enemies like *daityas* and *danavas* in that region. The tiger among the sages went to the place where Agastya’s hermitage was. Having defeated the *daityas*, all the gods, Rudras, Adityas, the two Ashvins, Indra, Vishnu, Yama and Agni also arrived there. There were delighted sounds of “victory” and the large number of Maruts praised them. On seeing Dadhichi, tiger among sages, the lords of the gods bowed down before him. Dadhichi was also delighted and separately honoured the gods. Along with

his wife, he exhibited a householder's hospitality towards the gods. ⁶⁶⁴ He asked the gods about their welfare and the gods also asked Dadhichi and his wife about their welfare. They sat down with joyous minds and repeatedly bowed down before the *rishi*. The gods said, "O *rishi*! Since we have obtained the compassion of someone like you, we have now got something that is extremely rare in this world. O sage! You are like a tree that bestows every object of desire. O excellent sage! This is the kind of fruit that a man who is alive should get—bathing in the *tirthas*, compassion towards creatures and meeting a person like you. O sage! Listen to what we are affectionately telling you. We have come here after defeating the *daityas* and slaying the bulls among *rakshasas*. O brahmana! We are happy, especially after seeing you. Our weapons have not given us such fruits. Indeed, we are incapable of bearing them. O lord among sages! We do not see a place where we can lay down our weapons. If we keep them in heaven, the enemies of the gods will get to know and will steal them. That is also what will happen if we place the weapons in Rasatala. O one who shows honours! Therefore, let us keep our weapons in your sacred hermitage. O brahmana! There is no fear here from the *danavas* and the terrible *rakshasas*. There is no one who is equal to you in austerities and your commands protect this sacred place. O supreme among those who know about the *brahman*! We have already defeated the enemy and have killed large numbers of *daityas*. Enough of these weapons. They are a heavy load to bear and they have served their purpose. O lord of sages! Let us keep them in this place near you. We will enjoy divine objects of pleasure along with the women in celestial gardens like Nandana. Having accomplished our task, along with Indra, we will leave for our own respective abodes. The weapons will be protected here. Your commands are capable of holding and protecting them." Hearing their words, Dadhichi agreed to the words spoken by the gods, though his beloved wife tried to restrain him. "What do we have to do with the tasks of the gods? For those who know the sacred texts, for those who are devoted to the ultimate objective, for those who have lost attachment for worldly objectives and for those who have nothing to do with the activities of others, these can have

perverse effects. O sage! They will not bring happiness in this world, or in the next world. O noble brahmana! Listen. If you grant a place here for the weapons, those who hate the gods will hate us. O lord of sages! If the weapons are lost or stolen, the gods will be angry and will become our enemies. O supreme among those who know about the Vedas! In addition, there can be a sense of ownership towards something that belongs to others. As long as the object remains with one's own self, there is friendship. But the moment it is lost or taken away, enmity results. If one has the capacity to donate objects, one should donate them to those who are in need. There is no need to think about that. If a person does not have possessions, he should try to help others through thoughts, words and deeds. However, the virtuous do not approve the idea of keeping other people's possessions. O loved one! Therefore, instantly get rid of them.' Hearing the words of his beloved, the brahmana spoke to his wife, the one who possessed excellent eyebrows. Dadhichi said, 'O fortunate one! I have already given my word to the gods. Therefore, saying no will not bring me pleasure.' Hearing the words of her husband, the beloved wife remained silent. She thought, "Other than destiny, no one is capable of doing anything to men." The gods placed their radiant weapons there. Having accomplished their objective, the enemies of the *daityas* bowed down to the Indra among sages, placed their weapons there and went to their own world. When the gods had departed, the noble sage happily lived there with his wife, following *dharma*.'

'After they left, one thousand divine years passed. O lord among sages! The gods did not say anything about their weapons. They did not even seem to think about them. Dadhichi told Gabhastini, "O fortunate one! The enemies of the gods are now full of energy. They will hate me. Having deposited their weapons here, the gods do not seem to want them back. Please tell me what is appropriate." Full of humility, she spoke to her husband in these words. "O lord! I told you and you know what is appropriate under the circumstances. The strength of the *daityas* has increased a lot because of their austerities. They will use their own weapons to take these away." To protect the weapons, he pronounced *mantras* and washed them with sacred water. The extremely sacred water sucked up the

energy from all those weapons and Dadhichi drank up the water. The weapons were robbed of their energy and form. In the course of time, they gradually decayed. The gods returned and told Dadhichi, “On account of our enemies, we now suffer a great fear. O supreme sage! Please give us the weapons the gods deposited with you.” Dadhichi replied, “I was scared of the enemies of the gods and you did not return for a long time. I have drunk up the weapons and they are inside my body now. Please tell me what is appropriate under the circumstances.” Hearing his words, the gods spoke to him humbly. “O Indra among sages! Please give us our weapons. Are you capable of giving them to us or are you refusing? O lord among sages! Without our weapons, we will always be defeated and our enemies are well-nourished. Where will we go? O father! ⁶⁶⁵ The gods will now find it impossible to reside in heaven, in the mortal world, or in the nether regions. You are a noble brahmana who is full of austerities. In your presence, it is not proper for us to say anything else.” The brahmana replied, “Accept the weapons that are in my bones. There is no need to think about it.” The gods replied, “What will we do with this? Without weapons, the Indras among gods are reduced to the state of being women.” The excellent sage responded again, “Using yoga, I will give up my body. You can then construct excellent weapons, supreme in forms, out of my bones.” The gods asked him to do this. Dadhichi was never distressed in spirit and was like Agni in form. O lord of sages! At that time, his beloved was not near him and couldn’t address him in agreeable words. The gods were also scared of her. Not seeing her, they told the brahmana, “Please hurry.” Life is very difficult to give up. However, he cheerfully gave it up and said, “O gods! As you wish, accept this body. May all of you be pleased with my bones. What purpose does a body serve?” Saying this, he sat down in *padmasana*. ⁶⁶⁶ He fixed his eyes on the tip of his nose and was as pure as light. Using *yoga*, he slowly conveyed the fiery wind inside him up to the narrow cavity inside the heart. ⁶⁶⁷ The great-souled one fixed his intelligence in the immeasurable and supreme destination of the *brahman*, which is what should be meditated on. He united himself with the *brahman*. The gods saw that his body had become completely lifeless. The gods swiftly told Tvashta, “Make many

weapons immediately.” He told them, “How can I do this? O gods! This is the body of a brahmana. I am terribly scared and incapable of doing this. If the body is split apart, I can immediately make excellent bones out of the weapons.” The gods quickly spoke to cattle. The gods said, “O cattle! We will make your mouths as firm as the *vajra*. For welfare and for the sake of weapons, instantly tear apart Dadhichi’s bones. Give us the pure bones now.” They followed the words of the gods. They licked the bones clean and gave them to the gods. Not distressed at all, the gods quickly went to their own abodes and the cattle also left. Making the weapons for the gods, Tvashta also departed in great haste.’

‘After some time, the extremely fortunate one, who was loved by her husband, returned. She possessed good conduct and there was a son in her womb. She hurried there with a pot full of water in her hand. She had gone to worship Uma. She returned swiftly wishing to see the household fire, her husband and the hermitage. She carried some fruits and flowers. Her mind was tormented, because along the path, the necklace had got dislodged from around her neck and had fallen down on the ground. The bangles had also fallen down from her hand. Her right eye throbbed. ⁶⁶⁸ She thought, “This is a great misery. Alas! What calamity will visit me soon?” As she was returning, a meteor fell down and checked Pratitheyi. ⁶⁶⁹ Scared, she arrived in the hermitage, but did not see her husband in front of her. “Where could he have gone?” Amazed, Pratitheyi asked Agni. ⁶⁷⁰ Agni told her everything in detail—the arrival of the gods, the request for the body, the collection of the bones and their departure. Hearing everything, she was miserable. Full of misery and anxiety, she fell down on the ground. Pratitheyi said, “I am incapable of cursing the immortals. What should I do? I will enter the fire.” The virtuous lady controlled the rage and sorrow on account of her husband and spoke the following words, full of *dharma*. Pratitheyi said, “Everything generated in the world of humans is subject to destruction. Therefore, one should not grieve. For the sake of cattle, *brahmanas* and gods, men who earn good merits give up their own lives. Having obtained a capable body in this whirling wheel of *samsara*, beings who give up their beloved lives for the sake of gods and *brahmanas* are blessed. For all embodied beings,

the breath of life is certain to go away. There is not the slightest bit of doubt about this. Knowing this, lords give it up for the sake of *brahmanas*, cattle, gods and the distressed. I tried to restrain him, but he kept the weapons of the gods who sought refuge. What can those in the mortal world do to know the mind of the one who ordains?” Having said this, taking the body hair and skin of her husband, she worshipped the fire and entered it. ⁶⁷¹ Splitting aside her stomach, Pratitheyi took out the son in her womb and took him in her hand. She bowed down before Ganga, the earth, the hermitage, the trees and the herbs and patiently entered the hermitage. Praitheyi said, “This boy does not have a son. He is without relatives and those from his own *gotra*. He is without a mother. Let the large number of beings, the herbs and the guardians of the world protect this child. Those who look after and protect this child, who is bereft of his parents, will be praised and certainly deserve to be worshipped by Brahma and the others.” Saying this, with her mind fixed on her husband, she cast aside her son. She bowed down to the *pippala* trees and placed her son near them. With the sacrificial vessel in her hand, Praitheyi performed *pradakshina* of the fire and entered it. Along with her husband, she went to heaven.’

‘All the trees and residents of the forest wept, since *rishi* Dadhichi had nurtured them like a son. Remaining alive without him was like remaining alive without a mother. All the birds, animals and trees spoke to each other. The trees said, “Our parents, who naturally looked after us children, have gone to reside in heaven. They are the successful humans, having constantly showered affection on us. Before this, Dadhichi and Pratitheyi looked after us in a way that even a mother and a father don’t do. We are wicked. Shame on us. For all of us, it is certain from now on that this child is Dadhichi. This child is Pratitheyi. That is the eternal *dharma*.” Saying this, the trees and the herbs approached King Soma and asked him for the excellent *amrita*. Soma gave them the excellent *amrita* and they gave the child the *amrita*, which is loved by the gods. He was satisfied with this and grew, like the moon during *shukla paksha*. Since he was reared by *pippala* trees, the child became Pippalada. When he grew up, he was surprised and spoke to the *pippala* trees. Pippalada said, “Humans are born from humans. Birds are

born from birds. Herbs and plants grow from seeds. In this world, nothing contrary is ever seen. With hands, feet and the breath of life, how could I have been born from trees like you?” Hearing his words, the trees told him everything in the due order—Dadhichi’s death, the entry into the fire by the virtuous lady and the collection of bones by the gods. They told him everything in detail. Hearing this, he became full of misery and fell down on the ground. The trees comforted him and again addressed him in words that were full of deep meaning. When he was comforted, he again spoke to the herbs and the trees. Pippalada said, “I will slay the one who killed my father. Otherwise, it is impossible for me to live. However, a real son is one who pardons the foes and enemies of his father. He is the true son. Others are said to be enemies in the form of sons. It is said that a true son saves and does good even to his father’s enemies.” The trees took the child with them and went to Soma’s presence. The trees reported the child’s words to Soma. Hearing this, Soma addressed the child Pippalada in these words. Soma said, “In the proper kind of way, accept every kind of learning. O son! Through my command, you will obtain austerities, prosperity, auspicious speech, bravery, beauty, strength and intelligence.” Pippalada humbly replied to the lord of the herbs. ⁶⁷² Pippalada said, “I think all of these will be futile unless I rebuff those who killed my father. Therefore, I won’t do that. Instead, please tell me what I should do first. O supreme among gods! In which region, at what time, praying to which divinity, using what *mantra* and in what *tirtha* will my resolution be successful?” Chandra meditated for a long time and said, ‘There is no doubt that all objects of pleasure and emancipation originate from the divinity Maheshvara.’ He asked Soma again, “How can I possibly see Maheshvara? I am a child and my intelligence is childish. I do not possess the capacity, or the austerities.” Chandra replied, “O fortunate one! Go to Goutami and praise Chakreshvara Hara. O child! Ishana is pleased with very little effort. Mahadeva will be pleased. Shiva is compassion himself. The powerful Vishnu saw Shambhu himself and he bestowed boons on Vishnu. He gave Vishnu the *chakra* that is worshipped by the gods. O immensely intelligent one! Go to the river Goutami, in the region of Dandaka. The herbs know about Chakreshvara

tirtha. Having gone there, with a concentrated mind, praise Shankara, the lord of the gods. O son! When he is pleased, he will grant you everything you wish for.” O brahmana! Hearing the king’s words, Pippalada, the great sage, went to the place where Rudra, the lord of the universe and the one who bestowed the *chakra*, was.’

‘Full of compassion for the child, the *pippalas* took him to their own hermitage. He bathed in Godavari and bowed down before the lord of the three worlds. Having purified himself, with a concentrated mind, Pippalada praised Shiva. Pippalada said, “Giving up every kind of *karma* and every kind of desire, those who are persevering conquer this mind and their breath of life. For the sake of emancipation, they make efforts to seek refuge with the original divinity. I bow down before Shambhu. He is witness to everything. He is inside everyone’s *atman*. He is the lord of everything. He is a reservoir of every kind of art. Knowing everything that there is in my mind, let Smara’s enemy take compassion on me. ⁶⁷³ In earlier times, Dashanana conquered the lords of the directions and agitated Kailasa, worshipped by the gods. With the pressure of the toe, he was dispatched to Rasatala. ⁶⁷⁴ Hearing the shriek when the mountain made him suffer, along with the goddess, he laughed and gave him what he wished for. Though he was angry, he became pleased. O Maheshvara! You give even to those who are undeserving. With *soutramani* sacrifices, Bana always worshipped and praised Hara. ⁶⁷⁵ In beautiful and agreeable ways, he worshipped the one who wears a slice of the moon on his crest and obtained prosperity. Having defeated the enemies of the gods, Vishakha ⁶⁷⁶ worshipped and bowed down to his senior. But he became angry when he saw that Gananatha was seated astride his lap. ⁶⁷⁷ Soma laughed. Though he was seated on Isha’s lap, because of his childish nature, the child did not let go of his mother’s lap either. Unable to pacify his angry son, Soma assumed the Ardhanarishvara form.” ⁶⁷⁸ At this, Svayambhu ⁶⁷⁹ was extremely pleased and spoke to Pippalada. Shiva said, “O fortunate one! O Pippalada! Ask for the boon you desire.”

Pippalada replied, “O Mahadeva! My extremely illustrious father has been slain by the gods. He wasn’t proud. He was truthful in speech. My mother

was also devoted to her husband. O lord! After having heard in detail about how the gods caused their destruction, I am filled with grief and rage. I am no longer interested in remaining alive. Therefore, please grant me strength, so that I can destroy the gods. O one with the moon on your crest! With your exception, they cannot be slain by anyone in the three worlds.” Ishvara replied, “O unblemished one! If you are capable of glancing at my third eye, only then will you possess the capacity to destroy the gods.” The lord made up his mind to see the third eye, but he was incapable of seeing it. He said, “O Shankara! I am incapable of seeing it.” Ishvara said, “O child! If you wish to see the eye, undertake some austerities. When you see the third eye, there is no doubt that you will accomplish your wishes.” Hearing Ishana’s words, he made up his mind to undertake austerities. Dadhichi’s son had *dharma* in his soul and he remained there for many years. Like a strong person, the child was devoted to meditating on Shiva. Every day, he got up in the morning. Having bathed, in the proper way, he bowed down to his seniors. Seated comfortably, he fixed his mind on the *sushumna*, thinking about nothing else. ⁶⁸⁰ Crossing his hands over his navel, he made the *svastika* sign. He forgot everything about the world. He was indifferent towards a superior place or an inferior place and fixed his mind on the great Shambhu. Pippalashana ⁶⁸¹ saw the divinity’s third eye. He joined his hands in salutation and humbly spoke these words. Pippalada said, “Earlier, Shambhu, the lord of the gods, granted me a boon. If I managed to see the light of the third eye, at that very instant, all that I wish for would come true. This is what the lord of the gods had said. Therefore, please grant me an instrument that will destroy the enemy.” At this, the tops of the *pippala* trees said, “O immensely radiant one! Before your mother, Pratitheyi went to heaven, she said the following. ‘Men who are always engaged in harming others and forget about what is good for them, have minds that wander around here and there and descend into the noose of hell.’ Hearing what his mother had said, Pippalashana became angry. When a person blazes in pride, all virtuous words are pointless.’

‘The brahmana had remembered *vadava* and Kritya assumed the form of *vadava*. ⁶⁸² Kritya emerged from his eyes ⁶⁸³ and exclaimed, “Give! Give!”

For the sake of destroying all creatures, she had emerged from the womb of the fire. Pippalashana was meditating on his mother, Gabhastini, in the form when she still had the child in her womb. Because of that *yoga* of meditation, she ⁶⁸⁴ emerged from the fire inside the womb. She originated in an extremely fierce form, her tongue was as terrible as death. She asked Pippalada, “What is my duty towards you? Please tell me.” Pippalada told her, “Devour the gods. They are my enemies.” Pippalada was standing in front of her. Addressed in this way, she seized him. He asked, “O Kritya! What is this?” She replied, “I am doing what you asked me. This body has been created by the gods.” Terrified, the sage went to Shiva and praised the divinity. At this, Shiva spoke to Kritya. Shiva said, “Following my command, do not seize any living being who is within a distance of one *yojana*. O Kritya! Therefore, go far away and do what you have to do there.” Kritya, created by the rishi, stood at a distance of one *yojana* to the east of Pippala tirtha, assuming the form of *vadava*. A great blaze emerged from her, capable of destroying the worlds. On seeing this, all the gods were terrified and approached Shambhu. Scared in their minds, they went to Chakreshvara Pippaleshva, satisfied by Pippalada. The residents of heaven spoke to Shambhu. The gods said, “O Shambhu! Please save us. Kritya and the fire that originated from her is making us suffer. O Bhava! You are the refuge. You are the lord of everything. For those who are scared, you grant freedom from fear. There are creatures who are afflicted from all sides. They suffer and their minds are exhausted. O Shiva! For all such beings, you are the refuge. Requested by the rishi, Kritya emerged from the fire in the eyes. She wishes to destroy the worlds. There is no saviour other than you.” The lord of the universe told them, “Kritya will not oppress anyone who resides within a distance of one *yojana*. Therefore, night and day, you must always reside within this space. O immortals! Within this region, you will have nothing to fear.” The gods spoke to the lord of the gods again. “O one who is worshipped by the gods! You have given us heaven. O protector! Having given that up, how will we survive?” Hearing the words of the gods, Shiva addressed them in these words. Shiva said, “The god who has his eyes in every direction is here. The god who has his faces in every direction

is here. The one who melts with his rays is here. It has always been held that he is the father. Surya himself will always be here, alone. His remaining here is the same as everyone remaining here, in his form.” Agreeing with Shambhu’s words, the gods created Divakara⁶⁸⁵ from the *parijata* tree. Tvashta told Bhaskara, “O lord of the universe! By remaining here, you are yourself capable of protecting the gods. In our own portions, we will also remain here, in Shambhu’s presence.” Everywhere around Chakreshvara, within a distance of one *yojana*, on both banks of Ganga, the excellent gods remained there. Along the banks of Ganga, each occupied an area of one-fourth of an *angula*.⁶⁸⁶ O supreme sage! There are three crores and five hundred *tirthas*. Who is capable of hearing about or speaking about their praise? After this, the large number of gods humbly spoke to Shiva. The gods said, “O lord of the gods! O one who pervades the universe! Please grant peace to Pippalada.” Approving of these words, the lord of the universe spoke to Pippalada.’

‘Shiva said, “If the gods are destroyed, your father will not return. Your father gave up his life to accomplish the task of the gods. For those who are afflicted and suffering, is there any relative who can be as compassionate as him? O son! Therefore, he has gone to heaven and so has your mother, who was devoted to her husband. No one is held to be her equal, not Lopamudra, nor Arundhati.⁶⁸⁷ Thanks to his bones, all the gods have been victorious and are always happy. Therefore, he has obtained extensive fame and your mother has obtained inexhaustible good merits. O son! Everywhere, you have obtained even great fame and deeds. You should save those who have been dislodged from heaven, scared of your strength. Out of fear of you, some immortals have fled. You should save them. There is nothing on earth that earns more good merits than saving those who are afflicted. For as many days as a man’s sparkling fame exists in this world, when he goes to heaven, he resides in the world hereafter for that many years, without any ailment. In this world, those who possess no fame are like those who are dead. Those who are devoid of learning are like those who are blind. Those who are not devoted to donations are eunuchs. Those who are not devoted to *dharma* should be grieved about.” Hearing the words that the lord of the

gods spoke, the sage was pacified. He joined his hands in salutation before the protector. Bowing down, he spoke these words. Pippalada said, “I will engage myself in ensuring the welfare of those who have done me a good turn in thoughts, words and deeds. I will always be engaged in their welfare and that of others. I prostrate myself before Soma,⁶⁸⁸ who is worshipped by gods and others. There are those who have protected me, those who have reared me. I possess the same *gotra* as they do. I follow the same *dharma* as they do. May Shiva do what they desire. I will always bow down before the one who wears the young moon on his crest. O lord! O lord of the gods! There are those who have always reared me, like a mother and a father. In the three worlds, let this *tirtha* be known by their names. If they become famous, I will be freed from the debt I owe them. If the gods grant that this place is superior to all the *kshetras* and *tirthas* of the gods on the surface of the earth, I will always pardon the gods for the crime they have committed.” In the presence of the gods, with the one with one thousand eyes at the forefront, he softly spoke these words to the gods in clearly articulated syllables. The gods agreed with the generous words spoken by Dadhichi’s son. Knowing about the child’s intelligence, humility, learning, bravery, strength, courage, truthfulness in speech, devotion towards his parents and purity of sentiments, Shankara spoke to Pippalada. Shankara said, “O son! You will obtain whatever is your cherished desire and whatever is loved by the gods. Please tell me. You will get whatever is good for you. Do not hesitate to say what is in your mind.” Pippalada replied, “O Mahesha! Those who are devoted to *dharma*, bathe in Ganga and see your lotus feet—let them obtain everything that they wish for. After death, let them obtain a destination with Shiva. O lord! My father, my mother, the *pippalas* and the immortals obtained a destination with you. O lord of lords! After they have obtained happiness, let them go to your destination and see you.” Maheshvara, the lord of the gods, agreed to what Pippalada had said. He addressed him, along with the gods, and honoured them.’

‘The gods were happy at being freed from fear on account of him. In Shiva’s presence, all of them spoke to Dadhichi’s son. The gods said, “There is no doubt that you have done what is desired by the gods. The

commands of the lord of the gods ornament the three worlds and you have carried them out. O brahmana! What you asked for earlier, is for others and not for your own self. Therefore, tell us about something else. We wish to give you something.” The large number of gods repeatedly said this to the excellent brahmana. Pippalada joined his hands in salutation and bowed down to Shambhu, the original god, Uma and the *pippalas* and then spoke. Pippalada said, “I have always heard about my parents through words. I wish to see them. Blessed are creatures in this world who are under the control of their mother and father. They are the ones who always serve them and wait for their commands. Having obtained senses, a body, a lineage, capacity, intelligence and a form, a person should devote himself to serving those two. ⁶⁸⁹ He then accomplishes his objective. Even for animals and birds, it is very easy to see the mother. But that has been extremely difficult for me. Is that because of a sin I have committed? Had this been something that was difficult for everyone, it wouldn’t have mattered. However, this is very easy for some to obtain. Therefore, there is no sinner like me. O excellent gods! Even if I can see the two of them, that will be fruits obtained through my thoughts, words and deeds. If a person is born and cannot see his parents, which lord is capable of enumerating his sins?” Hearing his words, the gods consulted among themselves and spoke. “Today, you will certainly see your parents, the auspicious couple, seated astride an excellent *vimana*. They wish to see you. Abandon your sorrow, avarice and delusion. Make your mind serene.” The excellent gods told Dadhichi’s son, “Look. Behold. The two of them are in heaven, adorned with golden ornaments. They are astride an excellent *vimana*. The auspicious couple is there. Your parents are anxious to see you. They are being fanned by celestial women. They are being praised by *kinnaras*.” He saw his parents in Shiva’s presence, and bowed down before them. His eyes were filled with tears of delight. But somehow, he managed to speak to them. The son said, “Sons who make their parents cross over are those who extend the lineage. However, I am one who has only been able to split aside my mother’s stomach. Such am I, an extremely evil-minded person. Nevertheless, in my confusion, I am looking at them.” Looking at them, he

could not say anything more because of his misery. The gods spoke to Pippalada and his parents. The gods said, “O son! You are blessed. Your fame is known in this world and has reached heaven. You have directly seen the three-eyed one, you have reassured the gods. For you, the virtuous worlds will never be exhausted.” From heaven, flowers showered down on his head. O great sage! The gods pronounced words of “Victory”. Dadhichi, along with his wife, pronounced benedictions over their son. After bowing down to Shambhu, Ganga and the gods, he addressed his son in these words. Dadhichi said, “Get a wife. Be devoted to Shiva. Serve Ganga. Have sons. Perform sacrifices in the proper way and donate *dakshina*. O son! You will then accomplish your objective and reside in heaven for a long time.” Pippalashana told Dadhichi that he would act accordingly. Dadhichi and his wife repeatedly comforted their son. Taking the permission of the large number of gods, they then returned to heaven.’

‘With trepidation, all the gods spoke to Pippalada. The gods said, “O fortunate one! Pacify Kritya and the large fire that has originated from her.” Pippalada replied, “I don’t have the capacity to restrain her. I have never uttered a falsehood. You speak to Kritya. If she sees me, that extremely terrible one will do exactly the opposite.” To pacify her, the gods went and spoke to her and the fire. But both of them refused. “The brahmana has created me for devouring everything. In that way, the fire has been created from me. How can it be otherwise? Everything must be in our mouths, the five great elements and mobile and immobile objects. There must be nothing that remains.” Having consulted me, the gods spoke to them again. “In due order, both of you devour everything.”

O Narada! Listen to what Vadava told the gods. Vadava said, “O excellent gods! As you have desired, everything should be devoured by me.” O sage! Vadava became a river and merged with Ganga. There was an extremely terrible fire that originated from her. The immortals speak of this fire as the first among the elements. The gods said, “Water is known as the first among the elements, but you are also the first. Though you have originated from water, you are the first. Hence, devour the ocean. As we have told you, go and devour it, as you please.” Anala⁶⁹⁰ told the gods, “There is water there.

How can I go? I can go only if you convey me to that great water.” They asked, “O Agni! What will your progress be like?’ Agni told the gods, “There must be a maiden who possesses all the qualities. She must place me in a golden pot and take me there. That will be my progress.” Hearing his words, they spoke to the maiden Sarasvati. The gods said, “Bearing Anala on your head, quickly convey him to Varuna’s abode.” Sarasvati told the gods, “I don’t have the capacity to bear him alone. If I am helped by four others, I will quickly convey him to Varuna’s abode.” Hearing Sarasvati’s words, the gods separately spoke to Ganga, Yamuna, Narmada and Tapati. Placing Anala in a golden pot, they placed him on their heads and went to Varuna’s abode. They placed him in Prabhasa, where Somanatha, the lord of the gods and the lord of the universe, with the moon as his ornament, resides, along with the gods. The five rivers, including Sarasvati, took him there. The great fire resides there and slowly drinks the water.’

‘After this, the large number of gods spoke to Shiva, supreme among the gods. The gods said, “Please tell us how the bones, the gods and the cattle can be purified.” Shiva told them, “All of you carefully bathe in Ganga. There is no doubt that the gods and the cattle will then be freed from sins. Also wash the bones that have been obtained from the *rishi*’s body. When they are washed, they will become pure.” The place where the gods were freed from their sins is a *tirtha* that destroys all sins.⁶⁹¹ Bathing and donating there cleans the sin of killing a brahmana. The place where the cows were purified is known as *Go-tirtha*. An immensely intelligent one who bathes there obtains the fruit of the sacrifice of a cow. O Narada! The place where the brahmana’s bones were purified is known as *Pitri tirtha*. It enhances the delight of the ancestors. If the ashes, bones, nails and body hair of any living being fall into this *tirtha*, even if he is extremely evil in his deeds, he resides in heaven for as long as the moon, the sun and the stars circle. O Narada! Thus, three *tirthas* originated from Chakra *tirtha*. Having been purified, the large number of gods and cattle spoke to Shambhu. The cattle and the gods said, “We will leave for our own abodes. Surya is established here. As long as the one who makes the day is established here, all the gods are also established here. O lord of the universe! You should

now grant us permission to leave. Surya is the eternal *atman* of everything in the universe. We have established Divakara here and all the gods are in him. Ganga, the mother of the universe and Tryambaka are also here. All the gods exist when Tryambaka is present.” Taking their leave of Pippalada, the gods left for their own abodes. In the course of time, the *pippalas* obtained an eternal place in heaven. The powerful brahmana, Pippalada, obtained a position for the trees. Having worshipped Shankara, he made them the master of a *kshetra*. Dadhichi’s son was a sage who was fierce in his energy. He obtained Goutama’s daughter as a wife. Having obtained sons, prosperity and fame, along with his well-wishers, the persevering one went to heaven. Since then, that *tirtha* has been spoken of as Pippaleshvara. It is sacred and yields the fruits of all sacrifices. Even if one remembers it, sins are destroyed. What need be said about bathing or donating there, or seeing it? Chakreshvara and Pippaleshvara are the names of the lord of the gods. If one knows about this mystery, one will obtain everything that one desires. The place where Surya is established and the gods are also established is known as the *kshetra* of Pratishthana.⁶⁹² It is loved by the gods. This is an extremely sacred account. If one reads it, hears it, or remembers it, one lives for a long time and obtains riches and *dharma*. If one remembers Shambhu at the time of death, one will always obtain him.’

Chapter 2(41) (Naga *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Naga *tirtha* is auspicious and yields everything that one desires. The divinity known as Nageshvara exist there.⁶⁹³ Hear about it in detail. In the city of Pratishtana, there was a king known as Shurasena. He was born in the lunar dynasty. He was handsome and intelligent and was an ocean of qualities. Along with his beloved, he made great efforts for the sake of a son. After a long time, a son was born to him. But he was a snake, who was terrible in form. Surasena, lord of the earth, reared his son. Other than the king, no one knew that his son was a snake. Except his mother and his father, no one in the inner quarters also knew. The nurse-maid did not know, nor did the adviser, or the priest. On seeing that terrible snake, the supreme among kings and his wife were always tormented. However, they thought that having a snake was better than having no son. There was something special about this great snake. He always spoke like a human. The snake spoke to his father. ‘Please perform the rites of *chudakarma* and *upanayana*.⁶⁹⁴ Please arrange for me to study the Vedas. Until he studies the Vedas, a *dvija* is as good as a shudra.’⁶⁹⁵ Hearing his son’s words, Shurasena became extremely miserable. He summoned a brahmana and had the *samskaras* performed. When he had studied the Vedas, the snake spoke to his father. The snake said, “O king! O supreme among kings! Please perform my marriage. I desire a woman. It is my view that otherwise, the requisite tasks will not be completed. The father must perform all the *samskaras* recommended in the Vedas for his son. A father who does not do this cannot escape from hell.” Amazed, the father spoke to his son who was in the form of a snake. Shurasena said, “Even brave men are scared when they hear his voice. O son! Who will bestow a maiden on such a person? What will I do?” Hearing his father’s

words, the discriminating snake replied. The snake said, “O king! O lord of men! There are many kinds of marriages. Forcible abduction and marriage with weapons is also praised. ⁶⁹⁶ When a son gets married, a father accomplishes all his tasks. If this is not done, there is no doubt that I will die in Ganga.” The supreme among kings got to know about his son’s intention. Lacking a human son, he summoned his advisers for the sake of the marriage and addressed them in the following words. Shurasena said, “My son Nageshvara is the heir apparent and he is an ocean of qualities. He possesses qualities and is intelligent. He is brave and impossible to defeat. He scorches his enemies. When the *naga* is seated on a chariot with his bow, there is no one on earth who is his equal. His marriage must be undertaken. I am old. Passing on the burden of the kingdom to my son, I will be reassured. Until my beloved son has a wife, he will not give up his childish sentiments. Therefore, all of you should agree to this. Engaged in ensuring my welfare, please make efforts for the marriage. When my son is married, I will no longer have any worries. I will pass on the burden to my son and leave for the forest to perform austerities.” Hearing the king’s words, all the advisers humbly joined their hands in salutation. Full of delight, they spoke to the immensely energetic king. The advisers said, “Your son is superior in qualities and is famous everywhere. About your son’s marriage, there is nothing to be consulted. There is nothing to be thought about.” When the advisers said this, the excellent king turned somber. He did not tell his advisers that his son was a snake and they did not know. The king again said, “Who is a maiden who is superior in qualities? Who is the prosperous king born in a great lineage who is a reservoir of qualities? Who is best for a matrimonial alliance? With which brave one will a matrimonial alliance be praised?” Amongst the advisers, there was an extremely intelligent one. He had been born in a noble lineage and was exceedingly virtuous. He was engaged in the king’s tasks. Hearing the king’s words and knowing the king’s mind, he read the signs and spoke. The adviser said, “O great king! In the eastern region, there is a king named Vijaya. His horses, elephants and jewels cannot be enumerated. The intelligent king has eight sons who are great archers. Their sister,

Bhogavati, is like another Lakshmi herself. O king! I think she will be an appropriate wife for your son.” Hearing the aged adviser’s words, the king replied. The king asked, “How can his daughter become my son’s wife? Please tell me that.” The aged adviser answered, “O great king! I have noticed what is in your mind. Please grant me permission to carry out Shurasena’s task.” Hearing the words of the aged adviser, he honoured him with ornaments, garments and words. He sent him, along with a large army.’

‘He went to the eastern region and met the great king. In the proper way, he honoured him with words and other modes sanctioned by good policy. The intelligent one arranged for a marriage between the great king’s daughter, Bhogavati and King Shurasena’s intelligent son, who was a *naga*. In the matrimonial alliance, both true and false words were used. He honoured the king with ornaments, garments and other things. Having obtained these honours, the king said that he would bestow his daughter. After this, the immensely intelligent aged adviser returned to King Shurasena and told him that arrangements for the marriage had been made. After many days passed, the immensely intelligent aged adviser again went with a large army, garments and ornaments. He went quickly, surrounded by many other advisers. The intelligent chief adviser spoke to the great king⁶⁹⁷ about the marriage. Surrounded by the other advisers, the aged adviser spoke about everything. The aged adviser said, “King Shurasena’s son is known as Naga. He is intelligent and is an ocean of qualities. He does not wish to come here. O king! There are many kinds of marriages for a *kshatriya*. O immensely intelligent one! Therefore, let the marriage be with the weapons and ornaments. *Kshatriyas* and *brahmanas* speak the truth. Hence, allow this marriage to take place with weapons and ornaments.” Hearing the aged adviser’s words, Vijaya, the excellent king, took the words spoken the adviser and the king⁶⁹⁸ to be the truth. Therefore, the king arranged for a complete marriage of Bhogavati with the weapons, as is recommended in the sacred texts. He then sent her. Full of joy, Vijaya sent his own advisers and many cows and horses and a lot of gold along with her. Taking these with them, the advisers, with the aged adviser leading the

way, went to Pratishtana and presented Shurasena with his daughter-in-law. They presented her and reported the many words that Vijaya had spoken. They presented the wonderful ornaments, female servants and garments to Shurasena. The king welcomed and honoured Vijaya's advisers, who had come along with Bhogavati. He showed them a great deal of respect and having expressed his affection for Vijaya, allowed them to leave.'

'Vijaya's daughter was a maiden who was young and beautiful. The slender-waisted one always served her father-in-law and mother-in-law. Bhogavati's husband was an extremely large and terrible snake. He lived alone, in a deserted house that was beautifully adorned with jewels. It was strewn with fragrant flowers and was cool and pleasant. The snake repeatedly spoke to his mother and father. "Why doesn't my wife, the princess, approach me?" Hearing her son's words, the snake's mother replied. The king's wife said, "O nurse-maid! O extremely fortunate one! Quickly go to Bhogavati and tell her that her husband is a snake. Tell me what she says." The nurse-maid agreed and went to Bhogavati. In private, she humbly told her everything, from the beginning. The nurse-maid said, "O extremely fortunate one! O fortunate one! I know that your husband is a divinity. You should never reveal that he is a snake and not a man." Hearing her words, Bhogavati replied. Bhogavati said, "In general, a human woman obtains a human man as a husband. But a husband who is divine in form is only obtained through good merits." In due order, she went and reported all of Bhogavati's words to the snake, the snake's mother and the king. Hearing her words and remembering the course of *karma*, the king wept. Bhogavati spoke to the friend she had spoken to earlier. ⁶⁹⁹ Bhogavati said, "O fortunate one! Show me my beloved husband. My age is passing in vain." At this, she showed her the extremely terrible snake. In secret, she went to the place that was strewn with fragrant flowers and saw her husband, the extremely terrible snake, lying down, ornamented with jewels. She joined her hands in salutation and addressed her beloved in energetic words. Bhogavati said, "I am blessed that I have been favoured in this way. My husband is a divinity." Saying this, she remained on the bed, following the

inclinations of snakes and playing with the snake. The slender-limbed one embraced his limbs and sang songs. She satisfied her husband with fragrant flowers and drinks. O sage! Through her favours, the snake remembered what had happened. He remembered everything that had happened because of destiny.'

'In the night, the snake spoke to his beloved. The snake asked, "O princess! O beloved! When you see me, why are you not scared?" She replied, "O lord! Who is capable of transgressing what destiny has determined? The husband is the refuge for women. In particular, all the gods are in him." Pleased at this, the immensely intelligent Indra among *nagas* spoke to his wife. The snake replied, "I am satisfied with your devotion. What will I give you? What do you desire? O slender-limbed one! Through your favours, I have remembered everything. The wielder of Pinaka, the lord of the gods, was angry with me and cursed me. I am a *naga* and am the immensely strong son of Shesha. I was coiled around Maheshvara's arm. I was your husband earlier too. You were my wife, named Bhogavati. In private, Shambhu was once delighted at Uma's words and laughed loudly. O fortunate one! In the divinity's presence, I too laughed. At this, Shambhu became angry and cursed me that I would be reduced to this state. Shiva said, 'Though you will possess learning, you will be born as a snake in a human womb.' O fortunate one! Along with me, you also sought Shambhu's favours. O fortunate one! He again said, 'I will give you knowledge. In the form of a snake, you will worship me in Goutami. Through Bhogavati's favours, you will then be freed from your curse.' O one with the beautiful face! That is the reason I have obtained you, despite being reduced to this state. Please take me to Goutami and worship him, along with me. Freed from the curse, both of us will then go to Shiva. For everyone, in every possible situation, Shiva is the ultimate refuge." Hearing her husband's words, along with her husband, she went to Goutami. They bathed in Goutami and worshipped Shiva. O sage! Pleased, the illustrious one gave them divine forms. Along with his wife, the snake got ready to leave for Shiva's world and sought the permission from his parents. Knowing this, the immensely intelligent father replied. The father

said, ‘You are my only son. You are the eldest and the heir apparent. Therefore, rule over this entire kingdom and have many sons. When I leave for the supreme destination, go to Shiva’s city.’ Hearing his father’s words, the king of *nagas* agreed. Along with his wife, the one who was excellent in his vows could assume any form at will. Along with his father, mother and sons, he ruled over the extremely extensive kingdom. When his parents went to the world of heaven, he instated his sons in his own place. With his wife, advisers and others, he went to Shiva’s city. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Naga *tirtha*. The divinity Nageshvara was established there by Bhogavati. Bathing and donating there yield the fruits of all sacrifices.’

Chapter 2(42) (Matri *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Matri *tirtha* brings every kind of success to men. Even if a being remembers that *tirtha*, he is freed from all mental ailments. There was a terrible battle between the gods and the *asuras*. In the battle, the gods were unable to vanquish the *danavas*. With the gods, I went to the place where the wielder of the trident was standing. I joined my hands in salutation and praised him with many kinds of gentle words. “Having consulted among themselves, all the gods and *asuras* decided that they would churn the ocean. O Mahesha! The poison known as *kalakuta* resulted from this. Other than you, who is capable of swallowing it up? There is the one who is capable of robbing the three worlds of their dependence by striking them with flowers.”⁷⁰⁰ He deserves to be worshipped by all the gods. However, when he sought to strike Hara, he headed towards his own destruction. O Ananga’s enemy! O Shambhu! When the lord of waters was churned, you gave the residents of heaven the excellent object⁷⁰¹ and withdrew the poison into your own self. That certainly established your greatness.” The illustrious original creator, Trilochana,⁷⁰² was pleased with this. Shiva said, “O excellent gods! Speak. I will give you what you want.” The gods replied, “O Vrishadhvaja! On account of the *danavas*, we are suffering from a terrible fear. O lord! You are our protector. Slaughter the enemies of the gods. O Shambhu! You are a well-wisher without any motive. Had you not been there, what would have become of us? What would afflicted creatures, suffering from grief, have done?” Addressed in this way, he immediately went to the place where the enemies of the gods were. There was a battle between Shankara and the enemies of the gods. When Trilochana Shiva was exhausted, he assumed a form that was full of *tamas*. As he fought, drops of sweat fell down from his forehead. Resorting

to his *tamasa* form, he slaughtered large numbers of *daityas*. Seeing this form, the *asuras* fled to the slopes of Meru. Slaying all the *daityas*, Hara went to earth. Terrified, all of them rushed around here and there, on earth. Angry, Rudra also followed the enemy. Wherever Shambhu fought, drops of sweat fell down. O sage! Wherever Maheshvara's sweat fell down on the ground, Matrikas⁷⁰³ were generated and they were like Shiva in form. All of them told Maheshvara, "We will eat the *asuras*." Surrounded by large numbers of gods, the illustrious one spoke to all of them. Shiva said, "From heaven, the *rakshasas* came to earth and have now reached Rasatala. Listen to the words I speak. Let the Matrikas go wherever the enemies are. Scared of me, the enemies have now reached Rasatala. Follow the enemies to Rasatala." Following his words, they shattered the earth and went to the place where the *daityas* and *danavas* were. The Matrikas killed all the extremely terrible enemies of the gods. The Matrikas followed the same path and returned to the gods. Once the Matrikas left and until they returned, the gods went to the banks of Goutami and remained there. The place the Matrikas left from, and the place where the gods remained, is the extremely sacred *kshetra* of Pratishthana. It extends victory. The places where the Matrikas originated are separate Matri *tirthas*. There are holes there, for going to Rasatala. The gods spoke and granted them boons. "As long as Shiva is worshipped in this world, let the Matrikas also always be worshipped, in the same way." Saying this, the gods vanished, but the Matrikas remained there. The places where the goddesses remained are known as Matri *tirthas*. The gods also frequent them. What need be said about humans and others? Following Shiva's words, bathing, donations and water-rites performed for the ancestors there, are known to yield all the inexhaustible benefits. If a person constantly hears, reads or remembers this account of Matri *tirtha*, he obtains a long lifespan and is happy.'

Chapter 2(43) (Brahma *tirtha* and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘After this, there is another *tirtha*. Even the gods find it extremely difficult to reach this. This is known as Brahma *tirtha*. It bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation on men. O best among sages! When the *daityas* entered Rasatala and the Matrikas followed them, the soldiers of the gods remained there. My fifth face had assumed the terrible form of a donkey. With that face, I remained amidst the soldiers of the gods and said, “O *daityas*! Why are you running away? Do not be scared. I will come and quickly devour all the gods in an instant.” On seeing that I was about to devour them, all the gods restrained me. Scared, they told Vishnu, “O Vishnu! O lord of the universe! Please save us and cut off Brahma’s face.” The one who wields the *chakra* spoke to the gods. “I will sever his head with this *chakra*. But the moment it is destroyed, all mobile and immobile objects will also be destroyed. O gods! Therefore, I will tell all of you a *mantra*. Listen to me. There is no doubt that the one with the three eyes is the right person to sever the head, since he will hold it.” Thereupon, as suggested by me, I and all of them, praised Shambhu. “Sacrifices are seen to yield fruits for a short while. It is therefore held that they don’t yield fruits to those who undertake them. Hence, those who wanted fruits from donations have determined that the rites must be performed for the one with the matted hair.” At this, the lord of the gods was pleased. To accomplish the task of the gods and for the welfare of the worlds, he told the gods that he agreed. That face was evil in form and was extremely terrible. It made the body hair stand up. Using his nails as a weapon, he severed it and asked, “Where will it be placed?” Ila ⁷⁰⁴ told the gods, “I am incapable of bearing the head. I will go to Rasatala.’ The ocean said, “I can’t hold it. I will be dried up in an instant.” The gods spoke to Shiva. “Out of compassion for

the worlds, you must hold Brahma's head. If it is not severed, the world will be destroyed. However, if it is severed, because of the taint, that is exactly what will happen." While thinking about it, Somesha ⁷⁰⁵ held the head. Witnessing this extremely difficult task on the banks of Goutami, the gods devotedly prostrated themselves and praised the lord of the universe. The extremely terrible head would have harmed the gods. For the sake of devouring them, it had approached. However, using his needle-like nails as weapons, the one with the moon on his crest severed it. Out of compassion, because of the taint it would cause if it was released, he held onto that fragment. All the gods were standing near Brahma. On witnessing this deed, which surpassed the deeds of the gods, the gods praised Ishana. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Brahma *tirtha*. Even today, Brahma is present there with his four faces. If a person sees only the head, he obtains a destination with Brahma. Rudra himself remained there to cut off Brahma's head. That place is known as Rudra *tirtha*. The extremely wonderful place where Divakara himself remains in the form of the gods is known as Sourya *tirtha*. It yields the fruits of all sacrifices. If a person bathes there and sees the sun, he doesn't have to be born again. Ensuring what would bring benefit to the gods, Mahadeva severed Brahma's fifth head and placed it in a *kshetra* known as Avimukta. Along the banks of Goutami, in Brahma *tirtha*, this is the place where the head alone can be seen. This is the *kshetra* of Avimukta, where the head was placed. If a person sees Brahma's sacred head, he is purified even if he has killed a brahmana.'

Chapter 2(44) (Avighna *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The *tirtha* known as Avighna is said to remove all kinds of impediments. ⁷⁰⁶ In this connection, I will recount an incident. O Narada! Listen devotedly. The gods organized a sacrifice on the northern bank of Goutami. However, because of the taint of some impediments, the sacrifice could not be completed. At this, all the gods spoke to me and Hari. I meditated on what they had said and ascertained the reason. “The sacrifice has not been completed because of impediments created by Vinayaka. ⁷⁰⁷ Therefore, all of you should praise Vinayaka, the original god.” Agreeing to this, the large number of gods bathed along Goutami’s banks. They devotedly praised Ganeshvara, the divinity who is the original god. The gods said, “In every undertaking, Vighnaraja must always be worshipped by the gods, Isha and the one who originated from the lotus. ⁷⁰⁸ He should be bowed down to and thought about. We seek refuge in him. In bestowing desires of the mind, there is no other divinity who is Vighnaraja’s equal. Having determined this, before destroying the cities, ⁷⁰⁹ the destroyer of Tripura also worshipped him. Let Ambikeya quickly removed the impediments that exist in our great sacrifice. When he is meditated upon, all the mental wishes of those with bodies come to complete fruition. As soon as the goddess thought about him, a son was born and there were great festivities everywhere. Therefore, large number of gods who have accomplished their objectives speak of Vighnaraja as Sadyojata ⁷¹⁰ and bow down before him. When he was lying down on his mother’s lap and his mother tried to restrain him, he used his force to hide the moon in his father’s matted hair. This is how Ganadinatha found delight. Having drunk milk from his mother’s breast, he was content. Nevertheless, his mind was full of envy towards his brother. Therefore, Shambhu said, ‘Be Lamodara’.

⁷¹¹ Thus, Vighnaraja is known as Lambodara. Surrounded by a large number of gods, Mahesha said, ‘Start dancing’. Ganeshvara delighted him merely by the sound of the tinkling of his anklets. His father consecrated him. ⁷¹² He holds the noose of impediments in one hand. With the other hand, he holds an axe on his shoulder. If he is not worshipped, he causes impediments, even to his mother. Who is Vighnapati’s ⁷¹³ equal? In the pursuit of *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and other things, he must be worshipped first. The gods and *asuras* always worship him. If he is worshipped, there is no destruction. He must be worshipped first. I bow down before the first one. When he is worshipped and prayed to, all the fruits and success are seen to be appropriately obtained. He is extremely proud of his independent capability. He loves his brother. He rides on a mouse. I worship him. He satisfies his mother exceedingly well with delightful singing and dancing and all the desired kinds of amusement. I seek refuge with the illustrious Ganesha. Because of his father’s favours, he is always prosperous. For the benefit of the gods, I am using *stotrams*, bowing down and other *mantras* to seek refuge with the illustrious Ganesha. In ensuring victory against the cities, his father did something unparalleled. Instead of being worshipped by him, he cheerfully worshipped him. ⁷¹⁴ Hence, he removed all the impediments. I prostrate myself before Ganesha.” When the large number of gods praised him, Vighnesha spoke to them. Ganesha said, “Through my favours, from now on, all sacrifices performed by the enemies of the *asuras* will be without impediments.” When the sacrifice of the gods was over, Ganesha spoke to the gods again. Ganesha said, “Those who are firm in their vows and devotedly satisfy me with this *stotram*, will never suffer from poverty and misery. Let this be known. Those who attentively and devotedly bathe and undertake donations here will always be successful in all their objectives.” Simultaneously, the gods also agreed with this statement. When the sacrifice was over, the gods left for the abode of the gods. Since then, that place has been known as *Avighna tirtha*. It yields every kind of desire to men and destroys every kind of impediment.’

Chapter 2(45) (Shesha *tirtha* and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Shesha *tirtha* bestows every object of desire. I have already spoken about it and I will describe its nature. There was a giant *naga* named Shesha and this lord was the king of Rasatala. Surrounded by all the *nagas*, he went to Rasatala. But the *rakshasas*, *daityas* and Danu’s offspring⁷¹⁵ entered Rasatala and exiled Bhogipati.⁷¹⁶ He was agitated and spoke to me. Shesha said, “You gave Rasatala to me and also to the *rakshasas*. However, they are not giving me a place. Therefore, I have sought refuge with you.” At this, I told the *naga*, “O *pannaga*! Go to Goutami. When you praise Mahadeva there, you will obtain what you wish for. In the three worlds, there is no one else who can give you what you desire.” Urged by my words, the *naga* carefully bathed in Ganga. He joined his hands in salutation and praised the lord of the gods. Shesha said, “O lord of the three worlds! O one who destroyed Daksha’s sacrifice! I bow down to you. O original creator! I bow down to you. O one whose form is the three worlds! I bow down to you. O one with one thousand heads! I bow down to you. O one who brings about destruction! I bow down to you. O one with forms as Soma, Surya and Agni! I bow down to you. O one with the form as water! I bow down to you. O one who always has every kind of form! I bow down before you. O one with a form as Kala! I bow down before you. O Shankara! Save me. O lord of everything! O Somesha!⁷¹⁷ O one who goes everywhere! Save me. O lord of the universe! I bow down before you. Please grant me what my mind wishes for.” At this, Maheshvara was pleased and gave the *naga* the desired boon. For the destruction of the enemies of the gods—the *daityas*, *danavas* and *rakshasas*, he gave Shesha a trident and said, “Slay the bulls among the enemies with this.” When Shiva said this, with the other *nagas*, Shesha

went to Rasatala and used the trident to slay the enemies in a battle. When he had killed the *daityas*, *danavas* and *rakshasas* with the trident, the *naga* returned to the place where the divinity, Shesheshvara ⁷¹⁸ Hara was. A hole was created, along the path the king of *nagas* used to come to the place where the divinity was, that is, when he returned from Rasatala to see the divinity. Even now, the waters of Ganga flow through that hole and it is sacred. That water merges with Ganga and the flow has a confluence with Ganga. In front of the divinity, the *naga* created an extremely large sacrificial pit and offered oblations to him. Agni is always present there. At the confluence with Ganga, the water is hot. After having worshipped the lord of the gods, the immensely illustrious *naga* was delighted at having got what he wanted. Obtaining this from Shiva, he went to the nether regions of Rasatala. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Naga *tirtha*. It is sacred and yields everything that is desired. It destroys disease and poverty. It bestows a long lifespan and prosperity. It is auspicious. Bathing and donating there, bestow emancipation. This also happens if one devotedly hears about it, reads about it, or remembers it. The place where Shiva gave the trident is Shesheshvara *tirtha*. ⁷¹⁹ O tiger among sages! Along both banks, there are two thousand and one hundred *tirthas*. They bestow every kind of prosperity.'

Chapter 2(46) (Vadava and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Mahanala is also known as Vadavanala.’⁷²⁰ The divinity is Mahanala and the river is Vadava. O son! I will tell you about that *tirtha*. It destroys death, old age and other taints. In earlier times, the *rishis* performed a sacrifice in Naimisha forest. The ascetic *rishis* made Mrityu the *shamitri*.⁷²¹ While the sacrifice was going on, Mrityu stood there as the *shamitri*. Therefore, no mobile or immobile objects died. O best among sages! Barring the sacrificial animals, mortals became immortal. As a result of this, heaven became empty and the mortal world was crowded because Mrityu was ignoring it. At this, the gods told the *rakshasas*, “Go to the sacrifice of the *rishis*. Go and destroy that great sacrifice.” Hearing the words of the gods, the *rakshasas* spoke to the gods. “We will destroy the sacrifice. But what fruits will we get from this? Nowhere does anyone engage in an undertaking without a motive.” The gods told the *asuras*, “The sacrifice is also for you. Therefore, you should go to the excellent sacrifice of the *rishis*.” Hearing this, they quickly went to the place where the sacrifice was taking place. They went there to destroy it, especially because the gods had asked them to. Getting to know, the *rishis* asked Mrityu, “What will we do? Urged by the words of the gods, the *rakshasas* have come here to destroy the sacrifice.” The residents of Naimisha forest consulted with Mrityu. O Narada! Along with the *shamitri*, all of them left their own hermitages. They only took the sacrificial fire with them and left vessels and other things behind. To complete the sacrifice, they quickly went to Goutami. They bathed there. For the sake of their protection, they joined their hands in salutation and praised Mahesha, the lord of the gods. The *rishis* said, “In his pastimes, he created this entire universe. He is the creator of the three worlds and he is the one who

ordains. The universe is his form. He is beyond cause and effect. We seek refuge with that Someshvara.” Mrityu said, “Merely through his will, he destroys everything. He is the one who creates and preserves. He is the lord of the gods. I seek refuge with Shankara. He is immense in size. He is gigantic in strength. He is adorned with a great serpent. He is the divinity who has a huge form. I seek refuge with that Shankara.” Thus addressed, the illustrious one asked Mrityu, “What is it that you want?” Mrityu replied, “O lord of the gods! There is a terrible fear on account of the *rakshasas*. Please protect our sacrifice, so that the sacrifice can be completed.” The illustrious three-eyed Vrishadhvaja did this. With Mrityu as the *shamitri*, the sacrifice of the *rishis* was completed. To take their shares of the oblations, the immortals arrived there, in the due order. Along with Mrityu, the large number of agitated sages spoke to them. The *rishis* said, “You sent the *rakshasas* to destroy our sacrifice. Therefore, from now on, the wicked *rakshasas* will be your enemies.” Since then, the gods and the *rakshasas* have been enemies. Along with the unblemished *rishis*, the gods told the Kritya Vadava to be Mrityu’s wife and consecrated her accordingly. The water used for the consecration led to the creator of the river Vadava. The *lingam* established by Mrityu is known as Mahanala. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as the confluence of Vadava. The divinity Mahanala exists in that *tirtha* and bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation. Along both banks, there are one thousand *tirthas* there and they give everything that one wishes for. Even if one remembers these, all sins are destroyed.’

Chapter 2(47) (Atma *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘Atma *tirtha* is famous and bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation on men. I will describe its powers to you. Jnaneshvara Shiva is present there. Atri’s son was known as Datta ⁷²² and he was loved by Hara. His beloved brother, Durvasa, was accomplished in all kinds of *jnana*. He went to his father. Prostrating himself, he spoke humbly. Datta asked, “How can I obtain *jnana* about the *brahman*? Who shall I ask? Who will I go to?” Hearing his son’s words, Atri meditated and addressed him in these words. Atri replied, “O son! Go to Goutami and praise Maheshvara there. If he is pleased with you, you can obtain *jnana* from him.” Thus addressed, Atri’s son went to Ganga. He purified and controlled himself. Joining his hands in salutation, he devotedly praised Shankara. Datta said, “I have fallen into this pit of *samsara*. Because of destiny and delusion, I am hidden in this mire of misery in the world. I am enveloped in the darkness of ignorance. O lord of the gods! I do not know the supreme. I have been mangled by the strong trident of sin. The razor of worries has shattered me. I am scorched by the fierce heat of the five senses. I am exhausted. O Somanatha! Please help me to cross over. I am bound in the bondage of poverty. I have been struck by the fierce heat of disease. I have been attacked by the serpent of death. I am extremely scared. O Shambhu! What shall I do? I am suffering a great deal from birth and death, hunger and thirst, *rajas* and *tamas*. I have been overwhelmed by such old age. O protector! Behold my state and show compassion on me now. I am suffering many hardships on account of desire, anger, envy, insolence, pride and many other things. They have pierced me. O protector! Strike these enemies away. O protector! It is true that when a man is suffering from hardships and has fallen down, someone or the other will save him. O Somanatha!

However, with the exception of you, there is no one who has a word of pity for me. Until I utter the words ‘I bow down to Shiva’, I will have to suffer anger, fear, delusion, sorrow, ignorance, poverty, ailments, desire and other things and death. I do not possess *dharma*. I do not possess devotion. I do not possess discrimination. Where is there compassion in me? You are the one who bestows. You are the refuge. Therefore, let the word ‘Soma’ be fixed in my mind. O Somanatha! I do not wish to be a god or a king. But you should be in the lotus in my heart. I wish to be near the illustrious Soma’s lotus feet. Reflect on this and please do it. Though you know that I am a sinner, please listen to what I am saying. Let me be in a place where the word ‘Shiva’ is heard. Let Soma always be with me. O Gouri’s consort! O Shankara! O Somanatha! O lord of the universe! O ocean of compassion! O one who is the *atman* of everything! If such praises are heard in a place, surely a successful person resides there.” Hearing Dattatreya’s praise, the illustrious Hara was satisfied. Bhava, the creator of the universe, told the *yogi*, “I am the one who bestows boons.” Atri’s son replied, “O one who is worshipped by the gods! I seek the boon of knowledge about the *atman*, emancipation, extensive devotion ⁷²³ towards you and the greatness of this *tirtha*.” Shambhu said he agreed with this and vanished. Since then, learned ones have known that *tirtha* as Atma *tirtha*. O Narada! Bathing and donations there, yield emancipation.’

Chapter 2(48) (Ashvattha Pippala and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘To the north, there are Ashvattha *tirtha*, Pippala *tirtha* and Manda *tirtha*. Hear about their greatness. Earlier, the Lord Agastya, the illustrious lord of the southern direction, was sent by the gods to request Vindhya. Surrounded by one thousand sages, he slowly approached Vindhya. He went to the best among mountains, full of many trees. Vindhya, with one hundred summits, was challenging Meru and the sun. The mountain was exceedingly lofty. When Lopamudra’s patient husband, the sage, approached, he and other *brahmanas* were treated with hospitality. To accomplish the task of the gods, the best among sages praised the mountain and spoke to him. Agastya said, “O best among mountains! Along with these sages, who know the truth, I am going on a visit to the *tirthas*. I will go to the southern direction. O lord of the mountains! Please show me hospitality. Please grant me passage. Until I return, please remain in your present position. ⁷²⁴ Let it not be otherwise.” The excellent mountain agreed. Surrounded by the sages, the sage reached the southern direction. He slowly went to Goutami and consecrated himself for a sacrifice there. Surrounded by the *rishis*, he performed that sacrifice for an entire year.’

‘Kaitabha had two wicked sons. These two *rakshasas* were thorns in the path of *dharma*. In the residence of the gods, they were known as Ashvattha and Pippala. Ashvattha assumed the form of an *ashvattha* tree and Pippala assumed the form of a *brahmana*. They entered inside, wishing to destroy the sacrifice. Desiring to do this, those two evil-minded *danavas* assumed these forms. Ashvattha was in the form of a tree and Pippala was in the form of a *brahmana*. O store of austerities! Those two always oppressed the *brahmanas*. Whoever touched the *ashvattha* tree, was eaten by it. The

rakshasa Pippala assumed the form of a chanter of Sama hymns and devoured the disciples. Even now, *brahmanas* who chant Sama hymns are completely devoid of compassion. Because the number of *brahmanas* was declining, the sages got to know that this was because of the two *rakshasas*. Realizing this, the immensely wise ones resorted to the southern bank. They approached Shanaishchara, Surya's evil son.⁷²⁵ Firm in his vows, he was performing austerities. All the large number of sages went and told him about the deeds of the *rakshasas*. Surya's son told the large number of sages, "O *brahmanas*! When my austerities are completed, I will kill the two *rakshasas*. As long as my austerities are incomplete, I am incapable." The large number of sages replied, "We will give you our great stores of austerities." Addressed by the *brahmanas* in this way, Surya's son said that it would be done. Surya's son assumed the form of a brahmana and approached the *rakshasa* who was in the form of an *ashvattha* tree. As a brahmana, he performed *pradakshina*. While he was performing *pradakshina*, the wicked *rakshasa* took him to be a brahmana. As was always the case, he used his *maya* to devour him. When he was inside, he looked at his entrails with his eye. As soon as Ravi's evil son looked at him, the wicked *rakshasa* was reduced to ashes in an instant, like a mountain that has been struck by the *vajra*. After reducing *Ashvattha* to ashes, he went to the other one, who was in the form of a brahmana. He approached the *rakshasa*, who was a store of sin. He humbly approached, just as a disciple would approach a brahmana to study. As earlier, Pippala devoured Bhanu's son. One he had been devoured, as was the case earlier, he looked at his entrails with his eye. Through that glance alone, the *rakshasa* was reduced to ashes. Having slain both of them, Bhanu's son asked, "What else remains to be done? Let the sages tell me." With Agastya at the forefront, all the ascetic sages were filled with delight. Pleased, the *rishis* wished to bestow boons on Surya's slow-moving son. Pleased, Shani, Surya's powerful son, spoke to the *brahmanas*. Surya's son said, "On my day,⁷²⁶ if people control themselves and touch an *ashvattha* tree, let all their tasks be successful and let them not suffer hardships on account of me. Let this be known as *Ashvattha tirtha*. If men bathe here, let all their tasks be successful. There is

another boon too. ‘Throbbing of the eyes, throbbing of the arms, nightmares, worrying thoughts and the uprising of enemies. Let all these be quickly pacified for me.’ O *devarshi*! ⁷²⁷ On my day, if men rise in the morning, devote themselves to meditating on Shiva and touch an *ashvattha* tree while reciting this *mantra*, let the adverse effects of evil planets be dispersed for them.” Since then, that place has been known as Ashvattha Pippala *tirtha*. Shanaishchara *tirtha* is there and the one where Agastya performed his sacrifice. Other than the *tirtha* where the sacrifice was performed, there is the *tirtha* where the Sama hymns were recited. In this way, there are sixteen thousand and eight *tirthas*. Bathing and donating there, yield the fruits of all sacrifices.’

Chapter 2(49) (Soma *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘Great-souled ones have spoken about the place named Soma *tirtha*. Bathing and donations there yield the fruits obtained from drinking *soma*. Earlier, herbs were the mothers of the universe and were honoured by living beings. Those goddesses are also my mothers. They originated before the earliest who originated. *Dharma*, studying and the rites of sacrifices are established in them. They hold up everything in the three worlds, mobile and immobile objects. There is no doubt that they cure every kind of ailment. They provide food and save every kind of life. These herbs deserve to be worshipped by the universe. Without any ego, they spoke to me in these words. The herbs said, “O supreme among gods! Give us a king and a husband.” Hearing their words, I spoke to the herbs. “All of you will obtain a husband and a king who will enhance your delight. O sage! Hearing the word “king”, they spoke to me again. “Where will we go?” I replied, “O mothers! Go to Goutami. If she is satisfied, you will get a king who is worshipped by the worlds.” O best among sages! They went and praised the river Goutami. The herbs said, “O Goutami! O one who is loved by Shambhu! O one with the auspicious waters! People on earth are miserable because of their association with many kinds of sins. If you had not descended on earth, what would have happened to them? O queen of rivers! What would have been the fate of those who have come to earth with human bodies? O Ganga! You are the one who destroys the aggregate of great sins. O mother! You can easily be reached. O mother of the universe! O Ganga! O one who deserves to be worshipped by the three worlds! Who is capable of knowing about your powers? Though his body is embraced by Gouri, Smara’s enemy ⁷²⁸ holds you on his head. O mother! I bow down before you. O one who bestows what is desired! I bow down before you. O

one who is full of the *brahman*! O one who destroys sins! I bow down before you. O one who flows from Vishnu's lotus feet! I bow down before you. O one who flows from Shambhu's matted hair!" Thus praised, the goddess asked, "What will I give you?" The herbs replied, "O mother of the universe! Please give us a husband, a king who will be extremely energetic." Addressed by the herbs, the river Ganga answered in these words. Ganga said, "My form is made out of *amrita* and the herbs are the mothers of *amrita*. I will give you Soma as a husband. He has *amrita* in his *atman* and he is like you." The gods, the *rishis* and Soma agreed with these words. The herbs also agreed with these words and returned to their own abodes. The great herbs obtained Soma, who has *amrita* in his *atman*, as their king. He is the one who counters every kind of torment and sin. The place where this occurred is known as Soma *tirtha* and it confers the fruits of drinking *soma*. Bathing and donations there lead to the ancestors going to heaven. If a person constantly hears this, reads it, or remembers it with devotion, he obtains a long lifespan, daughters and riches.'

Chapter 2(50) (Dhanya *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Dhanya *tirtha* bestows everything desired on men. It gives men what has not been asked for and peace. It counters every kind of calamity. Having obtained King Soma as a husband, the herbs were delighted. They spoke these words, agreeable to all the worlds and to Ganga. The herbs said, “There is an auspicious chant in the Vedas. Those who know the Vedas know about it. “The land near Ganga is as revered as his mother, indeed, it is his mother. ⁷²⁹ From that region, if a man donates some land that yields crops, he obtains everything that he desires. This land has the form of Vishnu, Brahma and Isha. If a man cheerfully and devotedly donates such land with crops, cattle and herbs, his learning becomes inexhaustible and he obtains everything that he desires. The king of the herbs is Soma. Soma is the lord of the herbs. Knowing this, if a person donates herbs to a person who knows about the *brahman*, he obtains everything that he desires and attains greatness in Brahma’s world.” Pleased with Soma as their king, the herbs repeatedly said this. The herbs said, “O king! Near the Ganga, if someone donates us, you make him cross over. You are the lord of the excellent herbs. Everything mobile and immobile is under your control.” The herbs spoke to King Soma in this way. “O king! If a person gives us to *brahmanas*, you make him cross over. Our form is that of the *brahman*. Our form is that of the breath of life. O king! If a person gives us to *brahmanas*, you make him cross over. O king! If a person controls himself, observes the vows, worships us and always gives us to *brahmanas*, you make him cross over. We pervade everything in the universe, mobile and immobile. O king! If a person gives us to *brahmanas*, you make him cross over. O king! If a person gives *havya*, *kavya*, *amrita*, anything that is consumed or anything that is superior to that,

you make him cross over. This is a chant in the Vedas. O king! If a person hears this, remembers it or reads it devotedly, you make him cross over.” The place on the banks of Ganga where the herbs recited this chant along with King Soma, is spoken of as Dhanya *tirtha*.⁷³⁰ Since then, that *tirtha* has also been named after herbs, Soma, amrita, the chant of the Vedas and Matri *tirtha*. A person who bathes, meditates, offers oblations, donates, performs water-rites for the ancestors and donates food there deserves infinite benefits. Along both banks, there are one thousand and six hundred *tirthas*. They destroy every kind of sin and enhance every kind of prosperity.’

Chapter 2(51) (Confluences of Vidarbha and Revati)

Brahma said, ‘The confluence of Vidarbha and the confluence of Revati are auspicious. I will tell you what happened there. Those who know about the ancient accounts know about this. There was a *rishi* named Bharadvaja and he was superior to others in austerities. Revati was his sister. She was ugly in form and her voice was loathsome. On seeing that she was disfigured, her brother, the powerful Bharadvaja, who lived on the southern bank of Ganga, was filled with great worries. “Who will I bestow this maiden, my sister, on? She is terrible in form. No one will accept her. However, my sister has to be given away. Alas! No one should have a daughter who becomes the cause of miseries. For any living being, even if he is alive, this is like death at every step.” In his extremely beautiful hermitage, he thought in this way. An excellent sage came there, to see Bharadvaja, who was generally firm in his vows. He was sixteen years of age and his form was handsome. He was serene and controlled. He was a reservoir of qualities. He was known by the name of Katha. He bowed down to Bharadvaja. Bharadvaja also honoured the brahmana Katha in the proper way. Standing in front of him, he asked him about the reason why he had come. Katha told Bharadvaja, “I have come to you for the sake of learning. That is the reason I wished to see you. What is appropriate should now be done.” Bharadvaja told Katha, “Study what you wish—the Puranas, the *smṛiti* texts, the Vedas and the many sacred texts on *dharma*. O immensely wise one! I know them all. Without any delay, tell me what appeals to you. You have been born in a noble lineage. You are devoted to *dharma*. You are devoted to serving your *guru*. You are proud and possess a sharp memory. ⁷³¹ Such a disciple is only obtained through a lot of good

merits.” Katha replied, “O brahmana! I am your disciple and I am without any sins. Please instruct me. I am devoted to serving. I am faithful. I have been born in a noble lineage. I am truthful in speech.” Bharadvaja agreed and bestowed every kind of learning on him. Having obtained this learning, Katha was pleased and spoke to Bharadvaja. Katha said, “O *guru*! I wish to give you the *dakshina* that your mind desires.”⁷³² Please tell me, even if it is something extremely difficult to get. You are my *guru* and I prostrate myself before you. Having obtained the knowledge, out of delusion, if a person does not give the *guru* the fee, he descends into hell for as long as the moon and the stars exist.” Bharadvaja answered, “Accept this maiden. Following the norms, make her your wife. She is my sister. I ask for the *dakshina* that you make her happy.” Katha said, “A disciple is always like a *guru*’s son. Since the *guru* is like a father, I am like her brother. How can there be a relationship with her?” Bharadvaja answered, “Act in accordance with my words. Make your pledge come true. I command you that this is your *dakshina*. O Katha! You have learnt everything. Now turn your mind towards supporting Revati.” Katha agreed with his *guru*’s words and accepted her hand. When Revati was bestowed in the proper way, Katha looked at her. For the sake of Revati’s beauty and his prosperity, he worshipped Shankara, the lord of the gods, there itself. Since Shiva was pleased, Revati became extremely beautiful, lovely in all her limbs. There was no one who was superior to her in beauty. The water with which Revati was sprinkled flowed into the Ganga as river. After her name, the river was known as Revati. It bestows every kind of beauty and good fortune. For the sake of an auspicious form and success, he again used *darbha* grass to perform many kinds of sprinkling. This became the river Vidarbha.”⁷³³ Full of faith, if a man bathes at the confluence of Ganga and Revati, he is freed from every kind of sin and obtains greatness in Vishnu’s world. O sage! In that way, if a person faithfully bathes at the confluence of Vidarbha and Goutami, he instantly obtains objects of pleasure and emancipation. Along both banks there, one hundred excellent *tirthas* exist. They destroy every kind of sin and bestow every kind of success.’

Chapter 2(52) (Purna *tirtha* and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘On Ganga’s northern bank is the place known as Purna *tirtha*. Even if a man bathes there inadvertently, he obtains what is auspicious. Which living being is capable of describing the greatness of Purna *tirtha*? The wielder of the *chakra* and the wielder of Pinaka, both reside there. In ancient times at the beginning of the *kalpa*, Ayush had a son named Dhanvantari. He performed many kinds of sacrifices, a horse sacrifice being the most important. He donated many kinds of objects and enjoyed all the objects of pleasure. He understood the perversity associated with objects of pleasure and became supremely non-attached. Dhanvantari thought, “If one undertakes austerities, offers oblations and performs *japa* on the summit of a mountain, on the far side of the ocean along the banks of the river Ganga, in the temples of Shiva and Vishnu and particularly in sacred confluences, one obtains eternal benefits. Understanding this, he tormented himself through great austerities there. Resorting to the feet of Bhimesha, ⁷³⁴ he was filled with *jnana* and non-attachment. At the confluence of Ganga with the ocean, he undertook extensive austerities. Earlier, in a battle, a great *asura* had been repulsed by this king. He fled and scared, hid in the ocean for one thousand years. When Dhanvantari left for the forest, his son obtained the kingdom. When the king ⁷³⁵ developed non-attachment, Tamas ⁷³⁶ emerged from the ocean. O sage! On the banks of Ganga, King Dhanvantari was engaged in austerities and the powerful *asura*, named Tamas, went there. Devoted to knowledge about the *brahman*, the king was constantly engaged in *japa* and offering oblations. To destroy his enemy, Tamas emerged from the ocean. ‘This powerful king has repulsed me several times. I will now destroy this enemy.’ That is the reason Tamas emerged from the ocean. He used his *maya* to assume the

form of a beautiful woman and appeared before the king. She possessed excellent eyebrows and was beautiful to behold. Singing, dancing and laughing, she arrived there. For a long time, he looked at her beautiful limbs. She was serene and devotedly followed him. Taking pity, he spoke to her. The king asked, 'Who are you? Who do you belong to? Why are you residing in this desolate forest? O fortunate one! Who are you laughing at? I am asking you. Please tell me.' Hearing his words, the lady replied to the king. The lady said, 'When you are here, who else can be the reason for my joy? I am Indra's prosperity. On seeing you, I have been smitten with desire. That is the reason, full of delight, I am repeatedly roaming around in front of you. Unless a person possesses innumerable good merits, I am impossible for him to obtain.' Hearing her words, the king instantly abandoned the austerities, which were very difficult to perform. He thought about her. He was devoted to her. He was attached to her. She became the king's only refuge. O brahmana! When his extensive austerities had been destroyed, Tamas vanished.'

'Meanwhile, I arrived there, to bestow a boon on him. I saw that he was distracted, having deviated from his austerities. It was as if he was dead. Using many different kinds of arguments, I comforted the excellent king. "Your enemy, named Tamas, has caused this deviation from austerities. O king! With the objective accomplished, he has departed. You should not grieve. Women not only give men delight, they also torment them. This is true of all of them. Why should it not be true of one who was created out of *maya*?" Forgetting his distraction, the king joined his hands in salutation and spoke to me. The king asked, "O Brahma! How will I obtain what is beneficial for me? What will I do? O Brahma! How will I obtain what is beyond austerities?" I answered, "Make every effort to praise Janardana, the lord of the gods. He will give you what is the best. That is the way you will obtain success. He is the creator of everything in the universe. He is the ancient being who can be known through the Vedas. He is the one who bestows every kind of success on men. In the three worlds, there is no one else." The excellent king went to the Himalayas, supreme among mountains. He joined his hands in salutation and devotedly praised Vishnu.

Dhanvantari said, “Victory to Vishnu. Victory to the one who cannot be thought of. Victory to Jishnu. ⁷³⁷ Victory to Achyuta. Victory to Gopala, Lakshmi’s lord. Victory to Krishna, who pervades the universe. Victory to the lord and master of all living beings. Victory to the one who lies down on a *pannaga*. Victory to Govinda, who goes everywhere. Victory to the creator of the universe. I bow down before you. Victory to the divinity who enjoys the universe. Victory to the one who holds up the universe. I bow down before you. Victory to the lord who is existence and non-existence. Victory to Madhava, the one who is full of *dharma*. Victory to the one who is desired, the one who bestows objects of desire. Victory to Rama, the ocean of qualities. Victory to the one who bestows victory and nourishment, the one who is the lord of nourishment. Victory to the one who bestows welfare. Victory to the lord and master of living beings. Victory to the one who arranges for honour. Victory to the one who bestows *karma*, the one who is *karma*. Victory to the one who is attired in yellow garments. Victory to the lord of everything, the one who is everything. Victory to the one whose form is auspicious. Victory to the supreme lord of living beings. Victory to the one who can be known through the Vedas. I bow down before you. Victory to the one who bestows birth, the one who is all those who are born, the *paramatman*. I bow down before you. Victory to the one who bestows emancipation, the one who is emancipation. O Keshava! Victory to the one who bestows objects of pleasure. Victory to the one who bestows worlds, the lord of the worlds. Victory to the one who destroys sin. Victory to the one who is devoted to devotees. Victory to the one who holds the *chakra*. I bow down before you. Victory to the one who bestows honour, the one who is honour. Victory to the one who is revered by the worlds. Victory to the one who bestows *dharma*, the one who is *dharma*. Victory to the one who enables the crossing over of *samsara*. Victory to the one who bestows food, the one who is food. Victory to the lord of speech. I bow down before you. Victory to the one who bestows strength, the one who is strength. Victory to the victorious one who bestows boons. Victory to the one who bestows sacrifices, the one who is sacrifices. Victory to the one with eyes like the petals of a lotus. Victory to the one who bestows donations, the one

who is donations. Victory to the one who slew Kaitabha. Victory to the one who bestows deeds, the one who is deeds. Victory to the one who bestows forms, the one who assumes forms. Victory to the one who bestows happiness, the one whose *atman* is happiness. Victory to the one who purifies those who purify. Victory to the one who bestows peace, the one who is peace. Victory to the one who originated from Shankara. Victory to the one who bestows drinks, the one who is drinks. Victory to the one whose form is light. Victory to Vamana, the lord of riches. Victory to the one who has smoke on his flag.⁷³⁸ Victory to the one who is everywhere in the universe, in the form of a donor. I bow down before you. For those who live and subsist in the three worlds, you alone are the one who is accomplished in destroying hardships. O glorious Pundarikaksha!⁷³⁹ O ocean of compassion! O Vishnu! Place your hand on my head.” Praised in this way, the illustrious one, the one who holds the conch shell, the *chakra* and the mace, the one who bestows every kind of desire and prosperity, asked him to choose a boon. Dhanvantari’s mind was pleased that the one who holds a *chakra* was ready to bestow a boon on him. Govinda, the lord of the gods, was standing in front of him, ready to bestow a boon. The king told him, “I desire to obtain the kingdom of the gods. O Vishnu! If you grant me that, I will accomplish everything that I wish for.” Praised and worshipped properly in this way, Vishnu vanished from the spot. Progressively, the king became the lord of the gods.’

‘The one with the one thousand eyes came under the subjugation of a lot of his earlier *karma* becoming fructified. Therefore, he was dislodged from his own position thrice—by Nahusha when Vritra was killed, in connection with the killing of Sindhusena and because he had intercourse with Ahalya.⁷⁴⁰ These were the reasons. Remembering these incidents, Indra was tormented by thoughts and distress in his mind. Therefore, the lord of the gods addressed Vachaspati⁷⁴¹ in these words. Indra asked, “O lord of speech! Once in a while, why am I dislodged from my kingdom and prosperity by men, even though I am superior? The progress of *karma* in living beings is mysterious. Who knows the truth? O one who is eloquent in speech! Other than you, no one knows this mystery in all creatures.”

Brihaspati told Hari, “Go and ask Brahma. He is the one who knows about the past, the present and the future. O immensely wise one! He is the one who will tell you how this happens.” Those two immensely wise ones came to my presence and bowed down. They joined their hands in salutation and addressed me in these words. Indra and Brihaspati said, “O illustrious one! Shachi’s consort is pervasive in his intelligence. O protector! What fault causes him to be dislodged from his kingdom? You should clear up this doubt.” O brahmana! I thought about it for a long time and spoke to Brihaspati. “The sin of violating *dharma* causes him to be dislodged from his kingdom. Among those with bodies, the violation of *dharma* occurs in different ways—taints in the time and the place; transgression of faith and *mantras*; not donating appropriate *dakshina*; donating objects that should not be given; and in particular, showing disrespect to gods and *brahmanas*. The effects of these are impossible to give up and cause mental torment and loss of status. If one causes injury to *dharma*, the mind is agitated. Since one is anxious, the tasks are not successfully completed. When one’s own *dharma* is left incomplete, why should injury not result?” O unblemished one! I told the two of them about the earlier account. Ayush had a prosperous son named Dhanvantari, who was extensive in his intelligence. Tamas created an impediment for him and this was destroyed by Vishnu. I properly described the incidents from the earlier births. Hearing this, the two of them were surprised and spoke to me again. Indra and Brihaspati asked, “O supreme divinity! How can the taint be countered?” I thought about it again and told them, “Listen to how the taint can be countered. Hear about the reason behind every kind of success and how one can cross the ocean of *samsara*. Hear about the refuge for those whose senses are tormented and about how living beings can obtain emancipation. Go to the goddess Goutami and praise Hari and Shankara. In the three worlds, barring those two and her, there is no other means for purification.” O excellent sage! At this, both of them went to Goutami.’

‘They happily bathed there and simultaneously praised the two divinities. Indra said, “I bow down to Matsya, Kurma and Varaha. I prostrate myself before you. I bow down to you. I bow down to the divinity Narasimha. I

bow down to Vamana. I prostrate myself before you. I bow down to Hayarupa. I bow down to Trivikrama. I bow down to the one who has the form of Buddha, the one who has the form of Rama and Kalki. I bow down to the lord who is Ananta and Achyuta. I bow down to Jamadagni's son. I bow down to the one who has the form of Varuna and Indra, the one who has the form of Yama. I bow down to the divinity who is the supreme lord. The three worlds are his form. Your radiant form has Sarasvati in your mouth. You are omniscient. I bow down to you. O unblemished one! You are the one with Lakshmi. Your radiant form has Lakshmi on your chest. You possess many arms, thighs and feet. You possess many ears, eyes and heads. It is from you that happiness is obtained. In many ways, you are the one who is bliss. O Hari! When men seek refuge with you, their adversity, jadedness and misery end. You are an ocean of compassion.” ⁷⁴² Brihaspati said, “O Isha! You are the subtle and infinite light. You are infinite in form. You are Omkara ⁷⁴³ and you are beyond Prakriti. You are the form of consciousness and bliss. You are everything. O Isha! Those who desire emancipation praise you. O Isha! Even those who possess no desire worship you through the five great sacrifices. ⁷⁴⁴ They cross the ocean of *samsara* and obtain their supreme desire of entering your divine world and form. They are impartial in their intelligence in the way they look at all creatures. Against the six waves, their sentiments are serene. ⁷⁴⁵ They use their *jnana* to cast aside the fruits of *karma*. O Shambhu! They meditate and enter you. This is not obtained through the *dharma* of *jatis*, the sacred texts of the Vedas, *dhyana*, *yoga* or the *dharma* of *samadhi*. Rudra Shiva Shankara is obtained through devotion and a serene mind. O divinity! O Soma! I bow down before you. O Shambhu! Though I am foolish, your feet are the manifest form of emancipation. Through devotion towards them, I will obtain your body. *Jnana*, sacrifices, austerities, *dhyana* and oblations yield great fruits. However, those excellent fruits are also obtained through constant devotion to Someshvara. O one in whom the universe resides! O one who is always loved by all living beings! Devotion towards you represents the flight of stairs through which one obtains the fruits that are seen and heard of, heaven and emancipation. Those fruits are obtained

through your feet. However, persevering ones do not speak about that flight of stairs. O compassionate one! Hence, let me be devoted towards you. I do not know the means whereby one should serve your form. O Isha! Use your greatness to glance towards us, as if towards a relative. We are sinners, but show us your favours. You are the gross and the subtle. You are without beginning. You are eternal. You are the father and the mother. You are the existent and the non-existent. You are praised in this way in the *shruti* texts and in the Puranas. I bow down to Someshvara Isha, who is praised in this way.” At this, Hari and Hara, the two lords of the gods, were pleased.’

‘Hari and Hara said, “Ask for the boon that is in your mind, even if it is extremely difficult to obtain. Indra told the lords of the gods, ‘My kingdom is repeatedly lost and regained. Let that sin be pacified. Let me be stable in my kingdom. Let everything that belongs to me be steady. If the two lords of the gods are extremely pleased, let everything always remain stable for me.’ They honoured Hari’s ⁷⁴⁶ words and said that they approved of them. Extremely pleased, the two of them glanced towards them with smiling faces. They never leave. They are without support. They are without transformations. They have their own respective forms. They are refuges for all the worlds. They are the ones who bestow objects of pleasure and emancipation. Hari and Hara said, ‘This great *tirtha* has three divinities. Goutami bestows whatever is wished for. Using the following *mantra*, one should lovingly bathe in her. For the great Indra’s consecration, let Brihaspati pronounce the auspicious benediction. Let the two of us be remembered for prosperity, stability and success. “Let all the good deeds I have performed in this and earlier lives achieve fruition. O Godavari! I bow down before you.” Remembering this, if a person bathes in Goutami through our favours, all his acts of *dharma* will become complete. He will be freed from all the sins committed in earlier lives and become pure.’ Pleased, Indra of the gods and Dhishana ⁷⁴⁷ acted in that way. The divine *guru* performed Indra’s great consecration. The sacred river that originated from the water is known as Mangala. It bestows everything that is auspicious and its confluence with Ganga is sacred. Vishnu pervades the universe. Indra praised him. Thus, Shakra obtained an image of the lord of

the universe that is revered by the three worlds. There, it is known by the name of Govinda. The wielder of the *vajra* obtained a cow that is revered by the three worlds. Hari gave it and Hari became Govinda. ⁷⁴⁸ O sage! There is a place where Brihaspati, the preceptor of the gods satisfied Maheshvara. Because of this, the kingdom of the great-souled Indra of the gods became stable. There, the divinity's *lingam* is Siddheshvara and it is worshipped by the gods. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Govinda. The confluence of Mangala is the supreme Purna *tirtha*. It is also famous as Indra *tirtha* and is also known after Brihaspati. The divinities there are Siddheshvara, Vishnu and Govinda. Any good deeds that are performed there, like bathing and donations, bring inexhaustible benefits and one obtains learning. The place is extremely dear to the ancestors. If a person constantly hears about the greatness of this *tirtha*, reads about it and remembers it, he gets back the kingdom he has lost. Along both banks, there are thirty-seven thousand *tirthas*. O tiger among sages! Along both banks, they yield every kind of success. There is no other *tirtha* that yields great fruits like Purna *tirtha*. If a man does not frequent it, his birth is futile.'

Chapter 2(53) (Rama *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Rama *tirtha* destroys the sin of killing a brahmana. Even if one remembers it, one is freed from all sins. In the Ikshvaku lineage, there was a powerful *kshatriya* who was famous in the worlds. He was strong, intelligent and brave. He was like Shakra Purandara. Like Bali, he ruled over the kingdom of his father and grandfather. O immensely wise one! He was King Dasharatha and he had three queens—Koushalya, Sumitra and Kaikeyi. They were extremely fortunate and had been born in noble lineages. They possessed beauty and qualities. O sage! The king was the lord of the kingdom of Ayodhya. His chief priest was Vasishtha, supreme among those who knew about the *brahman*. There was no physical ailment in the kingdom, no famine. There was no drought, nor any mental ailment. All the *brahmanas*, *kshatriyas*, *vaishyas* and shudras happily subsisted in their own separate *ashramas*. That Indra among kings, the extender of the Ikshvaku lineage, ruled in this way. For the sake of the kingdom,⁷⁴⁹ there was a battle between the gods and the *danavas*. Sometimes, the gods triumphed. Sometimes, the others did. While this continued, the three worlds suffered excessively. O Narada! At this, I spoke to the gods, *daityas* and *danavas*. However, they did not act in accordance with what I said. An extremely great battle took place between them again. The gods went and spoke to Vishnu and to Ishana, who pervades the universe. Both of them spoke to the gods, *daityas* and *danavas*. “Become strong through austerities. Fight after that.” They agreed to this. All of them engaged in austerities, observing rituals and vows. However, full of envy, the gods attacked the *rakshasas* again. There was an extremely terrible battle between the gods and the *danavas*. The gods did not win. Nor did the *daityas* and *danavas*.⁷⁵⁰ While the battle was going on, an invisible voice

was heard. The voice from heaven said, “The side aided by King Dasharatha will win, not the other.” Hearing this, for the sake of victory, both the gods and the *danavas* went to him. Vayu rushed to the king and spoke to him. Vayu said, “O king! Come to the battle between the gods and the *danavas*. It has been heard that the side aided by King Dasharatha will be victorious. Therefore, you must side with the gods, so that the gods are victorious.” Hearing Vayu’s words, King Dasharatha replied, “O Vayu! I will come. This is my pledge. Return happily.” When Vayu had left, the *daityas* arrived before the lord of the earth. They said, “O illustrious one! You should help us. O prosperous King Dasharatha! If you are with us, we will be victorious. Hence, you should help the lord of the *daityas*.” The lord of men answered, “Vayu asked me earlier and I have promised him. O *daityas* and *danavas*! Please leave.” Thus, the king went to heaven and fought against the *daityas*, *danavas* and *rakshasas*. Namuchi’s brother was watching the battle with the gods. Using many kinds of sharp arrows, he shattered the axle of the king’s chariot. Because he was preoccupied, the king did not realize that the axle of his chariot had been shattered. O Narada! Kaikeyi, the one with the excellent eyebrows, was standing near the king and noticed. Though the one who was good in her vows saw this, she did not inform the king. Instead, noticing that the axle had got shattered, she placed her own hand there instead. O tiger among sages! She used her hand like an axle and this was exceedingly wonderful. On the chariot where she had placed her hand, the best among charioteers defeated the *daityas* and sons of Danu. He obtained many boons from the gods. Taking the permission of the gods, he returned to Ayodhya. Half-way along the path, the great king noticed his beloved. Witnessing what Kaikeyi had done, he was filled with great wonder. O Narada! Therefore, he granted her three boons. Accepting what the king had said, Kaikeyi replied to him in these words. Kaikeyi said, “O Indra among kings! For the moment, let the boons granted by you remain with you.” The Indra among kings gave his beloved ornaments. Victorious on his chariot, the king happily returned to his own city. When the appropriate time comes, what does one not give to one’s beloved wife?’

‘On one occasion, Dasharatha was wandering around in the forest, surrounded by those who were addicted to hunting. In the night, he stopped the flow of water. ⁷⁵¹ A lord of the earth should be free from the seven vices. ⁷⁵² But this was destiny. Though he knew because he was under the subjugation of destiny, he did not act accordingly. The mighty-armed one used his sharp arrows to kill the animals that entered the watering-hole to drink. Listen to the catastrophe that destiny brought about. The king entered that watering-hole in the excellent mountain. There was an aged man named Shravana. He could neither see, nor hear. His wife was also like him. They spoke to their son. The mother and the father said, “We are thirsty and the dark night has set in. O son! For the aged like us, though you are a child, you are the only means for us to remain alive. Shame on the lives of aged people who are blind and deaf. O son! Our bodies are suffering from old age. Shame on our lives. Men should remain alive for only as long as they possess prosperity and firm bodies and as long as their commands are not ignored. After that, in *tirthas* or in other places, they should die.” Hearing the words of the aged couple, the son, who was devoted to his seniors, replied in sweet words, so that he could dispel their unhappiness. The son said, “As long as I am alive, why should you suffer from this kind of misery? If a son’s conduct is such that he does not do what brings delight to his parents, what is the point of his possessing a body? He only increases his family’s anxiety.” Saying this, the great-minded one bowed down to his parents. He placed his aged parents on the branch of a tree. Taking a water-pot in his hand, the *rishi*’s son left. The *rishi* ⁷⁵³ did not know about the king and the king did not know about the brahmana. Both of them were in a hurry. With his water-pot, the brahmana bent down near the water, so as to quickly fill it with water. Taking the brahmana to be an elephant, the king pierced him with sharp arrows. A wild elephant should not be killed by a lord of the earth. Nevertheless, the king pierced him. What can one do if one is deceived by destiny? Pierced in his inner organs, he miserably addressed him in these words. The brahmana said, “I am a brahmana. Why have you perpetrated this wretched act against me? O father! ⁷⁵⁴ I have never committed a crime against you.” Hearing the words spoken by the

afflicted sage, the king was unable to move. He lost all enterprise. However, slowly, he approached the place. He saw the excellent brahmana, blazing in his energy. As if he had been struck by a stake, he fell down unconsciousness. After comforting and steadying himself, the king spoke. The king asked, “O tiger among *brahmanas*! Who are you? Why have you come here? Please tell me. I have committed a sin. Please tell me about the best means for atonement. O immensely intelligent one! A person who has killed a brahmana should not be touched or seen by the *varnas*,⁷⁵⁵ not even by one who has been born as a *shvapaka*.” Hearing the king’s words, the sage’s son addressed him in these words. The sage’s son replied, “My breath of life is about to leave, but I do wish to tell you something. Know that your willful and ignorant conduct has led to your *karma* being cooked. I am not grieving for my own sake. But my parents are aged. Who will tend to them? They are blind and I was their only son. Without me, how will they survive in this great forest? Alas! This is my misfortune. My serving my parents will suffer. I have been alive so far, but will lose my life now. Because of destiny, what have you done? Nevertheless, take this water-pot and go there quickly. So that they do not die, give them this water.” Saying this, he gave up his life in that great forest. Casting aside his bow and arrows, the king grasped the water-pot. He quickly went to the spot in the great forest where the two aged ones were. Though they were aged and it was night, they were conversing with each other. The aged ones said, “We are anxious. Is he angry with us? Has he been devoured? He is like our staff⁷⁵⁶ and he has not yet returned. What will we do? What will happen to us? Among all mobile and immobile objects, a son like him is not to be found. Even when he is reprimanded, he does not act against the words of his parents. If we are unable to see him, our life is hard as the *vajra*. But the breath of our lives does not quickly emerge from our bodies.” In the forest, the aged couple spoke to each other in many similar ways. At that time, King Dasharatha slowly approached the spot. Hearing his footsteps,⁷⁵⁷ they thought that the son had come. The aged ones said, “O son! Where have you come from? Why has it taken you such a long time? You are like our sight. Why aren’t you saying anything? Are you angry that you are the son

of a blind couple?” He was afflicted by grief, as if he had been struck by a stake. He was miserable because of his evil act. He was scared. O Narada! The Indra among kings spoke. “Please drink the water.” They heard the king’s words and remarked, “These aren’t words spoken by our son. Who are you? First tell us that. We will drink the water later.” The king spoke to them. The king said, “Your son is where the watering-hole is.” Hearing this, the miserable couple replied, “Please tell us the truth and not what is false.” At this, the king told them everything that had happened. The aged couple fell down. They said, “Take us there. But do not touch us. The sin of touching someone who has killed a brahmana is never destroyed.” The excellent king took the aged Shravana and his wife there, to the spot where their son had fallen down. They touched him and lamented. The aged couple said, “The separation from our son will bring about our death. O wicked one! You will also come by your death through separation from your son.” O brahmana! As they were saying this, their breath of life departed. The king lit the funeral pyre for the aged couple and the *rishi*’s son. O sage! Miserable, the king returned to his city. He told Vasishtha everything, in detail. For kings who belonged to *surya vamsha*, Vasishtha was the ultimate refuge. Vasishtha consulted with other excellent *brahmanas* about the means for atonement. Vasishtha said, “Summon Galava, Vamadeva, Jabali, Kashyapa and others here and make efforts for a horse sacrifice. Undertake a horse sacrifice, with copious amounts of *dakshina*.” Along with the *brahmanas*, King Dasharatha performed the horse sacrifice.’

‘Meanwhile, an invisible voice was heard. The voice from the sky said, “King Dasharatha’s body has been rendered pure. One can now have an association with him. He will have sons. Through the favours of his eldest son, the king will be freed from his sin.” After many days had passed, through Rishyashringa, lord among sages, sons were born. They were like gods and were born to accomplish the tasks of the gods. Koushalya’s son was Rama, while Sumitra’s son was Lakshmana. Kaikeyi’s sons were Shatrughna and Bharata, who was supremely intelligent. All of them were intelligent. They were loved by the king and were obedient to him. The

rishi, Prajapati Vishvamitra, came before the king. O immensely intelligent one! He asked for Rama and Lakshmana for the sake of protecting sacrifices. The sage knew about their greatness. The aged king had obtained sons after a very long time. He refused. The king said, “O sage! In my old age, through the great working of destiny, they have somehow been born to me. These two sons bring me a great deal of joy. I will give you my body and this kingdom, but not these two sons.” At this, Vasishtha told King Dasharatha to do what was asked. Vasishtha said, “O king! Those born in Raghu’s lineage ⁷⁵⁸ have not been taught to refuse anything that is asked for.” With some effort, the king spoke to Rama and Lakshmana. The king said, “Please protect the sacrifice of *brahmarshi* Vishvamitra.” Telling his sons this, the king let out warm sighs. He acted in accordance with the sacred texts and handed over his two sons to Vishvamitra. They agreed with what Dasharatha had said and repeatedly prostrated themselves before him. For the sake of protecting, they cheerfully went along with Vishvamitra. Pleased with them, the sage happily bestowed on them the great knowledge known as Maheshvari, the science of *dhanurveda*, the sacred texts, human and divine weapons, the knowledge of fighting with chariots, the knowledge of fighting with elephants, the knowledge of fighting with horses, the knowledge of fighting with maces and *mantras* for summoning and withdrawal. ⁷⁵⁹ Rama and Lakshmana imbibed all these different kinds of knowledge. For the welfare of the residents of the forest, in the forest, they killed Tataka. By touching Ahalya with the foot, they freed her from the curse. They killed the *rakshasas* who arrived to destroy the sacrifice. Having obtained all the knowledge, with bows in their hands, they protected the sacrifice. Vishvamitra, lord of sages, completed his great sacrifice. With both the sons, he went to see King Janaka. Taking the permission of his *guru*, along with Soumitri, ⁷⁶⁰ in the midst of the kings, Prince Rama exhibited his wonderful skill with the bow. ⁷⁶¹ Pleased at this, Janaka bestowed Sita, born from Lakshmi’s portion, on him. O sage! Listening to what Vasishtha said, the prosperous King Dasharatha arranged for the marriages of Bharata, Shatrughna and the others.’

‘Many days passed. With everyone’s permission and with the permission of his *guru*, the king decided to hand over the kingdom to him. ⁷⁶² Manthara was sent by evil destiny. Urged by her and overcome by jealousy, Kaikeyi created an impediment by asking that the king not bestow the kingdom on him, that he be sent to the forest and that Bharata be given the kingdom instead. ⁷⁶³ To make his father’s words of pledge come true, with Soumitri and with Sita, he entered the great forest. The minds of the virtuous are pure. In addition, because of his own qualities, Rama emerged, readying himself for a period of exile in the forest, with Lakshmana and Sita. He was devoid of any hankering for the kingdom. He thought of the curse imposed by the brahmana and about the qualities possessed by Rama, Soumitri and Sita. Overwhelmed by great sorrow, King Dasharatha miserably gave up his life. O immensely wise one! Like all mobile and immobile objects, because of the wicked deed he had committed, the king was taken away by Yama’s followers. O Narada! In Yama’s abode, the king was conveyed to many terrible and fierce hells, Tamisra and others. The king was flung there, in different types of hells. O immensely wise one! There, the king was cooked, sliced, crushed, pulverized, dried, stung and burnt many times. In this way, he was cooked in terrible hells. In the forest, Rama reached Chitrakuta. O immensely wise one! He spent three years there. He then proceeded to the southern direction and reached Dandaka forest. This region is famous in the three worlds and bestows everything auspicious. He entered that great and fierce forest frequented by *daityas*. The *rishis* had abandoned it because of fear, but he killed the *daityas* and *rakshasas*. Serving the *rishis*, he roamed around in Dandakaranya.’

‘O Narada! Listen attentively to what occurred there. While the king was in hell, Rama slowly reached within five *yojanas* of Goutami. Yama spoke to his own servants. “Rama, Dasharatha’s intelligent son, is proceeding towards Goutami. There is no doubt that you should take the king, his father, out from hell. As long as Rama is within a distance of five *yojanas* from Goutami, his father should not be cooked in hell. If you messengers do not act in accordance with my sacred words, then all of you will be immersed in terrible hell. The virtuous say that Goutami’s waters are

supreme. They unite with Shiva's Shakti. Therefore, those waters are honoured and worshipped by Hari, Brahma and Mahesha. If anyone crosses her, that sin can never be countered. If a sinner's son remembers Ganga on any occasion, even if the sinner has been submerged in many impenetrable hells, he obtains emancipation. What need be said of a son like this, who is stationed near Goutami? No one is capable of cooking him in hell now."

Yama's servants heard the words spoken by the lord of the southern direction. The king, the lord of Ayodhya, was being cooked in hell.

Listening to his words, they took him out of that terrible hell and spoke these words. Yama's servants said, "O tiger among kings! Since you have a son like this, you are blessed. Who obtains a good son like this, so that one can obtain rest in this world and in the next world?" Having rested, the king slowly spoke to the servants in these words. The king said, "I was repeatedly cooked in terrible hells. Why have I been taken out from there? You should tell me quickly." One of them was tranquil in his mind and he replied to the king. Yama's messenger said, "This secret of the Vedas, the sacred texts and the Puranas are carefully preserved. But it is being revealed. This is because of the powers of both your son and the *tirtha*.

Your prosperous son, Rama, has come to Goutami. O supreme among men! That is the reason you have been taken out from the terrible hell. O supreme among kings If Rama and Lakshmana bathe in Goutami, remember you and offer you *pinda*, you will be freed from all your sins and go to heaven." The king answered, "I will go there and tell my two sons about your words. You are my refuge and you should grant me permission." Hearing the king's words, Yama's servants took pity on him. They gave him permission and the king went to his two sons. Because of the terrible pain his body had been through, he sighed repeatedly. He looked at himself. Full of shame, he remembered what he had done. As he wished, Raghava ⁷⁶⁴ roamed around and reached Ganga. Rama and Lakshmana were near Goutami's banks. Along with Vaidehi Sita, they followed the norms and bathed. Along the banks of Goutami, there was nothing to eat. At that time, there were those who resided along the banks of Goutami. Seeing them, Lakshmana was unhappy ⁷⁶⁵ and spoke to his brother, Rama. Lakshmana said, "We are the

sons of Dashartha and you possess such strength. Nevertheless, there is nothing for us and the residents along the banks of Ganga to eat.” Rama replied, “Nothing can counter the *karma* that has been ordained. The earth is full of food and we desire food. O Soumitri! However, it is also true that we have not offered oblations through the mouth of a brahmana. We have neglected the earth. We have not offered oblations to the gods and worshipped them. O Lakshmana! That is the reason those who are born are always hungry. We must bathe and worship the gods. We must offer oblations into the fire. Then, at the right time, the divinity will arrange for us to get food.” O brahmana! Having witnessed the progress of *karma*, the brothers conversed in this way. At that time, King Dasharatha slowly arrived at the spot. On seeing him, Lakshmana pulled the string of his bow and quickly said, “Wait! Are you a *rakshasa* or a *danava*? Wait!” On seeing that he continued to approach, he added, “Go away. Behold. King Rama, the son of Dashartha, who always does what is auspicious and in accordance with *dharma*, is here. He is devoted to his seniors and is firm in adherence to the truth. He serves gods and *brahmanas*. Raghava, who possesses the capacity to protect the three worlds is here. Evil-doers like you are not allowed to enter this place. O sinner! If you enter, you will be killed.” Hearing his son’s words, he reflected for a while on the consequences of wicked deeds. With a downcast face, he joined his hands in salutation and softly addressed his two sons and daughter-in-law in these words. The king said, “I am King Dasharatha. O sons! Listen to my words. I am surrounded by the sin of having killed three *brahmanas*. That is the reason I face this misery. Look at my body. It has been sliced and cooked in hell.” Rama, Lakshmana and Sita joined their hands in salutation.’

‘All of them prostrated themselves on the ground and addressed him in these words. Sita, Rama and Lakshmana asked, “O father! O supreme among kings! What deed has led to such fruits?” He told them what had happened and about the slaying of the three *brahmanas*. The king said, “O sons! Having killed a brahmana, no one can escape.” Filled with great misery, all of them sank down on the ground. The king’s son ⁷⁶⁶ remembered everything—the exile of the king, the mother and the father,

the onset of misery, the progress of *karma* and the descent into hell and was filled with confusion. Seeing that the king was unconscious, Sita addressed him in these words. ⁷⁶⁷ Sita said, “Great-souled ones like you do not grieve because of a hardship. They think of how human destiny can be countered. Even if one grieves for one thousand *yuga*, a calamity cannot be averted. When a calamity arises, discriminating people never behave in that way. O lord of men! What is the point of this futile misery? The sin of that first death was extremely terrible. Please let it be given to me. That brahmana was innocent and was accomplished in the Vedas and *Vedangas*. He was devoted to his parents and his conduct was auspicious. I will follow the sacred texts and undertake the atonement for that sin. The two of you ⁷⁶⁸ should not grieve. After that, Lakshmana will take up the sin of the second death and you accept the one that is left.” Sita firmly uttered these words, which were full of *dharma*. When both of them ⁷⁶⁹ agreed with this, Dasharatha spoke. Dasharatha said, “You are the daughter of Janaka, who knows about the *brahman*. But you have not been born from a womb. ⁷⁷⁰ You are Rama’s wife. It is no wonder that you should speak in this way. But there is no need for you to go through the least bit of exertion. Through bathing in Goutami, donations and the offering of *pinda*, I will be freed from the three sins of killing *brahmanas* and will go to heaven. O one born through Janaka! You have said what is appropriate for your own lineage. Such women convey the lineage to the other side of the ocean of *samsara*. Through Godavari’s favours, nothing is extremely difficult to obtain.” They prepared to offer *pinda*. However, the slayer of enemies ⁷⁷¹ did not see anything that could be offered as food and spoke to Lakshmana. Lakshmana humbly told him, “Here are *inguda* fruits. ⁷⁷² These will suffice.” He instantly brought those oilseeds. Rama’s mind was a trifle unhappy at the disagreeable prospect of offering a *pinda* to his father in Ganga, using oilcakes. However, a divine voice said, “O son of a king! Give up this sorrow. You have been dislodged from the kingdom and have come to the forest. You possess nothing. You are not deceitful. You follow *dharma*. You should not grieve. If a person uses deceit to obtain wealth and uses that to undertake rites of *dharma*, he is a sinner. Listen to what the sacred texts say.

O Rama! Listen attentively. O king! ‘The gods should be offered the food that a man himself partakes.’ As soon as the *pinda* was placed on the ground, he could no longer see his father. The place where the dead body fell down is known as the excellent Shava *tirtha*.⁷⁷³ Even if a person remembers it, a large number of major sins are destroyed. Astride their own respective *vimanas*, the guardians of the worlds, the Rudras, the Adityas and the two Ashvins came there. His father was in their midst, astride an extremely radiant *vimana*, praised by *kinnaras*. His form was like that of an Aditya. However, though he saw the gods on their *vimanas*, he could not see his own father. Therefore, Rama joined his hands in salutation and asked, ‘Where is my father?’ At this, there was a divine voice that addressed Rama and Sita. ‘King Dasharatha has been freed from the three sins of killing *brahmanas*. O son! Look at him, surrounded by the gods.’ The gods said, ‘O Rama! You are blessed. You have accomplished your objective. Your father has gone to heaven. Blessed is the person who saves his forefathers from the many kinds of hell. He ornaments the three worlds. O mighty-armed one! Look at him, freed from sins and as resplendent as the sun. Even if he possesses prosperity, a sinner is like a tree that has been burnt down. Even if a person possesses nothing, a person with good deeds is seen to be like the one with the moon on his head.’⁷⁷⁴ On seeing his son, the king showered benedictions on him. He honoured him and spoke. The king said, ‘O fortunate one! O unblemished one! You have succeeded in your objective. I have crossed over. In this world, a son who makes his ancestors cross over is blessed.’ To accomplish the tasks of the gods, the large number of gods spoke to Rama, best among men. ‘O son! Go, as you please.’ Hearing their words, Rama spoke to the gods. Rama asked, ‘O gods! What else needs to be done for my father, my *guru*?’ The gods replied, ‘There is no river that is Ganga’s equal. There is no son who is your equal. There is no divinity who is Shiva’s equal. There is no *mantra* that is equal to Omkara. O Rama! You have done everything that needs to be done for your *guru*. O Rama! O one who bestows honours! Because of his son, your father has crossed over. We will leave for our own abodes. You can also go wherever you wish.’ At these words of the gods, Lakshmana’s elder

brother and Sita were delighted. Amazed at witnessing Ganga's greatness, he spoke the following words. Rama said, 'How wonderful are Ganga's powers. Nothing in the three worlds is comparable. We are blessed that we have seen Ganga, who purifies the three worlds.'

'Full of great joy, he instated the divinity Maheshvara there and attentively worshipped Ishana with the sixteen kinds of service. ⁷⁷⁵ The excellent divinity possessed thirty-six *kalas*. ⁷⁷⁶ Joining his hands in salutation, Rama praised Shankara. Rama said, "I bow down to you. O Shambhu! O Purusha! O ancient being! I bow down to you. O omniscient one! O one who is beyond all sentiments! I bow down to you. O Rudra! O lord without decay! I bow down to you. O Sharva! With my head lowered, I bow down to you. I bow down to the supreme divinity, who is without transformation. O Umapati! O preceptor of the worlds! I bow down to you. I bow down to you! O one who destroys poverty! I bow down to you. O one who destroys disease! I bow down to you. I bow down to the one who is welfare. O one whose form cannot be thought of! I bow down to you. O one whose form is the seed of the origin of the universe! I bow down to you. O one who is the cause behind the preservation of the universe! I bow down to you. O one who is the destroyer! I bow down to you. O one who loves Gouri! O one without decay! I bow down to you. O one who is eternal! O one who is the destructible and the indestructible! I bow down to you. O one whose form is consciousness! O one whose existence is incomprehensible! O three-eyed one! I bow my head down to you. I bow down to you. O one who brings compassion to the world! O one who is terrifying! I always bow down to you. I bow down to you. O one who bestows everything wished for! I first bow down to you. O Somesha! O Umesha! ⁷⁷⁷ I bow down to the one whose eyes are the three Vedas. I bow down to the one who is devoid of the three forms. ⁷⁷⁸ I bow down to the auspicious one. You are beyond existence and non-existence. I bow down to you. O one who destroys sins! I bow down to you. I bow down to the one who is engaged in the welfare of the universe. I bow down to the one who assumes many kinds of forms. You are the protector of the universe. You are behind cause and effect. I bow down to you. O lord of the universe! I bow

down to you. O lord of sacrifices! O one towards whom *havya* and *kavya* are offered! O one who is always auspicious for the worlds! He is the one to whom all worship is rendered. I bow down to you. O one who loves donations! O desired divinity! I bow down to Someshvara. O independent one! O Umapati! O Vijaya! I bow down to you. O lord of Vighneshvara and Nandi! O one who loves his sons! I bow my head down to you. I bow down to the divinity who destroys the grief and misery of the world. O one who bears the moon! I bow down to you. I bow down to the one who holds up Ganga. O Isha! O one who deserves to be worshipped! O Uma's consort! O supreme divinity! I bow down to you. O one whose feet are worshipped by Aja,⁷⁷⁹ the original lord,⁷⁸⁰ Purandara and the other gods and the *asuras*! I bow down to the one who wished to have three eyes so that he could see the beautiful face of the goddess. I bow down to Soma, who is worshipped through the five kinds of *amrita*,⁷⁸¹ fragrances, incense, lamps, wonderful flowers, many kinds of *mantras*, many kinds of food and other articles." At this, the illustrious Shambhu spoke to Rama and Lakshmana. "O fortunate one! Ask for a boon." Rama spoke to Vrishadhvaja. Rama said, "O supreme divinity! O Shankara! If a person devotedly uses this *stotram* to satisfy you, let all his intended tasks become extremely successful. O Shambhu! There are those whose ancestors have descended into the ocean of hell. Let them be purified through *pindas* and other things and go to heaven. Since birth, if anyone has committed a sin in thoughts, words and deeds, as soon as he bathes here, let those sins be instantly destroyed. O Shambhu! If a person faithfully gives even a trifle to some who wants it in this place, let the good merits be inexhaustible. Let such donors obtain such fruits." Delighted, Shankara told Rama that it would be that way. When the best among the gods had departed, Rama and his followers slowly went to the place where Goutami originated. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Rama *tirtha*. When Lakshmana was filled with compassion, the place where the arrow fell down from his hand is known as Bana *tirtha*.⁷⁸² It destroys every kind of impediment. The place where Soumitri bathed and worshipped Shankara came to be known as Lakshmana *tirtha*. This is how Sita *tirtha* also came about. It is capable of completely destroying the aggregate of many types of

sins. If a person bathes in the place where Ganga who purifies the three worlds, touched the feet of the one from whose feet she originated,⁷⁸³ the specialty of that place cannot be described. There is no *tirtha* that is equal to Rama *tirtha*.’

Chapter 2(54) (Putra *tirtha* and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Putra *tirtha* is spoken of as a sacred *tirtha*. It yields everything one desires, even if one hears about its greatness. O Narada! I will tell you about its nature. Listen attentively. The sons of Diti and the sons of Danu started to dwindle. ⁷⁸⁴ O Narada! The sons of Aditi were superior in every kind of way. From a sense of rivalry, Diti was miserable at being separated from her sons. She went to Danu. Diti said, “O fortunate one! Our sons are dwindling. What will be do? In this world, *karma* is powerful. Look at Aditi’s lineage. They are excellent and possess a great kingdom. They possess fame, victory and prosperity. They have defeated their enemies and their deeds and *dharma* are increasing. This is enough to destroy the happiness in my heart. We have the same husband. Our *dharma* is the same. Our *gotra* is the same. Our beauty is the same. On witnessing the prosperity and rise of Aditi’s offspring, I have been shattered and will no longer live. That will be the desired state after beholding my miserable state and the excessive prosperity of Aditi’s offspring. Entering a forest conflagration will yield greater happiness than seeing the prosperity of a rival, even in a dream.” She sighed and said this in an extremely miserable voice. Parameshthi’s son was honoured. ⁷⁸⁵ When his exhaustion was gone, he comforted the beautiful lady. Parameshthi’s son said, “O fortunate one! You should not lament. What is desired can only be obtained through good deeds. The great-minded Prajapati will tell you about the means for obtaining success. O virtuous one! When you present yourself humbly before him, he will tell you everything you need to do to become successful.” O Narada! While this was being said, Danu spoke to Diti. Danu said, “O fortunate one! Use your own qualities to satisfy your husband, Kashyapa. If your husband is satisfied, you will obtain what you desire.”

Thus addressed, she satisfied Kashyapa in every possible way. The illustrious Kashyapa Prajapati spoke to Diti. Kashyapa asked, “O Diti! O one who is excellent in vows! What will I give you? What do you wish for? Ask.” Diti asked her husband for a son who would possess many qualities. He would conquer all the worlds and be revered by all the worlds. She humbly said, “O father of the gods! In this world, let me have such a brave son. That is the boon I ask for.” Kashyapa replied, “I will tell you about an excellent vow that must be observed for twelve years. It will yield the fruits. When it has been completed, I will impregnate you and you will obtain what you wish for. Desires are met only when one has been cleansed of sins.” The large-eyed Diti was pleased at the words her husband had spoken and bowed down before him. As instructed by her husband, she properly observed the vow. If a living being does not frequent *tirthas* and donate to deserving people, and if he does not observe vows, how can he possibly accomplish his wishes?’ After this vow was over, Diti was impregnated. In private, Kashyapa again spoke to his beloved Diti. Kashyapa said, ‘O one with the beautiful smiles! Even those who practice austerities do not obtain what they desire if they ignore the recommended tasks. During the two *sandhyas*, the prohibited tasks must be avoided. One should not sleep or go anywhere. The hair must not be worn loose. O extremely fortunate one! At the time of *sandhya*, when *bhutas* congregate, one should not eat, sneeze or yawn. If these have to be done, and especially if one has to laugh, these must always be done behind a cover. At the time of *sandhya*, one must never remain near the threshold of a house. O beloved one! During night or day, one must never step over a pestle, a mortar, a winnowing basket, a stool, a scabbard, or similar objects. One should never sleep with one’s head facing the north, especially at the time of *sandhya*. One should not utter a falsehood, or go to someone else’s house. One should try to never look at a man other than one’s own beloved. If you follow these and other *niyamas* that I have mentioned, you will have a son who will enjoy all the prosperity of the three worlds.’ She promised her husband, who was revered by the worlds, that she would do this. O

brahmana! Kashyapa left and roamed around, here and there, and then went to the gods.’

‘The pure and strong fetus in Diti’s womb increased in size. Through his *maya*, the *daitya* Maya got to know the truth about all this. Maya had a friendly and affectionate relationship with Indra. In secret, out of his affection towards Indra, Maya went and humbly told Indra about Diti and Danu’s intention, the vow, the growth and energy of the fetus and various other things. If one accepts a single trustworthy friend, it is possible to avoid all kinds of fear. One can obtain many kinds of good merits, even if those have not been earned.’

Narada asked, ‘The immensely strong *daitya*, Maya, was Namuchi’s beloved brother. O lord of the gods! How did Maya become friendly with the person who killed his brother?’

Brahma continued, ‘In ancient times, there was a powerful lord of the *daityas*, named Namuchi. He had an extremely fierce enmity with Indra and it made the body hair stand up. Once, the brave Namuchi, lord of the *daityas* saw that Shatakratu was leaving the field of battle. He pursued him. On seeing him advance, Shachi’s consort was filled with fear. Abandoning the elephant, Airavata, Indra entered some foam. Riding on the foam, the one who has a *vajra* in his hand, quickly slew his enemy, Namuchi. To destroy his brother’s slayer, Maya, Namuchi’s younger brother, tormented himself through great austerities. Maya obtained many kinds of *maya*, which the gods found to be terrifying. Through his austerities, he obtained boons from Vishnu, the refuge of the worlds. Maya was generous in donating and pleasant in speech. He worshipped the fire and *brahmanas*. He waited for an opportunity to defeat Indra. He donated to those who desired. He was praised by the *bandis*.⁷⁸⁶ Through Vayu, Maghavan⁷⁸⁷ got to know about his enemy Maya, who possessed powers of *maya*. Assuming the form of a brahmana, he approached the one who was preparing himself for an excellent fight. Shachi’s consort repeatedly spoke to the *daitya* Maya. Indra said, “O lord of the *daityas*! I am someone who seeks. Give me my desired boon. I have heard that you are the best among donors. I, an excellent brahmana, have come before you.” Maya took him to be a brahmana and

replied, “I have given it to you. When a supplicant is in front, accomplished people do not ponder a lot.” Thus addressed, Hari responded, “I ask for a friendly relationship with you.” Maya again replied to Indra, “O excellent brahmana! Why do you ask for this? There is no enmity between you and me.” Hari told Maya, “May you be fortunate.” When the *daitya* asked Hari to tell him the truth, he revealed his own true form, which is spoken of as thousand-eyed, to the *daitya*. The *daitya* Maya was astounded and spoke to Hari. Maya asked, “O one who has the *vajra* in his hand! What is this? O friend! This is not deserving of you.” Hari laughed and embraced him. “I have achieved my objective. The learned achieve their objectives through whatever means that are possible.” O tiger among sages! Since then, there was great friendship between Shakra and Maya and Maya was always engaged in ensuring Hari’s welfare. He went to Indra’s residence and told him everything. Hari asked Maya, who possessed knowledge of *maya*, “What will I do?” Out of affection towards Hari, Maya gave him knowledge of *maya*. Having obtained it, Hari was extremely pleased and asked, “O Maya! What will I do? Please tell me.” Maya replied, “Go to Agastya’s hermitage. The expectant Diti is there. Remain there and tend to her for many days. O Maghavan! Holding the *vajra*, enter her womb. Using that, sever the fetus that is growing. Because of the *vajra*, it will either come under your subjugation or be dead. In either case, your enemy will cease to exist.” Maghavan agreed and worshipped Maya.’

‘He went and humbly presented himself before his mother, Diti. ⁷⁸⁸ Shakra served the goddess, the mother of *daityas*. Diti did not know that Shakra harboured enmity in his heart. But the fetus inside the womb knew, because of the invincible and unassailable energy of the sage Kashyapa, what Indra of the gods intended to do. The thousand-eyed Purandara seized his *vajra*. Desiring to enter inside, he waited for a long period of time. On one occasion, the one with the *vajra* as his weapon saw that at the time of *sandhya*, she was sleeping with her head facing the north. ⁷⁸⁹ “This is my opportunity.” Saying this, he entered Diti’s stomach. The fetus that was inside saw Indra with the weapon desiring to kill it. Not frightened at all, it repeatedly spoke. The fetus asked, “O one with the *vajra*! I am your brother.

Why don't you protect me? Why do you wish to kill me? There is no sin greater than killing someone without a fight. O mighty-armed Shakra! That should only be done in the course of battle. Let me emerge and let there be a fight with you. Otherwise, this does not suit you. You are Shatakratu, the one with one thousand eyes. You are Purandara, Shachi's consort. You are Indra of the gods with the *vajra* in your hand. O lord! This is not worthy of you. O mighty-armed one! If you wish to fight with me, arrange for me to emerge. Withdraw from this course of action. Even if there is a calamity, great ones do not tread along a wicked path. I do not possess learning, nor knowledge of weapons. I do not have a complement of weapons I can fight with. You possess learning and you hold a *vajra* in your hand. Are you not ashamed that you are trying to kill me? A person born in a noble lineage never commits a condemned act. Having killed me, what fame or good merits will you get? If you wish to kill a brother who is still in the womb, what act of manliness is this? On the other hand, perhaps you are indeed eager to fight with your brother." He clenched his fists and stood in front of the one with the *vajra*. "You are the killer of a child. You are the killer of a brother. You are guilty of committing a breach of trust. O Shakra! Ready to kill me, these are the fruits you will obtain. Everything, mobile and immobile, follows his commands. However, he now wishes to kill me, a child. What is the fame here? Where is the manliness?" While the fetus was saying this, he used his *vajra* to slice it. A person who is greedy and blind in rage never displays any compassion. The fetus did not waver. Instead, it sorrowfully said, "We are your brothers." He sliced those fragments again, which said, "O Shatakratu! Do not kill us. We were assured, in our mother's womb. We are your own brothers." The minds of those who are overwhelmed with hatred do not exhibit the slightest bit of pity. He sliced those fragments again. They possessed hands and feet and it was as if they were alive. They seemed to be ⁷⁹⁰ indifferent. On seeing those, seven times, seven fragments, he was extremely surprised. Those auspicious fragments in the womb were one, but had many different forms. They wept in many different ways and Hari said, '*Ma ruda.*' ⁷⁹¹ Thus, the extremely powerful and energetic Maruts were born. While they were still in the womb, they

were not scared of Shakra and spoke to each other. They spoke to Agastya, the tiger among sages. Their mother was staying in his hermitage. Our father, your brother is your friend and respects you a lot. ⁷⁹² O sage! We know that there is affection towards us in your mind. The wielder of the *vajra* has done something that even a *shvapaka* will not do.” Hearing these words, Agastya was extremely worried. Diti was suffering from the pain inside his womb and he roused her. Agastya went there and filled with rage, cursed Shachi’s beloved. Agastya said, “O Hari! In a battle, the enemies will always see your back. When the back of a proud person is seen, as he is running away from the field of battle, even if he remains alive, he is as good as dead.” Angry, Diti cursed Indra, who was still inside her womb. Diti said, “O Hari! Since you have not exhibited an act of manliness, you will be cursed. You will be vanquished by women and will be ousted from your kingdom.” At that time, Prajapati Kashyapa arrived there and was distressed when he heard from Agastya what Shakra had done. Scared, Shakra spoke to his father from inside the womb. Shakra said, “Because of Agastya and Diti, I am scared to come out.” Approaching his wife, Prajapati Kashyapa saw what his son had done, while he was still inside the womb. He heard about the curses of Agastya and Diti and grieved. Kashyapa said, “O Shakra! O son! Emerge. Why did you commit this sin? The minds of those who are born in sparkling lineages do not turn towards such sins.” The one with the *vajra* in his hand emerged. He was ashamed and stood there silently, with his face cast downwards. The forms of men reveal the good and bad deeds they have committed.’

‘Shakra said, “I will undoubtedly do what ensures welfare.” Kashyapa and all the guardians of the worlds approached me. They told me everything. The gods again asked me in due order, how Diti’s womb could be pacified, how the one with one thousand eyes could be freed from his curse, how there could be friendliness between all those inside the womb and Indra, how the taint caused by Shachi’s husband could be healed and how there could be release from the curse imposed by Agastya. I addressed Kashyapa, who was full of humility, in these words. “O Kashyapa! O Prajapati! O one who bestows honours! Along with the Vasus, Indra and the

guardians of the worlds, go to Goutami. Bathe there. All of you praise Mahesha. Through Shiva's favours, everything will be beneficial."

Accepting this, Kashyapa went to Goutami. Bathing there, he used these words to duly praise the divinity, Isha. Two entities are spoken of as the destroyers of every kind of misery—the sacred river, Goutami, and Shiva, the ocean of compassion. Kashyapa said, "O Shankara! O lord of the gods! Save me. O one worshipped by the worlds! Protect me. O one who purifies! Save me. O lord of speech! O one with a *pannaga* as an ornament! Protect me. O Dharma! O one astride a bull! Save me. O one with the three Vedas as eyes! Protect me. O one who holds up the earth! O lord of prosperity! Save me. O Sharva! O one who wears an elephant's hide as garment! Protect me. O lord who destroyed Tripura! Save me. O one with the moon as an ornament on your head! Protect me. O lord of sacrifices! O Somesha! Save me. O one who bestows what is desired! Protect me. O abode of compassion! Save me. O one who bestows everything auspicious! Protect me. O origin of everything! Save me. O protector and lord of riches! Protect me. O radiant one! O lord of wealth! Save me. O one worshipped by Brahma! Protect me. O lord of the universe! O lord of success! Save me. O complete one! Protect me. I bow down before you. O Shiva! O ocean of compassion! You alone are the refuge of embodied beings who are wandering around in this terrible and desolate *samsara*, anxious in their minds." Praised in this way, Vrishdhvaja appeared before him. He asked Prajapati Kashyapa to ask for a boon. Kashyapa addressed Shiva in humble words and told him in detail about what Indra had done, the curse, the destruction of the sons, the mutual enmity, the perpetration of the sin and the curse invoked on Shakra. At this, Vrishakapi ⁷⁹³ spoke to Diti and Agastya. Shiva said, "The forty-nine Maruts are your sons. All of them will be extremely fortunate and will obtain their shares in sacrifices. Full of joy, they will always be with Indra. Wherever Indra has a share of the oblations in sacrifices, the Maruts will first have their shares. There is no doubt about this. When Shakra is with the Maruts, no one will be able to ever defeat him. He will always be victorious. O Prajapati! All of you remain happy. From now on, if anyone slays a brother, his lineage will be destroyed and he

will always face calamities.” Shambhu carefully spoke to Agastya, the tiger among *rishis*. Shambhu said, “O sage! You should not be angry with Shachi’s husband. O immensely wise one! Go in peace. The Maruts will be immortal.” Pleased, Vrishadhvasa Shiva also spoke to Diti. Shiva said, “You desired to have a son who would have the prosperity of the three worlds. Thinking that, you controlled yourself and engaged in austerities. Your efforts have now become successful. You have many auspicious sons who possess the qualities. They will be strong and brave. Therefore, cast aside your mental grief. O one with the excellent eyebrows! Without any anxiety, please ask for other boons.” Diti heard the words uttered by the lord of the gods. She joined her hands in salutation, bowed down and addressed Shambhu in these words. Diti said, “O one worshipped by the gods! In this world, the sight of a son brings delight to the parents. In particular, a son is loved by the mother. This is even more so if the son possesses beauty, prosperity, valour and bravery, even if it happens to be a single son. What need be said if there are many? Through your powers, my sons will certainly be victorious and strong. They are Indra’s brothers and the true sons of Prajapati. This has happened through the favours of Agastya and through Ganga’s favours. O divinity! O Shambhu! Through your favours, where is the doubt about any of this? I have been successful in my objective. Nevertheless, please listen to what I devotedly tell you. Please act for the welfare of the worlds.” Thus addressed, the creator of the universe spoke to Diti who was bowing down, “Speak out.” Diti said, “O one worshipped by the gods! In this world, the obtaining of an offspring is extremely rare. An offspring is especially loved by the mother. What need be said if the offspring happens to be a son? If the son possesses qualities and happens to be handsome with a long lifespan, where is the need for heaven, emancipation or Parameshthi’s status? In this world and in the world hereafter, to obtain the fruits, all beings always desire a son who possesses the qualities. Therefore, please bestow that favour on anyone who bathes here.” Shankara replied, “If a person does not possess offspring, that is the consequence of great sins. If a woman is born barren or if a man is born impotent, as soon as the person bathes here, that sin will be destroyed.

If a person bathes here and reads this *stotram*, bathing and donating for three months, that person will obtain the fruits of having a son. If a barren woman bathes here, she will have a son. After the period, if a woman bathes here, she will have a son. Three months after conception, if a woman uses this *stotram* and fruits to devotedly praise me and see me, there is no doubt that she will have a son who is Shakra's equal. O Diti! Hear about the supreme atonement for those who do not have sons because of the father's sins or because of the sin of stealing wealth. They should please the ancestors by offering *pinda* there and donate a little bit of gold. They will then have sons. Those who steal what has been kept with them in trust, those who steal or hide jewels and those who do not perform *shraddha* ceremonies are those whose lineages do not increase. For the world hereafter, this will be the refuge of such sinners. Those who frequent this *tirtha* will give birth to praiseworthy offspring. The lord Siddheshvara is without beginning and without end. He is without decay. He is consciousness, truth and bliss. His image is there and is frequented by gods, *rishis*, *siddhas*, *gandharvas* and lords among *yogis*. Mahadeva is himself present in that *lingam*, which is full of light and is without any blemish. At the place where Diti met Ganga, a person must use the various articles of worship to worship the *lingam*. He must always be devoted and controlled in his vows. Using this *stotram*, he must praise him on the eighth and fourteenth lunar days. According to his capacity, he must donate gold and feed *brahmanas*. If a person does this near Ganga, he will obtain one hundred sons. He will accomplish all his desires and at the end, go to Shiva's city. If a person uses this *stotram* to praise me, regardless of who that person is, will certainly obtain a son within six months, even if the woman is barren." Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Putra *tirtha*.⁷⁹⁴ Bathing, donating and other rites performed there yield everything that is desired. Because of friendship with the Maruts, it is also known as Mitra *tirtha*.⁷⁹⁵ Since that cleansed Indra of his sin, it is also spoken of as Shakra *tirtha*. The place where Indra regained his prosperity is known as Kamala *tirtha*.⁷⁹⁶ All these *tirthas* yield everything that is wished for. Saying that everything would be as she wished, Shiva vanished. Successful in their

objectives, all of them returned to wherever they had come from. One hundred thousand sacred *tirthas* exist there and are spoken about.'

Chapter 2(55) (Yama, Agni and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Yama *tirtha* enhances the delight of the ancestors. It is frequented by those who visit all other *tirthas*. It is sacred and bestows everything that is seen and not seen. It destroys every kind of sin. I will describe its powers. There was a powerful pigeon, known by the name of Anuhrada. His wife was a bird named Heti and she could assume any form at will. Anuhrada was the son of Mrityu’s son and Heti was the daughter of Mrityu’s daughter. In the course of time, the couple had sons and grandsons. Their enemy was a powerful king of birds, named Uluka.⁷⁹⁷ His sons and grandsons were the Agneyas and they were powerful. For a very long period of time, there was enmity between these two types of birds. The pigeons resided on the northern banks of Ganga. Uluka, the king of birds, resided on the southern bank. O supreme among *brahmanas*! He lived there, along with his sons and grandsons. They were opposed to each other and for a very long period of time, there were clashes between them. Both of them had strong sons and stronger grandsons. Neither the owl, nor the pigeon were victorious or defeated. The pigeon worshipped his grandfather Mrityu and obtained *yamya* weapons.⁷⁹⁸ Using these, he became superior to everyone else. In that way, the owl worshipped Agni and became extremely strong. Intoxicated because of their boons, there was an extremely terrible battle between them. Uluka hurled an *agneya* weapon towards Kapota.⁷⁹⁹ Kapota hurled Yama’s noose towards his enemy. He released Mrityu’s noose and staff towards Uluka. The battle continued between them, like the ancient clash between Adi and Baka.⁸⁰⁰ In that great battle, Heti, the female pigeon who was devoted to her husband, saw that the fire was approaching her husband and was overwhelmed with grief. In particular, she saw that her sons were surrounded by the fire. Heti went to

the fire-god and praised him, using many kinds of appropriate words. Heti said, “His form and gifts are not directly seen. All material objects originate in his *atman*. It is through him that the gods partake of oblations. I bow down to Svaha’s husband, the one who enjoys sacrifices. You are the mouth of the gods. You are omniscient. You are the bearer of oblations. For the gods, you are the *hotri*.⁸⁰¹ You are the messenger of the gods. I seek refuge with that god. O Vibhavasū! You are the original god. You exist inside and outside, in the form of the breath of life. Outside, you are the one who bestows food. He is the wealth of the sacrifice. I seek refuge with the one who conquers wealth.” Agni replied, “O female pigeon! My weapon has been released in this battle and it is infallible. O one devoted to your husband! Where will the weapon find its resting place? Please tell me that.” The female pigeon said, “Let the weapon rest in me, not on my sons or my husband. O lord of oblations! O Jataveda! Be truthful in speech. I bow down before you.” Jataveda replied, “O one devoted to your husband! I am satisfied with your words and at your devotion towards your husband. O Heti! I will bestow peace on you, your sons and your husband. My Agneya weapon will not burn down your husband, your sons, or you. O female pigeon! Go in peace.” Meanwhile, the female owl noticed her husband. He was enveloped in Yama’s noose and was being struck by his staff. The female owl was miserable. Suffering from fear, she approached Yama. The female pigeon said, “Because they fear you, people follow you. Because they fear you, they observe *brahmacharya*. Because they fear you, they perform virtuous deeds. Because they fear you, they are persevering and devoted to their tasks. Because they fear you, when they roam around in villages or forests, they do not cause any harm. Because they fear you, they are amiable. Because they fear you, they drink *soma*. Because they fear you, they donate food and cattle. Because they fear you, they speak about the *brahman*.” When she spoke in this way, the lord of the southern direction spoke to her. Yama replied, “O fortunate one! Ask for a boon. I will give you whatever brings pleasure to your mind.” Hearing Yama’s words, the one who was devoted to her husband spoke to him. The female owl said, “My husband has been enveloped in your noose and is being

struck with your staff. O best among the gods! Please save my sons and my husband.” Hearing these words, Yama was filled with compassion and spoke repeatedly. Yama replied, “O one with a beautiful face! Tell me about a resting place for the noose and the staff.” She said, “O Yama! O god! Let your noose enter and rest in me. O lord of the universe! Let your staff also rest inside me.” The illustrious Yama was filled with compassion and spoke again. Yama said, “Your husband and all your sons will live, free of anxiety.” Yama restrained his noose and the bearer of oblations restrained the Agneya weapon.’

‘The two gods ensured friendship between the pigeon and the owl. They told the two birds, “Ask for the boon that you desire.” The birds replied, “Because of our enmity, we have been able to see you, an objective that is extremely difficult to attain. O best among gods! We are birds. What will sinners do with a boon? Or, if the two of you wish to affectionately bestow a boon on us, we do not want anything for ourselves. Do not bestow the auspicious boon on us. O lords of the gods! Anyone who asks for himself should be grieved over. If a person is always engaged in ensuring welfare for others, his birth is truly successful. Fire, water, the sun, the earth and many kinds of grain only exist for the sake of others. In particular, this is true of those who are virtuous. O lords of gods! Brahma and others also have to confront death. Knowing this, it is futile to strive for one’s own sake. For any man, Parameshthi has ordained everything from the time of birth. This can never be countered. Therefore, creatures strive in vain. Therefore, we ask for something auspicious that will benefit the world, something that has qualities for everyone. Please approve of this.” For the sake of *dharma*, fame and the welfare of the worlds, the two birds, famous in the worlds, spoke in this way to the two gods. The birds continued, “Let our hermitages be *tirthas* on both sides of Ganga. You are the lords of the universe. This is the first boon for us. Bathing, donating, *japa*, oblations and worshipping of the ancestors, whether undertaken by those with good deeds or bad deeds—let these bring inexhaustible good merits to anyone who undertakes these there. This is the second boon for us.” Extremely pleased, the gods replied, “It shall be that way. But we have something else to say.”

Yama said, “If a person reads the *stotram* to Yama on the northern bank of Goutami, seven generations of his family will never suffer from untimely deaths. If a man recites this, he will always possess every kind of prosperity. If a person controls himself and always reads the *stotram* to Mrityu, he will not suffer from the eighty-eight thousand different kinds of ailments. O best among birds! If a lady who is expecting bathes in this *tirtha* every day for three months, or if a lady who is barren bathes in this *tirtha* every day for six months, that lady will give birth to a brave son who will live for one hundred years. He will be prosperous, intelligent and brave and his sons and grandsons will extend the lineage. If *pinda* is offered there, the ancestors will be liberated. If a man bathes there, he will be freed from sins committed in thoughts, words and deeds.” After Yama spoke these words, the bearer of oblations spoke to the two birds. Agni said, “If a man is controlled, follows vows and reads my *stotram* on the southern bank, I will bestow freedom from ailment, prosperity, wealth and beauty on him. If a man reads this *stotram* anywhere, or if he writes it down and keeps it in his house, he will never suffer any fear from fire. If a man purifies himself and bathes and offer donations in Agni *tirtha*, there is no doubt that he will obtain the fruits of an *agnishtoma* sacrifice.” Since then, learned people know of that *tirtha* as Yama *tirtha*, Agni *tirtha*, Kapota *tirtha*, Uluka *tirtha* and Heti-Uluka *tirtha*. There are three thousand, three hundred and ninety *tirthas* there. Each of them yields objects of pleasure and emancipation. If men bathe and offer donations there, they are purified after death. They possess sons and excellent wealth. They attain auspicious and divine worlds.’

Chapter 2(56) (Tapa *tirtha* and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Tapa *tirtha* greatly enhances asceticism. It is sacred and bestows every object of desire. It enhances the delight of the ancestors. Hear about what occurred in that *tirtha*. This destroys all sins. There was a conversation among *rishis* about water and fire. Some thought water was superior, others thought fire was superior. About the comparison between water and fire, the sages spoke in the following way. “How can there be life without fire? Life exists because fire exists. Agni is the *atman*. Agni represents oblations. Everything originates from Agni. Agni holds up the worlds. Agni provides the universe with light. Therefore, there is nothing superior to Agni. He is the great purifying divinity. He is the fire that is inside. He is the fire that is outside. Nothing exists without fire. The three worlds are his abode. Fire is the best among the elements. Just as a man impregnates the womb of a woman with semen, he is the strength inside the body. There is nothing other than Krishanu.⁸⁰² Vahni is the mouth of the gods. Hence, it is known that there is nothing superior.” Others, who spoke about the Vedas, thought that water was superior. “Food results from water. The purifying one⁸⁰³ originates from water. Water holds up everything. Water is remembered as the mother. Those who know about the ancient accounts say that water is the life of the three worlds. *Amrita* is produced from water. The herbs originate from water.” Some said that fire was superior, others said that water was superior. The *rishis*, who knew about the Vedas, could not come to a conclusion. Speaking in opposite ways, they approached me and spoke to me. The *rishis* said, “You are the lord of the three worlds. Please tell us whether fire or water is superior.” I replied to the *rishis*, controlled in their vows, who had come there. “Both of them should be worshipped by the worlds. The

universe originates in both of them. *Havya*, *kavya* and *amrita* result from both of them. In this world, life and sustenance of the body are due to both. Between the two, neither is superior. Both are held to be equal. My view is that neither of the two is superior.” However, those excellent *rishis* decided that one or the other must be superior. They were not satisfied with my words. Hence, those ascetics went to Vayu. The sages asked, “O Vayu! You are the breath of life and truth is established in you. Which of the two is superior?” Vayu answered, “Anala ⁸⁰⁴ is superior. Everything is established in Agni.” “That is not true.” Telling each other that, the *rishis* went to Vasundhara. ⁸⁰⁵ The sages asked, “O earth! You are the one who holds up mobile and immobile objects. Speak truthfully. Who is superior?” The earth humbly spoke to the *rishis* who had come. The earth answered, “The waters are eternal goddesses and the waters are my foundation. Everything originates in water. Therefore, it is evident that water is superior.” “That is not true.” Telling each other that, the *rishis* went to the one who lies down on the milky ocean, the one who holds the conch shell, the *chakra* and the mace. Using many kinds of *stotrams*, they praised him.

The *rishis* said, ‘You are the one who knows all the worlds. You are the reservoir in which the past, the present and the future are hidden. At the end, all the varied and wonderful three worlds merge into you. You are the imperishable and eternal one. You are immeasurable. The *rishis* speak of you as one who cannot be known through the Vedas. By resorting to you, they obtain what they wish for. You are the truth and we seek refuge in you. You are the greatest of the great elements. You are the most important entity in the universe. *Yogis* do not get to know of Vishnu’s form. O refuge of the universe! Speak to the *rishis* who have come here. Please tell us the truth. You are in the *atmans* of all those with bodies. You alone are everything. O lord! Everything is in you. Because of Prakriti, no one anywhere gets to know about your powers. You are inside and outside everything. Your *atman* is in the ever-changing universe.’ The creator of the universe spoke through a divine and invisible voice. The divine voice said, ‘Let both of them be worshipped through austerities, devotion and rituals. Whichever one bestows success first will be spoken of as superior.’ Agreeing to this, all

the *rishis*, worshipped by the worlds, departed. They were exhausted and their minds were distressed. They were full of supreme non-attachment. All of them went to Goutami, the mother of all the worlds and the one who purifies the three worlds. Controlling themselves through vows, they performed austerities there. They got ready to worship fire and water. Some were worshippers of fire, others were worshippers of water. The divine voice, Sarasvati, the mother of the Vedas, spoke to them. The divine voice said, ‘Water is the origin of fire. Purification is obtained through water. For those of you who are worshippers of fire, how will you complete the worship without water? One obtains the right to undertake rites only after water has been prepared. As long as a man is impure and dirty, he is not entitled to undertake rites. Even if he knows about the Vedas, he must purify himself by faithfully immersing himself in cool water. Therefore, since water is spoken of as the mother of everything, water must be superior. Hence, water is superior, especially because it is the mother of fire.’ Hearing those words, the *rishis*, who knew about the Vedas, came to the conclusion that water must be superior. O Narada! This occurred at the *tirtha* where the *rishis* were undertaking a sacrifice. That place is spoken of as Tapa *tirtha* and Satra *tirtha*.⁸⁰⁶ The learned also speak of it as Agni *tirtha* and Sarasvata *tirtha*.⁸⁰⁷ Bathing and donations there yield every object of desire and everything auspicious. There are another fourteen hundred *tirthas* there. These bestow good merits. Bathing and donations there confer heaven and emancipation. The place where the voice dispelled the doubt of the *rishis* is the place where the river Sarasvati originated and merged into Ganga. Which man is capable of speaking about the greatness of that confluence?’

Chapter 2(57) (Arshtishena *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Deva *tirtha* is on the northern banks of Ganga. I will tell you about its greatness. It destroys all sins. There was a king named Arshtishena. He possessed all the qualities. His wife was named Jaya and she was just like another Lakshmi. Their son was named Bhara. He was intelligent and devoted to his father. He was accomplished and skilled in *dhanurveda* and the Vedas. His beautiful wife was known by the name of Suprabha. King Arshtishena entrusted the kingdom to his son. With his chief priest, the lord of men consecrated himself and made efforts for undertaking a horse sacrifice on the banks of Sarasvati. With officiating priests and foremost *rishis*, accomplished in the Vedas and the sacred texts, the best among kings consecrated himself. There was a brave king of *danavas*, named Mithu. In the presence of the fire and the *brahmanas*, the powerful and evil-minded one destroyed the sacrifice and abducted the king, his wife and his priest. O sage! He swiftly took them to the nether regions of Rasatala. When the excellent king was taken away, the sacrifice was destroyed. Leaving the place where the sacrifice was being held, all immortals and officiating priests returned to their own respective abodes. The son of the royal priest was known as Devapi. He was a child. He could see his mother, but could not see his father. He was amazed at this and was exceedingly miserable. He asked his mother, “O mother! Where has my father gone? Without my father, I do not wish to remain alive. O mother! Please tell me the truth. Shame on the lives of those who do not have fathers. They are those who have committed wicked deeds. O mother! If you do not tell me, I will enter the water or the fire.” The mother told her son, “Along with the king, a *danava* has taken the king’s wife and the priest, your father, to the nether regions.” Devapi asked, “Who has taken

him away and why? Where was he taken? How was he taken? Who committed this deed? Who were watching? What is the place? Where does the *danava* live? Please tell me.” The mother answered, “In an assembly, the king consecrated himself for a sacrifice. The *daitya* Mithu took him to Rasatala, along with his wife and priest. In the presence of the fire and the *brahmanas*, the large number of gods looked on.” Hearing his mother’s words, Devapi remembered what he should do. “Irrespective of whether the gods, the fire, the officiating priests and the *asuras* looked on, it is my view that I must search for my father. There is nothing else to do.” Having decided this, Devapi spoke to Bhara, the king’s son. Devapi said, “Using austerities, *brahmacharya*, vows and *niyama*, I will bring back all those who have been taken to Rasatala. When something terrible has been done, if a person does not counter it, his birth is in vain and he is the worst among men. How does it matter whether such a person is dead or alive? Please rule over the entire earth, just as your father, Arshtishena, did. O king! Until I return, after achieving success, you should protect my mother. O Bhara! Please grant me permission.” After carefully thinking about everything, Bhara replied to Devapi. Bhara said, “Go happily and achieve success. You need not have the slightest bit of worry.”

‘Devapi meditated on the feet of the king of the immortals. He carefully searched out the officiating priests. He bowed down separately before each of the officiating priests. The child, Devapi, joined his hands in salutation and addressed them in these words. Devapi said, “When the person undertaking the sacrifice had consecrated himself, you should have saved him, the sacrifice, the priest and the wife of the person who had been consecrated. O officiating priests! While you looked on, the sacrifice was destroyed and the king was abducted. This is not worthy of you. I think you should return them, free of ailments. O foremost *brahmanas*! Otherwise, you deserve to be cursed.” The officiating priests replied, “In a sacrifice, Agni must be worshipped first. Agni is the divinity. Therefore, as servants of Agni, we do not know. ⁸⁰⁸ He is the lord of oblations. He is the one who bestows and he is the one who enjoys. He is the one who acts. He is the one who takes away.” Turning his back on the officiating priests, Devapi

followed the procedures and worshipped Jataveda. He told Agni everything. Agni replied, “Like the officiating priests, I am also the servant of the gods. I only bear the oblations for the gods. They are the ones who enjoy. They are the ones who protect.” Devapi said, “I will invoke the gods and give them their separate and complete shares of the oblations. Therefore, quickly take them to the gods.” Devapi went to the gods and bowed down separately before each of them. He told them about the words of the officiating priest, the words of Agni and the curse.⁸⁰⁹ The gods replied, “O supreme among *brahmanas*! When the officiating priests used *mantras* from the Vedas to summon us, in due order, we enjoy our shares of the oblations. We aren’t independent. Thus, we always follow the Vedas. We are urged by the Vedas. O brahmana! Since we are dependent, you should go and report this to the Vedas.” Devapi purified himself and carefully invoked the Vedas, using meditation and austerities. The Vedas appeared before him. Devapi bowed down repeatedly and spoke to the Vedas, informing them about the words of the officiating priests, the words of Agni and the words of the gods. The Vedas replied, “O son! We are dependent. We are under Ishvara’s subjugation. He is the one who holds up the entire universe. He is himself without a support and without blemish. He is a reservoir of every kind of power. He is the abode of every kind of prosperity. He is Mahadeva, the creator. He is Maheshvara, the destroyer. O brahmana! Though we speak and we know, we are only in the form of sounds. But we must do this much, tell you what you ask—who took them away, his name, his city and his strength and whether they have been eaten. We know that they have not been destroyed. We know your capacity, who you should worship and where so that you can get them back.” Hearing what the Vedas said, for a long time, he thought about this in his mind. Devapi answered, “O Vedas! Please tell me everything quickly and truthfully. I bow down to you. I bow down to all those who have been taken down to the nether regions. I shall get them back.” The Vedas said, “O Devapi! Go to Goutami and praise Maheshvara there. When he is extremely pleased, the compassionate one will give you what you wish for. O immensely wise one! If Shiva is praised and pleased, this is indeed what

will happen. King Arshtishena, his faithful wife, Jaya, and Upamanyu, your father, are in the nether regions. They do not suffer from any ailments. Through a boon bestowed by Mahesha, you will slay the *rakshasa* Mithu and attain fame and *dharma*. This is possible and the opposite will not happen.” Hearing their words, the child, Devapi, went to Goutami.’

‘The brahmana bathed, and at the right time, praised Maheshvara. Devapi said, “O lord of the gods! I am a child. You are the *guru* of my preceptors. I do not possess the capacity to praise you properly. O Shambhu! I bow down before you. The *nigama* texts do not know you, nor do the gods or the sages. Nor do Brahma and Vaikuntha. ⁸¹⁰ You are who you are. I prostrate myself before you. O Maheshvara! In the world, there are those who are without protectors, miserable, distressed, diseased and evil-souled. You save them. O lord of the universe! When they are worshipped through austerities, rituals and *mantras*, you are the one who bestows fruits on the residents of heaven. Those who seek cannot be donors. ⁸¹¹ What they wish for is with you. It is not extraordinary that you should be the cause of this perversity. O preceptor of the universe! O protector! When the word ‘Shiva’ is uttered, you save the ignorant, sinners and those who are submerged in the ocean of hell.’ Praised in this way, the three-eyed one appeared in front of him and spoke to him. Shiva said, ‘O Devapi! O child! Tell me the boon you want. Enough of this misery.’ Devapi replied, ‘O lord of the universe! I wish to get back the king, the king’s wife and my father and *guru*. I wish that my enemy should be killed.’ Hearing Devapi’s words, the lord of everything signified his consent. Through Shankara’s command, Devapi obtained everything. O Narada! Shambhu, the ocean of compassion, summoned his own *ganas*. Shambhu sent Nandi, with his trident. In Rasatala, Nandi killed Mithu, bull among the *asuras*. He brought his father and the others and handed them over. The intelligent Arshtishena’s horse sacrifice was performed there. Agni, the officiating priests, the gods, the Vedas and the *rishis* spoke. Agni and the others said, ‘O Devapi! The place where Shambhu, the lord of the gods and the lord of the universe, himself appeared will be Deva *tirtha*. It will destroy every kind of sin and bestow every kind of success on men. This *tirtha* will be sacred and your deeds will

be eternal.’ When the horse sacrifice was over, the gods bestowed boons on them. After bathing in Ganga and having accomplished their objective, they ⁸¹² went to heaven. Since then, along both banks, fifteen thousand and one hundred and eight *tirthas* developed. It is known that bathing and donations there confer great fruits.’

Chapter 2(58) (Tapovana and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘There is a place known as Tapovana, the confluence of Nandini and Siddheshvara *tirtha*. This is on Goutami’s southern bank. It is also known as Shardula. Hear about their accounts. Even if one hears about this, one is freed from all sins. Earlier, Agni was the *hotri* ⁸¹³ and bore the oblations for the gods. As a wife, he obtained the extremely beautiful Svaha, Daksha’s daughter. Initially, she didn’t have any sons and performed austerities for the sake of a son. Through extensive austerities, she satisfied Hutashana. ⁸¹⁴ Her husband, the enjoyer of oblations, spoke to his wife, the unblemished Svaha. Agni said, “O beautiful one! There will be offspring. Do not engage in austerities.” Hearing her husband’s words, she refrained from austerities. Except the words of a husband, nothing ever fulfils the wishes of a woman. After some time passed, a fear arose on account of Taraka. Kartikeya had not been born. Maheshvara and Bhavani were in private for a very long period of time. To accomplish the task of the gods, the scared gods appeared before Agni. The residents of heaven spoke to him. The gods said, “O immensely fortunate one! Go to the divinity Shambhu, worshipped by the three worlds. Inform Shambhu about the fear that has risen on account of Taraka.” Agni replied, “I will not go to a spot where a couple remains in privacy. This is the norm for an ordinary person, not to speak of a person who holds the trident in his hand. As they wish, they are alone and are conversing lovingly. If a person hears a couple’s words, he cannot be saved from hell. He is the lord of all the worlds. He is Mahakala who wields the trident. When he is in a private place with Bhavani, who is capable of looking at him?” The gods said, “When a great fear presents itself, this is good policy. What else are you describing? When there is a fear on account of Taraka, you are the Taraka. ⁸¹⁵ When others are

submerged in an ocean of great fear, the lives of the virtuous are meant for those others. Or assume some other form and go. Go and speak the words. After making Shambhu listen to the words of the gods, return quickly. O wise one! In both the worlds, we will then worship you.” Following the words of the gods, Hutashana assumed the form of a parrot and went quickly. He went to the place where the lord of the universe was sporting with Uma. Scared, Anala approached in the form of a parrot. However, the bearer of oblations was incapable of entering through the doorway. He went and sat on a window sill. He was trembling and his face was cast downwards. On seeing him, Shambhu laughed and in private, spoke to Uma. Shambhu said, “O goddess! Look. Following the words of the gods, Hutashana has come in the form of a parrot.” Ashamed, Parvati told the divinity, “Enough!” The lord of the gods saw Agni roaming around in front of him, in the form of a bird. He said, “O Agni! In many different ways, you have been recognized. Do not speak anything. Open your mouth, accept it and take it away.” Saying this, he released a lot of semen into Agni’s mouth. With that semen inside him, Agni was incapable of leaving. Exhausted, Agni sat down on the banks of the celestial river.⁸¹⁶ He flung the semen into the Kritikas and Kartika resulted.’

‘Some of Shambhu’s semen was still left inside Agni’s body. Vahni divided this semen into two parts and deposited it inside his own beloved wife, Svaha, especially because she was keen to have a son. Earlier, he had assured her that she would have offspring. Remembering this, Vahni deposited Shambhu’s semen. Through this semen, an excellent pair of twins was born to Agni. They were Suvarna and Suvarnaa and in their beauty, they were unmatched on earth. They pleased Agni, who was always engaged in ensuring pleasure to the worlds. Delighted, Agni bestowed Suvarnaa on the intelligent Dharma. He made up his mind that Samkalpa would become the beloved wife of his son, Suvarna. In this way, the wise one arranged for the marriages of his son and daughter. However, because of their associations with others, both of Agni’s offspring suffered from taints. His son, Suvarna, could assume many different forms. He assumed the forms of excellent gods, Indra, Vayu, Dhanada,⁸¹⁷ the lord of the waters,

⁸¹⁸ and lords among the sages, and had intercourse with their wives.

Whichever lord a wife loved, was a form Suvarna assumed. Sometimes, the wise one's son assumed the form and had intercourse even if the wife was faithful to her husband. In this way, he pleased Madana ⁸¹⁹ and with that extensive dalliance, thought that he was successful in his objective. This is what Suvarna did. As for Suvarnaa, Svaha's daughter, though she was Dharma's wife, she was a *svairini* and went to whoever appealed to her. If any human, *asura*, god, *rishi* or ancestor possessed a beautiful wife, she assumed her form and had intercourse with her husband. She indulged in intercourse with those who were handsome, generous, stable and profound. Whichever divinity she desired, she assumed the form of his wife and had intercourse with him. Through many different kinds of means and diverse techniques, she attracted his heart and accomplished her desire. All the gods and *asuras* witnessed the activities Agni's son, Suvarna, and Agni's daughter were engaged in. They became angry and cursed Agni's son and daughter. The gods and *asuras* said, "This is in the nature of adulterous behaviour. This is deceitful and wicked conduct. O bearer of oblations! Therefore, your son will become a transgressor and will go everywhere. O Agni! Similarly, Suvarnaa will never be satisfied with a single person. She will be satisfied not with one, but with many. She will enjoy the bodies of many who belong to condemned species. Because of her own sins, your daughter will enjoy them." Hearing the words of their curse, Agni was extremely frightened. He came to me and asked, "How can my son and daughter be saved?" I told Vahni, "Go to Goutami. O mighty-armed one! Praise Shankara and tell the lord of the universe everything. O Vahni! Such offspring have been born to you because Maheshvara's semen was deposited in your body. Tell the divinity that the gods have imposed such a curse. Shambhu will do what is best for his own offspring. If you devotedly praise the divinity and the goddess, Shiva will be pleased. Concerning your offspring, you will then obtain your cherished objective." Following my words, Agni went to Ganga. He controlled himself and praised Maheshvara, using words and hymns that are revered by the Vedas. Agni said, "He is the creator of the universe. He is the one who sustains. The universe is his

form. He is without blemish. He is the original creator. He is the one who created himself. I bow down to the lord of the universe. Assuming the form of fire, he destroys. Assuming the form of water, he creates. Assuming the form of the sun, he preserves. I bow down to the three-eyed one. In the form of a person who performs a sacrifice, he is the cause behind the contentment of the gods. In the form of Vayu, he makes arrangements for living beings. He saves in the form of Shiva. In the form of Hari, he brings eternal bliss. To create spaces inside living beings, he assumes the form of space.” The illustrious, infinite and undecaying Shambhu was pleased at this. The one who is worshipped by the gods asked Pavaka to choose a boon. He humbly told Shiva, “Your semen was inside me. Because of that, a handsome son, Suvarna, famous in the worlds was born. O divinity! O lord of the universe! In that way, a daughter, Suvarnaa, was also born. Because of this association with someone else’s semen, both of them suffer from a sin. O Shiva! My offspring have committed the sin of adulterous behaviour. O lord! All the gods have imposed a curse on them. Please arrange for its pacification.” At this, Shambhu addressed Agni in words that would ensure what was auspicious. Shambhu said, “It is because of my semen that Suvarna, extensive in valour, was born to you. For his benefit, I will bestow every kind of complete prosperity on Suvarna. O Vahni! You should not have any doubt on this account. Listen to my words. He will purify the three worlds. He will be like *amrita* in this world and will be loved by the gods. He will represent objects of pleasure and emancipation. He will be the *dakshina* at sacrifices. He will have all these forms and be the preceptor of all preceptors. It should be known that he will be supreme in valour. My semen is excellent. This is all the more because it has been deposited in you. What is the need to think about this? Without him, no kind of prosperity will be complete. Without Suvarna, men who are alive will be as good as dead. Even if he possesses no qualities, a rich man is respected. Even if he possesses qualities, a man without riches is not respected. Therefore, there will be nothing that is superior to Suvarna. ⁸²⁰ In that way, though she is fickle, Suvarnaa will be excellent. If she glances at anything, everything will become complete. In the three worlds, she will be obtained

through austerities, *japa* and oblations. Her powers will be extensive. O Agni! A little has been described. She will be present everywhere. She will come, but will wander around. Suvarnaa will be like Kamala herself and will be pure. From today, though your offspring will roam around as they please, they will be pure. There has been no one like them nor will there ever be.” Shambhu said this. Then, for the welfare of all the worlds, Shiva himself assumed the form of a *lingam* there.’

‘Having obtained the boons for his son and daughter, Vahni was satisfied. Suvarnaa, Agni’s daughter was henceforth content with her own husband, Dharma. Vahni’s son was also happy with Samkalpa. O sage! Meanwhile, Shardula, lord of the *danavas*, defeated Dharma and deceitfully abducted Swarnaa,⁸²¹ Agni’s daughter. She was the abode of good fortune and pleasure. He took Suvarnaa, famous in the worlds to Rasatala. Dharma, Agni’s son-in-law, and Agni, the lord of oblations, repeatedly praised Vishnu, the protector of the worlds. Both of them informed the powerful Vishnu about what had happened. Hari used his *chakra* to sever Shardula’s head. Vishnu brought back the goddess Suvarnaa, the supreme beauty in the worlds. She was the beloved daughter of both Maheshvara and Agni. O Narada! Vishnu showed her to Maheshvara. Maheshvara was delighted and repeatedly embraced her. The place where the blazing *chakra* was washed after severing Shardula’s head is famous by the name of Chakra *tirtha*. It is also known as Shardula *tirtha*. The place where Vishnu brought Suvarnaa to Shankara’s presence is known as Shankara *tirtha*, Vishnu *tirtha* and Siddha *tirtha*. O supreme among sages! In the place where Agni and Dharma obtained eternal bliss and tears of joy fell down from Agni’s eyes, the river Ananda or Nandini started to flow.⁸²² The confluence of the river with Ganga is sacred. Shiva is himself present there and Suvarnaa is also there. She is also known as Dakshayani, Shivaa, Agneyi Ambika, Jagadadhara, Katyayani and Ishvari. Both of her banks are ornamented and she always grants devotees what they want. The place where Agni tormented himself through austerities is known as Tapovana *tirtha*. O sage! There are such *tirthas* on both banks. Bathing and donating there yield every kind of auspicious desire. There are fourteen thousand *tirthas* on the northern bank

and sixteen thousand on the southern bank. In each of these *tirthas*, there are signs to identify them. They have separate names, but I have spoken about it briefly. If a man listens to this, reads it or remembers it, all his desires are fulfilled. Knowing this account, if a person bathes and performs the other rites there, Lakshmi is always present with him. Specifically, so is Dharma. The place that is to the west of Abjaka ⁸²³ is known as Shardula *tirtha*. It is superior to all other *tirthas*, such as Varanasi. If a person bathes there, worships the gods and the ancestors and performs water-rites, he is freed from all sins and attains greatness in Vishnu's world. There are many *tirthas* between Tapovana *tirtha* and Shardula *tirtha*. No one is capable of describing the greatness of each one of them.'

Chapter 2(59) (Indra *tirtha* and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Indra *tirtha* is also known as Vrishakapi. The confluence of Phena is where Hanumanta is. ⁸²⁴ It is also known as Abjaka, where the divinity Trivikrama exists. If one bathes or donates there, it is extremely rare for that person to return. ⁸²⁵ I will tell you what transpired on the southern banks of Ganga. Indreshvara is to the north. Listen attentively, with devotion. Indra’s enemy, Namuchi, was strong and extremely insolent. When he fought with Indra, Indra used foam to sever his head. ⁸²⁶ The foam from the water assumed the form of the *vajra* and severed the head of the enemy, Namuchi. Thereafter, the foam fell down on the southern bank of Ganga. It penetrated the earth and entered Rasatala. The purifying water of Ganga from the nether regions followed the path laid down by the *vajra* and came to the surface of the earth. The water, made out of foam, constituted the river named Phena. Its confluence with Ganga is sacred and is famous in the worlds. Like the confluence of Ganga and Yamuna, it destroys every kind of sin. Through the favours of Vishnu and Ganga, Hanuman’s stepmother was freed from the curse of being a cat as soon as she bathed in the water. This is Marjara *tirtha* and I have told you about it earlier. ⁸²⁷ That place is known as Hanumanta and I have described the account earlier. It is also known as Vrishakapi and Abjaka. Listen attentively.’

‘There was a powerful ancestor of the *daityas*, famous by the name of Hiranya. He tormented himself through austerities and none of the gods could defeat him. He was extremely terrible. He had a powerful son, who could never be defeated by the gods. He was known as Mahashani and his wife was Parajita. ⁸²⁸ For a very long period of time, there was an incessant battle between him and Indra. Mahashani was extremely energetic. In the

field of battle, he always vanquished Shakra, along with his elephant and handed him over to his father. Once he and his elephant had been bound and were devoid of substance, he would glance at them and giving up his cruelty, would hand them as offerings to the *daitya* Hiranya. His father, the *daitya* Mahashani, was superior to all those who had come before him. He would place Shachi's beloved in the nether regions and guard him there. After defeating Hari,⁸²⁹ Mahashani advanced against Varuna, wishing to vanquish him. The immensely intelligent Varuna bestowed his daughter on Mahashani. Varuna offered his own abode in the ocean to Mahashani. Thus, there was friendship between Varuna and Mahashani. Mahashani also loved the daughter, Varuni. Mahashani was a great *daitya*. He possessed valour, fame, bravery and strength. In the three worlds, there was no one who has his equal. When there was no longer an Indra in the worlds, the gods consulted among themselves. The gods said, "Vishnu is the only one who can give Indra back to us. He is the one who slays *daityas*. He is the one who knows the *mantras* and he will create another Indra." Having consulted in this way, the gods went and told Vishnu the import of their consultations. He said, "The great *daitya*, Mahashani, cannot be killed by me." Therefore, Vishnu went to the father-in-law, Varuna, the lord of the waters. Keshava went to Varuna and told him about Indra's defeat. "You must do something, so that Purandara returns." O sage! Hearing Vishnu's words, the lord of the waters quickly went to the brave Mahashani, his daughter's husband and Hiranya's son. The son-in-law showed the lord Varuna a great deal of respect. Humbly, he asked his father-in-law why he had come. Varuna told the *daitya* the reason why he had come. Varuna said, "O mighty-armed one! Give me Indra, whom you have defeated earlier. O friend! The lord of the gods has been bound in Rasatala. He is always respected by us. O slayer of enemies! Please give him to me. If an enemy who has been bound is freed, that brings great fame to the virtuous." When he was addressed in this way, the lord of the *daityas* thought about it for some time. He then returned Shachi's beloved to Varuna, along with his elephant. In the midst of the *daityas*, Hari was extremely resplendent. In the presence of the lord of the waters, Mahashani worshipped him with many great objects and spoke to

him. Mahashani said, “O Indra! Who has created you? Though you boast a lot, where is your valour? In a battle, you have been defeated by an enemy. Nevertheless, you remain as Indra. This is amazing. If a woman is imprisoned by a man, it is appropriate that her husband should free her. Women are not independent. It is men who are important. O Shakra! If you become a man, that will be praiseworthy. In a battle, I have bound you, along with your mount. Where is your weapon, the *vajra*, which is said to possess powers? As the king of the gods, you possessed everything that deserves to be enjoyed—the jewel Chintamani, Nandana, women, fame and strength. However, you have been freed by the lord of the waters. Shame on you! You wish to remain alive. Anything that is a store of fame is life. Anything that is contrary to fame is death. O Shakra! Knowing this, why aren’t you ashamed at having been freed by the lord of the waters? You were in heaven, surrounded by all the gods. You were fanned by your beloved. You were praised by the *apsaras*. But on seeing you, I think shame itself will be scared. ‘You are the slayer of Vritra. You are the slayer of Namuchi. You are the destroyer of cities. With the *vajra* in your hand, you have shattered mountains.’ The gods have worshipped you in this way. O victorious one! Therefore, give all this up. Creating such transgressions and causing such harm, you roam around in the worlds. How did the one who was born from the undecaying lotus create a person like you? Why does your heart not shatter?” Speaking in this way, the lord of *daityas* handed Indra over to the great-souled Varuna. He then again addressed him in these words. Mahashani said, “From now on, Varuna will be the *guru* and Indra will be the disciple. O Vasava! You have been freed through my father-in-law. Therefore, you should behave like a servant towards Varuna. Otherwise, I will bind you again and fling you into Rasatala.” Reprimanding Shakra in this way, he repeatedly laughed at him. He told him, “leave” and took his leave of Varuna.’

‘He returned to his own abode, tainted by shame. He went and told Poulami everything about how he had been defeated by the enemy. ⁸³⁰ Indra said, “O one with the beautiful face! This is the way the enemy has treated me and spoken to me. O fortunate one! Please tell me how I can pacify my

soul.” Indrani replied, “O Shakra! O slayer of Bala! I know about the origin, *maya*, defeat, boons and death of *danavas*. Therefore, hear from me everything about his birth, defeat and death. For the sake of your pleasure, I will tell you. He is Hiranya’s brave son. He is the powerful son of my paternal uncle. Therefore, he is my brother. ⁸³¹ He is insolent because of the boon he received. Through austerities and *niyama*, he satisfied Brahma. He, thus, obtained strength like this. What cannot be achieved through austerities? Therefore, your mind should not be surprised or disheartened. Listen to the task that must progressively be undertaken.” Telling Indra this, Poulami humbly continued. Indrani said, “There is nothing that cannot be achieved through austerities. There is nothing that cannot be achieved through sacrificial rites. There is nothing that cannot be achieved through devotion to Hara and Vishnu, the lord of the worlds. O beloved one! I have also heard this extremely wonderful account. O lord of gods! Only women can know about feminine nature. O lord! Therefore, there is nothing that cannot be achieved by the earth or the water. ⁸³² Austerities and sacrificial rites are undertaken through them. Hence, go to a land that has become a *tirtha*. If you worship Vishnu and Shiva there, you will get everything that you wish for. I have also heard this. Only women who are devoted to their husbands know everything. They hold up all mobile and immobile objects. The forest of Dandaka is in the middle of the earth and is its essence. O lord! Ganga, the mother of the world, is there. Worship Isha there. Or worship Vishnu, the lord of the universe. The protector is the one who dispels the miseries of the afflicted. Without a protector, men are immersed in an ocean of grief. For such people, there is no refuge other than Hari, Hara and Ganga. Therefore, make every effort to control yourself and satisfy them. Along with me, use devotion, *stotrams* and austerities. Through the favours of Isha and Vishnu, you will then obtain what is good for you. If a man performs a task unknowingly, the fruits obtained are only of one portion. However, when performed knowingly, the fruits obtained are one hundred times. When performed with the wife, the fruits are infinite. In every task undertaken by a man, the wife is an aide. Without her, there is no success in even the slightest of tasks. If he undertakes a task

alone, he gets only half the fruits. O lord! If a man undertakes the task along with his wife, he obtains the entire fruit. This has been said about the wife in the sacred texts and those who are familiar with *dharma* know this well. It has been heard that Goutami, best among rivers, is in Dandakaranya. She destroys every kind of sin. She bestows everything desired. Therefore, along with me, go there and undertake meritorious deeds that yield great fruits. Thereby, you will slay your enemy and obtain great joy.” Addressed in this way, Shatakratu agreed. Along with his *guru* and his wife, he went to Ganga, the mother of the universe, known as Goutami. Delighted, Hari went there, in the middle of Dandakaranya. He made up his mind to perform austerities to Shambhu, the lord of the gods.’

‘He first bowed down and bathed in Ganga. Joining his hands in salutation, he sought refuge with Shiva alone. He recited the following *stotram*. Indra said, “Using your own *maya*, you create, preserve and destroy all mobile and immobile objects. But you do not get entangled in this. You are alone and independent. You are the consciousness that has no duality. Your *atman* is bliss. May the one with the Pinaka in his hand be pleased with us. Sanaka and the others, who know about Vedanta, do not know the truth about him. They are ignorant about his mysteries. Parvati’s lord is the one who satisfies every kind of wish. Let the slayer of Andhaka be pleased with me. ⁸³³ He is the one who created himself. The illustrious one created Virinchi and saw his fearful head. ⁸³⁴ He severed it with the tips of his nails. When it stuck to his nails, he flung it away and the three *vargas* were created from it. ⁸³⁵ Sin, poverty, avarice, begging, delusion and calamities were born from this and obtained their powers. There were others and all these assumed the form of the misery of *samsara*. Everything is pervaded by them. Seeing all this, the lord of the gods was bewildered and spoke to the goddess. ‘Please save the universe. O goddess of the worlds! O mother of the universe! O Uma! O one who is the refuge! O extremely gentle one! O extremely fortunate one! O one in whom the universe is established! O one who bestows boons! Victory of you. You are the enjoyment of objects of pleasure. You are *samadhi*. You are supreme emancipation. You are Svaha. You are Svadha. You are Svasti. ⁸³⁶ You are

without origin. You are success. You are speech. You are intellect. You are without old age. You are without death. You are in the form of learning and other things. Following my instruction, you are the one who protects the three worlds. You are the one who creates the wonderful three worlds, in your form as Prakriti.’ Addressed in this way, Hara’s beloved was eager to embrace him and converse with him. When she was exhausted, she clung to the upper half of Bhava’s body and used her fingers to fling away the drops of sweat. From these drops, Dharma was born first. He was followed by Lakshmi, donations, excellent rain, prosperous living beings, lakes, grain, flowers, fruits, objects that bring good fortune, handsomeness of form and attire, objects used for *shringara*,⁸³⁷ dancing, singing, *amrita*, Puranas, *shruti* texts, *smriti* texts, *nit*i texts, food, drinks, weapons,⁸³⁸ sacred texts, appropriate equipment and weapons for houses, *tirthas*, forests, sacrifices, civic works, auspicious vehicles, sparkling ornaments and seats. ‘You embraced Bhava’s limbs and laughed and conversed with him.’⁸³⁹ Mobile and immobile objects were generated from the beads of your perspiration. O goddess! Everything that was thus born became cleansed of sin. There is abundance of joy. There is eternal auspiciousness that is radiant. This is because of your sentiments. O goddess! O mother of the universe! Therefore, save me. O supreme one in the universe! I am scared of *samsara*. There are some who are confused because of debates. There are others who are drowned. I bow down to the beautiful Shiva and Shakti, who are one.’ While he was praising in this way, Shiva appeared in front of him. Shiva asked, ‘O Hari! O one who is devoted! What is the boon you desire? Tell me.’ Indra replied, ‘My enemy is strong. He is like the *vajra* to behold. There are many occasions when I have been defeated by him, bound and taken down to the nether regions. I have been pierced by his words, which are like arrows. I have done this so that he can be killed. O lord of the universe! O lord! So that I can defeat my enemy, please give me energy and everything else needed to destroy my enemy. He is the one who is responsible for my defeat. If I can destroy him, I will think that I have been born again. Fame, victory and prosperity are the best.’ Shiva told Shakra, ‘Your enemy cannot be killed by me alone. Along with Poulami, you must

worship the undecaying Vishnu Hari, the divinity Janardana. He is the refuge of the three worlds. Single-mindedly fix your intelligence on Narayana. O Hari! From him and from me, you will then obtain what you love.’ The illustrious Maheshvara, the original creator, spoke again. ‘The sages know that *mantras*, practice of austerities and practice of *yoga* at any confluence ensure success. O brahmana! ⁸⁴⁰ What need be said about the confluence of Goutami and the river Phena? What need be said about a confluence of that river in a cave within the mountain? On the southern banks of Ganga, there is a brahmana named Apastamba. He is a lord among sages. His intelligence is fixed on Mukunda’s feet. O slayer of Bala! I am also pleased with him. With your wife, satisfy him and Gadadhara.’ ⁸⁴¹ He bathed at the sacred confluence of Phena with Ganga. He controlled himself and on Ganga’s southern bank, along with Apastamba, he praised the divinity Janardana. With many kinds of *mantras* from the Vedas, he performed austerities and satisfied him. Content, Vishnu appeared and asked, ‘What should be given to you?’ The illustrious Hari replied, ‘Please give me someone who will kill my enemy.’ Janardana answered, ‘Know that it has already been given.’ Through the favours of Shiva, Ganga and Vishnu, a man arose from the waters. He was born in the form of both Shiva and Vishnu. He held a *chakra* in his hand and wielded a trident. He went to Rasatala and killed the *daitya* Mahashani, Indra’s enemy. He became Indra’s friend. He is Abjaka Vrishakapi. Though he resided in heaven, Indra always followed Vrishakapi.’

‘On seeing that he was affectionate towards another, Shachi became angry. But Shatakratu laughed and reassured her. Indra said, “O Indrani! O beautiful one! I am not seeking refuge with anyone other than you. O beloved one! I pledge on water, on oblations, on the fire that always brings pleasure and on your limbs that I do not go anywhere else. Therefore, you should not speak about any suspicion regarding anyone else. You are devoted to your husband and you are my beloved. You are my aide in *dharma* and *mantras*. You have offspring and you have been born in a noble lineage. Other than you, how can anyone else be my beloved? Thus, because of your instructions, I went to the great river, Mahanadi. ⁸⁴²

Through the favours of Vishnu, the lord of the gods who holds a *chakra* in his hand, and through the favours of the divinity Shiva, Vrishakapi arose from the water. He is my friend Abjaka, famous in the worlds. O extremely fortunate one! I have overcome my grief. I am the Indra who cannot be dislodged. When the wife follows the husband's wishes, what cannot be achieved? O auspicious one! Though emancipation may be extremely difficult for us to obtain, the three ⁸⁴³ can be obtained. A wife is the greatest friend. She brings welfare in this world and in the next world. If she is born in a noble lineage, is pleasant in speech, is devoted to her husband, is beautiful, possesses the qualities and is indifferent towards prosperity and adversity, there is nothing in the three worlds that cannot be achieved by her. O beloved one! It is because of your intelligence that everything auspicious has happened to me. From now on, I will only do what you tell me and nothing else. For *dharma* in the world hereafter, there is nothing to match a virtuous son. But for a man who is afflicted, there is no medication like a wife. For obtaining what is beneficial and for cleansing sins, there is nothing like Ganga. O one with a beautiful face! Now listen to something else. For *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha* and for destroying sins, there is nothing other than realization that there is no difference between Shiva and Vishnu. There is no other means for emancipation. O virtuous one! It is because of your intelligence that I have obtained what was in my mind. I have obtained it because of the favours of Shiva, Vishnu and Ganga. I think that my position as Indra is now stable, thanks to the strength of my friend. O beautiful one! Vrishakapi, who originated from the water, is my friend. You are my eternal beloved friend. There is no one whom I love more. Goutami Ganga is best among *tirthas*, Hari and Shankara are best among gods. It is through their favours that I have obtained everything that I desired. This *tirtha*, famous in the three worlds, brings me pleasure. Therefore, in due order, I will ask the gods for something. Let the *rishis*, Ganga, Hari and Shankara sanction this. In Abjaka Indreshvara, let the gods be on both banks. Let the divinity Shankara be on one bank and Janardana on the other. Let Vishnu Trivikrama himself purify Dandakaranya. Let all the *tirthas* that are inside bestow every kind of good merit. As soon as they

bathe here, let everyone obtain emancipation. Even if they are wicked and sinners, let them obtain emancipation. If they follow *dharma*, let them obtain supreme emancipation, along with five generations of their ancestors and five generations of their descendants. If something is given to supplicants here, even if that happens to be a sesamum seed, let it bestow on the donor infinite merit, everything that is desired and emancipation. Let such a person be blessed and famous. Let him have a long lifespan and freedom from disease. Let it enhance his good merits. Knowing about this account of Vishnu and Shambhu, if a person bathes here, let him obtain emancipation. Let those who hear, or read about this *tirtha*'s greatness obtain good merits. Let them remember Shiva and Vishnu. They are the ones who sever the aggregate of every kind of sin. They are the ones for their whom sages have controlled their senses and minds seek.” The gods and the *rishis* said that it would be this way. There are seven thousand *tirthas* on the northern banks of Goutami that yield emancipation. These are frequented by gods, *rishis* and *siddhas*. Similarly, there are eleven thousand *tirthas* on the southern bank. Lords among sages have said that Abjaka is the heart of Godavari. It is the place where Isha, Vishnu and Brahma rest.’

Chapter 2(60) (Apastamba Someshvara *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The *tirtha* known as Apastamba is famous in the three worlds. Even if one remembers it, this is capable of destroying an aggregate of every kind of sin. Apastamba was an immensely wise and extremely famous sage. His wife Akshasutra was devoted to following her husband’s *dharma*. His son was the immensely wise and was named Karki. He knew about the truth. Agastya, supreme among sages, came to his hermitage. Apastamba, lord among sages, worshipped Agastya. Along with his disciples and followers, the intelligent one started to ask him. Apastamba asked, “O supreme among sages! Who among the three divinities ⁸⁴⁴ should be worshipped? Who is the one who bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation? Who is the one who provides food? O brahmana! Who is the infinite one? Who is the god of the gods? Who does one worship through sacrifices? Who is the divinity that the Vedas sing about? O great sage! Please dispel my doubt about this. Please tell me.” Agastya replied, “For the sake of *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*, the sacred texts are said to be the authority. Among sacred texts, it is held that the Vedas represent the supreme authority. The Vedas speak about a Purusha who is greater than Para. ⁸⁴⁵ The one who dies is known as Apra, the one who is immortal is spoken of as Para. The one without a manifest form is known as Para and the one with a manifest form is spoken of as Apra. Anything with a manifest form is pervaded by differences in the three kinds of *gunas*. ⁸⁴⁶ Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva are the same, though they are spoken of as three. The single one, who is superior to the three gods, is the one to be known. Depending on attributes and actions, the single one pervades in many different forms. The three forms result for the welfare of the worlds. A person who knows this supreme truth is learned, not someone else. A person

who speaks of differences is described as someone who differentiates the sign. ⁸⁴⁷ There is no atonement for a person who speaks of a difference in this way. The difference between the three gods is in the three different forms they assume. Every proof in the Vedas is about these separate manifested forms. It is held that the single one who has no manifest form is superior to them.” Apastamba said, “From this, I have not come to a firm determination. Therefore, quickly explain this mystery to me. Let there be no doubt and no alternative, so that the worship can bestow every kind of prosperity.” Hearing this, the illustrious Agastya spoke these words. Agastya replied, “There is no mutual difference between the gods. Nevertheless, every kind of success and bliss in the soul is obtained through Shiva. Shiva, the supreme brilliance, is the cause behind Prapancha. ⁸⁴⁸ O sage! With supreme devotion, worship Hara. The one who destroys all sins is in Dandaka forest, near Goutami.” Hearing the sage’s words, he was filled with great delight. He asked, “Which form bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation on men, the one that is manifest or the one that is not manifest? Which form undertakes creation? Who preserves? Who is the donor? Who destroys everything? Into which form is everything withdrawn?” Agastya replied, “The form of Brahma is the one who is the creator, the form of Vishnu is the one who is the preserver. The form of Rudra is the destroyer. This is what can be read in all the Vedas.” Thereupon, Apastamba went to Ganga. He controlled himself and bathed. O Narada! Using this *stotram*, he praised the divinity Shankara. Apastamba said, “O Somanatha! You are present in all living beings, like fire in wood, fragrance in flowers, trees in seeds and gold in stones. I seek refuge with you. In his pastimes, he is the creator of the three worlds and the one who ordains them. The universe is his form. He is beyond existence and non-existence. I seek refuge with that Someshvara. When one remembers him, one is not affected by the great curse of poverty and the body is not touched by different kinds of ailments. On resorting to him, one obtains everything that one desires. I seek refuge with that Someshvara. Earlier, because of him, Brahma and the others considered the *dharma* of the three ⁸⁴⁹ and desired to divide the body into two. ⁸⁵⁰ I seek refuge with that Someshvara.

Sanctified by *mantras*, it is into him that oblations proceed. It is he who is worshipped through oblations. He renders the oblations that gods subsist on. There is nothing superior to him. There is no one who is more praiseworthy. He is subtler than the most subtle. No one is greater. He is greater than the greatest. I seek refuge with that Someshvara. This wonderful universe, varied and great, becomes unified in action and follows his command. His form is unthinkable. I seek refuge with that Someshvara. The power is his. All the lordship is his. The states of creator and donor and greatness are his. Delight, fame, friendship and the original *dharma* are his. I seek refuge with that Someshvara. He is the one who should always be worshipped by everyone. He always loves those who seek refuge with him. He is always auspicious. He has every kind of form. I seek refuge with that Someshvara.” O Narada! At this, the illustrious one was pleased with the sage and asked him to seek something for himself or for others. Apastamba told Shiva, “Let those who bathe here and see the divinity Ishvara, the lord of the universe, obtain all that they wish for.” Shiva agreed to what the sage said. Since then, that place has been known as Apastamba *tirtha*. It is capable of destroying the darkness of ignorance, which is without beginning.’

Chapter 2(61) (Several *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The place famous as Yama *tirtha* enhances the delight of the ancestors. It completely destroys every kind of sin. Hear about what transpired there. This account is ancient history. ⁸⁵¹ O sage! There was a dog of the gods, famous by the name of Sarama. She had two excellent and extremely great sons. Those two dogs always followed people. They could move, even though they subsisted on air. They possessed four eyes and were loved by Yama. She protected the cows of the gods and the animals earmarked for sacrifices. As she protected, the *rakshasas*, *daityas* and *danavas* followed her. The immensely wise female dog, the mother of the two dogs, protected them. They made efforts to tempt her with many kinds of words and gifts. The wicked *rakshasas* abducted the cattle and the auspicious animals earmarked for sacrifices. Gradually, the female dog approached the gods and spoke to them. Sarama said, “The *rakshasas* bound me with nooses and struck me with rods. O gods! They abducted the cows and the animals earmarked for the success of the sacrifice.” Hearing her words, Brihaspati quickly spoke to the gods. Brihaspati said, “Her figure is malformed. Her sin can be discerned. The cows have been abducted with her sanction. There can be no other reason. Through the movements of her body, it is evident that though she pretends to perform good deeds, she is wicked.” Hearing his *guru*’s words, Indra struck the female dog with his foot. Struck by the foot, milk began to flow out of her mouth. Shachi’s husband said, “O female dog! You have drunk milk. The *rakshasas* have given it to you. That is how they have taken away my cattle.” Sarama replied, “O lord! I have not committed a crime. I have not acted in any perverse way. O lord of the gods! There has been no crime or negligence on my part. Despite your arrival, the cattle were taken away by

the *rakshasas*. Are you tainted because of that? O lord! Your enemies are strong.” At this, the *guru* of the gods meditated and understood what she had done.⁸⁵² “O Shakra! It is true that she is wicked and has taken the side of the enemy.” Therefore, Shakra cursed her. “O evil one! Become a bitch in the world of the mortals. Even if you committed this crime in your ignorance, you have become full of sin.” Because of Indra’s curse, she was born among humans. Just as Maghavan had cursed her, the evil one became extremely terrible. The lord of the gods sought to bring back the cattle that had been taken away by the *rakshasas*. He went and informed Vishnu.’

‘Vishnu got ready to kill the *daityas*, *danavas* and *rakshasas* who had taken the cattle away. He seized his great bow, Sharnga, famous in the worlds, used to destroy *daityas*. Janardana, who conquers his enemies and is worshipped by the gods, stationed himself in Dandakaranya. The lord held Sharnga in his hand. The powerful *daityas*, *danavas* and *rakshasas* were there. Vishnu killed the *rakshasas* who had abducted the cattle. In Dandakaranya, he is therefore famous as Sharngapani.⁸⁵³ Vishnu fought with the *daityas* and *rakshasas*. O great sage! Scared of Vishnu, they fled towards the southern direction. Parameshvara⁸⁵⁴ pursued and caught up with them on Garuda. With arrows as swift as thought released from Sharnga, Vishnu killed them on the northern bank of Ganga. Vishnu destroyed the enemies of the gods. From Sharnga, the powerful Vishnu shot arrows that were extremely swift. *Mantras* were invoked over them and they made a loud noise. Because of Vishnu’s arrows, the enemies of the gods were exterminated. The place where the divine cows were got back is known as Bana *tirtha*.⁸⁵⁵ It is also known in the worlds as Vishnu *tirtha* and is famous as Gou *tirtha*. Earmarked as sacrificial animals, the cattle were kept on the southern bank of Ganga. The gods gathered all those who had fled and brought them together, in Ganga. They constructed an island in the middle as a pen for the cattle. With those cattle, the sacrifice of the gods was completed in Ganga. The island where the cattle were kept in the middle of Ganga is known as Yajna *tirtha*. That auspicious spot is the place where the gods held their sacrifice and it yields every object of desire. O immensely radiant one! Ganga’s powers assume a manifested form there.

Samsara is like an ocean without substance that cannot be crossed, but it is like a boat that takes one across. She ⁸⁵⁶ is Vishveshvari Yogamaya, who always bestows freedom from fear on devotees. On Ganga's southern bank, this is the *tirtha* of Goraksha.' ⁸⁵⁷

'Sarama's two sons, the dogs with four eyes, were loved by Yama. They went to him and reported in detail everything about their mother's crime and the curse. Having reported it properly, both of them asked Yama what task would now ensure happiness and freedom from the curse. Along with them, Surya's son ⁸⁵⁸ went to Surya and told him all this. Hearing this, Surya told his son, "O supreme god! In Dandaka forest, there is Goutami Ganga, who purifies the three worlds. O child! Control yourself and full of great faith, bathe there. In due order, with every kind of sentiment, praise Brahma, Vishnu and Isha. Your two servants will then find delight." Hearing his father's words, Yama was pleased in his mind. To please them, Yama went there, so as to satisfy the gods. Goutami destroys every kind of sin. Extremely controlled in his mind, he satisfied Ganga and the excellent gods. Along with the dogs, the lord who is the prosperous lord of the southern direction, satisfied Bhanu ⁸⁵⁹ and Brahma on the southern bank. The powerful Dharma ⁸⁶⁰ himself satisfied Ishana and Vishnu on the northern bank. He sought many boons that would bring benefit to the worlds and they granted him excellent boons, so that Sarama would be freed from her curse. Yama said, "O Brahma! O Vishnu! O Maheshvara! If a person bathes here, for his own sake or for the sake of others, let him obtain the auspicious objects of desire. If a person bathes in Bana *tirtha* and remembers Sharngapani, from one *yuga* to another *yuga*, let him not suffer from penury or misery. If a person controls himself, bathes in Gou *tirtha* or Brahma *tirtha*, bows down to Brahma and performs *pradakshina* of the island, let that be the same as performing *pradakshina* of the entire earth, with its riches and seven *dvipas*. If he goes to the place where the gods held their sacrifice and gives a little bit of wealth to a brahmana, or offers some oblations to the fire, let that bestow all the fruits of horse and other sacrifices. If a person reads the *gayatri mantra*, the mother of the Vedas, even once, let it be as if he has read all the Vedas. Let him have no desire

and let him be deserving of emancipation. If a person bathes on the southern bank and devotedly and properly worships the goddess Shakti, let him obtain everything that he wishes for. Shakti is the mother of all three—Brahma, Vishnu and Mahesha. Let that person obtain everything that he wishes for. Let him have sons and riches. If a man controls himself and bathes on the southern bank, devotedly seeing Aditya, let him obtain everything desired that is got through sacrifices with many kinds of *dakshina*. If a person bathes on Ganga's northern bank and bows down and sees the destroyer of *daityas*,⁸⁶¹ let him obtain Vishnu's supreme destination. If a person controls his *atman*, bathes in Yama *tirtha* and immediately sees and worships the lord Yama, let him obtain infinite good fruits for his ancestors and extend his fame. Through bathing, donations, *japa* and praise there, let even evil-doers ensure emancipation for their ancestors." O Narada! There are eight thousand and three *tirthas* like these. Bathing and donating there yield every kind of infinite good merit. Remembering them is sacred and destroys the sins of many births. Because of my command, hearing or reading about them destroys grave sins for the person, his own family and his ancestors. A person should control his *atman*, bathe and donate a little. He should offer *pinda* to the ancestors and bow down before the gods. He will then obtain wealth, grain, fame, valour, a long lifespan, freedom from disease, prosperity, sons, grandsons, a beloved wife and everything else that he wishes for. He will not be separated from those he loves and will be respected by his relatives. He will save his ancestors and family members, even if they happen to be in hell. He will be purified and at the time of his death, he will remember Vishnu and Shiva and be surrounded by his loved ones. Following the words of the gods, he will obtain emancipation.'

Chapter 2(62) (Yakshini confluence)

Brahma said, ‘The *tirtha* known as the confluence of Yakshini yields every kind of fruit. Bathing and donating there, bestow everything that one wishes for. The divinity Yakeshvara is there. If one sees him, one obtains objects of pleasure and emancipation. As soon as one bathes there, one obtains the fruits of *satrayaga*.⁸⁶² Vishvavasus⁸⁶³ had a sister named Pippala. Her laughter was loud. The rishis held a sacrifice along the banks of Goutami. On seeing that the *rishis* were emaciated, the extremely proud one laughed. Having gone, she remained there and heard “Voushad” and “Shroushad”.⁸⁶⁴ She pronounced these in distorted tones and they cursed her, “Become a river.” She became a river, extremely well known as Yakshini. After this, Vishvavasus worshipped the *rishis* and the three-eyed divinity. She was made to merge with Goutami and was hence freed of her curse. As soon as one bathes at this confluence, one obtains the fruits of *satrayaga*. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as the confluence of Yakshini. Bathing and other rites performed there, yield every object of desire. The place where Shambhu was pleased by Vishvasu and bestowed this auspiciousness is the supreme Shiva *tirtha*. It is also known as Durga *tirtha*. It destroys the aggregate of every kind of sin. It destroys all calamities.⁸⁶⁵ O great sage! It represents the essence of all the best *tirthas*. All the excellent sages have described this *tirtha* as famous and it bestows every kind of success on men.’

Chapter 2(63) (Shukla *tirtha* and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Shukla *tirtha* bestows every kind of success on men. As soon as one remembers it, one obtains everything that one desires. Bharadvaja was a well-known sage and he was extremely devoted to *dharma*. His wife was named Paithinasi and she was the ornament of a noble lineage. She resided along the banks of Goutami and was devoted to her husband’s vows. She was engaged in preparing *purodasha* ⁸⁶⁶ for Agni, Soma and Indra. While the *purodasha* was being boiled, a being was born from the smoke. He was terrible for the three worlds and wished to eat up the *purodasha*. The sage angrily asked him, “Why are you destroying my sacrifice?” Bharadvaja, supreme among *brahmanas*, was full of rage and quickly spoke to him. Hearing the *rishi*’s words, the *rakshasa* replied to him. The *rakshasa* said, “O Bharadvaja! Know that I am famous as Havyaghna. ⁸⁶⁷ I am the son of Sandhya and the eldest son of Prachinabarhi. Brahma has granted me the boon that I can happily devour any sacrifice. Kali is my younger brother. He is strong and extremely terrible. I am dark. My father is dark. My mother is dark, and so is my younger brother. I will destroy the sacrifice. I will sever the sacrificial post. I am the destroyer.” Bharadvaja replied, “You should protect my beloved sacrifice. This is eternal *dharma*. I know that you are the destroyer of sacrifices. However, protect my sacrifice and the brahmana.” ⁸⁶⁸ Yajñaghna ⁸⁶⁹ said, “O Bharadvaja! Hear my brief words. Earlier, I used to be a brahmana. In the presence of the gods and the *danavas*, Brahma cursed me. Thereafter, I pacified the divinity who is the grandfather of the worlds. He said, ‘O Havyaghna! When the excellent sages sprinkle you with *amrita*, you will be freed from your curse, not otherwise.’ O brahmana! If you act in accordance with these words, everything that you desire will happen. This

will never be a falsehood.” Bharadvaja again replied, “O immensely intelligent one! You are my friend. Please tell me how my sacrifice can be saved and I will act accordingly. The gods and the *daityas* got together and churned the ocean of milk, obtaining *amrita* with a great deal of effort. How can we obtain that easily? If you are pleased and delighted, please tell me how that can be easily obtained.” Hearing the *rishi*’s words, the *rakshasa* was happy and spoke. The *rakshasa* said, “Goutami’s water is *amrita*. Gold is spoken of as *amrita*. The *ghee* that is obtained from cows is *amrita*. *Soma* juice is *amrita*. Sprinkle me with these three—Ganga’s water, *ghee* and gold. However, among all of these, Goutami’s water is the best and is divine *amrita*.” Hearing this, the *rishi* was filled with great contentment. He lovingly took Ganga’s water, the *amrita*, in his hand and sprinkled the *rakshasa* with this. In the sacrifice, he also sprinkled the sacrificial post, the sacrificial animal and the entire circular area around the sacrifice. As soon as the great-souled one sprinkled, all of these turned white. The immensely strong *rakshasa* also turned white. His form had been dark earlier. However, in an instant, it turned white. The powerful Bharadvaja completed everything connected with the sacrifice. He granted leave to the officiating priests and flung the sacrificial post into the waters of Ganga. O immensely intelligent one! That sacrificial post is still in the middle of Ganga. It was sprinkled with *amrita* and is an indication of the great event that transpired at this *tirtha*. The *rakshasa* again spoke to Bharadvaja. The *rakshasa* said, “O Bharadvaja! I am leaving. You have made me white again. From now on, anyone who undertakes bathing, donating, worship and other rites at this *tirtha* will obtain everything that he desires and also obtain the fruits of this sacrifice. O sage! As soon as it is remembered, all sins will be destroyed.” Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Shukla *tirtha*.⁸⁷⁰ This door to heaven is open along the Goutami in Dandakaranya. O tiger among sages! Along both banks, there are seven thousand *tirthas*. They yield every kind of success.’

Chapter 2(64) (Chakra *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘As soon as one remembers the place known as Chakra *tirtha*, all sins are destroyed. O Narada! I will describe its powers. Listen attentively. O sage! There were seven famous *rishis*.⁸⁷¹ Vasishtha was the foremost. Resorting to the banks of Goutami, they started to perform a *satrayajna*.⁸⁷² Extremely terrible *rakshasas* started to create impediments. The sages came to me and told me about the deeds of the *rakshasas*. O Narada! Using my *maya*, I created the form of a woman. I told them, “As soon as they see her, the *rakshasas* will be destroyed.” O sage! Saying this, I handed over the woman to the *rishis*. Following my words, the *rishis* took Maya⁸⁷³ and returned. She is known as Ajaika and her form is black and red. Even today, she exists in her own form and is known as Muktakeshi. She can assume any form at will and causes delusion in the three worlds. Because of her powers, all the excellent sages were assured in their minds. Along the banks of Goutami, best among rivers, they consecrated themselves for the sacrifice again. To destroy the sacrifice, the *rakshasas* arrived again. Near the sacrificial arena, those bulls among *rakshasas* saw Maya. They danced, sang, laughed and wept. Because of the powers of Maheshvari Mahamaya, they were extremely insolent. Shambara, the lord of the *daityas*, was among them. O Narada! The valiant one devoured the woman who was in the form of Maya. Those who had witnessed Maya’s powers were extremely surprised at this. When the sacrifice was being destroyed, they sought refuge with Vishnu.⁸⁷⁴ To protect the sages, Vishnu gave them his *chakra*. That *chakra* sliced off the *rakshasas*, *daityas* and *danavas*. Scared of it, the bulls among *danavas* died. The great sacrifice of the *rishis* was completed. Vishnu’s Sudarshana *chakra* was washed in Ganga’s waters. Since then, that *tirtha* has been described as Chakra *tirtha*.

By bathing and donating there, one obtains the fruits of a *satrayaga*. There are five hundred other *tirthas* that destroy sins. Bathing and donating in any of them bestows emancipation.'

Chapter 2(65) Confluence of Vani

Brahma said, ‘Hara Vagishvara exists in the place famous as the confluence of Vani. That *tirtha* frees from every kind of sin and bestows everything that is desired. Bathing and donating there, destroys sins like killing a brahmana. There was a dispute between Brahma and Vishnu, about who was superior. In their middle, Mahadeva appeared in the form of a column of light. O son! While they were arguing, “I am great,” an auspicious and divine voice spoke to them. The divine voice spoke to both of them. “You should not argue. Between the two of you, whoever can see the end of this column is superior.” At her words, Vishnu proceeded downwards and I proceeded upwards. Vishnu quickly returned and sat down near the column of light. O sage! I went further and further, but could not find the end. When I was exhausted, I returned and saw the lord Isha. At this, a terrible thought entered my mind. “I have seen the end of this divinity. Therefore, my superiority over Vishnu has been established.” O immensely intelligent one! Nevertheless, I thought again. “The mouth must speak the truth. Even though I am suffering, how can I utter false words? Among many kinds of sins, uttering a falsehood is the greatest sin. Since my mouths utter the truth, how can I utter a falsehood?” Therefore, I created a fifth mouth. It had the form of a donkey and was exceedingly terrible. Having created it, I thought for a long time about uttering a falsehood. Hari, the lord of the universe, was seated there and I spoke to him. “O Janardana! I have seen his end. Hence, I am superior to you.” As I said this, on my sides, Hari and Shankara assumed a single form, like the sun and the moon. Seeing them, I was amazed. Scared, I praised them. Angry, those two lords of the universe spoke to that voice. Hari and Hara said, “O wicked one! Become a river. There is no sin like uttering a lie.”

Agitated, she assumed the form of a river. Seeing this, I was amazed. Frightened, I spoke to her. “Stationed in Brahma’s mouth, you uttered a falsehood. Therefore, you will become invisible. There is no doubt that your form is sinful.” Getting to know about the curse, she prostrated herself before those two divinities. She repeatedly praised them and sought to be freed from the curse.’

‘She beseeched those two lords of the gods, who were worshipped by the gods. Hari and Hara were satisfied. Pleased, they spoke to the voice. Hari and Hara said, “O fortunate one! When you merge into Ganga, the purifier of the worlds, you will regain your form. O extremely beautiful one! You will become pure.” Addressed in this way, the goddess merged into Ganga. When she merged into Bhagirathi Goutami, she regained her own form. O brahmana! The goddess achieved what is extremely difficult for the gods. Merging into Goutami, the one who bestows auspiciousness became famous under the name of Vani. Where she merged into Bhagirathi, the goddess is also known as Sarasvati. She is famous in both the confluences ⁸⁷⁵ and is worshipped by the worlds. There is the confluence with Sarasvati and there is the confluence with Vani. The goddess, the divine voice, merged into Goutami as Vani and Sarasvati. The place where the voice worshipped the lord Shiva, the lord of the gods, and was freed from her curse is a *tirtha* that is worshipped everywhere. Brahma was cleansed of his wicked speech and returned to his own abode again. Therefore, if a person purifies himself, bathes at that confluence and sees Vagishvara, he immediately obtains emancipation. If a person undertakes some donations, oblations, fasting and other rites at that confluence, he does not return to *samsara* again. There are one thousand and nine hundred *tirthas* along both banks. They destroy all the sins that have been accumulated across many births.’

Chapter 2(66) (Moudgalya, Vishnu and other *tirthas*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Vishnu *tirtha* is famous. Hear about its account. Mudgala’s son was the *rishi* Moudgalya and he was well known. His wife was known by the name of Jabala and she was famous because she had excellent sons. The father, the *rishi* Mudgala, was famous in the world and was aged. His auspicious wife was famous under the name of Bhagirathi. Every morning, Moudgalya would control himself and bathe in Ganga. O supreme sage! He always followed a certain rite. He used a path taught to him by his *guru*. On the banks of Ganga, he used *kusha* grass, clay and *shami* flowers to invoke Vishnu in his heart, night and day. Moudgalya always performed this invocation. Invoked by him, Lakshmi’s consort and the lord of the universe swiftly arrived. He would be astride Vinata’s son ⁸⁷⁶ and would hold the conch shell, *chakra* and mace. He would be attentively worshipped by *rishi* Moudgalya. The lord of the universe would tell Moudgalya wonderful accounts. In the afternoon, Vishnu would repeatedly tell Moudgalya, “O child! You are exhausted. Return to your own abode.” Addressed in this way by the divinity Vishnu, the brahmana would leave. Along with the gods, the lord of the universe would also leave for his own residence. Moudgalya’s beloved wife was devoted to her husband. She carefully brought vegetables, roots and fruits for her husband. She served guests, her sons and her husband excellent food. Devoted to her vows, she ate only after she had served them food. Every night, after he had eaten, Moudgalya would always happily tell them the wonderful accounts he had heard from Vishnu.’

‘In this way, a long period of time elapsed. Extremely surprised, ⁸⁷⁷ in private, Moudgalya’s wife addressed her husband in these words. Jabala

said, “When Vishnu, worshipped by the gods, appears before you, you should ask the lord of the universe why we suffer from this kind of hardship. O immensely wise one! You should ask Vishnu this. As soon as he is remembered, old age, birth, death and ailments are destroyed. What need be said when he is seen? Please ask the lord of the universe.” Addressed by his beloved in these words, Moudgalya worshipped Hari, as he always did. He joined his hands in salutation and humbly asked him. Moudgalya said, “O lord of the universe! When you are remembered, sorrow, poverty and wicked deeds are destroyed. But even you are seen, how is it that I am faced with adversity?” Shri Vishnu replied, “Everywhere, living beings always enjoy the consequences of their own deeds. No one else does any good deed or bad deed towards anyone. The fruit is exactly like the seed that has been sown. How can a mango be produced from a *nimba* ⁸⁷⁸ seed? How can those who have not served Goutami, not worshipped Hari and Shankara and not given to *brahmanas* be recipients of prosperity? You have not given anything to *brahmanas*, or to me. Only something that has been given reaches the supreme. Through clay, water, *kusha* grass, *mantras* and other acts of purification, one can always cleanse one’s *atman*. One can dry up one’s body too. However, without donating, men never obtain objects of pleasure. One is purified by following virtuous conduct. After this, a man becomes non-attached. Thereafter, his acquisition of *jnana* is unconstrained. Even if he is alive, he becomes emancipated. By first being devoted towards me, everyone can become emancipated. Objects of pleasure and emancipation can be obtained through donations and dispelling the misery of living beings. However, only through devotion, objects of pleasure cannot be obtained.” Moudgalya asked, “How can there be emancipation through devotion? Compared to worldly pleasures, emancipation is more difficult to obtain. If emancipation has been achieved, what else does an embodied being need? O one who pervades the universe! Everyone should worship the emancipation that is brought about through devotion.” Vishnu said, “O brahmana! There is a difference. After remembering me, if anything is given to *brahmanas* or other supplicants, that brings infinite benefits. However, if anything is given without meditating on me, that only

brings fruits to the extent that it has been given. It does not yield any objects of pleasure in this world. O immensely intelligent one! Hence, after resorting to the banks of Goutami, you should give me or a foremost brahmana something to eat.” Moudgalya told Vishnu, “I have nothing to give you. Everything, including this body, has been offered to you.” At this, Vishnu, lord of the universe, quickly told Garuda, “Bring a fragment of grain to me. He will give me that. Thereby, he will obtain the objects of pleasure that are in his mind.” Hearing his master’s words, the king of the birds did that. Controlled in his vows, Moudgalya placed that fragment of grain in Vishnu’s hand. Meanwhile, Vishnu spoke to Vishvakarma. Vishnu said, “O immensely intelligent one! For seven generations, everyone in his family will obtain whatever their minds desire. They will possess cattle, gold, grain, garments and ornaments.” Through the powers of Vishnu and Ganga, Moudgalya obtained every kind of ornament that brings mental pleasure in this world. Vishnu told Moudgalya, “Go home.” He returned to his hermitage and saw all this prosperity. The *rishi* said, “The powers of donations and remembering Vishnu are wonderful. The powers of Ganga are wonderful. Who could have thought of these great things?” Along with his wife, sons, grandsons and relatives, Moudgalya enjoyed the objects of pleasure. Along with his ancestors, he obtained emancipation. Since then, that place has been known as Moudgalya *tirtha* and Vishnu *tirtha*. Bathing and donating there, yield objects of pleasure and emancipation. If a person hears about this *tirtha* or remembers it, Vishnu is pleased with him. He is freed from all sins and becomes happy. Along both banks, there are eleven thousand *tirthas*. Bathing, donations and *japa* performed there, bestow every objective.’

Chapter 2(67) (Lakshmi *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Lakshmi *tirtha* directly enhances prosperity. O Narada! It destroys Alakshmi.’⁸⁷⁹ Hear about its sacred account. O son! Earlier, there was a dispute between Lakshmi and Daridra.⁸⁸⁰ Acting against each other, they approached the universe. There is nothing in the three worlds that cannot be pervaded by them. They told each other, “I am superior”, “I am superior”. Alakshmi energetically told Shri, ‘I am the one who was born first.’ Shri Lakshmi replied, “I represent good lineage, good conduct and life in living beings. Without me, even if they are alive, those with bodies are as good as dead.” She spoke to Daridra in this way. Daridra told her, “I am superior to everything else. Emancipation is always dependent on me. Wherever I am present, desire, anger, avarice, insolence and malice never exist. There is no cause for fear. Madness, envy and arrogant conduct do not exist wherever I am present.” Hearing Daridra’s words, Lakshmi replied to her. Lakshmi replied, “Every being who is ornamented by me is worshipped. Even if a person without riches is Shiva’s equal, he is reviled by everyone. The five divinities who are present in the body utter the words ‘Give’ and instantly leave—Dhi, Shri, Hri, Shanti and Kirti.”⁸⁸¹ Qualities and superiority only exist in a person as long as he does not seek riches from another. As soon as a person seeks riches, where are his qualities? Where is his pride? A living being is regarded as the best and the store of all the qualities, he is worshipped by all the worlds, only as long as he does not seek riches from others. For those with bodies, the lack of riches represents hardship and the commission of great sins. A person without riches is never respected. People don’t speak to him, or touch him. O Daridra! Listen to my words. Therefore, I am the best.” Hearing Lakshmi’s words, Daridra addressed her in these words. Daridra said, “O

Lakshmi! Do not speak in this way. Aren't you ashamed of repeatedly saying, 'I am superior'? Giving up Purushottama, you always find pleasure in wickedness. You always deceive the world? How can you boast? Having obtained you, there is no happiness. Repentance is vastly superior. Even if a man happens to be a learned person, as soon as he comes into contact with you, he becomes intoxicated, much more than through liquor. O Lakshmi! In general, you always find pleasure in those who are wicked in conduct. I always reside with deserving people, those who follow *dharma* and good conduct, those who are devoted to Shiva and Vishnu, those who are grateful and great, those who exhibit virtuous behaviour and are serene, those who serve their seniors, those who are righteous and learned, those who are brave and good and those who are accomplished in their intelligence. O Lakshmi! I always reside with them. Therefore, there is superiority in me. I reside with pure *brahmanas*, those who follow their vows, mendicants and those who are without fear. O Lakshmi! Hear about where you reside—those who follow kings, the wicked, the cruel, the deceitful, those who indulge in calumny, the avaricious, those who are wicked in deeds, those who indulge in fraud, those who are ignoble, those who are ungrateful, those who are always against *dharma*, those who harm and injure their friends and those who are of unsound minds.” Arguing in this way, both of them came before me.’

‘Hearing their words, I spoke to both of them. “The earth originated before me and the water originated even before that. In an argument between women, only women know the answer, not others. ⁸⁸² Among them, the one who originated from a *kamandalu* is superior. Therefore, go to the goddess Goutami. She will tell you about the firm determination. She is the one who destroys every kind of affliction. She is the one who dispels every kind of doubt.” Following my words, they went to the earth. Along with the earth, they went to water and along with both earth and water, they went to Goutami. Bowing down before Goutami, the earth and water clearly stated everything that had happened and the statements of Daridra and Lakshmi, asking her to mediate. O Narada! While the guardians of the world heard, while the earth heard and while the water heard, Ganga addressed Daridra

in these words. Praising Lakshmi, Goutami spoke these words. Goutami said, “Lakshmi pervades every mobile and immobile object in the world—Brahma’s prosperity, the prosperity of austerities, the prosperity of sacrifices, the signs of deeds, the prosperity of wealth, the prosperity of fame, learning, wisdom, the goddess of speech, the prosperity associated with objects of pleasure, emancipation, memory, shame, fortitude, forgiveness, success, satisfaction, nourishment, peace, the water, the earth, ego, the strength of herbs, sacred texts, purification, the night, heaven, moonlight, benedictions, auspicious pronouncements, pervasiveness, the dawn, everything auspicious and everything radiant. The patience of *brahmanas*, forgiveness of the virtuous, those who possess learning, objects of pleasure, emancipation and everything that is beautiful and pleasant - all of these are characterized by Lakshmi. What is the need to speak a lot? Everything in the universe is full of Lakshmi. Everything, everywhere, that exhibits excellence is pervaded by Lakshmi. There is nothing without her. Hence, aren’t you ashamed of challenging that beautiful goddess? Go. Leave.” Ganga addressed Daridra in these words. Since then, the waters of Ganga have driven away poverty. One suffers from Daridra only as long as one does not resort to Ganga’s waters. Since then, that auspicious *tirtha* has been one that destroys Alakshmi. Through bathing and donating there, one obtains Lakshmi and everything auspicious. O immensely intelligent one! In that *tirtha*, there are another six thousand *tirthas*. They are frequented by gods, *rishis* and sages and bestow every kind of success.’

Chapter 2(68) (Bhanu *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Bhanu tirtha bestows every kind of success on men. I will tell you what happened there. This destroys great sins. There was a famous king known as Sharyati and he was extremely devoted to *dharma*. His wife was Sthavishtha and in her beauty, she was unmatched in the world. The king’s priest was a lord among brahmana *rishis*. He was born in Vishvamitra’s lineage and was known as Madhuchhanda. Along with his priest, the king, supreme among kings, departed, to conquer the directions. Having conquered the directions, on the road back to where they had camped, he spoke to the extremely great priest. He asked, “O extremely great one! Why are you full of dejection? Please tell me the reason. In my kingdom, you are the one who is respected by everyone. You are the one who has comprehended every kind of learning. You have cleansed your sins. Why can it be discerned that your mind lacks contentment? The earth has been conquered. Lords of men have been defeated. There is cause for great delight. Why are you emaciated? O noble one among *brahmanas*! O great one! Please tell me the truth.” So as to make Sharyati understand, the brahmana Madhuchhanda affectionately spoke these loving words. Madhuchhanda said, “O lord of the earth! Listen to the words spoken to me by my wife. ‘We are leaving while there is a *yama* still left.’⁸⁸³ ‘Half of the night is over.’⁸⁸⁴ She is the owner of this body and that beloved one is waiting for me. Remembering the words of the beloved one, my body is drying up. When love causes distraction, it is only the beloved who can restore life.” The king, the scorcher of enemies, laughed and spoke to his priest. The king said, “You are my *guru*. You are my friend. Why are you deceiving yourself? O immensely wise one! O one who confers honours! What purpose will my words serve? What use do

great-souled ones have for happiness that will be destroyed in a short while?” Hearing this, the intelligent Madhucchanda replied in these words. Madhucchanda said, “When a couple is favourably disposed towards each other, the three objectives of life prosper.”⁸⁸⁵ O king! Therefore, something regarded as a taint is actually an ornament.” Surrounded by the great army, he returned to his own kingdom. To test the efficacy of love, he had the following news circulated in the city. “When King Sharyati was proceeding to conquer the directions, a bull among *rakshasas* killed the king and his priest and went away to Rasatala.” O supreme among sages! The king’s wives sought to find out if this was true. However, on hearing the news from the messenger’s mouth, Madhucchanda’s beloved instantly gave up her life. It was extraordinary. Witnessing what happened in the city, the messengers went and reported to the king what the king’s wives and the priest’s beloved had done. The king was astounded and grieved. He spoke to the messengers again. The king said, “O messengers! Go quickly and preserve the brahmana lady’s body. Have the news conveyed that the king is arriving, along with his priest.” While the king was thinking in this way, and invisible voice spoke.’

‘The invisible voice said, “O king! Give up everything and resort to Ganga. Goutami is the one who purifies and pacifies every kind of hardship on earth.” Hearing this, Sharyati resorted to the banks of Ganga. He donated riches to *brahmanas* and satisfied the gods and the ancestors. With a lot of riches, he sent the priest, best among *brahmanas*, to another *tirtha*. He told him, “Make efforts to give these riches to travelers.” The king intended that the priest should not get to know about what he was doing. The great-souled *guru*, born in Vishvamitra’s lineage, departed. The king also sent his entire army away. On the banks of Ganga, the king entered the fire. The Indra among king spoke to Ganga, Bhanu and the gods. He said, “If I have donated, if I have offered oblations and if I have saved my subjects, through that truth, let the virtuous lady use my lifespan to come back to life.” Having said this, Sharyati, supreme among kings, entered the fire. Immediately, the wife of the king’s preceptor came back to life. The king’s *guru* heard what had happened—the reason for the king entering the fire;

his wife, devoted to her husband, dying and coming back to life; and the specific reason why the king had given up his life. He was amazed and was reminded of his own duty. “Should I enter the fire, or should I go to my beloved? Should I torment myself through austerities?” The brahmana arrived at a decision. “I think that this is the good deed I should perform. I will bring the king back to life. After that, I will go to my beloved. This is what is auspicious.” Therefore, he praised Bhaskara. Other than Ravi,⁸⁸⁶ there is no other god who can bestow all that is wished for. Madhucchanda said, “I bow down to Surya, the infinitely energetic one, the one who is emancipation. He is the divinity who is full of the Vedas. You are the meaning of Omkara. I prostrate myself before you. You are the one without a form. You possess an excellent form. You possess three *gunas*. You possess three forms. You are Vishnu’s power. You are the cause behind creation, preservation and destruction.” Pleased at this, Surya appeared and asked him to choose a boon. Madhucchanda said, “O lord of the gods! Give me the king and my beloved, who is pleasant in speech. Give me auspicious sons and give the king auspicious boons.” The lord of the universe gave him Sharyati, adorned with jewels. He also gave him his wife and other boons. Everything was auspicious. Pleased and delighted, the king returned to his own kingdom, along with the priest. He was happy. Since then, that *tirtha* has been remembered as an auspicious place. There are another three thousand *tirthas*, full of qualities, there. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Bhanu *tirtha*. It is also famous as Mritasanjivana⁸⁸⁷ and Sharyati. It is also famous as Madhucchanda. O sage! When it is remembered, sins are destroyed. Bathing and donating there, yields the fruits of all sacrifices. The dead come back to life. The lifespan and freedom from disease are enhanced.’

Chapter 2(69) (Khadga *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Khadga *tirtha* is on the northern banks of Goutami. If a man bathes and donates there, he obtains objects of pleasure and emancipation. O Narada! I will tell you what happened there. Listen attentively. There was a brahmana known as Pailusha and he was the son of Kavasha.⁸⁸⁸ He suffered from the burden of a large family and ran around here and there, in search of wealth. Since he did not get anything, he became full of non-attachment. When destiny is extremely adverse and when manliness becomes futile, nothing gives a learned person as much of strength as non-attachment. He sighed repeatedly and thought, “I do not possess any wealth that has come down to me and I have many to maintain. My soul is proud and I do not deserve this hardship. Shame on what destiny has brought about.” He did find occupations, but those occupations were temporary. Those occupations did not give him sufficient wealth and he became full of non-attachment. “Serving anyone is prohibited for me. Everything is difficult to undertake. Austerities are extremely difficult to perform. The thirst attracts me with great force, but everything is extremely difficult to accomplish. O Trishna!⁸⁸⁹ Out of ignorance, you have afflicted me in this way. I bow down to you.” Thinking about this, the intelligent one thought about the means to sever this bondage. Pailusha addressed his father in these words. Pailusha said, “O father! O lord! Anger, avarice and the ocean of *samsara* are extremely difficult to cross. Please tell me about the sword of *jnana* that can be used to sever these.” Kavasha replied, “It has been said in the Vedas that one should seek out *jnana* from Ishvara. Therefore, worship Ishana. That is the way you will obtain *jnana*.” Addressed in this way, for the sake of *jnana*, Pailusha worshipped Ishvara. Pleased, Mahesha bestowed this *jnana* on the brahmana. Having obtained

the *jnana*, the immensely intelligent one recited this chant. It confers emancipation. Pailusha said, “The first enemy is anger. Even if it is ineffective, it destroys the body. If one uses the sword of *jnana* to sever it, one obtains supreme happiness. Trishna has many kinds of *maya*. It creates bondage and wickedness of conduct. If a man uses the sword of *jnana* to sever it, he establishes himself in happiness. Supreme *dharma* is the sword. The gods and others have said this in the sacred texts. The *atman* is not attached, but attachment is the great enemy. Using the sword of *jnana* to sever it, one obtains the state of being unified with Shiva. Doubt is responsible for great destruction. For the sake of *dharma* and *artha*, it must be destroyed. Having severed doubt, a living creature obtains what is supremely desired. Hope enters, like a demoness. Having burnt it down, one obtains every kind of happiness. Having used the sword to destroy it completely, a living being obtains emancipation.” Having obtained *jnana*, he resorted to the banks of Ganga. He used the sword of *jnana* to rid himself of delusion and obtained emancipation. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Khadga *tirtha*.⁸⁹⁰ It is also known as Jnana *tirtha*, Kavasha *tirtha* and Pailusha *tirtha*. It bestows everything that is desired. The *maharshis* speak about another six thousand *tirthas* there. These completely destroy the aggregate of every kind of sin and bestow everything that is desired.’

Chapter 2(70) (Anvindra *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There is the excellent place known as Anvindra *tirtha*, also famous as Atreya *tirtha*. I will describe its powers. It is capable of getting back a kingdom that has been lost. On the northern banks of Goutami, surrounded by officiating priests and sages, the illustrious *rishi* Atreya started to perform sacrifices. Agni, the bearer of oblations, was the *hotri*. After this, he completed the sacrifice known as the Maheshvari sacrifice. The brahmana obtained prosperity and the power to go anywhere. The brahmana could go, as he pleased, to Indra’s beautiful residence in the world of heaven and also Rasatala. This happened because of the power of his auspicious austerities. On one occasion, he went to Indra’s world. There, he saw the one with one thousand eyes, surrounded by the auspicious gods. He was being praised by the *siddhas* and the *sadhyas*. He was watching the excellent dancing and hearing the sweet melodies, while being fanned by the *apsaras*. He was seated on a grand throne and was being worshipped by the leaders of the gods, who were also seated. He was with Shachi and his son, Jayanta, was on his lap. Thus, he obtained the greatest satisfaction. The great-souled lord of *brahmanas* saw the great Indra, the granter of boons and the refuge of the virtuous. Witnessing the prosperity of Indra’s kingdom, the Indra among sages was confused and deluded. Honoured by the large number of gods in the proper way, he returned to his own hermitage. He had seen Shakra’s city, extremely beautiful, adorned with jewels and complete with every kind of auspicious quality. In contrast, the brahmana saw that his own hermitage was bereft of gold and was depressed. Desiring to quickly obtain the kingdom of the gods, the great Atri’s son ⁸⁹¹ spoke to his beloved.

‘Atreya said, “Though the roots and fruits have been prepared well, they are not excellent and I am incapable of having them. I remember *amrita*, which is most auspicious, the various kinds of food that can be eaten, the excellent seats, the praise, the donations, the auspicious assembly-hall, the weapons, the garments, the city and the groves.” Through the powers of his austerities, the great-souled one invoked Tvashta and addressed him in these words. Atreya said, “O great-souled one! I wish to obtain Indra’s status. Quickly, please replicate Indra’s region here. If you say that you refuse to do what I have said, there is no doubt that I will reduce you to ashes.” The lord who created subjects, Vishvakarma,⁸⁹² swiftly acted in accordance with Atreya’s words. He constructed Meru, the city of the gods, *kalpadruma*, *kalpalata* and the cow.⁸⁹³ He fashioned houses that were adorned with diamonds and other things. They were wonderful and sparkled. He fashioned another Shachi, beautiful in all her limbs. She was like a chamber for love to find pleasure in. It was amazing. In an instant, he constructed the assembly-hall Sudharma and also charming *apsaras*. He created Uccaihsrava and the elephant,⁸⁹⁴ the *vajra* and other weapons and all the gods. Though his beloved tried to restrain him, Atri’s son made Shachi his bride. Along with the others, Atri being the foremost, Atri’s son fashioned weapons that were like the *vajra* and others. He devised singing and dancing, just as he had witnessed in Shakra’s city. On obtaining all these, the Indra among sages was content and happy in his mind. These objects are only apparently pleasurable. But in their presence, who can ignore them? Hearing about this, the *daityas*, *danavas* and *rakshasas* were filled with instant rage. “Why has Hari abandoned heaven and come to earth? It must be for happiness. Therefore, we will leave this place and go and fight with Vritra’s slayer. His sacrifice will not last long.” Just as they surrounded the gods, the *asuras* came and surrounded Atri’s son. They surrounded the city created by Atri’s son, known by the name of Indrapura. He was struck by the large shower of weapons. Scared, he spoke these words. Atreya said, “He was born first. The spirited god ornamented the gods with his sacrifices. Heaven and earth are raised up through Indra’s powers. He is the one who protects men.” After using this *sukta* to praise

Hari, Atri's son spoke to his enemies. Atri said, "I am not Hari. Shachi is not mine. This is not Indra's city. This is not Indra's grove. He is Indra, Vritra's slayer. He is the one with one thousand eyes, the wielder of *vajra*. He is the one who shatters mountains. He is the one who holds the *vajra* in his hand. I am a brahmana who knows the Vedas. I am surrounded by *brahmanas*. I reside on the banks of Goutami. Urged by evil destiny, I have committed an act that will not bring happiness, today or tomorrow." The *asuras* replied, "Withdraw these imitations of Indra. You will then truly obtain peace. There is no need to think about this." Atreya replied in these words. "O immensely fortunate ones! I will do what you have asked me to do. As proof of my pledge, I am touching the fire." Having told the *daityas* this, he again spoke to Tvashta. Atreya said, "O Tvashta! Out of affection towards me, you created this status of Indra. Please save a brahmana and take it back again. Give me back my own hermitage, with its animals and birds, trees and water, all that existed earlier. There is no need for anything divine. For learned people, anything that does not come naturally does not bring happiness." Agreeing to this, Tvashta, lord of subjects, withdrew everything. Making the place free of thorns, the *daityas* returned to their own regions. Tvashta also seemed to laugh, as he returned to his own abode. Surrounded by his disciples and along with his wife, Atreya withdrew and resorted to austerities along the banks of Goutami. While a great sacrifice was going on, ashamed, he spoke these words. Atreya said, "The strength of delusion is amazing and caused my mind to be in a whirl. What did the status of the great Indra get for me? Earlier, what did I do?" While the embarrassed Atreya was saying this, the gods arrived. The gods said, "O mighty-armed one! Give up this shame. You will have excellent fame. If a living being bathes in Atreya *tirtha*, he will easily obtain the status of being Indra. If he remembers it, he will obtain happiness." The learned say there are five thousand *tirthas* there. They are described under the names of Anvindra,⁸⁹⁵ Atreya and Daitya. Bathing and donating there, yield all the infinite merits. After saying this, the gods departed and the sage was satisfied.'

Chapter 2(71) (Confluence of Kapila)

Brahma said, ‘The tirtha known as the confluence of Kapila is famous in the three worlds. O Narada! Listen. I will tell you the sacred and excellent account. There was a sage named Kapila. He was immensely illustrious and knew the truth. He was devoted to the vow of austerities. Though he was cruel, he was also gracious. Resorting to the banks of Goutami, the best among sages performed austerities. Vamadeva and the others came to the great-souled one and spoke to him. Because of the curse of the *brahmanas*, Vena had been killed. Without a king, *dharma* was being destroyed. Kapila was an *acharya* who had obtained success. The large number of sages arrived and spoke to him. The large number of sages said, “The Vedas have left. *Dharma* has departed. O lord among sages! What should be done?” The sage Kapila meditated and then spoke to the sages who had arrived. Kapila said, “Vena’s thigh must be kneaded and something will happen.” The sages acted accordingly and kneaded Vena’s thigh. A being arose. He was extremely wicked and dark, terrible in his valour. On seeing him, the sages were scared and said, “Sit down.” He became Nishada and all the *nishadas* originated from him.⁸⁹⁶ In conformity with *dharma*, they kneaded Vena’s right arm. Prithu, whose voice was loud, originated.⁸⁹⁷ He was marked with all the auspicious signs. Prithu became a prosperous king. He possessed Brahma’s capacity. All the gods arrived. They congratulated him and bestowed auspicious boons on him. They gave him weapons with all the qualities and their *mantras*. Along with Kapila, the large number of sages spoke to Prithu. The sages said, “Provide food to living beings. The herbs have been swallowed by the earth.” The best among kings seized his bow and spoke to the earth. Prithu said, “For the welfare of subjects, give the herbs that have been swallowed by you.” Scared, the earth spoke to the

large-eyed Prithu. The earth said, “I have digested the great herbs. Please pardon me. How can I yield them up?” Full of rage, the king again addressed the earth. Prithu said, “If you do not give up the great herbs now, I will kill you and seize them.” The earth asked, “O king! How can you cause violence to a woman? O supreme among kings! Though you possess learning, how will you sustain these subjects without me?” Prithu replied, “There is no crime when one is destroyed for the sake of many. O earth! There is no sin and I will sustain the subjects through austerities. I do not see a sin. Nor are my words spoken in vain. When a single one’s destruction brings happiness to many, the sages say that this is superior to one hundred horse sacrifices.” At this, the gods and the *rishis* pacified the excellent king. The large number of gods spoke to the earth, the goddess who is the mother. The gods said, “O earth! Assume the form of a cow and let the great herbs assume the form of milk. Give them to King Prithu and the king will be pleased. The subjects will be saved through this and there will be welfare.” In Kapila’s presence, she assumed the form of a *kapila* cow.⁸⁹⁸ The king who originated from Vena’s arm milked the great herbs. O great sage! All the gods, the *gandharvas*, the *rishis* and the sage Kapila were present at the place where the earth assumed the form of a cow. Specifically, this was near Narmada, Bhagirathi, Sarasvati and Godavari and all the great rivers. The great milking took place. Milked by Prithu, the sacred waters became a river. This was extraordinary and it merged into Goutami. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as the confluence of Kapila.⁸⁹⁹ O immensely intelligent one! The large number of sages say that are eighty-eight thousand *tirthas* there, which deserve to be worshipped. O Narada! As soon as they are remembered, in the due order, they purify the universe.’

Chapter 2(72) (Devasthana)

Brahma said, ‘The *tirtha* known as Devasthana is famous in the three worlds. O Narada! I will describe its powers. Listen attentively. Earlier, at the beginning of *krita yuga*, there was a battle between the gods and the *danavas*. There was a beautiful *daitya* lady, known as Simhika. Her son was the great *daitya* known as Rahu. He was immensely strong. When *amrita* was generated, Simhika’s son was cut into two. His son was the great *daitya* known by the name of Meghahasa. Hearing that his father had been killed, he was extremely miserable and tormented himself through austerities. Rahu’s son resorted to the banks of Goutami and performed austerities. All the gods and *rishis* were scared and spoke to him. The gods and *rishis* said, “O mighty-armed one! Give up these austerities. Through the favours of Shiva and Ganga, everything that there is in your mind will come true. Through the favours of Shiva and Ganga, there is nothing that is impossible to obtain.” Meghahasa replied, “My father is my divinity and deserve to be worshipped. He has been overcome by you. If you do something that pleases him and me exceedingly, I will refrain from these austerities and my enmity towards you. The task of a son who loves his father is to harass the enemy. Therefore, I ask all of you to fulfil my wishes.” At this, the large number of gods made Rahu an entity who would follow the planets. They made Meghahasa a person who would be worshipped by the *rakshasas*. Thus, Rahu’s son became a lord and a ruler of *nairritas*.⁹⁰⁰ The *daitya* again spoke to the gods. “It is my view that the powers of this *tirtha* should be given to me, so that my fame lasts.” The gods agreed and granted him everything that was in his mind. O *devarshi*! That *tirtha* is described as being named after that lord of *daityas*. O immensely intelligent one! That is the place where all the gods were

present. Therefore, that *tirtha* is Devasthana, ⁹⁰¹ a place that is extremely difficult for even the gods to reach. The place is known as Deva *tirtha* and the divinity there is Deveshvara. O Narada! There are eighteen *tirthas* there, worshipped by the *daityas*. Bathing and donating there destroy great sins.’

Chapter 2(73) (Siddha *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘Siddheshvara Hara is present in the place famous as Siddha *tirtha*. I will describe its powers. It bestows every kind of success on men. Ravana, who made the world shriek, was born in Pulastya’s lineage.⁹⁰² He conquered all the directions and went to Soma’s world. When the one with the ten heads was about to fight with Soma, I spoke to him. “O Dashanana! Please withdraw from this fight with Soma. I will give you a *mantra*.” O Narada! Having said this, to pacify the Indra among the *rakshasas*, I gave him the one hundred and eight names of Shiva. In this *samsara*, for men who are without prosperity and are distressed, for those who suffer from many kinds of hardship, there is no refuge other than Shiva. With his ministers, the *rakshasa* withdrew from the attempt to conquer Soma’s world. Astride Pushpaka and swift in his speed and full of pride, the one with ten heads travelled around the worlds. He saw heaven, the firmament, the earth, *nagas*, elephants and *brahmanas*. He then saw the great mountain, Kailasa, the abode of Uma’s consort. On seeing this, Ravana was delighted in his mind. The persevering one approached and spoke. Ravana asked, “Which great-souled one resides on this mountain? I will uproot this mountain from the ground and take it away. Swiftly taken to Lanka, the mountain will become beautiful. Truly, Lanka will also become prosperous.” Hearing the words spoken by the lord of the *rakshasas* and understanding his sentiments, the *rakshasa*’s ministers, clever in their intelligence, said, “That won’t be appropriate.” However, the roamer in the night didn’t listen to their words. The *rakshasa* quickly set Pushpaka down and jumped onto the base of Mount Kailasa. The one with ten heads shook the mountain. Bhava got to know what he was doing. Having defeated the lords of the directions, the enemy of the gods became extremely insolent

and was shaking Kailasa. He pressed down with his toe and Dashanana was sent down to the world of Rasatala. He suffered and screamed. Hearing this, along with the goddess, he ⁹⁰³ laughed and gave him what he wished. Though he was angry, Shambhu was also pleased. There is no doubt that through Bhava's favours, even undeserving and brave people obtain excellent boons. As he proceeded to Lanka, for the sake of worshipping Bhava, he went to Ganga, who flows out of Shambhu's matted hair. Not depressed in spirit, he used many kinds of *mantras* and water from Ganga to worship Shambhu. He obtained a sword that was marked with the sign of the crescent moon, every kind of *siddhi* and all that is wished for. To save the moon, I had given him a *mantra* and he used this to successfully worship Bhava. Using this *mantra*, the lord of the *rakshasas* obtained success. Satisfied, he returned to Lanka. Since then, this extremely powerful *tirtha* has bestowed all the great *siddhis* and everything desired. It destroys all the floods of sins and is frequented by all the *siddhas*.'

Chapter 2(74) (Confluence of Parushni)

Brahma said, ‘The *tirtha* known as the confluence of Parushni is famous in the three worlds. It destroys every kind of sin. I will describe its nature. Atri worshipped Brahma, Vishnu and Maheshvara. When they were pleased, he said, “The three of you should be my sons. O divinities! Let a beautiful daughter also be born to me.” Thus, he got Brahma, Vishnu and Maheshvara as his sons. An auspicious daughter named Atreyi was also born. The great-souled one’s sons were Datta,⁹⁰⁴ Soma and Durvasa. Along with burning charcoal, Angiras was born through Agni. That is the reason he was known as Angiras.⁹⁰⁵ Atri bestowed the radiant Atreyi on him. Because of Agni’s powers, he always addressed Atreyi in harsh words. However, Atreyi always tended to him. Through her, extremely song and powerful sons were born to Angiras. Though Angiras always addressed Atreyi in harsh words, the sons, the Angirases, always pacified their father. On one occasion, because of her husband’s harsh tone and words, she was extremely miserable. Dejected, she joined her hands in salutation and spoke to her senior, her father-in-law. Atreyi said, “O bearer of oblations! I am Atri’s daughter. I am your son’s wife. I always serve my husband and my sons. My husband addresses me in harsh words. Without any reason, he looks at him angrily. O best among the gods! Please instruct me. My husband is my divinity.” The fire replied, “Your husband, *rishi* Angiras, has originated from burning charcoal. O fortunate one! So that he remains pacified, some policy must be thought of. O one with the beautiful face! Let your fiery husband approach Agni. Obeying my instructions, you must flow in the form of water.” Atreyi said, “I will tolerate harsh words. Let my husband not enter the fire. If women act against their husbands, what is the point of their remaining alive? I desire amiable words and I also want my

husband.” The fire replied, “Agni is present in water, in bodies and in mobile and immobile objects. I am always your husband’s refuge. I am thought of as his father. I am what I am. Knowing this, you should not worry. The waters are divine mothers and Agni is your father-in-law. O daughter-in-law! Use your intelligence to comprehend this and do not be miserable.” Atreyi said, “You said that the waters are mothers. O Agni! I am your son’s wife. O protector! Since I am his wife, how can I act in a perverse way, assuming the form of water and becoming his mother?” The fire replied, “At first, you were a *patni*. Then, for sustaining, you became a *bharya*. To give birth, you became *jaya*. Through your own qualities, you became *kalatra*.⁹⁰⁶ O fortunate one! You were radiant in all these different forms. Therefore, act in accordance with my words. If he is born through her, he becomes a son. Therefore, there is no doubt that you become his mother. Hence, those who know the truth about the sacred texts say that once a son has been born, you are no longer a *yoshit*.” Hearing the words spoken by her father-in-law, Atreyi acted accordingly. Her husband was in the form of fire and she flooded him in the form of water. O brahmana! The couple merged into the waters of Ganga. Thereby, the couple assumed a peaceful form. It was like Lakshmi being united with Vishnu, Uma being united with Shiva and Rohini being united with the moon. The couple resembled that. To flood her husband, she assumed a form made out of water. This river is famous as Parushni and it merged into Ganga. Bathing in Parushni yields the benefits that are obtained from donating one hundred cows. The Angirasas performed sacrifices there and donated a lot of *dakshina*. O son! Those who know about the ancient accounts say that there are three thousand *tirthas* there, on both banks of the river. Sacrifices performed there are known to yield separate fruits. It is held that bathing and donating there, yield benefits superior to those obtained from a *vajapeya* sacrifice. This is particularly true of the place where there is a confluence of Parushni with Ganga. It is impossible to describe the merits obtained from bathing and donating there.’

Chapter 2(75) (Markandeya *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Markandeya *tirtha* frees from sins. It yields the fruits of every kind of sacrifice and is auspicious. It counters sins. I will describe its powers. O Narada! Listen attentively. O Narada! Markandeya, Bharadvaja, Vasishtha, Atri, Goutama, Yajnavalkya, Jabali and other sages are those who composed sacred texts. They were accomplished in the Vedas and *Vedangas*. They knew about Puranas, *nyaya*, *mimasa* and other accounts. Depending on their intelligence, they conversed with each other about emancipation. Some praised *jnana*, some praised *karma* and some praised both. Debating in this way, they asked me about my views on these two paths. Ascertaining my views, they went to the one who holds the *chakra* and the mace. Ascertaining his views, those immensely energetic *rishis* again debated amongst themselves and sought to ask Shankara. To that end, along the banks of Ganga, they worshipped Bhava and asked him. The destroyer of Tripura replied, “*Karma* is most important. *Jnana* adopts the form of rites.” This is what he said. “All living beings obtain success only through *karma*. *Karma* pervades the universe. There is nothing else. The practice of learning, the performance of sacrifices, the practice of *yoga* and the worship of Shiva—all this is *karma*. Nowhere does a living being exist without *karma*. Thus, *karma* is the cause. Everything else is the utterance of a mad person.” There is a place where the debate between the *rishis* took place and where the divinity Maheshvara arrived at the determination that men obtain everything through *karma*. Since Markandeya was the chief, that place is known as Markandeya. On the northern banks of Ganga, that *tirtha* is full of a large number of *rishis*. It purifies the ancestors. Even when it is remembered, it always yields good merits. O son! The one who pervades the universe said that there are ninety

eight *tirthas* there. This has been spoken about in the Vedas and the *rishis* accepted this.'

Chapter 2(76) (Kalanjara *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The next *tirtha* is named after Yayati and Kalanjara Shiva is there. It destroys every kind of sin. I will describe its greatness. King Yayati, the son of Nahusha, was like another Indra himself. He had two wives. Both were from noble lineages and possessed the auspicious signs. The elder was Shukra’s auspicious daughter, named Devayani. The second was Sharmishtha and she was Vrishaparva’s daughter. Although born from a brahmana lineage, the slender-waisted Devayani was immensely wise. Through Shukra’s favours, she became Yayati’s wife. Sharmishtha, Vrishvaparva’s daughter, was also his wife. Devayani, Shukra’s daughter, had two sons. They were Yadu and Turvasu and they were like the sons of the gods. Through Sharmishtha, the king obtained three sons who were like gods. King Yayati’s excellent sons were Druhyu, Anu and Puru. O brahmana! Devayani’s two sons were like Shukra in form. Sharmishtha’s sons had the resplendence of Shakra, Agni and Varuna.’

‘On one occasion, miserable, Devayani spoke to her father. Devayani said, “O descendant of the Bhrigu lineage! I am unfortunate. I only have two sons. O father! My servant-maid has good fortune. She possesses three sons. Thinking about this, I am suffering from great grief. O preceptor of *danavas*! Because Yayati has acted disagreeably, I will die. O father! For a spirited person, death is superior to being dishonoured.” Hearing his daughter’s words, the powerful Shukra became angry. He quickly went to Yayati and spoke to him. Shukra said, “O Indra among kings! You are intoxicated because of your beauty. Therefore, you have acted in this disagreeable and have neglected my daughter. You will immediately become old. You will hanker after material objects. But you won’t be able to enjoy them. Nor will you be able to give them up. With your intelligence

confounded, you will desire them and sigh. Even if an embodied being remains alive, old age is like death. O lord of the earth! Therefore, quickly leave. You will find old age impossible to bear.” The intelligent Yayati heard the curse imposed on him by Shukra. King Yayati joined his hands in salutation and spoke to Shukra. Yayati replied, “I have not committed a crime. I have not been angry. I have not committed an act of *adharma*. Great-souled ones punish sinners, those who have committed acts of *adharma*. I follow *dharma*. Why have you cursed me? O best among *brahmanas*! Devayani has unnecessarily said something about me. O Indra among *brahmanas*! It is not appropriate for you to curse me like this. If learned people are confounded and curse the innocent in their rage, there is no sin when the minds of the foolish are heated by the fire of hatred.” Hearing Yayati’s words, Shukra remembered what she had done, how she had done evil and disagreeable things and how she was fierce, day and night. Kavya ⁹⁰⁷ told the king, “My rage has gone.” Shukra said, “Knowingly or unknowingly, I never intentionally utter a falsehood. O king! Listen. I will convert this curse into a favour. O one who bestows honours! O king! Whichever son you wish to give this old age to, through my favour, this old age will pass on to that son.” Yayati again humbly spoke to this father-in-law, Shukra. Yayati said, “O *guru* of the *daityas*! Please let it be such that whichever of my sons faithfully accepts the old age given by me, will be the king. O *guru*! If any of my sons does not welcome my words, I seek your permission to firmly curse him. O *guru*! Let this be granted.” The descendant of the Bhrigu lineage told the king that it would be that way.’

‘Yayati summoned his son and addressed him in these words. Yayati said, “O Yadu! You are my son. Accept the old age that the curse has inflicted on me. You are the oldest and mature. You know the purport of everything and amongst my sons, you are the one who can bear the burden. A father truly has a son when the son follows the instructions of the father.” Yadu refused his father Yayati, who used to give away a lot of *dakshina*. Thereupon, Yayati cursed Yadu and told Turvasu what he desired. Turvasu also refused to accept the old age given by his father. He cursed him and told Druhyu,

“Accept my old age.” Druhyu did not wish to accept the old age that would be given, destroying his beauty. The king told Anu, “Accept my old age.” When Anu refused, he cursed him and spoke to Puru. Puru welcomed the idea and accepted his father’s old age for one thousand years. The father was delighted. There are many kinds of objects of pleasure that can be enjoyed in youth. Satisfied with his son’s youth, Yayati happily enjoyed these. The king, Nahusha’s son, was satisfied with all these objects of pleasure. Happy, he summoned his son, Puru, and spoke to him. Yayati said, “O unblemished one! Through your youth, I have satisfied myself with all the objects of pleasure. O son! Take back your youth and return the evil old age back to me.” Puru refused and said, “O father! For those with bodies, thoughts of aberrations are extremely difficult to counter. But I have used old age to extinguish them. For all those with bodies, the strength of old age that comes prematurely can be used to counter them. Since I have accepted this benefit from my senior, how can I cast it aside? For all those with bodies, death is superior to giving up something that has been accepted. O king! Or, I will austerities to destroy this old age.” Telling his father this, he went to the supreme Ganga. On Goutami’s southern bank, he tormented himself through great austerities. After a long period of time, the divinity Shiva was pleased. Puru was ornamented in the jewel of pervasive qualities, superior to any in this world. The supreme god asked him, “What will I give you?” Puru replied, “O protector! O lord of the gods! My father obtained this old age through a curse. O lord of the gods! Please destroy this. O one worshipped by the gods! Angry, my father cursed my brothers. Please free them from their curses.” The lord of the universe agreed and destroyed the old age that had resulted from the curse. The lord of the universe also freed his brothers from their curses. Since then, that *tirtha* has destroyed old age and ailments. Even if one remembers it, untimely old age and other things are destroyed. Therefore, it is famous under the name of Kalanjara.⁹⁰⁸ It is also named after Yayati, Nahusha’s son, Shukra and Sharmishtha. O immensely intelligent one! There are another one hundred and eight *tirthas* there and they yield every kind of success. Bathing and donating there, or

reading and hearing about them, destroy all sins and bestow objects of pleasure and emancipation.'

Chapter 2(77) (The pair of *apsaras*)

Brahma said, ‘I will tell you about the pair of *apsaras* and the confluence of the *apsaras*. This auspicious place is on the southern bank. Even if one remembers it, one obtains good fortune. If a man undertakes bathing and other rites there, there is no doubt that he is emancipated. O Narada! If a faithful woman bathes there after her period, she will give birth to a son. For three months, along with her husband, if she bathes and donates there, she will give birth to a son, even if she happens to be barren. My words are always true. This *tirtha* is famous after the pair of *apsaras*. I will tell you about the reason for this. O Narada! Listen attentively. O brahmana! There was great rivalry between Vishvamitra and Vasishtha. For the sake of becoming a brahmana, Gadhi’s son ⁹⁰⁹ was controlled in his vows and tormented himself through austerities. He was seated in Gangadvarya. Indra sent Menaka. “O fortunate one! Follow my instructions. Go and make him deviate from his austerities.” Addressed by Indra, Menaka ⁹¹⁰ went and made Vishvamitra deviate from his austerities. She gave him the daughter she delivered and returned to Indra’s city. When she left, Gadhi’s son remembered everything that he had done. He gave up that region and *tirtha*, loved by the gods. He went south to Ganga where Kalanjara Hara is. Indra, the one with one thousand eyes, asked Urvashi, Mena, Rambha and Tilottama to bring an end to his austerities. But scared, they refused. Thereupon, Shachi’s consort asked Gambhira and Atigambhira, both of whom were extremely proud. They replied to the thousand-eyed god, Purandara. Gambhira and Atigambhira said, “We will go and end the austerities of Gadhi’s immensely radiant son. We will use our dancing, singing, beauty, youth and charms. We will use our sidelong glances, smiles, words and enticement. The one with the five arrows ⁹¹¹ always

resides with us. Who cannot be defeated?” When the one with one thousand eyes agreed, they went to the great river. They saw the great sage, Vishvamitra, engaged in austerities. He was like Death, impossible to assail. He was like Dhurjati ⁹¹² on earth. For one thousand and one years, they were incapable of glancing at him. They remained some distance away, singing, dancing and praising him. On seeing them, the tiger among sages was filled with rage. When a contrary act is witnessed, who does not become angry? Free from desire, the mighty-armed one seemed to laugh when he spoke to the one with one thousand eyes. “O one with one thousand eyes! I have been freed from all this.” Gadhi’s son then spoke to the two *apsaras* and cursed them. “Assume the form of rivers. You tried to melt me. Therefore, assume this light form.” When they pacified him, he freed them from the curse. “When you merge with Ganga, you will regain your divine forms.” As a result of the curse, they instantly assumed the forms of rivers. Those two rivers are famous as a pair of *apsaras*. Their mutual confluence and their confluence with Ganga is famous in all the worlds. Shiva is present there. He is the one who bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation. When he is seen, every kind of success is obtained. If one bathes there and sees him, one is freed from every kind of bondage.’

Chapter 2(78) (Kanva *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Koti *tirtha* is on the southern banks of Ganga. As soon as one remembers it, one is freed from every kind of sin. The divinity Kotishvara is there and the place possesses all the one crore qualities. There are a total of two crore *tirthas* there and they bestow all that is auspicious. O Narada! I will describe its greatness. Listen with an attentive mind. Kanva’s eldest son was known by the name of Bahlika. People addressed him as Kaanva ⁹¹³ and he was accomplished in the Vedas and the *Vedangas*. On the banks of Goutami, along with his wife, the one who knew about the Vedas and was worshipped by the worlds, performed *parvayana* ⁹¹⁴ and other sacrifices. In the morning, along with his wife, he always offered oblations into the fire. On one occasion, he was about to offer the oblations. He offered one round of oblations into the fire that had been kindled. Ready to offer another round of oblations, he took up the oblations in his hand. Meanwhile, the fire was pacified. Kaanva became full of thoughts. Debating this internally, he became greatly despondent. “What should be done? In between the two rounds of oblations, the fire has become pacified. Should one use another fire? What do the Vedas say? What is customary practice? Where should one offer the second round of oblations?” While he was trying to decide this, a divine and invisible voice spoke. “O lord of *brahmanas*! There is no need to arrange for another fire. Here or nearby, there may still be some sparks left. Offer the oblations into the half-burnt wood.” Kaanva refused. The voice spoke again. “Agni’s son is gold. ⁹¹⁵ The father is like the sun. What is given to bring pleasure to the son also brings pleasure to the father. When something that should be given to the father is given to the son, the qualities and pleasure that result are one crore times more.” When the divine voice said this, all the *maharshis*

decided that this was all there was to *dharma* and acted accordingly. They understood that in this world, what is given to the son is also given to the father. If something is given to the offspring, there is nothing else that pleases the father more. This is famous in the world. This is extremely well-known in the world and is honoured in all the worlds. O son! When something is given in this way, the qualities become one crore times more. Mental dejection goes away and great happiness results. The voice spoke again. “O sage! This Kaanva *tirtha* will become excellent. Because of the auspicious powers of Kaanva, it will be a great *tirtha*. In all the three worlds, no other *tirtha* will bestow such great fruits. If a person controls himself and faithfully undertakes bathing, donating and some other rites there, he will obtain all the fruits that are one crore times more in qualities. If a man undertakes anything here, bathing, donations and other rites—it should be known that the qualities will be one crore times more. Hence, it will be known as Koti *tirtha*.” The place where all this occurred is also known as Agni *tirtha*, Kaanva *tirtha*, Poutra *tirtha*, Hiranyaka *tirtha* and Vanisamjna *tirtha*. It is known as Koti *tirtha* because the fruits are one crore times more. Vachaspati and the other gods are incapable of describing the greatness of Koti *tirtha*. If any rite is undertaken there, regardless of how it is performed, because of Godavari’s favours, the qualities become one crore times more. If one gives an excellent brahmana a single cow in Koti *tirtha*, because of the *tirtha*’s greatness, the fruits obtained are identical to the fruits obtained from donating one crore cows. If one purifies oneself and with devotion in the mind, donates land there, the benefits obtained are one crore times more. Everywhere along the Godavari, donations in the name of the ancestors are excellent. In particular, in Koti *tirtha*, the fruits obtained are infinite. The sages say that there are forty-nine *tirthas* there.’

Chapter 2(79) (Narasimha *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place named after Narasimha is on Ganga’s northern bank. I will describe its greatness. It is capable of protecting against all impediments. Earlier, there was Hiranyakashipu and he was supreme among strong ones. Because of his austerities and valour, he could not be defeated, not even by the gods. His mind was polluted and he hated his own son,⁹¹⁶ who was devoted to Hari. The one whose *atman* is in the universe appeared from within a pillar and showed himself. Narasimha killed him and drove away his soldiers. One by one, the immensely energetic and great animal defeated all the great *daityas*. Having defeated the enemies in Rasatala, he went to the world of heaven. Having defeated the ones who were there, he went to the earth and killed the *daityas* who were in the mountains. There were other *daityas* in many other forms, residing in oceans, villages and forests. In the form of the animal, he slew them. He killed those who were in the sky and in the air, those who had gone to the worlds of the stellar bodies. He shook his large mane. His nails were more forceful than the strike of the *vajra*. His roar caused all the *daitya* women to miscarry. He defeated all the *rakshasas*. He roared and when he looked around, his glances were like the fire of destruction. With blows from his paws, he plucked out the entrails of other *asuras* and crushed them. In this way, after having killed many, Hari went to Goutami. She had emerged from his own lotus feet and brought delight to the mind and to the eyes. The enemy of the lord of Dandaka was there, known as Ambarya. In a battle, even the gods found him impossible to defeat. He was surrounded by a large army. There was an extremely terrible and fierce battle between them⁹¹⁷ and it made the body hair stand up. In the battle between Hari and the son of the *daitya*, *astras* and *shastras* were showered down. The prosperous Hari killed the

enemy on the northern bank. Along the Ganga, Narasimha *tirtha* is famous in the three worlds. Bathing, donating and other rites performed there, destroy every kind of sin and evil planet. It always protects against everything. It counters old age and death. Among all the gods, there is no one who is Hari's equal. Like that, among all the *tirthas*, this *tirtha* is the best. If a man bathes in this *tirtha* and worships Narasimha, there is nothing from heaven, the mortal world and the nether regions that he cannot obtain. O Narada! O sage! There are eight such great *tirthas* there. Learned people have separately spoken about the fruits of crores of *tirthas*. Even if one lacks faith and remembers them, all impediments are destroyed. Narasimha himself is always present there. Hence, who is capable of describing the fruits of frequenting such a *tirtha*? Just as there is no god who is superior to Hari, there is no *tirtha* which is the equal of Narasimha *tirtha*.'

Chapter 2(80) (Paishacha *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Paishacha *tirtha* is on the northern banks of Ganga. O immensely wise one! This is the place where a brahmana was freed from his state as a *pishacha*. Suyava’s son was known in this world as Ajigarti. ⁹¹⁸ He suffered from the burden of supporting his family. He also suffered from famine. The son in the middle was Shunahshepa and he was supreme among those who knew about the *brahman*. In exchange for a great deal of riches, he sold him to a *kshatriya* to be sacrificed. Even if a person is learned, when he faces a calamity, what sin is he incapable of committing? The sage also accepted a great deal of riches to be the slaughterer. The worst among *brahmanas* accepted wealth for cutting him up. As a result, he suffered from a great disease, for which, there was no cure. In the course of time, he died and descended into hell. The many kinds of violence a person has committed cannot be exhausted without enjoying the fruits. Following Yama’s commands, his servants moved him from one womb to another womb. He thus became a terrible *pishacha*, terrible in form. Yama’s servants flung him into places littered with dry wood, forests, places without water, desolate regions and forest conflagrations during the summer. Until all beings are destroyed in the deluge, those who sell their daughters, sons, land, horses and cows, do not return from hell. As a result of the sin he had himself committed, Yama’s terrible servants struck him and cooked him. Remembering what he had done, he wept loudly.’

‘On one occasion, as he was proceeding along the road, Ajigarti’s ⁹¹⁹ middle son heard the voice of a *pishacha* lamenting repeatedly. O brahmana! This was the voice of his father, Ajigarti, who had sold his son for a sacrifice. “I am a wicked brahmana who has sold his son. I am the

father who has killed him.” Shunahshepa responded, “You are extremely miserable. Who are you?” The miserable Ajigarti said, “I am Shunahshepa’s father. Having committed a wicked deed, I have been born as this terrible species. Having been cooked repeatedly in hell, I am now in this midway state. This is the destination obtained by all those who commit wicked deeds.” Full of sadness, Ajigarti’s son told him, “O father! I am your son. You sold me because of my sin and went to hell. I will now ensure that you go to heaven.” Having said this, the excellent sage, who had become the son of Gadhi’s son, ⁹²⁰ went to Ganga, desiring to obtain excellent worlds for his father. There are those who suffer and are purified by the fire of a large number of miseries and are submerged in the great ocean of delusion. For such embodied beings, there is no support in the three worlds other than Vishnu’s feet. The great-souled sage made up his mind to free his father from the hardship. Therefore, he quickly went to Goutami and bathing there, purified himself. He remembered Shambhu and Vishnu. He performed water-rites for his dead father, who was extremely miserable in the form of a *pishacha*. As soon as he did this, Ajigarti was purified and assumed an extremely auspicious form. Through the powers of his son and the powers of Ganga, Hari and Shambhu, he obtained Vishnu’s feet, worshipped by large numbers of gods, astride a *vimana*. His energy was like that of the creator. Since then, that place became extremely famous as a place where *pishachas* are destroyed. Even if men remember it, extremely grave sins are quickly destroyed. I have described the greatness of that *tirtha*. There are another three hundred *tirthas* there. They bestow objects of pleasure and emancipation, not to speak of other things. These three hundred *tirthas* have been described as those which bestow every kind of success. They are frequented by sages. Even when they are remembered, they grant what is desired.’

Chapter 2(81) (Nimnabheda)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Nimnabheda destroys every kind of sin. This *tirtha*, on the northern bank of Ganga, is famous in the three worlds. Even if one remembers it, all sins are destroyed. Vedadvipa is also there. If one sees it, one becomes learned in the Vedas. King Aila,⁹²¹ extremely devoted to *dharma*, desired Urvashi. When one sees the one with intoxicating eyes, who is not deluded? She came to him and only ate a little bit of *ghee*. The king also accepted her condition that she would remain with him for only as long as she didn’t see him naked. She was a beautiful woman and always seemed newer than the newest. When she was sleeping on the bed, Pururava got up. On seeing that he was without any clothes, she instantly left. The minds of women are as fickle as the lightning. Who can steady them?’⁹²²

‘Meanwhile, the king went out to fight with the enemy. Having defeated them, he again⁹²³ went to the world of the gods, where he was greatly honoured. Returning from there, the great king heard from the priest Vasishtha that Urvashi had left. He was filled with grief. He did not offer oblations. He did not eat. He did not hear. He did not see. The excellent king almost reached a state of death. Meanwhile, the priest used words full of reason to make him understand. Vasishtha said, “O great king! O immensely intelligent one! She is dead now. Do not grieve. If you remain in this state, inauspicious arrows will touch you.”⁹²⁴ O immensely wise one! No one knows what is in the minds of women. They are like wolves and jackals. O lord of the earth! Therefore, do not grieve. O Indra among kings! In this world, who has not been deceived by women? They are deceitful. They are cruel. They are fickle. They are evil in conduct. Since they are naturally like that, how can they lead to happiness? Who has not been slain

by time? Which supplicant has been honoured? Whose prosperity has not been whirled around? Who has not been betrayed by women? O king! They are like dreams and *maya*. Their hearts are full of pride. Who has obtained happiness through women? Knowing this, steady yourself. O immensely intelligent one! With the exception of Shankara, Vishnu and Goutami, the miserable have no other refuge in the three worlds.” Hearing this, the king made a great deal of effort and controlled his grief. He stood in the middle of Goutami. Extremely devoted to *dharma*, Aila attentively worshipped the divinity Shiva, Janardana, Brahma, Bhaskara, Ganga and the other gods there. When a living being comes under the subjugation of destiny, faces a calamity and does not serve *tirthas* or the gods, what state will he be reduced to? He sought Ishvara as his only refuge and was keen to serve Goutami. Full of great faith, he turned away from the state of *samsara*. With officiating priests, he performed many sacrifices and gave away copious quantities of *dakshina*. That place came to be known as Vedadvipa and Yajnavipa.⁹²⁵ On the night of the full moon, Urvashi always goes there. If a man performs *pradakshina* of that *dvipa*, it is as if he performs *pradakshina* of the earth, girdled by the ocean. If a person remembers the *Vedas* there, or remembers sacrifices there, he obtains fruits that are the same as the fruits of a sacrifice performed in conformity with the *Vedas*. It is also known as Aila *tirtha*, Pururava *tirtha* and Vasishtha *tirtha*. It is spoken of as Nimnabheda. When Aila was the king, there was nothing inferior in any of the rites. He did have inferior sentiments regarding Urvashi. However, because of Vasishtha and Ganga, those inferior sentiments were dissipated.⁹²⁶ Hence, it became Nimnabheda and it brings success in everything that is seen and not seen. It is said that there are seven hundred *tirthas* there, possessing all the qualities. Bathing and donating there, yield the fruits of all sacrifices. If a person bathes in Nimnabheda and sees the gods, in this world and in the next world, there is nothing inferior for him. Having obtained every kind of upliftment, like Shakra, he rejoices in heaven.’

Chapter 2(82) (Nanditata)

Brahma said, ‘There is a *tirtha* famous as Nanditata. Those who know the Vedas know about it. I will describe its powers. O Narada! Listen attentively. Atri had an extremely energetic son, known as Chandrama.⁹²⁷ O immensely intelligent one. In the proper way, he learnt all the Vedas, *dhanurveda* and all the other kinds of knowledge from Jiva.⁹²⁸ Chandrama told Jiva, “I will worship my *guru*.” Brihaspati was delighted and spoke to his disciple, Chandra. Brihaspati said, “You know that my beloved is Tara. Her radiance is like Rati’s.”⁹²⁹ Chandrama went inside the house to ask her.⁹³⁰ Tara’s face was like a star. Seeing her, he grasped her by the hand. Greedy, he forcibly dragged her towards his own house. As long as he is not bound in the snares of a beautiful lady’s eyes, a man possesses valour, intellect, learning and intelligence and manages to conquer his senses. This is especially the case if one sees a large-eyed and beautiful lady in private. Therefore, a lady from a noble lineage must never see another man in private. If one sees him, whose mind does not come under the subjugation of desire? The lady must be scared that her good conduct is not tainted. Brihaspati, extensive in his intelligence, got to know about this from his relatives. He suddenly arose and left. He went and witnessed the wicked deeds. Condemning that disagreeable deed in eloquent words, he angrily cursed. Witnessing his beloved being molested, which lord can tolerate it? Assisted by the gods, Jiva fought with Chandrama. But Chandra was not affected by the curse or by the weapons invoked with *mantras*, unleashed by the gods. The *mantras* used by Brihaspati did not harm the moon-god. Thus, Chandra took Tara and instated her in his house. Without any fear, he enjoyed her and Rohini⁹³¹ for many years. The rage of the gods could not defeat him, nor could the curse and the *mantras*. The kings or the *rishis*

couldn't do anything. *Sama*, *bheda* and *danda* served no purpose. Though he tried every possible means, the *guru* could not get his wife back. When all the means were exhausted, Jiva remembered his own policy. ⁹³² “A wise person must place honour behind him and place dishonour at the forefront. That is the way to enhance one's self-interest. Diminishing the self-interest is folly. Learned men must use every means possible to accomplish the objective. Those deluded by false pride quickly bring about a calamity.” Having decided this, the intelligent one went to Shukra and told him everything. ⁹³³ Knowing that he had come, Kavi ⁹³⁴ respectfully welcomed him. When he was seated and rested, he followed the norms and worshipped him. The *guru* of the *daityas* asked him about the reason for his arrival. Those who are superior do not refuse even enemies, when they come to their houses.’

‘Starting at the beginning, he told him about the abduction of his wife. Hearing Brihaspati's words, Kavi was filled with rage. O Narada! He agreed that the disciple, Chandra, had committed a crime. Hearing about his transgression, Kavi spoke in anger. Shukra said, “O lord of the planets! O brother! Your wife has been molested by another person. O mighty-armed one! Listen to my words. I will eat only after I have brought your wife back, worshipped Bhava and cursed Chandra.” Saying this, the preceptor of the *daityas* left, along with Jiva. He worshipped Shiva with great care and obtained supreme capability. He worshipped Shankara with deep sentiments and obtained many boons. Through Shiva's favours, what is difficult for an embodied being to obtain? Along with Jiva, Shukra went to the place where Chandrama was, with Tara. He cursed loudly. “O Chandra! Listen to my words. O sinner! Intoxicated by insolence, you have committed an extremely grave sin. You will be overcome by leprosy.” Kavi angrily cursed Chandra. He was burnt down by Kavi's curse. What kind of destruction is not faced by those who deceive and betray their *guru*, their master, or their friend? Chandra gave up Tara and Shukra took her away.’

‘Shukra summoned the gods, the *rishis*, the large numbers of ancestors, the female rivers, the male rivers, many kinds of herbs and women who were faithful to their husbands. He told them about the Tara episode and asked

them how one could be freed. ⁹³⁵ The *shruti* texts told the gods, “Along with Jiva, let Tara go to Goutami and devotedly bathe there. She will then be purified.” This is a deep secret and must never be spoken about to anyone. In every kind of hardship, Goutami is the only refuge for men. As is done, Tara bathed there, along with her husband. Flowers were showered down and there were exclamations of “Victory”. The gods bestowed her again. ⁹³⁶ Men bestowed her again. Kings, truthful in deeds, bestowed the wife on the brahmana. Having bestowed the wife on the brahmana again, the gods cleansed her of the taint. O great sage! Everything was well in that *tirtha*. It became a place that destroys all sins and grants everything that is desired. There was peace and happiness among the gods, the enemies of the *asuras*. In particular, Brihaspati, Shukra and Tara were filled with great joy. The *guru* ⁹³⁷ spoke to Ganga. The *guru* said, “O Goutami! You will always deserve to be worshipped by everyone. You will bestow emancipation. O one who purifies the three worlds! O best among rivers! In particular, when I am in Simha, ⁹³⁸ all the *tirthas* will assemble within you and all the *tirthas* in heaven, the mortal world and the nether regions will go to you to bathe there. O mother! They will go there when I am in Simha.” This *tirtha*, named Ananda, ⁹³⁹ is blessed. It enhances fame, a long lifespan, freedom from disease and prosperity. It generates good fortune and wealth. Goutama said that there are five thousand *tirthas* there. If one remembers them, or reads about them, one obtains all that one desires. Shiva’s Nandi is always there, along the banks of Ganga, performing rites of *dharma*. Therefore, it is spoken of as Nanditata. ⁹⁴⁰ The *tirtha* known as Ananda enhances every kind of happiness.’

Chapter 2(83) (Bhava *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘Bhava is himself present in the place known as Bhava *tirtha*. He is in the *atman* of all beings and the entire universe is in him. He is the form of truth and consciousness. In this connection, I will relate a sacred and auspicious account. Listen. There was a prosperous person who extended *surya vamsha*. He could bear the burden of *kshatriyas*. He was known as Prachinabarhi and he was accomplished in every kind of *dharma*. He was instated in the kingdom for three and a half crore years. He had taken a pledge. “When I lose my youth, when I am separated from my wife, my sons and my cherished objects, I will give up my kingdom. There is no doubt about this.” This is appropriate action for discriminating men who are born in noble lineages. When everything decays, they become non-attached and remain in solitude. However, while he ruled the earth, there was no separation from anything he loved. There were no physical or mental ailments. There was no famine. Among men, there were no conflicts between relatives. He ruled the kingdom in this way and there was no separation. For the sake of a son, the immensely intelligent king performed a sacrifice. The illustrious one, the divinity Maheshvara, was pleased and granted him the boon he desired. The king was on the banks of Goutami. Along with his wife, the king told Bhava, “Please grant me a son.” Delighted, Bhava told the king, “Look at my third eye.” O one who bestows honours! The Indra among kings looked at Bhava’s eye. A son was born from the resplendence in the eye and he was known by the name of Mahiman. It was he who composed the auspicious hymn famous as Mahimna.⁹⁴¹ When the illustrious destroyer of Tripura is pleased, what cannot be obtained? Hari, Brahma and the other gods always follow him. Having obtained a son, the king asked for an excellent *tirtha* that would

destroy the great sins of suffering men, who are afflicted by many kinds of calamities, and give them everything that they wished for. Bhava granted him a superior place, known as Bhava *tirtha*. Bathing and donating there, yield everything that is desired. Through Bhava's favours, Prachinabarhi obtained a son, Mahiman. The place known as Bhava *tirtha* is along the banks of Goutami. There are seventy sacred *tirthas* there and they grant everything.'

Chapter 2(84) (Sahasra kunda)

Brahma said, ‘Those who are conversant with the Vedas know of the *tirtha* famous as Sahasra kunda. Even if a man remembers it, he becomes happy. Earlier, Dasharatha’s son, Rama, constructed a bridge across the great ocean. He burnt Lanka down and in a battle, used arrows to kill Ravana and other enemies. Having got Vaidehi ⁹⁴² back, while the guardians of the worlds looked on and his *acharya* was standing in front of him, Rama spoke these words. Sita had been purified by the fire and Lakshmana was near him. Rama said, “O Vaidehi! You are pure. You should come and be seated on my lap.” However, the prosperous Angada and Hanuman said, “No. O Vaidehi! Along with the well-wishers, we will go to Ayodhya. While the brothers, the mothers and the ordinary people are watching, you must be purified. O daughter of a king! After you have been purified in Ayodhya, on an extremely auspicious day, you should sit on the lap. Who can have any doubt about her conduct? However, any condemnation by people must be warded off amidst one’s own people.” Lakshmana and Vibhishana ignored their words. Rama and Jambavan summoned the daughter of a king. As the gods pronounced benedictions, she sat on the king’s lap. All of them were delighted. Astride the radiant Pushpaka, they quickly reached the city of Ayodhya, which was his own kingdom. All of them were happy and always followed Rama.

‘After some days had passed, he heard adverse comments made by ignoble people. Hearing this, he cast away the one who was not born from a womb. ⁹⁴³ She was expecting at the time. How can those who are born in noble lineages tolerate slander, even if it is false? The innocent Sita was weeping and Lakshmana was also weeping. He left her near the hermitage of Valmiki, foremost among sages. He was afraid of doing this, but he did

not wish to transgress his senior's command. After some days passed, along with Soumitri, ⁹⁴⁴ the son of a king ⁹⁴⁵ consecrated himself for a horse sacrifice. Rama's two illustrious sons arrived there. They were Lava and Kusha. As singers, they were Narada's equal. They arrived at the sacrificial arena, singing the entire Ramayana and everything about Rama's conduct in extremely melodious voices that were like those of the *gandharvas*. From these signs, it was discerned that they were the sons of a king and that the two of them were Rama's brave sons and Vaidehi's sons. Having had them brought there, he ⁹⁴⁶ consecrated his sons, one by one. He took them up on his lap and repeatedly embraced them. For embodied beings who are suffering from the misery of *samsara*, embracing the son is a supreme source of solace. He repeatedly embraced his two sons and kissed them. Then, thinking about something, he sighed repeatedly. Meanwhile, the *rakshasas*, the residents of Lanka, arrived there. Sugriva, Hanuman, Angada, Jambavan and all the other *vanaras* also arrived. Vibhishana was at the forefront. Having arrived there, they approached the king, who was seated on his throne. Unable to see Sita, Hanuman and Angada, who wore golden armlets, asked, "Where is the mother, who was not born from a womb? Rama alone is seen." The gate-keepers replied, "She has been cast away by Rama." They ⁹⁴⁷ responded, "The guardians of the world watched and said that she was noble. Having entered the fire, Sita was purified. Nevertheless, the king behaved in this unrestrained way. Because people uttered certain things, Rama has abandoned his beloved. We will die." Saying this, they went to Goutami. Along with the residents of Ayodhya, Rama followed them at the rear. Having arrived at Goutami, they performed supreme austerities. Remembering Sita, the mother of the worlds, they repeatedly sighed. They no longer hankered after the state of *samsara* and were eager to serve Goutami. Rama, the lord of the three worlds, himself came there, along with his younger brothers. Having arrived and bathed in Goutami, he devoted himself to worshipping Shiva. Surrounded by thousands, he gave up all his torment. The place where this occurred is spoken of as Sahasra kunda. ⁹⁴⁸ There are another ten *tirthas* there, which yield every kind of objective. Bathing and donating there, bestow one

thousand times the usual fruit. Assisted by Vasishtha and other lords among sages, he offered oblations there, to counter all calamities and destroy all sins. With flows of wealth, he did this in one thousand different pools. Through the favours of Goutami, mother among rivers, the great ascetic, the destroyer of *rakshasas*, obtained everything that he wished for and desired. That *tirtha*, known as Sahasra kunda, bestows great fruits.'

Chapter 2(85) (Confluence of Kapila)

Brahma said, ‘Kapila *tirtha* is also known as Angiras *tirtha*. It is also known as Aditya *tirtha* and Simhika *tirtha*. O supreme among sages! On the southern bank of Goutami, the Angirases performed a sacrifice for the Adityas. As *dakshina*, the Adityas gave the Angirases the earth. The Angirases went away to undertake austerities. The earth adopted the form of Simhika ⁹⁴⁹ and devoured all the people. All the people were afraid. They went and reported this to the Angirases. Learning that they were frightened and that the earth had assumed the form of Simhika, the Angirases went to the Adityas and addressed them in these words. “Please take back the earth which you gave us.” The Adityas replied, “No. Learned people never take back what they have given as *dakshina*. If anyone takes away the earth, given by him or given by someone else, he is born as a worm and survives on excrement for sixty thousand years. There is no sin greater than taking away the earth, whether given by the one who takes away or by someone else. This is terrible and we will not accept her back again. What will happen if we take back what we ourselves have given? However, we can take back the earth, given as *dakshina*, if we purchase her back.” When they agreed to this, on the southern bank of Ganga the gods gave a *kapila* cow, possessing auspicious qualities, in place of the earth. Vishnu himself exists in that place, which bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation. This is the confluence of Kapila and it destroys all sins. As a result of the donation, water flowed in the form of the river Kapila. The donation of an excellent cow is superior to donating land that is fertile with crops. As a consequence of this exchange, the sage ⁹⁵⁰ saved the world. The *tirtha* where this event occurred is known as Gou *tirtha*. The learned say that there are one hundred *tirthas* there. These bestow everything auspicious. Bathing and donating

there, yield the fruits of donating land. The place where the river joined Ganga is known as the confluence of Kapila.'

Chapter 2(86) (Shankha *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There is the *tirtha* known as Shankha-hrada. ⁹⁵¹ The one who holds the conch shell and the mace is there. If a person bathes there and sees him, he is freed from the bondage of *samsara*. I will tell you what happened there. It grants objects of pleasure and emancipation. Earlier, at the beginning of *kritya yuga*, Brahma was chanting Sama hymns. *Rakshasas* were born from the store that was the cosmic egg and they could assume any form. They were intoxicated because of their strength. They held weapons and rushed towards Brahma, wishing to devour him. I spoke to Vishnu, the preceptor of the universe and asked him for protection. Raising his *chakra*, Vishnu was ready to slay the *rakshasas*. He sliced down the *rakshasas* with his *chakra* and blew on his conch shell. He removed thorns from the flat ground and made heaven free of enemies. After this, filled with delight, Hari blew on his conch shell. At this, all the remaining *rakshasas* were completely destroyed. The place where all of this happened, because of the strength of Vishnu’s conch shell, is known as Shankha *tirtha*. It confers every kind of peace on men. It is sacred and bestows all that is desired. Even if it is remembered, it bestows auspiciousness. It generates a long lifespan and freedom from disease. It enhances prosperity and sons. Even if one remembers this or reads about it, one obtains everything that one desires. O sage! There are ten thousand *tirthas* there and they dispel every kind of sin. Even Maheshvara is incapable of knowing about their powers. In terms of destroying sins, there is nothing that can substitute for them. There is nothing that is superior.’

Chapter 2(87) (Kishkindha *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Kishkindha *tirtha* yields everything that men desire. It destroys every kind of sin and Bhava resides there. I will tell you about its nature. O Narada! Listen carefully. Earlier, Ravana caused the worlds to shriek. With the assistance of the residents of Kishkindha, in the field of battle, Rama, Dasharatha’s son, killed him. The slayer of enemies killed him, along with his sons and soldiers and got Sita back. The king returned, along with his brother Soumitri, the extremely strong *vanaras*, the powerful Vibhishana and the gods. After the benedictions were pronounced, he was prosperous and radiant astride Pushpaka, which used to belong to the lord of riches earlier.⁹⁵² It was swift in speed and could go wherever it wishes. Astride this, all of them went to Ayodhya. Rama was the refuge of all those who sought refuge. He was the one who caused discomfort to his enemies. Along the way, he saw Ganga. Goutami is the one who purifies the universe. She fulfils every kind of desire. She is pleasant to see and removes the torments of those who seek refuge with her. The prosperous king saw her and entered the region along the banks of Ganga. On seeing her, the king was filled with joy and his voice choked because of his delight. O sage! He spoke to all the apes with Hanuman as the chief and invited them. Rama said, “It is because of her powers and favour that my lord and father was freed from all his sins and went to heaven. She is everyone’s mother. She is the one who bestows objects of pleasure on beings. She is the one who grants emancipation. She destroys terrible sins. Where is there a river who is her equal? Every difficulty, hard to cross, has been eternally destroyed. Through her favours, enemies have become friends. Vibhishana became my friend. I got Sita back. Hanuman became my relative. Lanka was shattered. It is through serving her that the

rakshasa was destroyed, along with his followers. Goutama worshipped Shiva, supreme among gods, the one with matted hair, the worthy refuge and obtained her. She is everyone's mother. She bestows everything that is desired. She destroys everything that is inauspicious. She is the one who purifies the universe. I have directly seen her today, the river who is the mother. In deeds, words and thought, I always seek refuge with Ganga. She is the one who is worthy of being a refuge. With all my sentiments, I worship the mother of the virtuous. She is the one who resides in Shambhu's matted hair." Hearing the king's words, all the apes leapt into the water. Following the norms, they separately worshipped her, using many flowers and other objects of worship found in the worlds. Worshipping Sharva, using every kind of sentiment, the king used words to praise him. All the *vanaras* were delighted and sang and danced. Along with his beloved, the great-souled one happily spent the night there. He was surrounded by those who loved him. He cast aside all the miseries caused by his enemies. If one serves Goutami, what is not possible?'

'Full of amazement, he looked at his several servants. He rejoiced and praised Godavari. Rama honoured all the large number of servants and was happy. In the morning, when the sparkling sun rose, Vibhishana spoke to Dasharatha's son. Vibhishana said, "We are still not satisfied with this *tirtha*. We will remain here for some more time. We will reside here for four more nights and leave for Ayodhya in a group." The apes agreed with his words. They stayed there for four nights and worshipped the divinity Sakaleshvara. He ⁹⁵³ then went to the *tirtha* named Siddheshvara, famous in the world and loved by his brother. It was through its favours that the one with the ten heads became extremely strong. They stayed there for five days. They established their own *lingams* and worshipped them. Hanuman, Vayu's son who was the king's follower, started to serve there. As he left, the Indra among kings told Hanuman, "Immerse all these *lingams*. Performing invocation with excellent *mantras*, I have established a *lingam* here and so have others who are Shankara's servants. No other form of Shankara should be worshipped and other *lingams* should not be joined to the great Bhava. If anyone still remains standing after disrespect, ⁹⁵⁴ it is as

if he is standing on the edge of a sword's blade. Those who worship Shiva's *lingam* with disrespect, those who do not act in accordance with what is recommended and those who do not do what is appropriate, suffer from all kinds of hardships and are cooked by Yama's servants." Following Rama's command, Vayu's son went and used both his arms. But he couldn't uproot the *lingam*.⁹⁵⁵ He then desired to seize the *lingam* with his own tail, by encircling it. However, he couldn't and gave up the attempt. The lords among the apes and the king found this to be a great wonder. Which immensely powerful and spirited man is capable of making Mahesha's *lingam* budge? On seeing that it could not be moved, the immensely powerful and supreme king quickly went out. Ramachandra invited *brahmanas* and performed *pradakshina* and worship in the proper way. Purifying himself, with no blemish in his heart, Rama bowed down before all those *lingams*. All the excellent residents of Kishkindha served that *tirtha*. If one bathes at the spot, there is no doubt that all major sins are destroyed. He⁹⁵⁶ devotedly prostrated himself before Ganga again and said, "O mother Goutami! Be pleased." Full of surprise, he controlled himself and repeatedly said this. He looked at Goutami and bowed down before her. Since then, the gods have said that Kishkindha *tirtha* is sacred. If one reads this, remembers it or hears it devotedly, sins are destroyed. What need be said about bathing and donating there?'

Chapter 2(88) (Vyasa *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The famous Vyasa *tirtha* is also known as Prachetas *tirtha*. There is nothing that is more purifying than this. It bestows every kind of success. I had ten sons through my mental powers and they are the creators of the world. ⁹⁵⁷ Those energetic ones had an inner desire to determine the ends of the earth. Some more were created but they too had a similar urge. They did not return. Neither did those who had departed before them. They were gone. O sage! After this, the immensely wise and divine Angirases were born. They knew the purport of the Vedas and the *Vedangas*. They were accomplished in all the sacred texts. Those stores of austerities bowed down before their *guru*, Angiras, and sought his permission. Without asking their mother, they made up their minds to perform austerities. In terms of those who deserve honour, the mother is superior to all *gurus*. O Narada! Therefore, in rage, she cursed her own sons. The mother said, “O sons! Disregarding me, you have sought to engage in austerities. Hence, you will never truly attain success of any kind.” They roamed around in many regions, but could not obtain success in their austerities. There were impediments in every place they went to. Sometimes, impediments were caused by *rakshasas*. Sometimes, they were caused by humans. Sometimes, they were caused by women. Sometimes, there were taints in the body. All those stores of austerities roamed around in this way. Agastya Kumbhayoni is supreme among those who performed austerities. ⁹⁵⁸ He is the preceptor of the universe. The Angirases, who were born in Agni’s lineage, bowed down before him. Humbly, they prepared to ask the lord of the southern direction. ⁹⁵⁹ The Angirases said, “O illustrious one! What sin is responsible for our austerities not being successful? We have used many different methods and used them repeatedly. What will we do? What method will we

use? How will we accomplish our austerities? O Indra among *brahmanas*! Please tell us. In austerities, you are certainly our senior. O brahmana! Among those who know, you are the one who knows best. Among those who are serene, you are the most serene. You are compassionate and always do what is agreeable. You are never angry. You do not hate. Therefore, please tell us what we wish for. Those who possess ego, those who are devoid of compassion, those who have given up serving their *guru*, those who are untruthful in speech and those who are cruel do not know the truth.” After thinking for a while, Agastya gradually told them. Agastya replied, “Your *atmans* are tranquil. Brahma has created you as creators. Your austerities have not been adequate. Remember the cause—your arrogance. There were those whom Brahma created earlier. They left and obtained happiness. There were those who went later, searching for them. They are the ones who became Angirases. You are they. When it was time to go, you did go. But you proceeded very gradually. There is no doubt that you will be superior to Prajapati. ⁹⁶⁰ Leave this place. Torment yourself through austerities near Ganga, the one who purifies the three worlds. In this *samsara*, there is no means other than Ganga, loved by Shiva. There is a sacred spot in the hermitage there. Worship the one who bestows *jnana* there. He is the immensely intelligent one and he will sever all your doubts. Without a good *guru*, no one has obtained success anywhere.” They asked, “O supreme among sages! Who is spoken of as the one who bestows *jnana*? O supreme among sages! Is it Brahma, Vishnu, Mahesha, Aditya, Chandrama, Agni or Varuna? Who bestows *jnana*?” Agastya replied again. “Hear about the one who confers *jnana*. That which is water is Agni. That which is Agni is said to be Surya. That which is Surya is Vishnu. That which is Vishnu is Bhaskara. The one who is Brahma is Rudra. Rudra is everything. He is the one who possesses all *jnana*. Therefore, he is the one who is described as the one who bestows *jnana*. There are many kinds of *gurus*—the one who indicates a direction, the one who urges, the one who explains, the *upadhyaya* and the one who gives birth in this body. But the one who bestows *jnana* is the best. *Jnana* is said to be only that which destroys differences. Shambhu alone is known by the names of Indra, Mitra

and Agni. For the sake of helping those who are confused, *brahmanas* speak of them in different ways.” Hearing the sage’s words, five of them went to the northern bank of Ganga and five went to the southern bank. They recited chants as they proceeded.’

‘They followed the norms and worshipped the gods, as Agastya had asked them to. Thinking about the truth, they sat on special seats. O sage! All the large number of gods were pleased with them. At the beginning of the *yuga*, the origin of the universe ⁹⁶¹ had thought of them as creators. This was for restraining *adharma*, establishing the Vedas, ensuring the welfare of the worlds, accomplishing *dharma*, *kama* and *artha* and interpreting the true meaning of the Puranas, *smriti* texts, the Vedas and the *dharmashastras*. “You have been created in these forms for the welfare of the universe. In due order, you will gradually become Prajapatis, whenever there is *adharma* and the Vedas suffer.” ⁹⁶² Whenever the Vedas suffer from dangers, they are born as Vyases. Whenever *dharma* suffers and the decay of the Vedas is seen, they are born as Vyases to revive them. ⁹⁶³ Ganga’s excellent bank became the place where they performed austerities. Shiva, Vishnu, I, Aditya, Agni and water are always present there. There is nothing that is more purifying than these. This is the supreme *brahman* alone, which assumes many different kinds of forms. Shiva is in all *atmans* and pervades everything. In his own form, he assumes every kind of form. To exhibit compassion to all living beings, he is especially present in this *tirtha*. He is surrounded by all the gods and shows them every kind of favour. They are known as Dharmavyasas and Vedavyasas. In the three worlds, their *tirtha* is named after them. Vyasa *tirtha* is excellent. The waters there wash off the mire of sins. The darkness of delusion and insolence is dispelled. Men obtain every kind of success there.’

Chapter 2(89) (Confluence of Vanjara)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Vanjara *tirtha* is famous in the three worlds. *Rishis*, *siddhas* and *rajarshis* ⁹⁶⁴ always frequent it. Earlier, the bird Garuda had become a servant of the *nagas*. Since his mother had become a servant, he was miserable and his mind was tormented. On one occasion, he was alone. He thought about it and sighed. Garuda said, “In this world, people who have performed good deeds are blessed. They do not have to serve others and do not face any hardship. Full of happiness, they sing, sleep and laugh. They are masters of their own bodies and are blessed. Shame on those who are under the control of others.” Thinking in this way, he was miserable and went to his mother. The one whose *atman* is immeasurable asked his mother, Vinata. Garuda asked, “O mother! Whose sin has led to your becoming a servant? Did my father do something? Was it I? Was it someone else? I am asking you about the reason. Please tell me.” She spoke to her beloved son, Aruna’s younger brother. ⁹⁶⁵ Vinata replied, “No one else committed the sin.

It is my own fault. It is I who said, ‘The person whose words are false will become a servant.’ Kadru and I went there together. Kadru and I had an argument and I was deceitfully defeated by her. O son! Destiny is powerful. What does it not do? O Kashyapa’s son! In this way, I became Kadru’s servant. I gave birth to you when I was a servant. O son of a brahmana! Thus, you also became a servant.” Extremely sad, Garuda was silent. He didn’t speak to his mother. He thought about what was inevitable.’

‘On one occasion, thinking about the welfare of her sons and her own prosperity, Kadru spoke to Vinata, the mother of birds. Kadru said, “Without being restrained, your son goes to Surya and bows down to him. Even though you are a servant, in the three worlds, you are blessed.” She

was extremely surprised at this. But hiding her own misery, she spoke to Kadru. Vinata replied, “Why don’t your sons go and see Ravi?”⁹⁶⁶ Kadru replied, ‘O extremely fortunate one! Please take my sons to the abode of the *nagas*. That extremely cool lake is near the ocean.” Suparna⁹⁶⁷ carried the *nagas*, Kadru and Vinata. Delighted, she spoke to his mother, Vinata. “Let Garuda take my sons to the abode of the gods.” Humbly, the mother of the snakes again spoke to Garuda. The mother of the snakes said, “My sons desire to see Hamsa,⁹⁶⁸ the preceptor of the three worlds. After bowing down to him, they should be returned to my residence. O Vinata! Let my sons be taken to Surya’s circle every day.” Trembling, the miserable Vinata spoke to Kadru. Vinata said, “O mother of the snakes! I am incapable of doing this. My son will take your sons. After seeing the god who creates the day, let them return.” Vinata spoke to her own son, the lord of the birds. “Through deceit, the *nagas* have become masters. The mother of the snakes has told me that they wish to bow down to the radiant one.” Agreeing to this, Garuda replied, “Let the *pannagas* climb atop me.” Thereupon, the snake soldiers climbed onto Garuda, the lord of the birds. Very slowly, they approached the place where the god Divakara⁹⁶⁹ was. They were scorched by Bhanu’s fierce heat and were distressed. The snakes said, “O immensely wise one! O bird! We bow down to you. Return. Enough of bowing down to Surya in his abode. We are being burnt down by Surya’s energy. O Garuda! We will leave, with or without you.” When the *nagas* said this, he replied, “I will show you Aditya.” Saying this, he swiftly sped through the sky, in Aditya’s direction. The serpents were burnt and fell down on the island of Virana. Several hundreds of thousands suffered. Their bodies were scorched. Kadru heard the screams of her sons, falling down on the surface of the earth. Extremely anxious, she arrived there, so as to comfort them. Kadru told Vinata, “Your son has committed a very wicked deed. His intelligence is evil and they are unable to find peace. One should never act against the words of the lord Phanishvara.”⁹⁷⁰ Had the extremely energetic Kashyapa been here, he would have found a means to free them of this suffering. O beautiful one! How can my sons find peace?” Hearing Kadru’s words, Vinata was extremely scared. She spoke to her great-souled son

Garuda, the lord of the birds. Vinata said, “O son! This is not worthy of you. It has been said that humility is an ornament. Its opposite is not appropriate. A virtuous person must never be treacherous, not even towards enemies. The moon shines equally over learned *brahmanas* and *antyaajas*. O son! The worst among men are incapable of using force to do anything directly. Therefore, they cause harm through deceit.” Vinata then asked the mother of the snakes how this could be countered. Vinata asked, “How can I ensure peace for your sons? I will do that. Old age has seized them. Please tell me. How can I ensure peace for them?” Kadru told Vinata, “There is water in Rasatala. If my sons are sprinkled with that, they will find peace.” Hearing her words, he ⁹⁷¹ immediately brought water from Rasatala and sprinkled the *nagas* with this. After this, Garuda spoke to Maghavan Shatakratu. Garuda said, “The clouds do good deeds to the three worlds. Let them shower down here.” To ensure auspiciousness for the *nagas*, the clouds showered down. Ganga’s water was brought from Rasatala and brought life to the *nagas*. Garuda brought it, for the purpose of destroying misery and old age. The place where the *nagas* were sprinkled is known as the abode of the *nagas*. Garuda brought water from Rasatala there. For everyone, that water from Ganga destroys every kind of sin. With old age countered, everything was auspicious for the *nagas*. Brought from Rasatala, Ganga’s water revived life for the *nagas*. The place is on Ganga’s southern bank and destroys misery and old age. The river Vanjara flowed from this and it is like a flow of *amrita* itself. It destroys old age, poverty, torment and hardships. This is a confluence between Ganga from Rasatala and the Ganga who is in the mortal world. How can anyone describe it? Even if one remembers it, the store of sins is destroyed. Which lord is capable of describing the fruits that result from bathing and donating there? Learned men say that there is an aggregate of one hundred and twenty-five thousand *tirthas* there. They bestow every kind of prosperity and destroy every kind of sin. There is no *tirtha* that can match the confluence of Vanjara. Even if one remembers it, calamities and adversities are destroyed.’

Chapter 2(90) (Devagama *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The *tirtha* known as Devagama is auspicious and bestows everything that is desired. It bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation on men. It provides satisfaction to the ancestors. I will describe what happened there. O Narada! Listen attentively. For the sake of wealth, there was rivalry between the gods and the *asuras*. The gods obtained heaven and the *asuras* obtained the earth. Having obtained *karma bhumi*, the *asuras* spread everywhere. The *asuras* killed those who offered shares in sacrifices to the gods. All the categories of gods were deprived of their shares in sacrifices. Distressed, they came to me and asked, “What should be done?” I told the large number of gods, “Use your strength to defeat the *asuras* in a battle. When you obtain the earth, you will also get the rites, the oblations and fame.” Addressed in this way, the gods went to earth, desiring to fight. The *daityas*, *danavas* and *rakshasas* were proud of their strength. They united and fought. They wished to fight and be victorious. Ahi, Vritra, Tvashta’s son,⁹⁷² Namuchi, Shambara, Maya—there were these and many other warriors, proud of their strength. There were Agni, Indra, Varuna, Tvashta, Pusha, the two Ashvins, the Maruts and the guardians of the worlds—accomplished in fighting in diverse ways. In the battle, all the *danavas* stationed themselves in the southern direction. Resorting to the shores of the southern ocean, they made great efforts. Earlier, Trikuta, best among mountains, belonged to the *rakshasas*. Together, all of them went southwards, to the forest. All of them gathered together at the place where Mount Malaya is. This region around Malaya also belonged to the enemies of the gods. The gods gathered along the banks of Goutami, because Shiva is present there. Since they gathered there, that place is named after *devas*. Astride their own chariots, *devas* arrived there. They came to the banks of

Goutami, mother of rivers, whose waters are sparkling. When she is pleased, she grants everything that is desired, to the ancestors and to everyone else. After this, the large number of gods praised the divinity Maheshvara. They thought, and discussed with each other, how they might obtain freedom from fear. The gods said, “What method will we use? Will we be defeated by the enemy? This alone is best for us—victory or defeat. Shame on spirited people who still remain alive after being overcome by their enemies.” O son! At this time, an invisible voice was heard. The voice from the sky said, “O large number of gods! Enough of this hardship. Quickly go to Goutami. Devotedly, worship the two lords there, Hari and Hara. If Godavari and those two are pleased, what is extremely difficult to obtain?” Hari and Isha were pleased and because of them, the gods obtained victory. Having obtained everything, the residents of heaven departed, protecting everything. The place where the gods arrived is famous as a *tirtha*.⁹⁷³ The sages who know about the truth praise Devagama. O Narada! There are eighty thousand Shiva *lingams* there. The mountain of Devagama is known as Priya.⁹⁷⁴ Since then, that *tirtha* has also been known as Devapriya.’

Chapter 2(91) (Kushatarpana *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Kushatarpana is also known as the confluence of Pranita. Among all the *tirthas* in the worlds, this is the one that bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation. I will describe its nature. Listen to the auspicious account that destroys all sins. On the southern flank of Vindhya, there is the great mountain known as Sahya. Rivers arise from its feet, Godavari and Bhimarathi being the foremost.⁹⁷⁵ The place where Ekavira arose is Viraja. No one is capable of describing its greatness. I will tell you about the sacred region on that mountain. O Narada! Listen attentively. I will tell you about what is the greatest secret among all secrets. This auspicious account is directly mentioned in the Vedas. Even the sages, gods, ancestors and *asuras* do not know about this. To please you, I will tell you about it. As soon as one hears this, everything desired is obtained. The supreme one is known as Purusha and it is without decay. The inferior one is subject to decay and is with Prakriti.⁹⁷⁶ The Purusha with form originated from the Purusha who was without form. Water was born from him and Purusha originated from water.⁹⁷⁷ O sage! From both of them,⁹⁷⁸ a lotus was born and I originate from that. O sage! Earth, wind, space, water and fire were created before me and originated simultaneously. I saw only these. There was nothing else, mobile or immobile. The Vedas did not exist then. I could see nothing. I could not even see what I had originated from.⁹⁷⁹ When I remained silent, I heard these excellent words. The voice from the sky said, “O Brahma! Create the universe and the mobile and immobile objects.” O Narada! At this, I replied to Purusha’s voice. “How will I create? What will I create? With what will I create the universe?” The voice replied, “The goddess known as Prakriti has been sent by Vishnu. She is the mother of the universe and she pervades the universe.” The voice from the

sky continued, “There is no doubt that you will have the capacity if you undertake a sacrifice. O Brahma! The eternal shruti texts say that Yajna ⁹⁸⁰ is Vishnu. Through a sacrifice, what cannot be accomplished in this world or in the next world?” I again asked the goddess, “Where will I undertake it and with what? Please tell me. O immensely fortunate one! How will the rites of the sacrifice be undertaken?” The voice from the sky replied to me. She is the goddess who assumes the form of Omkara. She is thought of as the mother. She pervades the universe. “In *karma bhumi*, perform a sacrifice to the lord of sacrifices. He is the being personified in sacrifices. He is the means and instrument. O one excellent in vows! Undertake a sacrifice to him. He is the sacrifice, *svaha*, *svadha*, *mantras*, the chief priest, oblations and other things. Hari alone is everything. Everything is obtained through Vishnu.” I again asked the goddess, “What is described as *karma bhumi*?” O Narada! At that time, there was no Bhagirathi or Narmada. There was no Yamuna, Tapi, Sarasvati or Goutami. There were no oceans, male rivers, lakes, or sparkling female rivers. Shakti repeatedly spoke to me again. The divine voice said, “The region beyond the southern slope of Sumeru, to the south of Mount Himalaya, to the south of Vindhya and to the south of Sahya is *karma bhumi*. It always brings everything auspicious to everyone, all the time.” Having heard her words, I abandoned Meru, the great mountain.’

‘I went to that region and wondered, “Where will I stay?” At this, Vishnu’s invisible voice spoke to me. The voice from the sky said, “Leave this place. Stay there. Sit down here. Take the resolution to undertake a sacrifice. The sacrifice will be completed. O supreme among gods! For the sake of the sacrifice, take the resolution. Do everything else that is recommended in all the Vedas.” On their own, *itihasa*, Puranas and everything else that is articulated through sound surfaced in my memory and issued through my mouth. In an instant, I got to know all the meanings of the Vedas. I remembered *Purusha sukta*, ⁹⁸¹ famous in the worlds. I devised everything that is spoken about as a component of a sacrifice. Following the recommended means, I devised the vessels for the sacrifice. I purified myself, controlled my *atman* and remained in a certain place. I

consecrated myself in that region. That spot is known as a region of *brahmanas*. It is named after me. O great sage! I undertook a sacrifice in that sacred place. After my name, it is remembered as Brahmagiri. It extends for twenty-four *yojanas*. Brahmagiri is to the east of the sacred place where I performed the sacrifice. The sacrificial altar was in the middle. I devised the *garhapatya*, *dakshinatya* and *ahavaniya* fires. The indications in the *shruti* texts are that a sacrifice is not successful without a wife. O sage! Therefore, I divided my body into two. For the success of the sacrifice, the part to the left became my wife. I remained the part to right. The *shruti* texts speak of her as Jaya. O Narada! As the best form of oblations of *ghee*, I devised the period of Vasanta.⁹⁸² I thought of Grishma as kindling and Sharad as oblations. O son! I thought of the season of Varsha as the *barhi* grass. The seven *chandas*⁹⁸³ were thought of as the sticks laid around the sacrifice. *Kala*, *kashtha* and *nimesha*⁹⁸⁴ were thought of as kindling, vessels and *kusha* grass. O *devarshi*! *Kala*⁹⁸⁵ is without a beginning and without an end. He himself assumed the form of the sacrificial altar, to which, the sacrificial animal would be tied. The three *gunas*, *sattva* and the others, became the ropes. But there was no sacrificial animal. Therefore, I spoke to Vishnu's invisible voice. "Without a sacrificial animal, the sacrifice cannot be completed." The eternal goddess, the disembodied voice, replied. The voice from the sky said, "Use Purusha *sukta* to praise the supreme Purusha." Thus addressed, I praised Janardana, the lord of the gods, the one who was my origin. I devotedly used Purusha *sukta*. The goddess then told me, "O Brahma! Make me your sacrificial animal." I then got to know that the undecaying Purusha was my father. I tied him next to the sacrificial post, which was in the form of time, and tethered him with the noose of the *gunas*. I stood outside. Inside, Purusha stood in front of me, as the consecrated sacrificial animal. Meanwhile, everything in the universe originated from him. *Brahmanas* originated from his mouth and *kshatriyas* from his arms. Indra and Agni originated from his mouth, *prana* from his breath. The directions were born from his ears, heaven was born from his head. Everything originated in this way. The moon was born from his mind, the sun was born from his eyes, the

firmament was born from his navel and the *vaishyas* were born from his thighs. The shudras were born from his feet. The earth was also born from his feet. The *rishis* were born from his body hair, the herbs from his hair. All the wild and domestic animals were born from his nails. Worms, insects and flying insects were born from his anus and genital organs. All the mobile and immobile objects are everything seen and unseen were thus born from him. The gods were born through me. Meanwhile, Vishnu's divine voice spoke to me. The voice from the sky said, "Everything has been completed. The desired creation has taken place. Now offer all the vessels and implements into the fire. Cast aside the sacrificial post, the sacrificial cup and the *kusha* grass. O Brahma! Cast aside everything—the forms of the officiating priest and sacrificial objects you had thought of, the sacrificial ladle, Purusha and the noose." O great sage! I gradually did everything that the origin of the sacrifice had asked me to do. I progressively offered them into the *garhapatya*, *dakshinatya* and *ahavaniya* fires as oblations. I meditated on Purusha, the origin of the universe, who had been sanctified with the *mantras*. He is the lord of the sacrifice, who pervades the universe. He is the protector of the world, the creator of the universe. I saw him near the sacrificial pit. In the *ahavaniya* fire, Vishnu was white in form. In the *dakshinatya* fire, Vishnu was dark in form. In the *garhapatya* fire, the wise one was yellow in form. Vishnu was present everywhere, all the time. There is nothing without Vishnu. He is the cause of the universe. I pronounced the *mantras* over the water in the sacrificial cup, used for consecration. The water from the sacrificial cup became the auspicious river, Pranita.⁹⁸⁶ I cleaned the sacrificial cup with *kusha* grass and cast it aside. When it was cleaned, drops of water fell from the sacrificial cup. *Tirthas*, excellent in qualities, originated at the place where those drops fell. O tiger among sages! Bathing in the river that originated, yields the fruits of all sacrifices. The wielder of the Sharnga bow, the lord of the gods, ornaments it all the time. For everyone, the flight of steps represents ascent to Vaikuntha. The auspicious *kusha* grass used for cleaning fell down on the ground. That place is known as Kushatarpana. It yields the fruits of many good merits. It is known as Kushatarpana because

everyone was satisfied with *kusha* grass.⁹⁸⁷ O immensely intelligent one! Later, for a different reason, Goutami merged with Pranita and the confluence of Pranita resulted. In the region known as Kushatarpana, the *tarpana* with *kusha* grass was performed. It is there that I devised the sacrificial post, to the north of Vindhya. The place where I cast it aside is a spot resorted to by Vishnu and is worshipped by all the worlds. The auspicious place is without decay. Hence, there is an Akshaya Vata there.⁹⁸⁸ It is in the form of time and is eternal. The act of remembering it yields the fruits of all sacrifices. The place where I performed the sacrifice is known as Dandakaranya. When the sacrifice was complete, I faithfully sought Vishnu's favours there. All pure deeds originated from the being known as Virat in the Vedas. I was born from him and he is the one who created this universe. I honoured the divinity who is the lord of the gods and cast him aside. The place where I performed the divine and auspicious sacrifice extends for twenty-four *yojanas*. O Narada! Even today, there are three sacrificial pits there. They are in the form of the lord of sacrifices, Vishnu, the one who holds the *chakra* in his hand. Since then, the place where I performed the sacrifice has been famous. Even worms and insects obtain emancipation there. Dandakaranya is said to be the seed of *dharma* and the seed of emancipation. In particular, the region that touches Goutami is most sacred. If a person bathes and undertakes other rites in the confluence of Pranita or in Kushatarpana, he proceeds to the supreme destination. It should be known that if a man remembers, reads or hears it faithfully, he obtains everything that he desires. It is a place that bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation. Along both banks, the learned say that there are eighty-six thousand *tirthas*. The sacredness of these places has already been described. O sage! Kushatarpana is superior to even Varanasi. Among all mobile and immobile entities, there is no other *tirtha* that is its equal. Even if one remembers it, sins like the killing of a brahmana are destroyed. O sage! On the surface of the earth, that *tirtha* is spoken of as a gate to heaven.'

Chapter 2(92) (Manyu *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Manyu *tirtha* destroys every kind of sin. It bestows everything desired on men. Even if it is remembered, it destroys sins. I will describe its powers. O sage! Listen attentively. Earlier, there was a battle between the gods and the *danavas*. In this, the gods were defeated and the *danavas* were victorious. Dispirited, the large number of gods withdrew from the battle. They came to me and said, “Please grant us freedom from fear.” I told them, “All of you go to Ganga. On the banks of Goutami, praise the divinity Maheshvara. He is the beautiful one, the one who bestows bliss with no effort or with a little bit of effort. O gods! From Maheshvara, all of you will obtain means to ensure victory.” Agreeing to this, the large number of gods praised Maheshvara. Some of them tormented themselves through austerities. Others danced. Some bathed him, ⁹⁸⁹ others worshipped him. The illustrious Maheshvara, who holds the trident in his hand, was pleased. Pleased, he told the gods, “Tell me what you desire.” The gods replied to the lord of the gods, “For the sake of victory, give us a being who is greatly praiseworthy. He will stand before us in the battle. Resorting to the strength of his arms, we will be happy.” The illustrious Maheshvara told the gods that he agreed to this. Through his own energy, Parameshthi created a being known as Manyu. He was fierce and he would lead the soldiers of the gods. Having obtained him, all the gods bowed down to Shiva and returned to their own abodes, along with Manyu.’

‘They decided to fight again. When they stood in the field of battle, the *danavas* and the *daityas* were extremely strong. Cladding themselves in armour, the gods stood in front of Manyu and spoke to him. The gods said, “Show us your capacity. After that, we will fight with the enemy. O Manyu! We wish to fight. But show us what you can do.” Hearing the words of the

gods, Manyu smiled as he spoke. Manyu replied, “The one who created me is the lord of the gods. He knows everything. He is the lord who sees everything. He knows the abodes and names of everyone and what is in their minds. He always knows everything. But there is no one who knows him. He is the creator who pervades the universe. He is without form, but knows everything that has form. He is himself the supreme and illustrious one. He is in heaven and in the firmament. Who is capable of knowing his form? He is the creator who pervades the universe. I have originated from someone like him. How are you worthy of knowing me? However, if you still wish to see me, behold.” Having said this, Manyu showed them his own great form. He had originated from Parameshthi Bhava’s third eye. That form was an aggregate of all the energy that is spoken about. He is manliness in men. He is ego in human beings. He is the terrible anger in everyone.⁹⁹⁰ He is the one who causes destruction. Shankara’s representative blazed in his own energy. He wielded every kind of weapon. On seeing him, all the gods prostrated themselves before him. The *daityas* and *danavas* were terrified and the gods joined their hands in salutation. They said, “O Manyu! Please be the leader of our soldiers. O Manyu! We will enjoy the kingdom that you bestow upon us. You are victorious in all your deeds. You are the one who enhances victory. Therefore, you are Indra. You are Varuna. Indeed, you are the guardians of the worlds. For the sake of victory, enter all of us gods.” Manyu told all of them, “Without me, there is nothing. I enter and am inside everyone. However, no one ever knows me.” Manyu was the illustrious one himself, originating in separate forms. He is the one in the form of Rudra. Rudra is Manyu and Shiva. Everything mobile and immobile is pervaded by Manyu. Having obtained him, all the gods were victorious in the battle. Victory, Manyu and valour originated from Isha’s energy. In the battle, through Manyu, they obtained victory over the *daityas*. Protected by Manyu, all of them then returned to wherever they had come from. There is a place where the gods worshipped Shiva on the banks of Goutami. That is the spot where they obtained Manyu and victory and it is known as Manyu *tirtha*. If a man controls himself and remembers Manyu and his origin, he is victorious and no one can defeat him. O great

sage! There is no place as purifying as Manyu *tirtha*. In the form of Manyu, Shankara himself is always present there. Bathing and donations there and remembering it, bestows everything that is wished for.'

Chapter 2(93) (Shveta Parvata)

Brahma said, ‘The *tirtha* named Sarasvata bestows the fruits of everything that is desired. It confers objects of pleasure and emancipation on men. It destroys every kind of sin. It destroys every kind of disease. It bestows every kind of success. O Narada! Therefore, listen to its account in detail. On the eastern side of Pushpotkata, there is a mountain that is famous in the worlds. That best among mountains is named Shubhra and it is on Goutami’s southern bank. Shakalya was a famous sage and he was extremely devoted. He tormented himself through excellent austerities on sacred Mount Shubhra. Resorting to the banks of Goutami, the best among *brahmanas* practiced austerities there. All the large number of beings always prostrated themselves before him and praised him. He was devoted to serving the fire and devoted to studying the Vedas. He did this on the extremely sacred mountain which gave gods and *brahmanas* freedom from fear. There was a *rakshasa* named Parashu. He hated sacrifices and killed *brahmanas*. He could assume any form at will and roamed around in the forest, assuming many different forms. In an instant, he would assume the form of a brahmana. Sometimes, he would assume the form of a tiger. Sometimes, he would assume the form of a god. Sometimes, he would assume the form of an animal. Sometimes, he would assume the form of a woman. Sometimes, he would assume the form of a deer. Sometimes, he would assume the form of a child. In this way, the evil-doer wandered around.’

‘The extremely wicked Parashu, worst among *rakshasas*, arrived at the place where Shakalya, the learned brahmana who was supreme among sages, was. Parashu always went there, intent on abducting or killing the pure and best among *brahmanas*. However, though he tried, the evil-doer

was unable to do this. On one occasion, after carefully worshipping the gods, the best among *brahmanas* wished to eat. O sage! At that time, Parashu arrived there, assuming the form of a brahmana who was weak, grey-haired and feeble. He had a maiden with him. He addressed Shakalya in these words. Parashu said, “O brahmana! Know that this maiden and I wish for some food. O one who bestows honours! We have come at the time when guests should be tended to. Please do what needs to be done. In this world, those who have homes where the wishes for guests are met are blessed. When they leave, others are as good as dead, even if they are alive.

⁹⁹¹ Having sat down to eat, if a person gives away to guests what he has earmarked for himself, it is as if he has given away the entire earth.” Shakalya did not know that Parashu was only disguised as a brahmana. Hearing this, he made him sit on a seat and replied, “I will give.” Shakalya followed the norms, worshipped him and gave him food. Taking water for rinsing in his hand, Parashu spoke the following words. Parashu said, “From a distance, the gods follow a tired guest. When he is satisfied, they are satisfied. If they are not satisfied, there is a calamity. The guest and the slanderer—these two are the relatives of the universe. The slanderer destroys sins and the guest bestows heaven. ⁹⁹² If a person looks at a guest, who is exhausted from travelling along the road, with indifference, his *dharma*, fame and prosperity are instantly destroyed. O supreme among *brahmanas*! Therefore, as an exhausted guest, I am seeking from you. I will eat if you grant me what I desire, not otherwise.” Shakalya told the *rakshasa*, “I will give you. Please eat.” At this, Parashu replied, “I am Parashu, a supreme *rakshasa*. I am your enemy. I am not an aged and emaciated brahmana with grey hair. I have spent many years, looking at you. My limbs are drying up, like a small body of water during the summer. O supreme among *brahmanas*! Therefore, I will take away you and your followers and eat you.” Hearing Parashu’s words, Shakalya addressed him in the following words. Shakalya said, “Those born in extremely great lineages and those who know all the *agama* texts act according to their pledges, never in a contrary way. O friend! Do what is appropriate. But listen to my words. Even if a person is ready to kill you, excellent words

that are good for his welfare must be stated. I am a brahmana and my body is like the *vajra*. Hari protects me in every direction. Let Vishnu protect my feet and let the divinity Janardana protect my head. Let Varaha protect my arms and let Dharmaraja ⁹⁹³ protect my back. Let Krishna protect my heart and let the animal ⁹⁹⁴ protect my fingers. Let the lord of speech protect my mouth and let the one who travels on the bird ⁹⁹⁵ protect my eyes. Let the lord of riches protect my ears and let Bhava protect me in every direction. In many kinds of hardship, the divinity Narayana is himself the refuge.” Saying this, Shakalya continued, “As you wish, take me, or eat me. O Indra among *rakshasas*! O Parashu! Be attentive now.” Hearing his words, the *rakshasa* prepared to devour him. Indeed, there is not the slightest bit of compassion in the hearts of sinners.’

‘With a mouth that had terrible fangs, he approached near. Looking at the brahmana, Parashu spoke these words. Parashu said, “O supreme among *brahmanas*! I see you as one who holds the conch shell, the *chakra* and the mace in your hands. You are the lord with one thousand feet and heads. You possess one thousand eyes and hands. You are the single refuge for all beings. Your form is that of the Vedas. You pervade the universe. O brahmana! When I look at you now, you no longer possess your former body.

O brahmana! Therefore, I am trying to please you. You alone are the refuge. O immensely intelligent one! Grant me *jnana*. Tell me about a *tirtha* that can free me of my sins. O brahmana! Visiting a great person is never futile, even if it is done out of hatred, ignorance or distraction. When a piece of iron touches gold, it too assumes that form.” He heard the words that the *rakshasa* had spoken. Full of compassion, Shakalya replied, “Sarasvati is the one who bestows boons. O lord of the *daityas*! Therefore, without any delay, praise Janardana. To accomplish one’s wishes, there is nothing other than the praising of Narayana. But, in this world, there is another cause too. O *rakshasa*! Listen. If the goddess is pleased, my words will come true.” Addressed in this way, Parashu bathed in Ganga, who purifies the three worlds. He purified and controlled his mind and stood, facing Ganga.

There, he saw Sarasvati, mother of the universe. She was divine in form and

was adorned with divine fragrances and unguents. He followed Shakalya's words and stood there. She is the one who removes all inactivity from the universe. She is Bhuvaneshvari, the mother of the universe. Cleansed of his sins, Parashu addressed her humbly. Parashu said, "My *guru* Shakalya told me to praise the one the one who has the bird on his standard, loved by you.⁹⁹⁶ Through your favours, please act so that I have that capacity." The illustrious Sarasvati told Parashu that she granted him this. Through Sarasvati's favours, Parashu used many kinds of words to praise Hari. Janardana, the ocean of compassion, was pleased and granted the *rakshasa* boons. Janardana said, "O *rakshasa*! Everything that is in your mind will occur." Though the *rakshasa* Parashu was a sinner, through the favours of Shakalya, through the favours of Goutami, through the favours of Sarasvati and through the favours of Narasimha, he went to heaven. He went there through the favours of the one who wields the Sharnga bow, whose lotus feet represent all *tirthas*. Since then, that place has been known as Sarasvata *tirtha*. If one bathes or donates there, one obtains greatness in Vishnu's world. Through the powers of the goddess of speech, Vishnu, Shakalya and Parashu, there are many *tirthas* in Shveta Parvata.'⁹⁹⁷

Chapter 2(94) (Chinchika *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Chinchika *tirtha* destroys every kind of disease. It dispels every kind of worry. It bestows every kind of peace on men. I will describe its nature. That white and excellent mountain is on the northern bank of Ganga and the divinity Gadadhara ⁹⁹⁸ is present there. There was a *bherunda* ⁹⁹⁹ who was a king of birds and he was known as Chinchika. He always lived there, on Mount Shveta, and ate flesh. It was full of many kinds of fruits and flowers. The mountain was covered with blossoms from every season. It was frequented by the best among birds and adorned by Goutami. It was full of *siddhas*, *charanas*, *gandharvas*, *kinharas* and immortals. There was another mountain nearby and there were some bipeds and some quadrupeds there. They never suffered from disease, afflictions, hunger, thirst, worries and death. This mountain possessed such qualities and it was surrounded by a large number of many types of sages. There was a king of the eastern direction and he was known as Pavamana. The prosperous one was devoted to the *dharma* of *kshatriyas* and protected gods and *brahmanas*. With a large army and with his priest, he went to the forest. He happily enjoyed himself with charming women there, with dancing and the playing of musical instruments. He held a bow in his hand and was surrounded by those who loved hunting. On one occasion, wandering around in this way and exhausted, he arrived before a tree. It grew along Goutami’s banks and was full of a large number of many kinds of birds. It was as if the lord of a house, who knows about *dharma*, was surrounded by those from all the *ashramas*. Pavamana, supreme among kings, sought refuge at that excellent tree and rested. Surrounded by all these people, he looked at that excellent tree.’

‘He saw a stout bird there. It was beautiful in form, but it possessed two mouths. It seemed to be worried and exhausted and the excellent king asked it. The king asked, “O bird with two mouths! Who are you? It is evident that you are full of thoughts. Here, there is no one who is miserable and afflicted. Where has this grief come upon you?” Comforted in its mind, the bird Chinchika sighed repeatedly and slowly spoke to King Pavamana. Chinchika said, “Others have no reason to fear me and I suffer no hardships on account of others. This place is full of many kinds of flowers and fruit. It is frequented by sages. Nevertheless, this mountain seems empty to me. That is the reason I am grieving. I never get any happiness. I am never satisfied. I never get any sleep. I cannot find peace. There is no end to this.” Hearing what the two-mouthed bird’s words, the king was amazed. The king asked, “What sin have you committed? Why is the mountain empty? On this excellent mountain, beings are satisfied with one mouth. Despite possessing two mouths, why are you not satisfied? Why have you been reduced to this state? Did you commit a sin in this birth or in an earlier one? Tell me everything truthfully. I will save you from this great fear.” The bird Chinchika sighed and replied to the king. Chinchika said, “O Pavamana! I will tell you what happened earlier. Listen. I was a supreme brahmana, accomplished in the Vedas and the *Vedangas*. I was born in a noble lineage and was known as a sage. But I loved quarrels and disturbed tasks. I would say one thing before a being and another thing when the back was turned. I was always unhappy at the prosperity of others. I used fraud to deceive the world. I was ungrateful and devoid of truth. I was accomplished in criticizing others. I caused harm to friends, masters and *gurus*. My conduct was full of insolence and I was extremely cruel. In my thoughts, words and deeds, I tormented many people. I always amused myself by causing violence to others. I always indulged in separating couples, destroying groups and breaking agreements. I acted without reflecting on it. I turned myself away from serving the learned. In the three worlds, there was no other sinner like me. Therefore, I was born with two mouths. Since I tormented others and made them miserable, I am now tormented by this grief. This mountain is empty for me. O lord of the earth! Hear some other

words. They are in conformity with *dharma* and *artha*. One can suffer a sin equal to that from killing a brahmana, without having done that. During a battle, if a *kshatriya* kills someone who is fighting with another, someone who is fleeing, someone who has laid down his weapons, someone who is trusting,¹⁰⁰⁰ someone who is reluctant to fight, someone who does not know he is being attacked, someone who is seated, or someone who says he is scared—if a *kshatriya* kills any of these, that sin is like the sin of killing a brahmana. If a person forgets what he has studied, uses the word ‘*tvam*’ for those who are superior,¹⁰⁰¹ or shows dishonour towards *gurus*—that sin is like the sin of killing a brahmana. If a person uses pleasant words in someone’s presence, but harsh words behind his back; if he thinks and says something, but always does the opposite; if he takes an oath in the name of his *gurus* and hates them; if he criticizes *brahmanas*, if his humility is false and if he is evil-souled—that sin is like the sin of killing a brahmana. Out of hatred, if a person criticizes gods, the Vedas, *adhyatma*, or an assembly of *brahmanas* devoted to *dharma*, that sin is like the sin of killing a brahmana. O king! Because of pride and shame,¹⁰⁰² I was like that. O king! That is the reason I became a bird. Despite being born like this, I must have performed some good deed somewhere. O king! Because of that good deed, I remember what I had done earlier.” Hearing Chinchika’s words, Pavamana was extremely surprised. The king asked the bird, “Through what deed can you be liberated?” Hearing these words, the king of birds replied to the king.’

‘Chinchika said, “On Goutami’s northern bank, in this excellent mountain, there is a *tirtha* named Gadadhara. It destroys every kind of sin. O one excellent in vows! That *tirtha* is extremely sacred. Please take me there. The great sages have said that it bestows everything that is desired. In terms of destroying hardships, there is nothing superior to Goutami and Vishnu. It is my view that with every kind of sentiment, I should see that *tirtha*. Through my own efforts, I am incapable of doing this. How else can those who have performed evil deeds obtain what they wish for? O brave one! It is extremely difficult to reach. Though I made efforts, I could not see it. Through your favours, I should be able to see Gadadhara. He is an ocean

of compassion. I have told you the reason for my misery. If men see him, they no longer suffer from the sorrows of *samsara*. O one who is excellent in vows! Through your favours, I will see him and go to heaven.” The bird Chinchika thus told the king what was in his mind and he showed the bird the divinity and Ganga. Chinchika spoke to Ganga, the one who purifies the three worlds. Chinchika said, “O Ganga! O Goutami! O one who purifies the three worlds! In this world and in the next world, a man is a sinner only as long as he has not seen you. O best among rivers! Therefore, save me from everything. O one who has originated from Vishnu’s lotus feet! For embodied beings in *samsara*, there is no refuge other than you.” Thus, his *atman* purified through devotion, the bird sought refuge in Ganga. He bathed there, remembering the words, “O Ganga! Please save me.” While the residents of the mountain watched, he prostrated himself before Gadadhara. Taking Pavamana’s permission, he went to heaven. Along with his followers, Pavamana returned to his own city. Since then, that *tirtha* has been named after Pavamana and Chinchika. Those who know about the Vedas also know it as Gadadhara *tirtha* and Koti *tirtha*. The rites performed by men there, yield fruits that are crores and crores more in terms of qualities.’

Chapter 2(95) (Bhadra *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Bhadra *tirtha* counters every kind of harm. It destroys all sins and bestows great serenity. Usha, Tvashta’s daughter, was Aditya’s beloved wife. She was devoted to her husband. Chhaya was also Savitar’s daughter and her son was Shanaihshchara. ¹⁰⁰³ His sister was Vishti. She was extremely terrible and wicked in form. Savitar’s mind turned to the question, “Who will I bestow this daughter on?” Whenever Surya, the lord and preceptor of the worlds, wished to bestow her on someone, hearing that she was terrible, said, “What will I do with such a wife?” While this was going on, extremely unhappy, she spoke to her father. Vishti said, “If a father bestows his daughter on an extremely beautiful person while she is still a child, he is successful in this world. If he doesn’t do this, the father perpetrates a wicked deed. The father must undertake every effort to get his daughter married off after she is four years old, but certainly before she has completed her tenth year. The daughter must be bestowed on a groom who is prosperous, learned, young, famous and generous. He must be born in a good lineage and his father must be alive. If a father acts contrary to this, he always descends into hell. O Bhaskara! For the learned, a daughter is the means of accomplishing *dharma*. However, for a foolish person whose mind is overwhelmed by desire, she is also responsible for hell. In a balance, it is said that an excellent and ornamented daughter, free from blemishes, is on one side and the entire earth, with its mountains, forests and groves, is on the other. If a person sells his daughter, a cow or sesamum, nothing will be able to save him from Rourava and other hells. The task of marrying off a daughter must never be negated. If a father does not do this, who is capable of describing that sin? While the daughter does not show shame and while she still plays

with dust, she should be given away. If not, the father descends downwards. The son is the father's own form. The father is like the son. In this world, who acts so as to not make himself happy? Donations, rearing and worship that are done for the sake of a daughter are good deeds. However, when she is given away, that brings everlasting benefits. What is given to daughters at that time brings infinite merits. O Ravi! Who does not act so as to make his sons and grandsons happy? If a person acts for the sake of his daughters, he becomes prosperous." Addressed by his daughter, Vishti, in this way, Bhaskara replied to her. Surya said, "What will I do? Because your form is terrible, no one will accept you. Whether it is for a man or a woman, at the time of a matrimonial alliance, lineage, beauty, youth, riches, conduct and good behaviour are considered. O auspicious one! Except for your quality of beauty, we possess everything. What will I do? Who will I bestow you on? Why are you shaming me?" After saying this, Bhaskara spoke to Vishti again. Surya continued, "O Vishti! Please grant me permission. If you allow me, I will bestow you on whoever I can, today itself." Vishti replied to her father, "A husband, sons, riches, happiness, a long lifespan, beauty and joy, these are in accordance with what one has done earlier. Whatever be a living being's *karma*, whatever good or bad deeds the person has performed earlier, lead to fruits obtained by the being in a subsequent birth. The father must lovingly only avoid sins he commits. The fruits that result, depend on whatever has been done earlier. Therefore, in bestowing through a matrimonial alliance, a father must only consider what is appropriate for his own lineage. The rest is destiny. Whatever is going to happen, will happen." Tvashta heard the words of his daughter.'

'He bestowed his terrible daughter Vishti, who caused fear to the worlds, on Vishvarupa. Vishvarupa was also terrible and fierce in form. Thus, they were similar to each other in good, conduct, behaviour and beauty. Between the couple, on some occasions, there was love. On other occasions, there were differences. Their sons were Ganda, Atiganda, Raktaksha, Krodhana, Vyaya and Durmukha. The youngest was known as Harshana and this son was full of merits. He was good in conduct and extremely fortunate. He was serene, pure in intelligence and pure. On one occasion, he went to his

maternal uncle's house, to visit him. ¹⁰⁰⁴ He saw many beings, some in heaven and some miserable. He prostrated himself before his maternal uncle and asked him about eternal *dharma*. Harshana asked, "O father! ¹⁰⁰⁵ Who are the ones who are happy? Who are the ones who are being cooked in hell?" Asked in this way, Dharmaraja told him everything, accurately. He described everything about the course of *karma*. Yama replied, "Men who never violate what has been recommended, never see hell. Those who do not respect the sacred texts, those who do not possess good behaviour, those who are not extremely learned and those who violate what has been recommended, reside in hell." Hearing Dharmaraja's words, Harshana spoke again. Harshana said, "My father, Tvashta's son, ¹⁰⁰⁶ is terrible. My mother, Vishti, is terrible. O supreme among the gods! Please tell me about the tasks I must now undertake to make them and my brothers great-souled, serene in intelligence, extremely handsome and devoid of taints. How will they bestow what is auspicious? Otherwise, I will not go back to them." Thus addressed, Dharmaraja spoke to Harshana, who was pure in his intelligence. "You are Harshana. ¹⁰⁰⁷ There is no doubt about this. There may be many sons, but none among them may extend the lineage. But there may be a single son who holds up the lineage. The one who brings pleasure to his parents is the one who is the foundation of the lineage. A son who saves his ancestors is a true son, not one who acts otherwise. What you have asked me will also bring great joy to your maternal grandfather. ¹⁰⁰⁸ Go to Goutami. Restrain your mind and bathe there. With a tranquil and happy mind, praise Vishnu, the origin of the universe. If he is pleased with you, he will grant you everything that you wish for." Hearing Dharma's words, Harshana went to Goutami. He purified himself and praised Hari, the lord of the gods. Hari was pleased and bestowed everything fortunate on Harshana's lineage. "Let everything be fortunate. Let everything unfortunate be destroyed." Therefore, Vishti is known as Bhadraa. Since the father became fortunate, the sons are known as Bhadras. ¹⁰⁰⁹ Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Bhadra *tirtha*. Bhadrapati Hari is present there and bestows everything auspicious on men. If men frequent that *tirtha*, it

bestows every kind of success. The divinity Janaradana, the single ocean of everything auspicious, is himself present there.'

Chapter 2(96) (Patatri *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Patatri *tirtha* destroys disease and sins. As soon as a man hears about it, he becomes successful in his objective. Kashyapa had two sons—Aruna and the other was the lord of birds. ¹⁰¹⁰ Sampati was born in that lineage and Jatayu was younger to him. Tarkshya Prajapati’s sons were Aruna and Garuda. Sampati, supreme among birds, was born in that lineage. The famous Jatayu was born as his younger brother. Both of them were intoxicated of their own strength and sought to rival each other. They rose up into the sky, to bow down before the one who creates the day. ¹⁰¹¹ Those two excellent birds approached Surya. But their wings were burnt down. Exhausted, they fell down on the summit of the mountain. Aruna saw that his relatives had fallen down. They were immobile and had lost their senses. Overwhelmed by misery, he spoke to Bhaskara. “Those born in our lineage have had their wings burnt down. They have fallen down on earth. O one with the fierce rays! Comfort them. Otherwise, they will die.” Addressed in this way, the one who makes the day revived the two birds. Hearing about the state they had been reduced to, Garuda arrived there, along with Vishnu. O Narada! Having arrived, he comforted them and they were happy. To destroy the sin, all of them, Jatayu, Aruna, Sampati and Garuda, went to Ganga. To please them, Surya and Vishnu also went to the extremely sacred *tirtha*. Since then, that place has been known as Patatri *tirtha*. ¹⁰¹² It destroys poison and yields everything that is desired. Surya, Vishnu, Suparna and Aruna are themselves present there, on the northern bank of Goutami. Vrishadhva is also present there. Since the three divinities ¹⁰¹³ are present there, it is an excellent *tirtha*. If one purifies oneself and bathes there, prostrating oneself

before the gods, one is freed from all physical and mental ailments and obtains supreme happiness.'

Chapter 2(97) (Vipra Narayana *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There is a place known as Vipra *tirtha*. It is also known as Narayana *tirtha*. I will relate its account to you. It gives rise to great wonder. Listen. There was a brahmana in Antaravedi. ¹⁰¹⁴ The brahmana was accomplished in the Vedas. His sons were extremely wise and possessed qualities and beauty. Among them, the youngest brother was serene and he was surrounded by all the qualities. He was known as Asandiva. He was immensely intelligent and possessed every kind of learning. The father made efforts to get Asandiva married off. Meanwhile, at night, the brahmana’s son went to sleep without remembering Vishnu. He did not control himself and his head was facing the north. ¹⁰¹⁵ There was a terrible *rakshasa*, ¹⁰¹⁶ cruel in nature, who could assume any form she wanted. She swiftly seized him and went to the southern bank of Goutami. This was to the northern side of Shrigiri, a place frequented by many *brahmanas*. This city was an abode of *dharma*. It was Lakshmi’s abode. The king there was Brihatkirti and he possessed all the qualities of a *kshatriya*. The place was extremely peaceful and there were many kinds of alms to be obtained. At the end of the night, with the *brahmanas*’ son, she reached that place. The *rakshasi* reached that city. She always assumed a radiant and agreeable form. Assuming any form she willed, along with the brahmana, she roamed around the entire earth. In the region that was on the southern bank of Godavari, the terrible one assumed the form of an aged woman and spoke to the brahmana. The *rakshasi* said, “O best among *brahmanas*! This is Ganga and it is time for the *sandhya* rites. Along with the best of *brahmanas*, undertake them. If excellent *brahmanas* do not make efforts to perform the *sandhya* rites at the right time, lords among sages say that when their lives are over, they are born as the leaders of

antyajas. Tell them that I am your mother. If you do not do this now, you will be destroyed. O Indra among *brahmanas*! If you act in accordance with my words, I will do what brings you pleasure and make you happy. You will again reach your own home and country and meet your *guru*. I tell you truthfully.’ The bull among *brahmanas* asked, ‘Who are you?’ The *rakshasi* could assume any form at will. His senses were in a whirl. She developed his trust and took many pledges. She told the son of the leader among sages, “I am famous in this world under the name of Kankalini.” The brahmana replied, “I will do what you have asked me to do. There is no doubt that I will do and say what brings you pleasure.” Hearing the brahmana’s words, the *rakshasi*, who could assume any form at will, assumed a form that was pleasing in all its limbs. Though she was aged, she was adorned in celestial ornaments. She took the brahmana and roamed around everywhere. Everywhere, she said, “He is my son. He is an abode of qualities.” This is what she did and said. The brahmana possessed beauty, good fortune and youth and was adorned with learning. They took her to be his aged mother, who possessed all the qualities.’

‘There was a best among *brahmanas*. Honouring the *rakshasi*, he bestowed his daughter, adorned in ornaments, on the brahmana. Having obtained such a husband, the daughter thought that she was fortunate. However, the brahmana saw that his wife possessed all the qualities and was extremely miserable. The brahmana said, “This *rakshasi* is evil in nature. She may devour me. What will I do? Where will I go? Who will I tell this to? I confront a great calamity. Who will save me? My fortunate wife possesses beauty and qualities. This inauspicious *rakshasi* may devour her too.” Meanwhile, the aged woman, impossible to assail, had gone somewhere. His wife possessed all the qualities. The maiden was devoted to her husband and was confident about his love. She got to know that her husband was miserable. In private, she humbly spoke to him. The wife asked, “O husband! Why has this sorrow come upon you? Please tell me.” Gradually, he told his wife everything that had taken place earlier. To a beloved friend and a wife born in a noble lineage, what cannot be told? Hearing her husband’s words, the supreme among eloquent ones spoke to

him. The wife said, “If a person is not in control of himself, fear seizes him from every direction, even in his own home. If a person is in control of himself, what is there to fear, especially along the banks of Goutami? Those who are devoted to Vishnu reside here, those who are discriminating and non-attached. Purifying yourself and bathing here, praise the divinity, who bestows freedom from ailments.” Hearing this, he bathed in Ganga and was freed from his sins. On Goutami’s banks, the brahmana praised Narayana. The brahmana said, “You are inside the *atman* of the universe. O Mukunda! You are the creator, the preserver and the destroyer. You are the protector. O Narasimha! You are the protector of those who are distressed. If you do not protect, how can there be protection?’ Narayana is the one who counters the misery of the universe. Hearing his prayer, he used his radiant Sudarshana *chakra*, with one thousand edges, to slay the evil *rakshasi*. The lord gave him his desired boons and he reached his *guru* again. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Vipra *tirtha* and Narayana *tirtha*.¹⁰¹⁷ Through bathing, donations and worship performed there, one obtains the desired success.’

Chapter 2(98) (Bhanu *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘There is a *tirtha* named after Bhanu, Tvashta, Maheshvara, Indra, Yama and Agni. It destroys every kind of sin. There was a king known as Abhishtuta and he was handsome to behold. He started to worship the gods by performing a sacred horse sacrifice. There were sixteen officiating priests there. Vasishtha and Atri were the foremost. “When a *kshatriya* is performing the sacrifice, what should the sacrificial ground be like? When a brahmana has consecrated himself for a sacrifice, the king grants the land required for the sacrifice. However, when a king has consecrated himself for a sacrifice, who will give it to him? Who shall he ask? If he asks it from any of the *brahmanas*, that will give rise to a sin. In particular, how will a *kshatriya* then undertake the sacrifice?” In this way, the *brahmanas* discussed this amongst themselves. The immensely wise Vasishtha, supreme among those who knew about *dharma*, spoke. Vasishtha said, “When a king consecrates himself for a sacrifice, the land should be sought from Surya. ‘O god! O Savitar! Please grant me the land appropriate for undertaking a sacrifice to the gods. You are the divine *kshatriya*. You are also the brahmana. O lord of beings! I bow down before you.’¹⁰¹⁸ To undertake an auspicious sacrifice for the gods, the king should ask Savitar in this way. O king!¹⁰¹⁹ When you ask the lord Divakara in this way, he will give it to you.” Abhishtuta agreed to this. Full of devotion, he praised Divakara. He asked Ravi, the lord of the gods, who has Hari, Isha and Aja in his *atman*. The king said, “O Savitar! I bow down before you. Please grant me a sacrificial ground to undertake a sacrifice to the gods.” Surya is the divine *kshatriya*. He gave the lord of the earth the ground that was required. Savitar, the divinity who is the lord of the gods, said, “I will give.” If a person undertakes a sacrifice in this way, he never comes to any harm.

Thus, the horse sacrifice was performed by *brahmanas* who were accomplished in the Vedas. King Abhishtuta undertook the sacrifice and the place where Ravi gave the lord of the earth the land, for the sake of undertaking a sacrifice to the gods, is known as Bhanu *tirtha*. The excellent horse sacrifice was undertaken for the gods. The *daityas*, *danavas* and others who destroyed sacrifices also arrived there, disguising themselves in the garb of *brahmanas*. All of them recited the Sama hymns. Therefore, the immensely wise ones did not bar their entry. Some of the *asuras* criticized the ladles, the vessels, the rings on the sacrificial posts, the Sama hymns, the drinking of *soma*, the oblations, the officiating priests and the king. Some flung objects away. Others laughed.’

‘O sage! Other than Vishvarupa, no one got to know what they were attempting. Vishvarupa told his father, “These are *daityas*.” Hearing his son’s words, Tvashta spoke to the gods. Tvashta said, “Take water and *darbha* grass and sprinkle it in every direction. ‘All those who criticize the sacred sacrifice, the ladles and the *soma* are hereby removed by me.’ While you do the sprinkling, say this.” The large number of gods did what Tvashta had asked them to. All of them were reduced to ashes and fled. “Those extremely wicked ones have been slain by me.” Saying this, he sprinkled the water. At this, the angry *daityas* lost their lifespans and left the place where they had been stationed. The spot where Tvashta, the Prajapati of the worlds, sprinkled the water came to be known as Tvashta *tirtha*. It destroys every kind of sin. Yama slew the *daityas* who were dislodged as a result of Tvashta’s words. He angrily used his staff of destiny, his *chakra* and his noose of destiny. The spot where he killed the *daityas* came to be known as Yama *tirtha*. There was the spot where the sacrifice was completed and a lot of *amrita* was offered as oblation into the fire. That is the place where the bearer of oblations ¹⁰²⁰ was praised and pleased with the incessant flow of oblations, resembling a flight of arrows, at the great sacrifice. This came to be known as Agni *tirtha* and it yields the fruit of a horse sacrifice. Indra and the Maruts addressed the king in these auspicious words. “O king! In both the worlds, you will become a universal emperor. You will always be my beloved friend. There is no doubt about this.” If a person performs water-

rites at this Indra *tirtha*, in the mortal world, he is the one who is successful. In particular, to please the ancestors, water-rites must be performed in Yama *tirtha*. There is the spot where *brahmanas*, accomplished in all the rites, worshipped Shiva, full of devotion. This is known as Maheshvara *tirtha*. Maheshvara, who deserves worship, was worshipped with *mantras* from the Vedas and ordinary *mantras*, singing, dancing, the playing of musical instruments, the five articles of worship, ¹⁰²¹ many other objects, prostrating oneself on the ground, *dakshina*, incense, lamps, food, flowers, fragrances and scents. With single-minded attention, Vishnu, lord of the gods, and Shambhu were worshipped. The two lords of the gods were pleased and gave him powerful boons. Both of them granted King Abhishtuta objects of pleasure and emancipation. They also bestowed greatness on that excellent *tirtha*. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Vishnu *tirtha* and Shiva *tirtha*. Bathing and donating there, are known to yield everything that is wished for. If one remembers or reads about all these *tirthas*, one is freed from all sins and goes to the cities of Shiva and Vishnu. In particular, bathing in Bhanu *tirtha* yields every kind of success. In that extremely sacred *tirtha*, there are another one hundred *tirthas*.'

Chapter 2(99) (Bhilla *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Bhilla *tirtha* destroys ailments and destroys sins. It bestows devotion towards Mahadeva’s two lotus feet. O immensely intelligent one! The sacred account that transpired there is the following. Listen. Along Ganga’s southern bank, to the north of Shrigiri, Mahadeva is always present in the form of the *lingam* known as Adikesha. He is worshipped by the *rishis* and bestows everything that is desired. There was a sage known as Sindhudvipa and he was extremely devoted to *dharma*. His brother, Veda, was a supreme *rishi*. He would always faithfully worship Adikesha, the three-eyed divinity who was the enemy of Tripura. When the sun reached midday, the discriminating Veda would go to a village, in search of alms. Whenever that excellent brahmana went, a hunter, who was extremely devoted to *dharma*, would always go to that excellent mountain for a hunt. As he willed, he would wander around in different places, killing animals. Exhausted, the hunter would place a bit of meat on the tip of his bow and come to the place where the lord Adikesha Shiva was. He would place the meat outside. He would go to Ganga and take some water in his mouth. He would return to Shiva. He would devotedly take some leaves in one hand. In the other hand, he would devotedly offer the meat as *naivedya*.¹⁰²² The energetic Veda would have already arrived and worshipped Adikesha. He¹⁰²³ would kick away his offerings with his foot. Using the water in his mouth, he would bathe Shiva and worship the divinity with the leaves. He would offer the meat and say, “May Shiva be pleased with me.” He knew nothing else except this auspicious devotion to Shiva. After this, he would return to wherever he had come from, taking the remaining meat with him. He would come and go every day, going this. Nevertheless, Isha was satisfied with him. Ishvara’s

ways are wonderful. Until Bhilla ¹⁰²⁴ arrived, Shiva wouldn't be happy. Who is knowledgeable enough to measure the extent of Shiva's compassion towards his devotees? In this way, every day, he worshipped Adikesha Shiva, along with Uma. A long period of time passed.'

'Veda angrily exclaimed, "I worship Shiva in my wonderful way, with *mantras* and devotion. Which sinner destroys it? He deserves to be killed by me. If a person causes injury to a *guru*, a god, a brahmana, or a master, he deserves to be killed, even by a sage. That apart, if a man causes injury to Shiva, he deserves to be killed by everyone." Having decided this, the intelligent Veda, Sindhu's ¹⁰²⁵ younger brother, wondered. "Whose wicked act is this? Who is the evil-souled sinner? I perform worship with divine and wild flowers and auspicious roots, tubers and fruits. He destroys that and performs another worship with meat and the leaves of trees. He deserves to be killed by me. I will hide myself and see the sinner who worships Ishvara in this way." The intelligent one thought in this way. Meanwhile, as happened on earlier occasions, the hunter arrived there. When he worshipped in the usual way, Adikesha spoke to him. Adikesha said, "O hunter! O immensely intelligent one! Are you exhausted? You have come after a long time. O son! I am miserable without you. O son! I cannot find any happiness. Rest." Veda heard the divinity say this and saw. He was full of rage and wonder, but did not say anything. As he did every day, the hunter completed his worship and returned to his own abode. Full of anger, Veda approached Isha and spoke to him. Veda said, "This hunter is evil in his acts. He doesn't possess knowledge and doesn't know the rites. He is cruel and indulges in violence towards creatures. He is ruthless towards all beings. He belongs to an inferior class and is ignorant. In due order, he has not learnt from his *guru*. He always does what should not be done. He has not conquered the aggregate of the senses. However, you have shown yourself to him and do not say anything to me. O Isha! I am controlled in my vows and worship you according to the norms, using *mantras*. You are always my only refuge. I do not have a wife and sons. The hunter worships you with tainted meat. O illustrious one! Yet, you are pleased with him. This is extremely extraordinary. I will punish Bhilla, who acts in this

injurious way. Some are pleased with mild people. Others are pleased with evil-souled people. Therefore, there is no doubt that I will bring this rock down on your head.” When Veda said this, Isha laughed and spoke to him. Adikesha said, “Wait till tomorrow. After that, bring the rock down on my head.’ Agreeing to this, Veda used his hand to cast aside the rock. He controlled his rage and replied, ‘I will do it tomorrow.” When it was morning, he bathed and performed the other rites. As was customary, Veda performed the worship. He noticed a terrible flow of blood that had covered the *lingam*’s head. Veda was amazed. “What is this on the *lingam*’s head? This is a terrible omen. What does this mean?” He worried. He wiped it clean with clay, cow dung, *kusha* grass and water from Ganga. He then performed the worship, as he always did. Meanwhile, the hunter, free of blemishes, arrived there. He entered and saw Shankara Adikesha. He saw the wound on the *lingam*’s head, covered with blood. He saw and exclaimed, “What is this strange thing?” Saying this, he used sharp arrows to cut himself, one hundred times and one thousand times. “On seeing a master disfigured, which good person is capable of tolerating it?” He repeatedly reprimanded himself. “How could this have happened while I am alive? How has this calamity come to be? Alas! What kind of evil destiny is this?” Witnessing what he did, Mahadeva was greatly surprised. The illustrious one spoke to Veda, supreme among those who knew about the Vedas. Adikesha said, “O immensely intelligent one! Look at the hunter. He is full of true devotion. You touched my head with clay, *kusha* grass and water. O brahmana! But this one has offered himself up to me. Devotion, love and strength exist when there is discrimination. O supreme among *brahmanas*! That is the reason I bestow boons on him first and on you, later.” The divinity Maheshvara asked the hunter to choose whatever boon he wished for. The hunter told the lord of the gods, “Let your *nirmalya* be given to us. ¹⁰²⁶ O protector! Let this *tirtha* be named after me. As soon as this *tirtha* is remembered, let the fruits of all sacrifices be obtained.” The lord of the gods agreed. Since then, that excellent *tirtha* has been known as Bhilla *tirtha*. It destroys the cause behind every kind of sin. It generates great devotion towards the illustrious Mahadeva’s feet. Bathing and

donating there, yield instant objects of pleasure and emancipation. Shiva also bestowed many kinds of boons on Veda.'

Chapter 2(100) (Chakshu *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Chakshu *tirtha* bestows beauty and good fortune. On the southern bank of Goutami, the divinity Yogeshvara is present there. On the summit of a mountain, there was a city known as Bhouvana. The king there was named Bhouvana and he was devoted to the *dharma* of *kshatriyas*. In that excellent city, there was a brahmana named Vriddha-Koushika. His son was known as Goutama and he was supreme among those who were learned in the Vedas. However, because of his mother’s mental taints, this brahmana’s tendencies were contrary. His friend was a merchant, known as Manikundala. Their friendship was between unequals, between a brahmana and a *vaishya*. It was between a prosperous person and a poor one. However, they always wished each other’s welfare. On one occasion, Goutama spoke to the *vaishya* Manikundala, the lord of riches. In private, he affectionately addressed him repeatedly in these words. Goutama said, “To gather riches, we should go to the mountains and the oceans. Without articles that can give rise to pleasure, youth is futile. How can we exist without riches? Shame on a man who does not possess riches.” Kundala ¹⁰²⁷ told the brahmana, “My father has earned wealth. O supreme among *brahmanas*! What will I do with this great amount of wealth?” The brahmana again strongly urged Manikundala in these words. Goutama said, “If a person is satisfied with *dharma*, *artha*, *jnana* and *kama*, he is not praised. O friend! Embodied beings are praised only if they obtain excellence in these. Blessed creatures are those who live on the basis of their own enterprise. If one is satisfied with riches that have been given by others, it is a hard life. O Kundala! In this world, a son who does not desire what he has received from his ancestors and does not talk about it, is honoured by his parents and praised. In this world, a son who has earned

wealth through the strength of his own arms is successful. He does not touch his father's wealth. A son who earns riches himself and gives it to his father and relatives, is known as a true son. The others are like worms in the womb." Hearing the words of the greedy brahmana, he accepted these words. He swiftly collected his own jewels and riches and gave them to Goutama. He said, "With this wealth, as we will, we will travel in various lands. We will collect riches and wealth and return home again." The merchant said this truthfully. But the brahmana was a deceiver. The merchant did not understand that the brahmana was evil-souled, with wicked intentions. Without their fathers and mothers knowing, the two of them got together. For the sake of wealth, the merchant and the brahmana travelled from one land to another. The brahmana wished to steal the riches the merchant possessed. The brahmana said, "Through whatever means possible, I will take that wealth away. How wonderful is this earth, with its thousands of cities. Women are divinities of love and bestow whatever is wished for. Those enchanting ones are present in different places. What will I do? After carefully gathering some riches, if it is given to women, one can always enjoy oneself with them and life becomes truly successful. One can engage in singing and dancing and always be ornamented with courtesans. I will enjoy myself. But how will the *vaishya*'s riches come into my hands?" Goutama thought in this way. He laughed and spoke to Manikundala. "There is no doubt that creatures obtain prosperity, happiness and what they desire only through *adharma*. In this world, it is seen that creatures devoted to *dharma* always obtain a share of misery. Therefore, what purpose does *dharma* serve? It only leads to the fruit of unhappiness." The *vaishya* replied, "It is not like that. Happiness is based on *dharma*. Misery, fear, grief, poverty and hardships result from sin. Emancipation is based on *dharma*. If one follows one's own *dharma*, how can one be destroyed?" As they debated amongst themselves, it became an argument and they said, "Whichever person wins the debate, will win over the other person's riches. Let us ask—which side is stronger, the one with *dharma*, or the one with *adharma*?" "Material objects of this world are superior to the Vedas." "Wherever there is *dharma*, there is happiness." Arguing in this way, they

asked all the people—“Between *dharma* and *adharma*, which is more powerful on earth? Tell us what is accurate. Which is stronger?” Among them, some said, “Those who follow *dharma* experience misery. Wicked people are happy.” Defeated in this way, he handed over all his wealth to the brahmana.’

‘However, Maniman ¹⁰²⁸ was supreme among those who followed *dharma* and he praised *dharma* again. The brahmana asked Maniman, “Do you still praise *dharma*?” The *vaishya* said this was indeed the case and the brahmana spoke again. The brahmana said, “O *vaishya*! I have won over your wealth. Why do you still speak, without any sense of shame? Since I was victorious, *dharma* means doing whatever you wish to do.” Hearing the brahmana’s words, the *vaishya* smiled and spoke. The *vaishya* replied, “O friend! I think that those who do not have *dharma* are like shriveled grain among grain and small bees among those with wings. Among the four objectives of human existence, ¹⁰²⁹ *dharma* is mentioned first. *Artha* and *kama* are mentioned after that. Such *dharma* is present in me. O best among *brahmanas*! How can you say you have defeated me?” The *brahmanas* again told the *vaishya*, “Let our two hands be the stake.” The *vaishya* agreed to this. As was the case earlier, they went to people and asked. The brahmana said, “I am victorious.” He severed his two hands and asked, “What do you think of *dharma* now?” Thus reprimanded by the brahmana, the *vaishya* replied in these words. The *vaishya* said, “Even when my breath of life sticks in my throat, I will think that *dharma* is superior. For embodied beings, *dharma* is like a father, a mother and a well-wisher.” As a result of this dispute, the brahmana obtained wealth. The *vaishya* lost his riches and his two hands. Roaming around in this way, they reached Ganga and Yogeshvara Hari. O best among sages! Wandering around as they willed, they conversed again. The *vaishya* praised Ganga, Yogeshvara and *dharma*. Full of great rage, the brahmana again reprimanded the *vaishya* in the following words. The brahmana said, “Your riches have been lost. Your hands have been severed. All that is now left is your breath of life. If you still continue to speak in this perverse way, I will use this sword to slice off your head.” The *vaishya* laughed again and spoke to Goutama emphatically.

The *vaishya* said, “I think that *dharma* is supreme. Do what you want. A person who criticizes *brahmanas*, *gurus*, gods, the Vedas, *dharma* and Janardana is a sinner and should not be touched. He is an evil-doer and should be ignored. Such a person who abuses *dharma* is evil-souled and wicked in conduct.” At this, he angrily replied, “Since you still praise *dharma*, let our lives be the stake.” O sage! Addressed by Goutama in this way, the merchant agreed. As was the case earlier, they asked people and people said what they had said earlier. On Goutami’s southern bank, in front of Yogeshvara, the brahmana brought the *vaishya* down and plucked out his eyes. The brahmana said, “O *vaishya*! Since you have always praised *dharma*, you have been reduced to this state. You have lost your riches. You have lost your eyes. Your hands have been severed. O friend! I seek your permission to leave. Do not speak to me about this again.” When he had left, the *vaishya* thought about this in his mind. “Alas! O Hari! I have been single-mindedly devoted to *dharma*. What is this hardship that has befallen me?” Kundala, best among merchants, was without any wealth. He had lost his hands. He had lost his eyes. Full of grief, he remembered *dharma*. Seated on the ground, he thought about this in many kinds of ways. He made no attempt to move. He was without any enterprise. He had descended into an ocean of grief.’

‘On the eleventh lunar day in *shukla paksha*, when the day was over and the lunar disc had risen in the sky, Vibhishana arrived there. He followed the norms and worshipped the divinity Yogeshvara. Along with his son and surrounded by *rakshasas*, he bathed in Goutami Ganga. Vibhishana’s son was like a second Vibhishana. He was known as Vaibhishani. On seeing him, he spoke to him. The one who knew about *dharma* heard the *vaishya*’s words and got to know exactly what had happened. He reported this to his great-souled father, the lord of Lanka. The lord of Lanka spoke affectionately to his son, who was an ocean of qualities. Vibhishana said, “The illustrious Rama is my *guru*. His friend is known as Hanuman and is revered by me. Earlier, on a certain occasion, he brought a large mountain. That mountain was a store of all the herbs. When the task was over, he took it back to the Himalayas, to the place he had brought it from. The

immensely intelligent one brought *vishalyakarani* and *mritasanjivani* ¹⁰³⁰ and gave them to Rama, whose deeds are unsullied. When the occasion arose, he told him what could be achieved through those. When the task was over, he returned the mountain to the divine range. ¹⁰³¹ Remembering and establishing Hari in his heart, he brought it. That is how the extremely generous one brought what everyone wished for. When he speedily took *vishalyakarani* back again, a bit fell down on the banks of Goutami, at the place where Yogeshvara Hari is.” Vaibhishani answered, “O father! Without any delay, please show me where that herb is. In the three worlds, there is nothing better than alleviating the afflictions of someone else.” Vibhishana agreed to this and showed his son where it was. Out of love for the *vaishya*, the son said, “*ishetva*” ¹⁰³² and cut off the tree’s branch. The virtuous are always engaged in the welfare of others. Vibhishana said, “The powerful tree fell down on this mountain. Take its branch and place it on his heart. As soon as he is touched by it, he will regain his original form.” Hearing his father’s words, Vaibhishani, pervasive in his intelligence, did that and placed that piece of wood properly on the *vaishya*’s heart. Maniman got back his hands and eyes. Who is capable of understanding the power of *mantras* and herbs?’

‘He ¹⁰³³ took that piece of wood and remembered *dharma*. The *vaishya* bathed in Goutami Ganga and prostrated himself before Yogeshvara Hari. He again picked up that piece of wood and wandered around. He reached a king’s city, known as Mahapura. The extremely strong king was known as Maharaja. He did not have a son. He did have a *putrika*, ¹⁰³⁴ but she had lost her eyesight. He brought his daughter up like a son and took the following vow. “If a person restores my daughter’s sight, I will bestow my daughter and this kingdom on him—irrespective of whether that person is a god, a *danava*, a brahmana, a *kshatriya*, a *vaishya*, or one born as a shudra, and irrespective of whether he possesses qualities, or does not possess qualities.” This is the announcement the king made. Night and day, the *vaishya* heard this announcement and spoke. The *vaishya* said, “There is no doubt that I will restore the sight of the princess.” They quickly seized the *vaishya* and presented him before Maharaja. As soon as she was touched by

that piece of wood, the princess got back her eyesight. The king was astounded and asked, “Who are you?” The *vaishya* accurately reported to the king all that had happened. The *vaishya* said, “I possess this kind of power because of the favours of *brahmanas*, *dharma* and austerities, the strength of donating many and various kinds of *dakshina* and the energy of this divine herb.” Hearing the *vaishya*’s words, the lord of the earth was amazed. The king exclaimed, “Such a great person is almost like a god. Otherwise, how can he display such kinds of powers? I will bestow my daughter and this kingdom on him.” Having made up his mind, he gave him his daughter and the kingdom.’

‘On one occasion, he ¹⁰³⁵ went out to amuse himself and was filled with great distress. “Without a friend, what does this kingdom mean? Without a friend, how can there be happiness?” The *vaishya*’s son started to constantly think about the brahmana. Among those with bodies, this is a sign of nobility of birth. Their minds are always moist with compassion, even towards those who cause injury. When Maharaja left for the forest, Manikundala became the king. On one occasion, while he was ruling over the kingdom, he saw the brahmana Goutama. Manikundala saw him. All his wealth had been taken away by evil gamblers. Since he knew about *dharma*, he took his brahmana friend with him and honoured him. He told him everything about *dharma*’s powers. For the removal of all the sins, he made him bathe in Ganga. Along with all those who were born in their own *gotras*, and all the *brahmanas* and relatives who were born in their own country, with Vriddha-Koushika as the chief, the *vaishya* and the *brahmanas* performed a sacrifice near Yogeshvara. They worshipped the gods and went to heaven. Since then, that tirtha has been known as Mritasanjivani *tirtha*, Chakshu ¹⁰³⁶ *tirtha* and Yogeshvara *tirtha*. Even if one remembers it, everything auspicious is obtained. It brings delight to the mind and destroys every kind of misery.’

Chapter 2(101) (Urvashi *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘The place known as Urvashi *tirtha* yields the fruits of a horse sacrifice, if bathing, donations and the worship of Mahadeva and Vasudeva are performed there. The divinity there is Maheshvara and Hari is in the form of Sharngadhara. ¹⁰³⁷ There was a king named Pramati. He was powerful and a universal emperor. He defeated his enemies and quickly went to Indra’s world, surrounded by the gods. O Narada! He saw the lord of the gods there, along with the Maruts. Pramati, bull among *kshatriyas*, laughed at Indra, who held dice in his hand. On noticing that he was laughing, Hari ¹⁰³⁸ spoke to Pramati. Indra said, “O immensely intelligent one! This is the abode of the gods, where the Maruts play. Having conquered the directions, you have reached heaven. Come and play with me.” King Pramati heard Hari’s biting words. He agreed and replied, “O Indra of the gods! What do you think should be the stake?” Hearing Pramati’s words, the lords of the gods spoke to the king. Indra replied, “Urvashi is our stake. She can only be obtained through all kinds of sacrifices. I think that Urvashi should be my stake. O king! What do you think should be yours?” Hearing Indra’s words, Pramati proudly replied, “O lord of the gods! O Shatakratu! I will offer as a stake whatever you think is appropriate.” Indra told Pramati, “Your right hand will be your stake, along with your armour, arrows and *dharma*. Give me that as stake and let us play.” Pledging these stakes, they started to gamble. Pramati won Urvashi, the celestial lady. Having won her, Pramati arrogantly spoke to Shatakratu. Pramati said, “O lord! Offer something else as stake and I will play with you again.” Indra replied, “This *vajra* is worthy of the gods. I will offer this and the excellent chariot, Jaitra, ¹⁰³⁹ as a stake. O king! Without thinking about it, I will play with you, with your hand as a stake.” Pramati laughed.

He seized the unmatched dice, decorated with jewels, and said, “O Shakra! I have won.” Meanwhile, the great lord of the *gandharvas* arrived there. He was known as Vishvavasu and he was skilled in playing with the dice. Vishvavasu said, “O king! Using the knowledge of the *gandharvas*, I will play with you.” The king agreed and replied, “I have won.” After defeating both of them, the foolish king addressed Indra of the gods in these sinful words. Pramati said, “O Mahendra! Whether it is in a battle, or whether it is in gambling, you will never be victorious. Therefore, worship me. Tell me. How did you become Indra of the gods?” He proudly told Urvashi, “Go and become a servant-maid.” Urvashi replied, “I will behave towards you just as I behave towards the gods. In none of your sentiments, should you try to shame me.” Pramati told her, “I have servant-maids like you. O fortunate one! Why are you ashamed? Go and become a servant-maid.” There was a lord of the *gandharvas*, known as Chitrasena. He was the powerful son of Vishvavasu and he heard the king’s words. Chitrasena said, “O king! O lord of the earth! I will play with you with all these as stake, the kingdom and life, both yours and mine.” Chitrasena and the excellent king agreed to this and played, full of great anger. Chitrasena won. He bound the king up in the great noose of the *gandharvas*. Chitrasena won back everything, Urvashi, the kingdom, the treasury, the army and everything else. All of Pramati’s riches now became Chitrasena’s.’

‘His son was a child and spoke to the immensely wise and energetic priest Madhucchanda, descended from Vishvamitra’s lineage. Pramati’s son asked, “What sin has my immensely intelligent father committed? Why has he been bound? How can he regain his own status? How can he be freed from the bondage?” Hearing Sumati’s ¹⁰⁴⁰ words, the excellent sage meditated. Madhucchanda told him about where Pramati was.

Madhucchanda said, “O immensely intelligent one! Your father has been bound in the world of the gods. There are many taints associated with gambling. He has been dislodged from his kingdom. Anyone who goes to an assembly of gamblers suffers from hardships. O son of a king! There are taints associated with gambling, drinking and eating flesh. Evil-souled people always develop sins from these. Each one of these leads to what is

undesirable, sin and hell. Desiring vehicles, seats and other things, gamblers indulge in such things, even if they have been born in noble lineages. They love the resultant quarrels. What need be said about ordinary people who are gamblers? The wife of a gambler is always tormented. The sinful gambler looks at his wife and is also tormented. Bereft of all pleasure, the evil-doer looks at her and always says, ‘Alas! In this wheel of *samsara*, there is no sinner who is my equal. In this world, I do not obtain the slightest bit of pleasure from material objects. In the two worlds, no gambler is ever seen to be happy. It is evident that he is always ashamed and his mind is scorched. He loses his *dharma*. He is devoid of happiness. He wanders around, with all his pride gone. For those who are *brahmanas*, any profession other than gambling is praised. Even agriculture, animal husbandry and trade are permissible, but no gambling. Anyone who wishes to lose his riches should resort to gambling as a profession.’ People who strive for *dharma*, *artha* and *kama* are deprived of all manliness. It is an activity that is condemned in the Vedas, but your father has accepted it. O son! Therefore, what shall we do? We will do what you say. Which learned person can deviate from the path determined by the one who ordains?”

Hearing the priest’s words, Sumati replied. Sumati said, “What must my father, Pramati, do to get back his kingdom again?” Madhuchhanda meditated again and addressed Sumati in these words. “O child! Go to Goutami and worship Shankara, Aditi, Varuna and Vishnu. He will then be freed from his bondage.” Agreeing to this, he quickly went to Ganga and prostrated himself before Janardana. He worshipped Shambhu. He was controlled in his vows and tormented himself through austerities. His father was in bondage for one thousand years. After this, he was released from the gods and got his kingdom back again. Because of Shiva and Isha ¹⁰⁴¹ and because of what his own son had done, he was freed from his bondage. He obtained the knowledge of the *gandharvas* and was loved by Shatakratu. Since then, that *tirtha* has been known as Shambhu *tirtha*, Vishnu *tirtha*, Urvashi *tirtha* and the *tirtha* of gamblers. What cannot be obtained through the favours of Shiva, Vishnu and the mother of the rivers? Bathing and

donating there, yield many kinds of auspicious fruits. One is freed from the bondage of sins and all kinds of calamities are destroyed.'

Chapter 2(102) (Godavari reaches the ocean)

Brahma said, ‘There is a place known as Samudra *tirtha*.¹⁰⁴² It yields the fruits of all the *tirthas*. I will tell you about its nature. O Narada! Listen attentively. Released by Goutama, Ganga, the destroyer of sins, flowed towards the ocean, for the sake of ensuring the welfare of the worlds. When she was proceeding, the divine river was held in a *kamandalu* by me. Shambhu, the *paramatman*, held the goddess in his matted hair. She originated from Vishnu’s feet and was brought down to the world of the mortals by the great-souled brahmana. When she is remembered, she destroys sins. She is greater than the greatest. On seeing her, the ocean wondered. “She deserves to be worshipped. She is the goddess of the universe. She is worshipped by Brahma, Isha and others. If I do not advance and welcome her, I will be tainted by *adharma*. When a great-souled one arrives, if a person is deluded and does not advance to welcome, he becomes a sinner in both the worlds and no one can save him.” Thinking this, the lord of jewels assumed an embodied form. The lord of the rivers joined his hands in salutation and spoke to Ganga. The ocean said, “I will not say anything. Let the water that is in the nether regions, on earth and in the firmament enter me. There are jewels, *amrita*, mountains, *rakshasas* and gods inside me. I hold many other terrible things too. Along with Kamala,¹⁰⁴³ Vishnu always sleeps in me. In the world of mobile and immobile objects, there is nothing that is impossible for me. When a great person arrives, out of insolence, if a person does not rise up in welcome, he is dislodged from *dharma* and other things and goes to hell. Except for being subdued by Agastya,¹⁰⁴⁴ I do not have any fear or regret. What need be said about someone like you, more glorious than all of them? O goddess Ganga! I am speaking to you. Peacefully, merge into me. But if you come in a

single form, I cannot bear it. There can be a confluence if you merge into me in many different forms. O goddess! That is the way a confluence can take place, not otherwise. O Ganga! Therefore, one should consider the confluence in many different forms.” Addressed in this way, Ganga replied to the ocean, the lord of the waters. The goddess Goutami said, “Act in accordance with my words. Bring the wives of the *saptarshis*, with Arundhati ¹⁰⁴⁵ at the forefront, here, along with their husbands. Bring them here and I will assume a small form. The confluence with you can then take place.” Agreeing to this, he brought the *saptarshis* and their wives. Surrounded by the *rishis*, the goddess divided herself into seven streams. In seven flows, Goutami Ganga merged into the ocean. Those seven flows of Ganga were named after the seven *rishis*. Bathing and donating there, donations, devotedly reading and hearing about it and remembering it, bring all the desired auspicious fruits. In the three worlds, there is no place superior to Samudra *tirtha*. It destroys sins and bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation. It brings delight to the mind.’

Chapter 2(103) (Bhimeshvara *tirtha*)

Brahma said, ‘O Narada! There is a place named after the sacrifice of the *rishis*. The seven *rishis* sat down to perform austerities there, in the place where Bhimeshvara Shiva exists. ¹⁰⁴⁶ In this connection, I will tell you the account about the gods, the *rishis* and the ancestors. Listen attentively. I will tell you about an auspicious account that bestows everything that is desired. After the seven *rishis*, Ganga divided herself into seven flows. O Narada! Vasishthi was to the south. Vishvamitri was to its north. The next one is known as Vamadevi. The auspicious Goutami is in the middle. Another one is known as Bharadvaji. Atreyi was next. Jamadagni was the last. These were the seven flows. All those great-souled *rishis* performed a sacrifice together. Those accomplished *rishis* undertook a great sacrifice.’

‘The gods had a powerful enemy, known as Vishvarupa. While this was going on, he arrived at the sacrifice undertaken by the sages. Following the norms, he observed *brahmacharya*, austerities and worship. Humbly, and in due order, he spoke to all the *rishis*. Vishvarupa said, “For the sake of my welfare, all of you must certainly do what I wish. Let me have a powerful son, whom even the gods will find to be invincible. O sages! Please tell me whether this can be accomplished through sacrifices or austerities.” The immensely intelligent and great-minded Vishvamitra spoke to him.

Vishvamitra said, “O son! Many kinds of fruits are obtained through *karma*. ¹⁰⁴⁷ There are three causes. The first cause is the *karma* itself. The second cause is the agent who undertakes the *karma*. The motive is said to be the third cause. The learned know that *karma* alone is not the seed. While *karma* is a cause, there are other causes too. The fruits depend on their presence or absence. But fruits are dependent on *karma*. Know that there are two types of *karma*—that which is being done and that which has

already been done. When one does what should be done, that has been spoken of as a means. However, *karma* becomes successful because of the motive. Hence, both these are causes. Therefore, a discriminating being undertakes *karma* according to the motive. The fruits are said to be according to the motive. If one undertakes *karma* in the proper way, but the motive is absent, the fruits are perverse. Everything depends on the motive. Therefore, the fruits that austerities, vows, donations, *japa*, sacrifices and other rites bestow, depends on the motive. *Karma* yields fruits according to the motive. Know that there are three kinds of motive—based on *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*. Accordingly, the fruits follow *karma*. Depending on the quality of the motive, *karma* has wonderful forms. Therefore, an accomplished person will decide on his motive according to his wishes. Thereafter, when the required *karma* is undertaken, it yields the appropriate fruits. If fruits are meant to be given, the one who bestows fruits grants the corresponding fruits. There is nothing for the agent to do, except undertake the *karma* naturally. The motive varies, according to *sattva* and the other *gunas*. Motive initiates it and fruits are dependent on the motive. *Karma* is the cause behind *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*. *Karma*, determined by motive, is responsible for both emancipation and bondage. In this world and in the next world, *karma* follows a person's natural qualities. Accordingly, many different kinds of fruits swiftly manifest themselves. Because of differences in motives, an object can appear differently. What is enjoyed and what is done is distinguished according to the motive. If you undertake *karma* according to the right motive, you will obtain what you wish for.” Hearing the words of the intelligent *rishi*, Vishvamitra, for a long period of time, he tormented himself through austerities. However, his motive was that of *tamas*. Vishvarupa undertook terrible *karma*, terrifying even to the gods. The best among the *rishis* saw him and constantly tried to restrain him. However, he followed his own internal rage and undertook that terrible *karma*. He dug up a terrible pit and ignited a terrible fire. In the cavity of his heart, he meditated on a terrible and fierce being. On witnessing that he was tormenting himself, an invisible voice spoke. “O Vishvarupa! Leaving aside your matted hair, offer yourself as an oblation into the fire. You will

have a son who will be just like you. He will be Indra. He will be Varuna. He will be everything. Leaving aside your matted hair, offer yourself as an oblation. From that sin, he will be born as a sinner. He is the one mentioned in the Vedas as Vritra. Who knows about the ferocity and greatness of the lord of the universe? He creates everything, but is not touched by anything.” The voice recited this and stopped. The lords among sages bowed down to Bhimeshvara and returned to their own hermitages. Vishvarupa was extremely terrible. His form was as terrible as his deeds. His motive was terrible. His body was terrible. He meditated and offered himself as an oblation. Therefore, in the Puranas, one reads about the divinity as Bhimeshvara. ¹⁰⁴⁸ There is no doubt that bathing and donating there, bestows emancipation. A person should read and hear it devotedly. He should prostrate himself before Shiva, the lord of the gods, who has a terrible form there. He is known as the one who destroys every kind of sin as soon as the refuge of his feet are remembered. He is the one who bestows emancipation. Godavari is the one who destroys all sins. She bestows the supreme objective. This is true everywhere, but is especially true at the place where she merges into the ocean. If an embodied being bathes at the confluence of Godavari with the ocean, he become a performer of good deeds. He saves his ancestors from all the terrible hells and goes to the city of Tripura’s enemy. Bhimanatha ¹⁰⁴⁹ is indeed the *brahman* itself, worshipped and known through *Vedanta*. If one sees him, an embodied being is never submerged in the misery of *samsara* again.’

Chapter 2(104) (Confluence of Ganga and the ocean)

Brahma said, ‘Ganga deserves to be worshipped by the gods. She merged into the eastern ocean. She was followed by all the gods and praised by all the sages—Vasishtha, Jabali, Yajnavalkya, Kratu, Angiras, Daksha, Marichi, Vaishnavas, ¹⁰⁵⁰ Shatatapa, Shounaka, Devarata, Bhrigu, Agniveshya, Atri, Marichi, ¹⁰⁵¹ Daksha, ¹⁰⁵² Manu, Goutama, Koushika, Tumbaru, Parvata and others who had cleansed their sins. There were Agastya, Markanda, Pippala, Galava and others who were devoted to yoga. There were Vamadeva, Angirasa and Bhargavas, who were wise in their knowledge of the pleasant *shruti* and *smriti* texts. All of them knew the meanings of the Puranas. They knew a lot and followed Goutami, the divine river. They praised her, with many *mantras* from the *shruti* texts. As they praised her, they were cheerful in their minds. On seeing that she had merged, Shiva and Hari showed themselves to the sages. While the immortals and ancestors watched, those two gods, who dispelled the afflictions of everyone, were praised. The Adityas, the Vasus, the Rudras, the Maruts and the guardians of the worlds—all of them joined their hands in salutation and praised Hari and Shankara. O Narada! Those two gods are always present in the seven confluences. They are always established in the confluence of Ganga with the ocean. The divinity Maheshvara is known as Goutameshvara there. ¹⁰⁵³ Along with Rama, ¹⁰⁵⁴ Madhava is always present there. For the welfare of the worlds and for my own reason, I established Shiva in the place known as Brahmeshvara. Along with the gods, I praised the one known as Chakrapani. ¹⁰⁵⁵ Vishnu is present there, along with the gods and large numbers of Maruts. In the place known as Aindra *tirtha*, the divinity is present as Hayamurdha. ¹⁰⁵⁶ The gods are also present where Vishnu has the

form of Hayamurdha. Someshvara Shiva is present in the place known as Soma *tirtha*. For the sake of Indra, who is famous for *soma*, the gods and the *rishis* prayed to Soma—*indrayendo pari srava*.¹⁰⁵⁷ “There are many suns in the seven directions. There are seven *hotris* and officiating priests. There are seven gods, the Adityas. O Soma! Protect us. Flow Indu¹⁰⁵⁸, for the sake of Indra. O King Soma! Protect us with this oblation. It has been prepared for you. Let enemies not be able to destroy us, nor anything that belongs to us. Flow Indu, for the sake of Indra. O sage Kashyapa! Raise up your voice, with the *mantras* in the *suktas* composed by the *rishis*. In the sacrifice, bow down to Soma, the lord of the herbs. Flow Indu, for the sake of Indra. I am the artisan.¹⁰⁵⁹ I am the physician. I am the one who lays down the measure. With many kinds of intelligence, we are like cows for the earth. Flow Indu, for the sake of Indra.” The *rishis* spoke in this way and obtained some for the wielder of the *vajra*. When they gave it to him, Shatakratu’s sacrifice was completed.’

‘Since then, that place has been known as Soma *tirtha* and Agni *tirtha* is in front of it. Agni performed great sacrifices and worshipped me, obtaining what his mind wished for. Through my favours, he obtained it. I am always present there. For the welfare of the worlds, Vishnu and Shiva are also present there. Therefore, it is named after Agni. Aditya *tirtha* is beyond this. The one who is the form of the Vedas is always worshipped there. Assuming a different form, he arrives there at midday, to see me, Shankara and Hari. Therefore, at midday, everyone should always be bowed down to. That is because one doesn’t know what form Savitar will assume when he arrives. Therefore, it is named after Aditya. Brihaspati *tirtha* is after that. Brihaspati was worshipped by the gods there. That is the reason it has this name. He also performed many sacrifices there. That is the reason it is named after Brihaspati. As soon as one remembers that *tirtha*, the adverse planets are pacified. There is another *tirtha* on the excellent mountain of Indragopa. For a different reason, a great *lingam* was established there by the Himalayas. That *tirtha* is known as Adri *tirtha*.¹⁰⁶⁰ Bathing and donating there, yield all the auspicious desires. In this way, Goutami Ganga originated from Brahmagiri. As she proceeded towards the ocean, I have

briefly mentioned a few of the *tirthas*. They are auspicious and possess many secrets. Goutami is famous in the Vedas and the Puranas and the worlds and the *rishis* bow down to her. O Narada! Who is capable of describing her powers completely? Who has that strength? If one devotedly tries and something is left out, there is no offence in that. There is no doubt about this. For the welfare of the worlds, I have sought to give some indications. Which lord is capable of describing her powers in every *tirtha*? Perhaps Vishnu, Lakshmi's consort, or Someshvara Shiva might be able to. O immensely wise one! Over the course of time, some *tirthas*, sometimes, come to possess qualities for men. But Goutami always has these. She is always sacred, everywhere. Who is capable of describing and recounting her qualities? Therefore, it is appropriate that one should prostrate oneself before her.'

Chapter 2(105) (Benefits of listening to Ganga *mahatmya*)

Narada said, ‘O lord of the gods! O master of the gods! You have said that Ganga has three presiding divinities. The auspicious one was brought down by a brahmana. The sacred one purifies the universe. O supreme among the gods! In the beginning, in the middle and in the end, along both banks of the river, she is pervaded by Vishnu, Isha and you. I have still not obtained satisfaction. Please tell me again, briefly.’

Brahma replied, ‘She was originally in the *kamandalu*. She then flowed from Vishnu’s feet. She was next stationed in Maheshvara’s matted hair and is bowed down to. Because of the energy and power of the brahmana and because Shiva was carefully worshipped, she reached the sacred mountain and flowed towards the eastern ocean, where the goddess reached and merged. She has all the *tirthas* and bestows what men desire. Her powers are special. In the three worlds, I do not think that there is any superior *tirtha*. Through her powers, any wish of the mind can be satisfied. Till today, no one has been able to describe her greatness. She is the supreme *brahman* that one devotedly speaks about. It is my view that there is no *tirtha* superior to her. If one mentions her in conjunction with any other *tirtha*, that won’t be *dharma*. My words, which describe her qualities, are like *amrita*. After hearing those words, why doesn’t everyone’s intelligence turn towards what is beneficial? O sage! In the three worlds, this is indeed a great wonder.’

Narada said, ‘You know about *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha* are the one who can instruct. The Vedas and their mysteries, the smriti texts, the *dharma shastra* texts and everything else has a foundation in your words. O lord! Among *tirthas*, donations, sacrifices, austerities, divinities, *mantras*

and service, what is best? Please tell me. O illustrious one! Whatever you faithfully say must be true. It cannot but be otherwise. O Brahma! I have a doubt and you should use your words to sever it.'

Hearing what was in his mind, Brahma was surprised.

Brahma replied, 'O Narada! Listen. I will tell you about the supreme mystery of *dharma*. There are four kinds of *tirthas*. There are also four *yuga*. There are three *gunas*. There are three beings who are the eternal divinities. It is said that the Vedas and the *smriti* texts are four. The objectives of human existence are four. There are four kinds of speech. ¹⁰⁶¹ O Narada! Along with *samatva*, ¹⁰⁶² the *gunas* are also four. Because *dharma* is eternal, *dharma* generally exists everywhere. There are many kinds of views about what one should try to achieve and about how those can be achieved. These always depend on two kinds of things, the time and the place. Depending on the time and the place, *dharma* is always enhanced, or diminished. Depending on the nature of the *yuga*, it diminishes by one quarter. ¹⁰⁶³ O immensely wise one! *Dharma* depends on both, the time and the place. Even when *dharma* is a function of time, it can be firmly established in the place. Thus, though it is diminished with the *yuga*, it does not decay because of the place. If both are absent, *dharma* becomes non-existent. When *dharma* is firmly established in the place, it possesses all its four quarters. That is the reason *dharma* exists in places that assume the form of *tirthas*. When it is *krita yuga*, *dharma* has the foundation of both time and place. In *treta yuga*, *dharma* loses one of its quarters, but can find it in a specific place. In *dvapara*, only half of what is due to time is left, but *dharma* can find that in the place. With a single quarter left in *kali*, *dharma* wavers and faces a difficulty. However, even when this happens, for those who know, *dharma* does not diminish. Depending on the nature of the *yuga*, there are differences in how it is established. The qualities and the qualities of the agents differ. Therefore, the way *dharma* is established is wonderful. *Tirthas*, *varnas*, Vedas, heaven and *moksha* have increased or diminished powers, depending on the qualities. Depending on their nature and inclination, *dharma* is distinguished. Time is spoken of as the one who causes the manifestation.

The place is what is manifested. O brahmana! When time is the one who causes the manifestation, its foundation is accordingly established. There is no doubt about this. The forms of the gods and the Vedas are appropriate to the *yuga*. This is also true of *karma*, *tirtha*, *jati* and *ashrama*. In *satya yuga*, people worship a *tirtha* where all three divinities are present. In *treta yuga*, a *tirtha* with two of the divinities present is worshipped. In *dvapara yuga*, a *tirtha* with one divinity present is worshipped. It should be known that there is nothing like this in *kali yuga*. However, listen to something else. In *krita yuga*, a *tirtha* is known to belong to the gods. In *treta yuga*, it is known to belong to the *asuras*. In *dvapara yuga*, it is said to belong to the *rishis*. In *kali yuga*, it is said to belong to humans. O Narada! I will tell you about another reason for this. Listen. You have asked me about Goutami and I will describe it to you in detail.'

'O great sage! Ever since Ganga reached Hara's head, Shambhu started to love Ganga the most. Uma is the goddess of the three worlds. She is the mother who is engaged in the welfare of the universe. She is spoken of as the serene *shruti* texts. She is the one who bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation. She got to know what was in the god's mind and spoke to Gajavaktra. ¹⁰⁶⁴ Hearing his mother's words, Gajavaktra spoke to her. Gajavaktra asked, "O mother! What needs to be done? Please instruct me and there is no doubt that I will do it." Uma told her son, "Ganga is established in Maheshvara's matted hair and Isha has truly come to love her a lot. She needs to be brought down. O son! It is strange that Isha is also always present there. The gods, the eternal Vedas, all the *rishis*, men and ancestors also reside wherever Shiva is. Therefore, Ishana Mahadeva, the lord of the gods, must be made to return. When the divinity withdraws from Ganga, everyone else will also withdraw. Listen to my words. In every possible way, Shankara must be made to withdraw from her." Hearing his mother's words, Ganeshvara spoke again. Ganeshvara replied, "I am not capable of making the divinity Shiva withdraw. As long as Shiva does not withdraw, the gods are also incapable of withdrawing. O mother of the universe! There is another reason too. Earlier, the great-souled Goutama *rishi* made Ganga descend, to ensure the welfare of the three worlds. She

was worshipped by the worlds. Following your words, I suggested the means. Full of energy, the brahmana worshipped the lord of the gods, using austerities. He praised Bhava. Pleased, Shankara spoke to Goutama. Shankara said, ‘O immensely intelligent one! Choose a sacred boon. Ask for whatever is loved and desired by your mind. Today, I will give you everything that you wish for.’ When Shiva said this, while I listened, Goutama replied. ‘O Shankara! Give me the one who is in your matted hair. I ask for the auspicious Ganga. What will I do with any other boon?’ Shambhu, who ensures the welfare of all the worlds, spoke again. Shambhu said, ‘You have not asked anything for yourself. Ask for something that is extremely difficult to obtain.’ Indomitable in spirit, Goutama joined his hands in salutation and spoke to Bhava. ¹⁰⁶⁵ Goutama said, ‘Amongst everything, the most difficult thing is to see you. O Shankara! Through your favours, I have been able to achieve that today. As soon as they remember your feet, learned people become successful in their objectives. O Maheshvara! What need be said when you have been directly seen?’ Addressed by Goutama in this way, Bhava was filled with delight. ‘O immensely intelligent one! You asked for this for the welfare of the three worlds. Ask something for your own self.’ Shiva told the brahmana this. Addressed again in this way, the brahmana thought and spoke to Shiva. He was not depressed in spirit. He spoke humbly full of devotion towards Shiva. He again asked for the welfare of all the worlds. While the guardians of the worlds heard, Goutama spoke. Goutama said, ‘O Vrishadvaja! The goddess has been released from Brahmagiri. As she proceeds towards the ocean, you must always be present everywhere. O lord of the universe! For those who desire fruits, you alone are the one who bestows fruits. O lord of the gods! The other *tirthas* are only auspicious in certain places. But the places where you exist are known to always bestow what is auspicious. You have handed over Ganga, who was located in the crown of your matted hair. O Shankara! You are always present with her and every such place is a *tirtha*.’ Hearing Goutama’s words, Shiva happily spoke to him again. Shiva said, ‘O Goutama! Any person can give anything anywhere, as long as he is full of devotion. He may go on pilgrimages, bathe, donate and offer water-

rites to the ancestors. He may hear, read and remember. As long as a man is controlled in his vows and faithfully does this along the Godavari, he obtains *dharma* equivalent to the *dharma* obtained by donating the entire earth, with its seven *dvipas*, mountains, groves, forests, jewels, herbs and beautiful oceans. He is adorned with equivalent *dharma*. This is said to be the *dharma* associated with Goutami. O brahmana! Near the river Godavari, the ground is like that. At the time of a solar or lunar eclipse, a learned man may be controlled in his vows, in my presence. He may devotedly donate a beautiful cow, along with her calf, to a brahmana¹⁰⁶⁶ or to Vishnu, at a confluence that is famous in the world. O best among *brahmanas*! A person who donates in this way obtains good merits. However, Goutami is a great river, worshipped by the universe. If a man bathes and donates along her, he obtains superior good merits. Therefore, brought by you, Godavari Ganga will destroy every kind of sin and bestow everything that is desired.’ O mother! I heard Shiva tell Goutama this. This is the reason why Shambhu is always present near Ganga. O mother! Who is capable of making that ocean of compassion return? O mother! However, it can still be achieved. Because of the noose of impediments, men may be bound. They will not go to Godavari, even though she is nearby. They will not prostrate themselves before the divinity Shiva. They will not remember and praise him. O mother! So as to satisfy you, that is what I will do. Please pardon my words. But if one doesn’t do what you say, there is hardship.’ Since then, Vighnesha creates some impediments for men. However, ignoring the impediments, if a person devotedly goes to Goutami and performs the worship, he is successful in this world and nothing else remains for him to do. If a worst among men desires to leave his house, many kinds of impediments present themselves. However, if he places them on his head and firmly steps towards going to Ganga, what fruits cannot be achieved? Baring Shiva himself, who is capable of describing her powers?’”

‘Following the steps indicated in *itihasa*, I have briefly described them. In this world of mobile and immobile objects, there are methods for achieving *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*. All of them have been described in detail in *itihasa*. It has brought together everything stated in the

Vedas and in the *smriti* texts. The mysteries and the reasons are always described. For the welfare of the universe, this has been properly stated and described in this Purana, who is full of many kinds of *dharma*. If a person faithfully reads or hears one of its *shlokas* or one of its lines and pronounces the words “O Ganga! O Ganga!” he obtains everything auspicious. It has the capacity to destroy the impurities of *kali yuga*. It brings every kind of success. It is sacred and auspicious. If one utters the excellent word, “Ganga”, worshipped by the universe, one obtains every fruit that is desired. O Goutama! O fortunate one! You have done well. Who else is your equal? You are the one who lovingly brought Ganga to Dandaka forest. Even if a person utters the words “O Ganga! O Ganga!” from a distance that is one hundred *yojanas* away, he is freed from all sins and goes to Vishnu’s world. In the three worlds, the number of *tirthas* is three and a half crores. When Brihaspati is in Simha, all these come to Ganga to have a bath. When Brihaspati is in Simha, bathing once in Godavari is equal to bathing in Bhagirathi for sixty thousand years. O son! Because of Shiva’s command, such is Goutami. Bathing in her bestows emancipation on all men, all the time. Hearing about this yields the fruits that are obtained from undertaking thousands of horse sacrifices and one hundred *vajapeya* sacrifices. O Narada! If a person keeps the Purana narrated by Brahma in his house, he faces no fear on account of *kali yuga*. This excellent Purana must not be narrated to anyone. It must only be narrated to those who are faithful and tranquil, great-souled ones who are devoted to Vishnu. It bestows objects of pleasure and emancipation. As soon as a man hears it, he accomplishes his objective. If a person writes it down in the form of a book and gives it to a brahmana, he is freed from all sins and does not have to enter a womb again.’

This ends Part II of Brahma Purana, the Goutami Mahatmya section.

This ends Brahma Purana.

- ¹ For example, *shlokas* 2.4.10, 4.1.2 and 4.5.11 of the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad use the two expressions together.
- ² Chandogya Upanishad, 7.1.2.
- ³ *Ancient Indian Historical Tradition*, F. E. Pargiter, Oxford University Press, London, 1922.
- ⁴ *Sutas* were bards, minstrels, raconteurs.
- ⁵ The Critical Edition of the Valmiki Ramayana was brought out by the Baroda Oriental Institute, now part of the Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda. The Critical Edition of the Mahabharata was brought out by the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute, Pune.
- ⁶ The Bhagavad Gita translation was published in 2006 and reprinted in 2019, the translation of the Critical Edition of the Mahabharata in 10 volumes between 2010 and 2014 (with a box set in 2015) and the translation of the Critical Edition of the Valmiki Ramayana in 2017. The translations are by Bibek Debroy, and in each case, the publisher is Penguin.
- ⁷ *The Brahmamahapurānam*, Nag Publishers, Delhi, 1985.
- ⁸ The Brahma Purana, Parts I to IV, translated by a board of scholars, Motilal Banarsidass Publishers, Delhi, 1985 to 1986.
- ⁹ *Studies in the Puranic Records on Hindu Rites and Customs*, R. C. Hazra, University of Dacca, 1940. This has since been reprinted several times, by different publishers.
- ¹⁰ *The Bhagavata Purana*, Volumes 1–3, Penguin Books, 2018. *The Markandeya Purana*, Penguin Books, 2019.

- ¹ Oblations respectively offered to gods and ancestors.
- ² *Nitya* rites are those that are regularly performed, *naimittika* rites those undertaken for a special reason or occasion. *Kamyā* rites are those undertaken to accomplish a desire.
- ³ Good behaviour.
- ⁴ Of *dharma*, *artha* and *kama*.
- ⁵ Spend one-fourth of the wealth on *dharma*.
- ⁶ To make the meaning clear, we have taken some liberties with the text here.
- ⁷ A *muhurta* is a period of 48 minutes. Brahma *muhurta* is named after Brahma and is an auspicious time just before dawn, regarded as the last *muhurta* of the night. The precise hour depends on the time when the sun rises.
- ⁸ *Sandhya* is the intervening period between day and night. The morning *sandhya* is dawn, the evening *sandhya* is dusk. Midday is also referred to as *sandhya*. A *nakshatra* is an asterism. It is usually a star, but can also be a collection of stars.
- ⁹ A *tirtha* is a sacred place of pilgrimage, where there is water.
- ¹⁰ *Ucchishṭa*, stale or leftover food.
- ¹¹ People like a *guru*. *Guru* means a preceptor, as well as a senior.
- ¹² *Pradakshina* is an act of circumambulation. But it is more specific in the sense that the person/object being circumambulated must always be to one's right.
- ¹³ The word *chaitya* has several meanings—sacrificial shed, temple, altar, sanctuary and a tree that grows along the road.
- ¹⁴ A *pumshchali* is a loose woman, in a specific sense. *Svairinis* are loose women who have sex with anyone they want, but only with those from the same *varna*. *Kaminis* are loose women who have sex with anyone they want, irrespective of *varna*. *Pumshchalis* have no sense of discrimination and are almost like harlots.
- ¹⁵ Made out of wheat flour, sugar, ghee and milk.
- ¹⁶ *Krisara* is a dish made out of sesamum and grain.
- ¹⁷ The text uses the respective expressions Agastya's direction and Purandara's direction.
- ¹⁸ Without the intention of offering it at a sacrifice.
- ¹⁹ Ablutions, the rinsing of the mouth.
- ²⁰ After passing stool.

- ²¹ *Parva* days, when intercourse is to be avoided.
- ²² A *snataka* is a student who has finished studying and is ready to embark on the next phase of life. The word *snataka* is derived from *snana* (the act of taking a bath), ritually performed before anything auspicious is undertaken.
- ²³ Anumati is the personified form of the fifteenth lunar *tithi*.
- ²⁴ We have translated *manika* as water-pot. The word also means jewel.
- ²⁵ The personified form of dawn.
- ²⁶ Shiva, the word used is *bhutapati*.
- ²⁷ ‘Svadha! I bow down to you too.’ *Svadha* is an exclamation made when offering oblations to the ancestors. *Svaha* is an exclamation made when offering oblations to the gods.
- ²⁸ Loosely, the sense is that ‘let disease be kept away’.
- ²⁹ These *tirthas* are parts of the hand, sacred to specific divinities.
- ³⁰ Nandimukhas are a special class of ancestors and the *nandimukha* rite is for them.
- ³¹ Meaning, he should not call the cow at that time.
- ³² By sprinkling water over it.
- ³³ A paste made out the sediment of oily substances.
- ³⁴ With cow dung.
- ³⁵ The fig tree.
- ³⁶ One usually equates *chandala* with shudra, but there were eight different types of shudras, though the listing varies. For instance, *vyadha* (hunter), *vyalagrahi* (those who eat snakes), *vagatita* (one with whom one does not speak), *chandala* (*brahmana* mother, shudra father) and so on.
- ³⁷ Referring to the sun or the moon.
- ³⁸ Literally, those dug by the gods.
- ³⁹ Depending respectively on the *varna*.
- ⁴⁰ *Asthi*, those left after cremation.
- ⁴¹ There is a long list of those who are *sapindas*, such as, in the absence of a son, a daughter, a daughter’s son, a father, a mother, a brother, a brother’s son and so on. There is another such list of *sahodakas*.
- ⁴² Act of giving up one’s life by fasting to death.
- ⁴³ As is obvious, the duration depends on the *varna*.
- ⁴⁴ A monthly rite continued for one year.
- ⁴⁵ The four stages (*ashramas*) of life are *brahmacharya* (celibate student stage), *garhasthya* (householder), *vanaprastha* (retiring to the forest) and

sannyasa (stage of renunciation).

⁴⁶ *Dvija* is sometimes used as a synonym for *brahmana*. But it actually means a person who has had two births, the first the physical birth and the second the symbolic birth at the time of the sacred thread ceremony. Thus, as is the case here, *dvija* also means the first three *varnas*.

⁴⁷ This has been interpreted as the recommended modes for cooking food offered at sacrifices. However, *paka-yajna* also means a simple sacrifice undertaken at home and that seems to be a better meaning.

⁴⁸ The word used is *rajanya*, meaning royalty. But this means *kshatriya*.

⁴⁹ That is, a *kshatriya* must not simultaneously follow the tasks of both a *vaishya* and a *shudra*.

⁵⁰ Known as *upanayana*.

⁵¹ The preceptor.

⁵² We have deliberately used the word teacher, as opposed to preceptor (*guru*). Here, the text uses the word *acharya*. Unless used synonymously, in the hierarchy of teachers, *upadhyaya* is inferior to *acharya* and *acharya* is inferior to *guru*. The word for disciple/student is *shishya*.

⁵³ Literally, a mendicant who begs. This is *sannyasa*.

⁵⁴ So that there is no attachment towards a home.

⁵⁵ When the cooking is over and there is still food in the house.

⁵⁶ The six vices are *kama* (desire), *krodha* (anger), *lobha* (avarice), *moha* (delusion), *mada* (arrogance) and *matsarya* (jealousy). *Darpa* is a synonym for *mada*.

⁵⁷ Meaning the first three *varnas*, not just *brahmanas*.

⁵⁸ Shiva destroyed a city of the demons known as Tripura.

⁵⁹ Uma, Shiva's consort, was the daughter of the Himalayas.

⁶⁰ At the time of Daksha's sacrifice, Shiva gouged out Bhaga's eyes and knocked down Pusha's teeth.

⁶¹ Brahma.

⁶² *Pratiloma*, the upward progression, a *shudra* becoming a *vaishya*.

⁶³ Lord of beings, Shiva's name.

⁶⁴ *Jnana* is knowledge gleaned from the sacred texts and the *guru*, *vijnana* is that obtained through inward reflection.

⁶⁵ Beyond the *atman*, that is, the metaphysical.

⁶⁶ Someone with a *kshatriya* father and a *shudra* mother.

⁶⁷ We have translated this literally. But this may mean offering oblations to the digestive fire.

- ⁶⁸ *Vrishala* is a synonym for shudra, though it has some specific meanings too.
- ⁶⁹ That is, without first offering the meat in a sacrifice.
- ⁷⁰ *Ahavaniya*, *garhapatya* and *dakshinatya* (the fire that burns in a southern direction).
- ⁷¹ He must be generous. One touches water before any act, such as that of giving donations. In that sense, the hand remains wet.
- ⁷² To burn down his sins.
- ⁷³ As taxes.
- ⁷⁴ *Dharma*, *artha* and *kama*.
- ⁷⁵ Devoid of *gunas*.
- ⁷⁶ Any arranged collection of texts, the word is applied to various texts.
- ⁷⁷ A *pinaka* is both a trident and a bow. In particular, *Pinaka* means Shiva's bow. Shiva is known as Pinaki. He wields both a bow and a trident.
- ⁷⁸ He is reborn as human.
- ⁷⁹ A gift given to a guest to show respect.
- ⁸⁰ Respectively, water to wash the feet and rinse the mouth.
- ⁸¹ *Shvapakas* are sometimes equated with *chandalas*. *Shva* means dog and *paka* means to cook. Thus, *shvapaka* means someone who cooks dogs (eats dogs) or cooks for dogs (lives with dogs). A *pulkasa* (equivalently *pukkasa*) is the son of a *nishada* father and a shudra mother.
- ⁸² Brahma.
- ⁸³ Virupaksha, meaning with malformed eyes, is Shiva's name.
- ⁸⁴ *Agamas* are texts other than the *Vedas*, such as the *tantra* texts.
- ⁸⁵ A *brahmana* who becomes a *rakshasa*.
- ⁸⁶ An exclamation made at the time of offering oblations.
- ⁸⁷ The enemy of Tripura, Shiva's name.
- ⁸⁸ The three-eyed one, Shiva.
- ⁸⁹ The lord of the universe, being used for Shiva, though it is also used for Vishnu.
- ⁹⁰ The cycle of life.
- ⁹¹ Trivikrama, the one with the three strides, is Vishnu's name, a reference to the *vamana avatara*.
- ⁹² Vishnu's name, the one with eyes like lotuses.
- ⁹³ The goddess of wealth and prosperity, Lakshmi.
- ⁹⁴ Bow made out of horn, used by Vishnu.
- ⁹⁵ Garuda, the enemy of all the *nagas* (serpents).

- ⁹⁶ Known as *yogamaya*, the power of illusion.
- ⁹⁷ The title of Prajapati is applied to anyone who is a creator of beings.
- ⁹⁸ Dakshayani means Daksha's daughter, Aditi, married to the sage Kashyapa. Aditya, the sun-god, is the son of Kashyapa and Aditi.
- ⁹⁹ In the line of Manus, this is Vaivasvata Manu, the son of Vivasvat, the sun-god.
- ¹⁰⁰ Pururava is the first king of the lunar dynasty (*chandra vamsha*). He is the son of Ila, which is Sudyumna's feminine form.
- ¹⁰¹ The word 'son' has to be interpreted in a broad sense, since some generations are often missed in the telling. For instance, there were two Chitrarathas and two Shuras in the line and this concise telling treats them as identical.
- ¹⁰² The son is Vaasudeva and the father is Vasudeva.
- ¹⁰³ Descended from Yadu, meaning Krishna.
- ¹⁰⁴ Sanaka, Sananda, Sanatana and Sanatkumara are sons born through Brahma's mental powers.
- ¹⁰⁵ Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva.
- ¹⁰⁶ Balarama is a manifestation of Shesha/Ananta, who holds up the earth.
- ¹⁰⁷ Meaning Garuda.
- ¹⁰⁸ A tree that bestows whatever one wishes for.
- ¹⁰⁹ *Antyajas* are those who belong to lower classes, such as *chandalas*. They live just outside habitations.
- ¹¹⁰ *Yoga* leads to eight major *siddhis* or powers. These are *anima* (becoming as small as one desires), *mahima* (as large as one desires), *laghima* (as light as one wants), *garima* (as heavy as one wants), *prapti* (obtaining what one wants), *prakamya* (travelling where one wants), *vashitvam* (powers to control creatures) and *ishitvam* (obtaining divine powers).
- ¹¹¹ Shakra is another name for Indra.
- ¹¹² A *sadhaka* is someone who is aspiring for success, or has accomplished it.
- ¹¹³ The eleventh lunar day.
- ¹¹⁴ Offering of food.
- ¹¹⁵ Silent chanting.
- ¹¹⁶ This is usually stated as *shadaja*, *rishabha*, *gandhara*, *madhyama*, *panchama*, *dhaivata* and *nishada*, that is, *sa-re-ga-ma-pa-dha-ni*.
- ¹¹⁷ The twelfth lunar day.
- ¹¹⁸ March–April.

- ¹¹⁹ A kind of myrobalan.
- ¹²⁰ *Matanga* is a synonym for *chandala*.
- ¹²¹ *Rakshasas* wander around in the night and are known as *nishacharas*.
- ¹²² Without offering it in sacrifice first.
- ¹²³ Respectively, the night of the new moon, the sixth lunar day, the eighth lunar day and the fourteenth lunar day.
- ¹²⁴ A funeral ceremony.
- ¹²⁵ The elder brother who has not married before his younger brother, or the younger brother who has got married before his elder brother.
- ¹²⁶ *Shvapacha* is one who is an outcaste. Literally, one who eats dogs, or eats with dogs. This is thus a synonym for *chandala*. *Kunapa* is a dead body and *Kunapasha* (one who eats dead bodies) is an indirect way of referring to the *brahma-rakshasa*.
- ¹²⁷ Outside the temple.
- ¹²⁸ This is a reference to *Manu Samhita*, for example, 8.11.
- ¹²⁹ A *yama* is a period of three hours and two *yamas* are six hours. Night consists of three *yamas*.
- ¹³⁰ A person who employs priests to perform sacrifices.
- ¹³¹ Shiva.
- ¹³² A *muhurta* is a period of 48 minutes and in a 24-hour period, there are 30 *muhurtas*.
- ¹³³ *Prithudaka* is named after King *Prithu*. It is believed that *Vishvamitra* became a *brahmarshi* in the *Sarasvati* temple there. This is identified as *Pehowa* in *Karnal* district.
- ¹³⁴ *Kokamukha tirtha* was probably in *Nepal* and *Skanda* means a temple to *Skanda/Kumara/Kartikeya*.
- ¹³⁵ *Vedanga* means a branch of the *Vedas* and these were six kinds of learning that were essential to understand the *Vedas*—*shiksha* (phonetics), *kalpa* (rituals), *vyakarana* (grammar), *nirukta* (etymology), *chhanda* (metre) and *gyotisha* (astronomy).
- ¹³⁶ A *siddha* is someone who has obtained success. The *siddha* had disguised himself to hide his powers.
- ¹³⁷ Pounded ground meal, colloquially known as *sattu*.
- ¹³⁸ *Urvashi* was born from *Narayana's* thighs.
- ¹³⁹ The stream known as *Matsyodari* has now been reduced to a lake known as *Macchodari*, in *Varanasi*.
- ¹⁴⁰ The god of love.

- ¹⁴¹ Referring to Urvashi.
- ¹⁴² The fire-god.
- ¹⁴³ The sun-god. Another name for Bhaskara is Aditya.
- ¹⁴⁴ Both Shankara and Shambhu are Shiva's names, as is Trilochana, meaning the three-eyed one.
- ¹⁴⁵ The self-creating one, Brahma.
- ¹⁴⁶ The *shruti* texts, such as the *Vedas*, *Brahmanas*, *Aranyakas* and *Upanishads* are in the nature of revelation and do not have human authors. *Smriti* texts have human authors.
- ¹⁴⁷ Kamadamana means someone who has conquered desire.
- ¹⁴⁸ Without a son, one is destined for the hell named *put*.
- ¹⁴⁹ *Gana* (companion of Shiva), *kinnara/kimpurusha*, *vidyadhara*, *uraga/naga* and *guhyaka* (companion of Kubera) are semi-divine species.
- ¹⁵⁰ Vishnu killed two demons named Madhu and Kaitabha.
- ¹⁵¹ Murari means Mura's enemy. Since Vishnu killed a demon named Mura, he is known as Murari.
- ¹⁵² Nrisimha is the same as Narasimha, Vishnu's half-man half-lion *avatara*.
- ¹⁵³ The king of Kashi.
- ¹⁵⁴ Charudharma and Sudharma have the same meaning.
- ¹⁵⁵ Brahma.
- ¹⁵⁶ Virinchi is Brahma. There are different stories about why Shiva severed Brahma's fifth head. The severed head stuck to Shiva's hand.
- ¹⁵⁷ Kapalamochana means the place where the skull (*kapala*) was released (*mochana*). There are various Kapalamochana tirthas, but this one is probably the temple in Varanasi.
- ¹⁵⁸ Indra.
- ¹⁵⁹ This is a reference to Indra killing Vritra. The consequent sin refused to leave him.
- ¹⁶⁰ A *pishacha* is a demon who eats flesh, *rudra* means terrible.
- ¹⁶¹ For those who die in Varanasi, at the time of death, Shiva chants the *taraka mantra*. *Taraka mantra* means the *mantra* that enables one to cross over. Different versions are given of *taraka mantra*.
- ¹⁶² Kamadamana is relating all this to his father, King Agnidhra.
- ¹⁶³ Since he did not marry, this leaves an unexplained inconsistency.
- ¹⁶⁴ *Kalpa* is one of Brahma's days, the time for creation. When Brahma's night starts, there is a great destruction (*pralaya*).
- ¹⁶⁵ *Prakrita pralaya* will be explained in Chapter 1(124).

- ¹⁶⁶ This leaves a lot of things unsaid. A *mahayuga* is a cycle of *krita*, *treta*, *dvapara* and *kali*. *Krita* has 4,000 divine years, *treta* has 3000 divine years, *dvapara* has 2000 divine years and *kali* has 1000 divine years. There are 400 additional years at either end of *krita*, 300 at either end of *treta*, 200 at either end of *dvapara* and 100 at either end of *kali*. This amounts to 12,000 divine years for a *mahayuga* and there are 1,000 *mahayuga* in one of Brahma's days.
- ¹⁶⁷ Dharma has four feet in *krita*, three in *treta*, two in *dvapara* and one in *kali*. Each *yuga* loses a foot.
- ¹⁶⁸ Irrespective of *varna*.
- ¹⁶⁹ *Svairinis* are loose women who have sex with anyone they want, but only with those from the same *varna*. *Kaminis* are loose women who have sex with anyone they want, irrespective of *varna*. *Pumshchalis* have no sense of discrimination are almost like harlots.
- ¹⁷⁰ A *pana* is a small coin.
- ¹⁷¹ For rain.
- ¹⁷² The god of rain.
- ¹⁷³ Meaning, they are as thorny as the *shami* (silk-cotton) tree.
- ¹⁷⁴ *Anu* has been translated as atom.
- ¹⁷⁵ A fragrant grass.
- ¹⁷⁶ In *kali yuga*, even limited efforts yield great results.
- ¹⁷⁷ Two are shudras and women. The third seems to be those who make a little bit of effort in *kali yuga*.
- ¹⁷⁸ In *kali yuga*.
- ¹⁷⁹ The end of a *mahayuga*.
- ¹⁸⁰ *Kali yuga*.
- ¹⁸¹ While eating, they should be seated in different rows (*pankti*). A *kandaprishtha* is a *brahmana* who earns a living by making arrows, or is the husband of a courtesan.
- ¹⁸² The *Vajasaneya Samhita* of the *Yajur Veda*.
- ¹⁸³ Those who speak about *dharma*. *Antyavasina* means one who lives towards the extremities of a habitation. This is, thus, a synonym for *antyaja*.
- ¹⁸⁴ 'Bhoh' is difficult to translate. It is a bit like 'Hey'. The intention is to state that they will not know anything more than this exclamation.
- ¹⁸⁵ The text uses the word *kashaya*, meaning *kali yuga*.
- ¹⁸⁶ The will rule through hearsay, without verifying the facts.

- 187 Koshi in Bihar.
- 188 Those who do not speak Sanskrit, barbarians.
- 189 Used for the extraction.
- 190 According to the injunctions, cooked food should not be bought and sold.
- 191 That is, regarded as valueless. Unless comprehended, the true value of *dharma* is also not realized.
- 192 The same as *prakrita pralaya*.
- 193 In Sanskrit, the higher number is written to the right. Therefore, literally, each number is ten times the number that precedes it. But we have changed it, so that there is no confusion.
- 194 1 followed by seventeen zeros.
- 195 *Laya/pralaya* means destruction.
- 196 The twinkling of an eye.
- 197 A *pala* is a measure of weight, but its stated weighted varies across sources. 30 grams is a rough indication. *Angula* is the length of a finger. *Masha* is just short of one gram. This entire shloka is very cryptic and impossible to understand. Therefore, we have expanded the translation, so as to make the meaning clear.
- 198 A *prastha* is thirty-two *palas*. Instead of six and a half *palas*, the vessel has a weight of thirty-two *palas*.
- 199 Therefore, a *muhurta* is 48 minutes and a *nadika* is 24 minutes.
- 200 That is, a *mahayuga*.
- 201 The seven nether regions are Atala, Vitala, Nitala, Sutala, Talatala, Rasatala and Patala.
- 202 *Bhuloka* is earth, *svarloka* is heaven and *bhuvarloka* is the space between the two.
- 203 Clouds of destruction.
- 204 The name of a gigantic elephant that guards the southern direction.
- 205 Both are types of white jasmine.
- 206 A reddish insect, sometimes identified with a firefly.
- 207 The Great Dipper, part of Ursa Majoris.
- 208 Asleep, immersed in *yoga*.
- 209 Thus the expression *naimittika*, *nimitta* means cause.
- 210 Brahma.
- 211 The one without birth, Brahma.
- 212 This is secondary destruction, at the end of one of Brahma's days. *Prakrita pralaya* occurs when Brahma's lifespan is over.

- ²¹³ The mountain that separates the region illuminated by the sun from the region not illuminated by the sun.
- ²¹⁴ The text uses the word *bhutadi* (origin of the elements), meaning *ahamkara*.
- ²¹⁵ *Abhimana*.
- ²¹⁶ The great intelligence.
- ²¹⁷ This is the essence of *samkhya* philosophy and the seven *prakritis* presumably mean the five elements, the mind and *ahamkara*. This use of the word *prakriti* is not to be confused with the subsequent Prakriti.
- ²¹⁸ Mahat is another word for Mahabuddhi.
- ²¹⁹ *Sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*.
- ²²⁰ Purusha, also referred to in these sections as the unmanifest part of Prakriti.
- ²²¹ The one without destruction, the *paramatman*.
- ²²² *Nivritti* is detachment from fruits and renunciation of action. *Pravritti* is action with a desire for the fruits.
- ²²³ *Hrasva* or short vowels are pronounced over one *matra* (a prosodial or syllabic instant), *dirgha* or long vowels over two *matras* and *pluta* or elongated vowels over three *matras*.

- ²²⁴ Relating to *adhidaivika* (destiny), *adhibhoutika* (nature) and *adhyatmika* (one's own nature).
- ²²⁵ The hells.
- ²²⁶ *Viveka*.
- ²²⁷ *Shabda*-brahma is the ritualistic elements of the *Vedas*, the *karmakanda*. *Para*-brahma is the *paramatman*.
- ²²⁸ Brahma.
- ²²⁹ He is both Saguna and Nirguna.
- ²³⁰ The *atman* of everything.
- ²³¹ The lord.
- ²³² The supreme lord.
- ²³³ Heat and cold, happiness and unhappiness and so on.
- ²³⁴ *Yavagu* is gruel made from any grain (including barley) and *takra* is buttermilk.
- ²³⁵ The word *chaitya* has several meanings—sacrificial shed, temple, altar, sanctuary and a tree that grows along the road.
- ²³⁶ 9 p.m. to midnight, or 3.00 a.m. to 6.00 a.m.
- ²³⁷ The lotus posture.
- ²³⁸ The control of the breath of life (*prana*).
- ²³⁹ *Pranava* means to chant 'Oum'. Covering the mouth means that he should not say anything else.
- ²⁴⁰ *Kshetrajna* means the *atman*.
- ²⁴¹ It is small and subtle.
- ²⁴² Yoga has eight elements—*yama* (restraint), *niyama* (rituals), *asana* (posture), *pranayama* (breathing), *pratyahara* (withdrawal), *dharana* (retention), *dhyana* (meditation) and *samadhi* (liberation). That's the reason the expression *ashtanga* (eight-formed) *yoga* is used.
- ²⁴³ The state of emancipation, when everything is extinguished.
- ²⁴⁴ A living being has four states—waking, dreaming, sleeping and *turiya*. *Turiya* is the fourth state, when one perceives union between the human soul *atman* and the *brahman*.
- ²⁴⁵ With the *atman*.
- ²⁴⁶ *Prana* draws breath into the body, *apana* exhales it. *Vyana* distributes it through the body and *samana* assimilates it. *Udana* gives rise to sound. These are the five forms of the breath of life.
- ²⁴⁷ This is left unexplained. The sixteen attributes should be the five senses of perception, the five organs of action, the five elements and the mind.

Adding the *jivatman*, one gets seventeen.

²⁴⁸ Respectively, the universal soul and the soul in a creature. The text uses the word *atman* for both. We have expanded it, so that the meaning is clear.

²⁴⁹ This is identical with *Bhagavad Gita* 5.18.

²⁵⁰ The first part of this shloka occurs in many other places, including the *Ashtavakra Gita* and *Anushasana Parva* of the *Mahabharata*.

²⁵¹ The *paramatman*.

²⁵² This is identical to *Bhagavad Gita* 13.13.

²⁵³ Hamsa (a swan) is used as a term for the *atman*. A swan is believed to have discrimination. From a mixture of milk and water, it can drink up the water. The body is the city with the nine gates (two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, the mouth, the anus and the genital organ).

²⁵⁴ The *shlokas* are cryptic. The meaning seems to be that the *jivatman* (Hamsa) is perishable because it eventually merges into the *paramatman*.

²⁵⁵ Transcendental knowledge about the *paramatman*.

²⁵⁶ That is, he should not get distracted by such extraordinary powers.

²⁵⁷ Though the word used is 'and', the sense is of two alternative paths, of *pravritti* and *nivritti*.

²⁵⁸ The sixteen mentioned earlier.

²⁵⁹ As the moon goes through waxing and waning, there are sixteen *kalas* (digits).

²⁶⁰ This probably means the five senses of perception, the five organs of action and the mind.

²⁶¹ *Kshetra* is the physical body.

²⁶² Bhuloka, Bhuvarka, Svarloka, Maharloka, Satyaloka, Tapoloka and Janaloka.

²⁶³ This is similar to *Bhagavad Gita* 3.42, though not identical.

²⁶⁴ A *snataka* is an individual who has completed the *brahmacharya* stage of studying and is ready to enter the next stage of life.

²⁶⁵ As mentioned earlier, this is similar to *Bhagavad Gita* 3.42.

²⁶⁶ Joy, misery and confusion.

²⁶⁷ *Sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*.

²⁶⁸ *Kshetrajna* and *sattva*.

²⁶⁹ In mineral form.

²⁷⁰ The cluster fig tree, a gnat is attracted to its fruit.

²⁷¹ A *buddha* is an awakened and enlightened person.

- ²⁷² Which is like the great tree.
- ²⁷³ The *jivatman*.
- ²⁷⁴ Which preach and talk about different things.
- ²⁷⁵ *Darshana* is more than a school of philosophical thought, since it also includes insight about *adhyatma*.
- ²⁷⁶ There is an additional *shloka* that is not included as part of the main text. Hence, we have not translated it. This talks about eating bits of grain and oilcakes and avoidance of oily substances.
- ²⁷⁷ Brahma's sons are Sanaka, Sananda, Sanatana and Sanatkumara. Both Isha and Bhava must mean Shiva, so there is repetition.
- ²⁷⁸ Varuni, the goddess of liquor.
- ²⁷⁹ The moon.
- ²⁸⁰ Garuda.
- ²⁸¹ Since *samkhya* texts differ, it is difficult to enumerate which qualities are intended in these numbers.
- ²⁸² Agni.
- ²⁸³ Earth.
- ²⁸⁴ Five senses of perception, five organs of action, five elements and the mind.
- ²⁸⁵ Synonym for *devarshis*.
- ²⁸⁶ The body is the city with nine gates.
- ²⁸⁷ The text uses the word *vadava*. The subterranean fire is known as *vadava* (mare), because it is in the form of a mare's head.
- ²⁸⁸ The Maruts, the wind-gods, are sometimes listed as seven and sometimes as forty-nine.
- ²⁸⁹ The question seems to imply, what is special about *samkhya*?
- ²⁹⁰ We have expanded these sentences a bit, to make the meaning clear.
- ²⁹¹ *Akshara*, means imperishable, without decay. *Kshara* means perishable, with decay.
- ²⁹² King Karala belonged to the Janaka lineage.
- ²⁹³ Vasishtha's name.
- ²⁹⁴ A *mahayuga* consists of a cycle of *satya yuga*, *treta yuga*, *dvapara yuga* and *kali yuga*, made up of twelve thousand years of the gods. 1000 *mahayuga* make up one *kalpa*, one of Brahma's days. We have amended the text to make it conform to the standard usage. Probably because of typos, the text causes confusion. The word *kalpa* is used for a *mahayuga* and four hundred *kalpas* are equated with one of Brahma's days.

- ²⁹⁵ Yoga leads to eight major *siddhis* or powers. These are *anima* (becoming as small as one desires), *mahima* (as large as one desires), *laghima* (as light as one wants), *garima* (as heavy as one wants), *prapti* (obtaining what one wants), *prakamyā* (travelling where one wants), *vashitvam* (powers to control creatures) and *ishitvam* (obtaining divine powers).
- ²⁹⁶ Equated with Ishana.
- ²⁹⁷ Literally, the single one and the one without decay.
- ²⁹⁸ Respectively, the one with many forms and the one with the universe as his form.
- ²⁹⁹ Of the elements.
- ³⁰⁰ Hiranyagarbha.
- ³⁰¹ The creation of knowledge.
- ³⁰² The creation of ignorance.
- ³⁰³ This is a terse *shloka* and the meaning isn't obvious. The sense seems to be something like the following. While there was knowledge initially, ego and consciousness cloud it and lead to ignorance.
- ³⁰⁴ The first being Hiranyagarbha and the second being *ahamkara*. This third creation of the elements is known as *bhuta-sarga*.
- ³⁰⁵ The 5 senses, the 5 objects of the senses, the 5 organs of action, the 5 elements, mind, intelligence, ego and consciousness.
- ³⁰⁶ The word used is *tata*. While this means son, it is used for anyone who is younger or junior.
- ³⁰⁷ *Rakshasas*.
- ³⁰⁸ Black antelopes.
- ³⁰⁹ The *atman*.
- ³¹⁰ *Tattva* means the true state, identified with the *paramatman*.
- ³¹¹ Respectively associated with *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*.
- ³¹² A cocoon.
- ³¹³ Disease treated by thermal cauterization.
- ³¹⁴ Spots. There were 18 kinds of leprosy and this is one of those.
- ³¹⁵ Different kinds of austerities are being described. *Chaturvas* is a vow of eating once in four days.
- ³¹⁶ Literally, posture of a hero. A seated position used by ascetics.
- ³¹⁷ *Kasha* is a kind of grass.
- ³¹⁸ A *chandrayana* is fasting determined by the moon's progress. For example, during *krishna paksha*, the food taken is diminished by one

mouthful per day and during *shukla paksha*, it is increased by one mouthful per day.

319 Brahma's day.

320 Prakriti.

321 The *atman*.

322 The body.

323 The body.

324 The moon's diameter is divided into sixteen *kalas*. The moon waxes and wanes by one *kala* each day and the sixteenth one is the one that remains on the night of the new moon.

325 The 5 senses, the 5 organs of action, mind, intelligence, ego, ignorance and Prakriti (or consciousness influenced by Prakriti) are probably the 15 which are modified. Pure consciousness (not influenced by Prakriti) is the 16th.

326 Have offspring.

327 The *atman*.

328 The word used is *tata*.

329 Non-male includes female and neuter.

330 It is difficult to make sense of this sentence. Vayu was born from the breath of Purusha, so perhaps Vayu stands for the breath of life. Rasa means semen. This leaves Puman. If Vayu and Rasa have been understood correctly, Puman might mean the physical body.

331 Five senses of perception, five organs of action, five gross elements, five subtle elements, intelligence, mind and *ahamkara* and Prakriti account for twenty-four. Purusha is the twenty-fifth.

332 This is expressed in a convoluted way. Intelligent ones know about Vishnu. Those who know are those who know about the unmanifest. But since Vishnu and the unmanifest one are identical, the two destinations are also identical. Intelligent is an expression being applied to the practitioners of *samkhya*, while those who know is a label that is being applied to the practitioners of *yoga*.

333 The many is destructible and the one is indestructible.

334 That the *atman* is one.

335 *Pranayama* is performed while chanting *mantras*, but concentration of the mind doesn't require *mantras*.

336 The twenty-four have been mentioned earlier. In *pranayama*, there are different methods of breathing and controlling *prana*, with a list that runs

into around fifty. Clearly, twenty-two of these are being singled out.

337 A fire has seven flames.

338 The five elements, *ahamkara*, Mahat and the original Prakriti.

339 That is, *ahamkara* is created after Mahat, but is destroyed before Mahat.

340 In this context, Purusha.

341 Purusha.

342 Purusha makes Prakriti many.

343 Prakriti is the *kshetra* (field) and the great-souled one is the *brahman*.

344 The *brahman*.

345 The field or *kshetra* is Prakriti and the one who knows about the field, *kshetrajna*, is the *brahman*.

346 The word *pura* means earlier, ancient, in the beginning. Hence, Purusha means the original or primeval one.

347 Respectively, knowledge and ignorance. The twenty principles are ten senses (perception and action) and the ten elements (gross and subtle).

348 The *jivatman* and Prakriti.

349 Prakriti.

350 Purusha into Prakriti.

351 Purusha.

352 Distinct from Prakriti. Succeeding *shlokas* suggest that this is a description of a *yogi* in meditation.

353 The *brahman*.

354 Referring to states of birth—high being gods, medium being humans and low being inferior species.

355 Prakriti.

356 Prakriti.

357 The *brahman*.

358 *Samkhya* philosophy does not believe in a personal god and this simply states that.

359 The one who knows is the *jivatman* and the one who is to be known is the *paramatman* or *brahman*. *Yoga* talks of both.

360 The *brahman*. Aja means without birth. Throughout this chapter, the *shlokas* are very difficult to understand and several liberties have been taken.

361 The *jivatman*.

362 *Budhyamana* means the one who comprehends and is being used for the *jivatman*, which can understand the nature of the *paramatman*.

- ³⁶³ This seems to be a reference to the *jivatman*, but can mean Prakriti too.
- ³⁶⁴ The *jivatman* seems to be the twenty-fourth, Prakriti the twenty-fifth and the *paramatman* the twenty-sixth.
- ³⁶⁵ Prakriti.
- ³⁶⁶ Thinks that the *jivatman* is no different from the *paramatman*.
- ³⁶⁷ Prakriti.
- ³⁶⁸ Prakriti.
- ³⁶⁹ Prakriti.
- ³⁷⁰ Gnats are found inside ripe figs.
- ³⁷¹ The *jivatman* and the *paramatman*.
- ³⁷² The *jivatman*.
- ³⁷³ Respectively, the *paramatman* and the *jivatman*.
- ³⁷⁴ Narada.
- ³⁷⁵ This could be a reference to *nyaya*. But *nyaya* only has sixteen categories (*padarthas*). But there were eighteen kinds of learning—four *Vedas*, six *Vedangas*, *mimasa*, *nyaya*, *dharmashastra*, Puranas, *arthashastra*, *ayurveda*, *dhanurveda* and *gandharva vidya*. So defect might mean not knowing about these. Defects listed for rhetoric also do not amount to eighteen in number.
- ³⁷⁶ In debating, one first stated the views of the opponent, known as *purvapaksha*. This was then rebutted to arrive at a final conclusion.
- ³⁷⁷ That is, Mahabharata.
- ³⁷⁸ Grammar.
- ³⁷⁹ Bhadra.

380 This is Brahma replying to Narada.
381 Narada was Brahma's son.
382 Those for humans.
383 The forest (*aranya*) known as Dandaka.
384 Region where *karma* is performed and its fruits enjoyed.
385 Continent.
386 Meaning *asura tirthas*.
387 Brahma. Dhatri can loosely be translated as Creator. Dhatri is the
Creator, Vidhatri is the one who controls/ordains.
388 The river Bhima.
389 Venya.
390 Tapti.
391 Identified with Purna, or part of Tapti.
392 Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva.
393 The sense seems to be that once the three gods show themselves and
grant boons, the good merits are exhausted.
394 Since the grandfather, Brahma, originated from Vishnu.
395 Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva.
396 Relating to *adhidaivika* (destiny), *adhibhoutika* (nature) and *adhyatmika*
(one's own nature).
397 Vishnu's *varaha*, *matysa* and *kurma avataras*.
398 This was the boon Taraka received from Brahma.
399 The wife of the Himalayas, also referred to as Menaka.
400 Daksha's daughter, Sati. In the course of Daksha's sacrifice, Sati
immolated herself and was reborn as Parvati, the daughter of the
Himalayas and Mena.
401 The personified forms of strength, everything auspicious, intelligence,
wisdom, fortitude, comprehension, modesty, nourishment and speech.
Shiva is the masculine, Shivaa the feminine.
402 Shiva.
403 Shiva.
404 Madana and Kandarpa are the names of Kama, the god of love.
Manmatha is also one of his names.
405 Girija, the daughter of the mountain, is Parvati's name.
406 Kama is the one with five arrows to his bow.
407 Spring. Another name for Spring is Madhava.
408 Rati is Kama's wife.

- ⁴⁰⁹ Shiva's glance reduced Kama to ashes.
- ⁴¹⁰ Vasishtha's wife.
- ⁴¹¹ Vishnu.
- ⁴¹² The architect of the gods.
- ⁴¹³ The personified forms of victory, prosperity, auspiciousness, forbearance, fame and nourishment. These are intended to indicate Daksha's daughters.
- ⁴¹⁴ Being used here as a synonym for Goddess Earth.
- ⁴¹⁵ 60,000 sages who were the sizes of thumbs. They preceded the sun's chariot.
- ⁴¹⁶ A sacred water-pot.
- ⁴¹⁷ This is a hymn for purification found in *Taittiriya Samhita* and *Taittiriya Brahman*. *Pavamana* means something that flows and purifies, that is, water.
- ⁴¹⁸ Aditi, Kashyapa's wife, was the mother of the gods.
- ⁴¹⁹ A dwarf.
- ⁴²⁰ Shukracharya, the preceptor of the demons.
- ⁴²¹ Shukracharya. Shukracharya was descended from Bhrigu and is therefore known as Bhargava.
- ⁴²² Since Bali had not heeded his warning, Shukra was angry. In other accounts, Shukra cursed Bali.
- ⁴²³ Meaning the earth, since the earth is held up on the back of a tortoise.
- ⁴²⁴ Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva.
- ⁴²⁵ Vishnu's name, the one with the three valiant strides.
- ⁴²⁶ Bali will be Indra in the next *manvantara*.
- ⁴²⁷ Hari is also one of Indra's names. That is, Bali's fame would transcend that of Indra's.
- ⁴²⁸ Shiva. Shiva destroyed Tripura, a city of the demons.
- ⁴²⁹ Ganga.
- ⁴³⁰ Gouri is Uma and Bhava is Shiva.
- ⁴³¹ Vinayaka is Ganesha, Skanda is Kumara/Kartikeya and Jaya is Goutama's daughter and Uma's companion.
- ⁴³² The king of impediments, Ganesha. He creates impediments and also removes them.
- ⁴³³ Brahmagiri is in the Western Ghats, bordering Kerala and Karnataka.
- ⁴³⁴ Lord of *ganas*, another name for Ganesha.
- ⁴³⁵ The traditional four means are *sama* (conciliation or negotiation), *dana* (bribery), *danda* (punishment) and *bheda* (dissension) and there is an

allusion to this.

⁴³⁶ Lord of *ganas*, Ganesha.

⁴³⁷ A fine variety of rice.

⁴³⁸ *Humkara* means to utter the sound ‘hum’, a sound believed to possess special powers.

⁴³⁹ Vighnaraja.

⁴⁴⁰ These eight forms are Bhava, Sharva, Rudra, Pashupati, Ugra, Mahadeva, Bhima and Ishana. However, the text doesn’t quite follow this and mentions earth, water, Shiva, Kala (Time/Destiny), Sun/Moon/Fire, Vayu, space and Shambhu.

⁴⁴¹ A *yajna* and a *kratu* are both sacrifices. However, the former is performed with a sacrificial post and the latter without one. More specifically, the former is performed with sacrificial animals and the latter without sacrificing animals.

⁴⁴² This abrupt *shloka* is unclear and we have taken liberties in the translation.

⁴⁴³ Parvati.

⁴⁴⁴ Brahma.

⁴⁴⁵ The three *Vedas*.

⁴⁴⁶ *Vaidhriti* is also known as *vyatipata*, an inauspicious period that lasts for almost 24 hours during every lunar month.

⁴⁴⁷ The statement is made thrice to firmly establish its veracity.

⁴⁴⁸ In the sense of having committed sins.

⁴⁴⁹ Ganga’s name.

⁴⁵⁰ Gangadvara usually refers to Har ki Pauri in Haridvara/Haridwar.

⁴⁵¹ This means Prayaga. The word *prabhasa* should hence be interpreted as the splendid place, rather than the famous Prabhasa.

⁴⁵² This means Sangameshvara in Kurnool district, near Shrishailam.

⁴⁵³ Since Payoshni is the river Purna, this must be a reference to Mudagaleshvara in Parbhani district.

⁴⁵⁴ As should be obvious by now, Goutami Ganga is the Godavari.

⁴⁵⁵ Jupiter.

⁴⁵⁶ The constellation Leo.

⁴⁵⁷ Brihaspati and the sun. Because of the position of the sun, it would be incorrect to identify this with the current *kumbha* in Tryambakeshvara/Nashik. In the current *kumbha*, Brihaspati is in Leo, but the sun is in Cancer.

- ⁴⁵⁸ That is, born in the solar dynasty. The first king of the solar dynasty was Ikshvaku.
- ⁴⁵⁹ The ocean is known as *saagara*.
- ⁴⁶⁰ *Rajarshi* means royal sage.
- ⁴⁶¹ From Indra, the *rakshasas* obtained the horse.
- ⁴⁶² Narada would of course have known and there was no need to tell him.
- ⁴⁶³ These were Sagara's thoughts.
- ⁴⁶⁴ Son in an extended sense.
- ⁴⁶⁵ Meaning Someshvara, the lord of the moon (Soma).
- ⁴⁶⁶ The sage Agastya drank up the ocean.
- ⁴⁶⁷ The *jyotirlingam* of Tryambakeshvara in Nashik district, near the Godavari's origin.
- ⁴⁶⁸ There are different places named Varaha *tirtha*. Since this is in the context of the Godavari, this Varaha *tirtha* must be the one near the temple in Tryambakeshvara.
- ⁴⁶⁹ There is an implicit pun. *Sruva* means sacrificial ladle, as well as a spring or cascade of water.
- ⁴⁷⁰ This is a lake (*kunda*) next to Tryambakeshvara. When Godavari descended from Brahmagiri, Goutama stopped the flow in Kushavarta with a wall of *kusha* grass.
- ⁴⁷¹ Since Nilaganga is in Ujjain, this breaks the geographical continuity. This must therefore mean the Nilambika temple, atop Mount Nila, near Tryambakeshvara.
- ⁴⁷² This Brahmagiri hill is to the west of Tryambakeshvara.
- ⁴⁷³ The eyes were probably sunken.
- ⁴⁷⁴ The text uses the word Atriya, Atri's son. This means the moon, the moon was the sage Atri's son.
- ⁴⁷⁵ *Kapota* means any bird. Specifically, it means a dove or pigeon.
- ⁴⁷⁶ This is an unexpected guest, *atithi*. *Tithi* is a lunar day and there are guests who are invited and arrive on specific *tithis*, because these are festive occasions. These are expected and invited guests, visitors. *Atithi* means *a-tithi* and is therefore not any guest, but a guest who arrives uninvited and is unexpected.
- ⁴⁷⁷ Taraka/Tarakasura was killed by Kartikeya.
- ⁴⁷⁸ Vishakha is Kartikeya's name.
- ⁴⁷⁹ Kartikeya.
- ⁴⁸⁰ Gangeya is one of Kartikeya's names.

- 481 Kavi is being used as a term for Agni. Agni swallowed up Shiva's semen,
produced for Kartikeya's birth.
- 482 Vasishtha's wife.
- 483 Since this is being told to Narada, this is superfluous.
- 484 Kartikeya.
- 485 The wives of the *rishis*. The Pleiades. Kartikeya was reared by the
Krittikas. They adopted him as their son. That is the reason he is known
as Kartikeya.
- 486 October–November.
- 487 Gishpati is another name for Brihaspati.
- 488 Bhouvana is being addressed as a sage.
- 489 This bit is repeated.
- 490 *Dasha* (ten) *ashvamedha* (horse sacrifice).
- 491 There are several mountains that have this name, but this is the one near
Brahmagiri.
- 492 Indra.
- 493 Adrika's son.
- 494 Vrishakapi is another name for Hanuman, Marjara means cat.
- 495 The confluence of the river Phenā with Godavari.
- 496 *Kshudha* means hunger.
- 497 That is, Kshudha.
- 498 The divine cow, *kamadhenu*, the cow who yields all the objects of desire.
- 499 The texts of the *Vedas*, or related to them.
- 500 The one who performed 100 sacrifices, Indra's name.
- 501 Indra's name is Purandara, the destroyer of cities.
- 502 Hari is one of Indra's names.
- 503 In this Purana, the river Ahalya has a confluence with the Godavari. The
description in other Puranas is different.
- 504 She was Varuna's daughter. Gunarnava means ocean of qualities.
- 505 This is reminiscent of Bhagavad Gita 3.8.
- 506 *Dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*.
- 507 Etymologically, the forest of Dandaka, or Dandakaranya, has a sense of
punishment, that is, it is a place to which one was exiled or banished.
Today, Dandakaranya straddles several central Indian States.
- 508 Both *tirthas* and *kshetras* are sacred places of pilgrimage. However,
tirthas are associated with water, while *kshetras* are not.

- ⁵⁰⁹ A part of the forest of Dandakaranya. Janasthana means place with people. The text suggests an etymological link with the name Janaka.
- ⁵¹⁰ This is an odd way of addressing Narada.
- ⁵¹¹ Yama's.
- ⁵¹² Savitar, Surya and Bhanu are all names for the sun-god.
- ⁵¹³ The Destroyer, Yama's name.
- ⁵¹⁴ The text uses Yama's name of Kala.
- ⁵¹⁵ That is, each is performing the appointed task.
- ⁵¹⁶ Surya.
- ⁵¹⁷ Vaivasvata means the son of Vivasvat (Surya). Hence, Manu is also Vaivasvata Manu.
- ⁵¹⁸ *Chhaya* means shadow.
- ⁵¹⁹ Savarni Manu.
- ⁵²⁰ Surya realized this through his powers of meditation.
- ⁵²¹ Surya's name.
- ⁵²² *Vata* is the holy fig tree.
- ⁵²³ The physicians of the gods.
- ⁵²⁴ In Gujarat.
- ⁵²⁵ Tapi/Tapati is the daughter of Surya and Chhaya.
- ⁵²⁶ Vishnu.
- ⁵²⁷ That is, Garuda.
- ⁵²⁸ Garuda.
- ⁵²⁹ The one seated on the lotus, Shri/Lakshmi.
- ⁵³⁰ Nandi.

- 531 The celestial cow, the mother of all cattle.
532 Nandi.
533 Literally, the place where cattle flourish.
534 Meaning, they are so many that they cannot be described.
535 There is more than one Goutameshvara temple. This must be the one in Manthani, in Telangana.
536 Literally, the destroyer of sins.
537 We have translated *jati* as class, to distinguish it from *varna*.
538 Galava had taught Sannajata.
539 Since they were living as man and wife.
540 *Dhoutapapa* means a place where sins are washed away.
Papapranashana means a place where sins are destroyed. The meanings are effectively identical.
541 South of Papapranashana *tirtha*.
542 *Pitris*.
543 Vishvamitra was descended from Kusha and is, hence, known as Koushika.
544 Indra.
545 *Madhu* is honey, *shyena* is a hawk and Parjanya is the god of rain, that is, Indra.
546 When he died, Yama's messengers came.
547 Chitraka/Chitrugupta maintains a record of a person's good and bad deeds. Mrityu is Death.
548 Shiva.
549 Ghost or goblin.
550 Relating to *adhidaivika* (destiny), *adhibhoutika* (nature) and *adhyatmika* (one's own nature).
551 The one with a blue throat, Shiva's name.
552 Yama.
553 There are thirty-four thousand *tirthas* on the northern bank.
554 Nine thousand on the southern bank. However, this is written in such a way that one can also obtain an aggregate of thirty-six thousand.
555 The son of Angiras was Jiva/Brihaspati, while Bhrigu's son was Kavi/Shukracharya.
556 The text says Bhargava, though Bhrigu is intended.
557 Here, the text uses the word *acharya*. Unless used synonymously, in the hierarchy of teachers, *upadhyaya* is inferior to *acharya* and *acharya* is

- inferior to *guru*. There is an intended slight in this address.
- 558 Bhrigu's descendant, Shukracharya.
- 559 The word *guru* means heavy, as well as preceptor. There is, thus, a double meaning.
- 560 The knowledge of bringing the dead (*mrita*) back to life (*sanjivani*).
- 561 This is a reference to the Ahalya incident.
- 562 Derived from *mala* (dirt/impurity). Malava is the Malwa region.
- 563 The confluence of Punya. Punya might be the river Purna.
- 564 Sikta might therefore be the river Indravati.
- 565 Kubera.
- 566 Vishrava was the son of Pulastya. Kubera was the son of Vishrava and Ilavida, while Ravana and his brothers were the sons of Vishrava and Kaikasi (also known as Nikasha or Keshini). Dhanada means the lord of riches and is one of Kubera's names.
- 567 They were born through different wives of the sage Kashyapa.
- 568 Ravana.
- 569 Kubera.
- 570 The same as Dhanada.
- 571 Parvati, Shiva's wife.
- 572 Shiva burnt down Kama and Kama and Rati (Kama's wife) were thus separated. Girjia means daughter of the mountain, that is, Parvati.
- 573 That is, Kubera should regain his earlier status.
- 574 This must be the one in Nashik.
- 575 Meaning descendant of Pulastya.
- 576 Jataveda and Havyavat/Havyavahana (the bearer of oblations) are usually given as Agni's names.
- 577 Respectively, *prayaja* and *anuyaja*. These will be Agni's share.
- 578 Agni.
- 579 All of these are Agni's names. They respectively mean: the origin of the *Vedas*, the extremely radiant one, the one with seven rays, the blue-red one, the one hidden in water, the one hidden inside a *shami* tree and the one inside a sacrifice. Vibhavasus is also one of Agni's names, meaning the one with a wealth of light.
- 580 Heaven and earth.
- 581 Rinamochana is the same as Rinapramochana.
- 582 A *parivetta* is someone who marries or accepts a share in a sacrifice before his elder brother. By not worshipping the fire, what is meant is

- that Prithushrava did not worship the householder's fire.
- 583 The debt to gods is repaid through sacrifices, that to ancestors is repaid by obtaining sons and that to the sages is repaid through studying.
- 584 Release (*mochana*) from debt (*rina*).
- 585 Elsewhere, Suparna is called Vinata.
- 586 Presumably because pregnant women shouldn't have gone there.
- 587 A reference to Shiva having sliced off one of Brahma's heads. The sin pursued him.
- 588 This is Nandur Madhmeshwar in Nashik district, along the banks of Godavari.
- 589 The lord of success.
- 590 Parvati's.
- 591 Relating to *adhidaivika* (destiny), *adhibhoutika* (nature) and *adhyatmika* (one's own nature).
- 592 Relating to *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*.
- 593 A reference to the moon on Shiva's head.
- 594 The *simantonnayana samskara* means parting the hair and is performed in the 4th month of pregnancy.
- 595 Named after Suparna. There is a Souparnika river in Andhra Pradesh, but this should be near Nashik. Kadru is probably the river named Kadva.
- 596 There is a Jatadhari river in Odisha, but this may not be the same one.
- 597 Meaning, goddess of speech, that is, Sarasvati.
- 598 This should be the one in Kaygaon Toka in Ahmednagar. In that case, Pravara would be the river Sarasvati.
- 599 Sarasvati is usually the daughter Brahma pursues. But here, the eldest daughter seems to be Usha, distinct from Sarasvati.
- 600 Shiva assumed this form and pursued Brahma.
- 601 With Godavari.
- 602 Hunter (*vyadha*) of deer (*mriga*).
- 603 *Asvattha* and *vata* are holy fig trees, *palasha* is a tree with red blossoms and *arka* is the sun-plant.
- 604 Respectively, surviving on roots, or on water.
- 605 Cross the ocean of *samsara*.
- 606 Though both sages are speaking, the word 'me' is used.
- 607 *Charu* is an oblation of rice, barley and pulses, cooked in butter and milk.
- 608 The art of fighting.

- ⁶⁰⁹ The son's name. The text uses both *astra* and *shastra*. These are both weapons and the words are often used synonymously. However, an *astra* is a weapon that is hurled or released, while a *shastra* is held in the hand.
- ⁶¹⁰ Harishchandra.
- ⁶¹¹ Varuna had inflicted Harishchandra with this.
- ⁶¹² A sacrifice at which a human being (*nara*) is sacrificed.
- ⁶¹³ Vishvamitra.
- ⁶¹⁴ The text uses the word Vak, meaning Sarasvati, the goddess of speech.
- ⁶¹⁵ Soma.
- ⁶¹⁶ This probably means *apsaras*, *kinnaras*, *vidyadharas*, *guhyakas* and the like. The number eight is difficult to pin down, since *gandharvas*, *yakshas*, *rakshasas* and *siddhas* have already been separately mentioned. It is also possible that the eight Vasus are meant.
- ⁶¹⁷ There should not be any confusion between Soma, the moon-god, and *soma*, the drink.
- ⁶¹⁸ The word *purna* means complete.
- ⁶¹⁹ There are actually twenty-four names. So perhaps Shriparna is meant to be two separate rivers, Shri and Parna. Or it is possible that Pravara should be added to the list.
- ⁶²⁰ The same as Devagiri.
- ⁶²¹ The confluence of Pravara and Godavari is in Ahmednagar district.
- ⁶²² The ocean.
- ⁶²³ Vachaspati means Brihaspati.
- ⁶²⁴ *Soma* is being used as a synonym for *amrita* here.
- ⁶²⁵ The moon-god, not to be confused with *soma*.
- ⁶²⁶ A name for the sun-god.
- ⁶²⁷ The word *pravara* means excellent.
- ⁶²⁸ Meaning the city of residence.
- ⁶²⁹ The temple in Parthardi Taluka in Ahmednagar.
- ⁶³⁰ Meaning Agni.
- ⁶³¹ There is a problem with this *shloka*, which doesn't make sense.
- ⁶³² Vishnu's abode.
- ⁶³³ *Vridha* means aged woman.
- ⁶³⁴ Confluence of Vridha.
- ⁶³⁵ Ila was the son of Vaivasvata Manu.
- ⁶³⁶ The householder's fire was always carried everywhere.
- ⁶³⁷ Female *yaksha*.

- 638 Uma's forest.
- 639 This will be explained a little later.
- 640 We will use Ila for the masculine and Ilaa for the feminine.
- 641 From the *yakshini*.
- 642 The lunar dynasty, *chandra vamsha*.
- 643 *Puru* (loud) and *rava* (sound).
- 644 Ilaa's son, Pururava.
- 645 Uma.
- 646 Respectively, dancing, singing and good fortune.
- 647 Chariots, elephants, cavalry and infantry.
- 648 Shambhu, Ila's lord.
- 649 There is more than one Chakreshvara temple. This is probably the one in Chakan, near Pune.
- 650 Sureshvari and Dakshayani (Daksha's daughter) are Sati's names.
- 651 Jaya and Vijaya were Sati's companions.
- 652 Respectively, the personified forms of faith, nourishment, satisfaction, peace, bashfulness, speech, earth, heaven, night, forbearance, dawn, hope, victory and intellect.
- 653 Here, Tvashta and Vishvakarma are not being used synonymously.
- 654 *Pramathas* are Shiva's companions, who strike.
- 655 The lord of the moon.
- 656 Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva.
- 657 Garuda.
- 658 Bhavani is Parvati/Uma.
- 659 Vishnu.
- 660 *Pippala* is the holy fig tree.
- 661 Shesha.
- 662 Lopamudra was the wife of the sage Agastya.
- 663 Kumbhayoni is Agastya's name.
- 664 The hermitages of Agastya and Dadhichi were next to each other.
- 665 The word used is *tata*.
- 666 The lotus posture.
- 667 *Daharakasha* is the narrow cavity inside the heart, an image of the expansive sky. What is described is a *hatha yoga* principle of driving up the breath of life into the *anahata chakra*.
- 668 A bad omen.
- 669 Pratitheyi is one of Gabhastini's names.

- ⁶⁷⁰ Agni in the household fire.
- ⁶⁷¹ She entered the fire a little later.
- ⁶⁷² The moon-god.
- ⁶⁷³ Smara is Kama, the god of love. Shiva is Smara's enemy because he burnt down Smara.
- ⁶⁷⁴ Dashanana is Ravana. In his insolence, Ravana tried to raise up Kailasa. Shiva pressed down on Kailasa, with Ravana trapped under it, with his toe and Ravana was crushed.
- ⁶⁷⁵ A *soutramani* sacrifice is an animal sacrifice in which liquor is also offered. Bana means Banasura.
- ⁶⁷⁶ Kartikeya.
- ⁶⁷⁷ Gananatha is Ganesha. Soma, in this context, means Shiva. Soma is one of Shiva's names, though rarely used. Kartikeya became angry, seeing that Ganesha was seated on Shiva's lap. But Ganesha was also half-seated on his mother's lap.
- ⁶⁷⁸ *Ardha* (half) *nari* (female) *ishvara* (lord), the half male, half female form.
- ⁶⁷⁹ In this case, meaning Shiva.
- ⁶⁸⁰ *Sushumna* is the central artery in the body. Those who pass through this reach the *brahman*.
- ⁶⁸¹ The same as Pippalada.
- ⁶⁸² *Vadava* is the subterranean fire and *Kritya* is a demoness. The subterranean fire is in the form of a mare (*vadava*).
- ⁶⁸³ Out of Shiva's eyes.
- ⁶⁸⁴ *Kritya*.
- ⁶⁸⁵ Surya. Bhaskara is another name for Surya.
- ⁶⁸⁶ An *angula* is a finger.
- ⁶⁸⁷ The respective wives of Agastya and Vasishtha.
- ⁶⁸⁸ Shiva.
- ⁶⁸⁹ The parents.
- ⁶⁹⁰ Another name for Agni.
- ⁶⁹¹ Known as Papanashana *tirtha*.
- ⁶⁹² The word *pratishthana* means foundation/position. There is more than one place known as Pratishthana. This is Paithan, in Aurangabad district.

- ⁶⁹³ This must, therefore, be the one in Gujarat.
- ⁶⁹⁴ There are thirteen *samskaras* or sacraments. The list varies a bit. But one list is *vivaha* (marriage), *garbhalambhana* (conception), *pumshavana* (engendering a male child), *simantonnayana* (parting the hair, performed in the 4th month of pregnancy), *jatakarma* (birth rites), *namakarana* (naming), *chudakarma* (tonsure), *annaprashana* (first solid food), *keshanta* (first shaving of the head), *upanayana* (sacred thread), *vidyarambha* (commencement of studies), *samavartana* (graduation) and *antyeshti* (funeral rites).
- ⁶⁹⁵ Here, the word *dvija* is meant to be taken as twice-born, not as a *brahmana*. Thus, it means any of the first three *varnas*.
- ⁶⁹⁶ When the groom is not physically present, marriage can take with the groom's weapons, the weapons acting as a stand-in for the groom.
- ⁶⁹⁷ Vijaya.
- ⁶⁹⁸ Shurasena.
- ⁶⁹⁹ That is, the nurse-maid.
- ⁷⁰⁰ Meaning Kama, the god of love. Ananga is one of Kama's names.
- ⁷⁰¹ *Amrita*.
- ⁷⁰² One with three eyes, Shiva.
- ⁷⁰³ Mother goddesses.
- ⁷⁰⁴ A name for the earth.
- ⁷⁰⁵ Shiva's name.
- ⁷⁰⁶ *Vighna* means impediment. Thus, *avighna* means without impediment.
- ⁷⁰⁷ Vinayaka, Ganeshvara and Vighnaraja are names for Ganesha. So is Ambikeya (Ambika's son).
- ⁷⁰⁸ Brahma.
- ⁷⁰⁹ The three cities of Tripura.
- ⁷¹⁰ Meaning, instantly born.
- ⁷¹¹ Someone with an elongated stomach, pot-bellied.
- ⁷¹² As lord of the *ganas*.
- ⁷¹³ Vighnapati means lord of impediments, as does Vighnesha.
- ⁷¹⁴ Shiva (the father) worshipped Ganesha (the son).
- ⁷¹⁵ *Danavas*.
- ⁷¹⁶ Meaning, the lord of the *nagas*.
- ⁷¹⁷ Lord of Soma.
- ⁷¹⁸ Meaning Shesha's lord.
- ⁷¹⁹ This is the same as Shesha *tirtha* or Naga *tirtha*.

- ⁷²⁰ Respectively, the great fire and the Vadava fire.
- ⁷²¹ In the course of a sacrifice, a *shamitri* is the one who undertakes the slaughtering. Thus, Death was made the slaughterer.
- ⁷²² That is, Dattatreya.
- ⁷²³ We have corrected an obvious typo in the text. It says *bhukti* (object of pleasure), but should be *bhakti* (devotion).
- ⁷²⁴ Before Agastya, Vindhya had bent down.
- ⁷²⁵ Shanaishchara (Shani) is evil because he has an evil eye. The word Shanaishchara means slow-moving. Saturn is a planet that moves slowly.
- ⁷²⁶ Shani's day, Saturday.
- ⁷²⁷ This is specifically addressed to Agastya.
- ⁷²⁸ Shiva.
- ⁷²⁹ The text does not indicate where the chant begins and where it ends. What we have placed within quotes seems to be right.
- ⁷³⁰ *Dhanya* means grain.
- ⁷³¹ *Shrutadhara*. Literally, someone who remembers something as soon as he has heard it.
- ⁷³² Here, *dakshina* is the fee that is given to a *guru* after the successful completion of studies.
- ⁷³³ From *darbha*.
- ⁷³⁴ Shiva.
- ⁷³⁵ Dhanvantari.
- ⁷³⁶ The *asura*.
- ⁷³⁷ Jishnu is Vishnu's name, meaning the one who is victorious.
- ⁷³⁸ That is, fire.
- ⁷³⁹ Vishnu's name, the one with eyes like a lotus.
- ⁷⁴⁰ Indra (the one with one thousand eyes) committed the crimes of killing Vritra and violating Ahalya. Sindhusena was a demon who ousted Indra. But Sindhusena was killed by Vishnu.
- ⁷⁴¹ Brihaspati.
- ⁷⁴² In this eulogy, several of Vishnu's *avatars* are named—Matsya (fish), Kurma (tortoise), Varaha (boar), Narasimha (man-lion), Vamana (dwarf), Hayarupa (Hayagriva/Hayashira), Trivikrama (as Vamana), Buddha, Rama, Kalki and Jamadagni's son (Parashurama).
- ⁷⁴³ The sound of Oum.
- ⁷⁴⁴ Every householder has to undertake the five great sacrifices—studying, worshipping gods, worshipping ancestors, honouring humans through

hospitality, and offerings to animals and birds.

⁷⁴⁵ The six waves are the six vices of *kama* (desire), *krodha* (anger), *lobha* (avarice), *moha* (delusion), *mada* (arrogance) and *matsarya* (jealousy). Alternatively, this could be the five senses and the mind.

⁷⁴⁶ Indra's.

⁷⁴⁷ Brihaspati's name.

⁷⁴⁸ There is a play on words. Hari and Govinda are Vishnu's names. Hari is also Indra's name. Govinda means someone who has obtained a cow (*gou*). Thus, Indra became Govinda.

⁷⁴⁹ The kingdom of the gods.

⁷⁵⁰ The text says *manavas*. It should read *danavas* and we have corrected it.

⁷⁵¹ The flow of water in a river, so that he could kill the animals which came to drink water.

⁷⁵² The number of vices is not usually listed as seven. Ten vices are usually listed as resulting from desire and eight vices resulting from anger. One can't deduce which seven are being singled out.

⁷⁵³ Meaning the son.

⁷⁵⁴ The word used is *tata*.

⁷⁵⁵ That is, the first three *varnas*.

⁷⁵⁶ For support.

⁷⁵⁷ There is an obvious inconsistency. In other accounts, they are only blind.

⁷⁵⁸ Raghu was Dasharatha's grandfather.

⁷⁵⁹ There were *mantras* for invoking, releasing and withdrawing divine weapons.

⁷⁶⁰ Lakshmana.

⁷⁶¹ Sita's *svayamvara* was taking place.

⁷⁶² To Rama.

⁷⁶³ These were the three boons Kaikeyi asked for.

⁷⁶⁴ That is, Dasharatha.

⁷⁶⁵ Since the residents had nothing to eat.

⁷⁶⁶ This seems to mean Rama.

⁷⁶⁷ Sita is clearly speaking to Rama.

⁷⁶⁸ Dasharatha and Rama.

⁷⁶⁹ Rama and Lakshmana.

⁷⁷⁰ Janaka found Sita while tilling the ground.

⁷⁷¹ Rama.

⁷⁷² A medicinal tree.

⁷⁷³ *Shava* means dead body/corpse.

⁷⁷⁴ That is, Shiva, a person who possesses nothing.

⁷⁷⁵ There are sixteen kinds of service (*upachara*)—*dhyana*, *avahana* (invoking the deity), *asana* (offering a seat), *padya* (offering water to wash the feet), *arghya*, *achamana* (offering water to rinse the mouth), *snana* (bathing the deity), *vastra* (dressing the deity), *upavita* (offering a sacred thread), *gandha* (offering fragrances), *pushpa* (offering flowers), *dhupa* (offering incense), *dipa* (offering a lamp), *naivedya* (offerings of food), *tambula* (offering betel leaf) and *pradakshina* (combined with bowing down).

⁷⁷⁶ Shiva has 36 principles, known as *tattvas*—(1) creation; (2) preservation; (3) destruction; (4) concealment; (5) grace; (6) *maya*; (7) *kaala* (sheath of time); (8) *vidya* (sheath of imperfect knowledge); (9) *raga* (sheath of desire); (10) *niyati* (sheath of causality); (11) *kalaa* (sheath of being limited); (12) Purusha; (13) nose; (14) tongue; (15) eyes; (16) skin; (17) ears; (18) anus; (19) genital organs; (20) legs; (21) hands; (22) mouth; (23) smell; (24) taste; (25) form; (26) touch; (27) sound; (28) earth; (29) air; (30) water; (31) fire; (32) space; (33) *manas* (mind); (34) *buddhi* (intellect); (35) *ahamkara* (ego); and (36) *chitta* (consciousness). These *tattvas* of Shaivite philosophy are similar to those of *samkhya*.

⁷⁷⁷ Uma's lord.

⁷⁷⁸ Made out of *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*.

⁷⁷⁹ Here, Aja means Vishnu.

⁷⁸⁰ Meaning Brahma.

⁷⁸¹ Meaning milk, *ghee*, curds, honey and molasses.

⁷⁸² *Bana* means arrow.

⁷⁸³ Ganga originated from the feet of Vishnu (Rama).

⁷⁸⁴ The sons of Diti are *daityas*, the sons of Danu are *danavas* and the sons of Aditi are *adityas*. Diti, Danu and Aditi were married to Kashyapa and all three were Daksha's daughters.

⁷⁸⁵ The word Parameshthi is usually used for Brahma. It is not clear who Diti went to (Parameshthi's son). It could have been either Narada or Marichi, both of whom were Brahma's sons. Kashyapa was Marichi's son.

⁷⁸⁶ The *sutas* were charioteers, as well as raconteurs of tales. *Magadhas* were minstrels and bards. So were *bandis*. But *magadhas* seem to have also composed, while *bandis* sung the compositions of others.

- ⁷⁸⁷ Vayu is the wind-god, Maghavan is Indra's name.
- ⁷⁸⁸ That is, step-mother.
- ⁷⁸⁹ Until there was a violation in *niyamas*, Indra couldn't enter.
- ⁷⁹⁰ Indra first cut the fetus into seven pieces. He again sliced each of the seven into seven pieces. Thus, there were forty-nine altogether. The Maruts are sometimes described as seven and sometimes as forty-nine.
- ⁷⁹¹ 'Do not cry.'
- ⁷⁹² The father of the Maruts is Kashyapa and Kashyapa wasn't Agastya's brother. So the expression 'brother' shouldn't be taken in a literal sense.
- ⁷⁹³ Being used here for Shiva.
- ⁷⁹⁴ *Putra* means son.
- ⁷⁹⁵ *Mitra* means friend.
- ⁷⁹⁶ Because Kamala is one of Lakshmi's names.
- ⁷⁹⁷ *Uluka* means owl.
- ⁷⁹⁸ Weapons named after Yama. In this section, Mrityu and Yama are used synonymously.
- ⁷⁹⁹ *Agneya* weapons are named after Agni, *kapota* is a pigeon.
- ⁸⁰⁰ The clash between Adi/Ati (*turdus ginginianus*) and Baka (Indian crane) is a famous story, recounted in many Puranas, such as the Markandeya Purana. The sages Vishvamitra and Vasishtha assumed the forms of these two birds and fought.
- ⁸⁰¹ *Hotri* is the chief priest at a sacrifice.

- ⁸⁰² Krishanu is Agni's name, as is Vahni.
- ⁸⁰³ Agni is the purifying one.
- ⁸⁰⁴ Agni.
- ⁸⁰⁵ The earth.
- ⁸⁰⁶ *Satra* means sacrifice.
- ⁸⁰⁷ Because of Sarasvati.
- ⁸⁰⁸ That is, the responsibility is being passed on to Agni.
- ⁸⁰⁹ His threatened curse.
- ⁸¹⁰ That is, Vishnu.
- ⁸¹¹ The gods cannot give.
- ⁸¹² Arshtishena and the others.
- ⁸¹³ There were four classes of priests, though the classification varied over time. The *hotri* is the chief priest and is accomplished in the *Rig Veda*. The *adhvaryu* is the assistant priest and is accomplished in the *Yajur Veda*, though later, the *udgatri* came to be identified with the *Sama Veda*. In addition, there was the *brahmana* or *purohita*.
- ⁸¹⁴ Agni's name.
- ⁸¹⁵ There is a pun on words. Taraka means rescuer/deliverer.
- ⁸¹⁶ Ganga.
- ⁸¹⁷ Kubera.
- ⁸¹⁸ Varuna.
- ⁸¹⁹ The god of love.
- ⁸²⁰ *Suvarna* means gold. It is also one of Shiva's names.
- ⁸²¹ The same as Suvarnaa.
- ⁸²² The tears created the river, perhaps also from Dharma's eyes, although that is not specifically mentioned. *Ananda* means joy/bliss, while *Nandini* means one who delights. *Nandini* also means daughter. Perhaps two separate rivers were created, Ananda from Agni's tears and Nandini from Dharma's tears. However, the subsequent *shloka* suggests that both rivers were the same.
- ⁸²³ *Abjaka* means lotus. But it is not clear which place is intended. Perhaps it means Vishnu *tirtha*. Alternatively, Abjaka might be a typo for Ambika. However, Abjaka has also been identified as the confluence of Phena/Sindhuphena with Godavari.
- ⁸²⁴ The river Phena/Sindhuphena is probably Penganga/Painganga.
- ⁸²⁵ To be reborn.
- ⁸²⁶ The word used is *phena*, which means foam.

⁸²⁷ In Chapter 2(14).
⁸²⁸ This should probably read Aparajita.
⁸²⁹ Indra.
⁸³⁰ Poulami is Shachi. She was Puloma's daughter. Shachi is also known as Indrani.
⁸³¹ That is, cousin.
⁸³² The earth and water are feminine in nature.
⁸³³ Andhaka was a demon killed by Shiva.
⁸³⁴ Virinchi is Brahma. Shiva severed one of Brahma's heads.
⁸³⁵ The three *vargas* are the three objectives of existence—*dharma*, *artha* and *kama*.
⁸³⁶ Benediction for welfare/prosperity.
⁸³⁷ Amorous passion.
⁸³⁸ These weapons, as compared to the subsequent mention, are divine in nature.
⁸³⁹ As will become evident, this is being said by Indra.
⁸⁴⁰ Since this is being spoken to Indra and not to Narada, this is an anomaly.
⁸⁴¹ Gadadhara is one who holds the mace, Vishnu.
⁸⁴² Poulami should have known all this, since she went with Indra.
⁸⁴³ *Dharma*, *artha* and *kama*.
⁸⁴⁴ Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva.
⁸⁴⁵ Para means something that is higher than everything else, beyond everything else. Apra means something that is not Para.
⁸⁴⁶ *Sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*.
⁸⁴⁷ The word used is *lingambhedi*.
⁸⁴⁸ Prapancha means the visible universe.
⁸⁴⁹ This probably means Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva.
⁸⁵⁰ What this means is not clear. Since Shiva is being eulogized, perhaps two means Brahma and Vishnu.
⁸⁵¹ The word used is *itihasa*.
⁸⁵² She had helped the *rakshasas*.
⁸⁵³ The one with Sharnga in his hand (*pani*).
⁸⁵⁴ The supreme lord.
⁸⁵⁵ *Bana* means arrow.
⁸⁵⁶ Ganga's powers in manifest form.
⁸⁵⁷ Literally, protection of cattle.
⁸⁵⁸ That is, Yama.

- ⁸⁵⁹ Surya.
- ⁸⁶⁰ Yama.
- ⁸⁶¹ That is, Vishnu.
- ⁸⁶² *Satrayaga* is a *soma* sacrifice that extends over a long period of time.
- ⁸⁶³ King of the *gandharvas*.
- ⁸⁶⁴ These are exclamations made when oblations are offered to gods and ancestors. Pippala deliberately mispronounced these.
- ⁸⁶⁵ Since *durgati* is calamity, it is known as Durga *tirtha*.
- ⁸⁶⁶ Sacrificial oblation made out of ground rice.
- ⁸⁶⁷ Literally, destroyer of oblations.
- ⁸⁶⁸ The priest.
- ⁸⁶⁹ Literally, destroyer of a sacrifice. Therefore, the same as Havyaghna.
- ⁸⁷⁰ *Shukla* means white.
- ⁸⁷¹ The *saptarshis*.
- ⁸⁷² The same as *satrayaga*.
- ⁸⁷³ The woman created with the use of *maya*.
- ⁸⁷⁴ The sages sought refuge with Vishnu. Since Maya had been devoured, the *rakshasas* could destroy the sacrifice.
- ⁸⁷⁵ With Goutami and with Bhagirathi.
- ⁸⁷⁶ Garuda.
- ⁸⁷⁷ Because of the condition they were in.
- ⁸⁷⁸ Tree with bitter fruit.
- ⁸⁷⁹ The negation of Lakshmi, adversity/penury. Lakshmi is also referred to as Shri.
- ⁸⁸⁰ *Daridra* means poverty.
- ⁸⁸¹ Respectively, the personified forms of intellect, prosperity, modesty, peace and fame. They leave in the absence of riches.
- ⁸⁸² The earth and water are both feminine.
- ⁸⁸³ These are words spoken by Madhuchhanda to his wife. A *yama* is a period of three hours. Since *yama* also means ‘we are leaving’, there is a pun on words.
- ⁸⁸⁴ These are words spoken by Madhuchhanda’s wife. Since *yamini* means night, there is another pun on words.
- ⁸⁸⁵ The three objectives of life are *dharma*, *artha* and *kama*.
- ⁸⁸⁶ Bhaskara and Ravi are Surya’s names.
- ⁸⁸⁷ Literally, the place where the dead are brought back to life.

- ⁸⁸⁸ The text says Kavaya here, but Kavasha later. We have made it consistent.
- ⁸⁸⁹ Thirst.
- ⁸⁹⁰ *Khadga* means sword.
- ⁸⁹¹ Atreya means Atri's son.
- ⁸⁹² That is, Tvashta.
- ⁸⁹³ *Kalpadruma* is a divine tree (*druma*) in Indra's world, *kalpalata* is a divine creeper (*lata*), also in Indra's world. The cow means the celestial cow, Surabhi. All these possess the attribute of bestowing whatever one desires.
- ⁸⁹⁴ Airavata.
- ⁸⁹⁵ Literally, Anvindra means following Indra, or after Indra.
- ⁸⁹⁶ The *nishadas* were hunters who dwelt in mountainous regions. The word '*nishida*' means 'sit down', explaining the name Nishada.
- ⁸⁹⁷ The word *prithu* means large/great. An alternative explanation for the name Prithu is that Vena's arm was large. Here, the explanation is the loud voice.
- ⁸⁹⁸ Specifically, a *kapila* is a brown cow. As is obvious, there is a play on words.
- ⁸⁹⁹ That is, the river was also known as Kapila.
- ⁹⁰⁰ *Nairritas* are a specific class of demons.
- ⁹⁰¹ Literally, the place of the gods.
- ⁹⁰² *Ravana* means screaming/wailing. Ravana got his name because he made the worlds scream. Dashanana means one with ten faces/heads.
- ⁹⁰³ Shiva.
- ⁹⁰⁴ Dattatreya.
- ⁹⁰⁵ Burning charcoal is *angara*.
- ⁹⁰⁶ These are synonyms for a wife, with slightly different nuances. Along with the husband (*pati*), a *patni* takes part in rites. *Bharya* is one who sustains and maintains. *Jaya* is one in whom the husband is reborn as a son. *Kalatra* has the sense of being a citadel. *Yoshit* is woman in general, applied to wife.
- ⁹⁰⁷ Shukracharya.
- ⁹⁰⁸ The etymology seems to be destroyer (*kala*) of old age (*jara*).
- ⁹⁰⁹ Vishvamitra.
- ⁹¹⁰ The text says Mena, the same as Menaka.
- ⁹¹¹ The god of love has five arrows.

⁹¹² Shiva.

⁹¹³ The father is Kanva, the son is Kaanva.

⁹¹⁴ Sacrifices performed on special occasions (*parva*), or at the time of *ayana*.

⁹¹⁵ We have translated *hiranya* as gold. The succeeding *shlokas* do not make it clear where the second oblation was to be offered.

⁹¹⁶ Prahlada.

⁹¹⁷ Hari and Ambarya.

⁹¹⁸ Ajigarti sold his son Shunahshepa. The *kshatriya* was King Harishchandra. Among other places, this story is told in Markandeya Purana and is also briefly referred to in Chapter 1(8).

⁹¹⁹ The text switches to Jigarti. For the sake of consistency, we have retained Ajigarti.

⁹²⁰ Vishvamitra adopted Shunahshepa.

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- ⁹²¹ That is, Pururava.
- ⁹²² The text has a *shloka* that it states is inconsistent and interpolated. Therefore, we have not included this in the translation. It says that the king was greatly surprised in the night and the one who subsisted only on *ghee* saw him without his clothes on.
- ⁹²³ Pururava had been there earlier.
- ⁹²⁴ Probably referring to the arrows of Kama, the god of love.
- ⁹²⁵ A *dvipa* (island) in the middle of the river.
- ⁹²⁶ *Nimna* (inferior, baser, lower) and *bheda* (cleared away). Thus, Nimnabheda.
- ⁹²⁷ The moon-god. Chandra is the same as Chandrama.
- ⁹²⁸ Jiva is Brihaspati's name.
- ⁹²⁹ Rati is the wife of the god of love, Kama.
- ⁹³⁰ To ask what she wanted, so that he could offer his *guru* the *dakshina*.
- ⁹³¹ Rohini is a *nakshatra*. All the *nakshatras* were married to the moon-god, but Chandra loved Rohini the most.
- ⁹³² Brihaspati's *niti* has maxims on good policy.
- ⁹³³ Brihaspati and Shukra were rivals. Thus, Brihaspati swallowed his pride in going to Shukracharya. In accounts of the battle over Tara, the *asuras* sided with Chandra.
- ⁹³⁴ Shukra.
- ⁹³⁵ From the taint.
- ⁹³⁶ After being purified, Tara was married again to Brihaspati.
- ⁹³⁷ Brihaspati.
- ⁹³⁸ When Jupiter is in Leo.
- ⁹³⁹ *Ananda* means joy/bliss.
- ⁹⁴⁰ Literally, Nandi's bank.
- ⁹⁴¹ This is a *stotram* about Shiva's greatness (*mahiman*) and is known as *Shiva-mahimna stotram*. It is usually ascribed to Pushpadanta, the king of the *gandharvas*.
- ⁹⁴² Sita.
- ⁹⁴³ Sita.
- ⁹⁴⁴ Lakshmana.
- ⁹⁴⁵ Rama.
- ⁹⁴⁶ Rama.
- ⁹⁴⁷ This seems to mean Hanuman, Angada and the others, not the gate-keepers.

- ⁹⁴⁸ Literally, the pool of one thousand, or one thousand pools.
- ⁹⁴⁹ A female lion.
- ⁹⁵⁰ This is in the singular. However, since there were Angirases, this should be in the plural.
- ⁹⁵¹ Literally, conch shell (*shankha*) lake (*hrada*).
- ⁹⁵² Before Ravana seized it, Pushpaka *vimana* belonged to Kubera, the lord of riches.
- ⁹⁵³ Vibhishana.
- ⁹⁵⁴ Showing disrespect to Bhava's great *lingam*.
- ⁹⁵⁵ This seems to refer to the main *lingam*.
- ⁹⁵⁶ Rama.
- ⁹⁵⁷ The list of sons born through Brahma's mental powers varies. Here, it probably means the seven *saptarshis*, Narada, Daksha and Svayambhuva Manu.
- ⁹⁵⁸ Agastya is known as Kumbhayoni because his origin (*yon*i) was in a pot (*kumbha*).
- ⁹⁵⁹ Meaning Agastya.
- ⁹⁶⁰ Meaning Brahma.
- ⁹⁶¹ Brahma.
- ⁹⁶² The Angirases were told this. The place where the quote ends is unclear. But this seems to be just about right.
- ⁹⁶³ The first part of this is reminiscent of Bhagavad Gita 4.7.
- ⁹⁶⁴ Royal sages.
- ⁹⁶⁵ Vinata's sons were Aruna and Garuda. Kadru and Vinata were married to the sage Kashyapa. The *nagas* were Kadru's children. Kadru and Vinata had an argument about the colour of Uchchaihshrava's tail. Vinata said it was white. Kadru said it was black. Kadru asked her children, the *nagas*, to coil around the tail, so that it seemed black. Thus, Vinata lost the bet.
- ⁹⁶⁶ Ravi is one of Surya's names.
- ⁹⁶⁷ Garuda.
- ⁹⁶⁸ In this context, the word Hamsa is being used to mean Surya.
- ⁹⁶⁹ The creator of the day, Surya's name. Bhanu is also Surya's name.
- ⁹⁷⁰ What his means is unclear. Literally, Phanishvara means lord of the serpents (hooded ones). It is possible that Phanishvara means Shiva.
- ⁹⁷¹ Garuda.
- ⁹⁷² That is, Trishira.
- ⁹⁷³ *Devagama* means the arrival (*agama*) of the gods (*deva*).

- ⁹⁷⁴ *Priya* means loved.
- ⁹⁷⁵ The Godavari's origin is in Tryambakeshvara. The Bhimarathi's (Bhima) origin is in Bhimashankara. The Ekavira temple is in Virar, where the river is known as Vaitarani. *Viraja* means without dust. Sahyadri (literally Sahya mountain) means the Western Ghats.
- ⁹⁷⁶ There is thus the notion, as in the Bhagavad Gita, of Akshara Purusha (without decay) and Kshara Purusha (with decay).
- ⁹⁷⁷ This sounds inconsistent. It probably means that water originated from the Purusha who was without form and the Purusha with form originated from water.
- ⁹⁷⁸ Water and the Purusha with form.
- ⁹⁷⁹ That is, the lotus.
- ⁹⁸⁰ Sacrifice.
- ⁹⁸¹ *Purusha sukta*, also found in *Shukla Yajur Veda* and *Atharva Veda*, is hymn 10.90 of *Rig Veda*.
- ⁹⁸² The six seasons (*ritus*) are *vasanta* or spring (Chaitra and Vaishakha), *grishma* or summer (Jyeshtha and Ashadha), *varsha* or monsoon (Shravana and Bhadrapada), *sharad* or early autumn (Ashvina and Kartika), *hemanta* or late autumn (Margashirsha/Agrahayana and Pousha) and *shishira* or winter (Magha and Phalguna).
- ⁹⁸³ The seven metres (*chandās*) used in the *Vedas*—Gayatri, Ushnih, Anushtubh, Brihati, Pankti, Trishtubh and Jagati.
- ⁹⁸⁴ All three are units for measuring time. The unit for measuring time is *kalaa*. Time/destiny is Kaala.
- ⁹⁸⁵ Time/destiny.
- ⁹⁸⁶ *Pranita* is the sacrificial cup. It also means something that has been brought forward.
- ⁹⁸⁷ *Tarpana* (satisfaction) with *kusha* grass.
- ⁹⁸⁸ *Vata* is the Indian fig tree and *akshaya* means without decay.
- ⁹⁸⁹ Bathed the *lingam*.
- ⁹⁹⁰ The word *manyu* means both anger and mettle.
- ⁹⁹¹ If the guests leave without their wishes having been met.
- ⁹⁹² When the slanderer does not slander and the guest is satisfied.
- ⁹⁹³ Yama.
- ⁹⁹⁴ Meaning Narasimha.
- ⁹⁹⁵ Garuda.
- ⁹⁹⁶ That is Vishnu, with Garuda on the standard.

- ⁹⁹⁷ *Parvata* means mountain.
- ⁹⁹⁸ The one who holds the mace, Vishnu.
- ⁹⁹⁹ An awful species of bird.
- ¹⁰⁰⁰ That is, someone caught unawares.
- ¹⁰⁰¹ *Tvam* is to be used for equals or juniors, not for those who are superior. For them, the proper form of address is *bhavan/bhavati* (depending on the gender).
- ¹⁰⁰² He hid his true nature out of shame.
- ¹⁰⁰³ Aditya/Savitar means the sun-god. Usha is referred to as Samjna elsewhere. Shanaihshchara is Saturn. Bhaskara is one of Surya's names, as is Ravi.
- ¹⁰⁰⁴ The maternal uncle is Yama.
- ¹⁰⁰⁵ The word used is *tata*. This means father, but is used for anyone who is senior.
- ¹⁰⁰⁶ That is, Vishvarupa.
- ¹⁰⁰⁷ Harshana means someone who causes delight.
- ¹⁰⁰⁸ Tvashta.
- ¹⁰⁰⁹ Bhadra/Bhadraa means fortunate. Bhadrapati means the lord of everything fortunate.
- ¹⁰¹⁰ Garuda. Sampati and Jatayu were Aruna's sons.
- ¹⁰¹¹ Surya is the one who creates the day.
- ¹⁰¹² *Patatri* means bird.
- ¹⁰¹³ Vishnu, Shiva and Surya.
- ¹⁰¹⁴ In East Godavari district, at the confluence of Vasishtha Godavari with the ocean.
- ¹⁰¹⁵ When sleeping, the head should face the south.
- ¹⁰¹⁶ Female *rakshasa*.
- ¹⁰¹⁷ *Vipra* means *brahmana*.
- ¹⁰¹⁸ This should be the king's prayer.
- ¹⁰¹⁹ Addressed to Abhishtuta.
- ¹⁰²⁰ Agni.
- ¹⁰²¹ Honey, *ghee*, molasses, curds, milk.
- ¹⁰²² Offering of food given to a god.
- ¹⁰²³ The hunter.
- ¹⁰²⁴ The word is being used as a proper name here. *Bhilla* is a mountain-dwelling tribe.
- ¹⁰²⁵ That is, Sindhudvipa's.

- 1026 The word *nirmalya* has a double meaning—purity, as well as offerings made to a god.
- 1027 That is, Manikundala.
- 1028 The same as Manikundala.
- 1029 *Dharma, artha, kama* and *moksha*.
- 1030 Two herbs which respectively heal wounds/stakes and revive the dead.
- 1031 The Himalayas.
- 1032 Literally, ‘You are the one who contains/possesses.’ More than the literal meaning, this implies taking the tree’s permission.
- 1033 Manikundala.
- 1034 In the absence of a son, a daughter who is brought up as a son and heir.
- 1035 Manikundala.
- 1036 Chakshu means eye.
- 1037 The one who holds the Sharnga bow.
- 1038 Indra.
- 1039 The name of Indra’s chariot.
- 1040 Sumati was Pramati’s son.
- 1041 Meaning Vishnu.
- 1042 Samudra is the ocean.
- 1043 Lakshmi.
- 1044 Agastya drank up the ocean.
- 1045 Vasishtha’s wife.
- 1046 This is probably the one in Nilagunda, Karnataka.
- 1047 There is some interpretation in translating what Vishvamitra said. The meanings are not self-evident.
- 1048 Literally, the terrible lord.
- 1049 That is, Bhimeshvara.
- 1050 Vishnu’s devotees.
- 1051 Marichi is repeated.
- 1052 Daksha is repeated.
- 1053 The one in Manthani.
- 1054 Lakshmi.
- 1055 The one with a *chakra* in the hand (*pani*), Vishnu.
- 1056 Horse-headed, the same as Hayashira/Hayagriva.
- 1057 This is a *mantra* from *Rig Veda* 9.113. This bit means, ‘Flow Indu (Soma) for the sake of Indra.’

- ¹⁰⁵⁸ These are now *mantras* from *Rig Veda* 9.114. We have skipped the Sanskrit and only given the English translation.
- ¹⁰⁵⁹ This bit is from *Rig Veda* 9.112. The artisan means Vishvakarma, the physician means the two Ashvins.
- ¹⁰⁶⁰ *Adri* means mountain.
- ¹⁰⁶¹ Probably meaning *vadin* (sonant), *samvadin* (consonant), *anuvadin* (assonant) and *vivadin* (dissonant), the four classes mentioned in *natya shastra*.
- ¹⁰⁶² Meaning equilibrium.
- ¹⁰⁶³ *Dharma* has four parts in *krita yuga*, three in *treta yuga*, two in *dvapara yuga* and one in *kali yuga*.
- ¹⁰⁶⁴ The one with a face like an elephant, Ganeshvara.
- ¹⁰⁶⁵ The text suggests that all this is being reported by Brahma. While Brahma is indeed telling Narada everything, this bit is still part of the Ganeshvara quote. Ganeshvara is still speaking to his mother.
- ¹⁰⁶⁶ Here, we have translated ‘lord of the earth’ as *brahmana*, instead of king, as that seems to be more appropriate.

Acknowledgements

The corpus of the Puranas is huge—in scope, coverage and size. The Mahabharata is believed to contain 100,000 *shlokas*. The Critical Edition of the Mahabharata, edited and published by the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute (Pune), doesn't contain quite that many. But no matter, this gives us some idea of the size. To comprehend what 100,000 shlokas mean in a standard word count, the ten-volume unabridged translation I did of the Mahabharata amounts to a staggering 2.5 million words. After composing the Mahabharata, Krishna Dvaipayana Vedavyasa composed the eighteen *mahapuranas*, or major Puranas. So the belief goes. Collectively, these eighteen Puranas amount to 400,000 *shlokas*, translating into a disconcerting and daunting number of 10 million words.

After translating the Bhagavadgita, the Mahabharata, the Harivamsha (160,000 words) and the Valmiki Ramayana (500,000 words), it was but natural to turn one's attention towards translating the Puranas. (All these translations have been, and will be, published by Penguin India.) As the most popular and most read Purana, the Bhagavata Purana chose itself as the first to be translated (3 volumes, 500,000 words). The Markandeya Purana, another popular Purana (1 volume, 175,000 words) came next. That these translations were well-received was encouragement along the intimidating journey of translating the remaining Puranas and I am indebted to the reviewers of these various translations, including those of the Bhagavata Purana and the Markandeya Purana.

Which Purana should one choose next to translate? This journey of translation has been marked by several coincidences. While still in the process of choosing, I happened to visit Pushkara for the first time in my life. Temples to Brahma are rare. Among Brahma's temples, the most

important is the one in Pushkara. As I gazed at Brahma's image, at his *kamandalu* and *akshamala*, the decision made itself. It had to be the Brahma Purana. The eighteen Maha-Puranas, as the introduction explains, are sometimes individually identified with Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva. The Bhagavata Purana is a Purana identified with Vishnu. The Markandeya Purana, though identified with Brahma, is partly about Devi, and hence, by extrapolation, identified with Shiva. One should accordingly choose Brahma Purana, often described as the first Purana, though the present text is clearly not the original Brahma Purana. Average familiarity with the Brahma Purana might not be as great as with the Bhagavata Purana or the Markandeya Purana, but there was no denying the Brahma Purana's importance. Hence, this translation in two volumes, running into 390,000 words. The coincidence did not end there. I had completed the actual translation and was going to start on the Introduction. In the interim, I happened to visit Rajamahendravaram (Rajamahendrapuram or Rajahmundry if you prefer) for the first time in my life. From Pushkara Ghat, I looked on at the wide expanse of the Godavari and watched the *arati* to Goutami. I visited the Koti Lingeshvara temple. The places described in the Goutami *mahatmya* section seemed to come alive, from Tryambakeshvara to Antaravedi, from the Sahya range to the confluence with the ocean.

The journey of translation hasn't been an intimidating one only for me. Penguin India must also have thought about it several times, before going ahead with the Purana translations. Most people have some idea about the Ramayana and the Mahabharata. But the Puranas are typically rendered in such dumbed-down versions that the market has to be created. However, Penguin India also believed in the Purana Project, which still stretches into some interminable horizon in the future, almost two decades down the line. For both author and publisher, this is a long-term commitment. But Bhagavata Purana, Markandeya Purana and Brahma Purana have been done. With the publication schedule inevitably disrupted because of the COVID pandemic, Vishnu Purana comes next, followed by Shiva Purana. I am indebted to Penguin India. In particular, Meru Gokhale, Ambar Sahil

Chatterjee, Tarini Uppal and Rea Mukherjee have been exceptionally patient, persevering and encouraging. But for them, the Purana Project might not have taken off. I also thank the copy editors. These Purana translations have been brought alive by the wonderful cover designs and illustrations, and I thank the illustrators and the designers.

Ever since this translation journey started in 2006, my wife, Suparna Banerjee Debroy, has been a constant source of support, ensuring the conducive and propitious environment for the work to continue unimpeded. Part II has a dialogue between Agni and Atreyi. Agni tells Atreyi, ‘At first, you were a *patni*. Then, for sustaining, you became a *bharya*. To give birth, you became *jaya*. Through your own qualities, you became *kalatra*.’ The vocabulary of Sanskrit is immensely rich. There are multiple synonyms for every word, each with a slightly different nuance. This is also true of the word ‘wife’—*patni*, *bharya*, *jaya* and *kalatra* are instances. Suparna has been all these and more. In every Purana text, I have been struck by the importance given to a wife, in her different roles and in the case of the Bhagavata Purana and the Markandeya Purana, I have quoted verses. The Brahma Purana is no different.

1.121.25 ‘Men desire wives for every kind of happiness. A wife is the source of happiness. Therefore, act in that way.’

2.10.30-31. ‘She is the mother of my *dharma*. She is the mistress of my body. She is always my aide in the pursuit of *dharma*, *artha*, *kama* and *moksha*. When I am content, she laughs. When I am angry, she wipes away my misery.’ One should note that this is said by a male pigeon about his wife.

2.59.60 ‘In every task undertaken by a man, the wife is an aide. Without her, there is no success in even the slightest of tasks.’ The translation work is not a slight task and without her as an aide and support, it wouldn’t have happened.

The Brahma Purana is rich in geography and it brought alive for me the region in, and around Odisha, a state I am especially fond of. Shaifalika Panda and Subhrakant Panda have told us stories about Odisha and have

also invited us there. This is an opportunity to tell our dear friends some stories about Odisha, by dedicating this book to a warm and generous couple.

Bibek Debroy
August 2021

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